
A S I A

113 Cities

674 Scams

33 Countries

Real stories from Reddit travelers. Every scam documented, every trick explained.

Know before you go — so you're never caught off-guard.

tabiji.ai
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Table of Contents

Southeast Asia

Cambodia

- Battambang — 4 scams
- Phnom Penh — 7 scams
- Siem Reap — 7 scams

Indonesia

- Bali — 9 scams
- Batam — 5 scams
- Jakarta — 6 scams
- Lombok — 6 scams
- Nusa Penida — 5 scams
- Ubud — 7 scams
- Yogyakarta — 7 scams

Laos

- Luang Prabang — 7 scams
- Vientiane — 8 scams

Malaysia

- Johor Bahru — 7 scams
- Kuala Lumpur — 7 scams
- Kuching — 5 scams
- Langkawi — 5 scams
- Penang — 5 scams

Myanmar

- Mandalay — 7 scams
- Yangon — 6 scams

Philippines

- Boracay — 5 scams
- Cebu — 7 scams
- El Nido — 4 scams
- Manila — 7 scams
- Siargao — 5 scams

Singapore

- Singapore — 6 scams

Thailand

- Bangkok — 10 scams
- Chiang Mai — 8 scams

- Chiang Rai — 3 scams
- Koh Phangan — 6 scams
- Koh Samui — 7 scams
- Krabi — 6 scams
- Pai — 5 scams
- Pattaya — 7 scams
- Phuket — 8 scams

Vietnam

- Da Nang — 5 scams
- Dalat — 4 scams
- Ha Long Bay — 6 scams
- Hanoi — 6 scams
- Ho Chi Minh City — 6 scams
- Hoi An — 5 scams
- Hue — 5 scams
- Nha Trang — 6 scams
- Sapa — 6 scams

East Asia

China

- Beijing — 8 scams
- Chengdu — 7 scams
- Guangzhou — 6 scams
- Guilin — 7 scams
- Hangzhou — 6 scams
- Kunming — 6 scams
- Shanghai — 7 scams
- Shenzhen — 7 scams
- Suzhou — 5 scams
- Xi'an — 7 scams

Hong Kong

- Hong Kong — 5 scams

Japan

- Fukuoka — 4 scams
- Hiroshima — 4 scams
- Kyoto — 6 scams
- Nara — 3 scams
- Okinawa — 3 scams
- Osaka — 6 scams
- Sapporo — 3 scams
- Tokyo — 7 scams
- Yokohama — 3 scams

Macau

- Macau — 6 scams

South Korea

- Busan — 4 scams
- Jeju — 4 scams
- Seoul — 6 scams

Taiwan

- Taipei — 6 scams

South Asia

Bangladesh

- Dhaka — 6 scams

India

- Agra — 7 scams
- Bangalore — 4 scams
- Chennai — 6 scams
- Delhi — 8 scams
- Goa — 7 scams
- Hyderabad — 6 scams
- Jaipur — 7 scams
- Kolkata — 8 scams
- Mumbai — 8 scams
- Rishikesh — 6 scams
- Udaipur — 6 scams
- Varanasi — 7 scams

Maldives

- Maldives — 6 scams

Nepal

- Kathmandu — 8 scams
- Pokhara — 6 scams

Sri Lanka

- Colombo — 7 scams
- Galle — 5 scams
- Kandy — 7 scams

Middle East

Armenia

- Yerevan — 6 scams

Azerbaijan

- Baku — 5 scams

Georgia

- Tbilisi — 6 scams

Israel

- Jerusalem — 8 scams
- Tel Aviv — 7 scams

Jordan

- Amman — 6 scams
- Petra — 6 scams

Lebanon

- Beirut — 6 scams

Oman

- Muscat — 5 scams

Qatar

- Doha — 5 scams

Saudi Arabia

- Dammam — 4 scams
- Jeddah — 7 scams
- Mecca — 7 scams
- Medina — 5 scams
- Riyadh — 5 scams

Turkey

- Antalya — 6 scams
- Bodrum — 5 scams
- Cappadocia — 5 scams
- Istanbul — 8 scams
- Marmaris — 6 scams

United Arab Emirates

- Abu Dhabi — 6 scams
- Dubai — 6 scams

Central Asia

Kazakhstan

- Almaty — 5 scams

Uzbekistan

- Bukhara — 4 scams
- Samarkand — 5 scams
- Tashkent — 6 scams

Southeast Asia

43 cities • 263 scams • 9 countries

■ Cambodia

■ ■ Battambang

4 scams documented • Cambodia

The Bamboo Train Tourist Trap

You hire a tuk-tuk to the famous Bamboo Train and a 'tourist police' officer at the station gives you a history lesson before directing you to the platform — \$5 per person for the ride. The 15-minute ride on a motorized bamboo platform is deafeningly loud with zero scenery. At the village endpoint, vendors surround you aggressively selling overpriced scarves and T-shirts while children demand tips. Redditors on r/cambodia describe it as a scam wrapped in a tourist attraction — the whole operation is designed to extract maximum cash through tuk-tuk fees, ride tickets, vendor pressure, and gu...

■ Red Flags

- Tuk-tuk driver quotes an inflated fare for the 'special trip'
- 'Tourist police' officer acts as an unofficial guide demanding tips
- Vendors at the endpoint are extremely aggressive
- Children are used to guilt tourists into paying more
- The ride is far shorter and less scenic than advertised

■ How to Avoid

- Negotiate tuk-tuk fare in advance — 4,000-6,000 riel round trip is fair
 - Set expectations low — the ride is brief and noisy
 - Bring small bills to avoid overpaying vendors
 - Politely but firmly decline aggressive sellers with a smile
 - Consider skipping it entirely — the Battambang bat caves are a better experience
-

The Tuk-Tuk Hotel Hijack

Perfect deal. Except he drives you to a completely different guesthouse — one that pays him a \$3-6 per-night commission for every tourist he delivers. He claims your booked hotel 'closed last month' or is 'completely full.' Redditors on r/solotravel explain that some bus companies share passenger names and hotel bookings with drivers, who compete to redirect you. If you insist on your original hotel, the driver may drop you blocks away and refuse to continue.

■ Red Flags

- Driver claims your booked hotel is closed, full, or 'moved'
- Drives you to a different guesthouse without your consent

- Pretends to call your hotel and reports it's unavailable
- Becomes aggressive or drops you far from your destination when you insist
- Multiple drivers compete for you at the bus station

■ How to Avoid

- Have your hotel's address and phone number saved offline
 - Call your hotel directly to confirm availability before trusting the driver
 - Insist firmly on your destination — threaten to get another tuk-tuk
 - Book a hotel pickup in advance through the guesthouse
 - Use Google Maps on your phone to verify the driver's route
-

The Dollar-Riel Confusion

The vendor gives you change in a confusing mix of US dollars and Cambodian riel — but the riel amount is short by 4,000-8,000 (about \$1-2). In the chaos of two currencies, different denominations, and a language barrier, most tourists pocket the change without counting. Redditors on r/cambodia warn that the dual-currency system is deliberately exploited in Battambang's provincial markets, where tourists are less savvy than in Phnom Penh. Some vendors also pass worn or torn US bills that other shops refuse to accept.

■ Red Flags

- Change given in a mix of dollars and riel to confuse the math
- Vendor counts quickly and pushes you to move along
- Worn or damaged US dollar bills included in your change
- Exchange rate used is worse than the standard 4,000 riel per \$1
- Vendor claims they don't have smaller dollar bills to make correct change

■ How to Avoid

- Know the current riel-to-dollar rate (approximately 4,100 riel = \$1)
 - Count your change immediately and do the math before walking away
 - Carry small US dollar bills (\$1s and \$5s) to minimize change issues
 - Refuse damaged dollar bills in your change — they'll be rejected elsewhere
 - Use a currency converter app on your phone for quick calculations
-

The Motorbike Bag Snatch

■ ■ *Riverside promenade, Street 1 and Street 3, near Psar Nat market* You're walking along Battambang's riverside in the early evening, phone in hand, when a motorbike ... You're walking along Battambang's riverside in the early evening, phone in hand, when a motorbike with two riders zips past and the passenger snatches your phone or bag in one swift motion. You're left stunned as they disappear into traffic. Redditors on r/cambodia describe this as the most common crime affecting tourists in Cambodian cities — the rider-and-passenger team targets anyone holding a phone or wearing a crossbody bag on the road side. In Battambang, it happens most along the quiet riverside stretch where there are fewer witnesses. Red Flags Motorbike with two riders slowing down near pedestrians Riders circling the same block or making U-turns near you Being on a quiet road with your phone or camera visible Bag worn on the road-facing shoulder How to Avoid Wear bags on the building side, not the road side Don't walk with your phone in your hand — use it only when stationary Stay alert on quiet riverside roads in the evening Use a cross-body bag with the strap across your chest, tucked under your arm Keep valuables in your hotel safe and carry only what you need ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Cambodian Tourist Police station. Call 117 (Police) or 119 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at tourismcambodia.com. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Phnom Penh is at #1, Street 96, Sangkat Wat Phnom, Khan Daun Penh. For emergencies: +855 23-728-000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Cambodia ■ ■

You're walking along Battambang's riverside in the early evening, phone in hand, when a motorbike with two riders zips past and the passenger snatches your phone or bag in one swift motion. You're left stunned as they disappear into traffic. Redditors on r/cambodia describe this as the most common crime affecting tourists in Cambodian cities — the rider-and-passenger team targets anyone holding a phone or wearing a crossbody bag on the road side. In Battambang, it happens most along the quiet riverside stretch where there are fewer witnesses.

■ Red Flags

- Motorbike with two riders slowing down near pedestrians
- Riders circling the same block or making U-turns near you
- Being on a quiet road with your phone or camera visible
- Bag worn on the road-facing shoulder
- Wear bags on the building side, not the road side

■ How to Avoid

- Wear bags on the building side, not the road side
 - Don't walk with your phone in your hand — use it only when stationary
 - Stay alert on quiet riverside roads in the evening
 - Use a cross-body bag with the strap across your chest, tucked under your arm
 - Keep valuables in your hotel safe and carry only what you need
-

■■ Phnom Penh

7 scams documented • Cambodia

Tuk-Tuk Overcharge & Commission Shops

You agree, thinking you've found a bargain. What follows is a tour that includes unexpected stops at gem shops, tailors, and souvenir stores where the driver receives a commission for every minute you spend inside. The 'real' sights get rushed visits while the commission shops get generous time.

■ Red Flags

- Driver offers day tours at suspiciously low prices
- Route includes unexpected 'interesting' shops
- Driver insists you 'just look' at stores you didn't ask about
- Negotiate a fair rate (\$10-20/day) and specify that no commission stops are included
- Use Grab (Southeast Asia's Uber) for metered, transparent pricing

■ How to Avoid

- Negotiate a fair rate (\$10-20/day) and specify that no commission stops are included
 - Use Grab (Southeast Asia's Uber) for metered, transparent pricing
 - Plan your own itinerary and show the driver specifically where you want to go
-

Fake Monk Bracelet Sellers

You're walking along Phnom Penh's scenic Mekong riverside when a saffron-robed figure approaches, clasps your hands in a blessing, and ties a bracelet on your wrist while chanting. You assume this is a genuine spiritual interaction and feel honored. Then he holds out his palm for a donation — often quite aggressively — and other 'monks' nearby watch to ensure you pay. Real Buddhist monks do not approach foreigners on streets to sell goods.

■ Red Flags

- Robed figure approaches you proactively rather than you approaching a temple
- Blessing performed without consent in a non-temple setting
- Donation demanded rather than suggested, with visible pressure
- Real monks do not approach tourists on the street to sell or bless
- Politely decline by pressing palms together and moving on

■ How to Avoid

- Real monks do not approach tourists on the street to sell or bless
 - Politely decline by pressing palms together and moving on
 - If you want to make a genuine donation, do so at a legitimate temple
-

Card Game Gambling Scam

He introduces you to his 'uncle' — a wealthy businessman who needs a foreigner to help him win a card game against a casino owner as part of a deal. You're shown practice games and always win, building your confidence. The real game requires you to put up your own money, and you lose everything — the entire thing was staged.

■ Red Flags

- Friendly stranger who 'just happened to meet you' and quickly becomes your new best friend
- Elaborate family story to establish credibility and trust
- Proposition involves making money with minimal effort
- Never follow strangers to private homes or unfamiliar venues, no matter how friendly they seem
- Any gambling setup where foreigners are guaranteed to win is a scam

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow strangers to private homes or unfamiliar venues, no matter how friendly they seem
 - Any gambling setup where foreigners are guaranteed to win is a scam
 - The 'helpful local' setup is one of the most sophisticated scams in Southeast Asia — trust your instincts
-

Fake eVisa Website

You search for 'Cambodia visa online' and click the first or second result, which looks exactly like an official government website. You fill in your details and pay \$36 for an e-visa. Later you discover the official e-visa costs \$30, the website you used was fake, and your personal data — including passport scans — is now in the hands of a scam operation.

■ Red Flags

- Website URL is not evisa.gov.kh (the only official Cambodian e-visa site)
- Visa fee is different from the official \$30 (Tourist) or \$35 (Business)
- Website requests payment by wire transfer or cryptocurrency
- Only use evisa.gov.kh for Cambodian e-visa — bookmark this before your trip
- Ignore all paid search ads for 'Cambodia visa' — scroll to the official [.gov.kh](http://gov.kh) domain

■ How to Avoid

- Only use evisa.gov.kh for Cambodian e-visa — bookmark this before your trip
 - Ignore all paid search ads for 'Cambodia visa' — scroll to the official [.gov.kh](http://gov.kh) domain
 - Alternatively, visas on arrival are available at major ports of entry
-

Fake Orphanage Voluntourism

a chance to spend a day playing with children while donating money to support them. What you're actually funding is an operation that keeps children in poor conditions deliberately to extract donations from well-meaning tourists. Many of the children have living parents who were paid to surrender them for 'orphanage tourism.'

■ Red Flags

- Organization allows brief volunteer visits for a fee with minimal vetting
- Children perform poverty or sadness for visitors
- Photos with orphans are encouraged as part of the 'experience'
- Never visit or donate to orphanages on a tourist basis — even well-intentioned visits cause harm
- If you want to volunteer, use established organizations like PEPY or Friends-International that vet thoroughly

■ How to Avoid

- Never visit or donate to orphanages on a tourist basis — even well-intentioned visits cause harm
 - If you want to volunteer, use established organizations like PEPY or Friends-International that vet thoroughly
 - UNICEF and Save the Children both advise against orphanage tourism in Cambodia
-

Motorbike Rental Damage Scam

When you return the bike, the owner claims there's damage you didn't cause and refuses to return your passport until you pay an inflated repair bill. Without your passport you can't leave the country, and you feel trapped into paying whatever they demand.

■ Red Flags

- Rental shop requires your actual passport (not a copy) as deposit
- No detailed written condition report done before rental
- Shop has very few online reviews or negative reviews about damage claims
- Never surrender your original passport as rental deposit — offer a copy and cash instead
- Photograph and video every centimeter of the vehicle before driving away

■ How to Avoid

- Never surrender your original passport as rental deposit — offer a copy and cash instead
 - Photograph and video every centimeter of the vehicle before driving away
 - Use well-reviewed rental shops with established reputations from hostel recommendations
-

The Massage Parlor Phone Theft

■ ■ *Massage parlors near Riverside promenade, establishments on Street 136 and Street 172 near the Royal Palace, and cheap massage shops in BKK1* You visit a massage parlor near the Riverside. The therapist asks you to leave your phone and valuables in a provided basket during the session. When the massage ends, your phone is gone or has been accessed -- your banking apps drained of funds. A Reddit user posted a detailed warning titled 'Sophisticated Scam in Cambodia (Phnom Penh)' describing this exact operation: the scam takes place in massage parlors where staff access phones during the session. While you are face-down and relaxed, they use your fingerprint (pressed against the sensor while your hand rests) or simply access unlocked phones to transfer money. The establishments look legitimate and have good initial reviews. **Red Flags** The massage parlor insists you leave your phone and valuables in an open basket rather than a locked safe The therapist positions your hands in a way that your fingerprint could be used on a phone sensor The price is unusually low, suggesting the real revenue comes from theft rather than the massage The establishment has very recent positive reviews that look generic or fake Staff show unusual interest in your phone or ask which apps you use **How to Avoid** Lock your phone with a PIN code (not fingerprint) before entering any massage parlor Keep your phone in a zippered pocket on your person during the massage rather than in a provided basket Use establishments recommended by your hotel or well-reviewed on Google Maps with a long history of reviews Enable two-factor authentication on all banking and payment apps Never bring more cash than you are willing to lose to a massage appointment ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Cambodian Tourist Police station. Call 117 (Police) or 119 (Emergency). Get an

official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at tourismcambodia.com. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Phnom Penh is at #1, Street 96, Sangkat Wat Phnom, Khan Daun Penh. For emergencies: +855 23-728-000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. Frequently Asked Questions Is Phnom Penh safe for tourists? ▼

The therapist asks you to leave your phone and valuables in a provided basket during the session. When the massage ends, your phone is gone or has been accessed -- your banking apps drained of funds. A Reddit user posted a detailed warning titled 'Sophisticated Scam in Cambodia (Phnom Penh)' describing this exact operation: the scam takes place in massage parlors where staff access phones during the session. While you are face-down and relaxed, they use your fingerprint (pressed against the sensor while your hand rests) or simply access unlocked phones to transfer money. The establishments ...

■ Red Flags

- The massage parlor insists you leave your phone and valuables in an open basket rather than a locked safe
- The therapist positions your hands in a way that your fingerprint could be used on a phone sensor
- The price is unusually low, suggesting the real revenue comes from theft rather than the massage
- The establishment has very recent positive reviews that look generic or fake
- Staff show unusual interest in your phone or ask which apps you use

■ How to Avoid

- Lock your phone with a PIN code (not fingerprint) before entering any massage parlor
 - Keep your phone in a zippered pocket on your person during the massage rather than in a provided basket
 - Use establishments recommended by your hotel or well-reviewed on Google Maps with a long history of reviews
 - Enable two-factor authentication on all banking and payment apps
 - Never bring more cash than you are willing to lose to a massage appointment
-

■■ Siem Reap

7 scams documented • Cambodia

Fake Angkor Wat Tickets

You're heading to Angkor Wat and someone flags down your tuk-tuk on the road, offering to sell you tickets before you reach the official gate — saving you the queue. The tickets look authentic and even have holograms. When you reach the actual entrance, the scanner rejects them and security explains they're sophisticated fakes. You've lost \$37 per day and need to buy official tickets again.

■ Red Flags

- Ticket sellers approaching vehicles on the road before the official booth
- Someone at your guesthouse offers to 'organize' Angkor tickets for you
- Tickets sold at slightly below official price to seem like a bargain
- Buy Angkor passes only at the official Angkor Enterprise ticketing center (well-signed)
- The official center is at the north of Siem Reap — go directly and don't stop for roadside vendors

■ How to Avoid

- Buy Angkor passes only at the official Angkor Enterprise ticketing center (well-signed)
 - The official center is at the north of Siem Reap — go directly and don't stop for roadside vendors
 - Angkor passes include a photo taken of you at the booth — that's the authentication
-

Pub Street Overpriced Bar Tab

Locals and staff are extremely friendly, ordering rounds and keeping your glass full. When the bill comes, it's massive — you were charged for rounds you didn't order, at prices far above what's on the menu. The chaos and friendliness was cover for systematic overcharging.

■ Red Flags

- Staff orders extra drinks without explicitly asking your permission
- Running tab rather than pay-per-drink system
- Bill appears with unfamiliar items or quantities
- Pay for each round as it's served rather than running a tab
- Check the menu prices and verify your bill line by line before paying

■ How to Avoid

- Pay for each round as it's served rather than running a tab
 - Check the menu prices and verify your bill line by line before paying
 - Stick to well-reviewed bars on TripAdvisor with consistent pricing feedback
-

Children Begging Near Temples

Their pitch is practiced and heartbreaking — 'one dollar, only one dollar' — and they follow you persistently. Giving money feels compassionate, but it directly incentivizes families to keep children out of school to work as tourist beggars. The money often goes to adults who organize the operation.

■ Red Flags

- Children actively selling items at every temple exit
- Child knows exact phrases in many languages to target different tourists
- Large group of children working the same area in coordinated fashion
- Do not buy from child vendors — however heartbreaking it feels, it funds school truancy
- If you want to help, donate to established organizations like Riverkids or Friends-International

■ How to Avoid

- Do not buy from child vendors — however heartbreaking it feels, it funds school truancy
 - If you want to help, donate to established organizations like Riverkids or Friends-International
 - Buying from children perpetuates the cycle — walk past firmly but kindly
-

Tuk-Tuk Temple Tour Commission Stops

After lunch, he suggests visiting a 'silk village' and a 'traditional floating village' that aren't on your plan. You go along to be polite, spend an hour at each, and realize at the end of the day you only saw half the temples you planned. Your driver collected commission at each stop.

■ Red Flags

- Driver suggests detours not on your agreed itinerary
- Each detour involves a shop, workshop, or village with goods for sale
- Driver is unusually enthusiastic about specific 'authentic' experiences
- Give the driver a written list of the temples you want to visit and say that's the day's plan
- Be politely firm: 'Today is just temples, thanks — maybe tomorrow for the village'

■ How to Avoid

- Give the driver a written list of the temples you want to visit and say that's the day's plan
- Be politely firm: 'Today is just temples, thanks — maybe tomorrow for the village'

- Book through your hotel for drivers with verified good reputations
-

Sunrise Tuk-Tuk 'Exclusive' Spot

Your driver offers to take you to a 'secret' spot away from the crowds for a premium fee. You pay extra and he takes you to a random field with a partial view of the temple — barely visible and certainly not worth the money. The 'crowd-free' main sunrise viewing pool is free and the view is spectacular.

■ Red Flags

- Any driver offering 'exclusive' or 'hidden' sunrise spots for extra money
- Route goes away from the main temple complex rather than toward it
- Driver discourages the main pool: 'too many tourists, better view I know'
- The reflection pool in front of Angkor Wat is the classic sunrise view — go directly there
- Arrive by 5:00 AM to get a good spot at the free viewing area

■ How to Avoid

- The reflection pool in front of Angkor Wat is the classic sunrise view — go directly there
 - Arrive by 5:00 AM to get a good spot at the free viewing area
 - Ignore offers of 'premium' sunrise experiences from anyone other than an established tour company
-

Dodgy Airport/Bus Station Transfer

You assume it's your hotel's transfer. At the hotel, you realize the driver was an independent tout — no connection to your booking — and has charged you \$20 when the hotel's free shuttle was waiting. Or you're dropped at a 'partner hotel' instead of your actual one.

■ Red Flags

- Driver holds your name on a sign but can't name your hotel accurately
- Driver is very eager to get you in the car before you confirm details
- Price much higher than Grab app rates
- Pre-arrange airport pickup through your hotel directly
- Use the Grab app for transparent, metered pricing from the airport

■ How to Avoid

- Pre-arrange airport pickup through your hotel directly
 - Use the Grab app for transparent, metered pricing from the airport
 - Confirm the driver's identity and your hotel name before getting into any vehicle
-

The 7-Eleven Short Change Hustle Near Pub Street

■ ■ 7-Eleven stores near Pub Street, convenience stores along Sivatha Boulevard, night market vendor stalls You stop at the 7-Eleven near Pub Street for water and snacks. The store insists on cash only — unusual for a chain that normally accepts cards. You hand over a \$10 bill for a \$3 purchase. The cashier counts your change quickly and hands back \$5 instead of \$7. When you question it, they argue that the price was different. Reddit users on r/cambodia specifically warned about the 7-Eleven near Pub Street: 'Cash only. They want cash only and will short-change you every chance they get.' Staff allegedly split the 'stolen money' among themselves daily. The tactic exploits tourists who are unfamiliar with Cambodian riel-to-dollar conversions. Red Flags A store that should accept cards insists on cash-only payment The cashier counts change very quickly or below counter level where you cannot easily see Prices are not clearly displayed or differ from what is charged at the register The cashier becomes defensive or dismissive when you question the change amount Your change comes in a mix of dollars and riel designed to confuse the total How to Avoid Count your change carefully and immediately at the counter before stepping away Know the current exchange rate: approximately 4,100 riel per US dollar Use stores further from Pub Street where tourist-targeting is less common Pay with exact change or small bills to minimize opportunities for short-changing If short-changed, ask firmly for the correct amount — most staff will comply when caught ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Cambodian Tourist Police station. Call 117

(Police) or 119 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at tourismcambodia.com. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Phnom Penh is at #1, Street 96, Sangkat Wat Phnom, Khan Daun Penh. For emergencies: +855 23-728-000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. *Frequently Asked Questions Is Siem Reap safe for tourists?* ▼

The store insists on cash only — unusual for a chain that normally accepts cards. You hand over a \$10 bill for a \$3 purchase. The cashier counts your change quickly and hands back \$5 instead of \$7. When you question it, they argue that the price was different. Reddit users on [r/cambodia](https://www.reddit.com/r/cambodia) specifically warned about the 7-Eleven near Pub Street: 'Cash only. They want cash only and will short-change you every chance they get.' Staff allegedly split the 'stolen money' among themselves daily. The tactic exploits tourists who are unfamiliar with Cambodian riel-to-dollar conversions.

■ Red Flags

- A store that should accept cards insists on cash-only payment
- The cashier counts change very quickly or below counter level where you cannot easily see
- Prices are not clearly displayed or differ from what is charged at the register
- The cashier becomes defensive or dismissive when you question the change amount
- Your change comes in a mix of dollars and riel designed to confuse the total

■ How to Avoid

- Count your change carefully and immediately at the counter before stepping away
 - Know the current exchange rate: approximately 4,100 riel per US dollar
 - Use stores further from Pub Street where tourist-targeting is less common
 - Pay with exact change or small bills to minimize opportunities for short-changing
 - If short-changed, ask firmly for the correct amount — most staff will comply when caught
-

■ Indonesia

■ ■ Bali

9 scams documented • Indonesia

Fake Money Exchange

A bright sign on Jalan Legian advertises an exchange rate that's 30% better than the airport. The young man behind the counter is friendly, counts out a stack of bills right in front of you, slides it across the glass, and you count along. Everything looks right. You pocket the cash and head toward your hotel. Three blocks away, you recount. You're short by 300,000 rupiah — about \$20 USD. The extra bills you thought you saw were just tucked underneath as 'bookmarks,' then palmed back by the counter man in a sleight-of-hand you didn't catch. Multiple [r/solotravel](https://www.reddit.com/r/solotravel) users report this happening ...

■ Red Flags

- Exchange rate advertised is significantly higher than bank rates
- Cashier counts money rapidly and distracts you with conversation
- Extra bills visible under the stack that seem to disappear
- No official signage, license, or Bank Indonesia certification displayed

- Pressure to hurry because of 'other customers waiting'

■ How to Avoid

- Use ATMs affiliated with major banks like BCA or Mandiri for cash
 - Only exchange at authorized money changers with official PT certification visible
 - Always count every single bill yourself before leaving the counter
 - Use the Wise card or similar travel card for fee-free conversions
 - If short-changed, stay at the counter and demand a recount before stepping away
-

Rigged Taxi Meter & Inflated Airport Cab

You wheel your luggage out of arrivals at Bali's international airport and immediately a dozen men press in, waving laminated cards. One grabs your bag and starts walking — you follow instinctively. He says he works for the 'official airport taxi' and names a flat fare to your hotel in Seminyak that sounds reasonable. You agree without checking and hop in. The driver takes a suspiciously long route, and the meter either doesn't run or starts at an inflated number. By the time you reach Seminyak, the fare is three times what apps like Gojek would charge. A r/bali user described paying 500,00...

■ Red Flags

- Driver approaches you inside arrivals before you exit to the official taxi stand
- Quote for fixed fare given before you state your destination
- Driver refuses to use or shows a pre-rigged taxi meter
- Additional fees (luggage, toll, airport) mentioned only upon arrival at destination
- Vehicle license plate doesn't match what the ride-hailing app shows

■ How to Avoid

- Book a Klook airport transfer in advance with a fixed confirmed price
 - Use the official prepaid taxi counter inside the terminal past customs
 - If using Gojek or Grab, meet your driver at the designated pickup point outside airport limits
 - Always agree on a final price including all fees before entering any vehicle
 - Screenshot your route on Google Maps so you can track if the driver deviates
-

Temple Dress Code Extortion

A man positioned right at the entrance — he could pass for an official — shakes his head sympathetically and says you need a sarong to enter. The temple requires modesty, which is true, but what isn't true is his price: 100,000 rupiah for a rental that should cost 10,000 or less, or is often free. He's counting on you being embarrassed and eager to comply quickly. Some freelancers go further: they hand you the sarong, tie it on you helpfully, and then demand a 'donation' for the temple on top of the rental. At Uluwatu, r/bali visitors reported being surrounded by a small group near the gate...

■ Red Flags

- Person demanding fees has no official uniform or temple ID badge
- Sarong rental price is quoted before you even ask
- Claims your pre-purchased ticket is invalid for part of the site
- Insists on tying the sarong for you and then demands a 'tip'
- Monkey takes your item and a 'helper' materializes immediately after

■ How to Avoid

- Wear or pack a sarong when visiting any Balinese Hindu temple
- Buy tickets only at official booths inside the entrance, not outside

- Free sarong loans are available at most major temples — ask official staff
 - Keep sunglasses, hats, and phones tucked away or secured near monkey zones
 - If approached by unofficial 'guides,' simply walk to the official ticket booth
-

Ubud Fake 'Closed Road' Detour to Commission Shop

There's a 'ceremony today,' he says — the road to your next destination is blocked. No problem, he knows a shortcut. Ten minutes later you're pulling up to a batik factory or silver workshop that, coincidentally, is run by his cousin. Inside, a very charming woman explains the traditional craft, offers you tea, and shows you the retail section. The prices are three to five times the market rate. This is perhaps the most-documented scam across all [r/solotravel](#) and [r/travel](#) India/Bali threads. One user described being taken to three different 'art cooperatives' in a single day tour: 'I didn't...

■ Red Flags

- Driver mentions a 'ceremony' or 'road closure' before you've even seen any blockage
- Detour ends specifically at a factory, gallery, or showroom — not an alternate route
- Staff are waiting and immediately begin a sales tour or craft demonstration
- You're served tea or snacks, creating social obligation to buy
- Any local who befriends you at a tourist site suggests a nearby 'authentic' shop

■ How to Avoid

- Book tours through reputable operators like Airbnb Experiences or established agencies
 - Agree with your driver in advance: 'No shopping stops unless I ask'
 - If taken to a shop, you are under zero obligation — drink the tea and leave
 - Research your route on Google Maps so you know if a 'detour' is legitimate
 - Use a metered taxi or app ride rather than private unregistered drivers for temple hops
-

Surfboard Damage Demand

The rental guy hands it over with barely a glance at the board's condition — no walk-around inspection, no photos taken. After a great session, you bring it back, and suddenly he crouches down and points to a ding on the rail. 'This is new damage,' he says. 'You must pay repair.' You're fairly certain it was already there, but there's no documentation to prove it. [R/bali](#) has an entire thread on this — one user was asked to pay 1,000,000 rupiah (about \$65 USD) for a small ding on a beat-up rental board at Echo Beach. The rental guy became aggressive when the tourist resisted, blocking the pa...

■ Red Flags

- Rental operator skips any inspection of board condition before handing it over
- No photos taken, no written rental agreement, just a handshake deal
- Damage appears on a part of the board you didn't make contact with
- Demand is made in a location away from the main beach area with few witnesses
- Operator becomes aggressive or threatens to involve police when you question the charge

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph every part of the surfboard on your phone before accepting it
 - Get operator to acknowledge existing damage in writing or on video
 - Rent from established surf schools like Odysseys or Pro Surf rather than freelance vendors
 - Agree on a damage policy and maximum liability in advance
 - If pressured, stay calm, get public witnesses, and contact your accommodation for help
-

Phishing Visa & Tourist Levy Websites

it looks official, has the Indonesian flag, and walks you through a familiar-looking form. You enter your passport number, travel dates, and credit card details. Days later you receive an email saying your 'visa has been processed.' Then you notice unfamiliar charges on your card. R/bali has multiple pinned warnings about this exact scam, with one moderator post noting: 'Beware of scam/phishing when applying for Indonesian Tourist Visa online — we used a site that looked official and our credit card details were compromised.' Indonesia's actual eVisa site is evisa.imigrasi.go.id, and Bali's...

■ Red Flags

- Visa or levy website URL does not end in [.go.id](https://www.go.id) (official Indonesian government domain)
- Site asks for credit card details rather than directing to a government payment portal
- Unsolicited email or social media ad promotes 'fast-track' or 'guaranteed' visa service
- Form asks for more personal details than an eVisa typically requires
- Confirmation email arrives immediately with no processing time at all

■ How to Avoid

- Bookmark the official Indonesian eVisa site: evisa.imigrasi.go.id before your trip
 - Pay the Bali tourist levy only at lovebali.baliprov.go.id
 - Complete the customs declaration on the official app or on arrival at the airport
 - Use a virtual credit card with a spending limit for online government forms
 - If you've already entered details on a suspect site, freeze your card immediately
-

Mount Batur Forced Guide Scam

The trail head at the base of the volcano in Kintamani is buzzing with activity at 3am. Before you can start hiking, a group of men blocks your way and informs you that 'guides are mandatory' for the hike. The 'mandatory guide' will cost you 500,000 to 800,000 rupiah — around \$30-\$50 USD — for a trail that is entirely walkable without assistance. This isn't a legal requirement in any official capacity, despite what these men insist. A r/bali post that went viral in March 2025 laid out step-by-step instructions for hiking Mount Batur without a guide, noting: 'Don't pay for the guides, it's a...

■ Red Flags

- Men physically position themselves across the path before you begin climbing
- Claim that guides are 'legally required' with no official sign or document to back it up
- Price quoted jumps if you hesitate or try to negotiate
- Only cash accepted, no receipt offered
- Claims that the trail is 'very dangerous' or 'impossible' without a guide

■ How to Avoid

- Book a legitimate guide through your hotel or guesthouse the evening before
 - Research the trail on AllTrails or recent r/bali posts — it is well-marked
 - Arrive in a larger group so individual pressure is less effective
 - Carry a headlamp with good battery and a downloaded offline map
 - If blocked, be firm but non-confrontational: 'No thank you' and walk around
-

The Corrupt Cop Drug Shakedown

You are walking back to your villa in Seminyak after a night out when a police officer on a motorbike pulls alongside you. He claims he can smell marijuana and demands to search your bag. Whether or not he finds anything, he produces a small bag of what he says is drugs and tells you that drug possession carries a minimum four-year prison sentence in Indonesia. He offers an alternative: pay 5 to 10 million rupiah in cash right now and the matter disappears. Bali Holiday Secrets, Bali Untold, and Sunshine Seeker's 2024 scam

guides all document this police shakedown as one of Bali's top scams...

■ Red Flags

- A police officer stops you on a quiet street late at night rather than at an official checkpoint
- The officer claims to smell drugs or says you were seen in a drug area
- A small bag of what the officer says is drugs appears during the search of your belongings
- The officer immediately suggests a cash payment to resolve the situation rather than taking you to a station
- The officer does not have a body camera or partner and insists the payment is informal

■ How to Avoid

- If stopped by police, stay calm and politely ask to be taken to the nearest police station rather than paying cash on the street
- Ask to see the officer's identification card and note or photograph his badge number
- Call your country's embassy emergency line if threatened with arrest and do not hand over your passport
- Walk in groups rather than alone when returning from nightlife areas in Kuta, Seminyak, and Canggu
- Never carry or use any drugs in Bali as Indonesian drug laws carry severe penalties including lengthy prison sentences

The Villa Booking Scam

■ ■ *Online listings on Instagram and Facebook for villas in Canggu, Ubud, and Seminyak, Kuta beachfront rental advertisements* You find a stunning Canggu villa on Instagram at half the price of similar listings on Airbnb. The account has beautiful photos and hundreds of followers. You message them, and they send a WhatsApp number. Payment is requested via bank transfer to a Balinese account. You send 8 million rupiah for a three-night stay. When you arrive in Bali, the address either does not exist or belongs to a completely different property. The Instagram account has blocked you. Bali scam guides from 2024 to 2026 warn extensively about fake villa listings on social media, noting that scammers steal photos from legitimate properties and create convincing accounts. **Red Flags** The villa is advertised only on Instagram or Facebook rather than established booking platforms The price is dramatically lower than comparable properties on Airbnb or Booking.com Payment is requested via bank transfer or crypto rather than through a platform with buyer protection The owner refuses a video call or live walkthrough of the property The listing has no reviews from verified guests on independent travel platforms **How to Avoid** Book villas only through established platforms like Airbnb, Booking.com, or Agoda that offer refund protection and verified reviews If you find a property on social media, search the photos on Google Images to check if they belong to a different listing Never pay by bank transfer to an individual; always use a platform or credit card with dispute protection Request a video call tour of the property before transferring any money Cross-reference the villa address on Google Maps Street View to verify the property exists and matches the photos ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Indonesian National Police (Polri) station. Call 110 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at polri.go.id. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Jakarta is at Jl. Merdeka Selatan No. 3-5, Jakarta 10110. For emergencies: +62 21-5083-1000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. *More Scam Guides More in Indonesia* ■ ■

The account has beautiful photos and hundreds of followers. You message them, and they send a WhatsApp number. Payment is requested via bank transfer to a Balinese account. You send 8 million rupiah for a three-night stay. When you arrive in Bali, the address either does not exist or belongs to a completely different property. The Instagram account has blocked you. Bali scam guides from 2024 to 2026 warn extensively about fake villa listings on social media, noting that scammers steal photos from legitimate properties and create convincing accounts.

■ Red Flags

- The villa is advertised only on Instagram or Facebook rather than established booking platforms
- The price is dramatically lower than comparable properties on Airbnb or Booking.com
- Payment is requested via bank transfer or crypto rather than through a platform with buyer protection
- The owner refuses a video call or live walkthrough of the property

- The listing has no reviews from verified guests on independent travel platforms

■ How to Avoid

- Book villas only through established platforms like Airbnb, Booking.com, or Agoda that offer refund protection and verified reviews
 - If you find a property on social media, search the photos on Google Images to check if they belong to a different listing
 - Never pay by bank transfer to an individual; always use a platform or credit card with dispute protection
 - Request a video call tour of the property before transferring any money
 - Cross-reference the villa address on Google Maps Street View to verify the property exists and matches the photos
-

■ ■ Batam

5 scams documented • Indonesia

The Immigration Shakedown

An officer pulls you aside into a small back room away from other travelers. He examines your passport and claims there's a problem -- maybe your visa is 'irregular,' or you were 'disrespectful' during the process. He suggests the issue can be resolved with a payment of S\$200-250, in cash, right now. If you refuse, he implies you'll be detained or deported. As reported extensively in 2025 by South China Morning Post and the Indonesian government's own investigation, systematic extortion by immigration officers at Batam's ferry terminal was so widespread that dozens of officers were fired an...

■ Red Flags

- An immigration officer pulls you out of the regular queue into a private room
- They claim a vague 'violation' without showing you any official documentation
- They request payment in Singapore dollars or cash rather than through official channels
- The amount demanded is a round number like S\$200 or S\$250 with no official receipt offered
- There is no other official present and no security camera visible in the room

■ How to Avoid

- Ensure all visa requirements are met before traveling -- Indonesian e-visa on arrival for Singapore residents is straightforward via the official Molina app
 - If pulled aside, remain calm and politely ask to see a supervisor or official documentation of the violation
 - Never pay cash without an official government receipt -- legitimate fines are processed through formal channels
 - Record the officer's name and badge number and report extortion to the Indonesia immigration hotline or the Singapore embassy
 - Travel with a printed copy of your visa confirmation and return ferry ticket to preempt false claims
-

The Taxi Fare Ambush

You exit the Batam ferry terminal and are immediately swarmed by taxi drivers shouting hotel names and waving laminated price cards. One driver offers to take you to Nagoya Hill for '100,000 rupiah.' You agree and climb in. But the ride ends with the driver demanding 100,000 per person, not per car. With three in your group, that's 300,000 IDR for a ride that Grab would price at 50,000-70,000 IDR total. The driver becomes aggressive when you challenge the fare. As Batam travel forums and Tripadvisor threads document, unlicensed drivers at Batam's ferry terminals consistently overcharge Sing...

■ Red Flags

- Drivers aggressively approach you inside or immediately outside the terminal building
- The vehicle has no meter and no ride-hailing app sticker (Grab or Gojek)

- The fare is quoted per person rather than per car, or the currency is ambiguous
- The driver does not offer a receipt and insists on cash payment
- The quoted fare is more than double what ride-hailing apps show for the same route

■ How to Avoid

- Download the Grab app and book rides from slightly outside the ferry terminal building where Grab drivers can pick up
 - Walk across to the nearby shopping mall parking area where Grab pickups are not restricted
 - Agree on the total fare for the entire car (not per person) before getting in, and confirm the currency is IDR
 - Arrange hotel airport transfers in advance -- most Batam hotels offer ferry terminal pickup for fixed rates
 - Use the official metered taxi rank if available, and insist the meter runs from the start
-

The Spa Bait-and-Switch

The price board says 250,000 IDR for a full-body treatment. It sounds like a steal. The massage begins, and partway through, the therapist offers an 'included' ear candling treatment. You confirm twice that it's part of the package. After the massage -- which ends 5 minutes early -- the therapist demands an additional S\$50 for the ear candling, insisting she never said it was included. The spa manager backs her up. As documented on Tripadvisor and Batam travel forums, some spas deliberately confuse tourists about what is included, then demand payment in Singapore dollars (worth roughly 12 t...

■ Red Flags

- The spa quotes some prices in IDR but switches to SGD for add-on services
- The therapist offers 'included' extras mid-treatment without showing a written price list
- The massage ends noticeably shorter than the booked duration
- Staff become confrontational when you dispute charges for services you believed were complimentary
- The spa has recent negative reviews mentioning hidden charges or bait-and-switch pricing

■ How to Avoid

- Confirm the full list of services and total price in writing (or on the spa's printed menu) before the treatment begins
 - Decline all add-on services offered during the massage unless you see the price first
 - Pay in Indonesian rupiah, not Singapore dollars -- the IDR price is always more favorable
 - Read Google and Tripadvisor reviews before visiting any spa, filtering for recent complaints about hidden fees
 - Visit well-established spa chains like Montigo Resorts or hotel-based spas with standardized transparent pricing
-

The Money Changer Sleight-of-Hand

A money changer near the mall entrance displays an exchange rate that's slightly better than the bank next door. You hand over S\$100 and the clerk begins counting out rupiah notes. The denominations are large and unfamiliar -- 100,000, 50,000, 20,000 notes all look similar to the untrained eye. The clerk counts quickly, stacks the notes, then counts them again, subtly palming two 100,000 notes in the process. You walk away 200,000 IDR short. As Indonesian travel forums warn, unlicensed money changers are experts at fast counting and distraction techniques designed to short-change tourists u...

■ Red Flags

- The exchange rate displayed is noticeably better than nearby banks or licensed changers
- The clerk counts and recounts the money multiple times, handling it very quickly
- The notes are spread across the counter in confusing piles rather than counted clearly once
- The shop is a small kiosk without official Bank Indonesia signage or licensing
- The clerk becomes impatient if you want to recount the money yourself

■ How to Avoid

- Exchange money only at licensed money changers inside malls or at major bank branches (BCA, Mandiri, BNI)
 - Count your money slowly and carefully at the counter before walking away, using a currency counting app for reference
 - Never hand over your Singapore dollars until the rupiah has been counted and verified
 - Use ATMs at reputable banks for the best exchange rates -- BCA and Mandiri have machines at the ferry terminal
 - Familiarize yourself with Indonesian banknote designs before your trip so you can quickly spot incorrect denominations
-

The Unlicensed Tour Guide Hustle

■ ■ *Batam Centre Ferry Terminal exit and Bareleng Bridge area* You step out of the ferry terminal and a man with a laminated badge approaches, offering a ... You step out of the ferry terminal and a man with a laminated badge approaches, offering a 'full-day Batam tour' for S\$30 per person. It sounds reasonable -- he promises visits to Bareleng Bridge, a seafood lunch, and a temple. An hour in, the itinerary becomes a series of commission stops: a spa where he earns a kickback, a souvenir shop with inflated prices, and a restaurant that overcharges while he eats for free. The actual sightseeing is rushed, and he asks for additional 'fuel money' and tips throughout the day. Reddit and Batam travel forums note that unlicensed guides at the ferry terminal run commission-based itineraries designed to maximize their income, not your experience. **Red Flags** The guide approaches you unsolicited at the ferry terminal with a pre-packaged tour deal Their badge looks unofficial and they cannot provide a government-issued guide license The itinerary includes multiple shopping or spa stops that seem unrelated to sightseeing Additional fees for fuel, tolls, or entrance tickets are requested throughout the day The guide steers you away from restaurants or shops you choose and toward their preferred partners **How to Avoid** Book tours through your hotel or reputable platforms like Klook or GetYourGuide before arriving in Batam If hiring a local guide, verify their government-issued tourism license (Kartu Tanda Pengenal Pramuwisata) Agree on a complete itinerary and all-inclusive price in writing before the tour begins Politely decline any stops at shops or spas that were not on the agreed itinerary Rent a car with driver through your hotel for more flexibility and transparent hourly pricing ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Indonesian National Police (Polri) station. Call 110 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at polri.go.id. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Jakarta is at Jl. Merdeka Selatan No. 3-5, Jakarta 10110. For emergencies: +62 21-5083-1000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in Indonesia** ■ ■

You step out of the ferry terminal and a man with a laminated badge approaches, offering a 'full-day Batam tour' for S\$30 per person. It sounds reasonable -- he promises visits to Bareleng Bridge, a seafood lunch, and a temple. An hour in, the itinerary becomes a series of commission stops: a spa where he earns a kickback, a souvenir shop with inflated prices, and a restaurant that overcharges while he eats for free. The actual sightseeing is rushed, and he asks for additional 'fuel money' and tips throughout the day. Reddit and Batam travel forums note that unlicensed guides at the ferry t...

■ Red Flags

- The guide approaches you unsolicited at the ferry terminal with a pre-packaged tour deal
- Their badge looks unofficial and they cannot provide a government-issued guide license
- The itinerary includes multiple shopping or spa stops that seem unrelated to sightseeing
- Additional fees for fuel, tolls, or entrance tickets are requested throughout the day
- The guide steers you away from restaurants or shops you choose and toward their preferred partners

■ How to Avoid

- Book tours through your hotel or reputable platforms like Klook or GetYourGuide before arriving in Batam
 - If hiring a local guide, verify their government-issued tourism license (Kartu Tanda Pengenal Pramuwisata)
 - Agree on a complete itinerary and all-inclusive price in writing before the tour begins
 - Politely decline any stops at shops or spas that were not on the agreed itinerary
 - Rent a car with driver through your hotel for more flexibility and transparent hourly pricing
-

■ Jakarta

6 scams documented • Indonesia

The Fake Blue Bird Taxi

Indonesia's most reputable taxi company, known for always using meters and employing professional drivers. The car is the right shade of blue with what looks like the bird logo. You get in, and the driver says the meter is broken but offers a fixed price. After a ride through confusing one-way streets with multiple twists and turns, you arrive at your destination and the driver demands 300,000 IDR for a trip that should have cost 130,000 IDR. TripAdvisor's Jakarta forum has multiple threads about Blue Bird taxi scams, including one titled 'BLUE BIRD taxi SCAM' where a traveler reported bein...

■ Red Flags

- The driver says the meter is broken and insists on a fixed price — real Blue Bird meters always work
- The logo on the car looks slightly different from the official Blue Bird logo — check for 'Blue Bird Group' vs the actual Bluebird design
- The driver is not wearing the distinctive blue batik uniform that all legitimate Blue Bird drivers wear
- There is no visible URL 'bluebird.co.id' on the windshield or a specific driver ID card on the dashboard
- The route involves unnecessary detours, one-way street explanations, and constant turns that prevent you from tracking your location

■ How to Avoid

- Use the official My Blue Bird app to book rides — the car, driver, and plate number are confirmed before pickup
- Book through Grab or Gojek apps instead, which show fixed upfront pricing and GPS-tracked routes
- Check three things before getting in: the Bluebird URL on the windshield, the ID number on the door, and the driver's blue batik uniform
- Never accept a taxi where the driver claims the meter is broken — exit immediately and find another cab
- At the airport, use the official Blue Bird taxi counter inside the terminal rather than hailing cabs from the curb

Money Changer Sleight of Hand

noticeably better than the 15,800 rate at the bank. You hand over \$100 and watch the teller count out 1,650,000 IDR in front of you. The amount looks correct. He then gathers the notes together to put them in an envelope, and in that moment, his hands drop several bills behind the desk or counter screen. He hands you the envelope with a friendly smile. You count it at your hotel and find only 1,200,000 IDR. Coconuts Bali published a viral article featuring a magician who demonstrated exactly how money exchange scammers use sleight of hand to con tourists, showing that bills are dropped behi...

■ Red Flags

- The advertised exchange rate is significantly better than the rate at banks or ATMs
- The booth advertises 'zero commission' or 'best rate guaranteed' with hand-painted signs
- The teller counts the money once to show you, then gathers and re-stacks the bills before handing them over
- There is a counter with a raised edge, screen, or partition behind which hands can disappear from view
- The teller rushes you to take the money and leave or places the bills in an envelope rather than letting you recount

■ How to Avoid

- Use ATMs from major Indonesian banks (BCA, Mandiri, BNI) for the best rates and guaranteed accurate amounts
- If you must use a money changer, go to a licensed bureau inside a shopping mall or at the airport — never a street booth
- Count the money yourself on the spot before leaving the counter — do not allow the teller to restack or envelope the bills

- Ignore exchange rates that seem too good to be true — a rate 5 percent better than the bank means someone is getting cheated
 - Keep your hand on the money once counted — do not let the teller take it back for any reason after the initial count
-

Ojek Driver Overcharge and App Cancellation

A motorcycle pulls up, the driver confirms your name, and you hop on. Five minutes into the ride, the driver stops and says there is a problem with the app and he needs to cancel the booking. He then offers to complete the ride for cash — at a price two to three times the app fare. If you refuse, you are stranded in an unfamiliar area of Jakarta. Some traditional ojek drivers use a different tactic: they wait outside tourist hotels and quote fixed prices that are five to ten times the app rate, and when you try to book Grab or Gojek, they tell you the apps do not work in this area. The Sout...

■ Red Flags

- An ojek driver outside your hotel quotes a fixed price without using an app and the amount is significantly higher than what Grab or Gojek shows
- Your app-booked driver cancels the ride mid-trip and offers to continue for cash at a higher rate
- Someone tells you Grab or Gojek do not operate in the area where you are standing — they almost certainly do
- Traditional ojek drivers at a bus station claim there are no buses to your destination and only their taxi can take you
- The driver asks you to cancel the app booking yourself, claiming a 'system error'

■ How to Avoid

- Always book rides through Grab or Gojek — the apps show upfront pricing, track the route via GPS, and provide driver accountability
 - If a driver cancels mid-ride, refuse the cash offer, open the app, and book a new ride from wherever they dropped you
 - Never cancel a booking at the driver's request — if there is a genuine technical issue, let the driver cancel so the platform records the issue
 - Ignore traditional ojek drivers who approach you at bus stations or airports claiming no other transport exists — check the app yourself
 - Set your pickup point to the hotel lobby or a nearby landmark where your app signal is strong, rather than on the street where conventional drivers might intercept
-

The Batik or Art Gallery Student Scam

You are taking photos near Monas when a friendly young person approaches, says they are an art student, and strikes up a conversation about your country. After pleasant small talk, they invite you to see their art exhibition or batik gallery just around the corner — free of charge. The gallery turns out to be a high-pressure sales room where paintings or batik fabrics are displayed with enormous price tags. The 'student' becomes the salesperson, and other staff members join in. A painting that would sell for 200,000 IDR at a local market is priced at 2,000,000 IDR or more. Bounding Over Our...

■ Red Flags

- A friendly stranger initiates conversation at a tourist site and seems particularly interested in where you are from
- They mention being an art or university student and invite you to see their work or a free gallery nearby
- The gallery or shop has no visible price tags, and prices are only quoted verbally after you have shown interest
- Once inside, the sales pressure intensifies with multiple staff members joining the conversation
- You are told the art is a special investment or that the student needs sales to fund their education

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline invitations from strangers to visit galleries, shops, or exhibitions — if the art were valuable, it would not need street recruitment

- If you want to buy batik or Indonesian art, visit established markets like Pasar Seni or Sarinah department store where prices are standardized
 - Never feel pressured to buy because someone spent time talking to you — conversation does not create a purchase obligation
 - If you enter a shop and feel trapped, simply say 'Tidak, terima kasih' (No, thank you) and walk out — they cannot legally detain you
 - Research the fair price range for batik and Indonesian artwork before your trip so you recognize inflated pricing immediately
-

Crowded Commuter Train Pickpocketing

The train is packed — standing room only with bodies pressed together. A group of people pushes onto the carriage, creating a surge of movement. In the confusion of bodies shifting, a hand reaches into your pocket or unzips your bag. You do not feel a thing. When you reach your stop and check for your phone, it is gone. GoDigit's comprehensive guide to tourist scams in Indonesia identifies pickpocketing as a major concern in crowded areas, noting that busy market areas and public transport are the primary target zones. World Nomads' Indonesia safety page specifically warns about pickpockets...

■ Red Flags

- Someone bumps into you unnecessarily in a crowd, especially from behind or to the side
- A group of people crowds around you despite available space elsewhere in the train or platform
- Someone asks you a question or creates a distraction while another person stands unusually close behind you
- Your bag zipper is partially open when you did not leave it that way
- You feel a light touch on your pocket, bag, or waistband that does not match the normal jostling of a crowd

■ How to Avoid

- Avoid rush hour on the KRL commuter trains — travel mid-morning or early afternoon when carriages are less packed
 - Use a cross-body bag worn on your front and keep one hand on it at all times in crowded transit
 - Keep your phone in a deep front pocket, ideally with a zipper, rather than in your back pocket or bag outer pocket
 - Consider using Grab or Gojek for point-to-point transport instead of crowded public transit, especially with valuables
 - If you must ride during rush hour, stand with your back against a wall or pole so no one can access your pockets from behind
-

The Scenic Detour Taxi Meter Scam

■ ■ Routes from Soekarno-Hatta Airport to central Jakarta, trips between major hotels, and any taxi ride during heavy traffic periods You hail a regular (non-Blue Bird) taxi from a shopping mall and ask to go to your hotel near Thamrin. The driver starts the meter and pulls into traffic. Jakarta's legendary gridlock gives him the perfect cover — the route should take 20 minutes but he weaves through side streets, claiming he knows a shortcut to avoid the jam. An hour later, you arrive at your hotel with a meter reading of 200,000 IDR for a trip that should have cost 60,000 IDR. When you question the amount, the driver points at the meter and shrugs. Jakarta Globe's investigation into tourist taxi scams explains how drivers deliberately take longer routes to inflate meter fares, particularly during heavy traffic when tourists cannot easily distinguish between a legitimate detour and an intentional one. The GoDigit scam guide warns that some drivers refuse to use the meter altogether, offering fixed prices that are much higher than normal. Ela Aleph Cruising's Indonesia guide confirms that counterfeit taxis scam tourists by charging much higher prices or not using the meter, with some taxi companies being particularly notorious. The introduction of ride-hailing apps has reduced but not eliminated this scam, as many tourists still hail conventional taxis from hotel ranks and street corners. Red Flags The driver takes back streets and residential areas instead of the main highway or direct route The trip takes significantly longer than Google Maps estimates, even accounting for Jakarta traffic The meter reading seems to climb faster than the distance traveled would suggest The driver ignores your Google Maps directions and insists he knows a better way You are in a taxi with no company markings, no driver ID displayed, or the meter looks modified How to Avoid Use Grab, Gojek, or the My Blue Bird app for all rides — GPS tracking and upfront pricing eliminate both route manipulation and meter fraud If taking a street taxi, follow the route on Google Maps in real time and speak up if the driver deviates significantly Choose Blue Bird or Express taxis only — these are the two

most reputable conventional taxi companies in Jakarta Know the approximate distance and cost to your destination before getting in — the airport to central Jakarta is about 30 km and should cost 150,000-200,000 IDR by metered taxi Take a photo of the taxi license plate and driver ID before departure and share it with your hotel or a friend ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indonesian National Police (Polri) station. Call 110 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at polri.go.id. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Jakarta is at Jl. Merdeka Selatan No. 3-5, Jakarta 10110. For emergencies: +62 21-5083-1000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Indonesia ■■

The driver starts the meter and pulls into traffic. Jakarta's legendary gridlock gives him the perfect cover — the route should take 20 minutes but he weaves through side streets, claiming he knows a shortcut to avoid the jam. An hour later, you arrive at your hotel with a meter reading of 200,000 IDR for a trip that should have cost 60,000 IDR. When you question the amount, the driver points at the meter and shrugs. Jakarta Globe's investigation into tourist taxi scams explains how drivers deliberately take longer routes to inflate meter fares, particularly during heavy traffic when touris...

■ Red Flags

- The driver takes back streets and residential areas instead of the main highway or direct route
- The trip takes significantly longer than Google Maps estimates, even accounting for Jakarta traffic
- The meter reading seems to climb faster than the distance traveled would suggest
- The driver ignores your Google Maps directions and insists he knows a better way
- You are in a taxi with no company markings, no driver ID displayed, or the meter looks modified

■ How to Avoid

- Use Grab, Gojek, or the My Blue Bird app for all rides — GPS tracking and upfront pricing eliminate both route manipulation and meter fraud
- If taking a street taxi, follow the route on Google Maps in real time and speak up if the driver deviates significantly
- Choose Blue Bird or Express taxis only — these are the two most reputable conventional taxi companies in Jakarta
- Know the approximate distance and cost to your destination before getting in — the airport to central Jakarta is about 30 km and should cost 150,000-200,000 IDR by metered taxi
- Take a photo of the taxi license plate and driver ID before departure and share it with your hotel or a friend

■■ Lombok

6 scams documented • Indonesia

The Forced Bracelet Scam

Before you can say anything, they've tied it onto your wrist with a tight knot. Now they demand 50,000-200,000 IDR (\$3-12) to remove it. If you refuse, they make a scene — loudly shaming you in front of other tourists.

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches with a bracelet already in hand
- They touch your wrist without asking permission
- A crowd of sellers appears once you engage with one
- Keep your hands in your pockets or crossed when vendors approach
- A firm 'Tidak, terima kasih' (No, thank you) while walking away

■ How to Avoid

- Keep your hands in your pockets or crossed when vendors approach
 - A firm 'Tidak, terima kasih' (No, thank you) while walking away
 - If a bracelet gets tied on, offer 5,000 IDR max — or just cut it off later
 - This is particularly aggressive around Kuta Lombok and temple parking lots
-

The Mount Rinjani Fake Guide

He has no safety equipment, no porter support, and no park permit. Halfway up, when you're exhausted and committed, he demands more money. Rinjani is a serious multi-day climb (3,726m) with real risks — people have died without proper guides.

■ Red Flags

- Price well below the standard ■2,500,000-4,000,000 IDR (\$150-250) per person for 2-3 day trek
- No official Taman Nasional Gunung Rinjani permit shown
- No visible safety equipment or first aid
- Operating from the side of the road, not an office
- Book through registered operators listed on the Rinjani National Park website

■ How to Avoid

- Book through registered operators listed on the Rinjani National Park website
 - Verify the guide has a Rinjani Trekking Management Board (RTMB) permit
 - Budget \$150-250 per person for a legit 2D/1N or 3D/2N trek
 - Check TripAdvisor and Google reviews before booking
-

The Motorbike Rental Overcharge

When you negotiate down, they agree but hand you a bike with bald tires or bad brakes. The 'savings' come from renting you an unsafe vehicle.

■ Red Flags

- Price above 100,000 IDR/day for a basic scooter
- Bike has visibly worn tires or doesn't brake smoothly
- No helmet included or helmet is cracked
- Fair rate is 60,000-80,000 IDR/day in Lombok
- Test ride the bike around the block before accepting

■ How to Avoid

- Fair rate is 60,000-80,000 IDR/day in Lombok
 - Test ride the bike around the block before accepting
 - Check tires, brakes, lights, and horn
 - Rent from your hotel or a Google-reviewed shop
-

The Bangsal Harbour Ticket Tout

Before you reach the official ticket counter, a swarm of touts surrounds you, grabbing at your bags and insisting the public boat is full, cancelled, or not running today. They offer a 'private fast boat' for 350,000 rupiah per person -- roughly five times the public boat fare of 15,000 to 35,000 rupiah. The public boat is running fine. If you push through the touts and reach the official counter, tickets are available at the standard price. Bangsal Harbour's aggressive tout culture is one of the most complained-about experiences in Lombok, documented extensively on [r/bali](#) and [r/travel](#).

■ Red Flags

- Touts approach aggressively before you reach the ticket counter
- They claim the public boat is cancelled, full, or dangerous
- Price quoted is five or more times the standard fare
- They try to carry your bags without permission, creating obligation
- They block your path to the official ticket window

■ How to Avoid

- Walk directly to the official ticket counter and ignore all touts
- Know the public boat fare in advance -- approximately 15,000-35,000 IDR to the Gilis
- Keep a firm grip on your bags and decline all offers to carry them
- Book a fast boat from Senggigi or Teluk Nare instead to avoid Bangsal entirely
- Travel with a local guide or hotel-arranged transfer for a smoother experience

The Taxi Overcharge from Airport to Senggigi

The quoted fare to Senggigi is 200,000 to 350,000 rupiah for a ride that local Grab drivers would charge 80,000 to 120,000 for. The airport taxi counter operates as a fixed-price service with inflated tourist rates. If you try to order a Grab, you discover that ride-hailing pickups are prohibited from the terminal. You must walk outside the airport perimeter to find one. For tourists unfamiliar with the layout, this effectively forces them into the overpriced airport taxis.

■ Red Flags

- Airport taxi counter quotes a price two to three times the Grab estimate
- Ride-hailing apps show no available pickups within the terminal area
- No meter is used and the price is non-negotiable
- Driver offers a 'tour package' as part of the airport transfer
- Other passengers are being charged different rates for the same destination

■ How to Avoid

- Arrange airport pickup through your hotel before arrival -- many include this service
- Walk approximately 200 meters outside the airport to reach the Grab pickup point
- If using the airport taxi, know that Senggigi should cost no more than 150,000-200,000 IDR
- Share a taxi with other travelers heading to the same area
- Download the Grab app and have it ready before landing

The Credit Card Skimming at Tourist Businesses

■ ■ *Hotels, restaurants, and dive shops in Senggigi and Kuta Lombok* You use your credit card at a dive shop or restaurant in Senggigi. Three days later, fraudulent charges appear on your statement from locations you have never visited. A Reddit user on r/bali described losing multiple Visa cards over twelve months to skimming in Lombok and Bali, with the fraud patterns traced back to tourist businesses where card details were copied. The skimming devices are hidden inside card terminals, or in some cases, the waiter takes your card out of sight for processing and photographs both sides. Lombok's less-developed payment infrastructure means fewer security checks on transactions. **Red Flags** Your card is taken out of your sight to a back room for processing The card terminal looks modified or unusually bulky You receive unexpected small-amount test charges on your card within days The business only accepts card payment through a mobile phone reader rather than a proper terminal Staff seem to take an unusually long time processing your card **How to Avoid** Pay in cash wherever possible in Lombok — withdraw from ATMs inside bank branches only If using a card, never let it leave your sight — insist the terminal be brought to your table Use a travel card with instant transaction notifications (Wise or Revolut) Set low daily spending limits and enable card lock when not in use Check your statements daily during your trip and freeze the card immediately if fraud appears ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Indonesian National Police (Polri) station. Call 110 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at polri.go.id. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the

thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Jakarta is at Jl. Merdeka Selatan No. 3-5, Jakarta 10110. For emergencies: +62 21-5083-1000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Indonesia ■■

Three days later, fraudulent charges appear on your statement from locations you have never visited. A Reddit user on r/bali described losing multiple Visa cards over twelve months to skimming in Lombok and Bali, with the fraud patterns traced back to tourist businesses where card details were copied. The skimming devices are hidden inside card terminals, or in some cases, the waiter takes your card out of sight for processing and photographs both sides. Lombok's less-developed payment infrastructure means fewer security checks on transactions.

■ Red Flags

- Your card is taken out of your sight to a back room for processing
- The card terminal looks modified or unusually bulky
- You receive unexpected small-amount test charges on your card within days
- The business only accepts card payment through a mobile phone reader rather than a proper terminal
- Staff seem to take an unusually long time processing your card

■ How to Avoid

- Pay in cash wherever possible in Lombok — withdraw from ATMs inside bank branches only
 - If using a card, never let it leave your sight — insist the terminal be brought to your table
 - Use a travel card with instant transaction notifications (Wise or Revolut)
 - Set low daily spending limits and enable card lock when not in use
 - Check your statements daily during your trip and freeze the card immediately if fraud appears
-

■■ Nusa Penida

5 scams documented • Indonesia

The Day Trip Tour Overcrowding

A Bali-based agency sells a Nusa Penida day trip for 350,000 IDR (\$22) including boat, transport, lunch, and 4 photo spots. You arrive and there's 15 people crammed into a van built for 8, driving on Nusa Penida's famously dangerous cliff roads. Each stop allows exactly 10 minutes for photos.

■ Red Flags

- Price under 500,000 IDR for a full day trip from Bali
- No mention of group size or vehicle type
- Itinerary promises 4+ spots in one day
- Book a private driver on Nusa Penida for 600,000-800,000 IDR for 2-3 spots max
- Stay overnight on the island rather than doing a rushed day trip

■ How to Avoid

- Book a private driver on Nusa Penida for 600,000-800,000 IDR for 2-3 spots max
 - Stay overnight on the island rather than doing a rushed day trip
 - 3 photo spots per day is realistic — 4+ means a rushed, dangerous drive
-

The Fast Boat No-Insurance Gamble

Budget boats charging 100,000 IDR cut costs on maintenance and insurance. In rough seas, these boats have capsized.

■ Red Flags

- Ticket price under 150,000 IDR
- Boat looks old or poorly maintained
- No visible life jackets or safety equipment
- Use established operators: Maruti Express, Angel Billabong, or Crown Fast Cruise
- Budget 200,000-300,000 IDR per crossing for a safe boat

■ How to Avoid

- Use established operators: Maruti Express, Angel Billabong, or Crown Fast Cruise
 - Budget 200,000-300,000 IDR per crossing for a safe boat
 - Sit near exits and locate life jackets before departure
-

Ferry Port Ticket Hawker Markup

Before you reach the official ticket counter, a man in a polo shirt with a clipboard intercepts you and offers to sell you a ticket. He walks you to the counter, pays the standard fare, and pockets a markup of 50,000 to 100,000 rupiah per ticket. You paid double what you would have by walking twenty meters further to the counter yourself. The same thing happens on arrival at Nusa Penida where unofficial guides swarm the dock.

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you in the parking lot or walkway before you reach the official ticket window
- They wear no official company uniform but carry a clipboard or lanyard that looks semi-official
- They insist on walking you to the counter rather than letting you buy the ticket directly
- The price quoted is higher than what you saw online for the same boat company
- They pressure you to choose a specific boat operator and discourage you from comparing prices

■ How to Avoid

- Buy fast boat tickets online in advance through the operator's website or platforms like 12Go or Bookaway
 - Walk past anyone who approaches you before the ticket counter — the official counters are clearly marked
 - Know the standard fast boat price beforehand — it is typically 150,000 to 200,000 IDR one way
 - If you need to buy at the harbor, go directly to the counter of your chosen operator
 - On arrival at Nusa Penida, pre-arrange your driver through your accommodation to avoid the dock hustlers
-

Scooter Rental Road Condition Deception

You ride out and within ten minutes hit a near-vertical dirt hill with loose gravel and no guardrails. Nusa Penida's roads are notoriously dangerous — steep, unpaved in many sections, and prone to sudden drops. Tourists have been seriously injured and killed on these roads. The rental shops know the conditions but downplay them because every rental is profit. When you return the scooter with scratches from a fall, the damage charge arrives.

■ Red Flags

- The rental shop owner says the roads are all straight and easy — this is categorically false on Nusa Penida
- No one asks about your riding experience or suggests which areas to avoid
- You are not offered a helmet or the helmet provided has no chin strap or is cracked
- The scooter has no existing damage report or photo taken before you ride it
- The rental agreement has vague damage liability terms or no agreement at all

■ How to Avoid

- Hire a local driver for the day instead of self-driving — it costs around 400,000-600,000 IDR and they know the roads
- If you do rent a scooter, take a video walking around it documenting every scratch before riding

- Only ride on the main paved roads — the roads to Kelingking Beach, Broken Beach, and Angel's Billabong have dangerous unpaved sections
 - Wear a proper full-face helmet and closed-toe shoes — the rental shop flip-flop helmet is not protection
 - Check your travel insurance specifically covers scooter accidents — many policies exclude them
-

The Port Luggage Porter Shake-Down

■ ■ Toyapakeh Port and Banjar Nyuh harbor on Nusa Penida, Sanur harbor boat terminals on the Bali side You arrive at Nusa Penida by fast boat. As you step off, men in plain clothes grab your bags and start carrying them toward the exit. They did not ask permission. At the end of the dock, they demand 50,000-100,000 IDR (about \$3-7 USD) per bag. If you refuse, they become confrontational. A Reddit user on r/bali described this exact scenario: on the ferry, guys run and tell you to hurry up or you will miss the boat, then grab your bags and demand payment. These self-appointed porters are not employed by the ferry company. They target tourists who are disoriented after the rough boat crossing. **Red Flags** Someone grabs your luggage without asking as you step off the boat They rush you along the dock, creating a sense of urgency so you do not have time to object They wear no uniform or official identification from the ferry company Multiple men work together, making it intimidating to refuse their services They demand payment in a location where you are surrounded by their colleagues **How to Avoid** Carry your own bags and firmly say 'No, terima kasih' (No, thank you) if anyone tries to take them Keep a firm grip on your luggage handles as you disembark -- do not let go If someone grabs your bag, immediately say 'Saya bisa sendiri' (I can do it myself) and take it back Arrange airport pickup with your hotel or villa in advance so a driver with a name sign is waiting at the port If confronted about payment for unwanted porter service, offer 10,000 IDR and walk away -- this is a reasonable tip if they did carry your bag ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Indonesian National Police (Polri) station. Call 110 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at polri.go.id. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Jakarta is at Jl. Merdeka Selatan No. 3-5, Jakarta 10110. For emergencies: +62 21-5083-1000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in Indonesia** ■ ■

As you step off, men in plain clothes grab your bags and start carrying them toward the exit. They did not ask permission. At the end of the dock, they demand 50,000-100,000 IDR (about \$3-7 USD) per bag. If you refuse, they become confrontational. A Reddit user on r/bali described this exact scenario: on the ferry, guys run and tell you to hurry up or you will miss the boat, then grab your bags and demand payment. These self-appointed porters are not employed by the ferry company. They target tourists who are disoriented after the rough boat crossing.

■ Red Flags

- Someone grabs your luggage without asking as you step off the boat
- They rush you along the dock, creating a sense of urgency so you do not have time to object
- They wear no uniform or official identification from the ferry company
- Multiple men work together, making it intimidating to refuse their services
- They demand payment in a location where you are surrounded by their colleagues

■ How to Avoid

- Carry your own bags and firmly say 'No, terima kasih' (No, thank you) if anyone tries to take them
 - Keep a firm grip on your luggage handles as you disembark -- do not let go
 - If someone grabs your bag, immediately say 'Saya bisa sendiri' (I can do it myself) and take it back
 - Arrange airport pickup with your hotel or villa in advance so a driver with a name sign is waiting at the port
 - If confronted about payment for unwanted porter service, offer 10,000 IDR and walk away -- this is a reasonable tip if they did carry your bag
-

■ ■ Ubud

The Art Student Gallery Scam

A polite young Indonesian tells you he's an art student and today is his 'end-of-year exhibition.' He invites you to his gallery — it's nearby. Inside, you find a commercial art shop with paintings priced at \$200-800. Emotional pressure and guilt tactics are used: 'This painting took me 3 months.' The 'art student' earns 20-30% commission and does this daily.

■ Red Flags

- Friendly stranger mentions an art exhibition unprompted
- Gallery just happens to be nearby
- Prices are high with immediate 'special discount' offered
- Student becomes noticeably less friendly if you don't buy
- Enjoy the chat but decline the gallery invitation

■ How to Avoid

- Enjoy the chat but decline the gallery invitation
 - Buy art from ARMA Museum, Neka Museum shop, or the Ubud Art Market (and negotiate)
 - If you want to support real artists, Ubud has legitimate gallery openings listed in local events
 - A painting that takes 3 months doesn't need to be sold by a sidewalk recruiter
-

The Money Changer Sleight-of-Hand

You hand over \$100. The cashier counts out what looks like 1,600,000 IDR in a fast flourish, fanning the notes like a card trick. You recount at your hotel: it's 800,000 IDR. The cashier palmed half the notes during the count. This scam is performed by highly practiced operators and even careful travelers get fooled.

■ Red Flags

- Rate significantly better than banks or official money changers
- Cashier counts notes in a fast, flashy manner
- Booth is small with no bank affiliation
- Located in a heavy tourist area
- Use official bank-affiliated exchange (BMC, Central Kuta, PT Dirgahayu Valuta Prima are legitimate)

■ How to Avoid

- Use official bank-affiliated exchange (BMC, Central Kuta, PT Dirgahayu Valuta Prima are legitimate)
 - Count the money yourself, slowly, before leaving the counter
 - Use ATMs instead — Wise or Revolut cards give near-market rates
 - If a rate looks too good, it IS too good — the difference is made up by short-changing you
-

The Monkey Forest Extortion

Inside, a monkey snatches your sunglasses right off your face. A different boy appears, claps his hands, and the monkey drops them. He demands 100,000-200,000 IDR for his 'service.' The boys and monkeys have a working relationship — the monkeys are trained to snatch, the boys are trained to retrieve.

■ Red Flags

- Boys loitering at the entrance offering to 'help with monkeys'
- Monkey targets your easily grabbable items (sunglasses, hats, water bottles)
- A 'helper' appears instantly when your item is stolen
- Remove sunglasses, hats, and earrings before entering

- Secure all loose items in a zipped bag

■ How to Avoid

- Remove sunglasses, hats, and earrings before entering
 - Secure all loose items in a zipped bag
 - Don't carry food or water bottles in hand
 - If a monkey takes something, wait — they usually drop it when bored (don't chase)
-

The Taxi Mafia and Ride-Sharing Ban

You walk a few blocks and a local taxi driver quotes 200,000 rupiah for a ride that should cost 50,000. The local transport mafia in Ubud has effectively blocked ride-sharing apps from operating in the town center. Drivers who accept Grab bookings near Ubud face intimidation from the transport cooperative. This leaves tourists at the mercy of fixed-price drivers who charge three to four times the normal rate.

■ Red Flags

- Grab and Gojek apps show no available drivers when you try to book from central Ubud
- Local drivers all quote the same inflated price for common routes
- Drivers tell you apps do not work in Ubud and you must use their service
- The quoted price is three to four times what the app would charge in other parts of Bali
- Drivers become aggressive or follow you if you try to walk away to find a cheaper option

■ How to Avoid

- Walk five to ten minutes away from the Ubud center to a main road where app drivers can pick you up
 - Rent a scooter for the day at 70,000 to 100,000 rupiah which is cheaper than a single taxi ride in Ubud
 - Negotiate firmly with local drivers and walk away if the price is above 100,000 for a short ride
 - Ask your accommodation to arrange a driver for the day at a flat rate which is often better value
 - Use the fixed shuttle services that run between major tourist points in Ubud
-

The Coffee Plantation Commission Tour

Your driver takes you to see the famous Tegallalang rice terraces but insists on stopping at a coffee plantation along the way for a free tasting. The tasting is pleasant but the kopi luwak (civet coffee) is priced at 500,000 rupiah for 100 grams. The same coffee sells for 150,000 in Ubud markets. Your driver earns a 20 to 30 percent commission on anything you buy. Some plantations also keep civets in small cages for tourist photo opportunities raising serious animal welfare concerns.

■ Red Flags

- Your driver insists on stopping at a specific plantation that was not in your itinerary
- The tasting is free but the products are priced far above market rate
- Your driver stays near the sales area watching whether you make a purchase
- The plantation has caged civets displayed for tourist photos
- Staff apply high-pressure sales tactics after the free tasting

■ How to Avoid

- Tell your driver in advance that you do not want commission stops
 - If you do visit a plantation, enjoy the free tasting but compare prices at Ubud market before buying
 - Avoid plantations that keep civets in cages as this supports animal cruelty
 - Buy coffee at Ubud's Pasar Seni market or directly from ethical roasters
 - Negotiate with your driver that the itinerary is fixed and commission stops will result in a lower tip
-

The Temple Dress Code Rental Scam

A man at the entrance insists you must rent a sarong for 50,000 rupiah. Inside the temple you notice others wearing free sarongs provided at the entrance. The man at the gate is not a temple employee but a private vendor exploiting the dress code requirement. Besakih temple is worse, with unofficial guides latching onto tourists at the parking area and demanding fees of 300,000 to 500,000 rupiah for mandatory guiding services that are actually optional.

■ Red Flags

- Someone at the parking lot or before the official entrance insists you pay for sarong rental
- The vendor does not have a uniform or official temple credential
- Other visitors are wearing identical sarongs that appear to be free temple issue
- An unofficial guide tells you the temple requires a guide and their fee is non-negotiable
- The person blocks your path or follows you insisting you need their services

■ How to Avoid

- Bring your own sarong or long pants to temples as this eliminates the rental leverage entirely
- Walk past vendors to the official temple entrance where free sarongs are typically available
- Pay only the official entrance fee at the ticket window and decline additional services
- At Besakih temple be aware that guides are optional despite what touts claim
- Check current entrance fees online before visiting so you know the correct amount

The Airport Visa Counter Sympathy Scam

■ ■ *Ngurah Rai International Airport (Bali) visa-on-arrival counter, immigration queue* You are in the visa-on-arrival queue at Bali's airport when an Indian family approaches and says ... You are in the visa-on-arrival queue at Bali's airport when an Indian family approaches and says their credit card is not working and they cannot pay the visa fee. They ask if you can cover their payment — they will pay you back in cash or transfer money immediately. You pay for their visas (500,000 IDR each), and they thank you profusely, promising to transfer the money. They never do. A Reddit user on r/bali documented this: 'We met an Indian family at Bali's airport visa office. The husband asked if we could help cover their visa payment, saying his Indian card wasn't working.' The sympathy scam relies on the stressful airport environment and travelers' desire to help. **Red Flags** A stranger at the airport asks you to pay for their visa or ticket because their card is 'not working' They promise immediate repayment via cash, bank transfer, or mobile payment that never materializes The amount requested is large enough to be a meaningful loss but small enough to seem reasonable to help with They create urgency by suggesting they will miss their flight or be denied entry They are well-dressed and articulate, making the story more believable **How to Avoid** Politely decline financial requests from strangers at airports — suggest they speak to airport staff or their airline for help The visa-on-arrival counter at Bali accepts cash in multiple currencies — if their card does not work, they can use cash or visit a nearby ATM If you want to help, offer to guide them to the airport information desk rather than paying on their behalf Remember that legitimate emergencies are resolved by airport authorities, not by asking random travelers for money Never hand over cash to a stranger regardless of how convincing or sympathetic their story is ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Indonesian National Police (Polri) station. Call 110 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at polri.go.id. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Jakarta is at Jl. Merdeka Selatan No. 3-5, Jakarta 10110. For emergencies: +62 21-5083-1000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. *More Scam Guides More in Indonesia* ■ ■

You are in the visa-on-arrival queue at Bali's airport when an Indian family approaches and says their credit card is not working and they cannot pay the visa fee. They ask if you can cover their payment — they will pay you back in cash or transfer money immediately. You pay for their visas (500,000 IDR each), and they thank you profusely, promising to transfer the money. They never do. A Reddit user on r/bali documented this: 'We met an Indian family at Bali's airport visa office. The husband asked if we could help cover their visa payment,

saying his Indian card wasn't working.' The sympa...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger at the airport asks you to pay for their visa or ticket because their card is 'not working'
- They promise immediate repayment via cash, bank transfer, or mobile payment that never materializes
- The amount requested is large enough to be a meaningful loss but small enough to seem reasonable to help with
- They create urgency by suggesting they will miss their flight or be denied entry
- They are well-dressed and articulate, making the story more believable

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline financial requests from strangers at airports — suggest they speak to airport staff or their airline for help
 - The visa-on-arrival counter at Bali accepts cash in multiple currencies — if their card does not work, they can use cash or visit a nearby ATM
 - If you want to help, offer to guide them to the airport information desk rather than paying on their behalf
 - Remember that legitimate emergencies are resolved by airport authorities, not by asking random travelers for money
 - Never hand over cash to a stranger regardless of how convincing or sympathetic their story is
-

■ ■ Yogyakarta

7 scams documented • Indonesia

The Batik Gallery Art Student Scam

After 10 minutes of pleasant chat, he invites you to his 'art exhibition' — it's the last day and it would mean so much to have foreign visitors. The 'exhibition' is a commercial batik gallery with astronomical prices. The student gets 20-30% commission on anything you buy. The friendly chat was rehearsed.

■ Red Flags

- Overly friendly stranger who speaks excellent English
- 'Exhibition' happens to be nearby and closing soon
- Art is suspiciously expensive for Indonesia
- Student becomes noticeably less friendly if you don't buy
- Enjoy the conversation but decline invitations to shops or 'exhibitions'

■ How to Avoid

- Enjoy the conversation but decline invitations to shops or 'exhibitions'
 - Buy batik from the government-fixed-price Batik Keris or market stalls
 - If you want quality batik, visit the actual Batik Museum or Tirtodipuran workshops
 - Genuine art students don't need to recruit customers off the street
-

The Borobudur Sunrise Ticket Scam

Outside, someone offers sunrise tickets for 350,000 IDR when the official price is 475,000 IDR for foreigners. Great savings! But the tickets are for the neighboring Mendut temple — which has a different sunrise view but isn't Borobudur. Or worse, they're completely fake.

■ Red Flags

- Tickets sold outside the official entrance
- Price below the listed foreign tourist rate
- Seller uses urgency: 'Only 3 tickets left for sunrise!'

- Ticket looks different from what's shown on the official website
- Buy tickets only from the official Borobudur ticket office or the Taman Wisata Candi website

■ How to Avoid

- Buy tickets only from the official Borobudur ticket office or the Taman Wisata Candi website
 - The official foreign tourist sunrise price is approximately 475,000 IDR
 - Arrive at the official entrance by 4:30am — tickets are available on-site
 - Cross-reference ticket prices on the official website before your visit
-

The Becak Driver Temple Detour

The driver agrees on 20,000 rupiah. Ten minutes in he stops at a batik shop and tells you he will wait while you look. Then a silver shop. Then a leather goods store. Each stop is a commission arrangement. If you refuse to stop he becomes sulky or claims a road is closed and detours through more shops. What should be a fifteen-minute ride takes an hour.

■ Red Flags

- The becak driver agrees to an unusually low fare suggesting he plans to make money through commissions
- The driver stops at shops that were not in the agreed route
- He claims roads are closed and detours through commercial areas
- The driver becomes upset or refuses to continue if you decline to enter shops
- Multiple drivers quote the same suspiciously low price for the route

■ How to Avoid

- Agree firmly on the destination and route before starting and state you do not want shop stops
 - Use Grab or Gojek for transparent pricing on longer routes
 - Walk short distances on Malioboro Street rather than taking a becak
 - If the driver makes unauthorized stops, negotiate a reduced fare for the time wasted
 - Tip fairly for honest direct service to incentivize good behavior
-

The Unofficial Borobudur Guide Shakedown

You arrive at Borobudur Temple and a man approaches in the parking lot saying he is a licensed guide and the temple requires a guide for entry. He quotes 300,000 rupiah. You agree, not realizing guides are optional and the entrance fee includes access without one. His knowledge of the temple is minimal, and he spends most of the visit posing you for photos. Official licensed guides cost 100,000 to 150,000 rupiah booked through the temple ticket office.

■ Red Flags

- A guide approaches in the parking lot rather than at the official ticket office
- He claims a guide is required or mandatory for temple entry
- The quoted price is double or more the rate charged by guides at the ticket office
- He cannot show an official guide license issued by the tourism ministry
- The guide has minimal historical knowledge and focuses on taking photos of you

■ How to Avoid

- Buy tickets and arrange guides only at the official Borobudur ticket office
 - Know that guides are optional at both Borobudur and Prambanan temples
 - If you want a guide, book through the official ticket counter where rates are fixed at 100,000 to 150,000 rupiah
 - Research the temple history before visiting using apps or guidebooks so you can self-guide
 - Decline all offers from people who approach in parking lots regardless of their claims
-

The Fake Police Motorcycle Stop

He says your international driving permit is invalid and the fine is 500,000 rupiah payable now. He does not provide documentation or a receipt. Real Indonesian police do stop tourists on motorbikes but always issue official paperwork and direct you to pay fines at a station or through a bank, never cash on the roadside.

■ Red Flags

- The officer demands immediate cash payment rather than directing you to a police station
- He does not provide a written citation or official documentation
- The uniform looks slightly off or the officer has no name tag or badge number
- He claims only cash payment will resolve the situation right now
- Other motorists are not being stopped by the same officer

■ How to Avoid

- Carry a valid international driving permit (IDP) which is legally required for riding a motorbike in Indonesia
 - If stopped, ask to see the officer's identification and badge number
 - Real fines in Indonesia are paid at a police station or through a bank, never as roadside cash
 - Politely insist on going to the nearest police station to settle any fine
 - Take a photo of the officer or their vehicle if the interaction feels suspicious
-

The Hotel Tour Package Markup

You agree because it is convenient. Later you discover the entrance fee is 100,000, and the minibus shared with eight other travelers costs the hotel 30,000 per person. The hotel markup is 300 percent. Independent travelers who arrange their own transport and tickets pay less than half. The same applies to Jomblang Cave and Parangtritis beach tours.

■ Red Flags

- The all-inclusive package price is vague about what is actually included
- The hotel discourages you from booking independently or visiting the attraction on your own
- No breakdown of costs is provided just a single total price
- Other travelers at the same hotel paid different prices for the same tour
- The tour uses shared transport with many travelers crammed into a single vehicle

■ How to Avoid

- Research entrance fees and transport costs independently before accepting any package deal
 - Use Grab for transport to temples which is often cheaper than hotel-arranged minibuses
 - Buy Borobudur sunrise tickets directly through the official Taman Wisata Candi Borobudur website
 - Compare prices at three or four different booking offices on Sosrowijayan or Prawirotaman Streets
 - Join other travelers to share a Grab car which splits costs while maintaining flexibility
-

The Taman Sari Street Batik Workshop Lure

■ ■ Streets around Taman Sari Water Castle, Malioboro pedestrian walk, side alleys near Kraton Palace You are walking near Taman Sari when a friendly Indonesian man starts chatting in English. He says he is a student and invites you to his 'family batik workshop' nearby — just to see, no pressure to buy. Inside the small studio, artisans demonstrate the traditional wax-resist technique. It is genuinely interesting. Then the sales pitch begins: finished batik pieces for 200,000-500,000 IDR that are available in tourist markets for 50,000 IDR. Reddit users on r/indonesia confirmed: 'The scammy workshops usually come from people who invite you to their batik workshop when you walk around Taman Sari or Malioboro.' The markup is 4-10 times the market rate, and the 'commission' goes to the person who brought you. Red Flags A stranger approaches you on the street and specifically invites you to a 'family workshop' or 'art studio' The workshop is in a small, private space rather than an established storefront with posted prices Prices are quoted verbally and seem significantly higher than what you have seen elsewhere The person who invited you lingers during your visit and encourages you to buy There is a subtle

sense of obligation because they have 'shown you something special' How to Avoid Visit established batik workshops with posted prices, such as Batik Winotosastro or Batik Plentong, where you can learn and buy without pressure If invited by a stranger, politely decline — you can visit Taman Sari independently and explore Malioboro batik shops at your own pace Know that basic batik scarves cost 20,000-50,000 IDR in Malioboro markets — anything significantly above this at a 'private workshop' is overpriced Compare prices at multiple shops before buying — Yogyakarta is full of legitimate batik artisans who do not need street recruiters If you do visit a workshop, never feel obligated to buy — 'terima kasih' (thank you) and a polite exit is perfectly acceptable ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indonesian National Police (Polri) station. Call 110 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at polri.go.id. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Jakarta is at Jl. Merdeka Selatan No. 3-5, Jakarta 10110. For emergencies: +62 21-5083-1000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Indonesia ■■

He says he is a student and invites you to his 'family batik workshop' nearby — just to see, no pressure to buy. Inside the small studio, artisans demonstrate the traditional wax-resist technique. It is genuinely interesting. Then the sales pitch begins: finished batik pieces for 200,000-500,000 IDR that are available in tourist markets for 50,000 IDR. Reddit users on [r/indonesia](https://www.reddit.com/r/indonesia) confirmed: 'The scammy workshops usually come from people who invite you to their batik workshop when you walk around Taman Sari or Malioboro.' The markup is 4-10 times the market rate, and the 'commission' goes to...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you on the street and specifically invites you to a 'family workshop' or 'art studio'
- The workshop is in a small, private space rather than an established storefront with posted prices
- Prices are quoted verbally and seem significantly higher than what you have seen elsewhere
- The person who invited you lingers during your visit and encourages you to buy
- There is a subtle sense of obligation because they have 'shown you something special'

■ How to Avoid

- Visit established batik workshops with posted prices, such as Batik Winotosastro or Batik Plentong, where you can learn and buy without pressure
- If invited by a stranger, politely decline — you can visit Taman Sari independently and explore Malioboro batik shops at your own pace
- Know that basic batik scarves cost 20,000-50,000 IDR in Malioboro markets — anything significantly above this at a 'private workshop' is overpriced
- Compare prices at multiple shops before buying — Yogyakarta is full of legitimate batik artisans who do not need street recruiters
- If you do visit a workshop, never feel obligated to buy — 'terima kasih' (thank you) and a polite exit is perfectly acceptable

■ Laos

■■ Luang Prabang

7 scams documented • Laos

The Morning Alms Ceremony Exploitation

A local materializes and sits you on a mat, hands you sticky rice and a basket. You participate in the beautiful tradition of offering food to monks. When it's over, the local demands 100,000-200,000 kip (\$5-10) for the rice and the 'experience.' The food cost them 5,000 kip. This commercialization is also damaging the ceremony itself — monks have gotten sick from tourist-provided food.

■ Red Flags

- Local approaches you with a pre-made kit before dawn
- No price discussed before materials are provided
- You're positioned in a prime photo spot (for their photographer friend to sell you photos)
- Watch respectfully from a distance — the ceremony is not a tourist activity
- If you want to participate, buy your own sticky rice from the morning market (5,000 kip)

■ How to Avoid

- Watch respectfully from a distance — the ceremony is not a tourist activity
 - If you want to participate, buy your own sticky rice from the morning market (5,000 kip)
 - Keep at least 2 meters distance and never use flash photography
 - UNESCO has asked tourists to observe, not participate, to preserve the tradition
-

The Slow Boat Accommodation Scam

At the overnight stop in Pakbeng, a man boards the boat claiming all guesthouses are fully booked — but he knows a place. He charges 3-5x the normal rate for a mediocre room, pocketing a fat commission. Meanwhile, Pakbeng's guesthouses have plenty of availability.

■ Red Flags

- Someone boards the boat specifically to announce accommodation is sold out
- Claims to be the 'only' option available
- Price much higher than listed on booking apps
- Targets anxious-looking tourists first
- Pre-book Pakbeng accommodation on Booking.com or Agoda before the boat trip

■ How to Avoid

- Pre-book Pakbeng accommodation on Booking.com or Agoda before the boat trip
 - Ignore anyone boarding the boat to sell accommodation
 - Walk 5 minutes from the dock and you'll find plenty of guesthouses
 - Typical Pakbeng room: 80,000-150,000 kip (\$4-8)
-

The Night Market Short-Change

The vendor digs through a pile of crumpled bills and hands you back 20,000 kip — ■30,000 short. When you point it out, she acts confused, shuffles more bills, and eventually gives you the right change. If you hadn't counted, you'd have lost \$1.50 — multiply that by 100 tourists per night.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor handles a confusing pile of small crumpled bills
- Change given slowly in small denominations
- Distraction or conversation during the change-giving
- Count your change carefully every single time
- Carry small bills so you can pay with near-exact change

■ How to Avoid

- Count your change carefully every single time

- Carry small bills so you can pay with near-exact change
 - State the amount you're handing over: 'This is 100,000'
 - Lao kip bills look similar — familiarize yourself with each denomination
-

The Tuk-Tuk to Kuang Si Falls Overcharge

Tuk-tuk drivers near the Night Market quote 300,000 to 400,000 kip for a return trip with waiting time. The fair price for this journey is 200,000 to 250,000 kip shared between passengers, or about 50,000 to 60,000 kip per person in a shared tuk-tuk. Drivers know that Kuang Si is the number-one day trip from Luang Prabang and that tourists have limited alternatives. They quote high and resist negotiation, especially during peak season when demand outstrips supply.

■ Red Flags

- Driver quotes significantly above 250,000 kip for a return trip to Kuang Si
- Price is quoted per person rather than for the whole vehicle
- Driver insists on a very short waiting time at the falls to pressure a quick visit
- No other drivers are willing to offer a competitive rate in the immediate area
- Driver adds extra stops at commission shops along the route

■ How to Avoid

- Ask your guesthouse to arrange a shared minivan to Kuang Si -- prices are typically 50,000-60,000 kip per person
 - Walk a few blocks from the Night Market to find tuk-tuks at lower prices
 - Group with other travelers to share the cost of a private tuk-tuk
 - Agree on the total price, waiting time, and route before departing
 - Rent a motorbike if you are comfortable driving -- the road to Kuang Si is scenic and manageable
-

The Fake Textiles at Night Market

You browse the famous Luang Prabang Night Market, admiring what appear to be handwoven Lao textiles -- silk scarves, wall hangings, and traditional sinh skirts. Vendors tell you each piece took weeks to weave by hand. You pay 200,000 to 400,000 kip for what you believe is authentic Lao silk. Back home, a textile expert tells you it is factory-made polyester imported from China or Vietnam. Genuine handwoven Lao silk is expensive and takes days or weeks to produce. The mass-market pieces sold at the Night Market are overwhelmingly imported, with only a handful of vendors selling authentic work.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor claims a piece is handwoven silk but the price is below 500,000 kip
- Fabric has perfectly uniform weave patterns inconsistent with handloom work
- Vendor has dozens of identical pieces in the same pattern
- The fabric feels slippery or synthetic rather than having the distinctive texture of real silk
- Vendor cannot describe the specific weaving village or technique used

■ How to Avoid

- Visit Ock Pop Tok living crafts center to see genuine weaving and buy authentic textiles
 - Genuine handwoven Lao silk starts at approximately 600,000 kip and up for a scarf
 - Feel the fabric -- real silk has a distinctive texture and warmth that synthetic cannot replicate
 - Ask about the weaving village and technique -- knowledgeable sellers can provide details
 - If you want affordable souvenirs, buy the Night Market pieces knowingly as decorative items, not as authentic silk
-

The Airport Visa-on-Arrival Overcharge

The officer asks for forty dollars plus one dollar for a 'photo processing fee.' That is the official rate. But then he asks for an additional five to ten dollars as a 'rush processing fee' that does not appear on any official schedule. If you hesitate, he points to the long line behind you and says it will take much longer without the extra payment. A Reddit user on r/laos documented being charged forty-one dollars at the official rate but noted that others in line were charged up to fifty dollars with no explanation. The standard visa-on-arrival fee is forty USD for most nationalities.

■ Red Flags

- Any fee above the official visa cost of forty USD plus one dollar for a photo
- Officer asks for an additional 'rush' or 'processing' fee in cash
- The extra fee is requested verbally with no receipt or official documentation
- You are told the process will be 'much slower' if you do not pay extra
- The officer pockets the extra cash rather than putting it in a till or register

■ How to Avoid

- Research the current visa-on-arrival fee for your nationality before flying — it is posted on the Lao Ministry of Foreign Affairs website
- Bring exact change in clean US dollar bills — torn or old bills may be rejected
- Politely decline any fees not listed on the official schedule posted at the counter
- Take a photo of the official fee schedule displayed at the immigration counter for reference
- Apply for an eVisa online before traveling to avoid the on-arrival process entirely

The Tuk-Tuk Bill Switch

■ ■ *Tuk-tuk routes between town center and Kuang Si Falls, night market area* You pay the tuk-tuk driver for a ride to Kuang Si Falls with a 100,000 kip note. He examines it, then holds up a 10,000 kip note and claims you gave him the wrong bill, demanding more money. A Reddit user on r/laos described this bill-switch technique where the driver palms your large note and produces a smaller one, insisting you short-changed him. The denominations of Lao kip notes look similar to the unfamiliar eye, making the switch easy to execute. With the exchange rate at approximately 22,000 kip per dollar, managing large-denomination notes can be confusing for visitors. Red Flags Driver claims you handed over the wrong denomination after you clearly counted your payment He holds up a different note than the one you gave him The claimed underpayment is always one denomination level — 10,000 instead of 100,000 or 20,000 instead of 50,000 Driver becomes aggressive or refuses to continue the trip until you pay more This happens after you have already boarded and are away from witnesses How to Avoid Announce the denomination out loud as you hand over each bill: 'here is one hundred thousand kip' Pay with exact change when possible — ask your hotel to break large bills Familiarize yourself with Lao kip denominations before your first tuk-tuk ride Agree on the total fare before departing and have the exact amount ready If disputed, calmly offer to resolve it at the nearest police station — scammers will back down ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Lao Police station. Call 1191 (Police) or 1195 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at laopdr.gov.la. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Vientiane is at Thadeua Road, Km 9, Ban Somvang Tai, Hatsayfong District, Vientiane. For emergencies: +856 21-48-7000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Laos ■■

He examines it, then holds up a 10,000 kip note and claims you gave him the wrong bill, demanding more money. A Reddit user on r/laos described this bill-switch technique where the driver palms your large note and produces a smaller one, insisting you short-changed him. The denominations of Lao kip notes look similar to the unfamiliar eye, making the switch easy to execute. With the exchange rate at approximately 22,000 kip per dollar, managing large-denomination notes can be confusing for visitors.

■ Red Flags

- Driver claims you handed over the wrong denomination after you clearly counted your payment
- He holds up a different note than the one you gave him

- The claimed underpayment is always one denomination level — 10,000 instead of 100,000 or 20,000 instead of 50,000
- Driver becomes aggressive or refuses to continue the trip until you pay more
- This happens after you have already boarded and are away from witnesses

■ How to Avoid

- Announce the denomination out loud as you hand over each bill: 'here is one hundred thousand kip'
 - Pay with exact change when possible — ask your hotel to break large bills
 - Familiarize yourself with Lao kip denominations before your first tuk-tuk ride
 - Agree on the total fare before departing and have the exact amount ready
 - If disputed, calmly offer to resolve it at the nearest police station — scammers will back down
-

■■ Vientiane

8 scams documented • Laos

Tuk-Tuk Overcharge and 'Free City Tour' Redirect

The driver grins, quotes you 20,000 kip, and you climb in. But instead of heading straight there, he pulls over near a 'government tourism office' or a shop run by his 'cousin' and explains that the temple is closed for a special ceremony today — very unlucky — but he can take you to two amazing other sights first, for free. At the end of three hours of being driven to shops and 'cultural centers' with high-pressure salespeople, you're RM150 lighter in souvenirs you didn't want and you never got to the temple — which was open the whole time. This redirect scam is one of the most widely repo...

■ Red Flags

- The driver proactively mentions that your intended destination is 'closed today' without you asking
- They suggest a 'free' alternative tour that happens to involve shops or 'cultural centers'
- The route diverges significantly from what maps show as the direct path to your destination
- The driver mentions a 'special event' or 'ceremony' that has never been listed on any tourist website
- Stops are at shops where the driver waits outside or follows you in — a telltale sign of commission arrangements

■ How to Avoid

- Verify your destination's opening hours via Google Maps or your hotel before departing — this immediately eliminates the 'it's closed today' story
 - Agree on a firm price and specific route before getting into any tuk-tuk, and confirm the driver understands 'no stops'
 - Use a map app to follow your route in real time and notice if the driver is heading somewhere unexpected
 - If redirected to a shop, stay in the tuk-tuk or simply decline to enter — you owe nothing
 - For reliable transport, ask your hotel or guesthouse to call a trusted tuk-tuk driver rather than flagging street operators
-

Visa Extension / Immigration 'Fee' Scam

An agent outside the gates approaches and offers to handle the extension paperwork for a flat fee of \$50 — much easier, he says, and guaranteed same day. You pay. Hours later he returns with what looks like a stamped passport. But at the airport two days later, immigration officers spot that the stamp is fraudulent and you're detained, fined, and potentially banned from re-entering Laos. Visa fraud and unofficial 'extension agents' around Laos's immigration offices have been documented in multiple travel safety reports. The official cost for a Laos tourist visa extension is \$2 per day at au...

■ Red Flags

- An agent approaches you proactively outside the immigration office rather than inside it
- The fee quoted is significantly higher than the published official rate (\$2/day for extensions)

- Payment is in cash with no official receipt or documentation from the immigration office itself
- The agent says they will submit documents on your behalf and you don't need to appear in person
- The stamp or documentation they return looks slightly different from examples you've seen online

■ How to Avoid

- Handle all visa matters directly at the official Lao Immigration Department office — the queue is manageable and the cost is published
 - Know the official Laos tourist visa extension cost (\$2/day) before you go so you can immediately identify overcharging
 - Always get an official receipt from the government office itself, not from any intermediary
 - If you genuinely want an agent, use only ones recommended by your accommodation who have verifiable track records
 - Plan ahead so you're not extending in a rush — book a ticket or plan your exit before the visa deadline approaches
-

Currency Confusion / Kip-Baht-Dollar Mix-Up

Lao kip, Thai baht, and US dollars — all circulate and are accepted casually in shops and restaurants. A vendor quotes you '50,000' for a souvenir. You assume that's kip (about \$2.50) and hand over a \$5 bill. The vendor pockets the \$5 and gives you change in kip — treating your payment as dollars, netting himself over \$47 more than the item's kip price. When you object, he points to the handwritten price tag that says '50' (which he now claims meant dollars). This deliberate three-currency ambiguity is one of Vientiane's most commonly reported tourist traps on Reddit and travel forums. Trav...

■ Red Flags

- A price is quoted with a number only — no currency symbol or denomination specified
- The vendor or driver seems deliberately vague when you ask to confirm the currency
- Change is given in a different currency than you paid in, reducing what you receive
- Prices for basic items seem wildly higher or lower than what you expected in dollars
- Menus or price boards use numbers without currency labels in establishments catering to tourists

■ How to Avoid

- Always confirm the currency when a price is quoted — ask explicitly 'kip or dollars?' before paying
 - Learn the basic conversion: 20,000 kip ≈ \$1 USD ≈ 28 Thai baht (approximate 2024 rates)
 - Carry kip for all day-to-day purchases — paying in kip eliminates currency ambiguity entirely
 - When paying by dollar or baht, confirm beforehand that the quoted dollar/baht price is reasonable using your kip benchmark
 - For significant purchases or tuk-tuk fares, write the agreed price on paper before handing over money
-

Fake 'Tourist Police' Shakedown

You're walking along the Mekong riverside in the evening when two men in quasi-official-looking vests approach and show you what look like police IDs. They inform you that your visa is 'not properly registered' or that they spotted you taking photos of a restricted building. They speak enough English to sound authoritative. They offer to resolve the issue 'without going to the station' for \$50 in cash, paid right now. One of them stands close behind you while the other does the talking. Fake police shakedowns exist across mainland Southeast Asia, and Vientiane is specifically mentioned in t...

■ Red Flags

- Individuals claim police authority on the street without a proper police station or vehicle nearby
- They mention visa irregularities or minor photo violations as the reason they're stopping you
- The proposed 'resolution' involves immediate cash payment rather than any formal process
- One person stands behind you or blocks your path while the other talks — a physical intimidation setup

- Their ID badge or credentials look unofficial, laminated, or don't match standard Lao police identification

■ How to Avoid

- Know that real Lao police do not demand cash on the street — any street cash demand is a scam regardless of the uniform
 - Ask to be taken to an official police station if you're genuinely being detained — real officers will have no problem with this
 - Have your embassy's emergency number saved in your phone before arriving in Laos
 - Stay calm, don't hand over your passport or wallet, and ask clearly for the officer's name and badge number
 - Avoid the Mekong riverfront area alone after dark and stay in well-lit areas near other tourists or locals
-

Slow Boat 'Upgrade' / Ticket Agent Overcharge

You've heard that the slow boat from Luang Prabang to Huay Xai is one of Southeast Asia's great travel experiences and you want to book your connecting transport from Vientiane. A travel agency near your guesthouse offers to book everything — the VIP bus to Luang Prabang, the slow boat tickets, and a guesthouse for the overnight stop — in one convenient package. The price sounds high but 'includes everything.' You pay \$95. Later you find that the bus ticket costs \$15, the slow boat tickets cost \$25, and the guesthouse was \$10 per night. You've paid \$95 for \$50 worth of services. Vientiane's...

■ Red Flags

- The package price seems significantly higher than individual components you could book separately
- The agent cannot or will not break down what each element of the package actually costs
- They claim certain buses or boats are 'fully booked' on your preferred date but have an alternative that conveniently costs more
- Urgent pressure: 'seats are going fast, you should book now' for routes that are rarely actually full
- The guesthouse or hotel included in the package is not one you'd choose independently

■ How to Avoid

- Research the base costs of your intended route before visiting any agency — Seat61 and TravelFish have reliable up-to-date Laos transport pricing
 - Book directly at the bus terminal or boat dock when possible — Talat Sao bus terminal in Vientiane sells most bus tickets at official prices
 - If you use an agency, ask for an itemized breakdown and compare each line item against what you know the actual cost is
 - Slow boat tickets are sold at the pier in Pakbeng and Huay Xai — you don't need Vientiane agency involvement for this
 - Factor in your time and stress levels — some markup is worth paying for legitimate coordination, but know what the baseline price is first
-

Drugged Drinks / Vang Vieng-Style Risk in Vientiane Bars

You're at a lively bar near Nam Phu Fountain when you strike up a conversation with some friendly locals who insist on buying you a round. The shots arrive quickly and the next two hours blur. You wake up in your hotel room with your wallet light and your phone missing. There's a vague memory of getting into a tuk-tuk with new friends but nothing concrete after that. Drugged drink incidents in Laos are most infamous in Vang Vieng but have been reported in Vientiane's bar scene as well. Multiple r/solotravel posts warn about accepting drinks from strangers in Laos — both backpacker social se...

■ Red Flags

- Strangers are very eager to buy you drinks before you've had a real conversation
- Your drink arrives without you watching it being poured or opened

- You feel significantly more intoxicated than the amount you've drunk would explain
- The new 'friends' are guiding you toward a specific location or away from other tourists
- Someone takes your phone 'for a photo' or offers to charge it for you

■ How to Avoid

- Only accept drinks you watch being poured or opened directly in front of you
 - Cover your drink with your hand when setting it down, even briefly — this is standard practice
 - Socialize in bars with good lighting and other traveler groups rather than isolated spots
 - If you feel suddenly or unusually drunk, immediately find other travelers and get to your accommodation
 - Use the buddy system in Vientiane bars — solo drinking in unfamiliar establishments is higher risk
-

Gem / Jewelry Investment Scam

A well-dressed, English-speaking local befriends you at a café and explains that he works for the Lao government helping to promote tourism. He mentions, almost in passing, that he knows where you can buy gemstones or gold jewelry at incredible local prices — and resell them for huge profit back home. He offers to take you to a 'government shop' where foreigners can buy at local rates. The shop looks official, prices seem reasonable, and you buy \$300 worth of sapphires. Back home, a jeweler confirms they're worth \$15. This gem investment scam is a classic long con that has been documented a...

■ Red Flags

- A new local acquaintance mentions a financial opportunity (gems, gold, resale profit) within the first conversation
- The shop they suggest is described as 'government-affiliated' or accessible only through a local contact
- The opportunity is framed as time-limited: 'only available today' or 'during a special government export window'
- The person you met seems coincidentally to have connections in exactly what you'd find most interesting
- The 'investment value' of an item is described without any documentation you can verify

■ How to Avoid

- Be skeptical of any unsolicited financial opportunity from a new acquaintance, no matter how friendly and genuine they seem
 - Never buy gems, gold, or jewelry as an 'investment' from any shop you were personally guided to by someone you just met
 - If interested in genuine Lao gemstones, visit reputable jewelers recommended by your hotel or guidebook and research market values independently beforehand
 - Understand that genuine government-sanctioned tourist shops don't require personal introductions from strangers to access
 - Enjoy the social interaction if you want — just politely decline when any financial opportunity or shop visit is mentioned
-

The Immigration Desk Cash Bribe

■ ■ Wattay International Airport immigration counter, Vientiane land border crossings, Friendship Bridge immigration post
 You fly into Wattay International Airport in Vientiane and reach the immigration counter. The officer stamps your passport, then casually says you owe 1 million kip (approximately \$50 USD) as an 'entry processing fee.' There is no posted fee schedule, no receipt, and no official signage. You pay because you are exhausted from travel and the officer has your passport. Reddit users on r/laos documented this: 'My friend and I flew into Vientiane and the immigration staff demanded 1 million kip each for entry. We didn't realise until after that it was not legitimate.' Another post described police confiscating a passport and demanding \$100 for its return. These are unofficial bribes by uniformed officials. Red Flags The immigration officer requests cash payment for a fee that is not displayed on any official sign or receipt The amount requested is significantly more than the published visa-on-arrival cost (which is \$30-40 USD) No receipt is provided for the payment The officer becomes impatient or threatening if you ask questions about the fee Other travelers in the queue are being waved through without paying the same fee How to Avoid Research Laos visa fees before arriving: visa-on-arrival for most nationalities is \$30-42 USD depending on nationality — any amount above this is suspicious Carry the exact visa fee in US dollars and decline to pay any additional 'processing' or 'service' charges Ask politely for an official receipt for any payment

— legitimate fees always come with documentation If pressured, calmly say you will contact your embassy before paying any unposted fee Apply for an eVisa before traveling to avoid the on-arrival negotiation entirely — available at laoevisa.gov.la ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Lao Police station. Call 1191 (Police) or 1195 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at laopdr.gov.la. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Vientiane is at Thadeua Road, Km 9, Ban Somvang Tai, Hatsayfong District, Vientiane. For emergencies: +856 21-48-7000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Laos ■■

The officer stamps your passport, then casually says you owe 1 million kip (approximately \$50 USD) as an 'entry processing fee.' There is no posted fee schedule, no receipt, and no official signage. You pay because you are exhausted from travel and the officer has your passport. Reddit users on r/laos documented this: 'My friend and I flew into Vientiane and the immigration staff demanded 1 million kip each for entry. We didn't realise until after that it was not legitimate.' Another post described police confiscating a passport and demanding \$100 for its return. These are unofficial bribes...

■ Red Flags

- The immigration officer requests cash payment for a fee that is not displayed on any official sign or receipt
- The amount requested is significantly more than the published visa-on-arrival cost (which is \$30-40 USD)
- No receipt is provided for the payment
- The officer becomes impatient or threatening if you ask questions about the fee
- Other travelers in the queue are being waved through without paying the same fee

■ How to Avoid

- Research Laos visa fees before arriving: visa-on-arrival for most nationalities is \$30-42 USD depending on nationality — any amount above this is suspicious
 - Carry the exact visa fee in US dollars and decline to pay any additional 'processing' or 'service' charges
 - Ask politely for an official receipt for any payment — legitimate fees always come with documentation
 - If pressured, calmly say you will contact your embassy before paying any unposted fee
 - Apply for an eVisa before traveling to avoid the on-arrival negotiation entirely — available at laoevisa.gov.la
-

■ Malaysia

■■ Johor Bahru

7 scams documented • Malaysia

The Counterfeit Goods Confidence Trick

You wander into a mall near the JB Sentral area and find a shop selling 'branded' bags, watches, and sneakers at incredible prices — a Gucci bag for RM350 instead of RM5,000. The seller insists they're 'Grade AAA originals' or 'factory overruns.' In reality, Johor police seized RM1.41 million in counterfeit goods from a single JB syndicate in December 2024. The fakes look convincing but fall apart within weeks. Worse, carrying counterfeits across the Singapore border risks confiscation and fines. Redditors on r/malaysia warn that JB's fake goods market is one of the most prolific in Southea...

■ Red Flags

- Brand-name items priced at 90%+ discount

- Seller uses terms like 'Grade AAA' or 'factory surplus'
- Shop is located in older or less reputable malls
- No original receipts, authenticity cards, or warranty offered
- Seller discourages close inspection of stitching and logos

■ How to Avoid

- If a luxury item's price seems too good to be true, it's counterfeit
 - Buy from authorized brand retailers or reputable department stores
 - Be aware that bringing counterfeits into Singapore is illegal and punishable by fines
 - Check stitching, zippers, and logo alignment closely before any purchase
 - Avoid buying electronics from non-authorized dealers
-

The Illegal Cross-Border Taxi

You're at JB Sentral and a friendly driver approaches on WhatsApp or at the CIQ checkpoint, offering a ride to Singapore for RM50 — cheaper than the official cross-border taxi. It seems convenient, but these are unlicensed operators running an illegal ride-hailing business. Touts make up to RM3,300 daily from this racket. If caught, passengers face fines up to S\$3,000 or six months jail in Singapore. The vehicles are uninsured, and drivers have been caught providing rides in seized Singapore-registered SUVs. Redditors on r/singapore document how these illegal services openly advertise in Te...

■ Red Flags

- Driver solicits via WhatsApp, Telegram, or approaches you at CIQ
- Price is significantly cheaper than official cross-border taxis
- Vehicle has no official taxi markings or license
- Driver asks you to claim you're friends if stopped at checkpoint
- No official receipt or booking confirmation provided

■ How to Avoid

- Use only officially licensed cross-border taxis (available at JB Sentral and Ban San Street Terminal)
 - Take the public bus across the causeway — it's cheap and legal
 - Book through Grab within Malaysia or Singapore separately, but not for cross-border trips
 - Report illegal operators to LTA Singapore or local authorities
 - Never share personal details on unofficial Telegram ride groups
-

The Parking QR Code Scam

It has a QR code for convenient payment. You scan it, enter your bank details, and pay RM50 to 'clear the fine.' Except the entire notice was fake — a scammer planted it, and you just sent money to a criminal account. One Malaysian man in JB lost RM3,000 through a fake parking QR code. Even legitimate parking fines in JB require the MBBB SPOT app, never a random QR code on a slip of paper.

■ Red Flags

- Parking fine notice uses a QR code for payment
- QR code links to a generic payment page rather than the official MBBB portal
- Fine amount seems unusually high or low
- Notice lacks official MBBB branding, serial numbers, or reference codes
- Never scan QR codes on parking fines — pay only through the official MBBB SPOT app

■ How to Avoid

- Never scan QR codes on parking fines — pay only through the official MBBB SPOT app

- Check if the fine appears in the official system before paying
 - Take a photo of the notice and report suspicious ones to MBBJ
 - Use paid parking lots with automated ticketing instead of street parking
 - If driving from Singapore, download the MBBJ SPOT app before crossing
-

The Snatch Theft on Motorbike

A motorbike roars up from behind — the pillion rider yanks your phone or bag strap in one swift motion and they speed off. Taman Pelangi and the streets near JB Sentral are known hotspots. Snatch thieves target tourists walking alone, especially those visibly using phones or carrying crossbody bags on the road side. Redditors on r/malaysia identify JB as one of Malaysia's highest-risk cities for this crime, particularly after dark.

■ Red Flags

- Walking alone on poorly lit streets after dark
- Using your phone visibly while walking near traffic
- Bag worn on the road-facing shoulder
- Hearing a motorbike slow down behind you
- Areas with few pedestrians and easy motorcycle escape routes

■ How to Avoid

- Carry bags on the building side, away from the road
 - Use a body-worn anti-theft bag or money belt for valuables
 - Avoid using your phone while walking — stop at a shop or cafe instead
 - Walk facing oncoming traffic so you can see approaching bikes
 - Stick to well-lit main roads and malls, especially after sunset
-

The Fake Banknote Change

The vendor fumbles through a thick wad of bills and gives you RM30 in change. Back at your hotel, you notice one of the RM20 notes feels wrong — the paper is too smooth and the watermark is missing. A Singaporean visitor reported receiving a counterfeit RM20 at JB's Ramadan bazaar and posted it on Reddit as a warning. Counterfeit ringgit circulates especially at busy markets and temporary food bazaars where transactions are fast and lighting is poor.

■ Red Flags

- Bills feel smoother or thinner than normal
- Watermark is absent, blurry, or incorrectly positioned
- Change is given quickly with the vendor hoping you won't inspect
- Transaction happens in a dimly lit or crowded environment
- Check change immediately under good lighting before walking away

■ How to Avoid

- Check change immediately under good lighting before walking away
 - Learn the key security features of Malaysian ringgit notes
 - Pay with small bills and exact change when possible
 - Use cashless payment (Touch 'n Go e-wallet or GrabPay) at hawker stalls
 - Exchange currency only at licensed money changers inside shopping malls
-

The Dodgy Massage Upsell

You walk in and the basic massage begins. Halfway through, the therapist starts offering 'upgrades': hot stone for RM60, cupping for RM80, a special oil for RM40. By the end, your RM38 massage costs RM574 and you've got painful blisters on your back from an aggressive cupping treatment. One Singaporean visitor documented massive back blisters from a JB massage in 2024, requiring medical treatment costing nearly S\$800. Reddit users warn that cheap JB massage shops often use undertrained staff.

■ Red Flags

- Advertised price seems impossibly low
- Therapist suggests multiple paid add-ons mid-session
- No clear price list for additional services displayed
- Staff seem pushy about 'premium' treatments like cupping or scraping
- Parlor has no visible license or health certification

■ How to Avoid

- Choose massage parlors with Google reviews from multiple sources
- Ask for a full price list including add-ons before the session begins
- Decline any treatment not on your original booking
- Avoid places advertising unusually low prices compared to neighbors
- Check for a valid business license displayed in the shop

The Fake Injury Beggar

■ ■ Near JB Sentral, Komtar JBCC, City Square Mall entrance areas You are walking near JB Sentral when a person with visible bandages or a sling approaches showing ... You are walking near JB Sentral when a person with visible bandages or a sling approaches showing what appear to be medical bills and asking for money for treatment. A Reddit post on r/malaysia from 2025 specifically documented scammers with fake injuries asking for money for medical bills in Johor Bahru. In some cases the injuries are staged — bandages wrapped over healthy limbs — and the medical documents are photocopied props. Similar reports describe foreign nationals approaching tourists and claiming to be stranded, needing cash for a bus ticket to another city. Red Flags Person approaches with visible bandages or injury that looks staged They show printed medical bills or hospital documents The story involves a very specific amount of money needed urgently They claim to have lost their wallet and cannot use a bank or embassy Multiple people in the same area appear to run the same story on different days How to Avoid Politely decline and keep walking — legitimate emergencies are handled through hospitals Never give cash to strangers on the street regardless of their story If you want to help, offer to call an ambulance or direct them to a hospital Remember that embassies and consulates assist stranded nationals, not street collections Report persistent scammers to nearby security guards or MBBJ enforcement ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Royal Malaysia Police (PDRM) station. Call 999. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at rmp.gov.my. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at No. 376, Jalan Tun Razak, 50400 Kuala Lumpur. For emergencies: +60 3-2168-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Malaysia ■ ■

You are walking near JB Sentral when a person with visible bandages or a sling approaches showing what appear to be medical bills and asking for money for treatment. A Reddit post on r/malaysia from 2025 specifically documented scammers with fake injuries asking for money for medical bills in Johor Bahru. In some cases the injuries are staged — bandages wrapped over healthy limbs — and the medical documents are photocopied props. Similar reports describe foreign nationals approaching tourists and claiming to be stranded, needing cash for a bus ticket to another city.

■ Red Flags

- Person approaches with visible bandages or injury that looks staged
- They show printed medical bills or hospital documents

- The story involves a very specific amount of money needed urgently
- They claim to have lost their wallet and cannot use a bank or embassy
- Multiple people in the same area appear to run the same story on different days

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline and keep walking — legitimate emergencies are handled through hospitals
 - Never give cash to strangers on the street regardless of their story
 - If you want to help, offer to call an ambulance or direct them to a hospital
 - Remember that embassies and consulates assist stranded nationals, not street collections
 - Report persistent scammers to nearby security guards or MJB enforcement
-

■■ Kuala Lumpur

7 scams documented • Malaysia

The No-Meter Taxi Hustle

He waves away your attempt to confirm the meter and says 'Fixed price, RM30.' Your Grab app shows it's a RM12 ride. You feel like arguing but you're not sure and it's getting dark. The no-meter taxi hustle is so prevalent in KL that virtually every travel forum recommends against using street taxis entirely — Grab completely dominates because of it.

■ Red Flags

- Driver declines to use the meter at journey start
- Quote is given as a 'fixed price' without your agreement
- Driver is dismissive of meter discussions
- Use Grab (Southeast Asia's Uber) exclusively — it's cheaper, safer, and widely used by locals
- If you must take a street taxi, insist on the meter before getting in and walk away if refused

■ How to Avoid

- Use Grab (Southeast Asia's Uber) exclusively — it's cheaper, safer, and widely used by locals
 - If you must take a street taxi, insist on the meter before getting in and walk away if refused
 - MRT and monorail are excellent for most tourist destinations
-

The Petronas Towers Fake Ticket Seller

You arrive at the Petronas Towers early and a well-dressed man outside approaches to say the tickets are sold out for the day — but he can 'get you in' through his company's allocation for RM200 each. He shows you what looks like an official ticket. You pay. The tickets are fake or already used, and the official ticket office tells you there were actually openings available when you bought. This is a classic sold-out fiction scam used at popular attractions worldwide.

■ Red Flags

- Stranger tells you tickets are sold out before you've checked yourself
- Offer to provide tickets at a premium from a 'special allocation'
- Transaction happens outside the official venue
- Check ticket availability yourself on the official Petronas Towers website
- Buy tickets only from official counters inside the building

■ How to Avoid

- Check ticket availability yourself on the official Petronas Towers website

- Buy tickets only from official counters inside the building
 - Book online in advance to avoid all of this
-

The Gem Investment Scam

You're wandering Central Market when a friendly, educated-seeming local explains that Malaysia is the world's best place to buy investment gemstones because they're mined locally and there's no export duty. He takes you to his 'friend's' gem shop where you're shown certificates and told how resale value is guaranteed. You buy a blue sapphire for RM1,500. It's a piece of glass. These gem investment scams are well-documented across Southeast Asia and KL is one of the hotspots.

■ Red Flags

- Unprompted 'insider knowledge' about gemstone investment from a new acquaintance
- Certificates provided look official but are from made-up organizations
- Price keeps adjusting to match your stated budget
- Investment-grade gems require certified independent valuation before purchase
- No legitimate gemstone dealer needs to be introduced to you by a stranger on the street

■ How to Avoid

- Investment-grade gems require certified independent valuation before purchase
 - No legitimate gemstone dealer needs to be introduced to you by a stranger on the street
 - Research common scams before visiting this area
-

The Fake Police Officer 'Inspection'

Two men in plain clothes approach you near Petaling Street, flash what looks like a police badge, and say they're doing a drug inspection — they need to see your passport and wallet. Once you hand over your wallet they photograph your cards and 'find' suspicious foreign currency that needs to be counted and verified. You get your wallet back but some cash is missing, and sometimes card details are used fraudulently within hours.

■ Red Flags

- Plainclothes men claiming to be police with impromptu 'inspection'
- Request to see wallet or passport in a non-official setting
- Being approached near Petaling Street or Bukit Bintang nightlife
- Real Malaysian police in plain clothes can show official ID — ask to go to the nearest police station instead
- You can refuse to show your wallet and offer to accompany them to an official station

■ How to Avoid

- Real Malaysian police in plain clothes can show official ID — ask to go to the nearest police station instead
 - You can refuse to show your wallet and offer to accompany them to an official station
 - Call their bluff: legitimate officers will comply with a station request
-

The Batu Caves Souvenir Markup

'for the temple, a blessing.' When you reach the top and offer RM5, he insists the price is RM50 and becomes increasingly theatrical about it, blocking you until you pay. Batu Caves has a small number of aggressive vendors using the temple context and social pressure on unsuspecting tourists.

■ Red Flags

- Item placed in your hands without a price being stated
- Vendor singles out tourists while ignoring local visitors
- Price only revealed after you've accepted the item

- Don't accept anything handed to you unless you've agreed the price first
- Hand it back immediately if you haven't agreed to buy it

■ How to Avoid

- Don't accept anything handed to you unless you've agreed the price first
- Hand it back immediately if you haven't agreed to buy it
- Real temple offerings are available inside at marked prices

The Fake Monk Solicitation

He hands you a small medallion or card with a Buddhist image and gestures for you to keep it. After you accept, he presents a donation book showing entries of 50 to 200 ringgit from previous visitors. The social pressure is intense -- you are holding his gift in a crowded area and refusing feels disrespectful. These are not genuine monks. Real Buddhist monks in Malaysia do not solicit individual donations on the street. This scam is documented across Southeast Asia and is particularly active in KL tourist areas.

■ Red Flags

- Person in monk robes approaches you individually rather than sitting at a temple
- They hand you an object before asking for anything
- A donation book shows suspiciously round numbers in foreign currencies
- They target tourists specifically in shopping and tourist districts
- Real monks do not carry donation books with them on the street

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline any unsolicited gifts on the street, regardless of the giver's attire
- Know that genuine monks do not solicit individual donations in public spaces in Malaysia
- If you accept an item before realizing the situation, simply hand it back
- Direct your charitable giving to established temples or organizations
- Do not feel guilty about refusing -- this is a well-known hustle, not a religious practice

The KLCC Street Photographer Extortion

■ ■ *KLCC Park, Saloma Bridge, Petronas Towers esplanade* A man with a professional camera approaches you near the Petronas Towers and offers to take your photo for RM20. You agree, and he snaps dozens of shots from every angle. When you ask for the photos, he reveals the RM20 was per photo — and he took 43 shots, totaling RM860. When you refuse to pay, he becomes aggressive. A Thai tourist documented this exact experience in 2025, with the incident going viral and leading to a DBKL enforcement operation. Unlicensed photographers at KLCC were fined RM2,000 each, but the practice continues with new faces replacing those caught. **Red Flags** Photographer approaches you unsolicited near KLCC or Saloma Bridge Price is quoted 'per person' but the actual charge is per photo They take an excessive number of photos without confirming how many you want No official photography permit or business card is displayed They become aggressive or block your path when you try to leave without paying **How to Avoid** Use your own phone or camera — the Petronas Towers have excellent selfie angles from KLCC Park If you want a stranger to take your photo, ask a fellow tourist, not someone with a professional setup If approached by a photographer, ask 'how much for ALL the photos total?' before agreeing Report aggressive photographers to the security guards stationed around KLCC Park Walk away immediately if the pricing seems unclear or the person becomes pushy ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Royal Malaysia Police (PDRM) station. Call 999. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at rmp.gov.my. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at No. 376, Jalan Tun Razak, 50400 Kuala Lumpur. For emergencies: +60 3-2168-5000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **Frequently Asked Questions** Is Kuala Lumpur safe for tourists? ▼

You agree, and he snaps dozens of shots from every angle. When you ask for the photos, he reveals the RM20 was per photo — and he took 43 shots, totaling RM860. When you refuse to pay, he becomes aggressive. A Thai tourist documented this exact experience in 2025, with the incident going viral and leading to a DBKL enforcement operation. Unlicensed photographers at KLCC were fined RM2,000 each, but the practice continues with new faces replacing those caught.

■ Red Flags

- Photographer approaches you unsolicited near KLCC or Saloma Bridge
- Price is quoted 'per person' but the actual charge is per photo
- They take an excessive number of photos without confirming how many you want
- No official photography permit or business card is displayed
- They become aggressive or block your path when you try to leave without paying

■ How to Avoid

- Use your own phone or camera — the Petronas Towers have excellent selfie angles from KLCC Park
 - If you want a stranger to take your photo, ask a fellow tourist, not someone with a professional setup
 - If approached by a photographer, ask 'how much for ALL the photos total?' before agreeing
 - Report aggressive photographers to the security guards stationed around KLCC Park
 - Walk away immediately if the pricing seems unclear or the person becomes pushy
-

■■ Kuching

5 scams documented • Malaysia

Unofficial Taxi / Grab Impersonator

A man holding a handwritten sign with your (guessed) name approaches and says he's your driver — but something feels off about his car and there's no app notification. You get in. Forty minutes later he pulls up to your hotel and quotes you RM150 for a trip that should have cost RM25 on Grab, claiming 'the app price doesn't include luggage' or 'the bridge toll is extra today.' Kuching's taxi scene has been evolving as Grab takes over, but unlicensed operators — particularly at the airport and along the waterfront where cruise ship passengers disembark — are known to impersonate Grab drivers...

■ Red Flags

- A driver approaches you rather than you approaching them after confirming via the app
- The driver's vehicle plate doesn't match what's shown in your Grab app
- The driver quotes a verbal price rather than using the meter or app
- Anyone at the airport directs you toward an 'official taxi counter' with no clear rate display
- The driver mentions extra charges for luggage, tolls, or airport fees that weren't mentioned before departure

■ How to Avoid

- Always use Grab — it's widely available in Kuching and the pricing is transparent and upfront
 - Before entering any car, verify the driver's name, photo, and license plate in the app matches the actual vehicle
 - If you use an official metered taxi, confirm the meter is running before moving and ask for a receipt
 - Ignore anyone approaching you at the airport or waterfront who claims to be your driver — wait for the app to confirm driver arrival
 - Book airport transfers through your hotel in advance as a reliable alternative to street taxis
-

Wildlife Tour Bait-and-Switch (Orangutan Guarantee)

The tout at the waterfront promises you a 'guaranteed orangutan sighting' plus proboscis monkeys, hornbills, and a river cruise — all for RM180 per person. You pay upfront. The next morning a crowded van collects you and drives two hours into the jungle, only to stop briefly near Semenggoh (which has its own public entry fee you now have to pay separately) for 20 minutes in the wrong season when orangutans rarely appear. The promised river cruise is a 15-minute boat ride on a concrete pier. The proboscis monkey stop is a single monkey in a tree 300 meters away. Kuching is genuinely one of t...

■ Red Flags

- Any operator 'guarantees' orangutan sightings — no legitimate wildlife guide makes this promise
- The price seems significantly lower than other operators for the same claimed itinerary
- Payment is required upfront in full with no written receipt or company name on the documentation
- The tout cannot name the specific guide, vehicle, or detailed route for the tour
- The tour includes Semenggoh Wildlife Centre without mentioning the separate RM10 entry fee

■ How to Avoid

- Book wildlife tours only through licensed operators — check Sarawak Tourism Board listings or TripAdvisor Kuching certificates
 - Ask for a detailed written itinerary with timing before paying, including any entry fees that are not included
 - Visit Semenggoh independently on your own schedule (RM10 entry) rather than as part of a packaged tour
 - Check whether your operator employs actual naturalist guides versus drivers who stop at popular spots
 - Plan visits to Semenggoh during feeding times (usually 8–10am and 3–5pm) — any legitimate operator knows this
-

Longhouse 'Cultural Tour' with Hidden Costs

would you like to visit his longhouse and experience authentic Iban culture? The price he mentions sounds reasonable, and the idea sounds incredible. You agree. At the longhouse, you're given tuak (rice wine), shown traditional weaving, and then presented with a bill that includes a 'community fee,' a 'welcoming ceremony fee,' a fee for the weaving demonstration, a fee for photos taken inside, and a separate transport fee back — totaling three to four times what was discussed. Authentic longhouse visits are a genuine highlight of any Sarawak trip, and many Iban communities do welcome tourists...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger in the city proactively invites you to their community's longhouse without you seeking it
- The price for the tour is given verbally with no written breakdown of what's included
- Additional fees are announced only once you've arrived at the longhouse
- The 'fixer' is not an official representative of Sarawak Tourism Board or a licensed guide
- You're asked to pay for photos, specific ceremonies, or items separately once you're already inside

■ How to Avoid

- Book longhouse visits through established licensed operators who have formal agreements with host communities
 - Ask for a complete written price list before departure covering all fees including transport, entry, demonstrations, meals, and photos
 - Contact Sarawak Tourism Board for a list of registered community tourism operators in Kuching
 - If you want a spontaneous visit, ask your hotel for a reputable contact rather than trusting street approaches
 - Set a clear budget expectation before departure and confirm in writing that the quoted price is all-inclusive
-

Gem / Handicraft 'Factory Direct' Overcharge

A friendly shopkeeper at a stall near the historic Main Bazaar notices you eyeing some hornbill motif carvings and says his family makes them personally — no middleman, so prices are much lower than a regular shop. You follow him to a small backroom studio where you watch a craftsman carve for two minutes, then you're

seated for tea while more and more pieces are brought out. The social pressure of tea, the 'exclusive' pricing narrative, and the friendly atmosphere make saying 'I'll think about it' feel rude. You buy three pieces for RM450 that you later see at the public market for RM80 ea...

■ Red Flags

- You're invited off the main shopping street to a 'private' showroom or back room
- Tea or food is offered immediately upon sitting — creating social obligation to buy
- The seller claims exclusive or direct-from-artisan pricing that cannot be found elsewhere
- High-value items are brought out progressively after you show interest in smaller ones
- You feel social pressure to stay or buy after spending time in the establishment

■ How to Avoid

- Do your browsing at reputable fixed-price shops first (Sarawak Craft Council, Sarawak Museum gift shop) to calibrate what items actually cost
- Bargain confidently at all open-market stalls — starting at 50% of the asking price is standard and expected
- Avoid following anyone to off-street locations or 'private showrooms' regardless of how friendly they seem
- Keep browsing casual and low-commitment until you've seen prices in several different shops
- Know that authentic quality Pua Kumbu textiles and wood carvings have value — just confirm with multiple vendors before committing

The Overpriced Semenggoh Orangutan Tour

■ ■ *Tour agencies on Main Bazaar and Jalan Padungan, online booking sites* A tour operator on Main Bazaar offers a half-day trip to Semenggoh Wildlife Centre to see ... A tour operator on Main Bazaar offers a half-day trip to Semenggoh Wildlife Centre to see orangutans for RM250 per person including lunch and guide. The catch is that Semenggoh is only 24 kilometers from Kuching city center, entry is just RM10, and a Grab ride costs about RM25 each way. The tour markup exceeds 400 percent, and the 'guide' adds little value since the wildlife center has its own rangers who explain the feeding sessions. You are essentially paying RM200 extra for a car ride and a packed lunch. Red Flags Tour price to Semenggoh exceeds RM100 per person for a half-day trip Tour is marketed as a 'full-day experience' for a visit that takes two hours Package includes 'lunch' that turns out to be a cheap nasi lemak packet The guide does not have an official nature guide license from Sarawak Forestry You are pressured to book immediately because 'spots fill up fast' How to Avoid Visit Semenggoh independently — take Grab for RM25 each way and pay RM10 entry Feeding sessions are at 9am and 3pm — arrive 30 minutes early for the best spot For Bako National Park, book the boat and park entry directly at the Bako boat jetty If booking tours, compare prices from at least three operators before committing Check reviews on Google Maps and TripAdvisor — reputable operators have hundreds of reviews ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Royal Malaysia Police (PDRM) station. Call 999. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at rmp.gov.my. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at No. 376, Jalan Tun Razak, 50400 Kuala Lumpur. For emergencies: +60 3-2168-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Malaysia ■■

A tour operator on Main Bazaar offers a half-day trip to Semenggoh Wildlife Centre to see orangutans for RM250 per person including lunch and guide. The catch is that Semenggoh is only 24 kilometers from Kuching city center, entry is just RM10, and a Grab ride costs about RM25 each way. The tour markup exceeds 400 percent, and the 'guide' adds little value since the wildlife center has its own rangers who explain the feeding sessions. You are essentially paying RM200 extra for a car ride and a packed lunch.

■ Red Flags

- Tour price to Semenggoh exceeds RM100 per person for a half-day trip
- Tour is marketed as a 'full-day experience' for a visit that takes two hours
- Package includes 'lunch' that turns out to be a cheap nasi lemak packet
- The guide does not have an official nature guide license from Sarawak Forestry

- You are pressured to book immediately because 'spots fill up fast'

■ How to Avoid

- Visit Semenggoh independently — take Grab for RM25 each way and pay RM10 entry
 - Feeding sessions are at 9am and 3pm — arrive 30 minutes early for the best spot
 - For Bako National Park, book the boat and park entry directly at the Bako boat jetty
 - If booking tours, compare prices from at least three operators before committing
 - Check reviews on Google Maps and TripAdvisor — reputable operators have hundreds of reviews
-

■■ Langkawi

5 scams documented • Malaysia

The Duty-Free Fake Alcohol

But some shops in Kuah sell counterfeit spirits in authentic-looking bottles. The vodka is industrial alcohol, the whisky is colored water with chemical flavoring. Fake alcohol has caused hospitalizations and even deaths across Southeast Asia.

■ Red Flags

- Price significantly below even Langkawi's duty-free rates
- Bottles have subtly wrong labels or caps that don't match
- Shop is an unmarked or makeshift stall rather than a proper duty-free store
- Seal on the bottle looks tampered with
- Buy from official duty-free shops: Zon, Coco Valley, or Langkawi Duty Free

■ How to Avoid

- Buy from official duty-free shops: Zon, Coco Valley, or Langkawi Duty Free
 - Check that bottle seals are intact and labels are straight/properly printed
 - If a bottle of premium whisky costs less than it would at the airport, it's probably fake
 - Stick to beer and sealed wine — much harder to counterfeit
-

The Island Hopping Bait-and-Switch

You show up and the boat is packed with 40 people. Each island stop is 10 minutes. The eagle-feeding stop (the highlight) is skipped because 'the eagles aren't there today.' Lunch is not included despite being promised. Return trip drops you at a different beach from pickup.

■ Red Flags

- Price below RM 60 per person for a full island-hopping tour
- No written itinerary with specific stops and times
- Boat looks overcrowded or in poor condition
- Vendor can't name the specific islands
- Book through your hotel or a verified operator (Dev's Adventure Tours is well-reviewed)

■ How to Avoid

- Book through your hotel or a verified operator (Dev's Adventure Tours is well-reviewed)
 - Standard rate is RM 60-80 per person including lunch
 - Ask how many people will be on the boat — 15-20 is reasonable
 - Get the full itinerary in writing with confirmed stops
-

The Jet Ski Rental Damage Claim

When you return, the operator inspects the hull and declares he has found a crack underneath that was not there before. He demands 3,000 to 8,000 ringgit for repairs and calls over several friends who stand around you while he makes his case. The damage was pre-existing, but without photos from before your ride, you cannot prove it. This is the same jet ski shakedown documented across Thai and Malaysian beach resorts, and Langkawi operators are equally aggressive. Some take your passport as collateral during the rental.

■ Red Flags

- No pre-rental inspection documenting existing condition
- Operator requests your passport as deposit
- Damage is discovered on a hidden surface you could not have checked
- Multiple people surround you during the dispute
- Repair quote far exceeds what a mechanic would actually charge

■ How to Avoid

- Video the entire jet ski from every angle before riding, especially the underside
 - Never hand over your passport -- offer a cash deposit or photocopy
 - Rent only from operators recommended by your hotel with positive reviews
 - If confronted with inflated damage claims, call the police rather than paying
 - Consider avoiding jet ski rentals at tourist beaches entirely
-

The Taxi and Tour Driver Commission Route

The itinerary sounds great -- Cable Car, Eagle Square, Cenang Beach. But throughout the day, the driver makes long stops at a chocolate factory, a batik workshop, and a duty-free outlet. At each stop, staff seem to know him by name. You realize the tour is structured around commission shops rather than sightseeing. The actual time at attractions is rushed while shop visits are leisurely. This commission routing is standard practice for budget island tours across Malaysia.

■ Red Flags

- Driver insists on stops at specific shops that were not on the agreed itinerary
- Staff at shops greet the driver by name
- Shop visits last 30-45 minutes while attraction visits are rushed
- Driver becomes reluctant to skip a shop stop when you request it
- Tour price is unusually cheap, suggesting commission is the real revenue

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on the exact itinerary including stops before the tour begins
 - State clearly that you do not want to visit any shops
 - Rent a car or scooter and explore independently -- Langkawi roads are easy to navigate
 - Book through established tour companies with reviews rather than airport touts
 - If the driver insists on shop stops, offer to pay a small amount more for a shop-free tour
-

The Market Price Seafood Restaurant Shock

■ ■ Seafood restaurants in Pantai Cenang, Kuah town waterfront restaurants You sit at a seafood restaurant in Pantai Cenang and order 'ikan siakap' (barramundi) from the menu. No price is listed — just 'market price.' When the bill arrives, it is RM1,852.50 for a single fish and sides. A Reddit user on r/malaysia shared this exact experience with a photo of the receipt, noting the restaurant owner claimed the price was reasonable because the fish weighed over two kilograms. The 'market price' system at Langkawi seafood restaurants is a documented trap where tourists order without knowing the per-kilogram rate and receive enormous bills. Red Flags Menu lists seafood items as 'market price' or 'seasonal price' with

no figure Waiter does not volunteer the per-kilogram price when you order The fish or seafood is brought out whole before cooking — making it hard to assess weight Restaurant is positioned on the beach or waterfront in a prime tourist location Reviews on Google Maps mention unexpectedly high bills How to Avoid Always ask for the per-kilogram price before ordering any 'market price' item Request to see the fish on the scale before it is cooked — confirm the weight and total price Compare prices at multiple restaurants along the same strip before sitting down Eat at restaurants with fixed-price menus displayed clearly at the entrance Check Google Maps reviews for price complaints before choosing a seafood restaurant ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Royal Malaysia Police (PDRM) station. Call 999. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at rmp.gov.my. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at No. 376, Jalan Tun Razak, 50400 Kuala Lumpur. For emergencies: +60 3-2168-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Malaysia ■■

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■ Red Flags

- Menu lists seafood items as 'market price' or 'seasonal price' with no figure
- Waiter does not volunteer the per-kilogram price when you order
- The fish or seafood is brought out whole before cooking — making it hard to assess weight
- Restaurant is positioned on the beach or waterfront in a prime tourist location
- Reviews on Google Maps mention unexpectedly high bills

■ How to Avoid

- Always ask for the per-kilogram price before ordering any 'market price' item
 - Request to see the fish on the scale before it is cooked — confirm the weight and total price
 - Compare prices at multiple restaurants along the same strip before sitting down
 - Eat at restaurants with fixed-price menus displayed clearly at the entrance
 - Check Google Maps reviews for price complaints before choosing a seafood restaurant
-

■■ Penang

5 scams documented • Malaysia

The Overcharging Minimart

The cashier rings it up quickly: RM 18. You were expecting RM 5. The prices aren't labeled on the items, and the cashier distracted you with conversation during the scan. This practice is particularly common in minimarts near George Town's street art and heritage zone.

■ Red Flags

- No price labels on individual items
- Cashier rings up quickly without showing the total
- Price seems high compared to 7-Eleven or Mydin
- Located in a heavy tourist foot-traffic zone
- Check prices before putting items on the counter

■ How to Avoid

- Check prices before putting items on the counter

- Shop at chain stores (7-Eleven, FamilyMart, Mydin) where prices are fixed and labeled
 - A 1.5L water should be RM 1-2, not RM 5+
 - Ask 'Berapa?' (How much?) before the cashier scans
-

The Trishaw Tour Bait-and-Switch

After 20 minutes, he stops at a batik shop, a craft store, and a 'famous' temple — each with commission arrangements. The actual heritage tour lasts 10 minutes. When you complain, he says the shops ARE the tour. The promised street art route and Clan Jetties? 'Not on this route.'

■ Red Flags

- Tour stops at shops within the first few minutes
- Driver insists you 'just look inside for 5 minutes'
- Promised landmarks are skipped due to 'traffic' or 'construction'
- Agree on a specific route before departing — name the landmarks you want to see
- RM 40-60 per hour is fair for a genuine trishaw tour

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on a specific route before departing — name the landmarks you want to see
 - RM 40-60 per hour is fair for a genuine trishaw tour
 - Decline all shop stops
 - Walking the heritage zone yourself with the George Town Heritage Trail map is honestly better
-

Fake Monk Donation Scam

They hand you a small medallion or prayer card and gesture for a donation. You give them twenty ringgit. Later you learn that Buddhist monks in Penang do not solicit donations on the street — they collect alms silently at dawn. The person was not a monk at all. This scam is documented across Penang's tourist areas, particularly near Kek Lok Si Temple and along the heritage walking routes.

■ Red Flags

- A 'monk' approaches you directly and initiates conversation or hands you an object
- They request a specific amount of money rather than accepting silent, voluntary donations
- They operate in tourist-heavy areas during midday rather than early morning alms rounds
- The robes look new or costumey rather than worn from daily use
- They carry a clipboard or donation book showing large amounts from other tourists

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline any object offered and keep walking — genuine monks do not solicit on the street
 - In Theravada Buddhism practiced in Malaysia, monks collect alms silently at dawn, never in tourist zones during the day
 - Do not feel guilty about declining — local Penangites recognize and ignore these individuals
 - If you wish to donate to Buddhist temples, do so inside the temple through official donation boxes
 - Report persistent fake monks to George Town's tourist police or call the Penang Tourism hotline
-

Taxi and Grab Driver Long-Route Overcharge

The driver avoids the direct Tun Dr Lim Chong Eu Expressway and instead winds through residential Bayan Lepas and Jelutong, adding twenty minutes and thirty ringgit to a trip that should cost around forty-five ringgit. Some airport taxis quote inflated flat fares of eighty to one hundred ringgit for the twenty-minute ride. Penang taxis have long had a reputation for refusing meters and overcharging tourists.

■ Red Flags

- The driver refuses to turn on the meter or claims it is broken
- The quoted flat fare is significantly higher than the Grab estimate on your phone
- The driver takes surface streets through residential neighborhoods when a highway is available
- You are pressured into the taxi before agreeing on a price
- The driver says ride-hailing apps do not work at the airport — they do

■ How to Avoid

- Use the Grab app for all rides — it provides a fixed fare, GPS-tracked route, and driver accountability
- If taking a taxi from the airport, use the coupon taxi counter inside the arrival hall where prices are fixed
- Follow the route on Google Maps during any taxi ride and question detours immediately
- For trips within Georgetown, walking or cycling is often faster and free — the heritage zone is compact
- Report overcharging taxi drivers to the Penang Land Public Transport Commission or call 1800-88-7723

The Fake Injury Medical Fund Beggar

■ ■ *Georgetown tourist streets near Armenian Street and Lebuah Chulia, Komtar bus terminal area, and outside major temples like Kek Lok Si* A person approaches you on Armenian Street in Georgetown showing a festering wound or bandaged ... A person approaches you on Armenian Street in Georgetown showing a festering wound or bandaged injury, asking for money for medical treatment. A Reddit user on r/malaysia described exactly this: a random man showed his festering wound and asked for money. Multiple threads confirm these beggars with fake or self-inflicted injuries are increasingly common in Penang, KL, and JB. They target tourists specifically because locals recognize the scam. Some use makeup or existing conditions to create shocking visuals. The money does not go toward medical treatment -- Malaysia provides subsidized healthcare at government hospitals for as little as 1 MYR per visit. **Red Flags** A stranger approaches you showing a wound or injury and asking for money for medical treatment They target tourists specifically and avoid approaching locals The wound looks staged, overly dramatic, or inconsistent with someone who is genuinely unable to seek treatment They have a specific amount they need that seems calculated to maximize tourist sympathy You see the same person working the same area on different days **How to Avoid** Know that Malaysia has affordable public healthcare -- anyone genuinely in need can visit a government hospital for 1 MYR Politely decline and keep walking -- do not stop to examine the injury or engage If you genuinely believe someone needs medical help, offer to call an ambulance (999) rather than giving cash Direct persistent beggars to the nearest government hospital or welfare office Report aggressive beggars to the Georgetown MBPP enforcement hotline or the nearest police station ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Royal Malaysia Police (PDRM) station. Call 999. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at rmp.gov.my. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at No. 376, Jalan Tun Razak, 50400 Kuala Lumpur. For emergencies: +60 3-2168-5000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in Malaysia** ■ ■

A person approaches you on Armenian Street in Georgetown showing a festering wound or bandaged injury, asking for money for medical treatment. A Reddit user on r/malaysia described exactly this: a random man showed his festering wound and asked for money. Multiple threads confirm these beggars with fake or self-inflicted injuries are increasingly common in Penang, KL, and JB. They target tourists specifically because locals recognize the scam. Some use makeup or existing conditions to create shocking visuals. The money does not go toward medical treatment -- Malaysia provides subsidized hea...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you showing a wound or injury and asking for money for medical treatment
- They target tourists specifically and avoid approaching locals
- The wound looks staged, overly dramatic, or inconsistent with someone who is genuinely unable to seek treatment
- They have a specific amount they need that seems calculated to maximize tourist sympathy
- You see the same person working the same area on different days

■ How to Avoid

- Know that Malaysia has affordable public healthcare -- anyone genuinely in need can visit a government hospital for 1 MYR
 - Politely decline and keep walking -- do not stop to examine the injury or engage
 - If you genuinely believe someone needs medical help, offer to call an ambulance (999) rather than giving cash
 - Direct persistent beggars to the nearest government hospital or welfare office
 - Report aggressive beggars to the Georgetown MBPP enforcement hotline or the nearest police station
-

■ Myanmar

■ Mandalay

7 scams documented • Myanmar

The Jade Market Gemstone Fraud

A vendor approaches with a tray of luminous green stones, claiming they are Grade A Kachin State jadeite — yours for only 200,000 kyat, a 'special price for foreigners.' The stones look stunning, but without gemological training you cannot tell that they are dyed quartzite or synthetic glass worth a fraction of the asking price. Some vendors even provide fake certificates of authenticity. Tripadvisor reviews stress that this market is for expert gemologists, not retail tourists — and multiple Reddit travelers have posted about losing hundreds of dollars on worthless stones.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor claims stones are 'rare' or offers a 'special foreigner discount'
- Paper certificate of authenticity with no verifiable issuer
- Pressure to buy quickly because 'another buyer is interested'
- Stone price is suspiciously low for claimed quality
- Vendor discourages you from getting an independent appraisal

■ How to Avoid

- Never buy gemstones at a market unless you are a trained gemologist or have one with you
 - If you want jade souvenirs, buy small inexpensive pieces as decorative items rather than 'investment' stones
 - Only buy from government-licensed Myanmar Gem Enterprise outlets with proper documentation
 - Be aware that exporting unregistered gemstones from Myanmar is illegal and can result in confiscation at the airport
-

The E-Bike Guide Commission Route

The owner helpfully suggests a 'guide' who can show you the best temples for an extra 5,000 kyat. Sounds like a deal. But the guide's route is 70 percent shopping stops — a jade market, a lacquerware workshop, a puppet shop, a silk weaving house — each one paying him commission on anything you buy. The actual temple visits get rushed to 15 minutes each. When you complain, the guide insists these stops are 'part of the cultural experience.' Multiple travelers on forums report identical itineraries from different guides, all hitting the same commission shops.

■ Red Flags

- Guide is 'recommended' by the e-bike rental shop rather than independently sourced
- Itinerary includes multiple shopping stops between temple visits

- Guide becomes insistent or upset when you skip a shop or leave quickly
- Shops seem to know the guide by name and offer you 'special prices'
- Temple visits are rushed while shopping stops last 30+ minutes

■ How to Avoid

- Rent the e-bike without a guide and navigate using Maps.me or Google Maps offline
 - If you want a guide, hire one independently through your hotel rather than through the rental shop
 - Set clear expectations upfront: tell the guide you want temples only, no shopping stops
 - If the guide steers you to a shop, you are under no obligation to enter or buy
-

The Fake Temple Entrance Fee

You arrive at Atumashi Monastery and a man sitting at a folding table near the entrance asks for a 10,000-kyat 'entrance fee,' handing you a handwritten receipt. The receipt looks unofficial because it is — he is not affiliated with the site. The legitimate Mandalay archaeological zone fee covers multiple sites and is purchased at an official counter. This scam also appears at Kuthodaw Pagoda and smaller temples on Mandalay Hill, where individuals set up impromptu collection points. Travelers on forums report that these fake fee collectors specifically target tourists arriving by e-bike wit...

■ Red Flags

- Handwritten receipt rather than a printed official ticket
- Collection point is a folding table or chair with no signage
- Collector is not in uniform and cannot show official identification
- Fee is demanded at individual temples when you have already paid the zone fee
- Purchase the official Mandalay archaeological zone ticket (10,000 kyat) at a legitimate counter — it covers Mandalay Palace, Atumashi, Shwenandaw, and Kuthodaw

■ How to Avoid

- Purchase the official Mandalay archaeological zone ticket (10,000 kyat) at a legitimate counter — it covers Mandalay Palace, Atumashi, Shwenandaw, and Kuthodaw
 - Keep your zone ticket visible and show it confidently if anyone asks for an additional fee
 - Refuse to pay anyone at a makeshift collection point — walk past firmly
 - Ask your hotel to confirm which sites require separate fees, if any
-

The Marionette Workshop Pressure Sale

You are invited into a traditional Mandalay marionette workshop for a 'free demonstration.' The craftsman performs a charming show with handmade string puppets, explains the history, and lets you try operating one. It is genuinely interesting. Then the mood shifts — you are escorted to a showroom where puppets range from 30,000 to 200,000 kyat. Staff crowd around, explaining the hours of work in each piece, making it socially excruciating to leave without buying. Travelers report feeling trapped in the showroom with multiple staff members blocking a graceful exit.

■ Red Flags

- Free demonstration that transitions directly into a retail showroom
- Multiple staff members surround you after the demonstration ends
- Emotional pitch about supporting traditional craftspeople
- No clear path to exit the showroom without passing through sales staff
- Enjoy the demonstration but decide your budget before entering — small puppets for 5,000-10,000 kyat are fair souvenirs

■ How to Avoid

- Enjoy the demonstration but decide your budget before entering — small puppets for 5,000-10,000 kyat are fair souvenirs
 - Say 'beautiful work, but I am just looking' and walk toward the door confidently
 - Do not feel obligated to buy — the demonstration is advertising, not a favor
 - If you want a puppet, compare prices at Zegyo Market first where they sell for less without the theater
-

The Airport Taxi Gouging

Taxi drivers at the arrivals exit immediately quote 40,000-60,000 kyat for the ride into town. The actual fair price is 10,000-15,000 kyat. They know you have no alternatives — there is no public bus, Grab coverage is unreliable from the airport, and it is too far to walk. If you try to negotiate, drivers band together and refuse to undercut each other. Travelers on Reddit describe a cartel-like pricing system where all drivers at the stand quote the same inflated rate.

■ Red Flags

- All drivers at the stand quote the same inflated price with no variation
- Driver refuses to use a meter or claims there is a fixed airport rate
- No official taxi counter or rate board visible at the terminal
- Driver discourages you from calling or waiting for a ride-hailing app
- Arrange airport pickup through your hotel before arriving — most hotels offer transfers at fair rates

■ How to Avoid

- Arrange airport pickup through your hotel before arriving — most hotels offer transfers at fair rates
 - Try booking a Grab car from inside the terminal; even if coverage is spotty, it sets a price benchmark
 - Walk past the first row of taxis to the road where independent drivers charge less
 - Share a taxi with other arriving passengers to split the cost
-

The Fake Monastic Donation

It is genuinely moving. Then the guide explains that the school is underfunded and invites you to make a donation — he will deliver it personally. You give 20,000 kyat in good faith. But the money never reaches the school. Guides or middlemen pocket the donations entirely, using the monks' poverty as a prop. Some travelers on Reddit have returned to the same schools and discovered that regular visitors' donations are routinely intercepted by unofficial guides. The monks themselves receive nothing.

■ Red Flags

- Guide collects the donation rather than you giving it directly to a monk or school administrator
- No receipt or official donation record provided
- Guide takes you to a specific school rather than letting you choose
- Emotional pitch about how desperately the school needs funds
- If you want to donate, give directly to a senior monk or place money in the official donation box at the monastery

■ How to Avoid

- If you want to donate, give directly to a senior monk or place money in the official donation box at the monastery
 - Never give cash to a guide to deliver on your behalf
 - Donate supplies like notebooks, pens, or rice rather than cash — harder to intercept
 - Visit monastic schools independently or through a reputable tour company, not a freelance guide
-

The Overcrowded Horse Cart Tour Commission

■ ■ Hotel areas near Mandalay Palace, routes to Sagaing and Mingun A horse cart driver offers a full-day tour of Mandalay's temples and Sagaing Hill for a low flat rate. The tour is pleasant, but the driver makes five 'bonus stops' at

workshops and souvenir shops where you face extended sales pitches. The workshops sell jade, marionettes, and silk at prices marked up for the captive tour-group audience, and the driver earns a commission of 20-30 percent on anything you buy. The total time spent at commercial stops may exceed the time at actual attractions. While this is common in Myanmar tourism, tourists should be aware the low tour price is subsidized by expected shop commissions. **Red Flags** Tour price seems remarkably low for a full-day excursion with transport Driver makes multiple unscheduled stops at workshops and shops Staff at each shop seem to know the driver and greet him by name You spend more time at commercial stops than at the advertised attractions Products at the workshop stops are significantly more expensive than at Zay Cho Market **How to Avoid** Agree in writing on the specific stops before the tour begins — no unscheduled workshops Rent a motorbike or e-bike and explore Mandalay independently for about 8,000-10,000 kyat per day If the driver stops at a shop, politely decline to enter and wait outside Buy souvenirs at Zay Cho Market in central Mandalay where prices are competitive Tip the driver fairly if you skip the shops — their base rate assumes commission income ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Myanmar Police Force station. Call 199 (Police) or 191 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at moi.gov.mm. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Yangon is at 110 University Avenue, Kamayut Township, Yangon. For emergencies: +95 1-753-6509. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in Myanmar** ■■

The tour is pleasant, but the driver makes five 'bonus stops' at workshops and souvenir shops where you face extended sales pitches. The workshops sell jade, marionettes, and silk at prices marked up for the captive tour-group audience, and the driver earns a commission of 20-30 percent on anything you buy. The total time spent at commercial stops may exceed the time at actual attractions. While this is common in Myanmar tourism, tourists should be aware the low tour price is subsidized by expected shop commissions.

■ Red Flags

- Tour price seems remarkably low for a full-day excursion with transport
- Driver makes multiple unscheduled stops at workshops and shops
- Staff at each shop seem to know the driver and greet him by name
- You spend more time at commercial stops than at the advertised attractions
- Products at the workshop stops are significantly more expensive than at Zay Cho Market

■ How to Avoid

- Agree in writing on the specific stops before the tour begins — no unscheduled workshops
 - Rent a motorbike or e-bike and explore Mandalay independently for about 8,000-10,000 kyat per day
 - If the driver stops at a shop, politely decline to enter and wait outside
 - Buy souvenirs at Zay Cho Market in central Mandalay where prices are competitive
 - Tip the driver fairly if you skip the shops — their base rate assumes commission income
-

■■ Yangon

6 scams documented • Myanmar

The Money Changer Sleight of Hand

slightly better than the shops inside. You hand over \$100 and he starts counting kyat notes. Midway through, he calls over a colleague to 'verify' your bill, and suddenly two or three guys are examining multiple notes simultaneously in loud, hurried voices. In the chaos of hands and bills moving, your \$100 vanishes. You walk away with roughly half of what you were owed. Travelers on TripAdvisor and Reddit warn that these street changers work in coordinated teams specifically targeting foreigners.

■ Red Flags

- Money changer operates from the street rather than an established shop

- Multiple people suddenly involved in counting or verifying your bills
- Rate offered is noticeably better than official shops inside the market
- Aggressive or hurried atmosphere during the transaction
- Changer insists on putting a rubber band around the notes before you count

■ How to Avoid

- Only exchange money at established shops inside Bogyoke Market like X-one Money Changer
 - Count your kyat carefully before handing over your dollars — never let both be out of your hands at once
 - Use ATMs inside bank lobbies for the best rates with no human trickery
 - If anyone calls over a second person during your exchange, take your money and walk away
-

The Dala Ferry Trap

Fine, that's the official price. But the real scam starts on the other side. A man claiming to be an 'official guide' insists foreigners are required to have one. He arranges a trishaw ride for what you think is 4,500 kyat, but at the end demands 36,000 kyat. Then you're steered to 'donate rice for the poor' at a shop selling 40,000-kyat bags. One Myanmar Times journalist documented losing over 75,000 kyat in a single visit. Tripadvisor reviews consistently call Dala the worst tourist trap in Yangon.

■ Red Flags

- Anyone at the Dala terminal claiming foreigners must have an official guide
- Trishaw drivers quoting prices that seem low then inflating at the end
- Pressure to buy rice or make donations at specific shops
- Guides steering you to predetermined stops rather than letting you explore freely
- Foreigners do NOT need a guide in Dala — decline firmly and explore on foot

■ How to Avoid

- Foreigners do NOT need a guide in Dala — decline firmly and explore on foot
 - Negotiate trishaw prices in writing before departing and pay only the agreed amount
 - If you want to donate, bring supplies from Yangon rather than buying at inflated Dala shops
 - Consider visiting Dala with a reputable Yangon-based tour company or local friend
-

The Taxi Meter Manipulation

The driver claims his meter is broken and quotes 10,000 kyat for a ride that should cost 2,500-3,500 kyat. If you insist on the meter, he reluctantly turns it on — but it ticks suspiciously fast. Some drivers take deliberately longer routes through congested side streets. At the airport, the markup is even worse: drivers at the arrivals curb routinely quote 15,000-20,000 kyat for a trip that costs 7,000-8,000 kyat via Grab. Reddit travelers consistently recommend downloading Grab before landing.

■ Red Flags

- Driver claims the meter is broken or not working
- Quoted fare is double or triple what Grab shows for the same route
- Driver takes an unfamiliar or winding route through congested areas
- Aggressive solicitation at the airport arrivals exit
- Download the Grab app before arriving — it works reliably in Yangon and shows fair prices

■ How to Avoid

- Download the Grab app before arriving — it works reliably in Yangon and shows fair prices
- If you must take a street taxi, agree on the fare before getting in
- For airport transfers, book through your hotel or use the official taxi counter inside the terminal

- A fair city ride in Yangon rarely exceeds 3,500 kyat; anything above 5,000 for a short trip is inflated
-

The Shwedagon Pagoda Shoe Watcher

A friendly local offers to 'watch' your shoes while you explore. When you return an hour later, they demand 5,000-10,000 kyat for the 'service' — or worse, claim your shoes have been moved to a different location and you need to pay to retrieve them. The official shoe storage areas are free, but the informal watchers position themselves to intercept tourists before they reach the proper shelves. It is a low-stakes scam, but it is universal at Shwedagon.

■ Red Flags

- Someone offers to watch your shoes rather than you placing them on the free shelves yourself
- No official signage or uniform on the person offering the service
- Your shoes are moved from where you left them when you return
- Demand for payment is aggressive or involves claimed 'storage fees'
- Use the official free shoe storage shelves at each entrance — look for the racks near the stairway

■ How to Avoid

- Use the official free shoe storage shelves at each entrance — look for the racks near the stairway
 - Carry a plastic bag and keep your shoes in your daypack
 - Politely decline anyone offering to hold your shoes with a firm 'no, thank you'
 - If someone moves your shoes, stay calm and retrieve them — you owe nothing
-

The Restaurant Price Ambush

The server quotes prices verbally: mohinga for 1,500 kyat, tea leaf salad for 2,000. Fair enough. But the bill arrives at 8,000 kyat because they added 'service charges,' drinks you did not order, and side dishes that were placed on the table unbidden. Travelers on Reddit report that some restaurants in tourist areas deliberately omit prices from menus so they can inflate the bill for foreigners, sometimes doubling or tripling the local price.

■ Red Flags

- No written menu with prices, only verbal quotes
- Dishes placed on your table that you did not order
- Bill significantly higher than the prices quoted when ordering
- Server avoids writing down your order or providing an itemized check
- Ask for a menu with prices — if none exists, confirm each price verbally and write it down yourself

■ How to Avoid

- Ask for a menu with prices — if none exists, confirm each price verbally and write it down yourself
 - Do not eat anything placed on the table that you did not order; send it back immediately
 - Check the bill line by line before paying and dispute any unrecognized charges
 - Eat where locals eat — if the restaurant is full of tourists and empty of Myanmar people, be cautious
-

The English-Speaking Stranger Confidence Scam

■ ■ *Downtown Yangon near Sule Pagoda, Bogyoke Aung San Market (Scott Market), tourist areas near Shwedagon Pagoda entrance* You are exploring downtown Yangon near Sule Pagoda when a well-dressed man approaches speaking fluent English. He says he is a teacher and offers to show you around. He seems knowledgeable and friendly. Over the course of the afternoon, he guides you to specific shops where you are pressured to buy overpriced gems or handicrafts. At the end, he presents a bill for his 'guide services.' Multiple Reddit posts on r/myanmar documented this: 'In a rare incident in downtown Yangon, an English-speaking Indian man scammed a Vietnamese tourist as locals couldn't help due to the language barrier.' The scam works specifically because few locals speak enough English to intervene. Red Flags A stranger approaches you speaking fluent English and offers to be your guide for free They steer you toward specific shops or

restaurants where they clearly have a relationship with staff The shops sell gems, jewelry, or handicrafts at prices that seem inflated At the end of the interaction, they present unexpected charges for their services Locals seem unable to assist because of the language barrier How to Avoid Hire guides only through your hotel, a licensed tour agency, or the Myanmar Tourism Federation Be skeptical of anyone who approaches you on the street offering free guidance — legitimate guides do not solicit on the sidewalk If you want to explore independently, download offline maps and use Google Translate for Myanmar (Burmese) Avoid buying gems or expensive items from shops a stranger leads you to — they earn commission on your purchases If someone insists on accompanying you, clearly state that you are not paying for any services ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Myanmar Police Force station. Call 199 (Police) or 191 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at moi.gov.mm. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Yangon is at 110 University Avenue, Kamayut Township, Yangon. For emergencies: +95 1-753-6509. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Myanmar ■■

He says he is a teacher and offers to show you around. He seems knowledgeable and friendly. Over the course of the afternoon, he guides you to specific shops where you are pressured to buy overpriced gems or handicrafts. At the end, he presents a bill for his 'guide services.' Multiple Reddit posts on r/myanmar documented this: 'In a rare incident in downtown Yangon, an English-speaking Indian man scammed a Vietnamese tourist as locals couldn't help due to the language barrier.' The scam works specifically because few locals speak enough English to intervene.

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you speaking fluent English and offers to be your guide for free
- They steer you toward specific shops or restaurants where they clearly have a relationship with staff
- The shops sell gems, jewelry, or handicrafts at prices that seem inflated
- At the end of the interaction, they present unexpected charges for their services
- Locals seem unable to assist because of the language barrier

■ How to Avoid

- Hire guides only through your hotel, a licensed tour agency, or the Myanmar Tourism Federation
 - Be skeptical of anyone who approaches you on the street offering free guidance — legitimate guides do not solicit on the sidewalk
 - If you want to explore independently, download offline maps and use Google Translate for Myanmar (Burmese)
 - Avoid buying gems or expensive items from shops a stranger leads you to — they earn commission on your purchases
 - If someone insists on accompanying you, clearly state that you are not paying for any services
-

■ Philippines

■■ Boracay

5 scams documented • Philippines

The Unregistered Tour Operator

half the price of the hotel's tour. He takes your money and says to meet at 8am at Station 1. Nobody shows up. The Malay-Boracay Tourism Office has issued official warnings about unregistered operators flooding the island since 2024, with online booking fraud rising sharply.

■ Red Flags

- Price significantly below what hotels or DOT-accredited operators charge
- No official receipt or DOT accreditation number
- Booking via Facebook messenger or cash only
- Operator has no physical office
- Only book with DOT-accredited operators — ask for their accreditation number

■ How to Avoid

- Only book with DOT-accredited operators — ask for their accreditation number
 - Book through your hotel's tour desk
 - If booking online, verify the operator on the DOT accreditation portal
 - Pay by credit card for fraud protection
-

The Tricycle Fare Gouge

But the driver quotes ■300 for a 5-minute ride. When you argue, he claims it's 'tourist price' or 'night rate.' Some drivers also take roundabout routes to justify higher fares to newly arrived tourists who don't know the island's tiny size.

■ Red Flags

- Fare quoted is 5-10x the local rate
- Driver claims special rates for tourists or time of day
- Unnecessarily long route on a very small island
- The driver starts the trip before you agree on a price, making it harder to negotiate mid-ride
- Ask your hotel what the standard tricycle fare should be

■ How to Avoid

- Ask your hotel what the standard tricycle fare should be
 - Standard fare is ■20-50 between stations, ■100-150 for longer routes
 - Agree on price before getting in
 - Use Angkas or walk — the island is only 7km long
-

The Jet Ski / Water Sports Damage Claim

When you return it, the operator peels back tape that was covering pre-existing scratches and cracks. 'You did this!' He demands ■15,000-50,000 for repairs. The tape was strategically placed to manufacture damage claims. Same scam, same playbook as Thailand.

■ Red Flags

- Tape or stickers on the hull that seem oddly placed
- No pre-ride damage inspection offered
- Operator becomes aggressive when you deny causing damage
- The operator does not offer any insurance or damage waiver options before you begin
- Video the entire jet ski including under all tape/stickers before riding

■ How to Avoid

- Video the entire jet ski including under all tape/stickers before riding
 - Take photos with the operator visible in frame for proof of condition
 - If confronted, stay calm and call the Tourism Police or barangay hall
 - Consider skipping jet skis entirely — this scam is extremely common
-

The Paraw Sailing Price Flip

You agree and hop aboard the traditional outrigger. Halfway through the trip, out on open water, he announces that the price was actually 500 pesos per person, not per boat, and that the hour started from when he began setting up the sail, not from when you boarded. Your one-hour trip for two becomes a 30-minute trip costing 2,000 pesos after he adds a sunset surcharge. Guide to the Philippines and Boracay travel forums document this price-flipping pattern with paraw boats along White Beach.

■ Red Flags

- The boatman agrees to a low price very quickly without negotiation
- No price or terms are written down before you board
- The duration or price per person changes once you are on the water and cannot easily return
- Additional surcharges for sunset, photos, or anchoring are announced mid-trip
- The boatman rushes the start time so your hour is shorter than expected

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on the total price for all passengers, the exact start and end time, and any inclusions before boarding and write it down or text it to yourself
- Book paraw sailing through your hotel or a licensed tour operator rather than directly from beach vendors
- Ask other tourists on the beach what they paid for a similar trip to establish a fair baseline price
- Carry only enough cash for the agreed price so there is no opportunity for the boatman to demand more
- If the boatman changes terms mid-trip, firmly state the original agreement and offer to pay only the agreed amount upon return

The Boracay Pier Departure Fee Scam

■ ■ *Boracay Jetty Port (Cagban Port), the pier area between Boracay and Caticlan, ticket booths at the departure terminal* You are leaving Boracay heading to Caticlan Airport and need to take the boat from the Boracay Jetty Port. At the pier, unofficial ticket sellers approach you aggressively before you reach the legitimate ticket counter, pushing you to buy tickets at inflated prices. A Reddit user on r/phtravel described being scammed by these intermediaries who position themselves between arriving passengers and the official booth. The first person baits you with a friendly greeting and offer to help, then a second person switches the price — a classic bait-and-switch reported on r/Philippines. The legitimate boat fare from Boracay to Caticlan is approximately 100-200 PHP depending on the vessel. Scammers charge 500-1,000 PHP or more by bundling fake 'environmental fees' and 'terminal fees' that are already included in your ticket. Klook app bookings can help you avoid this entirely by pre-purchasing your transfers. Red Flags Someone approaches you at the pier before you reach the official ticket booth and offers to sell you a boat ticket The price quoted is more than 300 PHP for a standard boat crossing to Caticlan The seller adds multiple surcharges like 'environmental fee' or 'porter fee' on top of the ticket price The ticket you receive does not have official branding from the boat operator The seller rushes you and insists the next boat is about to leave immediately How to Avoid Walk directly to the official ticket counter inside the terminal building and ignore anyone who approaches you outside Pre-book your Boracay to Caticlan transfer through Klook or Get Your Guide for fixed, transparent pricing The official boat fare is 100-200 PHP — know this before arriving so you can reject inflated quotes If you have a flight from Caticlan Airport, allow extra time so you are not pressured by urgency into paying more Report overcharging to the Boracay Inter-Agency Rehabilitation Management Group (BIARMG) or the local tourism office ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Philippine National Police (PNP) station. Call 911 or 117 (PNP Hotline). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at pnp.gov.ph. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Manila is at 1201 Roxas Boulevard, Ermita, Manila 1000. For emergencies: +63 2-5301-2000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Philippines ■ ■

At the pier, unofficial ticket sellers approach you aggressively before you reach the legitimate ticket counter, pushing you to buy tickets at inflated prices. A Reddit user on r/phtravel described being scammed by these intermediaries who position themselves between arriving passengers and the official booth. The first person baits you with a friendly greeting and offer to help, then a second person switches the price — a classic

bait-and-switch reported on r/Philippines. The legitimate boat fare from Boracay to Caticlan is approximately 100-200 PHP depending on the vessel. Scammers charge...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you at the pier before you reach the official ticket booth and offers to sell you a boat ticket
- The price quoted is more than 300 PHP for a standard boat crossing to Caticlan
- The seller adds multiple surcharges like 'environmental fee' or 'porter fee' on top of the ticket price
- The ticket you receive does not have official branding from the boat operator
- The seller rushes you and insists the next boat is about to leave immediately

■ How to Avoid

- Walk directly to the official ticket counter inside the terminal building and ignore anyone who approaches you outside
 - Pre-book your Boracay to Caticlan transfer through Klook or Get Your Guide for fixed, transparent pricing
 - The official boat fare is 100-200 PHP — know this before arriving so you can reject inflated quotes
 - If you have a flight from Caticlan Airport, allow extra time so you are not pressured by urgency into paying more
 - Report overcharging to the Boracay Inter-Agency Rehabilitation Management Group (BIARMG) or the local tourism office
-

■■ Cebu

7 scams documented • Philippines

The Broken Taxi Meter Scam

As the car pulls away, you ask the driver to turn on the meter. He waves dismissively and says 'Meter broken, sir — 500 pesos to the city.' The actual metered fare to Cebu City center is around 150-200 PHP. If you insist on the meter, some drivers will reluctantly turn it on but then take a deliberately longer route through traffic-congested streets. This is the most commonly reported scam in Cebu. A TripAdvisor thread titled 'Yellow Taxi Cab Drivers Are Scammers — BEWARE' documented a specific case where a driver demanded 300 PHP from Mactan Airport to Pier 1 while the meter, which was wor...

■ Red Flags

- The driver claims the meter is broken or says it is 'not working today' — this is almost always a lie
- The quoted fixed price is more than double what Google Maps shows for the distance
- The meter appears to be running unusually fast compared to the rate of travel
- The driver refuses to let you check the plate number and operator number displayed on the dashboard
- The driver immediately proposes a fixed fare without you asking — a sign they know the metered rate is much lower

■ How to Avoid

- Use the Grab app (Southeast Asia's equivalent of Uber) for all rides — prices are fixed, routes are tracked, and you can rate drivers
 - If using a taxi, insist the meter is running before the car moves — if the driver refuses, get out and take the next one
 - Note the taxi's plate number and operator number before getting in — displayed on a card on the dashboard
 - Pre-book airport transfers through your hotel, which typically costs 350-500 PHP to Cebu City center
 - Know the approximate fares: Airport to Cebu City center is 150-250 PHP metered, Airport to IT Park is 200-300 PHP
-

Fake Tour Guide Hustle

You are standing outside Magellan's Cross, reading the historical plaques, when a friendly local approaches and starts telling you fascinating stories about the site's history. He knows details that are not on the signs and offers to show you some 'hidden spots' that tourists never see. You follow him for an hour through the old

quarter, visiting a chapel, a viewpoint, and a 'local artisan workshop.' At the end, he demands 2,000-3,000 PHP for his services — roughly \$35-55 USD. When you balk, he becomes aggressive and claims you agreed to pay by following him. The Guide to the Philippines an...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you at a tourist site and begins giving unsolicited information or history
- They offer to show you 'hidden' or 'secret' spots that only locals know — creating a sense of exclusive access
- They never mention a price or show any identification badge during the entire interaction
- The route includes stops at specific shops or restaurants where the guide seems to know the staff personally
- At the end of the tour, they present a specific price and become confrontational if you do not pay

■ How to Avoid

- Only hire tour guides who display a DOT (Department of Tourism) accreditation badge
- Agree on the price, duration, and itinerary before any tour begins — get it in writing or via text message
- If a stranger starts giving you a tour unsolicited, politely say 'No thank you, I prefer to explore alone' within the first minute
- Book tours through your hotel, a reputable platform like Klook or GetYourGuide, or a licensed local agency
- If pressured for payment at the end of an unsolicited tour, offer 200-500 PHP as a tip and walk away — you do not owe the demanded amount

Money Changer Sleight of Hand

You need to exchange USD to Philippine Pesos and find a money changer near Colon Street offering a rate slightly better than the bank. You hand over \$200 USD. The teller counts out the pesos in front of you — it looks correct at around 11,000 PHP. She hands you the stack. Back at your hotel, you recount and discover you only have 8,500 PHP. The teller used a sleight-of-hand trick while counting, folding bills together or palming notes so deftly that you could not see it happening. The money changer scam in Cebu is well-documented. The Guide to the Philippines warns about the 'sleight of han...

■ Red Flags

- The offered rate is significantly better than banks or mall-based changers — if it seems too good to be true, it is
- A person on the street approaches you and offers to change money at a 'special rate'
- The teller counts rapidly, fans the bills, or engages you in conversation during the counting to break your concentration
- The exchange kiosk is a small independent booth, not inside a bank, mall, or established business
- The teller or someone nearby tries to distract you (pointing something out, asking a question) while handing you the money

■ How to Avoid

- Use money changers inside established malls only — Ayala Center Cebu and SM City Cebu have multiple reputable options
- Count the money yourself immediately at the counter, bill by bill, before walking away
- Calculate the expected amount on your phone before the transaction so you know exactly how many pesos to expect
- Never exchange money with someone who approaches you on the street, regardless of the rate offered
- Use ATMs from major banks (BDO, BPI, Metrobank) for the safest exchange, accepting the small withdrawal fee

Island Hopping Tour Bait and Switch

it promises visits to three islands, snorkeling gear, lunch, and photos. On the day, you are picked up and taken to a dock where a worn-out banca (outrigger boat) is waiting. The snorkeling gear is cracked and ill-fitting. You visit only two islands instead of three because 'the weather changed.' Lunch is a few pieces of grilled fish instead of the feast shown in photos. At the end, the boat operator demands an additional 500 PHP per person

for 'fuel surcharge' and 'island entrance fees' that were supposedly included. Cebu tourism authorities have been fighting this pattern actively. SunSta...

■ Red Flags

- The tour is marketed primarily through Facebook with no presence on TripAdvisor, Google, Klook, or other review platforms
- The price is significantly lower than comparable tours from established operators — a legitimate three-island tour runs 2,000-3,500 PHP
- The operator asks for full payment upfront via GCash or bank transfer with no written confirmation of what is included
- Photos on the listing look too professional or are clearly taken from other companies' marketing materials
- The operator cannot provide specifics about the boat, lunch menu, or island itinerary when asked

■ How to Avoid

- Book island hopping through established platforms (Klook, GetYourGuide, Viator) or directly through hotels that vet their partners
- Check TripAdvisor and Google reviews for the specific operator — not just the Facebook page reviews which can be faked
- Get a written or text-based confirmation listing every inclusion: islands visited, snorkeling gear, lunch details, entrance fees, and fuel costs
- Pay a deposit only, not full payment, and settle the balance after the tour is complete
- Ask to see the boat before committing — legitimate operators are happy to show their equipment

Dive Shop Bait and Switch

three dives including the famous sardine run, equipment rental, a PADI-certified dive master, and boat fees. When you arrive, the equipment looks old and poorly maintained. Your dive master turns out to be an unlicensed local who learned to dive informally. Then the hidden charges begin: the 100 PHP Marine Park fee per dive (300 PHP total), a 25 PHP Environmental User Fee, a 300-500 PHP mandatory 'local guide fee,' and a separate boat surcharge because 'fuel prices increased.' Your 3,500 PHP package has become 5,500 PHP. While Moalboal and Mactan have many excellent, reputable dive operator...

■ Red Flags

- The advertised price is significantly lower than established PADI 5-star dive centers in the same area
- The booking confirmation does not itemize what is and is not included — especially Marine Park fees, equipment, and boat transfers
- The operator cannot provide their PADI certification number or the name of a certified dive master
- Equipment looks worn, damaged, or does not fit properly — a serious safety concern, not just a comfort issue
- Additional fees are announced on the day of the dive that were not mentioned during booking

■ How to Avoid

- Book with PADI 5-star dive centers only — check their certification on PADI's website before booking
- Ask for a complete price breakdown in writing before committing: dives, equipment, boat, park fees, guide fees, and any other charges
- Pay a small deposit and settle the full amount only after verifying the equipment and meeting your dive master
- Check recent TripAdvisor and Google reviews specifically mentioning hidden charges or equipment quality
- For Oslob whale shark viewing, book through the official Oslob Tourism Office to ensure regulated pricing and ethical practices

Market Pickpocket Teams at Carbon Market

The narrow aisles are packed with vendors selling dried fish, produce, and household goods. As you squeeze through a particularly crowded section, someone bumps into you from behind while another vendor aggressively waves fabric samples in your face. By the time you emerge from the crowd, your wallet is gone from your back pocket and your bag has been unzipped. Carbon Market is both Cebu's most authentic market experience and one of its highest-risk areas for pickpocketing. CebuParadise's safety guide confirms that 'pickpockets are usually found in crowded places like touristy areas or mark...

■ Red Flags

- You are being jostled more than the crowd density explains — someone is creating unnecessary physical contact
- A vendor aggressively tries to get your attention by grabbing your arm or holding items in your face, even after you say no
- You notice the same person appearing near you multiple times as you move through the market
- Someone bumps into you and apologizes profusely, maintaining contact longer than necessary
- A group seems to be moving in coordination around you — one in front slowing down, others on the sides

■ How to Avoid

- Leave valuables at your hotel — bring only the cash you need in a front pocket, not a wallet in your back pocket
- Wear a crossbody bag on your front with the zipper facing your body, and keep one hand on it at all times
- Visit Carbon Market early in the morning when it is less crowded and visibility is better
- Go with a local guide or Filipino friend who knows the market layout and can watch your back
- Keep your phone in a front zippered pocket, not in your hand — phone snatching is as common as wallet theft

The Fake Resort Booking Scam

■ ■ *Fraudulent Facebook pages mimicking Bantayan Island and Malapascua resorts, fake booking sites targeting Cebu visitors, social media ads for Mactan beach hotels* You find a Facebook page for a Bantayan Island resort offering a three-night beachfront package at 60 percent off. The page has the resort's real photos, logo, and even more followers than the genuine page. You pay 15,000 pesos via GCash to the account listed. When you arrive at Bantayan Island, the resort has no record of your booking. At least 200 confirmed cases hit Bantayan Island resorts since September 2025, with Anika Island Resort and Kota Beach Resort each handling over 100 scammed guests. SunStar Cebu reported that tourism officials and hotel associations launched a crackdown after victims collectively lost approximately 500,000 pesos. **Red Flags** The resort booking is offered through a Facebook page rather than the resort's official website or a known booking platform. Payment is requested via GCash, bank transfer, or personal e-wallet rather than a booking platform with buyer protection. The price is dramatically lower than the same resort charges on Booking.com or Agoda. The Facebook page has more followers than the resort's official verified page, suggesting purchased fake followers. The booking confirmation comes via Messenger rather than an official hotel email from the resort's domain. **How to Avoid** Book Cebu and Bantayan Island resorts only through their official website or verified platforms like Booking.com, Agoda, or Traveloka. Verify the Facebook page by looking for the blue verification checkmark and comparing the URL with the resort's official website. Call the resort directly using the phone number from Google Maps to confirm the page and booking are real before paying. Never pay for resort bookings via GCash, personal bank accounts, or e-wallets; use credit cards or platform payments with dispute protection. Search for the resort name plus 'scam' on Google before booking if you found the deal on social media. ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Philippine National Police (PNP) station. Call 911 or 117 (PNP Hotline). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at pnp.gov.ph. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Manila is at 1201 Roxas Boulevard, Ermita, Manila 1000. For emergencies: +63 2-5301-2000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides** More in Philippines ■ ■

The page has the resort's real photos, logo, and even more followers than the genuine page. You pay 15,000 pesos via GCash to the account listed. When you arrive at Bantayan Island, the resort has no record of your booking. At least 200 confirmed cases hit Bantayan Island resorts since September 2025, with Anika Island Resort and Kota Beach Resort each handling over 100 scammed guests. SunStar Cebu reported that tourism

officials and hotel associations launched a crackdown after victims collectively lost approximately 500,000 pesos.

■ Red Flags

- The resort booking is offered through a Facebook page rather than the resort's official website or a known booking platform
- Payment is requested via GCash, bank transfer, or personal e-wallet rather than a booking platform with buyer protection
- The price is dramatically lower than the same resort charges on Booking.com or Agoda
- The Facebook page has more followers than the resort's official verified page, suggesting purchased fake followers
- The booking confirmation comes via Messenger rather than an official hotel email from the resort's domain

■ How to Avoid

- Book Cebu and Bantayan Island resorts only through their official website or verified platforms like Booking.com, Agoda, or Traveloka
 - Verify the Facebook page by looking for the blue verification checkmark and comparing the URL with the resort's official website
 - Call the resort directly using the phone number from Google Maps to confirm the page and booking are real before paying
 - Never pay for resort bookings via GCash, personal bank accounts, or e-wallets; use credit cards or platform payments with dispute protection
 - Search for the resort name plus 'scam' on Google before booking if you found the deal on social media
-

■■ El Nido

4 scams documented • Philippines

The Dangerous 'Alternative Ferry' to Coron

When you can't get one, a 'travel agent' appears offering passage on 'another boat.' What they don't tell you is this boat departs from a port in northern Palawan and involves a 10+ hour crossing on a rickety barge through open sea with significant swells. Tourists have been stranded, seasick for hours, and in genuine danger on these crossings.

■ Red Flags

- Ticket for a route that's 'sold out' at official operators
- Significantly cheaper than the official ferry
- Departure from a different, unfamiliar port
- No safety equipment or vessel registration visible
- Book El Nido-Coron ferries weeks in advance through official operators (Montenegro Lines, Bunso Ki Ferry)

■ How to Avoid

- Book El Nido-Coron ferries weeks in advance through official operators (Montenegro Lines, Bunso Ki Ferry)
 - If sold out, fly via Manila or wait for the next day's sailing
 - Never board an unregistered vessel for open-sea crossings
 - Your life is worth more than saving one day
-

The Island Tour Environmental Fee Stack

When you arrive at the port, you learn about the Eco-Tourism Development Fee (■200), the environmental fee (■200 per lagoon), kayak rental for the lagoon (■300), and lunch isn't included. Your ■1,200 tour is now

■2,500. The fees are legitimate — but honest operators include them in the quoted price upfront.

■ Red Flags

- Very low quoted price compared to other operators
- Fees and add-ons mentioned only at the port on departure day
- Operator doesn't give you a detailed price breakdown when booking
- Ask specifically: 'Does the price include environmental fee, ETDF, lunch, and lagoon fees?'
- The all-inclusive fair price for Tour A is ■1,500-2,000

■ How to Avoid

- Ask specifically: 'Does the price include environmental fee, ETDF, lunch, and lagoon fees?'
 - The all-inclusive fair price for Tour A is ■1,500-2,000
 - Book through hotels or established operators who quote all-in prices
 - The environmental fees are real and non-negotiable — just make sure they're in your quote
-

The Beachfront Seafood Bill Shock

You sit at a beachfront restaurant and order grilled fish and prawns from a menu that shows 'market price.' The waiter brings a stunning platter. The bill arrives at PHP 7,000 -- roughly \$125 -- for what you thought would be a casual dinner. The 'market price' was never disclosed before cooking, and additional charges for rice, sauces, and cooking fees have been added. Some restaurants also charge a significant service fee not mentioned on the menu.

■ Red Flags

- Menu shows 'market price' or 'SQ' (seasonal quote) without a figure
- Waiter doesn't confirm the total price before cooking starts
- Asterisks on the menu with fine print about additional charges
- Restaurant has no posted prices on the outdoor display
- Always ask for the exact peso price per kilo before ordering seafood

■ How to Avoid

- Always ask for the exact peso price per kilo before ordering seafood
 - Check Google Maps reviews for the specific restaurant before eating
 - Restaurants a block back from the beach are typically 30-50% cheaper
 - Budget restaurants in El Nido town offer full Filipino meals for PHP 150-300
-

The Vanishing Hotel Reservation

■ ■ *Hotels and guesthouses in El Nido town, Corong-Corong area* You arrive at your El Nido hotel after a long journey from Puerto Princesa only to be told your ... You arrive at your El Nido hotel after a long journey from Puerto Princesa only to be told your Booking.com reservation does not exist. The front desk claims they never received payment or the booking was canceled. They then offer you a room at a much higher 'walk-in' rate, knowing you are exhausted and have limited options in a small town. As r/Palawan and r/phtravel users report, some El Nido properties deliberately void online bookings during peak season to resell rooms at premium walk-in prices, telling guests to seek refunds from the platform while pocketing the higher rate from the next guest. **Red Flags** The hotel claims no record of your booking despite your confirmation email They blame the booking platform rather than checking their own system They conveniently have rooms available at a much higher walk-in rate This happens during peak season when demand exceeds supply Staff suggest you contact the booking platform for a refund rather than honoring the reservation **How to Avoid** Print your booking confirmation and bring it as proof Contact the hotel directly by phone or email a few days before arrival to reconfirm Book through platforms with strong buyer protection like Booking.com or Agoda Have a backup accommodation option identified before arriving If your booking is denied, call the platform's customer service immediately from the lobby ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Philippine National Police (PNP) station. Call 911 or 117 (PNP Hotline). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at pnp.gov.ph. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank

immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Manila is at 1201 Roxas Boulevard, Ermita, Manila 1000. For emergencies: +63 2-5301-2000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. [More Scam Guides](#) [More in Philippines](#) ■■

You arrive at your El Nido hotel after a long journey from Puerto Princesa only to be told your Booking.com reservation does not exist. The front desk claims they never received payment or the booking was canceled. They then offer you a room at a much higher 'walk-in' rate, knowing you are exhausted and have limited options in a small town. As [r/Palawan](#) and [r/phtravel](#) users report, some El Nido properties deliberately void online bookings during peak season to resell rooms at premium walk-in prices, telling guests to seek refunds from the platform while pocketing the higher rate from the ne...

■ Red Flags

- The hotel claims no record of your booking despite your confirmation email
- They blame the booking platform rather than checking their own system
- They conveniently have rooms available at a much higher walk-in rate
- This happens during peak season when demand exceeds supply
- Staff suggest you contact the booking platform for a refund rather than honoring the reservation

■ How to Avoid

- Print your booking confirmation and bring it as proof
 - Contact the hotel directly by phone or email a few days before arrival to reconfirm
 - Book through platforms with strong buyer protection like Booking.com or Agoda
 - Have a backup accommodation option identified before arriving
 - If your booking is denied, call the platform's customer service immediately from the lobby
-

■■ Manila

7 scams documented • Philippines

NAIA Airport Taxi Overcharge

The driver either refuses to use the meter or 'the meter is broken,' quoting you a flat rate of ■4,000 to your hotel in Makati — a trip that should cost ■200-300 by meter. Some drivers charge by terminal: the shuttle bus between T1 and T3 is free, but touts have been known to charge ■4,000 for the five-minute ride.

■ Red Flags

- Driver quotes flat rate before you state your destination
- Driver says meter is broken or unavailable
- Unlicensed taxi touts approach you before you reach the official queue
- Use Grab (rideshare app) from the designated Grab pickup zones at each terminal
- Or use the official airport taxi counters inside arrivals where rates are metered

■ How to Avoid

- Use Grab (rideshare app) from the designated Grab pickup zones at each terminal
 - Or use the official airport taxi counters inside arrivals where rates are metered
 - Never get in a taxi that won't run the meter — walk away
-

New Friend Card Game

You're approached by a very friendly Filipino who says he studied in your country and is now visiting his family in Manila. He invites you to his aunt's house nearby for some food. The 'aunt' sets up a card game where you're shown a rigged winning streak, bet increasing amounts, and then lose everything in one final hand. The entire family is part of the operation.

■ Red Flags

- Stranger claims connection to your home country immediately
- Invitation to a private home or apartment within minutes of meeting
- Card game presented as a way to 'help them win money'
- Never follow a stranger you just met to a private residence
- The 'friendly local with a connection to your home country' opener is the most common Manila scam intro

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow a stranger you just met to a private residence
 - The 'friendly local with a connection to your home country' opener is the most common Manila scam intro
 - If invited anywhere private within minutes of meeting someone, politely decline and leave
-

Kalesa Carriage Overcharge at Intramuros

You visit Intramuros and decide to take a traditional kalesa (horse-drawn carriage) for a romantic ride through the historic streets. The driver quotes ₱200 for a short loop. Afterward, the bill is ₱1,500 — you're told that's the 'full tour rate' and the ₱200 was just the starting fee. The driver becomes aggressive and bystanders seem to side with him.

■ Red Flags

- Price quoted verbally without showing a rate card
- Vague description of what the quoted price covers
- Driver initiates the ride before price is fully agreed
- Ask specifically: 'What is the TOTAL price for the full ride back to this point?'
- Official kalesa rates in Intramuros are posted — look for the tourism board rate card

■ How to Avoid

- Ask specifically: 'What is the TOTAL price for the full ride back to this point?'
 - Official kalesa rates in Intramuros are posted — look for the tourism board rate card
 - Pay only the pre-agreed amount — have exact change ready
-

Money Changer Short Change

You exchange \$100 at a money changer in Ermita and the teller counts out a stack of pesos quickly, placing them on the counter. When you get to your hotel and count the bills, you're short by several hundred pesos — the teller palmed some bills during the fast count. This is so common that locals call it the 'quick hand' scam.

■ Red Flags

- Teller counts money very quickly and hands it over immediately
- Money counted behind a partition or below the counter
- Teller urges you to move aside quickly for the next customer
- Count every bill yourself, in front of the teller, before leaving the counter
- Use ATMs or hotel exchange desks instead of street money changers

■ How to Avoid

- Count every bill yourself, in front of the teller, before leaving the counter
- Use ATMs or hotel exchange desks instead of street money changers

- Say clearly 'I need to count this' and do not be rushed
-

Fake Police Drug Setup

Shortly after, men identifying themselves as police officers stop you and claim you've just purchased illegal drugs. They threaten arrest unless you pay a 'fine' on the spot — often hundreds of US dollars. The 'police' and the seller are working together.

■ Red Flags

- Strangers approaching you in entertainment districts offering goods
- Police who appear immediately after a street purchase
- Demand for cash 'fine' paid directly to the officer rather than at a station
- Never buy anything from street sellers in Manila's entertainment districts
- Real Philippine police do not collect cash fines on the street

■ How to Avoid

- Never buy anything from street sellers in Manila's entertainment districts
 - Real Philippine police do not collect cash fines on the street
 - If approached, insist on going to the actual police station — scammers will back down
-

Overpriced Jeepney 'Tourist' Fare

The conductor gives you change, but you're short by ■50 or more. When you question it, the conductor speaks rapidly in Tagalog and waves away your concern. First-time visitors who don't know the exact fare are regular targets.

■ Red Flags

- Conductor gives change very quickly without verifying
- Not knowing the exact fare for the route
- Paying with large bills for small fares
- Carry exact change for jeepney fares — ask fellow passengers what the fare is before boarding
- The standard minimum fare is ■13-15 for the first 4km

■ How to Avoid

- Carry exact change for jeepney fares — ask fellow passengers what the fare is before boarding
 - The standard minimum fare is ■13-15 for the first 4km
 - Use Grab or the new EDSA Carousel BRT for hassle-free fixed-price travel
-

The Intramuros Aggressive Guide Shakedown

■ ■ *Intramuros entrance gates, Fort Santiago parking area, Manila Cathedral steps* You arrive at Intramuros and a man offers to be your guide for 500 pesos for a walking tour. The tour is rushed and shallow, but at the end he demands 2,000 pesos, claiming the 500 was only for the 'first section.' When you refuse, he becomes verbally aggressive and blocks your path. A Reddit user posted on r/MANILA that an unauthorized guide at Intramuros threatened to kill them when they disputed the final fee. The legitimate Intramuros Administration offers official tour guides at fixed rates, but the unauthorized freelancers who intercept tourists at the entrance gates are a persistent problem. Red Flags Guide approaches you at the entrance rather than at an official booking desk No identification card or Intramuros Administration badge is displayed Agreed price is vague — 'per section' rather than a clear total for the full tour The guide rushes through sites and seems more interested in finishing than educating Guide becomes aggressive or threatening when you dispute the final amount How to Avoid Book guides only through the Intramuros Administration office at Fort Santiago Official guided walking tours are approximately 500 pesos for a full two-hour circuit Agree on the exact total fee in writing or text message before beginning the tour If accosted by an aggressive guide, walk toward the nearest security guard post Self-guided tours using the Intramuros Administration map are perfectly feasible and free ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Philippine National Police (PNP) station. Call 911 or 117 (PNP Hotline). Get an official crime report —

you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at pnp.gov.ph. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Manila is at 1201 Roxas Boulevard, Ermita, Manila 1000. For emergencies: +63 2-5301-2000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. Frequently Asked Questions Is Manila safe for tourists? ▼

The tour is rushed and shallow, but at the end he demands 2,000 pesos, claiming the 500 was only for the 'first section.' When you refuse, he becomes verbally aggressive and blocks your path. A Reddit user posted on r/MANILA that an unauthorized guide at Intramuros threatened to kill them when they disputed the final fee. The legitimate Intramuros Administration offers official tour guides at fixed rates, but the unauthorized freelancers who intercept tourists at the entrance gates are a persistent problem.

■ Red Flags

- Guide approaches you at the entrance rather than at an official booking desk
- No identification card or Intramuros Administration badge is displayed
- Agreed price is vague — 'per section' rather than a clear total for the full tour
- The guide rushes through sites and seems more interested in finishing than educating
- Guide becomes aggressive or threatening when you dispute the final amount

■ How to Avoid

- Book guides only through the Intramuros Administration office at Fort Santiago
 - Official guided walking tours are approximately 500 pesos for a full two-hour circuit
 - Agree on the exact total fee in writing or text message before beginning the tour
 - If accosted by an aggressive guide, walk toward the nearest security guard post
 - Self-guided tours using the Intramuros Administration map are perfectly feasible and free
-

■■ Siargao

5 scams documented • Philippines

The Island Hopping Boat Safety Risk

Some operators use overloaded bangka boats without life jackets. The seas around Siargao can turn rough quickly, and multiple incidents of boats capsizing have been reported.

■ Red Flags

- Boat has no visible life jackets
- More than 10-12 people on a standard bangka
- Operator insists on going out despite rough seas
- Count life jackets before boarding
- Book through your resort or established operators

■ How to Avoid

- Count life jackets before boarding
 - Book through your resort or established operators
 - Maximum 10-12 people per standard bangka
 - If seas look rough, postpone
-

The Surf Lesson Price Gouge

After the lesson, they add charges: board rental (■300 extra), rash guard (■200), and photos (■500). Your ■500 lesson becomes ■1,500.

■ Red Flags

- The instructor quotes a price significantly higher than what surf schools at Cloud 9 charge
- No written agreement or posted price list is available
- The instructor does not have a visible affiliation with a recognized surf school
- Additional fees are added after the lesson for board rental or photos that were not mentioned upfront
- The lesson is much shorter than the agreed duration

■ How to Avoid

- Ask for an all-inclusive price before starting
 - Fair all-in price: ■800-1,200 per hour including equipment
 - Book through established surf schools (Kermit, Harana, Cloud 9 Surf School)
-

The Motorbike Rental Pre-Existing Damage Claim

You ride it for two days without incident. When you return it, the owner points to a scratch on the side panel and demands 5,000 pesos for repairs. The scratch was there when you picked it up but you did not document it. Motorbike rental disputes are the most common issue tourists face on Siargao, and without photo evidence, you have no leverage.

■ Red Flags

- The rental agreement does not list existing damage or has no condition checklist
- The shop discourages you from inspecting the bike carefully before riding off
- The owner takes the bike around a corner to inspect it out of your sight upon return
- The claimed damage is on a part of the bike you cannot remember checking
- The repair cost quoted seems disproportionately high for a minor scratch

■ How to Avoid

- Take detailed photos and video of the entire motorbike before riding away including all panels and mirrors
 - Point out any existing scratches or dents to the owner and record them agreeing on camera
 - Get a written rental agreement listing all pre-existing damage before paying
 - Rent from shops recommended by your hostel or with strong Google reviews
 - Return the bike during daylight so the inspection happens in good visibility
-

The Commission-Based Tour Operator Overcharge

When you arrive at the boat launch, you discover others on the same boat paid 800 to 1,000 pesos booking directly with the boatman. Your hostel pocketed a 50 percent commission. The same markup applies to sunset cruises, Sugba Lagoon trips, and surfing lessons where intermediaries add their cut without improving the experience.

■ Red Flags

- The hostel or booking office insists their tour is the only option and discourages you from comparing
- The price is significantly higher than what other travelers report paying for the same tour
- The booking agent cannot tell you the name of the actual boat operator
- You are told the tour is exclusive or limited when it is actually a standard group trip
- Payment must be in cash to the intermediary with no receipt from the actual operator

■ How to Avoid

- Compare prices at multiple booking offices along Tourism Road before committing

- Ask other travelers at your hostel what they paid and where they booked
 - Walk to the boat launch areas directly and negotiate with captains for island hopping tours
 - Check current prices on Facebook groups for Siargao travelers which share real-time pricing
 - Book surfing lessons directly at Cloud 9 with the surf schools rather than through a third party
-

The Hidden Beach Entrance Fee Shakedown

■ ■ Secret beaches and unnamed surf spots around General Luna, roads to Magpupungko Rock Pools, remote island stops You ride your motorbike to a 'hidden beach' recommended on social media. At the end of a dirt road, a local appears and tells you there is a 500-peso 'environmental fee' to access the beach. There are no signs, no receipts, and no officials. You pay because you have already driven 45 minutes on a rough road and do not want to turn back. Reddit users on r/Philippines_Expats noted that while Siargao generally does not have the scam culture of other Filipino tourist destinations, unofficial 'fees' have emerged at remote beaches and viewpoints as tourism has grown. The charges are pocketed by individuals, not collected for any environmental fund. Red Flags There are no official signs or posted fee schedules at the entrance to a beach or attraction The 'collector' cannot provide a printed receipt or any form of official documentation The fee is demanded only after you have traveled a significant distance to reach the location The amount is negotiable or changes depending on how many people are in your group Other locals nearby seem unaware of or uninvolved with the fee collection How to Avoid Ask your accommodation or local surf shops which beaches have legitimate entrance fees and what the correct amounts are If a fee seems unofficial, politely ask to see documentation or a receipt — legitimate sites always have them Travel with other tourists or locals who can confirm whether a fee is standard or invented Check recent reviews on Google Maps or travel forums for the specific beach before visiting Carry small bills so you are not pressured to overpay with a large note when you have no change ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Philippine National Police (PNP) station. Call 911 or 117 (PNP Hotline). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at pnp.gov.ph. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Manila is at 1201 Roxas Boulevard, Ermita, Manila 1000. For emergencies: +63 2-5301-2000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Philippines ■ ■

At the end of a dirt road, a local appears and tells you there is a 500-peso 'environmental fee' to access the beach. There are no signs, no receipts, and no officials. You pay because you have already driven 45 minutes on a rough road and do not want to turn back. Reddit users on r/Philippines_Expats noted that while Siargao generally does not have the scam culture of other Filipino tourist destinations, unofficial 'fees' have emerged at remote beaches and viewpoints as tourism has grown. The charges are pocketed by individuals, not collected for any environmental fund.

■ Red Flags

- There are no official signs or posted fee schedules at the entrance to a beach or attraction
- The 'collector' cannot provide a printed receipt or any form of official documentation
- The fee is demanded only after you have traveled a significant distance to reach the location
- The amount is negotiable or changes depending on how many people are in your group
- Other locals nearby seem unaware of or uninvolved with the fee collection

■ How to Avoid

- Ask your accommodation or local surf shops which beaches have legitimate entrance fees and what the correct amounts are
 - If a fee seems unofficial, politely ask to see documentation or a receipt — legitimate sites always have them
 - Travel with other tourists or locals who can confirm whether a fee is standard or invented
 - Check recent reviews on Google Maps or travel forums for the specific beach before visiting
 - Carry small bills so you are not pressured to overpay with a large note when you have no change
-

■ Singapore

■■ Singapore

6 scams documented • Singapore

The Overpriced Seafood Catch

it weighs 1.2kg and the price is 'market rate.' You say yes, it arrives, you enjoy it. The bill shows the crab at a 'seasonal rate' of S\$98 per 100g, a full set up you never agreed to, plus a 'seasonal surcharge' and service charge that puts your dinner for two at S\$340. These pricing sleights-of-hand are regularly documented in Singapore's tourist dining scene — prices are listed in ways that obscure the real total.

■ Red Flags

- 'Market rate' or 'seasonal rate' pricing without a specific number
- Waiter shows you the live animal rather than a price list
- Multiple additional charges listed in small print on menu
- Aggressive upselling of 'set menus' or additions
- Ask for the specific price in dollars before ordering any market-rate item

■ How to Avoid

- Ask for the specific price in dollars before ordering any market-rate item
 - Get a price estimate for the total meal before you order
 - Check Google reviews specifically mentioning 'bill' or 'price surprise'
-

The Airport Currency Exchange Trap

You land at Changi and head straight to the currency exchange booth in arrivals to get some Singapore dollars for your taxi. The exchange rate is 15-20% worse than you'd get at money changers in Orchard Road or Chinatown. Singapore locals never exchange at the airport — they know the dozens of city money changers offer dramatically better rates with zero commission.

■ Red Flags

- The exchange rate displayed is noticeably worse than what Google or XE.com shows
- The booth is prominently located in the arrivals hall targeting jet-lagged travelers
- Commission fees are buried in fine print or not disclosed until after the transaction
- The rate is advertised as 'commission-free' but the exchange rate itself includes a hidden markup
- Exchange only a small emergency amount at the airport

■ How to Avoid

- Exchange only a small emergency amount at the airport
 - Head to Tanjong Pagar Plaza or Lucky Plaza in Orchard for Singapore's best exchange rates
 - Wise or Revolut debit cards offer near-interbank rates anywhere
-

The 'Charity' Beggar Gang

An elderly or disabled-seeming person approaches you with a small packet of tissues or a handwritten laminated card explaining they need money for food or medical treatment. You give them S\$5, feeling good. Later you learn these are organized syndicate operations — the same individuals rotate through different neighborhoods following a schedule, with the collected money going to organizers rather than the people collecting it.

■ Red Flags

- Tissue packet or printed card given as an 'exchange'
- Persistent after initial refusal
- Same person appearing in different locations across days
- Do not give money to beggars on the streets as organized gangs exploit people for begging
- Donate to registered charities if you want to help vulnerable communities

■ How to Avoid

- Do not give money to beggars on the streets as organized gangs exploit people for begging
 - Donate to registered charities if you want to help vulnerable communities
 - Walk past confidently and do not engage in conversation with persistent beggars
 - Report organized begging to the Singapore Police Force as it is illegal
-

The Gem / Investment Sales Pitch

A friendly, well-dressed person strikes up a conversation with you near Clarke Quay and mentions they work in the gemstone import business. Over tea, they explain how their company has excess stock they need to sell quickly to avoid import duties — you can buy at 60% below retail. You buy what seems like a steal on a jade bracelet or colored gemstone. A jeweler at home tells you it's worth a fraction of what you paid.

■ Red Flags

- Unprompted 'business opportunity' in a tourist area
- Mention of import duty / excess inventory as justification for low prices
- Sense of urgency or 'limited time' deal
- Never buy gemstones or jewelry from strangers or informal sellers outside established jewelers
- If a deal seems too good to be true, it is — walk away from unsolicited investment offers

■ How to Avoid

- Never buy gemstones or jewelry from strangers or informal sellers outside established jewelers
 - If a deal seems too good to be true, it is — walk away from unsolicited investment offers
 - Buy jewelry only from reputable retailers certified by the Singapore Jewellers Association
 - Decline offers from people who approach you on the street with investment propositions
-

The Sim Lim Square Electronics Rip-Off

The vendor quotes 30 dollars. You agree and hand over your credit card. The receipt shows 300 dollars. The vendor claims you agreed to a warranty package. When you protest, the vendor becomes aggressive and threatens to call security. Sim Lim Square has a documented history of electronics vendors using bait-and-switch pricing, adding undisclosed warranty charges, and pressuring tourists into overpriced purchases.

■ Red Flags

- A shop quotes one price verbally but the credit card charge is significantly higher
- The vendor adds warranty or protection packages you did not agree to
- No prices are displayed on the products and the vendor names a price only verbally
- The vendor becomes aggressive or blocks you from leaving when you question the charge
- The shop has few reviews online or recent complaints about overcharging

■ How to Avoid

- Shop at established electronics retailers like Best Denki, Challenger, or Courts instead of small independent vendors
- Always confirm the total price including all add-ons before handing over your card

- Pay with cash if possible to avoid unauthorized credit card overcharges
 - If overcharged, contact the Small Claims Tribunal which has successfully ordered refunds for tourists
 - Report any fraudulent vendor to the Consumers Association of Singapore (CASE) at 6100-0315
-

The Mall Skincare Kiosk Hard Sell

■ ■ Orchard Road malls (especially ION and Wisma Atria), Marina Bay Sands Shoppes, VivoCity, Suntec City You are walking through a mall on Orchard Road when a smiling salesperson at a skincare kiosk ... You are walking through a mall on Orchard Road when a smiling salesperson at a skincare kiosk offers a 'free sample.' Before you know it, they have applied a cream to your hand and are leading you to a chair for a 'complimentary facial treatment.' The session feels relaxing until they reveal a product line costing S\$300-800 and apply heavy pressure to buy. Reddit users on r/askSingapore specifically warned about skincare kiosks where staff 'wait to bait shoppers with samples before using the product on them without them knowing they will be under pressure to buy.' The products are often generic Israeli Dead Sea cosmetics rebranded with luxury packaging. Red Flags A kiosk salesperson physically reaches out to apply a product to your hand or face without asking They guide you to sit down for a 'free demonstration' or 'complimentary treatment' Products are priced at hundreds of dollars but have no recognizable brand name They use high-pressure tactics like 'today only' discounts or claims the product is 'not available online' The salesperson becomes visibly upset or guilt-trips you when you try to leave without purchasing How to Avoid Politely but firmly say 'No thank you' and keep walking — do not stop, touch, or accept any samples If a product is already applied to your skin, you are still not obligated to buy anything Avoid making eye contact with kiosk salespeople if you want to walk through a mall without being approached Any product worth its price will be available for research online — never buy cosmetics under pressure from a kiosk Report aggressive sales tactics to mall management — Singapore malls have customer service desks for complaints ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Singapore Police Force station. Call 999. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.gov.sg. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 27 Napier Road, Singapore 258508. For emergencies: +65 6476-9100. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. Frequently Asked Questions Is Singapore safe for tourists? ▼

You are walking through a mall on Orchard Road when a smiling salesperson at a skincare kiosk offers a 'free sample.' Before you know it, they have applied a cream to your hand and are leading you to a chair for a 'complimentary facial treatment.' The session feels relaxing until they reveal a product line costing S\$300-800 and apply heavy pressure to buy. Reddit users on r/askSingapore specifically warned about skincare kiosks where staff 'wait to bait shoppers with samples before using the product on them without them knowing they will be under pressure to buy.' The products are often gen...

■ Red Flags

- A kiosk salesperson physically reaches out to apply a product to your hand or face without asking
- They guide you to sit down for a 'free demonstration' or 'complimentary treatment'
- Products are priced at hundreds of dollars but have no recognizable brand name
- They use high-pressure tactics like 'today only' discounts or claims the product is 'not available online'
- The salesperson becomes visibly upset or guilt-trips you when you try to leave without purchasing

■ How to Avoid

- Politely but firmly say 'No thank you' and keep walking — do not stop, touch, or accept any samples
 - If a product is already applied to your skin, you are still not obligated to buy anything
 - Avoid making eye contact with kiosk salespeople if you want to walk through a mall without being approached
 - Any product worth its price will be available for research online — never buy cosmetics under pressure from a kiosk
 - Report aggressive sales tactics to mall management — Singapore malls have customer service desks for complaints
-

■ Thailand

■■ Bangkok

10 scams documented • Thailand

Tuk-Tuk Gem Store Scam

you could tell he genuinely seemed sad about it. But he knew a beautiful temple nearby AND a special government gem export sale happening just today. Forty-five minutes later you were in a dingy shop in an industrial area of Bangkok, being shown 'investment grade' sapphires by a man in a suit. You bought a necklace for \$400. Back home, a jeweler told you it was worth \$8. Reddit's r/bangkok and r/solotravel are full of this exact story — the 'closed temple' setup has been running for over 20 years and the tuk-tuk drivers earn commissions of up to 40% of everything tourists spend.

■ Red Flags

- Driver volunteers that your intended destination is 'closed today for a special event'
- They offer to take you somewhere 'even better' for free or at a reduced price
- The detour involves a gem, silk, tailor, or souvenir shop
- Men in suits greet you warmly with 'special export price, today only'
- They claim gems or suits are government certified for overseas resale at profit

■ How to Avoid

- Verify temple opening times independently on Google Maps before leaving your hotel
- Never accept a tuk-tuk driver's suggestion to visit a shop — their earnings depend entirely on your purchases
- The Grand Palace closes only for specific royal ceremonies; check the official website (royalgrandpalace.th)
- Book legitimate tuk-tuk tours only through your hotel or a verified app
- If gems or suits are offered as an 'investment,' walk out immediately — no legitimate investment is sold this way

Taxi Meter Refusal

Your flight landed at Suvarnabhumi and you found the official taxi queue, got into a metered cab, and asked for your hotel on Sukhumvit Soi 11. The driver nodded, then said: '400 baht, I take you, no meter.' The meter would have cost around 250. When you insisted on the meter he shook his head and got out to flag the next passenger. It took five taxis before one agreed to use the meter. This is one of Bangkok's oldest and most reported complaints — r/bangkok threads about airport and tourist-zone taxi refusals generate hundreds of comments weekly, and the advice is always the same: walk awa...

■ Red Flags

- Driver quotes a flat rate before starting the meter
- Driver claims 'meter broken' — this is almost always untrue
- Driver at airport approaches you before the official taxi queue
- Price quoted is significantly higher than what the meter would show
- Driver agrees to the meter but then takes an obviously long route

■ How to Avoid

- Insist on the meter — say 'meter, please' firmly before the car moves
- If driver refuses the meter, exit politely and try the next taxi
- Use the Grab app for fixed-price rides that match or beat meter fare
- From Suvarnabhumi, the Airport Rail Link to Phaya Thai (45 baht) is faster and cheaper than any taxi

- Know approximate fares: airport to Sukhumvit ~250–350 baht on meter + 50 baht expressway toll
-

Ping Pong Show Overpriced Drink Trap

A friendly tout on Patpong Road handed you a laminated menu: free entry to a ping pong show, listed drink prices at 100 baht each. Inside, the show was bizarre but the 'host' kept bringing drinks you didn't order, and at the end the bill was 8,000 baht — €215. The menu you'd been shown was a fake; the real menu appeared only at payment time, with drinks at 700 baht each. Two large men stood between you and the exit. Dozens of [r/travel](#) and [r/solotravel](#) posts describe this exact scenario, and several recount being physically intimidated until they emptied their wallets or ATM cards.

■ Red Flags

- Menu shown outside has very low drink prices — these are not the real prices
- Host brings drinks you did not order and they appear on your bill
- Exit is blocked or guarded until the bill is settled
- The establishment is down a narrow alley or up stairs away from the main street
- Someone follows you from the street and is suspiciously eager to take you inside

■ How to Avoid

- Avoid any bar or show where the entrance price seems suspiciously low or 'free'
 - Never accept drinks you didn't specifically order — return them immediately
 - Keep only a small amount of cash on you in these areas; leave cards at hotel
 - If bill is astronomical and you're being intimidated, call Thai Tourist Police: 1155
 - Use licensed entertainment venues with clear signage and visible price lists inside
-

The 'Helpful Stranger' Temple Scam

You were trying to photograph Wat Arun from across the Chao Phraya when a well-dressed Thai man approached, spoke excellent English, and offered to show you a 'lesser-known temple even more beautiful, just 10 minutes away.' He helped you get a tuk-tuk and everything felt legitimate until you were firmly in a tailor shop on Charoen Krung Road, the driver outside waiting for his commission. The man mentioned his cousin had just opened the shop. This soft-sell approach — a friendly local, genuine conversation, then a gentle redirect to a commercial venue — is described in [r/bangkok](#) as the most...

■ Red Flags

- An exceptionally friendly stranger volunteers to guide you and speaks perfect English
- They have a reason why your planned destination won't work right now
- They suggest a tuk-tuk or vehicle and seem to already know the driver
- Conversation eventually steers toward tailors, gems, or 'authentic' silk stores
- They claim a lucky or rare event is happening 'just today'

■ How to Avoid

- Be politely cautious of unsolicited help near major Bangkok temples
 - If someone says your temple destination is closed, verify on Google Maps yourself
 - Engage in conversation freely but decline any offer to guide or transport you
 - Buy tailored suits or silk only from verified shops (ask your hotel for recommendations)
 - Genuine locals who approach tourists near temples are rare — most are working on commission
-

Jet Ski Damage Scam

When you returned it, the operator pointed to a deep scratch on the underside that definitely wasn't there when you took it — or at least, you didn't remember it. He called over friends and eventually a 'police officer' arrived who sided with the operator. The 'damage' would cost 20,000 baht to repair. Your wallet had 8,000 baht and you handed it all over just to leave. This scam is so documented in [r/solotravel](#) and [r/travel](#) that it has its own Wikipedia reference, and the UK, Australian, and US government travel advisories all specifically warn about it.

■ Red Flags

- Jet ski operator does not do a documented pre-rental inspection with photos
- Damage is pointed out on the underside or a hidden area you couldn't have seen during use
- A 'police officer' appears and immediately supports the operator's claim
- Demands are cash-only with no receipt for the payment
- Operator's friends appear and surround you quickly after you return the equipment

■ How to Avoid

- Take your own dated photos and video of the entire jet ski before leaving the shore
 - Insist on a written rental agreement that includes a pre-rental damage assessment
 - Avoid jet ski rentals from unregulated beach operators — use resort or hotel-vetted vendors
 - Pay with a credit card if possible so you have a payment dispute option
 - If targeted, call the tourist police (1155) rather than paying — the scam often collapses
-

Fake Monk Seeking Donations

Near Chatuchak Weekend Market, a man in saffron robes approached and placed a small amulet in your hands, then opened a donation book filled with names and amounts — €20, €50, written alongside international visitors' names and countries. He smiled and pointed to Thailand and the word 'temple.' You gave €15 and felt good about it. Back at your hotel, a quick search revealed real Buddhist monks do not solicit donations from tourists on the street — this is explicitly against Theravada Buddhist practice. Reddit's [r/bangkok](#) confirms this is a widespread impersonation scam, with the robes and s...

■ Red Flags

- A robed figure approaches you proactively and initiates physical contact
- They place an amulet or bracelet in your hands before any discussion
- A donation book with specific amounts is shown — social proof pressure
- They operate in commercial tourist areas, not near actual temples
- Genuine monks who speak to tourists do so at temples and do not solicit cash

■ How to Avoid

- Know that real Theravada Buddhist monks do not approach tourists for donations
 - If you want to make a genuine temple offering, do so inside a real wat (temple)
 - Return any amulet or object placed in your hands and walk away
 - Legitimate alms-giving involves monks' morning walks (tak bat) — a public ritual, not targeted solicitation
 - Donating to registered temples directly is always the right channel
-

The Grand Palace 'Closed Today' Redirect

You approach the Grand Palace and a well-dressed man with a laminated badge tells you the palace is closed today for a royal ceremony. He says it will reopen tomorrow and offers to take you to a beautiful temple nearby that most tourists miss. His tuk-tuk is conveniently parked around the corner. This is the setup for the classic Bangkok gem-store-and-tailor circuit: the driver takes you to a series of shops, earning 50 to 200 baht per stop plus commission on purchases. The 'closed' story is fabricated. The Grand Palace is rarely closed, and the official website lists actual closure dates i...

■ Red Flags

- Someone outside the Grand Palace tells you it is closed for a ceremony, holiday, or maintenance
- The person has a laminated badge or official-looking vest but is not standing at the actual ticket counter
- They suggest alternative temples or sights and a tuk-tuk or taxi conveniently appears
- The suggested alternative involves stops at a gem store, tailor, or souvenir shop
- They are unusually friendly and insistent that you must go right now before the alternative also closes

■ How to Avoid

- Walk past anyone telling you the Grand Palace is closed and go directly to the official ticket counter to check for yourself
 - Check the Grand Palace website or Google 'Grand Palace Bangkok open today' before visiting to confirm operating hours
 - Never accept transport from someone who approaches you outside an attraction; use Grab or flag your own taxi
 - The Grand Palace is open daily from 8:30 to 15:30 except on rare official royal ceremonies that are announced weeks in advance
 - If you want a tuk-tuk ride, agree on a destination and price first and say 'no stops' firmly before getting in
-

The Khao San Road Padded Bill

The menu shows beer at 80 baht and pad thai at 100 baht. When the bill arrives, it totals 1,200 baht for what should have been 500. Extra items you never ordered appear on the receipt: a cover charge, a service fee, an extra beer, and a mystery dish. The waiter points to tiny print at the bottom of the menu mentioning a per-person sitting charge. When you dispute it, the staff become hostile. Bangkok travel blogs and Reddit's r/thailand report this bill-padding pattern specifically on Khao San Road, where the high turnover of tourists means restaurants face little accountability.

■ Red Flags

- The bill is significantly higher than what you calculated from the menu prices
- Items you did not order appear on the receipt, such as cover charges or extra dishes
- The menu has tiny print at the bottom listing surcharges that were not mentioned by staff
- Staff become aggressive or threaten to call police when you question the total
- The restaurant has no Google reviews or has reviews mentioning overcharging

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph the menu when you sit down so you have proof of the listed prices if a dispute arises
 - Ask the waiter explicitly if there are any cover charges, service fees, or minimum spends before ordering
 - Request an itemized bill and check it line by line before paying, asking for clarification on any unfamiliar charges
 - Choose restaurants on Khao San Road with high Google Maps ratings and recent reviews mentioning fair pricing
 - If the bill includes charges you did not agree to, politely refuse to pay for those items and offer to pay only for what you ordered
-

The Dating App Bar Trap

The bar seems trendy and the conversation flows. Your date orders several cocktails and shots. After an hour, the bill arrives: 15,000 to 40,000 baht. The cocktails were priced at 1,500 baht each, but you never saw a menu. Your date vanishes to the bathroom and does not return. A bouncer blocks the door and insists you pay in full. This scam is well-documented on Reddit's r/thailand as the 'Tinder bar scam' and It's Better In Thailand's 2025 scam guide lists it as one of the most common scams targeting male tourists in Bangkok.

■ Red Flags

- Your Tinder or Bumble match suggests a specific bar or club rather than letting you choose the venue

- The bar has no visible menu with prices displayed
- Your date orders expensive drinks rapidly without discussing what they cost
- The bar has a bouncer at the door and no street-level windows
- Your date excuses themselves to the bathroom after the bill arrives and does not return

■ How to Avoid

- Always choose the meeting venue yourself and pick a well-reviewed public restaurant or rooftop bar rather than one suggested by your match
- Verify that the bar has Google Maps reviews from other tourists before going inside
- Ask for a menu with prices before ordering anything and set a spending limit for the evening
- If your date insists on a specific bar and will not meet elsewhere, that is a strong signal to cancel the date
- If confronted with an outrageous bill, call the Tourist Police hotline at 1155 rather than paying under duress

Fake Thailand Arrival Card Websites

■ ■ Online — targeting travelers before arrival, with Google search ads appearing above official results Before your flight to Bangkok, you Google 'Thailand arrival card' or 'Thailand TM6 form' to prepare your paperwork. The top search results include slick websites that look like official Thai government portals, complete with government-style logos and professional design. Reddit users on r/Bangkok document this in a comprehensive thread titled '30 real scams happening in Thailand right now,' noting these sites charge 500-2,000 THB for what is actually a free government form. Some of these sites harvest your passport details and personal information for identity theft. The official Thai immigration arrival process has been digitalized and no longer requires the physical TM6 form for most travelers arriving by air since 2024. Scam websites exploit confusion about whether the form is still required and what the current digital process looks like. The legitimate process is handled at immigration counters at Suvarnabhumi or Don Mueang airports at no charge. Red Flags A website charges any fee to fill out or submit a Thailand arrival card or immigration form The website URL does not end in .go.th — the official Thai government domain The site requests your credit card information or full passport scan to process a 'pre-arrival registration' Google search ads promote the site above the actual Thai Immigration Bureau website The site creates urgency by claiming your entry will be denied without pre-registration How to Avoid The TM6 arrival card has been eliminated for air travelers since 2024 — you do not need to fill out any form before arrival for most nationalities If any form is required, it will be provided free of charge on the aircraft or at the immigration counter at the airport Only use the official Thai Immigration Bureau website at immigration.go.th for any pre-arrival requirements Never enter passport details or credit card information on any non-.go.th website claiming to process Thai immigration forms Report fraudulent immigration websites to the Thai Cyber Crime Division at 1441 ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Tourist Police station. Call 1155 (Tourist Police) or 191 (General Police). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at touristpolice.go.th. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Bangkok is at 95 Wireless Road, Pathumwan, Bangkok 10330. For emergencies: +66 2-205-4000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. Frequently Asked Questions Is Bangkok safe for tourists? ▼

The top search results include slick websites that look like official Thai government portals, complete with government-style logos and professional design. Reddit users on r/Bangkok document this in a comprehensive thread titled '30 real scams happening in Thailand right now,' noting these sites charge 500-2,000 THB for what is actually a free government form. Some of these sites harvest your passport details and personal information for identity theft. The official Thai immigration arrival process has been digitalized and no longer requires the physical TM6 form for most travelers arrivin...

■ Red Flags

- A website charges any fee to fill out or submit a Thailand arrival card or immigration form
- The website URL does not end in .go.th — the official Thai government domain
- The site requests your credit card information or full passport scan to process a 'pre-arrival registration'
- Google search ads promote the site above the actual Thai Immigration Bureau website
- The site creates urgency by claiming your entry will be denied without pre-registration

■ How to Avoid

- The TM6 arrival card has been eliminated for air travelers since 2024 — you do not need to fill out any form before arrival for most nationalities
 - If any form is required, it will be provided free of charge on the aircraft or at the immigration counter at the airport
 - Only use the official Thai Immigration Bureau website at immigration.go.th for any pre-arrival requirements
 - Never enter passport details or credit card information on any non-.go.th website claiming to process Thai immigration forms
 - Report fraudulent immigration websites to the Thai Cyber Crime Division at 1441
-

■■ Chiang Mai

8 scams documented • Thailand

Tuk-Tuk Gem Shop Tour

You're standing near Tha Phae Gate, camera out, admiring the ancient moat, when a cheerful tuk-tuk driver pulls up and tells you the Grand Temple you were heading to is 'closed for cleaning' until 3 PM — but lucky you, he knows a special temple that only locals visit, and since he's waiting anyway, he'll take you for just 20 baht. You hesitate, but the story is convincing and the price is absurd. You climb in. The temple turns out to be lovely, but after five minutes your driver says his 'cousin' runs a gem shop just nearby and since he gets fuel credit for bringing tourists, it costs you n...

■ Red Flags

- Driver volunteers that your destination temple is 'closed' or 'has a special ceremony' today
- Offer of an unusually cheap or free tuk-tuk ride anywhere near tourist temples
- Driver steers conversation toward gems, jade, or 'Thai rubies' being exceptional investment value
- Shop staff produce official-looking certificates and claim gems resell for 3x price abroad
- Polished sales pitch with cold drinks in a suspiciously nice shop near an otherwise humble area

■ How to Avoid

- Verify temple hours yourself on Google Maps before asking any tuk-tuk driver
 - Never accept a 'free' or heavily discounted tuk-tuk ride that involves a stop at any shop
 - If you want gems, buy from reputable shops on Wualai Road (Silver Street) during the Saturday Walking Street
 - Use Grab or a metered taxi for transport — the app prevents mid-ride detours
 - Simply say 'no thank you' firmly and walk away — the 'closed temple' story collapses under 10 seconds of pushback
-

Tailor Shop Bait-and-Switch

Walking through the Night Bazaar area near Chang Klan Road, you're approached by a well-dressed man holding fabric swatches who says a friend of his just picked up a suit here and it came out beautifully. He walks you to a shop two streets over where the tailor is perfectly pleasant, takes your measurements and quotes you 2,500 baht for a custom suit. You're delighted — you pay a deposit and come back the next morning for a fitting. The suit looks reasonable but not perfect. The tailor says it needs one more day. When you collect it on day three, the stitching looks rushed, the lining is po...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you near a tourist area and specifically recommends a tailor shop
- Another 'tourist' inside the shop is already enthusiastically buying — they may be a planted shill
- Quote is dramatically below market (under 3,000 baht for a full suit)
- Tailor asks for full payment upfront rather than a deposit

- Delivery keeps being delayed by one day, making it difficult to reject before you leave town

■ How to Avoid

- Find tailors through hotel recommendations or TripAdvisor reviews rather than street touts
 - Never follow strangers to any shop — go independently and compare two or three quotes
 - Pay by credit card in stages: deposit only, balance on satisfactory delivery
 - Inspect the fabric label and lining material at the time of ordering — request the actual bolt of fabric be shown
 - Build in at least three extra days after your collection date so you can request corrections or dispute quality
-

Fake Monk Donation Request

You're climbing the 309-step naga staircase to Wat Doi Suthep when a man in saffron robes stops you near the top and presents a laminated card showing a temple building project. He speaks limited English but mimes writing in his book and hands you a pen. The book already has several names with donation amounts ranging from 500 to 2,000 baht — the social pressure to match these figures is deliberate. He blesses your journey and seems entirely genuine, so you hand over 500 baht. Real Buddhist monks in Thailand do not solicit cash donations from tourists on temple steps or public streets. Genu...

■ Red Flags

- A 'monk' actively approaches you or blocks your path rather than walking with eyes downcast
- Laminated donation card or English-language sign board showing a construction project
- Pre-filled donation book with large amounts to create social pressure
- Location is a tourist thoroughfare rather than inside an actual temple grounds
- The robes look new and bright orange-yellow rather than the faded saffron of practiced monks

■ How to Avoid

- Know that real Thai monks do not solicit cash from tourists — decline politely and walk past
 - If you want to make a temple donation, do so inside the temple's official donation box
 - Take the official red songthaew (shared truck taxi) up Doi Suthep road rather than walking the open road
 - Visit temples with a licensed guide who can identify legitimate versus fake religious figures
 - A respectful 'wai' gesture (palms together, slight bow) and continuing to walk is culturally appropriate
-

Elephant Sanctuary Fake-Out

You search online and find a place called something like 'Green Valley Elephant Sanctuary' or 'Hilltribe Elephant Care' with a nicely designed website, photos of happy elephants bathing in rivers, and reviews on Klook or a booking website. You pay 2,500 baht for a half-day. At the 'sanctuary,' you're given a mahout uniform, fed an elephant sugar cane, and posed for photos. It feels real. But behind the scenes the elephants are chained overnight, the rescue story is fabricated, and the same animals do 5–6 tours per day. Chiang Mai has approximately 20 truly ethical elephant facilities and do...

■ Red Flags

- Website or booking page uses the word 'sanctuary' without any verifiable rescue documentation
- Program allows elephant riding or elephant painting — real sanctuaries do not permit these
- Price is suspiciously low (under 1,200 baht) for a full-day 'sanctuary' experience
- Booking agent on Khao San Road or your guesthouse gets a commission for recommending it
- No mention of where the elephants came from or their rescue/retirement history

■ How to Avoid

- Book directly with Elephant Nature Park (ENP) or Elephant Valley Thailand — these have documented ethical practices

- Verify the operator on World Animal Protection's elephant-friendly venue list before booking
 - Reject any experience that includes riding, circus tricks, or painting — these require training methods harmful to elephants
 - Read recent reviews on TripAdvisor that specifically mention elephant behavior and conditions, not just photos
 - Ask the operator directly: 'Can we see where the elephants sleep and what the daily program looks like?' Fake sanctuaries avoid this question
-

Songthaew Fixed Price Dispute

you flag one down, tell the driver where you're going, and agree on a price. The standard rate within the city is 30–50 baht per person. But the driver you've flagged near the Night Bazaar quotes you 200 baht for what Google Maps shows is a 10-minute ride. You negotiate down to 100 and feel like you won. Later you discover locals pay 40 baht for the same route because they share the truck with strangers. You paid the 'private charter' price without knowing it. The songthaew price dispute isn't a sharp scam like the gem shop — it's a slow bleed that adds up. The confusion arises because the ...

■ Red Flags

- Driver quotes a price significantly above 50 baht for any in-city route
- Driver refuses to share the vehicle with other passengers heading the same direction
- Driver asks for payment upfront before the journey begins
- Vehicle is stationed directly outside a tourist hotel or major attraction rather than circulating
- Driver claims the metered rate doesn't apply because it's a 'special time' or 'holiday'

■ How to Avoid

- Use the Grab app for transparent pricing — it shows the route and fare before you confirm
 - Know the standard songthaew rate: 30–50 baht per person shared within city limits
 - Agree on the total fare AND confirm whether it's shared or private before getting in
 - Walk half a block away from major tourist attractions to flag down a circulating songthaew at local rates
 - If overcharged, note the truck's license plate and report to TAT (Tourism Authority of Thailand) at 1672
-

Sip-and-Tour Bar Commission Setup

locally called Nimman — when a friendly local guy, roughly your age, falls into step with you and starts recommending bars. He's charming, speaks great English, and seems genuinely helpful. After a drink somewhere that turns out to be mediocre, he suggests a place he knows 'where the real Chiang Mai people go.' Inside, the prices are triple what you'd expect, there's a cover charge you weren't told about, and the cocktails taste watered down. You spend 1,500 baht for a night you could have had for 400. This version of the commission bar scam is less aggressive than Bangkok's but follows the...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger who isn't working somewhere actively offers to take you to a better bar or rooftop
- New venue doesn't have prices visible outside or at the entrance
- Minimum spend per person is announced only after you're seated
- Drinks arrive faster than ordered and the bill accumulates quickly
- Your new 'friend' excuses himself shortly after you're settled in the bar

■ How to Avoid

- Choose bars independently — check Google Maps reviews and confirm prices are posted outside before entering
- Ask 'is there a cover charge or minimum spend?' before sitting down anywhere unfamiliar
- When exploring Nimman at night, stick to the main sois (1, 7, 9, 13) where competition keeps prices honest
- If a bar seems overpriced, ask for the bill immediately and leave — you're not obligated to stay

- Travel with other people at night — commission touts specifically target solo travelers who are easier to guide
-

Trekking Tour Bait-and-Switch

You've booked a 2-day hill tribe trekking tour for 1,800 baht from a guesthouse near Tha Phae Gate that had photos of happy trekkers, lush forests, and an overnight stay in a traditional Karen village. What arrives is a minivan with 14 other tourists, a 45-minute walk through rubber tree plantations, a lunch break at a road-accessible 'village' that gets 20 tour groups per day and sells the same keychains everywhere, and a night in a concrete-floored hut marketed as 'authentic.' The guide doesn't speak the hill tribe's language and knows less about the culture than you researched on Google....

■ Red Flags

- Tour price is dramatically below 1,500 baht for a multi-day trek with accommodation included
- Photos on the booking flyer look professional but the guesthouse can't name the specific villages visited
- Guide speaks Thai and English but not any hill tribe language
- More than 8 people in the group for a 'small group' trek
- Itinerary includes elephant riding or bamboo rafting as the main activities rather than cultural interaction

■ How to Avoid

- Book through established operators like Peak Adventure or Mirror Foundation who have documented community relationships
 - Ask specifically which villages are visited by name — legitimate operators know and can describe the specific communities
 - Request a maximum group size of 6-8 in writing before paying any deposit
 - Read recent (2023–2024) TripAdvisor reviews that mention the guide's name and specific village interactions
 - Consider independent transport to Chiang Dao and arrange treks through the local community center rather than city booking desks
-

The Karaoke Bar Extortion

■ ■ Bars off Loi Kroh Road, near Zoe in Yellow (Old Town), Chang Klan area A tuk-tuk driver or friendly local invites you to a 'fun karaoke bar' where the first drink is cheap or free. Once inside, hostesses appear and order expensive bottles on your tab without your consent. When the bill arrives, it is 23,000-50,000 THB for what you thought was a casual night out. If you refuse to pay, security blocks the exit and threatens violence. One Reddit user on r/ThailandTourism reported paying 23,000 THB after a seemingly normal Friday night near Zoe in Yellow in the old town. The bar has operated under names including 67 Bar, Snow White Karaoke, and Diamond Karaoke, repeatedly reopening after police raids. Red Flags A tuk-tuk driver recommends a specific bar unprompted Hostesses sit with you and order drinks without asking what you want There is no printed menu or the prices are hidden Security guards stand near the door watching customers The venue name changes frequently or has no visible signage How to Avoid Never follow a tuk-tuk driver's bar recommendations -- they earn commission Stick to well-reviewed bars in the Nimmanhaemin or Old City areas If hostesses arrive uninvited, leave immediately before any drinks are ordered Always check prices on a physical menu before ordering anything If threatened, call the Tourist Police hotline at 1155 immediately ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Tourist Police station. Call 1155 (Tourist Police) or 191 (General Police). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at touristpolice.go.th. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Bangkok is at 95 Wireless Road, Pathumwan, Bangkok 10330. For emergencies: +66 2-205-4000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Thailand ■ ■

Once inside, hostesses appear and order expensive bottles on your tab without your consent. When the bill arrives, it is 23,000-50,000 THB for what you thought was a casual night out. If you refuse to pay, security blocks the exit and threatens violence. One Reddit user on r/ThailandTourism reported paying 23,000 THB after a seemingly normal Friday night near Zoe in Yellow in the old town. The bar has operated under names

including 67 Bar, Snow White Karaoke, and Diamond Karaoke, repeatedly reopening after police raids.

■ Red Flags

- A tuk-tuk driver recommends a specific bar unprompted
- Hostesses sit with you and order drinks without asking what you want
- There is no printed menu or the prices are hidden
- Security guards stand near the door watching customers
- The venue name changes frequently or has no visible signage

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow a tuk-tuk driver's bar recommendations -- they earn commission
 - Stick to well-reviewed bars in the Nimmanhaemin or Old City areas
 - If hostesses arrive uninvited, leave immediately before any drinks are ordered
 - Always check prices on a physical menu before ordering anything
 - If threatened, call the Tourist Police hotline at 1155 immediately
-

■■ Chiang Rai

3 scams documented • Thailand

The White Temple Photo Fee Scam

You've just explored Wat Rong Khun -- Chiang Rai's stunning White Temple -- and you're admiring the ornate facade when a man with a professional camera offers to take your photo for 'free.' He positions you against the best backdrop, snaps several shots, then prints one instantly from a portable printer. Before you can react, he hands you the glossy print and demands 200-500 baht. When you try to decline, he loudly shames you in front of other tourists for 'wasting his ink and paper.' The tactic works because tourists feel embarrassed and pay up. The same operators work near the Blue Temple...

■ Red Flags

- Photographer offers free photos at a tourist landmark
- Photo is printed before you agree to pay
- Aggressive reaction when you decline to purchase
- Politely decline unsolicited photo offers
- Take your own photos — the temple is photogenic from every angle

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline unsolicited photo offers
 - Take your own photos — the temple is photogenic from every angle
 - If you want a professional photo, agree on the price before posing
-

The Golden Triangle Border Crossing Scam

A tour operator approaches offering a boat trip to the Laos side -- 'quick passport stamp and duty-free shopping, only 500 baht.' On the boat, he reveals an additional 300-baht 'Lao immigration fee' that doesn't exist. Once across, you're deposited at a tourist trap casino complex and commission shops selling overpriced goods. The operator claims the return boat leaves in two hours, trapping you in the shops. Legitimate Golden Triangle boat trips from the official pier cost 300 baht round-trip with no hidden fees.

■ Red Flags

- Tour offers border crossing at prices above the official visa fee

- Includes mandatory shopping stops
- Trip to the Myanmar side specifically
- Skip the border crossing unless you genuinely need to visit Laos
- The Golden Triangle viewpoint itself is free and worth visiting

■ How to Avoid

- Skip the border crossing unless you genuinely need to visit Laos
 - The Golden Triangle viewpoint itself is free and worth visiting
 - If crossing to Laos, the official visa-on-arrival is \$30-50 depending on nationality
-

The Night Market Tuk-Tuk Overcharge

■ ■ *Night Bazaar area, Clock Tower, bus station arrivals* You arrive at Chiang Rai's bus station after the scenic ride from Chiang Mai. Tuk-tuk drivers swarm the exit quoting 200 baht for the three-kilometer ride to your guesthouse near the Clock Tower. The actual going rate is 60-80 baht, or about 50 baht by songthaew. The same inflation happens at the Night Bazaar after dark, when drivers assume tourists won't walk. Unlike Chiang Mai, Chiang Rai has no Grab service in most areas, giving drivers more leverage. *Red Flags* Driver quotes over 100 baht for any in-town destination Multiple drivers echo the same inflated price as if it's fixed Driver claims Grab doesn't work in Chiang Rai Price suddenly increases at night or in the rain *How to Avoid* Walk to the main road and flag a passing songthaew for 40-60 baht Rent a bicycle or motorbike -- Chiang Rai's center is compact and flat Ask your guesthouse to arrange pickup before arrival Standard tuk-tuk rate within Chiang Rai town is 60-80 baht per person ■ *What to Do If You Get Scammed* ■ *File a Police Report* Go to the nearest Tourist Police station. Call 1155 (Tourist Police) or 191 (General Police). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at touristpolice.go.th. ■ *Cancel Your Cards* Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ *Lost Passport?* Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Bangkok is at 95 Wireless Road, Pathumwan, Bangkok 10330. For emergencies: +66 2-205-4000. ■ *Track Your Device* If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. *More Scam Guides More in Thailand* ■ ■

Tuk-tuk drivers swarm the exit quoting 200 baht for the three-kilometer ride to your guesthouse near the Clock Tower. The actual going rate is 60-80 baht, or about 50 baht by songthaew. The same inflation happens at the Night Bazaar after dark, when drivers assume tourists won't walk. Unlike Chiang Mai, Chiang Rai has no Grab service in most areas, giving drivers more leverage.

■ Red Flags

- Driver quotes over 100 baht for any in-town destination
- Multiple drivers echo the same inflated price as if it's fixed
- Driver claims Grab doesn't work in Chiang Rai
- Price suddenly increases at night or in the rain
- Walk to the main road and flag a passing songthaew for 40-60 baht

■ How to Avoid

- Walk to the main road and flag a passing songthaew for 40-60 baht
 - Rent a bicycle or motorbike -- Chiang Rai's center is compact and flat
 - Ask your guesthouse to arrange pickup before arrival
 - Standard tuk-tuk rate within Chiang Rai town is 60-80 baht per person
-

■ ■ Koh Phangan

6 scams documented • Thailand

The Full Moon Party Overpriced Everything

Bucket drinks that cost 150 baht elsewhere are 350+ baht. Beach bars charge 200 baht cover. Taxis back to your hotel go from 100 to 500 baht. Accommodation near Haad Rin triples in price. Everything inflates 2-5x during the party — and there's no alternative because you're on an island.

■ Red Flags

- Prices significantly higher than any other night
- Accommodation near Haad Rin quadruples around full moon dates
- Taxi drivers refuse to use normal rates
- Book accommodation weeks in advance — prices triple last-minute
- Pre-buy bucket drinks at 7-Eleven and bring them in (allowed)

■ How to Avoid

- Book accommodation weeks in advance — prices triple last-minute
 - Pre-buy bucket drinks at 7-Eleven and bring them in (allowed)
 - Stay in Thong Sala or Baan Tai and arrange transport in advance
 - Budget 2-3x your normal daily spend for the Full Moon Party night
-

The Scooter Rental Passport Hostage

When you return the bike, the shop 'finds' damage and demands 5,000-15,000 baht. If you refuse, they keep your passport. Without your passport, you can't leave the island, check into hotels, or board flights. You're effectively held hostage until you pay.

■ Red Flags

- Shop demands your actual passport (not a copy)
- No pre-ride condition documentation
- Bike has suspiciously placed tape or stickers
- NEVER leave your passport — offer cash deposit (2,000-3,000 baht) or a photocopy
- Photograph and video the entire bike before riding

■ How to Avoid

- NEVER leave your passport — offer cash deposit (2,000-3,000 baht) or a photocopy
 - Photograph and video the entire bike before riding
 - Rent from your hotel or well-reviewed shops
 - If they won't accept anything except your passport, find another shop
-

The Bucket Drink Spike

The neon-colored mix tastes sweet and strong, but halfway through you feel far more disoriented than alcohol alone would cause. Someone steadies you and offers to help you back to your hostel. You wake up the next morning with your phone, wallet, and bag gone. Drink spiking at the Full Moon Party is extensively documented on [r/thailand](#) and [r/solotravel](#), with travelers reporting that budget bucket stalls use cheap spirits mixed with unknown substances. Some victims report memory blackouts lasting hours.

■ Red Flags

- Bucket cocktails at suspiciously low prices from unlicensed stalls
- The drink tastes unusually sweet, masking what is mixed in
- You feel severely disoriented after only one or two drinks
- A stranger offers unsolicited help when you appear incapacitated
- Your friends notice you becoming incoherent faster than expected

■ How to Avoid

- Buy drinks only from established bars and watch them being prepared
 - Never leave your drink unattended, even for a moment
 - Stick with bottled beer or canned drinks you open yourself
 - Go with friends and agree to watch each other throughout the night
 - If you feel unexpectedly disoriented, tell your friends immediately and move to a safe area
-

The After-Party Taxi Hostage

Songthaews that cost 100 baht per person on the way there now demand 300 to 500 baht each. You are exhausted, possibly intoxicated, and stranded with thousands of other partygoers all competing for the same few vehicles. Some drivers refuse to leave until the truck is crammed beyond safe capacity. Others quote one price, then demand more when you arrive, knowing you are too tired to argue.

■ Red Flags

- Drivers quoting 3-5 times the normal fare after midnight
- Vehicle is dangerously overcrowded with no seatbelts or safety features
- Driver demands additional payment upon arrival that was not agreed
- No other transport options appear available, creating artificial urgency
- Driver refuses to move until every seat and standing space is filled

■ How to Avoid

- Book accommodation within walking distance of Haad Rin for Full Moon Party nights
 - Arrange return transport with your hotel or hostel before the party
 - Agree firmly on the fare before getting in and have exact change ready
 - Wait 30-60 minutes after the party ends for prices to normalize as more trucks arrive
 - Share a ride with a group to split costs and improve safety
-

The Bungalow Deposit Theft

The owner demands a 2,000 to 5,000 baht cash deposit for the key. When you check out, they claim the room has damage -- a stain on the mattress, a broken tile, a missing towel. The damage was there when you arrived, but you did not photograph it. The deposit is not returned. Some budget accommodations around Koh Phangan inflate prices by 300-500% during Full Moon Party week and then keep deposits as additional profit, knowing guests are transient backpackers who will not return to dispute.

■ Red Flags

- Large cash deposit demanded at check-in without written receipt
- Room shows signs of wear that could later be attributed to you
- Owner does not do a walk-through inspection at check-in
- Accommodation has poor or nonexistent online reviews
- Prices spike dramatically compared to non-party weeks

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph and video every surface of the room at check-in and share with the owner
 - Get a written receipt for any deposit paid, with room condition noted
 - Book through platforms like Booking.com or Agoda that offer dispute resolution
 - Read recent reviews specifically mentioning deposit disputes
 - Consider paying slightly more for established hostels with professional management
-

The Songthaew Fixed-Route Extortion

■ ■ **Thongsala Pier, routes to Haad Rin, Retro Mountain area** You arrive at Thongsala Pier and need to get to your hotel on the west coast. The songthaew drivers quote 300 baht per person for a fifteen-minute ride that should cost 100-150 baht. When you try to negotiate, every driver quotes the same inflated price — because the taxi association operates as a cartel that sets uniform rates. Koh Phangan island officials launched a taxi fare complaints help desk in Thongsala specifically to address this problem. A Reddit user on r/ThailandTourism described being charged triple the fair rate at the Retro Mountain Jungle Club area with no alternative transport available. **Red Flags** Every driver at the pier quotes the exact same inflated price Drivers refuse to negotiate even slightly on the fare Grab and Bolt ride-hailing apps do not work or show no available drivers on the island The quoted price for a short ride exceeds 200 baht per person Drivers become aggressive if you try to walk away or find alternative transport **How to Avoid** Rent a motorbike from a reputable shop — the island is small and roads are manageable Ask your hotel to arrange airport or pier pickup before arrival — many offer free transfers Use the official complaint desk at Thongsala pier if prices seem extortionate Share rides with other travelers arriving on the same ferry to split costs Walk to the main road from Thongsala pier — prices drop significantly away from the pier ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Tourist Police station. Call 1155 (Tourist Police) or 191 (General Police). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at touristpolice.go.th. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Bangkok is at 95 Wireless Road, Pathumwan, Bangkok 10330. For emergencies: +66 2-205-4000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in Thailand** ■ ■

The songthaew drivers quote 300 baht per person for a fifteen-minute ride that should cost 100-150 baht. When you try to negotiate, every driver quotes the same inflated price — because the taxi association operates as a cartel that sets uniform rates. Koh Phangan island officials launched a taxi fare complaints help desk in Thongsala specifically to address this problem. A Reddit user on r/ThailandTourism described being charged triple the fair rate at the Retro Mountain Jungle Club area with no alternative transport available.

■ Red Flags

- Every driver at the pier quotes the exact same inflated price
- Drivers refuse to negotiate even slightly on the fare
- Grab and Bolt ride-hailing apps do not work or show no available drivers on the island
- The quoted price for a short ride exceeds 200 baht per person
- Drivers become aggressive if you try to walk away or find alternative transport

■ How to Avoid

- Rent a motorbike from a reputable shop — the island is small and roads are manageable
- Ask your hotel to arrange airport or pier pickup before arrival — many offer free transfers
- Use the official complaint desk at Thongsala pier if prices seem extortionate
- Share rides with other travelers arriving on the same ferry to split costs
- Walk to the main road from Thongsala pier — prices drop significantly away from the pier

■ ■ Koh Samui

7 scams documented • Thailand

The Jet Ski Damage Shakedown

When you bring it back, the operator suddenly finds a crack on the hull and claims you caused it. His 'friend' shows up with a repair estimate: 30,000-50,000 baht (\$800-1,400). If you argue, bigger friends appear. The damage was there before you got on. This is Thailand's most documented tourist scam, and Koh Samui is ground zero.

■ Red Flags

- Damage 'discovered' only after you return the jet ski
- No pre-ride inspection offered or documented
- Intimidating men appear during the dispute
- Cash demanded immediately with no official repair quote
- Video-record the jet ski from every angle before and after — in front of the operator

■ How to Avoid

- Video-record the jet ski from every angle before and after — in front of the operator
 - Avoid jet skis on Chaweng and Lamai Beach entirely
 - If confronted, call the Tourist Police at 1155 — they handle this daily
 - Do not pay cash under pressure — insist on a police report
-

The Timeshare Presentation Trap

A friendly 'travel agent' approaches you on the street or at your hotel offering a free spa treatment, dinner, or island tour — all you need to do is attend a '90-minute presentation.' The presentation lasts 4+ hours, involves aggressive hard-sell tactics for timeshare or vacation club memberships costing \$10,000-50,000. Saying no requires extreme persistence.

■ Red Flags

- Free gifts or activities in exchange for 'just listening'
- Presentation is always much longer than advertised
- High-pressure sales with limited-time discounts
- Won't take no for an answer easily
- Never accept free activities conditional on attending a presentation

■ How to Avoid

- Never accept free activities conditional on attending a presentation
 - If you accidentally agree, you can leave at any time — just stand up and go
 - No legitimate vacation deal requires a same-day decision
 - The 'discounts' are fake — the regular price doesn't exist
-

The Full Moon Party Drink Spike

But some vendors add extra methanol-laced alcohol or even mild sedatives to make the party 'wilder.' Tourists wake up robbed, injured, or in the hospital. In 2023, several tourists died from methanol poisoning in Thai beach party drinks.

■ Red Flags

- Unusually cheap bucket drinks from unlicensed vendors
- Drink tastes medicinal or unusually strong
- You feel significantly more intoxicated than expected
- Vendor mixes drinks out of sight
- Buy drinks only from established bars, not random beach vendors

■ How to Avoid

- Buy drinks only from established bars, not random beach vendors
 - Watch your drink being made
 - Stick to beer or sealed bottles if you're unsure
 - Never leave your drink unattended
 - Travel with friends and agree on a buddy system
-

The Motorbike Rental Damage Claim

When you return it, the owner circles the bike pointing out scratches and a cracked mirror that were there before you took it. He demands 5,000 to 15,000 baht for repairs. You did not photograph the bike at pickup. If you refuse to pay, he threatens to call the police or keep your passport, which he required as a deposit. This is one of the most frequently reported scams on r/ThailandTourism for Koh Samui. The pre-existing damage is the business model -- the rental fee is almost irrelevant.

■ Red Flags

- Rental shop asks for your passport as deposit instead of a cash deposit
- No written rental agreement documenting existing damage
- Bike already has visible scratches, dents, or worn parts at pickup
- Owner becomes confrontational and threatens police involvement
- Repair costs quoted are far above actual market rates

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph and video every angle of the bike before riding away, including close-ups of any scratches
 - Never leave your passport as deposit -- leave a cash deposit or a photocopy instead
 - Rent from shops recommended by your hotel with established reputations
 - Get a written agreement listing all pre-existing damage before signing
 - If disputes arise, contact the Tourist Police (1155) rather than paying under duress
-

The Taxi Cartel No-Meter Overcharge

Every driver quotes 500 to 700 baht for the short ride to Chaweng, roughly 10 minutes away. No one will use a meter. The drivers operate as an informal cartel at the airport and ferry terminal, maintaining uniformly high prices because there is no competition. Ride-hailing apps like Grab have limited availability on the island due to resistance from local taxi operators. Reddit users on r/ThailandTourism describe this as one of the most frustrating aspects of Koh Samui travel.

■ Red Flags

- All drivers at the airport or ferry terminal quote identical inflated fares
- No driver will agree to use a meter
- Grab or Bolt apps show no available drivers in the area
- Driver quotes fare in a foreign currency rather than Thai baht
- Additional passengers are picked up along the way without reducing your fare

■ How to Avoid

- Arrange airport pickup through your hotel before arrival -- many include transfers
 - Walk a few minutes outside the airport taxi stand area to find cheaper songthaews
 - Share rides with other travelers heading to the same area
 - Download the Loca app, which works better than Grab on Koh Samui
 - Budget 500 baht for the airport-to-Chaweng transfer and factor it into trip costs
-

The Rental Car Phantom Damage Charge

When you return it, the owner inspects it with a flashlight and claims to find scratches or a 'smell of smoke' that was not there before. A Reddit user documented being charged 3,000 baht by 'All Way Rent a Car' for alleged smoking in the vehicle despite never smoking. The charges are applied to the credit card you left on file, and disputing them locally is near impossible since the rental contract was written in Thai with vague damage clauses. Some agencies photograph pre-existing damage after you leave and present it as new.

■ Red Flags

- Rental contract is entirely in Thai with no English translation provided
- Agency does not conduct a thorough inspection with you present at pickup
- No photos or video of the car's condition are taken at the time of rental
- You are asked to leave a blank credit card slip as 'deposit'
- Agency has low Google reviews mentioning damage charges or smoking fees

■ How to Avoid

- Film a complete walk-around video of the car including interior and any existing damage at pickup
- Photograph the odometer, fuel gauge, and any scratches with timestamps
- Rent from international chains or well-reviewed agencies — check Google Maps reviews first
- Never leave a blank signed credit card slip — agree to a specific deposit amount in writing
- If charged unfairly, dispute through your credit card company with your timestamped photos

The Bar Donation Collector

■ ■ *Lamai Beach bars, Chaweng nightlife area* You are drinking at a bar in Lamai when a man appears claiming to collect donations for the local ... You are drinking at a bar in Lamai when a man appears claiming to collect donations for the local temple or a charity helping children. He carries a laminated card and a collection box that looks official. A Reddit user on *r/ThailandTourism* described this exact scenario, questioning whether they had been scammed when a collector appeared in a bar and pressured them for a donation with no verifiable charity credentials. The collectors are not affiliated with any temple or registered charity — the money goes directly into their pockets. Red Flags Collector approaches you inside a bar or restaurant rather than at a temple Laminated card has no official charity registration number or QR code to verify Collector targets only foreign tourists and skips Thai patrons They become insistent or guilt-trip you if you decline Collection box is opaque so you cannot see if anyone else has donated How to Avoid Politely decline — legitimate Thai temple donations happen at the temple itself If you want to donate to local causes, visit the temple directly or use verified platforms Ask to see a registered charity number and verify it online before donating Bar staff can usually confirm whether the collector is legitimate or not A firm 'mai ao krap/ka' (I don't want it) in Thai is effective ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Tourist Police station. Call 1155 (Tourist Police) or 191 (General Police). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at touristpolice.go.th. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Bangkok is at 95 Wireless Road, Pathumwan, Bangkok 10330. For emergencies: +66 2-205-4000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Thailand ■ ■

You are drinking at a bar in Lamai when a man appears claiming to collect donations for the local temple or a charity helping children. He carries a laminated card and a collection box that looks official. A Reddit user on *r/ThailandTourism* described this exact scenario, questioning whether they had been scammed when a collector appeared in a bar and pressured them for a donation with no verifiable charity credentials. The collectors are not affiliated with any temple or registered charity — the money goes directly into their pockets.

■ Red Flags

- Collector approaches you inside a bar or restaurant rather than at a temple
- Laminated card has no official charity registration number or QR code to verify
- Collector targets only foreign tourists and skips Thai patrons
- They become insistent or guilt-trip you if you decline
- Collection box is opaque so you cannot see if anyone else has donated

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline — legitimate Thai temple donations happen at the temple itself
- If you want to donate to local causes, visit the temple directly or use verified platforms
- Ask to see a registered charity number and verify it online before donating

- Bar staff can usually confirm whether the collector is legitimate or not
 - A firm 'mai ao krap/ka' (I don't want it) in Thai is effective
-

■■ Krabi

6 scams documented • Thailand

The Longtail Boat Price Explosion

Great deal! But that's per person, not per boat. And the 'four islands tour' skips two islands because of 'bad weather' (it's sunny). Lunch isn't included despite being promised. The return trip requires an extra payment because it's 'after 4pm.' Your 800 baht day becomes 3,000+ baht.

■ Red Flags

- Price quoted without specifying per-person or per-boat
- Verbal promises without written itinerary
- Stops shortened due to vague 'weather' excuses
- Always confirm: per person or per boat, how many stops, what's included, return time
- Book through your hotel or a verified tour office with printed itinerary

■ How to Avoid

- Always confirm: per person or per boat, how many stops, what's included, return time
 - Book through your hotel or a verified tour office with printed itinerary
 - Pay 50% upfront, 50% upon completing the full itinerary
 - 800-1,200 baht per person for a 4-island tour with lunch is the fair rate from agencies
-

The Fake 'Closed' Attraction

He shakes his head: 'Closed today — special Buddhist holiday.' He offers to take you to a 'better temple' and a gem factory instead. The Tiger Cave Temple is open. This is the same scam that runs in Bangkok — it works because tourists don't think to verify.

■ Red Flags

- Driver claims popular attraction is 'closed today'
- Offers an alternative involving a shop or factory
- Happens near tuk-tuk stands, not at the attraction itself
- Check Google Maps reviews for real-time status before believing a driver
- Call the attraction or check their Facebook page

■ How to Avoid

- Check Google Maps reviews for real-time status before believing a driver
 - Call the attraction or check their Facebook page
 - This scam runs daily across Thailand — the attraction is almost never actually closed
-

The Tour Van to Phuket Hustle

You are told the journey takes three hours. Instead, the agency sends you to a staging area outside town where you wait over an hour for the actual van to arrive. The van then makes multiple stops at commission shops -- a rubber plantation, a cashew factory, a restaurant where everything is overpriced. What should be a three-hour trip becomes six hours. Some travelers report vans that never show up at all, with no refund offered. This scam is extensively documented on Tripadvisor Krabi forums.

■ Red Flags

- Transfer price seems unusually cheap compared to other options
- You are sent to an intermediate meeting point rather than picked up at your hotel
- The van makes multiple unscheduled stops at shops and restaurants
- No refund policy is stated in the booking
- The agency cannot confirm the exact vehicle or driver in advance

■ How to Avoid

- Book transfers through your hotel or through reputable platforms like 12Go Asia
 - Ask explicitly if the transfer is direct with no commission stops
 - Take the public bus from Krabi bus station for a guaranteed no-hassle ride
 - Pay on arrival rather than upfront if possible
 - Read recent TripAdvisor reviews for the specific agency before booking
-

The Ao Nang Jet Ski Damage Shakedown

When you return, the operator points to a scratch on the underside of the hull that you could not possibly have seen before riding. He demands 20,000 to 50,000 baht for the damage and calls over several friends who surround you and block your path. If you refuse, he threatens police and keeps your passport or credit card. The Thai jet ski scam is one of the most infamous in Southeast Asia and is well-documented at beach resorts including Krabi. Local police have historically sided with operators, making disputes nearly unwinnable.

■ Red Flags

- Operator does not do a thorough pre-rental inspection with you
- No written agreement documenting the condition of the jet ski
- Operator asks for passport or large cash deposit
- Damage is pointed out on hidden surfaces like the hull underside
- Multiple men appear to pressure you into paying immediately

■ How to Avoid

- Avoid renting jet skis at Thai beaches entirely -- the scam is too well-established
 - If you must rent, video every angle of the jet ski before and after, including the underside
 - Never hand over your passport -- offer a photocopy or cash deposit
 - Call the Tourist Police (1155) if confronted with inflated damage claims
 - Ask your hotel for recommendations on reputable water sports operators
-

The Ao Nang Taxi Mafia Overcharge

This is because the local taxi association controls transport in the area and blocks ride-hailing apps from operating. A Reddit user on r/ThailandTourism described the taxi mafia in Krabi as a group that has been scamming tourists for years, charging 600-800 baht for trips that would cost 100-150 baht in a competitive market. When tourists try to negotiate or use alternative transport, drivers can become confrontational.

■ Red Flags

- Grab or Bolt show no available drivers despite being in a populated area
- Every driver quotes the same inflated rate with no willingness to negotiate
- Quoted airport transfer price exceeds 800 baht for a thirty-minute drive
- Drivers become hostile when you mention ride-hailing apps
- Songthaew drivers refuse to take you unless you pay a per-person rate instead of a flat fare

■ How to Avoid

- Arrange airport transfers through your hotel before arrival — many offer competitive rates
- Rent a motorbike from a reputable shop in Ao Nang for full independence
- Use the public songthaew service that runs fixed routes at set prices
- Walk to the main road where prices tend to be lower than at the beach or hotel areas
- Travel with other tourists to split the cost of private hires

The Tailor Shop Tuk-Tuk Redirect

■ ■ *Tuk-tuks in Ao Nang, routes to Krabi Town and Tiger Cave Temple A tuk-tuk driver offers you a suspiciously cheap ride to Tiger Cave Temple or Krabi Town — just 50 baht. But instead of going directly, he makes 'quick stops' at a tailor shop, jewelry store, and souvenir outlet, where you are expected to browse for at least fifteen minutes at each. The driver earns a commission for every tourist he delivers, regardless of whether you buy anything. A Reddit user warned that any tuk-tuk driver who drops you at a tailor or jewelry shop is running a commission scam, and the low fare is subsidized by the shops. Red Flags Fare is suspiciously cheap for the distance — under 100 baht for a long ride Driver makes unscheduled stops at shops and asks you to 'just take a look' You feel pressured inside the shops by staff who seem to know the driver The driver insists the stop is 'on the way' when it clearly is not Products at the shops are overpriced compared to market rates How to Avoid Agree on the route and destination before getting in — no stops means no stops If the driver stops at a shop, stay in the tuk-tuk and tell him to continue Pay the fair market rate upfront rather than accepting suspiciously low fares Book rides through your hotel reception or use a meter taxi from Krabi Town If you want custom tailoring, research shops independently with Google reviews* ■ *What to Do If You Get Scammed* ■ *File a Police Report Go to the nearest Tourist Police station. Call 1155 (Tourist Police) or 191 (General Police). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at touristpolice.go.th.* ■ *Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details.* ■ *Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Bangkok is at 95 Wireless Road, Pathumwan, Bangkok 10330. For emergencies: +66 2-205-4000.* ■ *Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Thailand* ■ ■

But instead of going directly, he makes 'quick stops' at a tailor shop, jewelry store, and souvenir outlet, where you are expected to browse for at least fifteen minutes at each. The driver earns a commission for every tourist he delivers, regardless of whether you buy anything. A Reddit user warned that any tuk-tuk driver who drops you at a tailor or jewelry shop is running a commission scam, and the low fare is subsidized by the shops.

■ Red Flags

- Fare is suspiciously cheap for the distance — under 100 baht for a long ride
- Driver makes unscheduled stops at shops and asks you to 'just take a look'
- You feel pressured inside the shops by staff who seem to know the driver
- The driver insists the stop is 'on the way' when it clearly is not
- Products at the shops are overpriced compared to market rates

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on the route and destination before getting in — no stops means no stops
- If the driver stops at a shop, stay in the tuk-tuk and tell him to continue
- Pay the fair market rate upfront rather than accepting suspiciously low fares
- Book rides through your hotel reception or use a meter taxi from Krabi Town
- If you want custom tailoring, research shops independently with Google reviews

■ ■ Pai

5 scams documented • Thailand

The Scooter Rental Passport Hostage

The road from Chiang Mai to Pai has 762 curves — you're going to get scratches. When you return the bike, the shop claims damage and wants 5,000-15,000 baht. Having left your passport as deposit, you have no leverage.

■ Red Flags

- Shop requires your passport, not cash deposit
- No pre-ride condition documentation
- The infamous 762-curve road virtually guarantees drops for beginners
- Leave cash deposit (3,000-5,000 baht), never your passport
- Video the entire bike before and after with the shop owner visible

■ How to Avoid

- Leave cash deposit (3,000-5,000 baht), never your passport
 - Video the entire bike before and after with the shop owner visible
 - Get travel insurance that covers motorbike accidents
 - Honestly assess your riding ability — the Pai road is serious
-

The Bamboo Raft Tour Overcharge

When you arrive at the river, the raft operator tells you the price was just for transport to the river. The actual rafting costs another 500 baht, plus 200 for photos and 100 for the life jacket. Your 300-baht trip is now 1,100 baht. Pai's tour operators work on commission from guesthouses, and the advertised price rarely includes everything. Similar add-on pricing affects the Pai Canyon visit and hot springs trips booked through walking street agents.

■ Red Flags

- The tour price quoted at your guesthouse seems significantly cheaper than what other travelers report paying
- The booking agent cannot provide a written list of exactly what is included in the price
- You are told at the activity site that the guesthouse price only covered transportation
- The operator demands cash on the spot for extras with no receipt
- Other tourists at the same activity paid a different price than you were quoted

■ How to Avoid

- Ask specifically whether the quoted price includes the activity itself, transport, equipment, and any entrance fees
 - Get the total all-inclusive price in writing or on a text message before paying any deposit
 - Compare prices between multiple tour desks on Walking Street before booking — prices vary significantly
 - Read recent reviews on Google Maps for the specific tour operator, not just the activity
 - For popular activities like hot springs and rafting, some travelers report better prices booking directly at the site
-

The Late-Night Drink Spiking

You leave your drink on the bar while dancing and take a sip when you return. The next thing you remember is waking up in your guesthouse room the following afternoon with your wallet, phone, and passport missing. Drink spiking in Pai is reported across Reddit's [r/ThailandTourism](#) and [r/solotravel](#) forums, with both men and women targeted. The Thai Tourist Police hotline 1155 receives reports from Pai regularly during high season.

■ Red Flags

- A stranger is overly insistent on buying you a drink or offers you a drink that is already open
- You left your drink unattended for any period of time, even briefly
- You feel disproportionately intoxicated relative to how much you have consumed
- A new acquaintance is eager to leave the bar with you or help you get back to your accommodation

- You wake up with significant gaps in memory despite drinking only moderately

■ How to Avoid

- Never leave your drink unattended — take it with you or finish it before stepping away
 - Order drinks in sealed bottles or cans and open them yourself
 - Go out with people you trust and agree to watch each other's drinks
 - If you feel suddenly and unusually intoxicated, tell a friend immediately and get to a safe location
 - Report any spiking incidents to the Thai Tourist Police at 1155 — they maintain a presence in Pai
-

The Ghost Villa Booking Scam

You pay in advance. When you arrive in Pai, the property does not exist. A Reddit user posted a detailed warning titled 'Pai Villa by Eoutfitting on Booking.com Is a Non-Existent Property' describing exactly this: a listing with attractive photos and positive reviews for a property that was completely fabricated. The scam exploits Pai's remote location -- travelers often arrive late at night after the winding mountain drive from Chiang Mai, finding themselves stranded with no accommodation. Booking platforms have been slow to remove these listings despite multiple reports.

■ Red Flags

- The property has no Google Maps pin or the pin is in a field or on a road with no visible buildings
- The listing name does not match any registered business in Pai when you search for it independently
- Photos look professionally staged but do not appear in reverse image searches connected to the property name
- The price is significantly below market rate for the quality shown in the photos
- The host does not respond to messages with specific local details like directions from the Pai bus station

■ How to Avoid

- Cross-reference any Pai booking with Google Maps satellite view to verify a building exists at the listed location
 - Book properties with hundreds of reviews and verified photos rather than new listings with few reviews
 - Contact the property directly through WhatsApp or Line (common in Thailand) and ask for a live photo before booking
 - Have a backup accommodation option in Pai in case your primary booking does not exist upon arrival
 - Report ghost listings to the booking platform immediately so they can be removed for other travelers
-

The Canyon and Waterfall Entrance Fee Inflation

■ ■ *Pai Canyon (Kong Lan), Pam Bok Waterfall, Mo Paeng Waterfall, and other natural attractions around Pai* You ride your scooter to Pai Canyon, one of the most popular viewpoints. Someone at the entrance collects a fee of 200-300 baht per person. The actual entrance fee, if any, should be 20-40 baht, and some sites are free. Unofficial fee collectors set up at popular nature spots around Pai, exploiting the fact that tourists do not know the official prices. Some attractions have no official entrance fee at all, and the person collecting money is simply an opportunist with a folding table and a cashbox. There are no official receipts given. **Red Flags** The entrance fee is collected by someone without a uniform, official signage, or printed tickets The price seems high for a simple viewpoint or waterfall -- official Thai park entrance fees for foreigners are typically 100-200 baht maximum No receipt is given or the receipt is a handwritten scrap of paper The fee collector is aggressive or pressuring when you hesitate Other tourists who arrived earlier tell you they paid a different amount

How to Avoid Research entrance fees on recent travel blogs or the Thai National Parks website before visiting Ask your guesthouse or hostel in Pai about current entrance fees for the specific attractions you plan to visit If a fee seems unreasonable, politely ask for an official receipt -- legitimate collectors can provide one Visit popular spots early in the morning before unofficial fee collectors set up Join a group tour from Pai that includes entrance fees in the price so you know exactly what you are paying

■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Tourist Police station. Call 1155 (Tourist Police) or 191 (General Police). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at touristpolice.go.th. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Bangkok is at 95 Wireless Road, Pathumwan, Bangkok 10330. For emergencies: +66 2-205-4000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead.

Someone at the entrance collects a fee of 200-300 baht per person. The actual entrance fee, if any, should be 20-40 baht, and some sites are free. Unofficial fee collectors set up at popular nature spots around Pai, exploiting the fact that tourists do not know the official prices. Some attractions have no official entrance fee at all, and the person collecting money is simply an opportunist with a folding table and a cashbox. There are no official receipts given.

■ Red Flags

- The entrance fee is collected by someone without a uniform, official signage, or printed tickets
- The price seems high for a simple viewpoint or waterfall -- official Thai park entrance fees for foreigners are typically 100-200 baht maximum
- No receipt is given or the receipt is a handwritten scrap of paper
- The fee collector is aggressive or pressuring when you hesitate
- Other tourists who arrived earlier tell you they paid a different amount

■ How to Avoid

- Research entrance fees on recent travel blogs or the Thai National Parks website before visiting
 - Ask your guesthouse or hostel in Pai about current entrance fees for the specific attractions you plan to visit
 - If a fee seems unreasonable, politely ask for an official receipt -- legitimate collectors can provide one
 - Visit popular spots early in the morning before unofficial fee collectors set up
 - Join a group tour from Pai that includes entrance fees in the price so you know exactly what you are paying
-

■■ Pattaya

7 scams documented • Thailand

The Jet Ski Damage Shakedown

When you return the jet ski to shore, the operator's mood changes instantly. He points to scratches on the hull and a dent near the engine. 'You did this,' he insists, demanding 30,000-50,000 THB (\$850-1,400 USD) for repairs. You are certain you did not hit anything. As you protest, a police officer appears — who turns out to be the operator's relative. They escort you to a nearby ATM. The jet ski damage scam is so well-documented in Pattaya that the U.S. Embassy in Thailand includes it in their official 'Common Scams to Avoid' advisory. Pattaya Mail reported extensively on jet ski scams, n...

■ Red Flags

- The operator does not walk you through a pre-rental inspection or rushes through it dismissively
- There is no written rental agreement documenting the current condition of the jet ski
- After your ride, the operator immediately inspects the jet ski intensely, often with other staff watching
- A 'police officer' arrives remarkably quickly after the dispute begins — they were likely already nearby
- The demanded repair amount is disproportionate to the alleged damage — tens of thousands of THB for scratches

■ How to Avoid

- Do not rent a jet ski in Pattaya — the general advice from the US Embassy, travel guides, and experienced travelers is simply to avoid it entirely
- If you insist on renting one, photograph and video every inch of the jet ski before riding, with the operator in the frame acknowledging the recording
- Get a written agreement listing any pre-existing damage and the maximum liability in case of damage
- Do not carry your passport or large amounts of cash to the beach — without access to money, you have leverage in a dispute

-
- If confronted, call the Tourist Police at 1155 — they are separate from local police and handle tourist scam complaints
-

Walking Street Bar Bill Extortion

The staff are friendly, the music is loud, and drinks are flowing. A few bar girls join your table and chat. They order 'lady drinks' — which you assume cost the same as yours. Hours later, your bill arrives: 15,000 THB (\$425 USD). Your beers were 150 THB each, but the lady drinks were 400-800 THB each, and several were ordered without your knowledge. When you protest, security guards appear. In an extreme case documented by Khaosod English in February 2026, 'bar security guards beat tourist after bill dispute in viral clip' on Soi 6. In September 2025, a Walking Street nightclub was shut d...

■ Red Flags

- Bar girls order drinks for themselves that you did not specifically agree to buy — each one goes on your tab
- There is no menu with prices, or the prices on the menu do not match what appears on the bill
- Someone encourages you to ring the bar bell — this means buying a round for everyone in the venue
- Security guards position themselves near your table or the exit as the evening progresses
- Your tab is being kept on a handwritten notepad rather than an electronic system you can verify

■ How to Avoid

- Pay for each drink individually as you order — never open a tab at a Pattaya bar you have not visited before
 - Ask the price of every drink before it is ordered, including lady drinks — they can cost 3-5x regular drink prices
 - Set a firm budget before entering and leave when you reach it — do not get drawn into spending more
 - Never ring the bar bell, no matter how much staff encourage you — it will cost you thousands of baht
 - If you feel unsafe or the bill seems inflated, call the Tourist Police at 1155 immediately from inside the bar
-

Tuk-Tuk to Gem Shop Detour

40-100 THB for several hours. It sounds too good to be true, and it is. The tour includes a mandatory stop at a gem shop where a friendly 'government employee' explains that Thailand is the world's largest sapphire exporter, and right now there is a special tax-free promotion where tourists can buy gems wholesale and resell them at huge profit back home. The gems are glass or synthetic, worth a fraction of what you pay. Your tuk-tuk driver receives a fuel voucher or cash commission for every tourist he delivers. This scam is so prevalent that it is listed on the official US Embassy in Thai...

■ Red Flags

- A tuk-tuk or taxi ride is offered at an impossibly low price — below the driver's fuel cost, they are clearly making money elsewhere
- The driver insists on making 'just one quick stop' at a factory, showroom, or 'government gem center'
- Someone at the shop claims to work for the government, just returned from your country, or has a personal connection to the gem trade
- You are told about a 'one-time tax holiday' or 'special export program' that makes today a unique buying opportunity
- Staff pressure you to buy immediately and become hostile or lock the door when you try to leave without purchasing

■ How to Avoid

- Never accept a tour at a price that seems too cheap — the driver's real income comes from commissions at the shops
 - Give explicit instructions about where you want to go and refuse any side stops — 'No stops, directly to my destination'
 - If taken to a gem shop against your wishes, simply walk out — you are under no obligation to enter or buy anything
 - Use the Grab app for transportation instead of tuk-tuks — the route is tracked and the destination is fixed
 - If threatened or locked in a shop, call the Tourist Police at 1155 immediately
-

Baht Bus Foreigner Pricing

When you get off and hand the driver 10 THB (the standard fare), he waves his hand and demands 50-100 THB, claiming the fare is higher for your route. Thai passengers around you paid 10 THB for the same ride. If you look confused or hesitate, the price goes up. Pattaya Mail reported extensively on this issue in a series of articles. Their investigation 'Are Baht Buses in Pattaya Overcharging Foreigners?' confirmed that 'while Thai passengers are typically charged the standard 10 baht fare, foreigners often report being asked to pay 20 baht — or more — especially along beach routes or in nig...

■ Red Flags

- You ask 'How much?' before boarding — this signals unfamiliarity and invites a quoted (inflated) price
- The driver quotes a specific fare rather than letting you pay the standard amount when exiting
- Other passengers (Thai locals) pay visibly less than what the driver demands from you
- The baht bus is empty and the driver treats your boarding as a private charter rather than a shared ride
- The driver demands payment before you exit rather than letting you pay and walk away

■ How to Avoid

- Know the standard fare: 10 THB for shared routes along Beach Road and Second Road — have exact change ready
- Do not ask the price before boarding — simply get on the shared route, press the buzzer when you want to stop, and hand 10 THB through the window
- Wait for a baht bus that already has Thai passengers — this confirms it is running on the standard shared route and fare
- If a driver demands more than the standard fare, calmly place 10 THB on the dash and walk away — do not engage in negotiation
- For longer distances or off-route destinations, use the Grab app or Bolt for transparent pricing instead of trying to charter a baht bus

The Go-Go Bar Lady Drink Hustle

She asks 'You buy me drink?' and you agree — one drink to be polite. What you do not realize is that her 'drink' is a specially priced cocktail that costs 200-400 THB versus your 100 THB beer. Over the next hour, she and her friends order four more rounds, each time catching your eye and you nod without thinking. Your tab has silently climbed to 3,000 THB for what you thought was a few social drinks. The lady drink system is a well-known feature of Pattaya nightlife, but it becomes a scam when the pricing is not transparent. A Quora discussion on Pattaya bar pricing confirms that 'lady drin...

■ Red Flags

- Bar girls sit with you immediately and ask for a drink within the first few minutes — it is their job, not a social interaction
- You are not told the price of a 'lady drink' before agreeing to buy one
- Multiple girls rotate to your table, each ordering at least one drink — this is coordinated
- The bartender brings drinks to your table without you explicitly ordering them — they go on your tab
- The bar has no visible price list and staff are evasive when asked about drink costs

■ How to Avoid

- Ask the specific price of a lady drink before agreeing to buy one — if it is above 200 THB, you are in a premium venue
- Set a firm limit on how many lady drinks you will buy and communicate it clearly — 'I'll buy you one drink'
- Pay as you go rather than running a tab — this prevents bill inflation at the end of the night
- Be aware that buying a lady drink is a business transaction for the girl and the bar, not a social obligation — saying 'no' is acceptable
- Choose venues with visible price lists and electronic tab systems rather than handwritten tallies

Pattaya Dual Pricing at Attractions

The Thai-language sign shows 50 THB. The English-language sign next to it shows 200 THB. Some attractions do not even display the Thai price — they simply have separate queues or ticket windows. You pay 4x what Thai nationals pay for the same experience. Dual pricing — charging foreigners more than Thai nationals — is an official, widespread, and legal practice in Thailand. It is not technically a scam, but it catches tourists off guard and feels unfair. The It's Better in Thailand guide notes that this is a persistent point of contention. National parks, government-run attractions, and man...

■ Red Flags

- The price board has Thai script alongside English — check if the numbers are different (Thai numerals: ■■■ vs Arabic: 123)
- You see Thai visitors paying at a different counter or window than foreign tourists
- A local friend or guide expresses surprise at the price you were quoted for an attraction
- Online booking sites show a different (often lower) price than the walk-up ticket window
- Street food vendors pause and seem to recalculate when they see you are not Thai

■ How to Avoid

- Research attraction prices online before visiting — foreigner prices are usually listed on official websites
- Book tickets online through Klook, GetYourGuide, or the venue's website — online prices are sometimes lower than walk-up foreigner rates
- Accept dual pricing at government-run sites as a cultural reality rather than a scam — it subsidizes access for Thai citizens
- For market shopping, ask a Thai friend to check the price first, or learn basic Thai numbers to read the Thai price boards
- Focus your budget on experiences where pricing is transparent and uniform — many excellent Pattaya restaurants, for example, charge the same regardless of nationality

Money Exchange Rate Manipulation

■ ■ Exchange booths on Walking Street, Beach Road, Soi Buakhao, and near major shopping centers You spot an exchange booth on Walking Street advertising a rate of 35.5 baht to the dollar — better than any bank. You hand over three hundred dollars expecting 10,650 baht. The clerk counts out the bills behind a low partition, hands you a stack, and waves you off. Once you recount on the street, you have only 9,000 baht. The clerk used sleight of hand to palm several 500-baht notes during the count. Some booths also use rigged calculators or post rates that apply only to exchanges above ten thousand dollars, with the real tourist rate hidden in fine print. Red Flags The exchange rate displayed is significantly better than what major banks and SuperRich are offering The clerk counts the money behind a partition or below counter level where you cannot clearly see You are rushed through the transaction and told to move aside for the next customer Fine print below the rate board specifies a minimum exchange amount that makes the posted rate inapplicable The booth is in a heavy nightlife area rather than a shopping center or bank zone How to Avoid Exchange money at SuperRich, Bangkok Bank, or Kasikorn Bank branches which offer competitive and honest rates Always recount the money in front of the clerk before walking away from the window Compare the rate board to the current rate on Google or XE.com before exchanging Avoid exchange booths in nightlife districts — they target tourists who have been drinking Use ATMs at major banks for withdrawals — the exchange rate is set automatically at market rates ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Tourist Police station. Call 1155 (Tourist Police) or 191 (General Police). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at touristpolice.go.th. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Bangkok is at 95 Wireless Road, Pathumwan, Bangkok 10330. For emergencies: +66 2-205-4000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Thailand ■ ■

You hand over three hundred dollars expecting 10,650 baht. The clerk counts out the bills behind a low partition, hands you a stack, and waves you off. Once you recount on the street, you have only 9,000 baht. The clerk used sleight of hand to palm several 500-baht notes during the count. Some booths also use rigged calculators or post rates that apply only to exchanges above ten thousand dollars, with the real tourist rate

hidden in fine print.

■ Red Flags

- The exchange rate displayed is significantly better than what major banks and SuperRich are offering
- The clerk counts the money behind a partition or below counter level where you cannot clearly see
- You are rushed through the transaction and told to move aside for the next customer
- Fine print below the rate board specifies a minimum exchange amount that makes the posted rate inapplicable
- The booth is in a heavy nightlife area rather than a shopping center or bank zone

■ How to Avoid

- Exchange money at SuperRich, Bangkok Bank, or Kasikorn Bank branches which offer competitive and honest rates
 - Always recount the money in front of the clerk before walking away from the window
 - Compare the rate board to the current rate on Google or XE.com before exchanging
 - Avoid exchange booths in nightlife districts — they target tourists who have been drinking
 - Use ATMs at major banks for withdrawals — the exchange rate is set automatically at market rates
-

■■ Phuket

8 scams documented • Thailand

Tuk Tuk Gem Store Tour

he'll take you on a tour of the whole city for almost nothing. The catch: the route includes a stop at a gem shop where he tells you that Thailand is having a 'special government gem export day' and you can buy precious stones at wholesale prices to resell for huge profit at home. The gems are fake or wildly overpriced glass, and the driver gets commission for every tourist he delivers.

■ Red Flags

- Tuk tuk driver offering suspiciously cheap city tours
- Mention of any 'government sale' or 'special export day'
- Driver steering you toward specific shops you didn't ask for
- Never buy gems, jewelry, or tailor-made clothing based on a driver's recommendation
- Book tours through your hotel or official tourist offices

■ How to Avoid

- Never buy gems, jewelry, or tailor-made clothing based on a driver's recommendation
 - Book tours through your hotel or official tourist offices
 - If a deal sounds too good to be true in Thailand, it always is
-

Temple Closed Scam

special ceremony, national holiday, whatever the excuse sounds plausible. He then helpfully offers to show you a 'lesser-known but more special' temple, and conveniently has a tuk tuk waiting. The original temple was never closed; this was just a setup to redirect you to overpriced shops.

■ Red Flags

- Stranger who knows exactly where you were going before you told them
- 'Temple closed' claim without any visible sign or gate closure
- Immediate offer of alternative transportation
- Verify temple hours on Google before going
- Walk to the temple and check yourself — if it's actually closed there will be a sign

■ How to Avoid

- Verify temple hours on Google before going
 - Walk to the temple and check yourself — if it's actually closed there will be a sign
 - Never accept transportation from people who approach you claiming tourist sites are closed
-

Jet Ski Damage Demand

The operator and several large friends suddenly appear claiming there's serious damage — a scratch, a dent, a broken part — that was definitely there before you took it. They demand hundreds of dollars in cash, surround you, and won't let you leave until you pay or they call 'police' who are sometimes in on it too.

■ Red Flags

- Rental operator who rushes the pre-rental inspection
- Damage claims that appear immediately after return
- Multiple large men appearing to surround you suddenly
- Photograph the entire jet ski from every angle before renting
- Record a video on your phone showing all surfaces before going in the water

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph the entire jet ski from every angle before renting
 - Record a video on your phone showing all surfaces before going in the water
 - Pay with a copy of your credit card details held back — some travelers use a scan of a fake card copy at these operators
-

Taxi Flat Rate Overcharge

maybe 500 baht. This is always significantly more than the metered price would be. Phuket taxis famously refuse to use meters, so you're always at their mercy unless you use a ride-hailing app or negotiate before entering.

■ Red Flags

- Driver who refuses to use meter and insists on 'fixed price'
- Price quoted that seems high compared to what you've read online
- No meter visible in the taxi
- Use Grab (Southeast Asia's Uber equivalent) for all Phuket transport
- Agree price firmly before getting in if taking a metered taxi

■ How to Avoid

- Use Grab (Southeast Asia's Uber equivalent) for all Phuket transport
 - Agree price firmly before getting in if taking a metered taxi
 - Airport taxis to Patong should be around 600-800 baht — double-check this rate before traveling
-

Fake Buddhist Monk Donations

He smiles, chants something, then holds out a donation book showing other tourists gave €10-50 each. The social pressure in the moment is intense. Real Buddhist monks in Thailand are not permitted to solicit money or donations from strangers.

■ Red Flags

- 'Monk' approaching tourists proactively outside of temple grounds
- Donation book with high previous amounts listed to pressure you
- Monk who looks at your valuables or seems uncomfortable near real temples

- Real monks do not approach tourists for money — walk away politely
- If you want to donate to Buddhism, do so inside an actual temple

■ How to Avoid

- Real monks do not approach tourists for money — walk away politely
 - If you want to donate to Buddhism, do so inside an actual temple
 - These fake monks often operate in groups and can become aggressive if you refuse
-

Counterfeit Tour Booking

The price is slightly below other operators. On the day, the boat is overcrowded, the snorkeling equipment is worn out, and the 'private speedboat' is actually a crammed ferry. Some operators take payment and simply don't show up, especially for smaller cash bookings.

■ Red Flags

- Tour operator without a physical address or permanent office
- Price significantly below other operators for the same trip
- Payment requested in cash with no official receipt
- Book tours through your hotel or established operators with online reviews
- Get a full receipt with company name, license number, and trip details

■ How to Avoid

- Book tours through your hotel or established operators with online reviews
 - Get a full receipt with company name, license number, and trip details
 - Confirm your booking with a phone call the day before departure
-

Motorbike Rental Damage Extortion

The owner says no deposit is needed if you leave your passport. Two days later, you return the scooter in the same condition. The owner pulls out a flashlight, points to a scratch on the underside of the fender, and demands 15,000 baht for repairs. You know the scratch was there when you rented it but took no photos. Without your passport, you cannot leave. The Thai Tourist Police hotline 1155 receives hundreds of complaints about this scam annually from Phuket alone.

■ Red Flags

- The shop asks for your passport as a deposit rather than a cash deposit or credit card hold
- No written rental agreement or existing damage report is created when you pick up the scooter
- The scooter has visible scratches, dents, or wear marks that are not documented
- The quoted rental price is suspiciously low — the damage charge is where they make their money
- The shop has poor or no reviews on Google Maps, or reviews mention damage disputes

■ How to Avoid

- Never leave your passport — offer a cash deposit or credit card hold instead, and walk away if they insist on the passport
 - Take a detailed video walking around the entire scooter before riding, including close-ups of every scratch and dent
 - Insist on a written rental agreement that lists pre-existing damage — email yourself a copy immediately
 - Rent from shops with strong Google Maps reviews and no reports of damage disputes
 - If you face an unfair damage claim, call the Thai Tourist Police at 1155 — they mediate these disputes regularly
-

The Pharmacy Herb Shop Swindle

■ ■ *Pharmacy and traditional medicine shops on Bangla Road in Patong, Karon Beach shopping areas, and near Phuket Old Town tourist streets* A friendly local recommends a pharmacy or herbal medicine shop for a health remedy. Inside, staff perform a free health check and recommend expensive herbal supplements or traditional remedies. The bill comes to 20,000-60,000 THB (\$550-1,700 USD). A Reddit user on r/phuket described losing over 60,000 THB in a coordinated pharmacy-herb scam where local police were working with the shop. When the victim complained, police sided with the shop. These operations function as organized fraud rings with kickbacks to tuk-tuk drivers, tour guides, and sometimes local police. The products sold are generic supplements worth a fraction of the price. *Red Flags* A tuk-tuk driver, tour guide, or hotel staff specifically recommend a particular pharmacy or herb shop Staff offer a free health check or consultation that conveniently diagnoses expensive conditions Products are presented as rare Thai herbal remedies available only at this specific shop Prices are not clearly displayed and the total is revealed only after the consultation and product preparation Staff become aggressive or threatening when you question the price or try to leave without buying *How to Avoid* Never visit a pharmacy or herb shop recommended by a tuk-tuk driver, tout, or anyone who receives commissions Purchase medications only from licensed pharmacies like Boots, Watsons, or hospital pharmacies If you need traditional Thai medicine, visit the Thai Traditional Medicine Hospital in Phuket Town rather than tourist-area shops Always ask for prices before any consultation or product preparation and get the total in writing If overcharged, contact the Tourist Police at 1155 rather than local police who may be compromised ■ *What to Do If You Get Scammed* ■ *File a Police Report* Go to the nearest Tourist Police station. Call 1155 (Tourist Police) or 191 (General Police). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at touristpolice.go.th. ■ *Cancel Your Cards* Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ *Lost Passport?* Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Bangkok is at 95 Wireless Road, Pathumwan, Bangkok 10330. For emergencies: +66 2-205-4000. ■ *Track Your Device* If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. *Frequently Asked Questions* Is Phuket safe for tourists? ▼

Inside, staff perform a free health check and recommend expensive herbal supplements or traditional remedies. The bill comes to 20,000-60,000 THB (\$550-1,700 USD). A Reddit user on r/phuket described losing over 60,000 THB in a coordinated pharmacy-herb scam where local police were working with the shop. When the victim complained, police sided with the shop. These operations function as organized fraud rings with kickbacks to tuk-tuk drivers, tour guides, and sometimes local police. The products sold are generic supplements worth a fraction of the price.

■ Red Flags

- A tuk-tuk driver, tour guide, or hotel staff specifically recommend a particular pharmacy or herb shop
- Staff offer a free health check or consultation that conveniently diagnoses expensive conditions
- Products are presented as rare Thai herbal remedies available only at this specific shop
- Prices are not clearly displayed and the total is revealed only after the consultation and product preparation
- Staff become aggressive or threatening when you question the price or try to leave without buying

■ How to Avoid

- Never visit a pharmacy or herb shop recommended by a tuk-tuk driver, tout, or anyone who receives commissions
- Purchase medications only from licensed pharmacies like Boots, Watsons, or hospital pharmacies
- If you need traditional Thai medicine, visit the Thai Traditional Medicine Hospital in Phuket Town rather than tourist-area shops
- Always ask for prices before any consultation or product preparation and get the total in writing
- If overcharged, contact the Tourist Police at 1155 rather than local police who may be compromised

■ Vietnam

■ ■ Da Nang

The Airport Taxi Markup

You land at Da Nang airport and a taxi driver shows you a Grab-like app on his phone with a price of 500,000 VND to the city center. Looks official, right? But he's showing you the VIP/luxury option. The actual Grab price is 50,000-80,000 VND — he's charging you 6-10x the real fare. Some drivers even have fake apps installed that display inflated prices.

■ Red Flags

- Driver shows you a price on their phone rather than letting you book yourself
- Price displayed is for 'VIP' or 'premium' service
- Insistence on cash payment
- Driver approaches you in arrivals rather than waiting at the taxi stand
- Download Grab before landing and book your own ride

■ How to Avoid

- Download Grab before landing and book your own ride
 - The real fare from Da Nang airport to city center is 50,000-100,000 VND
 - Use the official airport taxi queue with metered vehicles
 - Never accept a fare shown on someone else's phone
-

The Beachfront Lounger Bait

A friendly vendor brings over two loungers and an umbrella — 'Free, free!' Once you're settled and comfortable, a different person appears with a menu of mandatory minimum drink orders: two coconuts at 100,000 VND each, or you lose the chairs. The 'free' setup was bait.

■ Red Flags

- 'Free' loungers offered without explanation
- Different person handles the billing than the setup
- No price list visible until you're seated
- Ask 'Bao nhieu?' before sitting in any provided chairs
- Many sections of My Khe Beach are genuinely free — use your own towel

■ How to Avoid

- Ask 'Bao nhieu?' before sitting in any provided chairs
 - Many sections of My Khe Beach are genuinely free — use your own towel
 - If a lounge comes with a minimum spend, that's normal — but confirm the amount first
-

The Motorbike Damage Claim

When you return it, the shop owner circles the bike finding scratches and 'damage' — most of which was there before you took it. They demand \$50-200 for repairs. If you left your passport as deposit (never do this), you have zero leverage.

■ Red Flags

- Shop asks for your passport as deposit
- No photo documentation of the bike's condition at rental time
- Aggressive claims of damage on return
- Never leave your passport — leave cash deposit or a copy instead
- Video-record the bike from all angles before riding away

■ How to Avoid

- Never leave your passport — leave cash deposit or a copy instead
 - Video-record the bike from all angles before riding away
 - Use reputable rental shops recommended by your hotel
 - Take timestamped photos that prove pre-existing damage
-

The Motorbike Helmet Swap

An hour later, your helmet is gone. The rental shop holds you responsible -- replacement cost is 200,000-500,000 VND deducted from your deposit. Helmet theft is opportunistic and common at popular parking spots in Da Nang. Some travelers have reported their decent helmet being swapped for a cracked one worth nothing.

■ Red Flags

- Your helmet disappears from the handlebars while parked at a tourist spot
- A stranger offers to 'watch' your bike for a small fee at an unattended lot
- Your helmet has been swapped for an obviously older or damaged one
- Take your helmet with you or use the under-seat compartment if the bike has one
- Park in attended lots where a staff member gives you a numbered ticket

■ How to Avoid

- Take your helmet with you or use the under-seat compartment if the bike has one
 - Park in attended lots where a staff member gives you a numbered ticket
 - Take a photo of your helmet before the trip so you can prove it was swapped
 - Budget for the replacement cost as part of your rental agreement -- it's a known risk
-

The Phone Snatch on Wheels

■ ■ *Han River Bridge area, My Khe Beach promenade, Dragon Bridge sidewalks* You are taking photos along the Han River waterfront when a motorbike with two young riders slows beside you. In a flash, the passenger grabs your phone from your hand and the bike accelerates into traffic. Within seconds your phone -- and everything on it -- is gone. Travelers on r/DaNang and r/VietNam report that Da Nang police recently caught a ring of four teenagers who had been snatching phones from pedestrians and tourists using exactly this method. While Da Nang is safer than Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh City for scams, motorbike phone snatching is a real and growing threat along the beachfront and tourist walking areas. Red Flags A slow-moving motorbike with two riders approaches from behind You are walking near the curb with your phone in your hand The area is poorly lit or the sidewalk puts you close to moving traffic Riders are wearing face masks and helmets that obscure their faces They circle back after passing you the first time How to Avoid Never walk along the street side of the sidewalk while holding your phone Use a phone lanyard or wrist strap so snatchers cannot grab it cleanly Walk facing oncoming traffic so you can see approaching bikes Keep your phone in a zipped pocket when not actively using it If taking photos, step back from the road and face away from traffic ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Vietnamese Police (Công An) station. Call 113. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at hanoi.gov.vn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 7 Lang Ha Street, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi. For emergencies: +84 24 3850-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Vietnam ■ ■

In a flash, the passenger grabs your phone from your hand and the bike accelerates into traffic. Within seconds your phone -- and everything on it -- is gone. Travelers on r/DaNang and r/VietNam report that Da Nang police recently caught a ring of four teenagers who had been snatching phones from pedestrians and tourists using exactly this method. While Da Nang is safer than Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh City for scams, motorbike phone snatching is a real and growing threat along the beachfront and tourist walking areas.

■ Red Flags

- A slow-moving motorbike with two riders approaches from behind
- You are walking near the curb with your phone in your hand
- The area is poorly lit or the sidewalk puts you close to moving traffic
- Riders are wearing face masks and helmets that obscure their faces
- They circle back after passing you the first time

■ How to Avoid

- Never walk along the street side of the sidewalk while holding your phone
 - Use a phone lanyard or wrist strap so snatchers cannot grab it cleanly
 - Walk facing oncoming traffic so you can see approaching bikes
 - Keep your phone in a zipped pocket when not actively using it
 - If taking photos, step back from the road and face away from traffic
-

■■ Dalat

4 scams documented • Vietnam

The Canyoning Tour Safety Gamble

A street agency near the central market offers the full-day experience for 500,000 VND (\$20) when established operators like Viet Challenge charge 1,400,000 VND (\$56). The cheap tour uses frayed ropes, guides without first aid certification, and skips safety briefings entirely. Midway through the rappel, you realize the carabiner isn't locking properly and your guide doesn't seem concerned. Dalat has recorded at least two tourist deaths from canyoning accidents with unlicensed operators. The cost difference is literally the price of your safety.

■ Red Flags

- Price under \$40 for a canyoning tour
- No mention of safety equipment or guide certifications
- No waiver or safety briefing before the activity
- Book with Phat Tire Ventures or Highland Sport Travel
- Budget \$60-80 per person for a safe canyoning experience

■ How to Avoid

- Book with Phat Tire Ventures or Highland Sport Travel
 - Budget \$60-80 per person for a safe canyoning experience
 - Ask about guide certifications and equipment age
-

The Easy Rider Motorbike Tour Knock-Off

But the original Easy Rider brand has been copied by dozens of unlicensed operators, some of whom approach tourists at Dalat's night market or outside popular cafes on Nguyen Chi Thanh street. You agree on a two-day tour to Nha Trang for 2,000,000 VND. Day one is fine, but that night your rider vanishes with your deposit and backpack. Legitimate Easy Riders operate through established booking offices and have verifiable long-term Google reviews going back years.

■ Red Flags

- Rider approaches you on the street claiming to be an Easy Rider
- No verifiable connection to the original group
- Demands full payment upfront in cash

- Book through the original Dalat Easy Riders website or their office
- Pay a deposit, not full payment, and settle the rest at the end

■ How to Avoid

- Book through the original Dalat Easy Riders website or their office
- Pay a deposit, not full payment, and settle the rest at the end
- Ask to see the bike and check its condition

The Airport Grab Cancellation Hustle

Before your driver arrives, men wearing unofficial-looking vests approach and insist you must cancel your Grab booking because 'app taxis are not allowed at the airport.' They pressure you into an unlicensed taxi charging 200,000-400,000 VND for a trip that costs 120,000 VND on Grab. Circulating video on r/VietNam shows these self-appointed officials physically confronting arriving passengers who refuse to cancel their Grab bookings, even going so far as to intimidate the Grab drivers into leaving without passengers.

■ Red Flags

- Men in unofficial vests approach you in the arrivals area before your Grab arrives
- They claim ride-hailing apps are banned at the airport
- They try to take your phone or pressure you to cancel the booking yourself
- The substitute taxi has no meter and quotes a flat fare double the app price
- Grab drivers you book send messages saying they cannot enter the pickup zone

■ How to Avoid

- Do not cancel your Grab booking no matter what anyone at the airport says
- Walk to the official pickup point marked for ride-hailing services
- If pressured, say firmly that you have already paid through the app
- Pre-book an airport transfer through your hotel for a hassle-free arrival
- Report intimidation to Dalat airport security or call the tourist hotline at 02633 810 010

The Fake Resort Booking Page

■ ■ Online -- targeting visitors planning Dalat trips While searching for Dalat accommodations on Facebook, you find a resort page with gorgeous photos, ... While searching for Dalat accommodations on Facebook, you find a resort page with gorgeous photos, 20,000 likes, and great reviews. You message them to book and transfer the full payment via bank transfer. When you arrive in Dalat, the resort has no record of your booking. The Facebook page was a sophisticated clone of a real resort's page, created specifically to steal prepayments from trusting tourists. R/VietNam users report one fake page operated for over three years before being taken down, stealing deposits from dozens of travelers during peak holiday seasons. Red Flags The resort only accepts direct bank transfers, not credit cards or established booking platforms The Facebook page URL is slightly different from the official resort page Prices are 30-50 percent below what the same resort charges on Booking.com or Agoda The page has many likes but few genuine comments from verified guests Communication is only through Facebook Messenger, never email or phone How to Avoid Always book through established platforms like Booking.com, Agoda, or the resort's official website Verify the Facebook page by cross-referencing the resort's actual website and phone number Never transfer money directly to a bank account based on a social media page alone Call the resort's verified phone number to confirm your booking exists Pay by credit card for chargeback protection if something goes wrong ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Vietnamese Police (Công An) station. Call 113. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at hanoi.gov.vn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 7 Lang Ha Street, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi. For emergencies: +84 24 3850-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Vietnam ■ ■

While searching for Dalat accommodations on Facebook, you find a resort page with gorgeous photos, 20,000 likes, and great reviews. You message them to book and transfer the full payment via bank transfer. When you arrive in Dalat, the resort has no record of your booking. The Facebook page was a sophisticated clone of a real resort's page, created specifically to steal prepayments from trusting tourists. R/VietNam users report one fake page operated for over three years before being taken down, stealing deposits from dozens of travelers during peak holiday seasons.

■ Red Flags

- The resort only accepts direct bank transfers, not credit cards or established booking platforms
- The Facebook page URL is slightly different from the official resort page
- Prices are 30-50 percent below what the same resort charges on Booking.com or Agoda
- The page has many likes but few genuine comments from verified guests
- Communication is only through Facebook Messenger, never email or phone

■ How to Avoid

- Always book through established platforms like Booking.com, Agoda, or the resort's official website
 - Verify the Facebook page by cross-referencing the resort's actual website and phone number
 - Never transfer money directly to a bank account based on a social media page alone
 - Call the resort's verified phone number to confirm your booking exists
 - Pay by credit card for chargeback protection if something goes wrong
-

■■ Ha Long Bay

6 scams documented • Vietnam

The Bait-and-Switch Cruise

The brochure shows a gleaming wooden junk with private cabins and a sundeck. The price seems like a steal at \$45 per person. On departure day, a minibus picks you up and drives four hours to the pier. But the boat waiting for you is nothing like the photos -- it's a rusty vessel with cramped shared rooms, stained bedding, and a bathroom you'd rather avoid. When you protest, the tour operator has vanished, unreachable by phone. As Reddit's r/VietnamTravel community documents, the bait-and-switch is Ha Long Bay's signature scam -- your \$45 cruise was always going to this boat.

■ Red Flags

- The cruise price is significantly below the \$120-150 per person minimum for a legitimate 2-day/1-night trip
- The booking office cannot provide the exact name of the boat you will board
- Photos in the brochure look stock or are obviously of a different, more luxurious vessel
- Payment is cash-only with no option for credit card or online platform booking
- The agency has no verifiable online reviews on TripAdvisor or Google Maps

■ How to Avoid

- Book directly through cruise operators' official websites rather than through street-level travel agencies
 - Budget at least \$120-150 per person for a reputable 2-day/1-night cruise as of 2025-2026
 - Request the exact boat name in writing and verify it exists through online reviews and photos
 - Book through platforms like GetYourGuide, Klook, or Booking.com that offer buyer protection and refund policies
 - Read recent TripAdvisor reviews specifically mentioning the boat name, not just the tour company
-

The Floating Restaurant Price Trap

Tanks full of live shrimp, crab, and grouper look incredible. You point at a few dishes without asking prices -- after all, seafood is cheap in Vietnam, right? Wrong. When the bill arrives, it's 2.5 million VND (over \$100) for what would cost 400,000 VND at a Hanoi restaurant. The floating restaurant is a captive market with no competition and no price regulation. As travelers on Reddit's r/travel note, with water on all sides, you literally have nowhere else to go. The crew receives commission for steering you there, and complaints to the boat operator go nowhere.

■ Red Flags

- The restaurant is only accessible by boat with no alternative dining options nearby
- There is no menu with prices -- you choose by pointing at live seafood in tanks
- The crew or guide seems unusually enthusiastic about recommending this specific restaurant
- Prices are quoted per 100 grams rather than per dish, making totals unclear until the bill
- Other tourists at nearby tables look shocked when their bills arrive

■ How to Avoid

- Always ask for a printed menu with prices before ordering anything at floating restaurants
 - Choose an all-inclusive cruise package that includes meals on the boat itself
 - If ordering seafood by weight, confirm the total price before the kitchen prepares it
 - Bring snacks and water aboard your cruise so you are not dependent on overpriced dining stops
 - Set a budget limit with the server upfront and ask them to stop adding dishes when you reach it
-

The Fake Pearl Farm Sale

It's genuinely educational and you watch workers carefully open oysters to reveal gleaming pearls. Then you're guided into the showroom where pearl necklaces, earrings, and rings are presented as 'farm-direct' prices. You buy a beautiful necklace for \$50, told it's a natural Vietnamese pearl worth three times as much at retail. Back home, a jeweler examines it and confirms it's a low-grade cultured pearl worth perhaps \$5. Reddit's r/VietnamTravel warns that these pearl farm visits are built into cruise itineraries because the cruise operator receives a kickback on every sale.

■ Red Flags

- The pearl farm visit is a mandatory stop on the cruise itinerary, not an optional activity
- The transition from educational tour to sales showroom is seamless and feels rehearsed
- Staff use high-pressure tactics like limited-time discounts or claims of authenticity certificates
- Prices are presented as massive discounts from supposed retail value
- The crew or guide receives visible perks or attention from the pearl farm staff

■ How to Avoid

- Enjoy the educational portion of the pearl farm visit but decline to enter the showroom
 - Understand that genuine high-quality pearls require expert gemological verification
 - If you want pearl jewelry, buy from established jewelers in Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh City with return policies
 - Research market prices for cultured pearls before your trip so you can recognize inflated pricing
 - Ask if you can skip the pearl farm stop -- some cruise operators allow it if you request in advance
-

The Hidden Surcharge Cruise

The price includes transport, accommodation, and meals. You're thrilled. But on the bus ride to the bay, the guide starts mentioning 'optional' extras: kayaking is \$15, the cave entrance is \$10, drinks are extra, and there's a \$5 per person 'environmental fee' nobody mentioned. By the end of the trip, your \$40 cruise has cost \$140. When you ask for a refund, the guide points to the fine print on your receipt that says 'basic package.' Reddit's r/backpacking calls this the Ha Long drip-pricing scheme -- the low upfront cost hooks you, and charges

accumulate throughout the trip.

■ Red Flags

- The advertised price seems far too low for everything described in the itinerary
- The booking agent is vague when asked exactly what is included versus extra
- You receive a receipt with 'basic package' or 'standard tier' printed in small text
- Extras like kayaking, cave visits, and drinks are mentioned as included verbally but not in writing
- The guide begins collecting additional fees on the bus before you even reach the pier

■ How to Avoid

- Get a detailed written breakdown of every inclusion before paying -- transport, meals, activities, entrance fees, and drinks
 - Request email confirmation listing all costs so you have documentation in case of disputes
 - Budget \$120-150 per person minimum for a legitimate all-inclusive 2-day cruise in 2025-2026
 - Ask specifically about kayaking fees, cave entrance fees, tip expectations, and drink prices
 - Book through platforms that clearly itemize what is included and offer dispute resolution
-

The Boat Switch at the Pier

You arrive at Tuan Chau Marina after the four-hour drive from Hanoi, excited to board the sleek vessel you saw in booking photos. But at the pier, the guide directs you to a completely different boat. 'Your original boat had a mechanical problem,' they explain apologetically. 'This one is just as good.' It is not just as good. The replacement is a budget vessel with peeling paint, no air conditioning, and a crew of two instead of eight. By now, you're at the marina with your luggage, your return transport is tied to this tour, and walking away means losing your entire payment. As Ha Long Ba...

■ Red Flags

- You are told at the pier that the boat has been changed due to 'mechanical issues'
- The replacement boat looks significantly different from what was advertised
- The guide discourages you from speaking to the crew or other passengers about the switch
- Other passengers on the replacement boat seem equally confused or disappointed
- The tour operator becomes unreachable by phone when you try to complain from the pier

■ How to Avoid

- Book with operators that have a fleet of consistently reviewed boats, not just one vessel
 - Include a clause in your booking that entitles you to a full refund if the boat is changed without consent
 - Arrive at the pier early and verify the boat name matches your booking confirmation before boarding
 - Pay with a credit card through a reputable platform so you can initiate a chargeback if the service differs materially
 - Read recent reviews that specifically mention the boat name and match it to your confirmed booking
-

The Kayak Extortion

■ ■ *Kayaking areas near Luon Cave and Dark-Bright Cave* Your cruise guide announces that the kayaking excursion is about to begin. You grab a paddle and head out toward the towering limestone karsts, surrounded by emerald water. It's magical -- until you reach a local in a small boat blocking the entrance to a particularly scenic cave or lagoon. They demand 50,000-100,000 VND per person to 'allow passage' through what they claim is their territory. If you refuse, they physically block your kayak. Some travelers on Reddit report being asked to pay multiple times at different chokepoints during the same paddle. The cave entrances are public waterways, but the isolated setting and language barrier make it difficult to argue. **Red Flags** A local in a rowboat positions themselves to block the entrance to a cave or lagoon. They demand cash payment for passage through what appears to be an open waterway. Your cruise guide did not mention any additional fees for the kayaking route. The amount demanded varies depending on how many tourists are in the group. Other kayakers are turning around or reluctantly paying to get through. **How to Avoid** Ask your cruise guide before kayaking whether any

passage fees exist on the route Carry only small amounts of cash while kayaking and leave valuables on the boat Choose cruise operators that include all kayaking fees in the package price and handle local payments If blocked, remain calm, paddle back, and report the incident to your cruise guide Kayak in groups rather than alone for safety and to reduce targeting by opportunistic locals ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Vietnamese Police (Công An) station. Call 113. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at hanoi.gov.vn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 7 Lang Ha Street, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi. For emergencies: +84 24 3850-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Vietnam ■■

You grab a paddle and head out toward the towering limestone karsts, surrounded by emerald water. It's magical -- until you reach a local in a small boat blocking the entrance to a particularly scenic cave or lagoon. They demand 50,000-100,000 VND per person to 'allow passage' through what they claim is their territory. If you refuse, they physically block your kayak. Some travelers on Reddit report being asked to pay multiple times at different chokepoints during the same paddle. The cave entrances are public waterways, but the isolated setting and language barrier make it difficult to argue.

■ Red Flags

- A local in a rowboat positions themselves to block the entrance to a cave or lagoon
- They demand cash payment for passage through what appears to be an open waterway
- Your cruise guide did not mention any additional fees for the kayaking route
- The amount demanded varies depending on how many tourists are in the group
- Other kayakers are turning around or reluctantly paying to get through

■ How to Avoid

- Ask your cruise guide before kayaking whether any passage fees exist on the route
 - Carry only small amounts of cash while kayaking and leave valuables on the boat
 - Choose cruise operators that include all kayaking fees in the package price and handle local payments
 - If blocked, remain calm, paddle back, and report the incident to your cruise guide
 - Kayak in groups rather than alone for safety and to reduce targeting by opportunistic locals
-

■■ Hanoi

6 scams documented • Vietnam

The Tinder Honeytrap Scam

A woman shows up and guides you to a restaurant for dinner, then suggests heading to a nearby nightclub. The restaurant bill comes back outrageously inflated — think \$150 for basic food — and the nightclub has a metal shutter that comes down once you're inside, trapping you until you pay hundreds more. This organized ring has been running for 5+ years with an estimated 30-50 victims per night, each losing \$100-200.

■ Red Flags

- Match met you on a specific street corner
- Suggests specific restaurant or bar you didn't choose
- Restaurant has no prices posted
- Club has security preventing you from leaving
- Never follow a Tinder date to a restaurant or club they specifically recommend in the Old Quarter

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow a Tinder date to a restaurant or club they specifically recommend in the Old Quarter
 - Agree on a venue yourself beforehand
 - Read Google Maps reviews of any bar before entering (sort by lowest)
-

The Shoe Repair Shakedown

maybe he points out a broken sole or loose strap. Before you can say anything, he's already glued it and demands an enormous fee. When you protest, he gets aggressive and refuses to give your shoe back until you pay. This quick-hands hustle catches tourists totally off guard.

■ Red Flags

- Man approaches and immediately touches your shoes without asking
- Moves very fast without discussing price
- Gets aggressive when you try to leave
- Keep walking if anyone crouches near your feet
- Never let anyone touch your belongings without discussing a price first

■ How to Avoid

- Keep walking if anyone crouches near your feet
 - Never let anyone touch your belongings without discussing a price first
 - Research common scams before visiting this area
-

The Donut/Street Food Bait

Once you've taken a bite, she demands a wildly inflated price — sometimes forcing you to pay for the whole basket. If you refuse, she causes a scene, drawing a crowd and relying on your embarrassment to extract payment.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor approaches you specifically and hands you food without asking
- Smiles very broadly while approaching
- Price is not stated upfront
- Don't accept any food or items handed to you on the street
- If something is pressed into your hands, hand it back immediately without tasting

■ How to Avoid

- Don't accept any food or items handed to you on the street
 - If something is pressed into your hands, hand it back immediately without tasting
 - Research common scams before visiting this area
-

The Cyclo Tourist Price

After the ride, the driver demands 10x that amount, claiming the price was per minute or that you misunderstood. He may grab your bag or block your path while demanding payment, knowing you probably don't want a public confrontation.

■ Red Flags

- Driver quotes a suspiciously cheap price
- Price is vague — 'per minute' not mentioned upfront
- Driver becomes aggressive at drop-off
- Always agree on a total price, route, and duration before getting in
- Write the agreed price down and show the driver

■ How to Avoid

- Always agree on a total price, route, and duration before getting in
 - Write the agreed price down and show the driver
 - Consider using Grab (ride-hailing app) instead
-

The Fake Tour Package

The pictures show beautiful boats and private cabins. When you arrive at the dock, you're herded onto a completely different, far cheaper vessel than advertised. Complaints go nowhere and refunds are impossible — you're stuck on the boat for two days.

■ Red Flags

- Price is significantly cheaper than competitors
- Agency can't provide the exact boat name or registration
- Booking is casual with no proper contract
- Book Halong Bay tours through verified operators on TripAdvisor
- Ask for the exact vessel name and look it up before paying

■ How to Avoid

- Book Halong Bay tours through verified operators on TripAdvisor
 - Ask for the exact vessel name and look it up before paying
 - Read recent reviews from the past 2-3 months
-

The Taxi Meter Trick

■ ■ *Noi Bai Airport, Old Quarter* You grab what looks like a legitimate taxi from the airport or hotel, and the meter is running — great. But when you arrive, the fare is staggering. The driver either had the meter running on a higher tariff setting, or the meter itself was tampered. Some drivers refuse to turn on the meter at all and then demand a huge flat fee at the destination. *Red Flags* Driver quotes a price before getting in (likely inflated) Meter ticks unusually fast Driver takes a very long route *How to Avoid* Use Grab (Vietnam's Uber equivalent) — fixed price before you get in If taking a taxi, only use Mai Linh or Vinasun green taxis with verifiable meters *Research common scams before visiting this area* ■ *What to Do If You Get Scammed* ■ *File a Police Report* Go to the nearest Vietnamese Police (Công An) station. Call 113. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at hanoi.gov.vn. ■ *Cancel Your Cards* Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ *Lost Passport?* Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 7 Lang Ha Street, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi. For emergencies: +84 24 3850-5000. ■ *Track Your Device* If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. *Frequently Asked Questions Is Hanoi safe for tourists?* ▼

But when you arrive, the fare is staggering. The driver either had the meter running on a higher tariff setting, or the meter itself was tampered. Some drivers refuse to turn on the meter at all and then demand a huge flat fee at the destination.

■ Red Flags

- Driver quotes a price before getting in (likely inflated)
- Meter ticks unusually fast
- Driver takes a very long route
- Use Grab (Vietnam's Uber equivalent) — fixed price before you get in
- If taking a taxi, only use Mai Linh or Vinasun green taxis with verifiable meters

■ How to Avoid

- Use Grab (Vietnam's Uber equivalent) — fixed price before you get in
- If taking a taxi, only use Mai Linh or Vinasun green taxis with verifiable meters

- Research common scams before visiting this area
-

■ Ho Chi Minh City

6 scams documented • Vietnam

Motorbike Bag Snatching

You're walking along a busy street in District 1 with your bag over one shoulder or your phone in your hand when a motorbike comes up from behind and the passenger grabs your belongings in one swift movement. It's fast, violent, and sometimes causes injury if the bag strap doesn't break. Ben Thanh Market area and tourist walking streets are prime targets, especially at night.

■ Red Flags

- Walking near curb with bags on street side
- Holding phone openly while walking in tourist areas
- Two people on one motorbike moving slowly near pedestrians
- Always wear bags across your body with the bag on the side away from traffic
- Keep your phone in your pocket when walking — use it in cafes

■ How to Avoid

- Always wear bags across your body with the bag on the side away from traffic
 - Keep your phone in your pocket when walking — use it in cafes
 - Walk with your bag on the building side, not the road side
-

Xe Ôm Price Bait-and-Switch

You hop on and he takes you on a confusing route through narrow alleys. Upon arrival, he demands 200,000 VND, claiming you misunderstood, the price was per kilometer, or the 'tourist rate' is different. You're far from home and he has your luggage on the bike.

■ Red Flags

- Price quoted feels suspiciously cheap compared to Grab app estimates
- Driver who doesn't confirm destination clearly before starting
- Driver who takes an unusually long or complex route
- Use Grab for all motorbike and car transport in Ho Chi Minh City — price is fixed upfront
- If using informal xe ôm, agree on price in writing (show on phone calculator) before riding

■ How to Avoid

- Use Grab for all motorbike and car transport in Ho Chi Minh City — price is fixed upfront
 - If using informal xe ôm, agree on price in writing (show on phone calculator) before riding
 - Never let a driver put your luggage in a separate container you can't access
-

Cyclo Overcharging

You agree and enjoy the ride. At the end, the driver pulls out a price list that says the price is per person — you assumed it was for the whole ride — and if you're a couple, the charge is now doubled. He then adds extra charges for 'photo stops' you made along the way.

■ Red Flags

- Price quoted without specifying 'per person' or 'total'
- Driver suggesting stops you didn't plan

- Tour that seems significantly longer than the agreed time
- Always confirm 'total price' explicitly for the whole agreed route
- Get it written on paper with the driver's signature if possible

■ How to Avoid

- Always confirm 'total price' explicitly for the whole agreed route
 - Get it written on paper with the driver's signature if possible
 - 30-minute District 1 cyclo tour should be roughly 100,000-150,000 VND total
-

Shoe Shine Ambush

Within seconds he's applied polish and is buffing away. You try to stop him but he insists he's almost done. When finished, he demands \$10-20 for the unsolicited service. This escalates quickly if you don't pay, with shouting that draws attention.

■ Red Flags

- Anyone approaching your feet without permission
- Service started without agreement on price or consent
- Trust your instincts — if something feels off, walk away
- Keep moving and say 'no' firmly if anyone approaches your feet
- If it happens, offer 20,000-30,000 VND maximum — that's a fair local price

■ How to Avoid

- Keep moving and say 'no' firmly if anyone approaches your feet
 - If it happens, offer 20,000-30,000 VND maximum — that's a fair local price
 - Wear trainers or sandals to make you a less attractive target for this scam
-

Fake Tourist Information Office

Inside, friendly staff offer to book tours, transport, and tickets on your behalf. The prices seem official and reasonable. But the tours they sell are overpriced, often don't match the description, or the commission goes entirely to the 'office' with no added value. Some also upsell travel insurance or visas that aren't legitimate.

■ Red Flags

- Tourist office not on official government listings
- Staff who push specific tours or transport providers exclusively
- Prices for tours that are significantly higher than what your hotel quotes
- The official tourist info center is at 39 Le Thanh Ton Street — check the government website
- Book tours through your hotel or reputable online platforms

■ How to Avoid

- The official tourist info center is at 39 Le Thanh Ton Street — check the government website
 - Book tours through your hotel or reputable online platforms
 - For official government services (visas, etc.), only use immigration.gov.vn
-

Counterfeit Cash Change

■ ■ *Markets, street food stalls, unlicensed exchange* You pay for food or shopping with a larger VND note and receive change, but mixed in are badly ... You pay for food or shopping with a larger VND note and receive change, but mixed in are badly printed counterfeit bills. Vietnamese currency is unfamiliar to most tourists, especially in dim restaurant lighting, making counterfeits hard to spot in the moment. Some street vendors also give short change knowing tourists can't quickly do VND mental arithmetic. *Red Flags* Change received in dim lighting without opportunity to check Bills that feel slightly different or lighter than usual Vendor who counts change for you very quickly *How to Avoid* Exchange money at official

banks or hotel desks — never on the street Learn what authentic VND feels like — run your thumb over the holographic strip Use cashless payment where possible, or pay with exact change to avoid the issue ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Vietnamese Police (Công An) station. Call 113. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at hanoi.gov.vn. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 7 Lang Ha Street, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi. For emergencies: +84 24 3850-5000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **Frequently Asked Questions** Is Ho Chi Minh City safe for tourists? ▼

You pay for food or shopping with a larger VND note and receive change, but mixed in are badly printed counterfeit bills. Vietnamese currency is unfamiliar to most tourists, especially in dim restaurant lighting, making counterfeits hard to spot in the moment. Some street vendors also give short change knowing tourists can't quickly do VND mental arithmetic.

■ Red Flags

- Change received in dim lighting without opportunity to check
- Bills that feel slightly different or lighter than usual
- Vendor who counts change for you very quickly
- Exchange money at official banks or hotel desks — never on the street
- Learn what authentic VND feels like — run your thumb over the holographic strip

■ How to Avoid

- Exchange money at official banks or hotel desks — never on the street
 - Learn what authentic VND feels like — run your thumb over the holographic strip
 - Use cashless payment where possible, or pay with exact change to avoid the issue
-

■■ Hoi An

5 scams documented • Vietnam

The Tailor Shop Bait-and-Switch

You pick premium fabric and a design from a catalog. The fitting looks great. But when you pick up the final product, the fabric feels different, the stitching is loose, and the buttons are cheap plastic. The shop insists it's the same fabric. Some shops use quality material for the fitting and swap in cheaper stuff for the final product.

■ Red Flags

- Extremely low prices compared to other shops
- Won't let you mark or photograph the fabric you chose
- Rush you through the final fitting
- No refund or alteration policy
- Use shops recommended by your hotel or with consistent Google reviews

■ How to Avoid

- Use shops recommended by your hotel or with consistent Google reviews
 - Photograph the exact fabric bolt and take a small cutting as reference
 - Always do a proper final fitting before paying the balance
 - Reputable shops: Yaly Couture, Bebe, A Dong Silk are consistently reviewed
-

The Currency Note Switch

The vendor quickly palms it and shows you a 20,000 VND note (~\$0.80) claiming that's what you gave them. Vietnamese dong notes look similar in dim lighting — the 500k and 20k notes are close in color. You're now being asked to pay again.

■ Red Flags

- Quick hand movements when accepting your payment
- Claim you gave a much smaller denomination
- Poor lighting at the transaction point
- State the denomination out loud as you hand it over: 'This is 500,000'
- Use a phone flashlight to verify notes in dim shops

■ How to Avoid

- State the denomination out loud as you hand it over: 'This is 500,000'
 - Use a phone flashlight to verify notes in dim shops
 - Pay by card or Grab where possible
 - Familiarize yourself with VND note sizes — larger notes are physically bigger
-

The Photo-Op Water Buffalo

Great Instagram content! After the photo, he demands 200,000-500,000 VND (\$8-20). Refuse and he follows you on foot for an uncomfortable distance. The buffalo is essentially a prop, and the 'farmer' does this all day.

■ Red Flags

- Overly enthusiastic invitation to interact with animals
- No price mentioned before the photo
- Located on a route popular with cycling tourists
- Ask 'Bao nhieu?' (How much?) before any interaction
- 20,000-50,000 VND is a fair photo fee if you want the shot

■ How to Avoid

- Ask 'Bao nhieu?' (How much?) before any interaction
 - 20,000-50,000 VND is a fair photo fee if you want the shot
 - Decline firmly with a smile and keep cycling
 - The further from Old Town, the more genuine the interactions
-

The Lantern Boat Price Surge

A woman at the dock offers a boat ride for 50,000 VND per person. You agree and climb in. After a five-minute paddle, she hands you a paper lantern to float on the river and then demands an additional 100,000 VND for the lantern 'ceremony.' When you return to shore, she expects another 50,000 VND tip, claiming it's customary. Your 50,000 VND ride has become 200,000 VND. On the 14th of each lunar month during the Full Moon Festival, prices double again.

■ Red Flags

- Boat operator quotes a low price but doesn't mention lanterns are extra
- No price board or official signage at the dock
- Operator becomes emotional or aggressive about tips at the end
- Price changes mid-ride after you're already on the water
- Agree on the total price including lanterns before boarding

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on the total price including lanterns before boarding

- Standard fair price is 50,000-100,000 VND total per person including one lantern
- Book through your hotel for a fixed-price evening boat experience
- Walk to quieter docks away from An Hoi Bridge for less pressure and better prices

The Basket Boat Ride Bait-and-Switch

■ ■ *Thu Bon River, Cam Thanh coconut village, boat docks near An Hoi Bridge* A woman near the river offers a 15-minute basket boat ride for two people at 150,000 VND -- a ... A woman near the river offers a 15-minute basket boat ride for two people at 150,000 VND -- a seemingly reasonable price. She leads you to a different person who leads you to yet another person at the actual boat dock. Once on the water, the boat operator demands more money for every additional minute, insists on tips, and tries to sell you coconut juice and souvenirs. The 150,000 VND ride balloons to 500,000 VND or more. As r/VietNam users describe, the handoff chain means the person who quoted the price is never the person you pay, and each intermediary adds their own markup. **Red Flags** The person quoting the price hands you off to someone else at the dock The agreed price is only for a very short ride with extras costing more Once on the water, the boat operator demands tips or additional fees The boat operator claims the original price did not include return to shore Add-on activities like net fishing or singing are pushed aggressively once you are on the water **How to Avoid** Book boat rides through your hotel or a reputable tour operator with fixed prices Confirm the total price including all fees before getting on any boat Deal only with the boat operator directly, not intermediaries on the street Carry exact change so you can pay the agreed amount and nothing more If the price changes once on the water, politely insist on the original agreed amount ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Vietnamese Police (Công An) station. Call 113. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at hanoi.gov.vn. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 7 Lang Ha Street, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi. For emergencies: +84 24 3850-5000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in Vietnam** ■ ■

A woman near the river offers a 15-minute basket boat ride for two people at 150,000 VND -- a seemingly reasonable price. She leads you to a different person who leads you to yet another person at the actual boat dock. Once on the water, the boat operator demands more money for every additional minute, insists on tips, and tries to sell you coconut juice and souvenirs. The 150,000 VND ride balloons to 500,000 VND or more. As r/VietNam users describe, the handoff chain means the person who quoted the price is never the person you pay, and each intermediary adds their own markup.

■ Red Flags

- The person quoting the price hands you off to someone else at the dock
- The agreed price is only for a very short ride with extras costing more
- Once on the water, the boat operator demands tips or additional fees
- The boat operator claims the original price did not include return to shore
- Add-on activities like net fishing or singing are pushed aggressively once you are on the water

■ How to Avoid

- Book boat rides through your hotel or a reputable tour operator with fixed prices
- Confirm the total price including all fees before getting on any boat
- Deal only with the boat operator directly, not intermediaries on the street
- Carry exact change so you can pay the agreed amount and nothing more
- If the price changes once on the water, politely insist on the original agreed amount

■ ■ Hue

5 scams documented • Vietnam

The Cyclo Overtime Trap

You hop in and enjoy the Imperial City sights. After exactly one hour, you ask to return to your hotel. The driver suddenly can't understand you, pedals in the opposite direction, and stretches the ride to nearly two hours. At the end, he demands 400,000 VND for two hours and brings friends to back him up. Reddit users on r/vietnam say the key trick is that drivers pretend not to understand when you try to end the ride, effectively holding your time hostage.

■ Red Flags

- Driver agrees to an hourly rate but has no watch or timer visible
- Suddenly stops understanding English or Vietnamese when you ask to return
- Takes long detours through back alleys instead of returning directly
- Other cyclo drivers gather around at the end to support the demand
- Set a phone timer and show it to the driver when you agree on time

■ How to Avoid

- Set a phone timer and show it to the driver when you agree on time
 - Take a photo of the driver's license plate and face before starting
 - Agree on a fixed route rather than a time-based fare
 - Use Grab bike for point-to-point transport instead of cyclos
 - Pay the agreed amount, show the timer, and walk away confidently
-

The Dong Ba Market Cash Grab

The vendor spots your cash and offers to 'help' count out the right bills, since Vietnamese dong has so many zeroes. In the confusion of shuffling colorful notes, she pockets one or two large bills through sleight of hand, then returns the rest. You realize 500,000 VND is missing only later at your hotel. Travelers on r/vietnam warn that some Dong Ba vendors also communicate your spending to neighboring stalls, so prices rise as you move through the market.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor reaches for your wallet or cash to 'help' sort denominations
- Quick hand movements when handling your money
- Prices at subsequent stalls seem unusually high after your first purchase
- No prices displayed at food stalls
- Never let anyone else handle your money or wallet

■ How to Avoid

- Never let anyone else handle your money or wallet
 - Pre-sort small bills at your hotel so you can pay with exact change
 - Keep large bills in a separate pocket or money belt
 - Ask the price before ordering and confirm it verbally
 - Learn to recognize Vietnamese banknotes — 500,000 and 20,000 VND look similar in color
-

The Shoe Shine Snatch

You're walking along the Perfume River near Trang Tien Bridge when a man suddenly crouches and points at your shoes, exclaiming about a loose stitch or dirty sole. Before you can respond, he grabs your foot, yanks off your shoe, and starts polishing furiously. Two minutes later, he demands 200,000-500,000 VND for the unsolicited shine. If your shoe has a tiny scuff, he'll claim he performed a 'repair' and charge even more. Reddit users on r/solotravel say the only defense is to keep walking the moment someone looks at your shoes.

■ Red Flags

- Stranger suddenly crouches and points at your footwear
- Grabs your shoe or foot without permission
- Claims your shoe needs urgent repair or cleaning
- Price is never mentioned before the service begins
- Keep walking immediately if anyone approaches pointing at your shoes

■ How to Avoid

- Keep walking immediately if anyone approaches pointing at your shoes
 - Wear sandals to make the scam impractical
 - Say 'khong, cam on' (no thanks) firmly and do not stop
 - If they grab your shoe, demand it back loudly — they rely on quiet compliance
-

The Fake Taxi Meter

the green or white color scheme looks right. But the name is slightly different: 'Mai Lin' or 'Vina Sun' with a space. The meter ticks at triple speed, and your 65,000 VND ride to the city center costs 650,000 VND. These copycat companies use nearly identical branding and modified meters. Redditors on r/vietnam report that the fakes even park near the legitimate taxi line to confuse arriving passengers.

■ Red Flags

- Company name is slightly misspelled on the door
- Meter seems to jump in large increments
- Car looks older or less maintained than typical branded taxis
- Driver is parked away from the official taxi queue
- Use Grab, Be, or Xanh SM apps for transparent pricing

■ How to Avoid

- Use Grab, Be, or Xanh SM apps for transparent pricing
 - If taking a taxi, verify the exact spelling: 'Mai Linh' or 'Vinasun'
 - Check the meter starts at the correct base fare (around 11,000-15,000 VND)
 - Note the license plate and driver ID displayed inside legitimate taxis
 - Pre-arrange airport pickup through your hotel
-

The Perfume River Boat Bait-and-Switch

■ ■ Perfume River, boat docks near Trang Tien Bridge and Thien Mu Pagoda You book a sunset dragon boat cruise on the Perfume River for 150,000 VND, expecting a scenic trip ... You book a sunset dragon boat cruise on the Perfume River for 150,000 VND, expecting a scenic trip past the Citadel and Thien Mu Pagoda with city lights. Instead, the boat anchors 10 minutes in and you're trapped for 45 minutes watching a mediocre traditional music performance you didn't sign up for. The crew then pushes overpriced drinks and demands tips. Some boat operators charge separately for 'docking fees' at pagoda stops that were supposedly included. Tripadvisor and Reddit reviews describe the experience as a classic bait-and-switch where the promised cruise never actually happens. Red Flags Extremely cheap cruise price compared to others Vague description of what the cruise includes Boat anchors shortly after departure for a 'show' Crew pushes drinks and donation boxes during the performance Additional fees appear for stops that were promised as included How to Avoid Book through reputable tour companies with verified Tripadvisor reviews Ask specifically if the boat will be moving the entire time or if there are stops Clarify all included stops and fees in writing before boarding Consider hiring a private boat for a small group — negotiate the full route upfront Read recent reviews mentioning the specific boat operator by name ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Vietnamese Police (Công An) station. Call 113. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at hanoi.gov.vn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 7 Lang Ha Street, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi. For emergencies: +84 24 3850-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself

— share the location with police instead. [More Scam Guides](#) [More in Vietnam](#) ■■

You book a sunset dragon boat cruise on the Perfume River for 150,000 VND, expecting a scenic trip past the Citadel and Thien Mu Pagoda with city lights. Instead, the boat anchors 10 minutes in and you're trapped for 45 minutes watching a mediocre traditional music performance you didn't sign up for. The crew then pushes overpriced drinks and demands tips. Some boat operators charge separately for 'docking fees' at pagoda stops that were supposedly included. Tripadvisor and Reddit reviews describe the experience as a classic bait-and-switch where the promised cruise never actually happens.

■ Red Flags

- Extremely cheap cruise price compared to others
- Vague description of what the cruise includes
- Boat anchors shortly after departure for a 'show'
- Crew pushes drinks and donation boxes during the performance
- Additional fees appear for stops that were promised as included

■ How to Avoid

- Book through reputable tour companies with verified Tripadvisor reviews
 - Ask specifically if the boat will be moving the entire time or if there are stops
 - Clarify all included stops and fees in writing before boarding
 - Consider hiring a private boat for a small group — negotiate the full route upfront
 - Read recent reviews mentioning the specific boat operator by name
-

■■ Nha Trang

6 scams documented • Vietnam

The Mandatory Peanut Bowl

Before you even order, a bowl of peanuts and a plate of herbs appears. You nibble while browsing the menu. The bill arrives with a 30,000-50,000 VND charge for the 'complimentary' peanuts and herbs. Every table gets them, every tourist gets charged. Locals know to wave them away immediately.

■ Red Flags

- Food arrives before you order anything
- Items placed on the table without explanation
- Bill includes items you didn't ask for
- Wave away any food that arrives before you order — say 'Không cần' (Don't need)
- If it appears, don't touch it — untouched items are harder to charge for

■ How to Avoid

- Wave away any food that arrives before you order — say 'Không cần' (Don't need)
 - If it appears, don't touch it — untouched items are harder to charge for
 - Check your bill line by line before paying
 - This applies to bread, peanuts, herbs, and wet towels at restaurants across Vietnam
-

The Motorbike Police Impound Scam

You don't have a Vietnamese driver's license (your international one doesn't cover motorbikes). They impound the bike and issue a 'fine' of 1,000,000-2,000,000 VND — payable cash on the spot to retrieve the bike. This is a legitimate stop (riding without a valid license IS illegal) but the fine is inflated and goes straight into their

pocket.

■ Red Flags

- You're driving a motorbike without a valid Vietnamese motorcycle license
- Police target roads popular with tourists
- Fine is demanded in cash immediately
- An international driving permit does NOT cover motorbikes in Vietnam unless you have a motorcycle endorsement
- Use Grab or taxis instead of renting a motorbike

■ How to Avoid

- An international driving permit does NOT cover motorbikes in Vietnam unless you have a motorcycle endorsement
 - Use Grab or taxis instead of renting a motorbike
 - If stopped, ask for an official receipt — legitimate fines are 100,000-400,000 VND at the police station
 - Many travelers risk it, but the legal exposure is real
-

Restaurant Seafood Overcharging

He brings a tray of prawns and crab to your table, praising the day's catch, and you nod along. No prices are discussed. When the bill arrives, the seafood platter alone costs 2,000,000 VND — roughly eighty-five dollars — for what would cost a quarter of that at a local restaurant one block from the beach. Questioning the bill brings the manager, who points to a small laminated card in Vietnamese that lists the prices. This bait-and-switch pricing has been reported across multiple Nha Trang travel forums.

■ Red Flags

- The waiter brings food to your table before you order it and does not state the price
- Prices are listed only in Vietnamese or not listed at all on the English menu
- The restaurant is right on the tourist beachfront with aggressive hawkers outside
- Seafood is sold by weight with no scale visible to the customer
- The restaurant has few or no Vietnamese customers dining there

■ How to Avoid

- Always ask for a menu with prices before ordering — if one does not exist, leave
 - For seafood sold by weight, ask to see the scale and confirm the price per kilogram before cooking
 - Eat at restaurants one or two blocks off the beachfront where locals dine — prices drop dramatically
 - Check Google Maps reviews for recent tourist reports of overcharging before sitting down
 - Take a photo of the menu with prices before ordering as evidence in case of a dispute
-

Hotel Booking Scam via Fake Facebook Pages

The page has the hotel's real photos, name, and logo. You message them and they offer a special rate if you transfer the deposit directly. You send 50 million VND. On arrival, the real hotel has no record of your booking. In 2025, Vietnamese police reported that four tourists lost a combined 50 million VND to scammers impersonating the Masova Hotel in Nha Trang through cloned Facebook pages.

■ Red Flags

- The hotel page messaged you first or responded suspiciously fast with a special deal
- Payment is requested via direct bank transfer rather than through the hotel's official booking system
- The Facebook page was created recently and has far fewer followers than the real hotel page
- The deal seems significantly cheaper than rates listed on Booking.com or Agoda for the same hotel
- The page URL does not match the hotel's official website or has extra characters added

■ How to Avoid

- Book only through verified platforms like Booking.com, Agoda, or the hotel's official website
- Never send deposits via direct bank transfer to a Facebook page or messenger contact
- Call the hotel directly using the phone number from their official website to confirm any booking
- Cross-reference the Facebook page against the hotel's website — the official page is always linked there
- If a deal seems too good to be true compared to rates on major platforms, it almost certainly is

The Cyclo and Taxi Meter Manipulation

The driver says ten thousand dong. At the end, he demands ten thousand dong per minute, not for the entire ride, turning your expected one-dollar trip into a fifteen-dollar argument. Taxi drivers pull a similar trick with modified meters that tick at double speed, or they simply refuse to use the meter and quote a tourist price. The Vietnamese dong's large denominations — with bills up to 500,000 — make it easy for drivers to exploit confusion around zeros.

■ Red Flags

- The cyclo driver agrees to a suspiciously low price without clarifying what unit the price covers
- The taxi meter seems to be ticking faster than normal or the driver starts it before you board
- The driver takes an indirect route through back streets rather than the obvious main road
- You are quoted a price in dong that sounds low but is actually per minute or per person rather than total
- The driver claims the meter is broken and insists on a flat fare

■ How to Avoid

- Use the Grab app for taxis — it shows a fixed price before you book and tracks the route via GPS
- For cyclos, agree on the total price for the entire ride in writing or on your phone calculator before starting
- Carry small bills in denominations of 10,000 to 50,000 dong for local transport so you can pay the exact agreed amount
- Mai Linh and Vinasun are the two most reputable taxi companies in Nha Trang — look for their branding
- Familiarize yourself with Vietnamese dong denominations before arrival to avoid confusion

The Taxi-Restaurant Kickback Trap

■ ■ Tourist restaurants in the Nha Trang beachfront area, particularly along Tran Phu Street and near Nha Trang train station You ask a taxi driver for a restaurant recommendation. He takes you to a specific seafood place where the prices seem reasonable at first. But the bill arrives with items you did not order, inflated weights on seafood priced by the kilo, and mandatory charges for wet towels and condiments. A Reddit user on r/Vietnam described being borderline robbed in Nha Trang, and another post described a train station taxi quoting 90,000 dong then demanding far more at drop-off. TripAdvisor documented a restaurant that works with taxi drivers on commissions, blocks stairways, and refuses to let customers leave until they pay the inflated bill. Vinasun (white taxis) and Mai Linh (green taxis) are the only reliable companies. Red Flags A taxi driver enthusiastically recommends a specific restaurant rather than the one you requested The restaurant does not have a printed menu or the prices are only in Vietnamese Bowls of peanuts, wet towels, and side dishes appear at your table without you ordering them Seafood is weighed after cooking rather than before, making it impossible to verify the weight Staff become hostile when you question the bill or try to leave without paying the full amount How to Avoid Choose restaurants independently using Google Maps reviews and never follow a taxi driver's recommendation Use only Vinasun (white), Mai Linh (green), or the Grab app for taxis in Nha Trang Ask for a menu with prices before ordering and photograph it for reference when the bill arrives Tell the waiter immediately that you do not want peanuts, wet towels, or any items you did not order For seafood, insist on seeing the raw weight before cooking and confirm the per-kilo price in writing ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Vietnamese Police (Công An) station. Call 113. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at hanoi.gov.vn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 7 Lang Ha Street, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi. For emergencies: +84 24 3850-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Vietnam ■■

He takes you to a specific seafood place where the prices seem reasonable at first. But the bill arrives with items you did not order, inflated weights on seafood priced by the kilo, and mandatory charges for wet towels and condiments. A Reddit user on r/Vietnam described being borderline robbed in Nha Trang, and another post described a train station taxi quoting 90,000 dong then demanding far more at drop-off. TripAdvisor documented a restaurant that works with taxi drivers on commissions, blocks stairways, and refuses to let customers leave until they pay the inflated bill. Vinasun (whit...

■ Red Flags

- A taxi driver enthusiastically recommends a specific restaurant rather than the one you requested
- The restaurant does not have a printed menu or the prices are only in Vietnamese
- Bowls of peanuts, wet towels, and side dishes appear at your table without you ordering them
- Seafood is weighed after cooking rather than before, making it impossible to verify the weight
- Staff become hostile when you question the bill or try to leave without paying the full amount

■ How to Avoid

- Choose restaurants independently using Google Maps reviews and never follow a taxi driver's recommendation
 - Use only Vinasun (white), Mai Linh (green), or the Grab app for taxis in Nha Trang
 - Ask for a menu with prices before ordering and photograph it for reference when the bill arrives
 - Tell the waiter immediately that you do not want peanuts, wet towels, or any items you did not order
 - For seafood, insist on seeing the raw weight before cooking and confirm the per-kilo price in writing
-

■■ Sapa

6 scams documented • Vietnam

The Persistent Hmong Guide Guilt Trip

Within minutes, Hmong women and children fall in step with you, chatting, sharing stories, and helping you over slippery sections. After 2-3 hours of what feels like a genuine friendship, they present handicrafts for sale — scarves, bracelets, embroidery — at 3-5x market prices. The emotional connection makes it nearly impossible to say no. If you buy one thing, three more appear.

■ Red Flags

- Locals join your trek without being hired
- Conversation is friendly but steers toward how difficult their life is
- Handicrafts presented after hours of walking together
- Prices higher than identical items in Sapa town market
- Book an official guide through your hotel or a licensed trekking company

■ How to Avoid

- Book an official guide through your hotel or a licensed trekking company
 - It's fine to buy a small item if you want — but know that prices in Sapa market are 50-70% less
 - A polite but firm 'No, thank you' is perfectly acceptable
 - If you want to help, donate to a registered NGO rather than buying overpriced goods
-

The Fake Trekking Package

A budget agency sells a '2-day homestay trek' for \$15 including meals, guide, and an 'authentic homestay.' The trek is actually a 4-hour walk to a concrete guesthouse (not a homestay), dinner is instant noodles, and the guide doubles as a handicraft seller. Meanwhile, legitimate operators charge \$40-60 for the same itinerary with real homestays and proper meals.

■ Red Flags

- Price under \$25 for a 2-day trek with meals and homestay
- No specific homestay or village named in the booking
- Agent can't show photos of the actual homestay accommodation
- Pay \$40-60 for a legitimate 2-day trek through Sapa Sisters, Sapa O'Chau, or Topas Ecolodge
- Ask to see specific photos of the homestay before booking

■ How to Avoid

- Pay \$40-60 for a legitimate 2-day trek through Sapa Sisters, Sapa O'Chau, or Topas Ecolodge
 - Ask to see specific photos of the homestay before booking
 - Read recent Google and TripAdvisor reviews of the exact operator
 - Real homestays have names — if they can't tell you where you're sleeping, don't book
-

The Homestay Bait-and-Switch

A driver takes you to a concrete building on the edge of town. Your mountain view is an air conditioning unit and a bare wall. The agent's office is now closed, and the homestay owner says this is the correct booking. Many budget homestays advertise idyllic photos from premium properties but deliver bare rooms in unfinished buildings far from the trekking areas.

■ Red Flags

- The booking agent cannot provide the exact address or photos that match the listing
- The price is significantly lower than similar homestays advertised online
- You are driven to a location that does not match the description or photos you saw
- The agent insists on full cash payment upfront with no refund policy
- The homestay has no reviews or only reviews from the past few weeks

■ How to Avoid

- Book directly through verified platforms like Booking.com or Agoda with real guest reviews
 - Request the exact GPS location before booking and check it against Google Maps satellite view
 - Pay only a deposit upfront and the remainder upon arrival and satisfaction with the room
 - Ask to see the actual room before committing if you book through a street agent
 - Read recent reviews specifically mentioning whether photos match reality
-

The Overpriced Grab Driver at Lao Cai Station

Drivers swarm the exit shouting prices. A Grab driver approaches and tells you to cancel your app booking because the price is wrong and he will take you for a better rate of 50,000 VND per person. The actual Grab fare is about 30,000 VND. Some drivers at the station are not affiliated with any app at all and charge 200,000 to 400,000 VND for the forty-minute ride to Sapa that should cost 80,000 to 100,000 VND by shared minibus.

■ Red Flags

- A driver asks you to cancel your existing Grab or app booking
- The quoted fare is double or more what the Grab app shows
- Multiple drivers quote the same inflated price suggesting coordination
- The driver does not have a visible Grab or app-affiliated identifier on the vehicle
- Someone claims the regular bus or minibus service is not running today

■ How to Avoid

- Book your Grab or Mai Linh taxi through the app before exiting the station
- Use the scheduled minibus services from Lao Cai to Sapa which run regularly and cost 80,000 to 100,000 VND

- Arrange a hotel pickup in advance as most Sapa hotels offer transfers from Lao Cai station
 - Decline offers from drivers who approach you at the station exit
 - If no app drivers are available, negotiate firmly and agree on the total price before entering the vehicle
-

The Forced Souvenir Purchase After Village Visit

She leads you through stunning rice terraces and into her village, sharing stories along the way. At the end, she brings you to a home filled with embroidered bags, scarves, and bracelets. The emotional pressure to buy is intense. You feel obligated after hours of her time and hospitality. The items are priced at 200,000 to 500,000 VND each, far above the 50,000 to 100,000 VND you would pay in Sapa market for identical products.

■ Red Flags

- A guide offers a free walk with no upfront discussion of costs or expectations
- The trek ends at a specific home or shop rather than back in Sapa town
- The guide becomes visibly upset or guilted you if you do not want to buy anything
- The handicraft prices are significantly higher than identical items sold in Sapa town market
- Multiple women from the village appear simultaneously to show you their goods

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on all costs including guide fees upfront before starting any trek
 - Book treks through established operators who pay their guides a fair wage
 - If you want to support the community, buy directly from the Sapa market where prices are competitive
 - Set a budget beforehand and politely decline purchases beyond that amount
 - It is fine to buy a small item as a thank-you but do not feel pressured into expensive purchases
-

The Lao Cai Station Private Car Switcheroo

■ ■ Lao Cai railway station exit, parking area outside the station, route from Lao Cai to Sapa town You arrive at Lao Cai station after the overnight train from Hanoi. You booked a private car transfer through your hotel or a booking platform for 350,000 VND. At the station exit, a man with a sign bearing your name leads you to a minibus instead, saying the private car 'had a problem.' He demands 650,000 VND for the shared van. When you protest, he says take it or wait. Multiple Reddit posts on r/vietnam documented this exact bait-and-switch: travelers paid double the agreed fare because the driver who met them at Lao Cai was not the one they booked. One post titled 'Defrauded in Sapa even when booked through official channels' described paying 650,000 VND for a ride that should have cost 350,000. Red Flags The person meeting you at the station directs you to a different vehicle than what was booked They claim the original car 'broke down' or 'is not available' and offer a substitute at a higher price The driver demands payment before starting the journey rather than at the destination The quoted price is significantly more than the 300,000-400,000 VND range for a standard Lao Cai to Sapa transfer There is no written confirmation matching the driver's name with your booking How to Avoid Book transfers through Grab or a verified hotel shuttle rather than through third-party agents Get your hotel to send a confirmation with the specific driver's name, phone number, and vehicle description Have your hotel's phone number ready so you can call them from the station to verify the driver's identity Agree on the exact price in writing before departure and do not pay until you arrive in Sapa If the vehicle or price does not match your booking, refuse the ride and book a Grab car directly from your phone ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Vietnamese Police (Công An) station. Call 113. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at hanoi.gov.vn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 7 Lang Ha Street, Ba Dinh District, Hanoi. For emergencies: +84 24 3850-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Vietnam ■ ■

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■ Red Flags

- The person meeting you at the station directs you to a different vehicle than what was booked
- They claim the original car 'broke down' or 'is not available' and offer a substitute at a higher price
- The driver demands payment before starting the journey rather than at the destination
- The quoted price is significantly more than the 300,000-400,000 VND range for a standard Lao Cai to Sapa transfer
- There is no written confirmation matching the driver's name with your booking

■ How to Avoid

- Book transfers through Grab or a verified hotel shuttle rather than through third-party agents
- Get your hotel to send a confirmation with the specific driver's name, phone number, and vehicle description
- Have your hotel's phone number ready so you can call them from the station to verify the driver's identity
- Agree on the exact price in writing before departure and do not pay until you arrive in Sapa
- If the vehicle or price does not match your booking, refuse the ride and book a Grab car directly from your phone

East Asia

25 cities • 136 scams • 6 countries

■ China

■■ Beijing

8 scams documented • China

Airport Black Taxi Ambush

You're bleary-eyed, phone barely charged, bags heavy. Before you even reach the official taxi stand, a guy in a vest materializes out of nowhere: 'Meter taxi! No wait!' He's persistent, friendly, speaking just enough English to be reassuring. The car looks normal. You get in. The meter is running — technically — but it's jumping in suspicious lurches. A 40-minute ride to a central hotel that should cost ¥120–180 ticks up to ¥600 by the time you arrive. When you protest, the driver shrugs: 'Night rate. Traffic surcharge. Special road.' You're alone, exhausted, at an unfamiliar address. You p...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you inside the terminal offering a taxi before you reach the official rank
- Driver quotes a flat price upfront before the trip begins
- Meter seems to jump in unusually large increments
- Driver mentions 'special route,' 'night surcharge,' or 'VIP road' mid-trip
- Car has no official Beijing taxi markings or license plate display in the back

■ How to Avoid

- Walk past every person offering taxis inside the terminal and proceed to the clearly marked official taxi rank outside
 - Set up DiDi (China's Uber) before landing — it works with international cards via the tourist version
 - Use the Airport Express metro line into the city for about ¥25 — completely reliable
 - If taking a taxi, confirm the meter starts at the standard base fare (¥13) before driving off
 - Screenshot your destination address in Chinese characters to show the driver — it reduces miscommunication excuses
-

Art Student / Art Teacher Gallery Trap

They speak excellent English — suspiciously good, actually. They introduce themselves as an art teacher or art student whose gallery is just around the corner, and they'd love to show you some work. It would mean so much to them if you came to see it. They're so genuine, so charming. Inside the 'gallery,' you're handed tea and surrounded by paintings. The pressure to buy escalates gradually — the work is 'very rare,' this is a 'special price just for you.' Pieces that cost a few yuan to produce are priced at hundreds or thousands. Some tourists leave having spent ¥5,000+ on what turns out t...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches unprompted and strikes up a conversation about art, culture, or 'student exhibitions'
- Exceptionally fluent English from someone claiming to be a casual passerby
- The invitation is to a 'gallery nearby' that happens to be down a side street
- Prices for artwork have no listed tags — they're quoted verbally and vary wildly
- Staff circle you and create social pressure, refilling tea and blocking the exit path naturally

■ How to Avoid

- Politely but firmly decline any invitation to visit a gallery from a street stranger
 - If engaged, say you have no cash and nowhere to pay — interest will evaporate instantly
 - If you want to buy art, visit established galleries or the 798 Art District where prices are transparent
 - Do not follow strangers down side streets, no matter how friendly or cultivated they seem
 - Remember: legitimate art students don't need to recruit customers on tourist streets
-

Tinder / Dating App Bar Trap

They're friendly, even romantic. They pick the venue: a bar called something like 'Ace Club' or 'Sky Lounge.' You meet at a mall, they walk you in. The menu looks pricey but one beer at ¥280 feels manageable. Except your date doesn't stop ordering. Beer after beer, and every time you glance at the bill it's grown. 'Don't worry,' they say. When the final bill arrives it's ¥3,000, ¥5,000, sometimes more. You've 'agreed' to the prices by being there. The staff is large and there are bouncers near the exit. You pay. This scam was described in vivid detail by a user on r/travelchina under 'Falli...

■ Red Flags

- A match on a dating app who immediately wants to meet and immediately picks the venue
- Extremely confident about meeting the same day despite being strangers
- The chosen venue is a bar or club in a tourist area you don't know
- The drinks menu has no prices displayed or prices that seem high but vague
- Your date orders repeatedly without discussing cost or hesitating

■ How to Avoid

- Never let a stranger pick the venue for a first meeting in a city you don't know
- Meet in a coffee shop or busy restaurant where you can easily see menu prices upfront
- If you do go to a bar, agree on a spending limit with your date before ordering anything
- Research the venue name before going — if it doesn't appear on Google Maps or Dianping, walk out

- If you feel pressured to stay or threatened when trying to leave, call local police (110)
-

Great Wall 'All-Inclusive' Budget Tour

The bus picks you up, and before you get anywhere near the Wall, it stops at a jade factory. Then a silk showroom. Then a 'traditional arts' outlet. Each stop involves a prolonged high-pressure sales pitch from staff who work on commission. Refusing to buy gets you dirty looks and passive-aggressive treatment for the rest of the tour. By the time you finally reach the Wall, you have maybe two hours before you're herded back onto the bus. The 'lunch' is a perfunctory bowl of rice. The ¥100 has been recouped ten times over through the commission the driver earns at each shop, whether you buy ...

■ Red Flags

- Tour price seems impossibly low for what's promised (under ¥200 for a full-day Great Wall trip)
- Tout approaches you on the street rather than through a registered agency or hostel
- The tour description includes vague 'cultural stops' or 'local workshops' with no names
- No printed itinerary or contract is provided before you board the vehicle
- The pickup is informal — a private minivan rather than a licensed tour bus

■ How to Avoid

- Book Great Wall tours through your hostel's front desk or reputable platforms like Viator or GetYourGuide
 - Take the direct public bus to Mutianyu (Bus 867 from Dongzhimen) — it's reliable and cheap
 - If a tour includes any shopping stops, that's a signal it's commission-based — pay more for a clean itinerary
 - Research Mutianyu over Badaling — it's less crowded, equally beautiful, and more foreigner-friendly
 - Go on a weekday and arrive early — the Wall experience is infinitely better without the weekend crush
-

Fake Peking Duck Restaurant Swap

A friendly local or fellow 'tourist' near Tiananmen or the hutongs strikes up a conversation and recommends a Peking duck restaurant — they even offer to walk you there. The place looks authentic, has Chinese menus, and the prices seem reasonable. But a look at your bill reveals you've been charged for dishes you didn't order, expensive teas that were 'complimentary,' or premium duck that was swapped for a lesser bird. In some versions, touts outside famous duck restaurants steer you to nearby fakes with nearly identical signage — 'Quan Ju De' vs 'Quan Jude' in slightly different characters...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger proactively recommends a restaurant and insists on walking you there
- The menu has an English version with different prices from the Chinese version
- Complimentary tea, napkins, or nuts are placed on the table without asking — these often appear on the bill
- Restaurant signage looks similar but not identical to a famous establishment
- Waiter rushes you to order without letting you review the menu carefully

■ How to Avoid

- Use Dianping (大众点评) app to find and verify restaurants — look for places with thousands of Chinese reviews
 - Book famous restaurants like Da Dong or Quanjude directly through their official app or WeChat
 - Always ask for and review an itemized bill in Chinese characters before paying
 - Send back any dish you didn't order and clarify 'complimentary' items before consuming them
 - Never follow a stranger's restaurant recommendation in a high-tourist area without independent verification
-

Temple of Heaven Massage / Guide Ambush

A friendly older woman sits next to you and starts chatting through a mix of gestures and broken English. She seems genuinely curious about where you're from. Then it emerges she's offering a traditional massage or a 'guided tour' of the park — the price is never mentioned upfront. After the service concludes, the price revealed is outrageous: ¥500 for a 15-minute back rub, ¥800 for a 'tour' that lasted 30 minutes. The operator becomes insistent and blocks your path when you try to leave. In worse iterations, there are accomplices nearby who create a subtle intimidation atmosphere until pay...

■ Red Flags

- Someone initiates unsolicited conversation at a tourist attraction and subtly transitions to offering a paid service
- No price is ever mentioned until after the service has begun or concluded
- The 'guide' or 'masseuse' has no ID badge or affiliation with the park
- Other people seem to be watching the interaction from a short distance
- The area is relatively quiet with few other tourists around

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline any unsolicited offers for services in parks — a simple 'no thanks' and walking away works
 - If you want a guide for Beijing's parks, book through a licensed agency or your hotel concierge
 - Do not begin any service without agreeing on a price in writing or seeing a printed menu first
 - Stick to areas with other tourists nearby where opportunistic scammers are less likely to push too hard
 - If you feel cornered, walk towards a uniformed park security officer
-

Rickshaw Hutong Tour Price Flip

Sounds like a deal — hutongs are exactly the kind of authentic old-Beijing experience you came for. You hop in. The driver is charming, knows the neighborhood, pedals you past courtyards and old lanes. You're enjoying it. At the end of the tour, when you hand over ¥30, the driver explodes in protest. The price was ¥30 per person — you have two people, so it's ¥60. Or the ¥30 was the deposit, and the full fare is ¥300. Or there's a 'hutong entrance fee' of ¥200 that he 'forgot to mention.' The disagreement happens in a narrow lane with no one else around. This is one of the most-reported sca...

■ Red Flags

- The price quoted seems suspiciously low for the service described (under ¥100 for a long tour)
- No written confirmation or printed price list is shown before the ride begins
- The driver is vague about exactly what's included — 'no extra costs, everything included'
- The tour ends in a narrow alley far from busy streets
- There's mention of a 'traditional tea house stop' or 'special courtyard visit' partway through

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on the total price for all passengers in writing (even on a piece of paper) before boarding
 - Book hutong tours through your hostel or a licensed tour company with clear pricing
 - Use DiDi or walk — the hutongs are navigable on foot with Gaode Maps
 - Confirm whether any stops involve additional entry fees before agreeing to the tour
 - Keep small denominations of cash and only produce the agreed amount when the tour ends
-

The Tea House Scam

■ ■ Streets around the Forbidden City south gate, Wangfujing pedestrian street, Tiananmen Square perimeter, Nanluoguxiang hutong A well-dressed young woman approaches you near the Forbidden City and says she is also a tourist from another province. She suggests getting tea together at a traditional tea house to experience Chinese culture. You follow her to a small teahouse down an alley. The tea ceremony is beautiful, with multiple varieties served in tiny cups. When the bill arrives, it reads 2,000 to 5,000 yuan. Your new friend vanishes. Consumer Rescue documented one victim who was billed 4,704 US dollars at a Beijing teahouse. The Roaming Renegades' 2026 guide and TravelChinaCheaper both

list the tea house scam as Beijing's number-one tourist trap, active for over a decade and still thriving despite widespread publicity. Red Flags A stranger, often a young woman, approaches you near a major tourist site and strikes up a friendly conversation in good English They suggest visiting a tea house or tea ceremony together as a cultural experience The tea house is down a side street or alley rather than on a main commercial road No menu with prices is shown before the tea service begins Your companion seems overly familiar with the staff and they greet each other warmly How to Avoid Politely decline any invitation to visit a tea house from someone you just met on the street, no matter how friendly they seem If you want a tea ceremony experience, book one through your hotel or a reputable tour company with verified reviews Never enter a restaurant or tea house without seeing a menu with prices first Be especially wary near the Forbidden City, Tiananmen Square, and Wangfujing, where the scam is most concentrated If you are caught in a tea house with an outrageous bill, call the police at 110 rather than paying; the scam is illegal and police are aware of it ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Chinese Police (警察局) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mps.gov.cn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in China ■■

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■ Red Flags

- A stranger, often a young woman, approaches you near a major tourist site and strikes up a friendly conversation in good English
- They suggest visiting a tea house or tea ceremony together as a cultural experience
- The tea house is down a side street or alley rather than on a main commercial road
- No menu with prices is shown before the tea service begins
- Your companion seems overly familiar with the staff and they greet each other warmly

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline any invitation to visit a tea house from someone you just met on the street, no matter how friendly they seem
- If you want a tea ceremony experience, book one through your hotel or a reputable tour company with verified reviews
- Never enter a restaurant or tea house without seeing a menu with prices first
- Be especially wary near the Forbidden City, Tiananmen Square, and Wangfujing, where the scam is most concentrated
- If you are caught in a tea house with an outrageous bill, call the police at 110 rather than paying; the scam is illegal and police are aware of it

■■ Chengdu

7 scams documented • China

The Mascot Photo Ambush

You're walking across the bridge outside Dujiangyan park when a group of young people in Disney mascot costumes wave you over for photos. They seem friendly, posing with tourists and making goofy gestures. After you snap a few selfies, they flash a small sign reading '10 RMB' and gesture for payment. When you try to

negotiate or walk away, they signal that they're deaf and mute, making communication impossible. Meanwhile, more costumed performers surround you, each expecting their own payment. Tripadvisor reviewers flagged this exact setup at Dujiangyan, and r/china travelers confirm simila...

■ Red Flags

- Costumed characters on bridges or sidewalks outside (not inside) attractions
- They initiate contact and pose with you before discussing any price
- Small payment sign only revealed after photos are taken
- Performers claim to be deaf/mute when you try to negotiate
- Multiple performers surround you at once, each wanting separate payment

■ How to Avoid

- Politely wave off anyone in costume who approaches you outside an attraction
 - If you do want a photo, agree on a price before posing
 - Keep walking and avoid eye contact — they target tourists who slow down
 - Travel with a companion who can help you disengage from persistent performers
 - Remember that legitimate performers work inside the parks, not outside on bridges
-

The Tea Ceremony Invitation

You're admiring the giant panda sculpture on Chunxi Road when two well-dressed university students approach, saying they're art majors and want to practice English. After a friendly conversation, they suggest visiting a 'traditional Sichuan tea ceremony' nearby. The tea house has no English menu, and a smiling attendant pours you several rounds of oolong in tiny cups. The bill: 1,200 RMB. Protest, and the owner materializes with security. As r/china posters warn, Chengdu's relaxed teahouse culture makes this scam especially convincing because going for tea actually is a normal local activit...

■ Red Flags

- Young 'students' approach you with flattery and perfect English
- They suggest a specific tea house, bar, or cultural venue
- The venue has no posted prices and no English menu
- Your new friends seem overly comfortable with the staff
- Tea is served in extremely small cups, maximizing per-serving charges

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow strangers to a venue they recommend, no matter how friendly they seem
 - Visit Chengdu's legitimate teahouses independently — People's Park Heming Tea House is famous and honest
 - If someone suggests tea, suggest a teahouse you've researched instead
 - A polite 'bù yòng, xièxiè' and continued walking is your best defense
 - Real students won't pressure you or suggest expensive outings
-

The Jinli Street Price Gouging

Instead, every few meters another vendor pushes an overpriced drink, mediocre snack, or photo op with a costumed performer that costs extra. A bowl of dandan noodles that costs 12 RMB elsewhere is 45 RMB here. Souvenirs are mass-produced trinkets marked up 300-500%. As Tripadvisor reviewers consistently note, the entire street is designed for extracting maximum money from tourists. R/china users describe it as a 'soulless commercial zone' with nothing authentic left.

■ Red Flags

- Prices are 3-5 times higher than identical items elsewhere in Chengdu

- Food tastes bland and mass-produced compared to local restaurants
- Every other shop sells identical souvenirs
- Aggressive vendors calling out to every passing tourist
- Photo ops with performers have hidden charges revealed after the photo

■ How to Avoid

- Visit Jinli for a quick walk-through but eat and shop elsewhere
 - Head to Kuanzhai Alley or local side streets for more authentic (and cheaper) food
 - Try actual Chengdu street food on Jianbing Street or near Sichuan University campus
 - If you buy anything, bargain hard — opening prices assume you won't
 - Ask your hotel for restaurant recommendations away from tourist zones
-

The Fake Panda Volunteer Program

You pay 1,500-2,000 RMB for a 'panda volunteer experience' at Dujiangyan Panda Base, expecting hands-on time with the animals. The reality: eight hours of shoveling panda dung, breaking bamboo sticks on the road, watching a BBC documentary, and eating a mediocre cafeteria lunch. Your actual panda contact consists of ten seconds pushing a bamboo stalk through a cage to a panda who barely notices you. As Tripadvisor reviewers warn, the program was once legitimate but is now widely criticized as overpriced manual labor disguised as an animal encounter. Some unlicensed travel agencies still adv...

■ Red Flags

- Agency advertises 'holding a panda' or 'panda hugging' — this is no longer offered
- Price seems steep for a 'volunteer' program (legitimate volunteering is usually free)
- Itinerary details are vague about actual panda interaction time
- The agency can't provide recent photos or reviews from participants
- They pressure you to book immediately with a 'limited spots' claim

■ How to Avoid

- Visit the Chengdu Research Base of Giant Panda Breeding instead for 55 RMB general admission
 - If you want close encounters, research which programs still offer them and read very recent reviews
 - Book directly through official panda base websites, not third-party street agencies
 - Understand that 'volunteer' programs are largely manual labor with minimal animal contact
 - Don't trust agencies advertising panda-holding photos — that ended years ago
-

The Black Taxi Airport Rip-Off

Before you even reach the exit, a man in casual clothes offers to carry your bags and drive you to your hotel 'quickly and cheaply.' He quotes 400 RMB for a ride that should cost 150-200 RMB by metered taxi or about 120 RMB via Didi. His car has no meter, no roof light, and no license. During the ride, the dashboard GPS takes a scenic route through random toll roads to pad the fare. As r/china users note, black taxis thrive at Chengdu's airports because Tianfu is new and far from the city center, making tourists uncertain about fair pricing.

■ Red Flags

- Driver approaches you inside the terminal building
- No taxi markings, roof light, or official license display
- Quotes a flat rate instead of offering to use the meter
- Claims Didi doesn't work at the airport or that no taxis are available
- Takes toll roads or expressways without explaining the extra charges

■ How to Avoid

- Use Didi to book a ride from the airport with transparent pricing
- Follow signs to the official taxi queue on the ground floor
- Take the Airport Express bus or metro line to the city center (much cheaper)
- Know that Tianfu Airport to downtown Chengdu is about 50km and should cost 150-200 RMB metered
- If a driver approaches you first, they are almost always unlicensed

The Hotpot Hidden Menu Overcharge

The server hands you a tablet menu in English with higher prices than the Chinese version. Premium beef slices are 88 RMB on your screen but 48 RMB on the Chinese menu at the next table. Add-ons like dipping sauces, napkins, and 'pot base fees' pile onto the bill without clear disclosure. By the end, your 200 RMB dinner costs 450 RMB. Travelers on r/china advise asking for the Chinese menu or using your phone's camera translation, because tourist-area restaurants routinely maintain two pricing tiers.

■ Red Flags

- English menu has different (higher) prices than the Chinese version
- Unexplained charges for pot base, sauces, or 'service fees' appear on the bill
- Server steers you toward the most expensive items enthusiastically
- Restaurant is directly on a major tourist street with English signage
- No prices visible before ordering or prices only shown in the app

■ How to Avoid

- Ask for the Chinese menu and use Google Translate camera mode to read it
- Eat where locals eat — look for restaurants a few blocks off the tourist streets
- Check the bill line by line and question any unfamiliar charges
- Use Dianping (China's Yelp) to find well-reviewed hotpot places with honest pricing
- Confirm the pot base fee and any mandatory charges before ordering

The Xinjiang Nut Cake Overweight Trap

■ Chunxi Road, Tianfu Square pedestrian area, tourist streets near Wenshu Monastery A vendor selling dense Uyghur-style nut cakes wrapped in cling film beckons you over and offers a free taste. When you express interest, the vendor cuts a piece before you agree on a price. The cake is incredibly dense, so even a thin slice weighs far more than you would expect by looking at it. The vendor points to a small sign showing prices per kilo and demands 200-500 RMB for a palm-sized chunk. If you refuse to pay, multiple vendors from neighboring stalls surround you and block your exit. R/travelchina users describe this as one of China's most persistent scams, reported across Chengdu, Beijing, and Shanghai for over a decade. Red Flags Vendor cuts the cake before you agree on any price Pricing is listed per kilogram, not per piece The cake is unusually dense and heavy for its small size Multiple vendors close in when you try to negotiate or leave A small 'no returns on cut items' sign appears only after cutting How to Avoid Politely decline any free samples from street nut cake vendors If interested in local snacks, buy packaged goods from supermarkets instead Never let a vendor cut anything before you agree on a total price Walk away confidently if pressured -- they rarely follow you far If surrounded, remain calm and offer 20-30 RMB for the piece and leave ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Chinese Police (警察局) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mps.gov.cn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in China ■■

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China's most persistent scams, reported across Chengdu, Beijing, and Shanghai for over a decade.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor cuts the cake before you agree on any price
- Pricing is listed per kilogram, not per piece
- The cake is unusually dense and heavy for its small size
- Multiple vendors close in when you try to negotiate or leave
- A small 'no returns on cut items' sign appears only after cutting

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline any free samples from street nut cake vendors
 - If interested in local snacks, buy packaged goods from supermarkets instead
 - Never let a vendor cut anything before you agree on a total price
 - Walk away confidently if pressured -- they rarely follow you far
 - If surrounded, remain calm and offer 20-30 RMB for the piece and leave
-

■■ Guangzhou

6 scams documented • China

The Tea House Ambush

After chatting for a few minutes, they suggest visiting a nearby teahouse to experience an authentic Cantonese tea ceremony. The place looks charming and traditional. A server brings out pot after pot of fragrant oolong and pu'er, each described as a rare regional variety. You're enjoying yourself until the bill arrives: 2,800 RMB for what amounted to a few cups of tea. The students suddenly vanish or claim they'll 'pay their share' but never do. As Reddit's r/China community warns, the students are employees of the teahouse earning commission on every tourist they reel in.

■ Red Flags

- Strangers approach you specifically to 'practice English' near tourist areas
- They suggest a teahouse or restaurant they know rather than letting you choose
- The teahouse has no visible English menu and no prices listed
- Your new friends seem overly familiar with the staff and ordering process
- Multiple varieties of tea are poured without you requesting or approving them

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline invitations from strangers to visit any restaurant or teahouse they suggest
 - If you want a tea ceremony experience, book through your hotel or a reputable tour platform
 - Always ask for a menu with prices before ordering anything in a teahouse
 - Suggest meeting at a public chain like Heytea or Nayuki if you genuinely want to chat with locals
 - If trapped with a large bill, call 110 (police) -- officers regularly intervene in known teahouse scams
-

The Rigged Taxi Meter

The driver is polite and starts the meter, which reads the normal 12 RMB starting fare. But something feels off -- the numbers are climbing suspiciously fast. By the time you reach your hotel in Tianhe, a ride that should cost 80-100 RMB shows 280 RMB. The driver has either tampered with the meter or taken a deliberately circuitous route through highway toll sections. Some drivers also pull the counterfeit bill switch: they take your 100 RMB note, quickly swap it for a fake, then hand it back claiming you gave them counterfeit money. Redditors on

r/travel flag Guangzhou airport taxis as a p...

■ Red Flags

- The driver insists on a flat fare instead of running the meter
- The meter digits increase noticeably faster than normal driving speed would warrant
- The driver takes highway routes with tolls for what should be a surface-street journey
- They hand back a bill claiming it is counterfeit and demand a replacement
- The driver refuses to give you a printed receipt at the end of the ride

■ How to Avoid

- Use the Didi app (China's Uber) instead of hailing taxis -- fares are calculated by GPS and prepaid
 - If taking a taxi, photograph the driver's ID card displayed on the dashboard before departure
 - Mark your banknotes with a small pen mark before handing them over to prevent bill-switching
 - Use the Guangzhou Metro from the airport to city center for a flat 7 RMB fare on the Airport Express
 - Request a receipt ('fapiao') at the end of every ride -- drivers with tampered meters often refuse
-

The Jade Museum Detour

Your group tour makes an unscheduled stop at what the guide calls a 'jade cultural museum.' Inside, a polished presenter explains the history of jade in Chinese culture, holding up translucent green stones to the light in a genuinely impressive demonstration. Then you're funneled into the showroom, where bracelets start at 3,000 RMB and pendants at 1,500 RMB. The guide hovers nearby, subtly encouraging purchases. What Reddit's r/China community confirms is that these 'museums' are commission shops -- the jade is cheap jadeite or synthetic material marked up 500-1,000 percent, and your guide...

■ Red Flags

- Your tour guide or driver makes an unplanned stop at a 'cultural center' or 'museum'
- The presentation seamlessly transitions from education to a sales pitch
- Prices are quoted verbally with no visible price tags on items
- Staff claim the jade is certified but certificates look generic or lack verifiable serial numbers
- The salesperson offers dramatic discounts when you hesitate, dropping from 3,000 to 800 RMB instantly

■ How to Avoid

- Decline all unscheduled shop stops on group tours -- you are never obligated to enter or buy
 - Research legitimate jade markets like Heping East Road and HuaLinyu Jade Market before your trip
 - Understand that authentic high-grade jade (nephrite or jadeite A-grade) comes with GIA or NGTC certificates
 - If you buy jade, insist on a certificate from the National Gemstone Testing Centre (NGTC) verifiable online
 - Book tours through reputable agencies that guarantee no-shopping itineraries
-

The Street Money Exchange

You're in the Xiaobei district, known for its international trading community, when a man offers to exchange your US dollars at a rate better than any bank. He counts out crisp RMB notes on a small table, splitting them into neat piles. While you count one pile, he casually picks up another to 'recount' it -- and palms several bills. By the time you walk away, you're short 300-500 RMB. When you realize the discrepancy and return, the man and his table have vanished. As travelers on Reddit's r/solotravel warn, street money changers in Guangzhou use professional sleight-of-hand techniques per...

■ Red Flags

- Someone offers exchange rates significantly better than bank rates
- They split your money into multiple piles instead of counting it once clearly

- They repeatedly take back notes to 'recount' or 'straighten' the bills
- The exchange happens on the street or in a back room rather than at a licensed counter
- Lookouts or associates stand nearby watching for police

■ How to Avoid

- Exchange money only at bank branches, hotel front desks, or official licensed exchange counters
- Use ATMs from major banks like ICBC, Bank of China, or China Construction Bank for the best rates
- Set up WeChat Pay or Alipay with an international card before arriving -- cash is increasingly unnecessary in Guangzhou
- If you must use a money changer, count all bills yourself in one continuous count before handing over your currency
- Report illegal street money changers to police at 110

The Fake Electronics Deal

You visit one of Guangzhou's famous electronics wholesale markets, drawn by what looks like incredible deals on smartphones, headphones, and tablets. A vendor demonstrates a perfect-looking iPhone, shows you the box with all the accessories, and quotes a price that's 40 percent below retail. You pay, and the vendor carefully wraps and bags the product. Back at your hotel, you open the sealed box to find a different, much cheaper phone inside -- or the same demo phone but with a cracked screen swapped during the bagging process. Reddit's r/shenzhen and r/China forums are full of stories about...

■ Red Flags

- Prices are dramatically below retail -- genuine discounts in wholesale markets are typically 10-20 percent, not 40-60 percent
- The vendor insists on wrapping or boxing the item themselves out of your sight
- They rush the transaction and discourage you from inspecting the boxed product
- The product has no verifiable serial number or the serial doesn't match when checked online
- Payment is cash-only with no receipt or invoice offered

■ How to Avoid

- Open and inspect every product in front of the vendor before paying, checking serial numbers against the box
- Use your own bag and never let the product out of your sight between demonstration and payment
- Research current retail prices before visiting so you can spot impossible deals
- Buy electronics from authorized retailers like JD.com or official brand stores in Tianhe for guaranteed authenticity
- If a deal seems too good to be true in a wholesale market, it almost certainly is

The Hair Salon Overcharge

■ ■ *Shopping streets in Tianhe and Liwan districts* You stop into a sleek-looking hair salon near your hotel for a simple wash and cut. A stylist greets you warmly and suggests a few 'complimentary' extras -- a conditioning treatment, a scalp massage, maybe some product to protect against the Guangzhou humidity. Everything seems pleasant until the bill arrives: 1,200 RMB for what was supposed to be a basic haircut. Each of those 'complimentary' treatments had premium prices attached, and products were applied to your hair without your explicit consent to be charged. As reported on Lemon8 and Reddit travel forums, this salon overcharge scam has caught multiple tourists in Guangzhou off guard, with bills reaching the equivalent of nearly \$200. **Red Flags** The salon offers free extras or complimentary treatments without showing you a price list Staff apply products or begin treatments without confirming the cost first There is no visible price menu in English, or the menu is vague about what is included The stylist keeps suggesting add-ons during the service in a casual, low-pressure way The final bill includes line items you never explicitly agreed to **How to Avoid** Ask for a complete price list before any service begins and confirm the total cost in writing Decline all add-ons and extras unless you have confirmed the price and agreed to them Use translation apps to read Chinese-language menus and price boards before sitting down Visit chain salons with standardized pricing, such as Watsons or well-reviewed spots on Dianping (Dazhong Dianping app) If presented with an inflated bill, calmly refuse to pay for services you did not agree to and ask to speak with a manager ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Chinese Police (警察局) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120

(Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at [mps.gov.cn](https://www.mps.gov.cn). ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. [More Scam Guides](#) [More in China](#) ■■

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■ Red Flags

- The salon offers free extras or complimentary treatments without showing you a price list
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- The final bill includes line items you never explicitly agreed to

■ How to Avoid

- Ask for a complete price list before any service begins and confirm the total cost in writing
 - Decline all add-ons and extras unless you have confirmed the price and agreed to them
 - Use translation apps to read Chinese-language menus and price boards before sitting down
 - Visit chain salons with standardized pricing, such as Watsons or well-reviewed spots on Dianping (Dazhong Dianping app)
 - If presented with an inflated bill, calmly refuse to pay for services you did not agree to and ask to speak with a manager
-

■■ Guilin

7 scams documented • China

The Tea House Friendship Trap

You're strolling along West Street in Yangshuo when two friendly young locals approach, complimenting your outfit and asking where you're from. After a few minutes of chat, they suggest you join them for a 'traditional Chinese tea tasting' at a nearby tea house. The tea comes in tiny cups and the experience feels cultural and authentic. Then the bill arrives: 800-2,000 RMB for what amounted to a few sips. The staff blocks the door if you protest. As [r/china](#) users confirm, this is China's most widespread tourist scam, and Guilin's tourist areas are prime hunting grounds.

■ Red Flags

- Strangers approach you with excellent English and excessive friendliness
- They suggest visiting a tea house, bar, or karaoke place they 'just discovered'
- The venue has no English menu and no visible price list
- Staff seems to know your new 'friends' personally
- The tea is served in impossibly small cups to maximize the per-cup charge

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow strangers to a bar, tea house, or restaurant they suggest

- If you want tea, find your own tea house independently and ask prices first
 - Politely decline with a firm 'bù yòng, xièxiè' (no thanks) and keep walking
 - Real Chinese students won't invite a stranger to an expensive venue
 - If trapped, call police (110) rather than paying an outrageous bill
-

The Black Taxi at the Station

You step out of Guilin North Station with your bags and unlicensed drivers immediately swarm you, quoting 200-300 RMB for a ride to your hotel in the city center. A legitimate metered taxi would cost 50-80 RMB for the same trip. If you take the bait, the driver may also route you through commission-paying restaurants or hotels. Some r/china travelers report being driven to remote spots where the driver's associates appeared and demanded additional money. The scariest part is there's no meter, no license, and no accountability if something goes wrong.

■ Red Flags

- Driver approaches you inside the station rather than waiting in the taxi queue
- No official taxi markings, light on roof, or visible license
- Driver quotes a flat fee instead of using a meter
- They insist their car is the only option or that taxis aren't available
- Driver wants to take you to a 'better' hotel than the one you booked

■ How to Avoid

- Use the official taxi queue and insist on metered rides (say '■■■■')
 - Book rides through Didi (China's Uber) before leaving the station
 - Take the city bus or airport shuttle for a fraction of the cost
 - If a driver approaches you first, they're almost certainly unlicensed
 - Note the taxi license plate and report rigged meters via 12345 hotline
-

The Bicycle Passport Hostage

The rental shop demands your passport as a deposit instead of cash. When you return the bike hours later, the owner claims there's new damage — a scratch on the frame, a bent spoke — and refuses to return your passport until you pay 500-2,000 RMB for 'repairs.' Some shops use duplicate keys to move or sabotage the bike while you're swimming at a river stop. Without your passport, you're trapped. Redditors on r/china call this one of Yangshuo's most infuriating scams.

■ Red Flags

- Shop demands your passport instead of a cash deposit
- No written rental agreement specifying conditions
- The bike already has visible wear but nobody documents it
- Shop is located on a side street with no clear signage or reviews
- Owner is vague about return conditions or damage policies

■ How to Avoid

- Never hand over your passport as a deposit — offer cash (200-500 RMB) instead
 - Photograph the bike from every angle before riding away
 - Use reputable rental shops recommended by your hotel with online reviews
 - Get a written agreement specifying the rental terms and damage conditions
 - Xijie's travel agency offers rentals for 20 RMB/day with a 200 RMB cash deposit
-

The Li River 'Premium Upgrade' Shakedown

After merging into a coach of 80 tourists, you're shuttled to the dock where your raft driver casually mentions that for an extra 100 RMB you can ride a raft 'without a noisy motor' and stop for photos with a cormorant fisherman. If you decline, your raft speeds through the best scenery without stopping. Twenty minutes of your ride is eaten up by photo-op upsells. As travelers discuss on [r/travel](#), the whole operation is designed to extract maximum money — the 'premium' experience is just what the basic ride should have been.

■ Red Flags

- Tour operator merges small groups into massive coach loads
- Tourist stickers are placed on you for tracking purposes
- Raft driver offers 'upgrades' at the dock that weren't mentioned in booking
- The raft has a loud motor despite being marketed as a 'bamboo raft'
- Photo stops with fishermen or props take up significant ride time

■ How to Avoid

- Book directly through your hotel or a reputable local agency, not street touts
 - Consider the Yulong River bamboo rafts instead — quieter, less commercialized
 - Clarify what's included (motor or paddle, stops, duration) before paying
 - Decline the upsells firmly — they're not worth the extra money
 - Check recent reviews on TripAdvisor or Xiaohongshu for honest assessments
-

The Counterfeit Money Switcheroo

The driver takes it, makes a quick hand movement below the seat, then turns around holding a wrinkled bill and says 'this is fake, give me a real one.' He's palmed your real note and swapped in a counterfeit. Now you're out 200 RMB — the fake bill plus the replacement. As [r/china](#) users explain, this switch trick is one of the oldest scams in Chinese cities and targets anyone paying with large bills. The 100 RMB note is the most commonly counterfeited denomination.

■ Red Flags

- Driver or vendor handles your bill below their line of sight
- Quick hand movements before claiming your money is counterfeit
- They insist on cash and seem disappointed when you offer mobile payment
- The 'fake' bill they show you looks noticeably different from yours
- This happens immediately after you hand over a large denomination note

■ How to Avoid

- Use WeChat Pay or Alipay for all transactions whenever possible
 - If using cash, pay with small bills (10 or 20 RMB notes)
 - Note the serial number on large bills before handing them over
 - Watch the vendor's hands continuously during the transaction
 - Get familiar with security features of RMB notes (watermarks, security threads)
-

The 'Attraction Closed' Redirect

He shakes his head solemnly and says it's 'closed for renovation' or 'no access today.' But don't worry — he knows an even better place nearby, or maybe a nice tea house where you can wait. The attraction isn't actually closed; the driver simply earns commission from wherever he redirects you. Some [r/china](#) travelers report being told multiple attractions were closed in a single day, all conveniently rerouting to the same jade shop. It's one of Yangshuo's most frustrating cons because it sounds so believable.

■ Red Flags

- Driver claims your destination is closed without evidence
- He immediately suggests an alternative destination
- The alternative happens to be a shop, tea house, or lesser-known attraction
- Multiple attractions are supposedly all 'closed today'
- He discourages you from calling the attraction to verify

■ How to Avoid

- Call the attraction directly or check their official WeChat/website before believing a driver
- Book through your hotel, which has no incentive to redirect you
- Use Didi so the destination is locked in and the driver can't detour
- Ask other tourists at your hotel if they visited the same place recently
- If the driver insists it's closed, get out and find another ride

The Art Student Landscape Painting Hustle

■ ■ Along the Li River walk, Elephant Trunk Hill park area, Zhengyang Pedestrian Street Near the Li River or Elephant Trunk Hill, a young person introduces themselves as a local art ... Near the Li River or Elephant Trunk Hill, a young person introduces themselves as a local art student and shows you beautiful landscape paintings they claim to have painted themselves. They offer you one as a 'gift between friends' or at a special student price of 200-400 RMB. The paintings are mass-produced prints sold wholesale for 5-10 RMB each. As an r/travelchina poster recounted, an American traveler in Guilin was suckered into paying 40 dollars for a crappy Guilin landscape painting because the 'artist' claimed he was a struggling student. The same paintings appear at every tourist site across China. Red Flags A young person claims to be an art student and approaches you near a tourist site Multiple identical paintings are available in their portfolio They claim to have painted the landscapes themselves but cannot discuss technique The paintings are on cheap paper or canvas with no gallery affiliation They offer a 'special price just for you' that is still far above the actual value How to Avoid Politely decline and keep walking -- genuine art students display in galleries, not on the street If you want Guilin landscape art, buy from established shops where you can verify authenticity Do not feel guilty about declining -- they approach dozens of tourists daily Check the back of the painting for print marks indicating mass production A genuine original painting would cost far more than what street sellers charge ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Chinese Police (警察局) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mps.gov.cn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in China ■■

Near the Li River or Elephant Trunk Hill, a young person introduces themselves as a local art student and shows you beautiful landscape paintings they claim to have painted themselves. They offer you one as a 'gift between friends' or at a special student price of 200-400 RMB. The paintings are mass-produced prints sold wholesale for 5-10 RMB each. As an r/travelchina poster recounted, an American traveler in Guilin was suckered into paying 40 dollars for a crappy Guilin landscape painting because the 'artist' claimed he was a struggling student. The same paintings appear at every tourist s...

■ Red Flags

- A young person claims to be an art student and approaches you near a tourist site
- Multiple identical paintings are available in their portfolio
- They claim to have painted the landscapes themselves but cannot discuss technique
- The paintings are on cheap paper or canvas with no gallery affiliation
- They offer a 'special price just for you' that is still far above the actual value

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline and keep walking -- genuine art students display in galleries, not on the street
- If you want Guilin landscape art, buy from established shops where you can verify authenticity

- Do not feel guilty about declining -- they approach dozens of tourists daily
 - Check the back of the painting for print marks indicating mass production
 - A genuine original painting would cost far more than what street sellers charge
-

■■ Hangzhou

6 scams documented • China

The Tea Ceremony Trap

You're admiring the willow-lined shores of West Lake when two cheerful young people approach, introducing themselves as university students eager to practice English. After twenty minutes of friendly conversation about Hangzhou culture, they suggest visiting a 'traditional teahouse' nearby for an authentic ceremony. The teahouse is serene, the decor beautiful. A server brings out six varieties of tea in delicate cups while explaining each one. It's mesmerizing. Then the bill lands: 3,200 RMB -- about \$440. The students look horrified and offer to split it, but somehow they've already slippe...

■ Red Flags

- Friendly strangers approach specifically to practice English near West Lake or Hefang Street
- They suggest a specific teahouse they know rather than a public or well-known chain
- The teahouse has no English menu and no visible pricing for individual teas
- Multiple tea varieties are served without you requesting or approving each one
- Your new friends seem completely comfortable and familiar with the teahouse staff

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline all invitations from strangers to visit teahouses, restaurants, or bars near tourist sites
 - If you want an authentic tea experience, visit the China National Tea Museum near West Lake, which is free and legitimate
 - Always request a menu with prices before any tea is served, and agree to a maximum spend
 - Suggest meeting at a public chain like Starbucks or Heytea if you genuinely want to chat with locals
 - If trapped with an inflated bill, call 110 (police) -- they are experienced with this scam and will intervene
-

The Dragon Well Village Shopping Tour

The guide drives you through beautiful terraced tea fields, explaining how the world's most prized green tea is cultivated. Then you're brought to what they call 'the authentic Dragon Well production base.' Inside, a lengthy sales presentation begins, with staff claiming their tea is harvested from the original West Lake terroir. The prices range from 500 to 5,000 RMB per 100 grams. Here's what the Oreate AI Blog and tea industry reports reveal: genuine West Lake Longjing production is only 800-1,000 tons per year, but sales volume exceeds 3,000 tons -- meaning two-thirds of what's sold as ...

■ Red Flags

- Your tour guide drives you to a 'tea production base' that's actually a retail showroom
- The sales presentation lasts longer than the actual village tour
- Staff claim their tea is the genuine premium West Lake Longjing variety at prices that seem suspiciously 'discounted'
- You are pressure-tested with free tastings designed to create a sense of obligation
- The guide earns commission and is noticeably eager for you to purchase

■ How to Avoid

- Visit Longjing Village independently by public bus (route Y3 from Hangzhou city center) rather than on a tour
- Buy tea only from shops certified by the Hangzhou Tea Research Institute with verifiable origin labels

- Understand that genuine premium West Lake Longjing costs 2,000-10,000 RMB per 500g at certified outlets -- anything cheaper is likely counterfeit
 - Visit the China National Tea Museum for free educational exhibits about Longjing without sales pressure
 - If buying tea, purchase from reputable online retailers like Taobao's certified tea stores with verified reviews
-

The QR Code Payment Diversion

The transaction goes through smoothly and you collect your food. What you don't realize is that a scammer had pasted a counterfeit QR code sticker over the vendor's legitimate one. Your payment went to a thief's account, and the vendor will soon discover they received nothing. This scam works in the other direction too: at some locations, fake QR codes are placed on shared bike-rental stands and parking meters, redirecting your payment and potentially capturing your financial details. As South China Morning Post reported, QR code fraud caused an estimated US\$13 million in losses in Guangdong...

■ Red Flags

- The QR code appears to be a sticker placed on top of the vendor's original signage
- The payment confirmation shows a different merchant name than the shop you're paying
- The QR code is on a separate piece of paper rather than integrated into the vendor's display
- You're directed to scan a QR code in an unusual location like a parking meter or bike-share stand
- The vendor seems surprised when you show them your payment confirmation

■ How to Avoid

- Always verify the merchant name on the payment confirmation matches the shop you're paying before completing the transaction
 - Look for QR codes that appear to be stickers overlaying original ones -- peel them if suspicious or ask the vendor to verify
 - Pay in cash at small street vendors if you're unsure about QR code authenticity
 - Use the in-app scanning feature of WeChat Pay or Alipay rather than a generic camera scan, as it provides better verification
 - Report suspected QR code fraud to the vendor immediately and to the WeChat Pay or Alipay security hotline
-

The West Lake Rickshaw Ransom

You're walking along the Broken Bridge at West Lake when a pedicab driver offers a scenic ride around the lakeside paths. 'Only 20 kuai for a full tour,' he says with a grin. The ride is lovely -- weeping willows, pagodas, couples taking photos. Twenty minutes later, you arrive back at your starting point and the driver demands 200 RMB. He insists the original price was per section of the lake, and you've passed ten sections. When you protest, he blocks your path and shouts, attracting attention. As China travel guides and Reddit warn, rickshaw and pedicab drivers near West Lake are notorio...

■ Red Flags

- The driver quotes an unusually low price that seems too good for a full lakeside tour
- There is no written price card on the rickshaw, or the card is in Chinese only with ambiguous terms
- The driver doesn't specify whether the price is per person, per trip, or per kilometer
- During the ride, the driver takes detours through less-traveled paths away from other tourists
- The driver becomes loud and confrontational at the end of the ride

■ How to Avoid

- Walk or rent a public bicycle (Hangzhou's bike-share is excellent and cheap) to explore West Lake instead of taking rickshaws
- If taking a pedicab, agree on the total price in writing (even type it into your phone translator) before boarding

- Use the official West Lake sightseeing bus or electric boat tours with posted, fixed prices for lakeside transport
- Film or photograph the price negotiation on your phone as evidence of the agreed fare
- If harassed for an inflated fare, call 110 or walk toward the nearest police kiosk (there are several around West Lake)

The Fake Monk Blessing

You're approaching Lingyin Temple, one of China's most famous Buddhist monasteries, when a person in orange robes steps into your path. They place their palms together, bow, and press a red string bracelet or golden amulet into your hand. It feels like a genuine spiritual moment. Then a donation card appears, showing amounts from 100 to 500 RMB with check marks next to the higher amounts, implying previous donors gave generously. The 'monk' points insistently at the 200 RMB line. As China Discovery and Reddit's r/China document, fake monks are a nationwide phenomenon in China, and Hangzhou'...

■ Red Flags

- A person in monk robes approaches you outside the temple grounds rather than inside
- They immediately hand you an item (bracelet, amulet, card) before any conversation
- A donation card shows preset amounts with marks suggesting others paid generously
- The person cannot answer basic questions about Lingyin Temple or their monastic order
- They become persistent or follow you if you decline

■ How to Avoid

- Do not accept any items from people in monk robes outside of temple grounds
- Understand that authentic Buddhist monks at Lingyin Temple do not solicit donations on the street
- If you want to make a donation, do so inside the temple at official donation boxes
- Say 'Bu yao, xie xie' (No, thank you) firmly and keep walking without stopping
- Report persistent fake monks to temple security or the local police station near Lingyin

The 'Free Travel' Group Tour Trap

■ ■ *Tour desks at budget hotels and hostels near Hangzhou East Railway Station* You see a flyer at your hostel advertising a 'quality free travel' package: a full day exploring ... You see a flyer at your hostel advertising a 'quality free travel' package: a full day exploring Hangzhou's top sites including West Lake, Longjing Village, and Lingyin Temple for just 50 RMB. It's impossibly cheap, and that's exactly the problem. The tour is real, but as the Oreate AI Blog documented, the itinerary is a series of orchestrated shopping stops disguised as cultural visits. The 'tea village' is a sales room, the 'silk museum' is a factory outlet, and the 'herbal medicine center' is a high-pressure supplement shop. The guide receives commission on every purchase, and the actual sightseeing is rushed to minutes. By the end, the 'free tour' has cost participants hundreds in pressured purchases. Red Flags A full-day tour price is drastically below the cost of transport alone The itinerary includes vague stops like 'cultural centers' or 'production bases' alongside real attractions The tour is marketed through flyers at budget hotels rather than through licensed tourism platforms The operator is vague about exactly how much time will be spent at each attraction versus shops Other tourists on the same bus mention being similarly recruited from different budget hotels How to Avoid Budget-quality full-day tours of Hangzhou from reputable operators cost 300-500 RMB minimum -- anything under 100 RMB is subsidized by commission shops Book tours only through licensed platforms like Klook, GetYourGuide, or Ctrip with verified reviews Explore Hangzhou independently using the excellent Metro system and public buses for a fraction of the cost Ask the tour operator in writing to confirm the number of shopping stops -- legitimate tours allow zero or one maximum If your tour becomes a shopping marathon, refuse to enter shops and demand to be taken to the advertised attractions ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Chinese Police (警察局) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mps.gov.cn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in China ■ ■

You see a flyer at your hostel advertising a 'quality free travel' package: a full day exploring Hangzhou's top sites including West Lake, Longjing Village, and Lingyin Temple for just 50 RMB. It's impossibly cheap, and that's exactly the problem. The tour is real, but as the Oreate AI Blog documented, the itinerary is a series of orchestrated shopping stops disguised as cultural visits. The 'tea village' is a sales room, the 'silk museum' is a factory outlet, and the 'herbal medicine center' is a high-pressure supplement shop. The guide receives commission on every purchase, and the actual...

■ Red Flags

- A full-day tour price is drastically below the cost of transport alone
- The itinerary includes vague stops like 'cultural centers' or 'production bases' alongside real attractions
- The tour is marketed through flyers at budget hotels rather than through licensed tourism platforms
- The operator is vague about exactly how much time will be spent at each attraction versus shops
- Other tourists on the same bus mention being similarly recruited from different budget hotels

■ How to Avoid

- Budget-quality full-day tours of Hangzhou from reputable operators cost 300-500 RMB minimum -- anything under 100 RMB is subsidized by commission shops
 - Book tours only through licensed platforms like Klook, GetYourGuide, or Ctrip with verified reviews
 - Explore Hangzhou independently using the excellent Metro system and public buses for a fraction of the cost
 - Ask the tour operator in writing to confirm the number of shopping stops -- legitimate tours allow zero or one maximum
 - If your tour becomes a shopping marathon, refuse to enter shops and demand to be taken to the advertised attractions
-

■■ Kunming

6 scams documented • China

The Tea Ceremony Trap

After some pleasant conversation, they suggest visiting a traditional Yunnan tea house nearby. 'It is a cultural experience -- you must try Pu'er tea in Kunming!' Inside a quiet upstairs room, a woman in traditional dress performs an elaborate ceremony, pouring cup after cup of different aged teas. It feels authentic and special. Then the bill arrives: 1,500 RMB for what you thought were free samples. Your new friends vanish, and the staff block the door. As r/China and r/travel users warn repeatedly, the tea house scam is China's most notorious tourist con and thrives in Kunming's universi...

■ Red Flags

- Strangers approach you specifically to practice English and quickly suggest a tea house
- They lead you to a tea house you have never heard of, often on an upper floor or in a back alley
- The menu has no prices or the prices are in tiny print you cannot read
- You are served many small cups in rapid succession without ever being told the per-cup cost
- Your new friends seem oddly familiar with the staff and the ordering process

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline invitations from strangers to visit tea houses, bars, or karaoke -- this is almost always a scam
 - If you want a genuine tea experience, visit Kunming's Xionгда Tea City market where wholesale prices are transparent
 - Always ask for a menu with prices before sitting down at any tea house and confirm the total before drinking
 - Tell the scammers you are meeting friends nearby and walk away -- persistence is their tool
 - If trapped with an inflated bill, call the police (110) -- officers regularly deal with tea scam complaints in Kunming
-

The Jade Museum Hustle

Your group tour to the Stone Forest includes an unscheduled stop at a 'Yunnan Jade Cultural Museum.' Inside, a guide in a white coat gives a polished presentation about Burmese jade's healing properties and how Yunnan is the jade capital of China. Then you enter the showroom where pendants are priced at 5,000-50,000 RMB. Your tour guide lingers, nodding approvingly. What you do not realize, as Redditors on r/travelchina explain, is that most jade in these museum shops is cheap jadeite or synthetic material marked up ten to twenty times its real value. Your tour guide earns a 30-50 percent c...

■ Red Flags

- The tour makes an unscheduled stop at a museum or factory that was not on the itinerary
- The presenter wears a lab coat or official-seeming uniform to appear scientific
- Prices have no comparison point and items lack independent certification
- The tour guide encourages purchases and stays close to the cashier
- You are told this jade is only available at this location and cannot be found elsewhere

■ How to Avoid

- Book tours through reputable agencies and confirm the itinerary has no mandatory shopping stops
 - Never buy jade at tourist shopping stops -- prices are inflated by 500-1,000 percent
 - If you genuinely want jade, visit the regulated Kunming International Jewellery City where prices are competitive
 - Ask for a GIA or NGTC gemological certificate for any jade purchase over 500 RMB
 - Politely decline and wait on the tour bus -- you are not obligated to enter the shop or buy anything
-

The Rigged Taxi Meter

The driver starts the meter, which reads 8 RMB as expected. But the numbers climb abnormally fast, and by the time you reach your hotel in the city center -- a 25-kilometer ride -- the meter shows 180 RMB instead of the expected 80-100 RMB. When you question it, the driver shrugs and says fuel prices went up. As discussed on r/china and travel forums, some Kunming taxis run modified meters that tick at double speed, while others are unlicensed vehicles with completely fake meters installed to look legitimate.

■ Red Flags

- The meter ticks faster than one unit per kilometer or seems to jump in increments
- The driver does not have a visible taxi license or photo ID on the dashboard
- The taxi lacks the standard Kunming taxi markings or the car looks unusually old
- The driver picks you up outside the official taxi queue at the airport or station
- The driver suggests a flat rate instead of the meter -- then switches to the rigged meter when you insist

■ How to Avoid

- Use DiDi, China's ride-hailing app, which shows the fare upfront and tracks the route on GPS
 - Take the Kunming Metro Line 6 from the airport to the city center for just 5 RMB -- it is fast and reliable
 - If using a taxi, only take one from the official queue and note the car number before getting in
 - The standard meter start is 8 RMB and approximately 1.8 RMB per kilometer in 2024-2026
 - Screenshot the route on your phone's map to verify the distance matches the fare
-

The Counterfeit Bill Swap

He examines it, frowns, and hands it back saying, 'This is fake money. Give me a real one.' Flustered, you pull out another 100 RMB note. What you do not realize is that the driver palmed your genuine note and returned a counterfeit he had ready. You are now out 200 RMB and holding a worthless bill. As r/travel and r/china posters describe, the counterfeit swap is a classic con in Chinese cities. It works because tourists cannot easily distinguish genuine from fake notes, especially in dim taxi interiors.

■ Red Flags

- A taxi driver or vendor claims your bill is counterfeit and quickly hands one back
- The exchange happens in a dimly lit area where you cannot inspect the returned note
- The driver or vendor becomes aggressive or impatient when you hesitate to produce more cash
- You receive unusually crisp or unusually worn large-denomination bills as change
- The vendor insists on cash payment despite WeChat Pay and Alipay being universally accepted

■ How to Avoid

- Pay with WeChat Pay or Alipay whenever possible -- mobile payments eliminate the counterfeit risk entirely
 - If paying cash, mark your large bills with a small pen dot so you can verify a returned note is the same one
 - Learn to check the watermark and color-shifting ink on 100 RMB notes -- tilt the bill to see the number change color
 - Refuse to accept a note back once given -- tell the driver to call traffic police if he truly believes it is fake
 - Get change and smaller bills from bank ATMs rather than money changers or shops
-

The Wild Mushroom Restaurant Overcharge

A restaurant near Guandu Ancient Town has beautiful photos of exotic fungi outside, and a waiter enthusiastically recommends 'today's special wild mushrooms, very fresh.' He brings plate after plate to your table, each variety more exotic than the last. You assumed they were part of a set meal. The bill arrives at 800 RMB -- each plate was priced individually, and the 'special' matsutake mushrooms cost 200 RMB per small dish. As travel forums for Yunnan warn, some tourist-area mushroom restaurants exploit the lack of clear pricing to charge by the plate at premium rates that locals would ne...

■ Red Flags

- The restaurant is located directly in a tourist zone with aggressive touts outside
- Menus show photos but prices are missing or in small print with confusing per-unit pricing
- The waiter keeps bringing dishes you did not explicitly order, calling them complimentary or recommended
- Prices are listed per liang (50 grams) rather than per plate, making costs seem deceptively low
- The restaurant has mostly foreign tourists and few local diners

■ How to Avoid

- Eat wild mushroom hotpot at restaurants with Chinese-language Dianping (Dazhong Dianping) reviews and transparent menus
 - Confirm the price per plate for every dish before it is served and ask for the total running cost
 - Visit the Kunming Mushroom Market on Guanshang Road to see real local prices for reference
 - Stick to restaurants where locals are eating -- if the clientele is entirely tourists, expect tourist prices
 - A generous mushroom hotpot for two at a local restaurant should cost 150-300 RMB, not 800-plus
-

The Flower Market Day Price Markup

■ ■ *Dounan Flower Market, Chenggong District near Dianchi Lake* You visit the famous Dounan Flower Market during the day, excited to see Asia's largest flower trading hub. Vendors enthusiastically sell you beautiful rose bouquets at 50-80 RMB each, and you feel you are getting a great deal. What you do not know, as local bloggers and r/kunming users explain, is that the wholesale night market opens after 7 PM, when the same bouquets sell for 10-20 RMB by weight. Daytime visitors pay retail markup aimed at tourists, while the real deals happen when commercial buyers arrive after dark. You have paid three to five times the actual market rate. **Red Flags** Vendors quote prices per stem or per bouquet rather than by weight. You are visiting during daytime hours when the market caters to retail tourists. The vendor does not use a scale and bundles flowers into pre-made tourist arrangements. Prices are quoted in round numbers without negotiation. The vendor area is on the ground floor facing the main tourist entrance. **How to Avoid** Visit the Dounan Flower Market after 7 PM to access the wholesale night auction where flowers sell by weight. Buy flowers by the kilogram at the night market -- prices drop to a fraction of the daytime retail rate. Bring a Chinese-speaking friend or use a translation app to negotiate in Mandarin for better prices. Compare prices at multiple stalls before buying -- the market is enormous and prices vary. Even during the day,

vendors on the upper floors and back sections tend to offer better prices than ground-floor tourist stalls ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Chinese Police (警察局) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mps.gov.cn. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. [More Scam Guides](#) [More in China](#) ■■

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- Visit the Dounan Flower Market after 7 PM to access the wholesale night auction where flowers sell by weight
- Buy flowers by the kilogram at the night market -- prices drop to a fraction of the daytime retail rate
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- Compare prices at multiple stalls before buying -- the market is enormous and prices vary
- Even during the day, vendors on the upper floors and back sections tend to offer better prices than ground-floor tourist stalls

■■ Shanghai

7 scams documented • China

Nanjing Road Dating App Bar Scam

They're charming, their English is polished, and they suggest meeting up right away. When you ask where, they recommend a bar near Nanjing Road — they know just the place. You meet outside, they walk you in. The vibe is nice. Drinks are pricey but hey, you're in Shanghai. Your date keeps ordering. Not just ordering — ordering aggressively, refilling before glasses are empty, ordering food you didn't ask for. You're having a good time so you don't track the bill. When it comes: ¥5,000. One user on r/travelchina reported paying more than that for champagne alone. The match vanishes or becomes...

■ Red Flags

- A new match wants to meet immediately and picks the venue before you've exchanged more than a few messages
- The venue is near Nanjing Road or another major tourist strip
- Your date orders without asking you or looking at prices
- The drinks menu has no visible price list or prices are obscured
- You feel subtle social pressure not to question the ordering

■ How to Avoid

- Always pick the venue yourself — or at minimum vet it on Dianping first before agreeing
 - Meet in a coffee shop or local restaurant for a first meeting, not a bar
 - Agree on a two-drink maximum before going anywhere for drinks with a new stranger
 - If you end up in a bar, ask for the menu and set a personal spending limit out loud
 - Trust your gut — if the match pushed unusually hard to meet immediately and pick the venue, that's a pattern
-

Airport Taxi Meter Rigging

You've just cleared customs at Pudong after 30+ hours of travel. You follow the signs to the official taxi rank, skip all the touts as you've been told, and get into a purple taxi from the legitimate queue. You're doing everything right. The driver asks about your destination. Then midway through the drive, mentions the fare will be ¥600. Something feels off but you're exhausted. When you arrive, the meter reads precisely ¥600 — but a normal late-night ride from Pudong to a central hotel should be ¥150–250. A parent's experience documented on r/travelchina: their elderly mother, alone at 2a...

■ Red Flags

- Driver mentions a price before the journey begins instead of showing a running meter
- The meter seems to jump to suspiciously round numbers
- Driver offers to take a 'better route' or 'faster highway' partway through
- No meter is visible or it appears to start unusually high
- Driver becomes evasive when you ask about the fare

■ How to Avoid

- Use DiDi — set up the app before arriving in China, as fare is fixed and the route is tracked
 - Take the Maglev from Pudong to Longyang Road station (¥50, 8 minutes), then metro to your hotel
 - If taking a taxi, confirm the meter starts at the base rate (¥18) before leaving the curb
 - Photograph the driver's ID card displayed on the dashboard at the start of every taxi ride
 - Have your destination written in Chinese characters to eliminate 'I didn't understand' excuses
-

Wine / Champagne Bar Overcharge

A hostess seats you and suggests a bottle of wine or champagne. The menu prices look high but manageable. What you don't know is that the bottle you ordered is a ¥5,000 item, or that there's a 'table minimum' of ¥3,000 that was never mentioned, or that the 'complimentary' snacks that appeared will cost ¥800. One Redditor on r/travelchina paid over ¥5,000 for champagne in a Shanghai bar scam — they'd read about it happening in Japan and Thailand but couldn't research it once inside China due to the firewall blocking Google. 'I paid out of fear,' they wrote. In other documented cases, the bar...

■ Red Flags

- A hostess or door person enthusiastically waves you into a bar without you seeking it out
- Drink menu doesn't show prices prominently — you have to ask or squint
- Staff immediately pushes premium bottles rather than offering a range
- Snacks or small plates appear on your table without you ordering them
- The bar is in a tourist area but has very few other customers — a bad sign

■ How to Avoid

- Identify bars you want to visit using Dianping or Time Out Shanghai before going out
- Ask for a full priced menu before sitting down — if prices aren't prominently displayed, leave
- Explicitly decline anything placed on your table that you didn't order
- Set a firm spending limit before entering any bar and stick to it regardless of social pressure
- If you feel unable to leave a situation safely, call 110 (police) — Shanghai police have tourist support

Fake 'Internal' Disneyland Fast Pass

They're offering a 'VIP internal fast pass' — ¥800 per person, no queues for 8 major rides, plus a private guide and the best fireworks spot. It sounds almost too good. It is. A Redditor posted a detailed account on r/travelchina: the 'fast entry' turned out to be the same public entrance as everyone else. At every major ride, the guide directed them to stand in the regular queue for 30–40 minutes. When confronted, the guide claimed he was 'saving them time navigating.' The ¥800 bought nothing that wasn't free. When they requested a refund, the guide's demeanor shifted sharply and he refused...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you outside the park claiming to offer 'internal' or 'VIP' access to skip queues
- The deal sounds much better than the official park offering at a fraction of the cost
- Payment is requested in cash upfront before entering the park
- The guide is not wearing official Disney employee identification
- Promises include 'best fireworks spot' or 'personal attention' that sound curated but vague

■ How to Avoid

- Purchase all Disneyland upgrades — including Lightning Lane — through the official Shanghai Disney Resort app
 - Ignore anyone soliciting outside the park gates, regardless of their pitch
 - Verify any tour guide's credentials through the park's official information desk inside
 - If you want a private guide for Disneyland, book through the park's concierge service
 - Remember: no legitimate shortcut to Disney queue-jumping exists outside the park's own systems
-

Tea Ceremony Ambush

They suggest a nearby traditional tea ceremony to experience authentic Chinese culture. It sounds wonderful. Inside the teahouse, you're treated to an elaborate performance of tea preparation while the host explains the history of each variety. Then the bill arrives: ¥2,000 for what you thought was a cultural experience. Each tiny cup of tea is priced individually at ¥200+, and the 'tasting set' you were given includes six varieties. The women who invited you have conveniently stepped outside. You're alone with staff who speak very little English except the word 'pay.' This is nearly identi...

■ Red Flags

- Two young women (almost always women, almost always in pairs) approach you near tourist sites claiming to practice English
- The conversation quickly pivots to an invitation to a nearby 'authentic cultural experience'
- The teahouse or venue is a few streets away from the busy tourist area
- No menu with prices is shown before being seated
- Your 'friends' disappear or become unavailable when the bill arrives

■ How to Avoid

- Decline invitations from strangers near tourist sites to 'authentic experiences' around the corner
 - If you want a genuine tea ceremony, book one through your hotel or a licensed cultural tour company
 - Always ask for a menu with prices before sitting down anywhere
 - If a price isn't agreed upon before the experience begins, don't begin
 - Trust the pattern: two friendly English students plus 'cultural experience' equals a well-rehearsed scam
-

Fake Goods Market Bait-and-Switch

You've heard about Shanghai's famous underground markets where you can buy surprisingly good knockoff goods at low prices. You find one, select a bag that looks perfect — genuine-looking stitching, solid hardware,

the right logo. The vendor quotes ¥500 and after some haggling you settle on ¥350. But when you get back to your hotel and open the bag properly, it's not the same item you inspected. The vendor swapped it during the wrapping process — the zippers are cheap plastic, the lining is thin, the logo is crooked. Or the 'genuine leather' shoes you bought have cracked after one day. Or th...

■ Red Flags

- The vendor insists on wrapping or bagging your item in a back room before handing it to you
- The price drops dramatically without much negotiation — may indicate a switch is planned
- The sample shown has visible quality markers that the wrapped version may not have
- The vendor is distracted or engages an accomplice during the wrapping process
- The item is sealed in a bag before you can inspect it one final time

■ How to Avoid

- Watch your item being wrapped at all times — do not let it disappear into a back area
- Open the bag and inspect the item fully before paying, even if the vendor acts impatient
- Pay only after you have the verified item in your hands
- Understand that most counterfeit goods are low quality regardless — set realistic expectations
- Consider whether buying fakes is worth the hassle — quality varies wildly even in the best stalls

SIM Card Touts at Pudong Airport

■ ■ Pudong Airport arrivals, along airport transit areas You land at Pudong and need a SIM card immediately — you need maps, you need to contact your accommodation, you need DiDi. A person near the arrivals gate offers to help. They have SIM cards right there. ¥300 for a card with data. You're tired, it's convenient, and you pay. The official carrier shops inside the airport sell the same cards for ¥50–100. The vendors near the exit are simply reselling at massive markup, sometimes with SIM cards that aren't properly registered (which is required in China under real-name registration rules) and may stop working after a day. This is a low-danger scam financially — you're not losing thousands — but it's a reliable first-day annoyance that many travelers report. The official China Mobile, China Unicom, and China Telecom counters are inside the terminal before you exit arrivals. Red Flags Someone approaches you in the arrivals area offering a SIM card before you've found official counters The price is quoted verbally with no packaging or official branding visible The vendor is not in a dedicated shop but standing near exits or baggage claim The card price is significantly higher than you've seen quoted online (typical cost: ¥50–100) No receipt or registration documentation is offered with the purchase How to Avoid Find the official carrier counters (China Mobile, Unicom, Telecom) inside the terminal before exiting Tourist SIM cards with 30 days of data typically cost ¥50–100 from official counters Alternatively, buy an eSIM before departure from providers like Airalo — eliminates the airport hunt entirely Bring your passport for SIM registration — real-name registration is required by law in China If you can't find a counter, the metro into the city is Wi-Fi connected and will get you to your hotel fine ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Chinese Police (警察局) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mps.gov.cn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in China ■ ■

you need maps, you need to contact your accommodation, you need DiDi. A person near the arrivals gate offers to help. They have SIM cards right there. ¥300 for a card with data. You're tired, it's convenient, and you pay. The official carrier shops inside the airport sell the same cards for ¥50–100. The vendors near the exit are simply reselling at massive markup, sometimes with SIM cards that aren't properly registered (which is required in China under real-name registration rules) and may stop working after a day. This is a low-danger scam financially — you're not losing thousands — but i...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you in the arrivals area offering a SIM card before you've found official counters

- The price is quoted verbally with no packaging or official branding visible
- The vendor is not in a dedicated shop but standing near exits or baggage claim
- The card price is significantly higher than you've seen quoted online (typical cost: ¥50–100)
- No receipt or registration documentation is offered with the purchase

■ How to Avoid

- Find the official carrier counters (China Mobile, Unicom, Telecom) inside the terminal before exiting
 - Tourist SIM cards with 30 days of data typically cost ¥50–100 from official counters
 - Alternatively, buy an eSIM before departure from providers like Airalo — eliminates the airport hunt entirely
 - Bring your passport for SIM registration — real-name registration is required by law in China
 - If you can't find a counter, the metro into the city is Wi-Fi connected and will get you to your hotel fine
-

■■ Shenzhen

7 scams documented • China

The Huaqiangbei Electronics Bait-and-Switch

The vendor demonstrates a product that sounds great, lets you test it, and agrees on a price of 150 RMB. But when she packs it up, she swaps the demo unit for a cheaper knockoff in identical packaging. You don't discover the switch until you're back at your hotel and the earbuds sound tinny and die after two hours. As r/china travelers explain, the stalls at Huaqiangbei are masterful at showcasing quality products and shipping inferior copies. The identical external appearance hides completely different internal components.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor demonstrates one unit but packages a different one from under the counter
- Price is 80-90% below legitimate retail for a 'genuine' branded product
- Packaging is sealed so you can't check the actual product before leaving
- Vendor discourages you from opening the package at the stall
- Stall has no visible business license or return policy posted

■ How to Avoid

- Open and test the exact item being packaged before paying
 - Assume anything at a fraction of retail price is counterfeit regardless of appearance
 - Mark the demo unit (small scratch or sticker) so you can verify it's the same one packed
 - Buy from established floors in SEG with posted return policies
 - Use the Huaqiangbei market for browsing and fun, not for serious electronics purchases
-

The Luohu Mall Aggressive Upsell

You cross the border from Hong Kong into Shenzhen and immediately enter Luohu Commercial City, a massive five-story mall right at the immigration checkpoint. Before you take ten steps, hawkers grab your arm, shouting 'bag! watch! massage! tailor!' in English. You follow one to a handbag stall, negotiate a price for a knockoff, but when you pay, the quality is visibly worse than what was shown. Try to return it and the vendor turns hostile. Tripadvisor reviewers describe this mall as a gauntlet of aggressive salespeople, counterfeit goods, and bait-and-switch tactics targeting day-trippers f...

■ Red Flags

- Touts physically grab your arm or block your path at the entrance
- The sample bag or watch shown is higher quality than what you receive

- Vendor refuses to let you inspect the product after payment
- Prices change mid-negotiation once you seem committed
- No receipts or return policies are offered

■ How to Avoid

- Don't follow hawkers who approach you at the entrance — browse independently
 - Inspect every item thoroughly before handing over money
 - Compare prices at multiple stalls before buying from any single vendor
 - Be prepared to walk away mid-negotiation — it's your strongest tool
 - Know that everything here is counterfeit, so set expectations accordingly
-

The Massage Parlor Price Escalation

You're approached by a card-holding tout on Dongmen Pedestrian Street offering a 'full body massage for 88 RMB.' It sounds like a deal, so you follow them upstairs to a parlor. The massage starts fine, but midway through, the masseuse offers add-ons: 'special oil,' 'hot stones,' 'foot treatment.' You agree to one or two. The final bill arrives at 680 RMB. Each add-on was priced separately, and the base massage somehow shrank to a 15-minute back rub. As travelers report on Tripadvisor, the upper floors of Luohu Commercial City and the backstreets of Dongmen are lined with parlors running thi...

■ Red Flags

- Touts handing out cards on the street with too-good-to-be-true prices
- The parlor is on an upper floor or down an alley with minimal signage
- Add-on services are offered mid-massage when you're relaxed and disrobed
- No price list is posted or shown before the session begins
- Staff become insistent or aggressive when you decline extras

■ How to Avoid

- Book massages at hotel spas or well-reviewed establishments on Dianping
 - Ask for a complete price list including all extras before the session starts
 - Decline all add-ons firmly once the massage begins
 - Never follow street touts to unknown parlors
 - Pay only the agreed-upon amount and leave if pressured for more
-

The Black Taxi at the Border

You cross from Hong Kong into Shenzhen at Futian Port and unlicensed drivers immediately descend, offering rides to your hotel. They quote 200 RMB for a trip to Nanshan that a metered taxi handles for 60 RMB. One r/china poster described a driver who took an expressway without mentioning it, then charged 80 RMB in tolls on top of the inflated fare. These black taxis cluster at every Shenzhen-Hong Kong border crossing, preying on day-trippers unfamiliar with local transport. The drivers have no meter, no license, and no insurance.

■ Red Flags

- Driver approaches you inside the immigration hall or just outside the exit
- No taxi markings, roof light, or meter in the vehicle
- Flat rate quoted instead of metered pricing
- Driver claims the metro is 'too complicated' or 'too far'
- Adds toll charges and 'fuel surcharges' to the bill at destination

■ How to Avoid

- Take the Shenzhen Metro from any border crossing — all ports have metro connections

- Use Didi to book rides with transparent, app-based pricing
 - If taking a taxi, use the official queue and ensure the meter is running
 - The Shenzhen Metro is clean, efficient, and costs 2-10 RMB per ride
 - Ignore anyone who approaches you offering transport at the border
-

The QR Code Payment Swap

Everything seems normal until you check your transaction history later and notice you paid a different merchant entirely — or the amount was higher than displayed. Scammers replace legitimate merchant QR codes with their own, printed on identical-looking stickers plastered over the real code. Some even set up fake Wi-Fi hotspot pages that redirect your payment. As r/china users explain, this scam exploits the very thing that makes China convenient: the universal reliance on QR code payments.

■ Red Flags

- QR code sticker looks freshly applied or layered over another one
- Payment confirmation shows a different merchant name than expected
- The stall has multiple QR codes posted in confusing locations
- Amount charged doesn't match what the vendor told you
- Vendor seems nervous when you closely examine the QR code

■ How to Avoid

- Have the vendor scan your payment code instead of you scanning theirs
 - Check the merchant name on the confirmation screen before confirming
 - Verify the payment amount matches what was agreed before hitting pay
 - Look for QR codes that seem tampered with or stuck on top of another
 - Keep transaction notifications on so you spot discrepancies immediately
-

The Fake Electronics Factory Tour

You find an ad for a 'Shenzhen electronics factory tour' promising an insider look at how iPhones and drones are assembled. You pay 300-500 RMB, and a guide takes you to a small workshop or showroom that's about as close to a real factory as a toy store is to a toy factory. The 'tour' lasts 30 minutes and ends in an aggressive sales pitch for gadgets at inflated prices. As r/shenzhen posters explain, real Shenzhen factories don't run tourist visits, and the legitimate maker culture experiences are found at places like Sseed Studio or Trouble Maker spaces — not through random hotel concierge...

■ Red Flags

- Tour is sold through hotel lobby flyers or street vendors, not tech platforms
- Price seems low for a genuine factory visit with transportation
- No specific factory name or address is provided before payment
- The guide deflects questions about which factory you'll visit
- The 'factory' turns out to be a showroom or small assembly workshop

■ How to Avoid

- Book legitimate maker tours through established platforms like Sseed Studio
 - Real factory visits require advance booking through business contacts, not tourism channels
 - Check reviews on TripAdvisor or Xiaohongshu before booking any tech tour
 - Visit the Huaqiangbei markets independently for free and explore on your own
 - If you're interested in Shenzhen's tech scene, visit the legitimate Maker Faire events
-

The Teen Shoe Cleaning Harassment

■ ■ Dongmen Pedestrian Street, Luohu Commercial City entrance, tourist areas near the border crossing, Shenzhen Bay area You are walking through Dongmen shopping area when a teenager suddenly kneels down and starts ... You are walking through Dongmen shopping area when a teenager suddenly kneels down and starts wiping your shoe with a cloth before you can react. Within seconds, they are 'cleaning' your shoe and demanding 50-100 yuan for the service. If you resist, two or three more teenagers appear and surround you, applying pressure. A Reddit user on r/chinalife spent four days in Shenzhen and was 'harassed as a foreigner by these teenagers (16-18 year olds) trying to clean my shoe' repeatedly. The scam specifically targets visibly foreign pedestrians and operates in groups for intimidation. Red Flags A teenager approaches you on the street and immediately touches your shoe without permission They begin 'cleaning' before you agree to or request any service Multiple teenagers gather around you as the interaction continues They demand payment of 50-100 yuan (or more) for unsolicited shoe cleaning The interaction happens specifically in tourist areas where foreigners are easily identified How to Avoid Keep walking and say 'bù yào' (■■■, meaning 'don't want') firmly if anyone approaches your feet Step back immediately if someone touches your shoe — do not let the cleaning start You are under no obligation to pay for unsolicited services — walk away without engaging Travel with a local friend or guide in areas known for street harassment Report persistent harassment to nearby security guards or police — this is illegal solicitation ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Chinese Police (■■■■) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mps.gov.cn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in China ■■■

You are walking through Dongmen shopping area when a teenager suddenly kneels down and starts wiping your shoe with a cloth before you can react. Within seconds, they are 'cleaning' your shoe and demanding 50-100 yuan for the service. If you resist, two or three more teenagers appear and surround you, applying pressure. A Reddit user on r/chinalife spent four days in Shenzhen and was 'harassed as a foreigner by these teenagers (16-18 year olds) trying to clean my shoe' repeatedly. The scam specifically targets visibly foreign pedestrians and operates in groups for intimidation.

■ Red Flags

- A teenager approaches you on the street and immediately touches your shoe without permission
- They begin 'cleaning' before you agree to or request any service
- Multiple teenagers gather around you as the interaction continues
- They demand payment of 50-100 yuan (or more) for unsolicited shoe cleaning
- The interaction happens specifically in tourist areas where foreigners are easily identified

■ How to Avoid

- Keep walking and say 'bù yào' (■■■, meaning 'don't want') firmly if anyone approaches your feet
- Step back immediately if someone touches your shoe — do not let the cleaning start
- You are under no obligation to pay for unsolicited services — walk away without engaging
- Travel with a local friend or guide in areas known for street harassment
- Report persistent harassment to nearby security guards or police — this is illegal solicitation

■■■ Suzhou

5 scams documented • China

The Silk Factory Hard Sell

Inside, a guide in a lab coat demonstrates how silkworms produce thread, then leads you to a showroom filled with silk duvets priced at 3,000-8,000 RMB. She claims only a limited number of quilts are available today -- a pressure tactic that works even though stock is always available. Your tour guide hovers near the register,

nodding enthusiastically. As TripAdvisor reviewers of Suzhou No. 1 Silk Mill warn, many visitors have reported items not arriving after being shipped, or receiving lower quality products than what was demonstrated. The tour guide earns a hefty commission on every sale.

■ Red Flags

- The factory stop was not on the original tour itinerary or was described vaguely as a cultural visit
- A limited supply urgency pitch pushes you to buy immediately
- Prices have no external comparison and are dramatically higher than online silk retailers
- The tour guide encourages purchases and seems overly familiar with the factory staff
- Shipping is offered but the factory has poor reviews about delivery fulfillment

■ How to Avoid

- Book tours that explicitly guarantee no shopping stops -- confirm this in writing before paying
 - If taken to a silk factory, politely browse but do not buy under pressure -- real silk is available across Suzhou at fair prices
 - Visit the Suzhou Silk Museum on Renmin Road for a genuine educational experience with no sales pressure
 - If you want to buy silk, shop on Guanqian Street or Shiquan Street where competition keeps prices honest
 - A quality silk duvet in Suzhou should cost 800-1,500 RMB at retail, not 3,000-8,000 RMB at a tour stop
-

The Rickshaw Price Flip

'Only 40 kuai, very nice tour!' You agree and climb in. The ride through the old lanes is charming, but after twenty minutes the driver pulls over in a quiet alley and produces a laminated price card: 'That was 40 kuai per person, per ten minutes. Four people, thirty minutes -- 480 kuai.' When you protest, he becomes agitated. As r/travel posters describe, Suzhou's rickshaw scam is one of China's most brazen -- drivers are well practiced at quoting one price verbally and then flipping to an inflated calculation using confusing per-person per-minute rates.

■ Red Flags

- The driver quotes a low flat rate verbally but nothing is written down
- They do not clarify whether the price is per person, per ride, or per time period
- The rickshaw has a laminated price card hidden under the seat that appears only at the end
- The driver takes you through quiet back alleys away from other tourists
- They become aggressive or block you from leaving when you dispute the fare

■ How to Avoid

- Before boarding, insist on a total price for the entire ride for all passengers -- write it on your phone and show the driver
 - Take a photo of the driver and rickshaw number before getting in
 - A reasonable rickshaw tour of Pingjiang Road should be 50-80 RMB total for 20-30 minutes
 - Walk Pingjiang Road on foot instead -- it is only about 1.5 kilometers and much of its charm is in the details you miss from a rickshaw
 - If a dispute arises, call the Suzhou tourism hotline at 0512-65223377 or dial 110 for police
-

The Tea House Invitation

After chatting warmly, they invite you to a nearby tea house to experience a traditional Suzhou tea ceremony. Inside a small room, a server pours cup after cup of Biluochun green tea, famous in Suzhou. It feels like genuine local hospitality -- until the bill arrives at 2,000 RMB. Your new friends have conveniently stepped outside. When you refuse to pay, the staff become threatening and block the door. As r/china users warn, this is the same tea scam that plagues other Chinese cities, adapted with a local Biluochun twist in Suzhou.

■ Red Flags

- Strangers approach you near transit hubs and suggest a tea house within minutes of meeting
- They specifically compliment you and want selfies to build a sense of friendship quickly
- The tea house is in a back street or upstairs location you would never find on your own
- No prices are shown and you are served without ever ordering specific items
- Your hosts seem to know the tea house staff and do not react to the astronomical bill

■ How to Avoid

- Decline all invitations from strangers to visit tea houses, restaurants, or bars -- no exceptions
 - If you want authentic Biluochun tea, visit the Dongshan or Xishan tea villages outside Suzhou where farmers sell directly
 - Tell approaching strangers you are late meeting friends and walk away immediately
 - If trapped with an inflated bill, do not pay -- call police at 110 who are experienced with tea house complaints
 - Buy Biluochun tea at the Suzhou Tea Culture Center or reputable shops on Shiquan Street at transparent prices
-

The Garden Ticket Reseller

A man approaches and says, 'I have tickets already bought -- save you one hour in line, same price!' The ticket looks genuine, and you pay 90 RMB. Inside, a garden official scans your ticket and frowns -- it is a used ticket from yesterday with the date smudged, or a printed counterfeit. You are turned away and the reseller has vanished into the crowd. As noted on Chinese travel forums, scalpers outside Suzhou's gardens sell expired or fake tickets to impatient tourists who want to skip the official queue.

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you outside the garden selling tickets at face value or a slight discount
- The ticket has no QR code or the code looks blurry and poorly printed
- The seller urges you to buy quickly before the tickets run out
- The date on the ticket is obscured, smudged, or covered by a sticker
- Other tourists are buying from the same person in rapid succession

■ How to Avoid

- Always buy tickets from the official window or from the garden's WeChat mini-program or Trip.com app
 - Book tickets online in advance to skip the queue legitimately -- most Suzhou gardens support digital tickets
 - Never buy tickets from individuals outside any attraction in China
 - Inspect any ticket for a clear date, QR code, and the garden's official hologram seal
 - If the line is long, the Suzhou Museum next door is free and also has beautiful garden views
-

The Canal Boat Bait-and-Switch

■ ■ Canal docks near Shantang Street and Panmen Gate scenic area You want to experience Suzhou's famous canals and find a boat operator at Shantang Street dock who ... You want to experience Suzhou's famous canals and find a boat operator at Shantang Street dock who offers a scenic ride for 80 RMB. Once you are floating through the canal, the boatman starts pointing out historic homes and bridges, providing a pleasant commentary. Midway through, he announces that to see the best section with lit lanterns, there is an extra fee of 100 RMB. When you decline, the ride abruptly ends at the next dock, far from where you started. As travel forums note, some independent boat operators on Suzhou's canals quote a low initial price but pad the actual experience with add-on charges for extended routes, commentary, or the prettiest canal sections. **Red Flags** The quoted price is significantly lower than the official boat tour rate The operator is not at an official dock with posted pricing No route map or duration is agreed upon before departure The boatman introduces extra charges mid-ride for better views or longer trips You are dropped at a different location than where you boarded **How to Avoid** Book canal tours from the official Shantang Street or Panmen scenic area ticket offices with fixed routes and prices Confirm the full route, duration, and total price including all sections before boarding The official Shantang Street night boat costs around 120-150 RMB and covers the full scenic route with no extras Ask to see the boat operator's license if

approached by an independent boatman Read recent reviews on Dianping or Trip.com to find reputable canal tour operators ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Chinese Police (警察局) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mps.gov.cn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in China ■■

You want to experience Suzhou's famous canals and find a boat operator at Shantang Street dock who offers a scenic ride for 80 RMB. Once you are floating through the canal, the boatman starts pointing out historic homes and bridges, providing a pleasant commentary. Midway through, he announces that to see the best section with lit lanterns, there is an extra fee of 100 RMB. When you decline, the ride abruptly ends at the next dock, far from where you started. As travel forums note, some independent boat operators on Suzhou's canals quote a low initial price but pad the actual experience wit...

■ Red Flags

- The quoted price is significantly lower than the official boat tour rate
- The operator is not at an official dock with posted pricing
- No route map or duration is agreed upon before departure
- The boatman introduces extra charges mid-ride for better views or longer trips
- You are dropped at a different location than where you boarded

■ How to Avoid

- Book canal tours from the official Shantang Street or Panmen scenic area ticket offices with fixed routes and prices
 - Confirm the full route, duration, and total price including all sections before boarding
 - The official Shantang Street night boat costs around 120-150 RMB and covers the full scenic route with no extras
 - Ask to see the boat operator's license if approached by an independent boatman
 - Read recent reviews on Dianping or Trip.com to find reputable canal tour operators
-

■■ Xi'an

7 scams documented • China

The Fake Terracotta Warriors Museum

You board what looks like a direct tourist bus to the Terracotta Warriors, but instead of the real museum, you end up at a privately run knockoff called something like the 'World Eight Wonders Museum.' Inside, brightly colored replica warriors with painted makeup stare back at you — nothing like the ancient gray originals. You've paid 200 RMB for admission to a glorified gift shop. In 2017, authorities actually destroyed over 40 fake warriors at one such site after waves of tourist complaints. Redditors on r/china warn that these fake buses and fake museums still operate on the highway to t...

■ Red Flags

- Bus fare is suspiciously cheap or bundled with 'tour packages'
- The bus makes detours or stops at shops along the way
- Warriors are brightly colored with makeup-like details instead of gray
- There's only one security checkpoint or none at all
- The Chinese name doesn't read '兵马俑' (Terracotta Warriors)

■ How to Avoid

- Take the official Tourist Bus 5 (You 5) from Xi'an Railway Station east square
 - Verify the museum's official Chinese name: 秦始皇兵马俑博物馆
 - The real museum costs 150 RMB with free shuttle buses inside the complex
 - Book through your hotel or a licensed tour operator
 - The real site has two security checkpoints before entering any pit
-

The Xinjiang Nut Cake Price Trap

You're wandering through the bustling Muslim Quarter when a vendor offers you a taste of Xinjiang nut cake (qiegao), a dense confection of dried fruits and nuts. It looks delicious, so you ask for 'one piece.' The vendor nods, grabs a massive cleaver, and hacks off a slab. Suddenly your 'one piece' costs 500 RMB because the price is per gram, not per slice. The chunk weighs far more than you expected, and the vendor refuses to cut it smaller since it's already been sliced. As r/china users explain, this is one of the most notorious street food scams in all of China.

■ Red Flags

- Price is listed per jin (斤) or per gram, not per piece
- Vendor cuts an enormous portion without confirming weight first
- No scale visible or the scale faces away from you
- The vendor becomes aggressive when you question the price
- Other tourists are watching with shocked expressions

■ How to Avoid

- Ask the price per piece AND confirm the total before anything is cut
 - Point to a specific size and get verbal confirmation of the cost
 - Watch the scale carefully and ask to see it before paying
 - Walk away if the vendor won't clarify pricing upfront
 - Stick to stalls where prices are clearly displayed on signs
-

The Fake Farmer Book Signing

After touring the Terracotta Warriors, your guide steers you to the museum gift shop where an elderly man sits at a table stacking books. Your guide announces that this is the actual farmer who discovered the warriors in 1974 and that he'll personally sign a book for you — only 200 RMB. The real farmer, Yang Zhifa, did sit at the museum for years, but multiple travelers on r/china report that various different men have occupied this chair. Whether it's the real farmer or not, the book signing is a well-oiled commission machine, and guides receive a cut of every sale.

■ Red Flags

- Guide specifically routes you through the gift shop on the way out
- The 'farmer' never speaks or interacts beyond signing
- Books are overpriced compared to identical ones sold elsewhere
- Guide seems overly eager for you to buy
- Multiple tour groups are being funneled to the same table

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline — the book has no special value beyond a signature
- If you want a souvenir book, buy it independently for a fraction of the price
- Don't feel pressured by your guide's enthusiasm
- Take your time leaving the museum without following the guided exit route
- Research the discovery story beforehand so you're not swayed by the narrative

The Illegal Taxi Detour Ambush

Instead of heading toward the city center, the car takes a detour to an 'attraction' or jade shop where you're pressured to buy overpriced souvenirs. Some travelers on r/china report being driven to remote locations where the driver's associates showed up, demanding payment for 'services.' These unlicensed taxi operators target confused arrivals and charge two to three times the metered rate — and the detour shops pay them commission on top of that.

■ Red Flags

- Driver approaches you inside the station instead of waiting at the taxi stand
- No official taxi markings, license plate, or meter visible
- Driver refuses to use the meter or claims it's broken
- The route includes unexpected stops at shops or attractions
- Driver gets hostile when you insist on going directly to your hotel

■ How to Avoid

- Only use the official taxi queue outside the station with metered cabs
 - Download Didi (China's ride-hailing app) and book rides through the app
 - Take the Xi'an Metro, which connects both railway stations to the city center
 - If a driver approaches you first, decline immediately
 - Share your live location with someone when taking any taxi
-

The Muslim Quarter Antique Breakage Scam

A shopkeeper encourages you to pick one up and look more closely. The moment you touch it, the item 'accidentally' falls and shatters on the floor. Suddenly the vendor is demanding 2,000 RMB for what was a worthless replica. Some shop setups are deliberate — items are balanced precariously on narrow shelves, or the vendor nudges something while you're browsing. As r/china travelers warn, these fake antique shops prey on the guilt of tourists who think they've broken something valuable.

■ Red Flags

- Items are placed close to the edge of shelves or on unstable surfaces
- Vendor encourages you to handle fragile-looking merchandise
- No clearly marked prices on any items
- Vendor claims the broken item is a 'genuine antique' worth thousands
- Other staff members quickly surround you after the breakage

■ How to Avoid

- Keep your hands at your sides in shops with crowded displays
 - Don't pick up items unless you're genuinely interested in buying
 - If something breaks, don't pay on the spot — ask for police involvement
 - Real antiques aren't displayed on street-level souvenir shop shelves
 - Stick to established stores with fixed prices rather than street-side stalls
-

The Fake Discount Ticket Sellers

You approach the Big Wild Goose Pagoda and a friendly person intercepts you, offering 'student discount' or 'special group rate' tickets at half price. The tickets look real but are either for a different venue, have been used and reprinted, or are simply fabricated. You don't discover the problem until you reach the entrance gate and are turned away. Meanwhile, the seller has vanished into the crowd. Redditors on r/china note that ticket scammers operate wherever there are queues, offering to help tourists 'skip the line' for a premium.

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you offering tickets outside the official ticket office
- Price is significantly lower than posted rates
- Seller claims a 'special discount' not advertised anywhere
- Tickets don't have QR codes or look different from official ones
- Seller is in a rush and discourages you from comparing at the ticket booth

■ How to Avoid

- Always buy tickets at the official ticket office or through authorized apps like Trip.com
- Book popular attractions online in advance to avoid queues entirely
- Never buy tickets from anyone approaching you on the street
- Official Xi'an attractions accept WeChat or Alipay for ticket purchases
- Check the attraction's official website for current pricing before you go

The Government Facility Jade and TCM Tour Stop

■ ■ *Tour buses between Xi'an and the Terracotta Warriors, stops at jade factories and TCM clinics along the highway, tourist shops near the City Wall You book a day tour to the Terracotta Warriors. The bus makes 'scheduled stops' at a jade carving factory and a Traditional Chinese Medicine clinic, presented as 'government-approved cultural experiences.' Inside, you are given tea, a health diagnosis by a 'TCM doctor,' and shown jade products that are 'certified government quality' at prices ranging from \$200-2,000. The products are low-grade mass-produced items worth a fraction of the price. Reddit users on r/travelchina asked about these stops: 'Are these actually run by the Chinese government? Are the products like snake skin oil and jade at least legitimate but low grade?' The answer: they are not government facilities, and the products are grossly overpriced. Red Flags A group tour includes 'free' stops at jade factories, silk workshops, or TCM clinics that were not in the original itinerary The venue claims to be 'government-approved' or 'state-certified' but has no verifiable credentials A 'doctor' diagnoses health issues after a two-minute consultation and recommends expensive herbal remedies Products come with certificates of authenticity that cannot be verified independently Tour guides earn commission on purchases and subtly pressure you to buy How to Avoid Book private tours directly through reputable agencies or your hotel to control the itinerary If your tour stops at a shopping venue, browse politely but do not buy — the same products are available for 10-20% of the price elsewhere Never believe medical diagnoses from TCM practitioners at tourist venues — they diagnose everyone with something that requires their expensive products Research jade quality and pricing before your trip — authentic high-grade jade is expensive even in China, and if it seems too cheap to be good, it is not jade Set a firm budget before entering any shop and stick to it — sales staff are trained to overcome objections ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Chinese Police (警察局) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mps.gov.cn. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in China ■ ■*

The bus makes 'scheduled stops' at a jade carving factory and a Traditional Chinese Medicine clinic, presented as 'government-approved cultural experiences.' Inside, you are given tea, a health diagnosis by a 'TCM doctor,' and shown jade products that are 'certified government quality' at prices ranging from \$200-2,000. The products are low-grade mass-produced items worth a fraction of the price. Reddit users on r/travelchina asked about these stops: 'Are these actually run by the Chinese government? Are the products like snake skin oil and jade at least legitimate but low grade?' The answer...

■ Red Flags

- A group tour includes 'free' stops at jade factories, silk workshops, or TCM clinics that were not in the original itinerary
- The venue claims to be 'government-approved' or 'state-certified' but has no verifiable credentials
- A 'doctor' diagnoses health issues after a two-minute consultation and recommends expensive herbal remedies
- Products come with certificates of authenticity that cannot be verified independently

- Tour guides earn commission on purchases and subtly pressure you to buy

■ How to Avoid

- Book private tours directly through reputable agencies or your hotel to control the itinerary
 - If your tour stops at a shopping venue, browse politely but do not buy — the same products are available for 10-20% of the price elsewhere
 - Never believe medical diagnoses from TCM practitioners at tourist venues — they diagnose everyone with something that requires their expensive products
 - Research jade quality and pricing before your trip — authentic high-grade jade is expensive even in China, and if it seems too cheap to be good, it is not jade
 - Set a firm budget before entering any shop and stick to it — sales staff are trained to overcome objections
-

■ Hong Kong

■ Hong Kong

5 scams documented • Hong Kong

The Electronics Grey Market Swap

You pay and walk out. Back at the hotel you open the box and find a different (inferior) model, a regional variant without warranty, or a display unit with a replaced battery. These Mong Kok electronics shops are notorious for bait-and-switch tactics on cameras, phones, and accessories, and multiple [r/HongKong](#) posts document the exact same experience.

■ Red Flags

- Price dramatically lower than retail or official stores
- Shop is small, staff are pushy, and the 'deal' is urgent
- Salesperson adds accessories you didn't ask for to the transaction
- Box is opened 'to demonstrate' before being resealed
- Check the model number, IMEI, and regional variant before leaving the shop

■ How to Avoid

- Check the model number, IMEI, and regional variant before leaving the shop
 - Buy electronics at official brand stores (Apple Store, Samsung Experience) or large chains like Broadway
 - If a deal seems too good to be true in Mong Kok, it is
-

The Fake or Overpriced Jade Shop

it will 'bring luck.' The price is HK\$1,200. It looks beautiful. Back home a gemologist tells you it's dyed quartzite worth about HK\$50. Fake jade is everywhere in Hong Kong's tourist jewelry scene, particularly at the Jade Market and souvenir shops on Nathan Road, and tourists without gemology knowledge have essentially no way to tell the difference.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor immediately has a 'special piece just for you'
- Price keeps dropping dramatically to close the sale
- No hallmark, certificate, or documentation with the piece
- Only buy jade from reputable jewelry stores with certification (look for HKJJA members)

- If you want jade as a souvenir rather than an investment, expect to pay tourist prices for tourist-quality goods

■ How to Avoid

- Only buy jade from reputable jewelry stores with certification (look for HKJJA members)
 - If you want jade as a souvenir rather than an investment, expect to pay tourist prices for tourist-quality goods
 - Never buy 'investment jade' from a market stall
-

The Overpriced Dim Sum Tourist Trap

You duck into what looks like a local dim sum restaurant on Nathan Road because someone at the door is enthusiastically pointing to a menu of photos. An hour later your bill for two is HK\$650 for food that would cost HK\$150 in an actual local restaurant two streets over. Tourist-facing restaurants specifically in the Golden Mile area on Nathan Road use photo menus and English-language staff to catch visitors who don't know what fair dim sum prices look like.

■ Red Flags

- Staff actively recruiting diners from outside the door
- English-only menus with no Chinese customers inside
- Prices are per piece rather than per basket (makes them harder to track)
- Head to local neighborhood dim sum places in Jordan or Sham Shui Po
- OpenRice app (Hong Kong's Yelp equivalent) shows local prices and reviews

■ How to Avoid

- Head to local neighborhood dim sum places in Jordan or Sham Shui Po
 - OpenRice app (Hong Kong's Yelp equivalent) shows local prices and reviews
 - A good dim sum lunch for two should cost HK\$120-200 at a local establishment
-

The Crooked Tailor Deposit Disappearance

just leave a 50% deposit. You come back the next day and either the shop is shuttered, the suit is unwearable, or the tailor demands more money to finish it. Same-day custom tailoring is a Hong Kong tourist institution, but the minority of dodgy operators can ruin your trip and take your money.

■ Red Flags

- 24-hour delivery promise for a suit
- Shop is new, no reviews visible
- Large deposit required before any work begins
- Use tailors with years of reviews and a physical established shop
- Sam's Tailor in Burlington Arcade has been operating since 1957 and has real reviews

■ How to Avoid

- Use tailors with years of reviews and a physical established shop
 - Sam's Tailor in Burlington Arcade has been operating since 1957 and has real reviews
 - Read reviews specifically about receiving the finished product, not just the fitting
-

The Counterfeit Goods Crackdown Bluff

■ ■ *Ladies' Market, Temple Street Night Market* You're at Ladies' Market happily browsing knockoff bags when a vendor whispers that police are ... You're at Ladies' Market happily browsing knockoff bags when a vendor whispers that police are nearby and you need to buy quickly. Feeling rushed, you pay before properly inspecting the item. The 'police pressure' is fabricated urgency — the item you've bought is worse quality than the samples shown, and you've overpaid. Counterfeit goods markets use fake urgency to stop customers examining what they're actually buying. Red Flags Any mention of police or urgency to buy quickly Item shown is different from item being sold Vendor produces better-quality samples than

wraps a different product How to Avoid Never feel rushed by police bluffs — they're theater Inspect what you're buying, not what you were shown Understand counterfeit goods confiscation can happen to buyers too ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Hong Kong Police Force station. Call 999. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.gov.hk. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Consulate General in Hong Kong at 26 Garden Road, Central, Hong Kong. For emergencies: +852 2523-9011. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. Frequently Asked Questions Is Hong Kong safe for tourists? ▼

You're at Ladies' Market happily browsing knockoff bags when a vendor whispers that police are nearby and you need to buy quickly. Feeling rushed, you pay before properly inspecting the item. The 'police pressure' is fabricated urgency — the item you've bought is worse quality than the samples shown, and you've overpaid. Counterfeit goods markets use fake urgency to stop customers examining what they're actually buying.

■ Red Flags

- Any mention of police or urgency to buy quickly
- Item shown is different from item being sold
- Vendor produces better-quality samples then wraps a different product
- Never feel rushed by police bluffs — they're theater
- Inspect what you're buying, not what you were shown

■ How to Avoid

- Never feel rushed by police bluffs — they're theater
 - Inspect what you're buying, not what you were shown
 - Understand counterfeit goods confiscation can happen to buyers too
-

■ Japan

■■ Fukuoka

4 scams documented • Japan

The Nakasu Bar Trap

You're crossing the neon-lit bridges of Nakasu when a friendly tout approaches in decent English: 'Great bar, cheap drinks, beautiful girls!' Intrigued, you follow him down an alley to a basement bar. The first drink is reasonably priced. Then a hostess sits down and orders a bottle of champagne 'on the house.' An hour later, the bill arrives: 85,000 yen -- roughly \$550. The champagne, the hostess's time, a 'table charge,' and a 'service fee' have all been added. When you protest, two large men materialize at the door. As Reddit's [r/JapanTravel](#) and Unseen Japan document, Nakasu is one of Ja...

■ Red Flags

- A street tout or barker actively solicits you to visit a specific bar or club
- The bar is in a basement or upper floor of a building with no visible signage from the street
- There is no visible drink menu with prices when you sit down
- Staff encourage female companions to join your table and order expensive drinks
- The tout disappears after leading you inside, leaving you with unfamiliar staff

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow a street tout to any bar -- legitimate establishments in Japan do not use sidewalk solicitors
 - Stick to bars and izakayas that display menus with prices in their windows or at the entrance
 - Ask to see a menu with prices before ordering your first drink and photograph it for reference
 - Avoid bars in Nakasu basements or upper floors that require tout guidance to find
 - If presented with an outrageous bill, calmly ask for an itemized receipt and call 110 (police) -- Japanese police regularly intervene in Nakasu bar disputes
-

The Scam Izakaya Overcharge

Inside, the atmosphere is lively and the staff are welcoming. You order a few beers, some yakitori, and edamame. The food is decent. But the bill is 12,000 yen for what seemed like a casual meal for two. Buried in the charges are a 500 yen per person 'otoshi' (appetizer charge), a 1,500 yen 'table fee,' a 2,000 yen 'weekend surcharge,' and an 18 percent 'service charge.' None of these were mentioned when you sat down. As travel blogs and Reddit's r/JapanTravel warn, tourist-targeting izakayas near major stations use rock-bottom drink prices to lure foreigners, then recoup through hidden fees.

■ Red Flags

- Extremely cheap drink prices advertised in English outside the restaurant
- No mention of table charges, otoshi fees, or service charges on the visible menu
- The menu is only in Japanese with no English translation available
- Staff seem overly eager to seat foreign customers but vague when asked about total pricing
- The restaurant is on the ground floor of a tourist corridor with aggressive signage

■ How to Avoid

- Ask about all fees before sitting down: 'Otoshi, table charge, service charge arimasu ka?' (Are there cover/table/service charges?)
 - Use the Tabelog or Google Maps reviews to find well-rated izakayas with transparent pricing
 - Understand that a legitimate otoshi charge is typically 300-500 yen and is standard in Japan -- anything above 800 yen is unusual
 - Choose izakayas that display full menus with prices in the window, which is required by Fukuoka city regulations
 - Visit local chain izakayas like Torikizoku or Uotami where pricing is standardized and transparent
-

The Fake Monk Donation

They press a small golden amulet or bracelet into your hand and bow. It feels like a genuine spiritual gift. Then they produce a clipboard showing a list of 'donation' amounts and point to the 2,000-5,000 yen line, implying that's the expected contribution. The amulet is worth about 50 yen. As Reddit's r/JapanTravel and GaijinPot explain, these are not real Buddhist monks -- authentic Japanese monks do not solicit donations on the street. The costume is a prop, and the 'temple' they claim to represent may not exist.

■ Red Flags

- A person in monk robes approaches you outside of a temple or shrine context
- They hand you an item before any conversation, creating a sense of obligation
- A clipboard shows preset donation amounts rather than accepting any voluntary contribution
- They cannot name a specific local temple or explain their religious order when asked
- The robes look like a costume rather than traditional Buddhist attire

■ How to Avoid

- Politely refuse any unsolicited gifts by saying 'Kekko desu' (No thank you) and not touching the item
- Understand that legitimate Japanese Buddhist monks collect alms silently and never pressure passersby
- If you want to support a temple, donate directly at the temple's offertory box (saisen-bako)

- Walk away immediately if someone hands you an item and then requests payment
 - Report persistent fake monks to local police (koban) near major shrines
-

The Yatai Tourist Tax

■ ■ *Riverside yatai stalls along the Naka River near Canal City Hakata* You take a seat at one of Fukuoka's famous yatai food stalls along the river. The atmosphere is electric -- lanterns glowing, ramen steam rising, locals chatting. There's no English menu, but the chef seems friendly and gestures at various dishes. You point at what looks good and enjoy a bowl of ramen and some gyoza. The bill comes to 4,500 yen -- about double what locals pay at yatai in other parts of the city like Tenjin. The riverside stalls near Canal City are the most tourist-oriented, and as Fukuoka food guides and Reddit note, some charge 1.5 to 2 times the normal prices specifically because foreign tourists don't know the going rate and can't read the Japanese-only menus. **Red Flags** The yatai has no visible menu with prices, or the menu is entirely in Japanese The stall is located on the tourist-heavy riverside stretch near Canal City rather than in Tenjin or Nagahama Prices are not quoted before dishes are prepared and served The chef or server seems focused on seating foreign tourists specifically Dishes arrive that you didn't order, described as 'service' or 'on the house' but appear on the bill **How to Avoid** Visit yatai stalls in the Tenjin area rather than the riverside tourist strip for more authentic pricing Use Google Translate's camera function to read Japanese menus before ordering Ask for prices before ordering by pointing and saying 'Ikura desu ka?' (How much is this?) Check that the yatai displays a menu with prices, which is required by Fukuoka city regulations for all yatai Budget 1,500-2,500 yen per person as a reasonable yatai meal cost -- anything above 3,500 yen for basic ramen and sides warrants questioning ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Japanese Police (Keisatsu) station. Call 110. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at keishicho.metro.tokyo.lg.jp. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 1-10-5 Akasaka, Minato-ku, Tokyo. For emergencies: +81 3-3224-5000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in Japan** ■ ■

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■ Red Flags

- The yatai has no visible menu with prices, or the menu is entirely in Japanese
- The stall is located on the tourist-heavy riverside stretch near Canal City rather than in Tenjin or Nagahama
- Prices are not quoted before dishes are prepared and served
- The chef or server seems focused on seating foreign tourists specifically
- Dishes arrive that you didn't order, described as 'service' or 'on the house' but appear on the bill

■ How to Avoid

- Visit yatai stalls in the Tenjin area rather than the riverside tourist strip for more authentic pricing
 - Use Google Translate's camera function to read Japanese menus before ordering
 - Ask for prices before ordering by pointing and saying 'Ikura desu ka?' (How much is this?)
 - Check that the yatai displays a menu with prices, which is required by Fukuoka city regulations for all yatai
 - Budget 1,500-2,500 yen per person as a reasonable yatai meal cost -- anything above 3,500 yen for basic ramen and sides warrants questioning
-

■ ■ Hiroshima

4 scams documented • Japan

The Fake Monk Donation

You're walking through Peace Memorial Park when a person in orange or brown robes approaches with a serene smile, offering you a small prayer bead bracelet or blessing card. They press it into your hands and bow. It feels like a genuine cultural exchange -- until they produce a donation book showing names with amounts of 2,000 to 5,000 yen next to them. The implication is clear: you should donate at least as much. As Japan Today and GaijinPot report, fake monks operate at major tourist sites across Japan, including Hiroshima's Peace Park. Real Buddhist monks in Japan rarely approach strange...

■ Red Flags

- A 'monk' approaches you rather than quietly collecting at a temple
- They place an item in your hands before any interaction or conversation
- They show a donation book with large amounts listed to anchor your contribution
- Their robes look generic or costume-like rather than from a specific Buddhist tradition
- They are persistent and follow you if you try to walk away without donating

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline by bowing slightly and saying 'Kekko desu' (No, thank you) while keeping your hands at your sides
 - Do not accept any items -- once something is in your hands, the social pressure to pay increases dramatically
 - Real Japanese monks collect donations at temples, not on public streets or in parks
 - If you want to donate to a Buddhist cause, visit an actual temple and use the donation box there
 - Walk away confidently -- fake monks will not follow you more than a few steps
-

The Nagarekawa Izakaya Overcharge

You're exploring Hiroshima's lively Nagarekawa nightlife district when a street tout beckons you into an izakaya with promises of cheap beer and local food. The menu shows beers for 300 yen and dishes for 500 yen -- great prices. After a few rounds, the bill arrives at 12,000 yen. There's a 1,500-yen per person 'seating charge,' an 'appetizer' you didn't order for 800 yen, and a 20 percent 'service fee.' As Unseen Japan and Travel Japan Alone have documented, scam izakayas use hidden charges to inflate bills by three to five times the expected cost. The street solicitors earn commissions fo...

■ Red Flags

- A tout on the street actively solicits you to enter an establishment -- legitimate bars don't need to
- The advertised prices seem unusually cheap compared to surrounding restaurants
- There's no clearly posted seating charge (otoshi), service fee, or table charge at the entrance
- You're given a small appetizer (otoshi) you didn't order -- this is normal in Japan but should be listed
- The bill includes vague charges like 'service' or 'seat' that weren't mentioned beforehand

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow street touts into bars or restaurants -- street solicitation is illegal under Japan's entertainment laws
 - Choose izakayas with visible menus displayed outside showing all prices including any cover charges
 - Ask 'Otoshi wa ikura desu ka?' (How much is the cover charge?) before sitting down
 - Stick to well-reviewed restaurants on Tabelog or Google Maps rather than places that recruit from the street
 - Hiroshima's Okonomimura building offers great local food in a tourist-safe multi-floor food hall
-

The Friendly English Practice Lure

You're browsing the Hondori shopping arcade when a friendly young person approaches and asks to practice English with you. They're enthusiastic and charming, and suggest moving to a nearby cafe for a proper conversation. At the cafe, the chat gradually shifts from language practice to philosophy, then to an invitation to

visit a 'special temple' or attend a meeting of their 'international cultural group.' As GaijinPot and r/japantravel have documented, this is a recruitment tactic used by certain religious organizations and cults that specifically target tourists and foreign residents at tr...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you specifically to practice English in a busy public area
- They suggest moving to a specific cafe or location they seem to know well
- The conversation shifts from casual chat to philosophy, spirituality, or personal beliefs
- They invite you to visit a temple, center, or meeting that isn't a mainstream tourist attraction
- They ask for your phone number, Instagram, or Line ID to arrange follow-up meetings

■ How to Avoid

- Be politely cautious of strangers who approach you to practice English -- genuine students use organized language exchange apps
- If the conversation turns to religion or spirituality, politely excuse yourself and leave
- Never follow a stranger to a secondary location, no matter how friendly they seem
- Look up any group or temple they mention on your phone before agreeing to visit
- If you want genuine cultural exchange, join organized events through your hostel or the Hiroshima International Center

The QR Code Payment Swap

■ ■ Restaurants and shops near Hiroshima Peace Memorial Park and Miyajima ferry terminal You finish lunch at a small restaurant near Peace Park and the server points to a QR code on the ... You finish lunch at a small restaurant near Peace Park and the server points to a QR code on the table for mobile payment -- increasingly common in Japan. You scan it with your phone, enter the amount, and confirm payment. But the QR code was a sticker placed over the restaurant's real code by a scammer, and your payment went to a fraudulent account. The restaurant still wants their money, so you pay twice. As Japan Today reported, fake QR code fraud has been rising across Japan's tourist areas as cashless payment adoption increases. Restaurants and small shops often don't check their QR codes regularly, making them vulnerable to swap-outs. Red Flags The QR code is on a sticker placed over another surface rather than printed directly on the table or stand The payment screen shows a different merchant name than the restaurant you're in The QR code looks newer, shinier, or different in quality from other signage in the restaurant You notice the edges of a sticker overlay when looking at the QR code closely The payment confirmation doesn't match the restaurant's name How to Avoid Check that the QR code is printed on the restaurant's own material, not a sticker overlay Verify the merchant name on your payment screen matches the restaurant before confirming Ask the server to show you their official QR code on their own device if you have any doubt Pay with cash or a physical credit card at restaurants if the QR code looks suspicious Use established payment apps like PayPay or credit cards rather than scanning unknown QR codes ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Japanese Police (Keisatsu) station. Call 110. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at keishicho.metro.tokyo.lg.jp. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 1-10-5 Akasaka, Minato-ku, Tokyo. For emergencies: +81 3-3224-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Japan ■ ■

You finish lunch at a small restaurant near Peace Park and the server points to a QR code on the table for mobile payment -- increasingly common in Japan. You scan it with your phone, enter the amount, and confirm payment. But the QR code was a sticker placed over the restaurant's real code by a scammer, and your payment went to a fraudulent account. The restaurant still wants their money, so you pay twice. As Japan Today reported, fake QR code fraud has been rising across Japan's tourist areas as cashless payment adoption increases. Restaurants and small shops often don't check their QR co...

■ Red Flags

- The QR code is on a sticker placed over another surface rather than printed directly on the table or stand
- The payment screen shows a different merchant name than the restaurant you're in

- The QR code looks newer, shinier, or different in quality from other signage in the restaurant
- You notice the edges of a sticker overlay when looking at the QR code closely
- The payment confirmation doesn't match the restaurant's name

■ How to Avoid

- Check that the QR code is printed on the restaurant's own material, not a sticker overlay
 - Verify the merchant name on your payment screen matches the restaurant before confirming
 - Ask the server to show you their official QR code on their own device if you have any doubt
 - Pay with cash or a physical credit card at restaurants if the QR code looks suspicious
 - Use established payment apps like PayPay or credit cards rather than scanning unknown QR codes
-

■■ Kyoto

6 scams documented • Japan

Bar Tout / Hostess Bar Trap

often African or occasionally Japanese — flashes a big smile and says he knows a great bar just around the corner. 'First drink is free,' he promises. You follow him into a dimly lit lounge where hostesses immediately sit beside you. An hour later the bill arrives: ¥60,000 or more for watered-down whisky and the women's 'company fees.' The menu you were never shown listed ¥10,000 per drink and ¥15,000 per hour per hostess. Multiple r/JapanTravel threads have documented this exact sequence — tourists share photos of receipts in the tens of thousands of yen and describe bouncers who block the...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger on the street proactively recommends a specific bar and offers to walk you there
- The bar has no visible menu or prices posted at the entrance
- Hostesses immediately join you without you requesting company
- The tout is notably persistent after you decline once
- The bar's other customers are almost exclusively foreign tourists

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow anyone to a bar you didn't independently choose — this is the single most-repeated safety tip on r/JapanTravel
 - Before sitting down anywhere, ask to see the menu with all prices, including cover charges and any 'service fees'
 - Use Google Maps or Tabelog to find and navigate to bars on your own
 - If you feel pressured at the door or inside, leave immediately and loudly — hostess bars rely on social compliance
 - Stick to well-lit, busy izakayas or bars with clear signage and multiple Japanese customers inside
-

Fake Buddhist Monk Donation Request

You're walking the stone path toward a famous shrine when a saffron-robed figure approaches, places a small medallion or bracelet in your hand, and then opens a donation book showing names and large contributions — implying you should match them. The item was never requested, the 'blessing' was unsolicited, and you feel rude refusing after holding the gift. Before you know it you've handed over ¥1,000 or more for something that cost the scammer nothing. This scam is less aggressive in Japan than in other countries, but r/JapanTravel users have noted it popping up near major Kyoto tourist si...

■ Red Flags

- A monk approaches you on a public path or outside a temple rather than inside a recognized religious space
- They place an object in your hand without asking — creating the 'foot in the door' psychological effect

- The donation book shows implausibly large sums from previous contributors
- They follow you when you try to walk away
- The monk is alone rather than in a recognizable group from an established temple

■ How to Avoid

- Simply keep walking and do not accept anything handed to you — 'No thank you' with a slight bow is respected in Japanese culture
 - Donate to temples through official collection boxes inside the grounds, never to individuals approaching you outside
 - Know that legitimate temples in Kyoto — Kinkaku-ji, Fushimi Inari, Ryoan-ji — all have properly designated donation areas
 - If an item is placed in your hand, calmly hand it back and keep moving
 - Travel in pairs or small groups, as these operators typically target solo travelers
-

Hidden Cover Charge / Otoshi Shock

You never asked for the tiny dish of pickled vegetables that appeared the moment you sat down — but it was placed there as part of 'otoshi,' a traditional table cover charge that Japanese diners accept without question. When the bill arrives, each person at your table has been charged ¥500–¥800 for food they didn't order, plus a ¥500–¥1,000 seating charge that appeared nowhere in the English menu. This isn't always a scam — otoshi is a legitimate Japanese custom — but in tourist-heavy areas of Kyoto it can be combined with genuinely inflated prices and menus that obscure charges. A widely-s...

■ Red Flags

- A small dish appears at your table before you order anything without explanation
- The menu lacks English pricing or lists charges only in Japanese footnotes
- Staff hesitate or seem evasive when you ask about the cover charge before sitting
- The restaurant is located in a high-tourist area with no local clientele visible
- The entrance fee or 'table charge' seems higher than standard (above ¥1,000 per person)

■ How to Avoid

- Before sitting, ask 'Is there a cover charge or table charge?' — legitimate places will tell you upfront
 - Understand that otoshi (a small appetizer with a ¥500 charge) is standard Japanese practice, not a scam, and budget for it
 - Check Google Maps or Tabelog reviews which often mention cover charges in the comments
 - If the total seems wrong when the bill arrives, politely ask for an itemized receipt (receipts are standard in Japan)
 - Use the r/JapanTravel wiki which has a full explanation of otoshi and typical pricing so you know what's normal
-

Overpriced Restaurant Near Temples (No-Menu Trap)

After hours at Kinkaku-ji you're starving, and a restaurant right across the street is waving you in with a laminated picture menu — no prices visible. The food looks beautiful. You sit, order what seems like a modest meal, and when the bill comes it's ¥6,000 per person for what should have been a ¥1,500 lunch. The menu with prices was in Japanese on a board you missed. The staff were not rude, there was no deception per se — but you walked into one of Japan's most tourist-targeted restaurant zones without knowing the game. r/JapanTravel users consistently warn that restaurants in the immedi...

■ Red Flags

- The restaurant is directly across from or immediately adjacent to a major tourist site
- Menus shown at the door or in the window display photos but no yen amounts
- Staff wave you in enthusiastically without giving you time to check prices
- The clientele is 100% tourists with no Japanese locals dining

- The plastic food displays or picture menus look enticing but have no price tags

■ How to Avoid

- Always check for prices before sitting — a quick 'how much?' or pointing gesture is universally understood
 - Walk two or three streets away from major sights before choosing a restaurant for significantly better value
 - Use Tabelog or Google Maps to check prices and reviews before entering any restaurant in a tourist zone
 - Look for restaurants where Japanese locals are eating — if every face is foreign, so is the pricing
 - Set a mental price check rule: if you can't see any prices within 30 seconds of entering, walk out
-

The Kyoto Station Sympathy Scam

You are at Kyoto Station when a well-dressed man approaches speaking English and explains he has lost his wallet and needs money for a train ticket home. He shows you a business card and promises to repay you via bank transfer. A Reddit user on r/JapanTravelTips described this exact scam at Kyoto Station, noting the same individual has been running this story for months. Japan has an extremely low rate of street crime, so any stranger approaching you with a money request in a train station is almost certainly a scammer — the real response for a lost wallet in Japan is to report it to the st...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you in a station asking for money — extremely unusual in Japan
- They show a business card and promise bank transfer repayment
- The story involves a lost wallet, missed train, or stranded tourist
- They speak English fluently and seem to target foreign travelers specifically
- The same person has been reported multiple times at the same station

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline and keep walking — legitimate emergencies in Japan are handled by station staff
 - Point the person toward the koban (police box) located at every major JR station
 - Remember that Japan has one of the highest lost-wallet return rates in the world
 - Do not hand over cash to any stranger regardless of their story
 - Report repeat scammers to station staff or the koban
-

The Geisha District Photo Trap

■ ■ Gion district, Hanamikoji Street, paths around Kiyomizu-dera You spot someone in full geisha or maiko dress on Hanamikoji Street and snap a photo. A man appears claiming to be their 'manager' and demands payment for the unauthorized photograph — anywhere from 1,000 to 5,000 yen. In reality, the person is likely a tourist wearing a rental kimono, not an actual geisha. Meanwhile, the 'manager' is running a shakedown. Genuine geiko and maiko are private entertainers who work in ochaya (tea houses) and do not pose on the street. Kyoto has actually implemented rules restricting photography in parts of Gion to protect real geisha from harassment. Red Flags Someone in geisha attire is posing conspicuously on a street corner A 'manager' or 'minder' appears immediately after you take a photo Payment is demanded in cash on the spot for the photograph The person in geisha dress seems comfortable being photographed by many tourists The 'manager' speaks English and targets only foreign tourists How to Avoid Respect Gion photography restrictions — signs are posted in English at key entrances Real geiko travel quickly between engagements and do not pose for street photos If someone demands payment for a photo, politely decline and walk away — there is no legal basis Enjoy kimono rental culture respectfully by visiting the rental shops yourself Visit Gion Corner or a cultural performance for authentic geisha experiences ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Japanese Police (Keisatsu) station. Call 110. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at keishicho.metro.tokyo.lg.jp. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 1-10-5 Akasaka, Minato-ku, Tokyo. For emergencies: +81 3-3224-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Japan ■ ■

A man appears claiming to be their 'manager' and demands payment for the unauthorized photograph — anywhere from 1,000 to 5,000 yen. In reality, the person is likely a tourist wearing a rental kimono, not an actual geisha. Meanwhile, the 'manager' is running a shakedown. Genuine geiko and maiko are private entertainers who work in ochaya (tea houses) and do not pose on the street. Kyoto has actually implemented rules restricting photography in parts of Gion to protect real geisha from harassment.

■ Red Flags

- Someone in geisha attire is posing conspicuously on a street corner
- A 'manager' or 'minder' appears immediately after you take a photo
- Payment is demanded in cash on the spot for the photograph
- The person in geisha dress seems comfortable being photographed by many tourists
- The 'manager' speaks English and targets only foreign tourists

■ How to Avoid

- Respect Gion photography restrictions — signs are posted in English at key entrances
 - Real geiko travel quickly between engagements and do not pose for street photos
 - If someone demands payment for a photo, politely decline and walk away — there is no legal basis
 - Enjoy kimono rental culture respectfully by visiting the rental shops yourself
 - Visit Gion Corner or a cultural performance for authentic geisha experiences
-

■■ Nara

3 scams documented • Japan

The Aggressive Deer Shakedown

You hold up a cracker and one deer approaches politely. But within seconds, five more deer have spotted the crackers in your hand and surround you. They start nudging, headbutting, nipping at your clothes, and one grabs the cracker packet right out of your bag. In the commotion, your phone falls from your pocket, or a deer tears your shopping bag. As r/JapanTravel users report frequently, deer-related injuries in Nara hit record numbers in 2024, with 35 tourists injured in September alone. This isn't a traditional scam, but it's a costly encounter that catches thousands of tourists off guar...

■ Red Flags

- You are holding visible food or cracker packets that attract deer from a wide radius
- Multiple deer approach simultaneously rather than one at a time
- Deer begin headbutting, nipping, or pulling at your clothing or bags
- You are surrounded with no clear escape route on a narrow path
- Male deer with antlers are present -- they cause the most serious injuries

■ How to Avoid

- Break crackers into small pieces and hold them one at a time -- hide the rest in a sealed bag inside your daypack
 - Show empty hands with palms open when you want deer to stop approaching -- they understand this gesture
 - Feed deer in open areas where you can back away, not on narrow paths or near fences
 - Do not tease deer by raising crackers above their heads -- this triggers aggressive lunging
 - Keep bags zipped and phones in secure pockets before engaging with any deer
-

The Fake Monk Donation Hustle

As you walk along the approach to Todai-ji Temple past the towering Nandaimon Gate, a man dressed in saffron robes stands near the path holding prayer beads and a collection box. He bows solemnly, hands you a small gold charm or blessing card, and gestures toward his donation box. It feels spiritual and you drop in 1,000 yen. But as r/JapanTravel users have documented, this man is not affiliated with any temple. Real Buddhist monks in Japan rarely solicit donations on the street -- temple donations happen inside the temple at designated boxes. These fake monks appear at major tourist temple...

■ Red Flags

- A monk solicits donations outside on the street rather than inside the temple grounds
- They hand you a trinket, bracelet, or card before asking for money, creating a sense of obligation
- Their robes look brand-new or do not match the style of the temple's actual monks
- They do not speak when approached and communicate only through gestures
- They are positioned near but not inside the actual temple complex

■ How to Avoid

- Know that legitimate Buddhist monks in Japan do not solicit donations on the street
- Make donations only at the official saisen boxes (offering boxes) inside temple buildings
- Politely decline any items pressed into your hands by returning them immediately
- Walk past without engaging -- a simple bow and continued walking is culturally appropriate
- If you want to support the temple, buy an official omamori (charm) from the temple's own gift counter

The Overpriced Souvenir Stall

■ ■ Shopping street between Kintetsu Nara Station and Nara Park (Sanjo-dori and Higashimuki-dori) You're walking the main shopping street from Kintetsu Nara Station toward the park when you pass ... You're walking the main shopping street from Kintetsu Nara Station toward the park when you pass stalls selling deer-themed souvenirs, matcha snacks, and traditional crafts. A cute deer-patterned hand towel catches your eye at 1,800 yen. You buy it, feeling good about supporting a local vendor. Later at the Todai-ji museum shop, you spot the exact same towel for 600 yen. As travelers on r/JapanTravel note, the stalls lining the tourist approach to Nara Park mark up common souvenirs by 100 to 200 percent compared to prices at the temple shops, Kintetsu Nara Station's souvenir floor, or Nara's established department stores. The items are mass-produced imports, not local artisan crafts. Red Flags Items lack packaging showing a manufacturer's name or origin The same generic deer-themed products appear at every stall along the street Prices are not displayed and are quoted verbally when you show interest Stalls are concentrated between the station and the park entrance -- the heaviest tourist traffic zone Vendors become persistent when you browse without buying How to Avoid Buy souvenirs at the official temple shops at Todai-ji, Kasuga Taisha, or Kofuku-ji for fair prices Check prices at the souvenir floor inside Kintetsu Nara Station before walking to the park Compare prices on Amazon Japan or Rakuten for common items like hand towels and keychains Look for items with the artisan's name or workshop information to ensure they are genuinely local Wait until the end of your Nara visit to buy souvenirs so you can compare prices across multiple locations ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Japanese Police (Keisatsu) station. Call 110. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at keishicho.metro.tokyo.lg.jp. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 1-10-5 Akasaka, Minato-ku, Tokyo. For emergencies: +81 3-3224-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Japan ■ ■

You're walking the main shopping street from Kintetsu Nara Station toward the park when you pass stalls selling deer-themed souvenirs, matcha snacks, and traditional crafts. A cute deer-patterned hand towel catches your eye at 1,800 yen. You buy it, feeling good about supporting a local vendor. Later at the Todai-ji museum shop, you spot the exact same towel for 600 yen. As travelers on r/JapanTravel note, the stalls lining the tourist approach to Nara Park mark up common souvenirs by 100 to 200 percent compared to prices at the temple shops, Kintetsu Nara Station's souvenir floor, or Nara'...

■ Red Flags

- Items lack packaging showing a manufacturer's name or origin
- The same generic deer-themed products appear at every stall along the street
- Prices are not displayed and are quoted verbally when you show interest
- Stalls are concentrated between the station and the park entrance -- the heaviest tourist traffic zone
- Vendors become persistent when you browse without buying

■ How to Avoid

- Buy souvenirs at the official temple shops at Todai-ji, Kasuga Taisha, or Kofuku-ji for fair prices
 - Check prices at the souvenir floor inside Kintetsu Nara Station before walking to the park
 - Compare prices on Amazon Japan or Rakuten for common items like hand towels and keychains
 - Look for items with the artisan's name or workshop information to ensure they are genuinely local
 - Wait until the end of your Nara visit to buy souvenirs so you can compare prices across multiple locations
-

■■ Okinawa

3 scams documented • Japan

The Naha Bottakuri Bar

You're exploring Naha's nightlife along Kokusai Street when a friendly local invites you to a 'great bar' down a side alley in the Matsuyama district. The entrance looks legitimate, and the tout promises cheap all-you-can-drink specials. Once inside, the atmosphere is pleasant and drinks keep flowing. But when the bill arrives, it's 30,000 to 50,000 yen -- drinks were served in premium-priced sizes you never ordered, and mysterious 'seat charges' and 'service fees' have been stacked on. As r/JapanTravel users warn, these bottakuri (rip-off) bars specifically target foreign tourists and mili...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger on the street invites you to a bar you've never heard of
- The bar is down an alley or on a higher floor with no visible menu outside
- Prices for drinks are not clearly displayed or quoted before ordering
- Staff pour drinks without asking your preference or confirming the size
- The bar has no online reviews or only suspicious five-star ratings

■ How to Avoid

- Choose bars yourself by checking Google Maps reviews or Tabelog before going out
 - Ask for a menu with prices before ordering anything and photograph it
 - Decline invitations from touts on the street -- legitimate bars don't need to recruit on sidewalks
 - Stick to well-lit, ground-floor establishments along main streets like Kokusai-dori
 - Set a budget and pay as you go rather than running a tab in unfamiliar bars
-

The Rental Car Insurance Upsell

At the rental counter, the agent launches into an alarming speech about Okinawa's narrow roads, typhoon-damaged guardrails, and expensive repair costs. Before you know it, you've been talked into three additional insurance packages, a GPS unit, an ETC card deposit, and a 'road safety kit' -- tripling your daily rate to 9,000 yen. As travelers on r/JapanTravel note, while basic CDW insurance is essential, the additional NOC waiver and premium packages are often unnecessary padding that rental staff earn commission on. The scare tactics about Okinawa's roads are exaggerated.

■ Red Flags

- Staff use fear-based language about local road conditions or typhoon damage

- Multiple insurance packages are presented as mandatory when they are optional
- The quoted price at pickup is significantly higher than what you booked online
- Add-ons are bundled together so you can't easily decline individual items
- Staff rush through paperwork and discourage you from reading the contract

■ How to Avoid

- Research which insurance coverage your credit card already provides for rentals in Japan
- Book through reputable agencies like Toyota Rent-a-Car or Times Car Rental with transparent pricing
- Ask the agent to itemize every charge and explain which are optional versus mandatory
- Use your phone's GPS or rent a pocket Wi-Fi instead of paying for the agency's GPS unit
- Read the full contract before signing and decline add-ons you do not need

The Fake Military Discount Vendor

■ ■ *Souvenir shops near American Village in Chatan and Naha's Makishi Public Market area* You're browsing shops near American Village when a vendor waves you over, promising a 'special ... You're browsing shops near American Village when a vendor waves you over, promising a 'special military discount' or 'tourist-only price' on Okinawan pottery, awamori bottles, or shisa statues. The price seems reasonable until you find the identical item at a department store or Kokusai Street shop for half the cost. As discussed in r/okinawa, some vendors near military bases and tourist zones mark up items by 100 percent, then offer a fake 'discount' that still leaves you paying well above retail. The items themselves are often mass-produced imports rather than genuine Okinawan crafts. Red Flags Vendor specifically mentions military or tourist discounts without being asked Items lack labels showing the artisan's name or workshop of origin Prices are not displayed and are quoted verbally depending on who is asking The shop is directly adjacent to a base gate or in a heavy tourist corridor Vendor becomes pushy or guilt-trips you about supporting local artisans How to Avoid Compare prices at Naha's established shops on Kokusai Street or department stores before buying Look for the 'Made in Okinawa' certification mark on genuine local crafts Visit Tsuboya Pottery Street for authentic Okinawan ceramics directly from workshops Check prices online for popular items like awamori or shisa figures before negotiating Take your time -- legitimate shops won't pressure you into immediate purchases ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Japanese Police (Keisatsu) station. Call 110. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at keishicho.metro.tokyo.lg.jp. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 1-10-5 Akasaka, Minato-ku, Tokyo. For emergencies: +81 3-3224-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Japan ■ ■

You're browsing shops near American Village when a vendor waves you over, promising a 'special military discount' or 'tourist-only price' on Okinawan pottery, awamori bottles, or shisa statues. The price seems reasonable until you find the identical item at a department store or Kokusai Street shop for half the cost. As discussed in r/okinawa, some vendors near military bases and tourist zones mark up items by 100 percent, then offer a fake 'discount' that still leaves you paying well above retail. The items themselves are often mass-produced imports rather than genuine Okinawan crafts.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor specifically mentions military or tourist discounts without being asked
- Items lack labels showing the artisan's name or workshop of origin
- Prices are not displayed and are quoted verbally depending on who is asking
- The shop is directly adjacent to a base gate or in a heavy tourist corridor
- Vendor becomes pushy or guilt-trips you about supporting local artisans

■ How to Avoid

- Compare prices at Naha's established shops on Kokusai Street or department stores before buying
- Look for the 'Made in Okinawa' certification mark on genuine local crafts
- Visit Tsuboya Pottery Street for authentic Okinawan ceramics directly from workshops

- Check prices online for popular items like awamori or shisa figures before negotiating
 - Take your time -- legitimate shops won't pressure you into immediate purchases
-

■■ Osaka

6 scams documented • Japan

Dotonbori Cabaret Bar Cover Charge

You order a few drinks and have a great time chatting with the staff. When the bill arrives it's ¥50,000 — you're charged for an undisclosed cover fee, a 'table charge,' charges for every snack placed in front of you, and inflated drink prices. The charges were listed somewhere in Japanese but never explained.

■ Red Flags

- Tout outside actively inviting you into the venue
- No English menu with clear prices shown before you sit
- Very friendly staff who continuously bring you unrequested items
- Never enter a bar because someone outside is specifically recruiting you
- Always ask for an English menu with all charges listed before ordering anything

■ How to Avoid

- Never enter a bar because someone outside is specifically recruiting you
 - Always ask for an English menu with all charges listed before ordering anything
 - Look up bars on Google Maps or Tabelog before entering rather than following touts
-

Coin Change Shortchange

You pay for a souvenir and the cashier counts out your yen change in a mix of coins and bills, placing them quickly in your hand. Japan is normally extremely honest, but at tourist-heavy shops some staff have learned to shortchange the coin portion knowing most foreign visitors can't quickly calculate yen coins. A ¥100 coin and a ¥10 coin look different but foreigners sometimes mix them up.

■ Red Flags

- Change returned very quickly without being counted aloud
- Mix of many small-denomination coins given as change
- Shop in very high tourist foot traffic area
- Familiarize yourself with yen coin sizes and values before shopping
- Count your coins in front of the cashier — this is socially acceptable in Japan

■ How to Avoid

- Familiarize yourself with yen coin sizes and values before shopping
 - Count your coins in front of the cashier — this is socially acceptable in Japan
 - Use IC cards (Suica, ICOCA) for transit and cashless payment where possible
-

Overpriced Tourist Lunch Menus

A set lunch that would cost ¥800 anywhere else is priced at ¥2,500 here. The food is identical to standard Japanese fare and there's nothing special about the experience except the proximity to the castle.

■ Red Flags

- Restaurant is physically attached to or directly facing a major tourist sight
- Prices not displayed outside — menu only available after entering

- English menu prominently displayed with simplified 'set meal' options
- Walk five minutes away from any major sight before choosing a restaurant
- Use Google Maps to find highly-rated restaurants in the surrounding area

■ How to Avoid

- Walk five minutes away from any major sight before choosing a restaurant
 - Use Google Maps to find highly-rated restaurants in the surrounding area
 - Osaka's covered shopping arcades (Tenjinbashisuji, etc.) have excellent cheap food far from tourist premiums
-

Counterfeit Brand Goods in Shinsaibashi

a luxury bag or branded sneakers at less than half the retail price. The goods look convincing with all the right labels, but they're counterfeit. You bring them home only to have a customs officer confiscate them, or give them as a gift to someone who immediately notices the poor quality.

■ Red Flags

- Brand-name goods priced significantly below retail without a clear sale reason
- Goods sold from a small shop or market stall rather than an official brand outlet
- Seller is evasive about the product's origin or authenticity
- If a price seems too good to be true for a luxury brand, it's counterfeit
- Buy branded goods only from official stores or major department stores like Isetan or Hankyu

■ How to Avoid

- If a price seems too good to be true for a luxury brand, it's counterfeit
 - Buy branded goods only from official stores or major department stores like Isetan or Hankyu
 - Importing counterfeit goods back to most countries is a customs offense
-

The Bar Tout Redirect Scam

You are looking for a restaurant in Dotonbori when a friendly person on the street tells you the popular chain izakaya you want is full but they know an affiliated restaurant nearby. You follow them to a small bar with no visible prices. After a few drinks and some small plates, the bill is 30,000-50,000 yen (about \$200-350). A Reddit user on r/JapanTravelTips reported being scammed in Osaka after ordering through a QR code menu with no servers and receiving a bill far higher than expected. In 2024, Japanese police arrested 15 suspects in Kabukicho for redirecting customers away from popula...

■ Red Flags

- A person on the street tells you a restaurant is full and redirects you to a supposedly affiliated place
- The redirected establishment has no visible menu, no prices displayed, and no other customers
- You order through a QR code with no staff interaction and no clear prices on the digital menu
- The bar is in a basement or upper floor with no street-level signage
- Staff become aggressive or block the exit when you question the bill

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow street touts (kyakuhiki) to restaurants in Dotonbori -- their operation is illegal under Osaka municipal ordinance
 - Check Google Maps to verify if a restaurant is actually full before accepting a stranger's claim
 - Eat only at restaurants that display clear prices on a physical or digital menu before you order
 - If a QR code menu has no prices, leave immediately before ordering
 - If overcharged, call the police at 110 -- Japanese police take fraud against tourists seriously and respond quickly
-

The Fake Beggar Outside Train Stations

■ ■ Namba station exits, Shin-Osaka station, Osaka station approaches, and near Dotonbori bridges A man outside Namba station approaches you speaking English and asks for money, claiming to be stranded or hungry. Unlike genuine Japanese homeless who sit quietly with signs near stations, this person actively approaches tourists. A Reddit user on [r/JapanTravelTips](#) warned about this common Osaka scam: a man approaches foreigners asking for money who is not a genuine beggar but a professional scammer. Real Japanese beggars sit outside stations with signs and never approach passersby. The active approach targeting foreigners specifically is the telltale sign of a scam. These individuals often circulate between tourist areas and may become aggressive if you engage. **Red Flags** A person near a train station actively approaches you speaking English to ask for money They tell a specific story about being robbed, stranded, or separated from their group They specifically target foreign-looking tourists and ignore Japanese pedestrians Their clothing and appearance do not match someone who is genuinely homeless They become persistent or follow you after you decline **How to Avoid** Know that genuine Japanese homeless people do not approach strangers -- anyone who does is likely running a scam Say 'Sumimasen' (excuse me) and keep walking without stopping Do not engage in conversation or make eye contact If someone becomes aggressive, walk toward a koban (police box) -- there is one at every major station Report aggressive beggars to station staff or the nearest koban ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Japanese Police (Keisatsu) station. Call 110. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at [keishicho.metro.tokyo.lg.jp](#). ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 1-10-5 Akasaka, Minato-ku, Tokyo. For emergencies: +81 3-3224-5000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **Frequently Asked Questions** Is Osaka safe for tourists? ▼

Unlike genuine Japanese homeless who sit quietly with signs near stations, this person actively approaches tourists. A Reddit user on [r/JapanTravelTips](#) warned about this common Osaka scam: a man approaches foreigners asking for money who is not a genuine beggar but a professional scammer. Real Japanese beggars sit outside stations with signs and never approach passersby. The active approach targeting foreigners specifically is the telltale sign of a scam. These individuals often circulate between tourist areas and may become aggressive if you engage.

■ Red Flags

- A person near a train station actively approaches you speaking English to ask for money
- They tell a specific story about being robbed, stranded, or separated from their group
- They specifically target foreign-looking tourists and ignore Japanese pedestrians
- Their clothing and appearance do not match someone who is genuinely homeless
- They become persistent or follow you after you decline

■ How to Avoid

- Know that genuine Japanese homeless people do not approach strangers -- anyone who does is likely running a scam
- Say 'Sumimasen' (excuse me) and keep walking without stopping
- Do not engage in conversation or make eye contact
- If someone becomes aggressive, walk toward a koban (police box) -- there is one at every major station
- Report aggressive beggars to station staff or the nearest koban

■■ Sapporo

3 scams documented • Japan

The Susukino Rip-Off Bar

You're exploring Sapporo's neon-lit Susukino district after a day at the Snow Festival when a friendly barker on a side street waves you over. 'Great bar upstairs! First drink only 500 yen!' It sounds like a bargain, so you head up the narrow staircase. Inside, the menu is only in Japanese and the hostess orders rounds of snacks and

drinks you didn't ask for. An hour later, the bill arrives: 50,000 yen or more. When you protest, large men appear at the door. These bottakuri bars are a known problem in Susukino, and despite a 2022 city ordinance banning barkers, Sapporo's own data shows soli...

■ Red Flags

- A barker on the street actively tries to pull you into an upstairs or basement bar
- The advertised entry price or first-drink price seems too cheap for a sit-down venue
- There is no English menu and staff order items for you without clearly stating prices
- The bar is on an upper floor or in a basement with no street visibility
- Staff become physically intimidating when you question charges or try to leave

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow a street barker into any bar -- if they're soliciting, they're likely breaking Sapporo's 2022 ordinance
 - Choose bars and izakayas listed on Tabelog or Google Maps with verified reviews from other tourists
 - Ask for an English menu and confirm all prices before ordering anything
 - Stick to the main streets of Susukino and well-lit venues at ground level with visible interiors
 - If a bill seems wrong, stay calm, refuse to pay the inflated amount, and call the police (110) -- officers will mediate
-

The Fake Shrine Monk

He presses a small prayer bead bracelet or golden sticker into your hand and bows. It feels like a kind gesture, so you accept. Then he produces a donation book showing previous entries of 5,000 and 10,000 yen and points expectantly at a blank line. When you try to return the item, he refuses and becomes insistent. As [r/japantravel](#) users explain, real Buddhist monks in Japan never approach strangers for money on the street. Genuine monks stand silently with a donation bowl and never initiate contact. These imposters, often flagged near popular shrines across Japan since 2016, have expanded ...

■ Red Flags

- A 'monk' approaches you rather than standing silently in place
- They press a trinket, bracelet, or amulet into your hands without being asked
- A donation book shows suspiciously high previous contributions to pressure you
- They become aggressive or guilt-trip you when you try to return the item or refuse to donate
- They are not near the actual entrance of a shrine or temple but in a park or shopping area

■ How to Avoid

- Do not accept any item pressed into your hands -- hold your palms up and say 'Kekkou desu' (No, thank you)
 - Know that legitimate Japanese monks never approach tourists, ask for money, or give unsolicited items
 - If you accidentally accept something, place it on the ground and walk away -- you owe nothing
 - Report fake monks to nearby koban (police boxes), which are staffed around major Sapporo attractions
 - If you want to donate at a shrine, use the official offering box (saisen-bako) at the entrance
-

The Overpriced Crab Restaurant Tout

■ ■ *Tanukikoji Shopping Arcade and near Nijo Fish Market* You're wandering Tanukikoji arcade, hungry for Hokkaido's famous crab, when a tout outside a ... You're wandering Tanukikoji arcade, hungry for Hokkaido's famous crab, when a tout outside a restaurant waves a menu with glossy photos: 'Best king crab in Sapporo! Special price today!' The menu shows a crab set for 3,000 yen -- a steal for king crab. Inside, after you're seated, the actual menu appears with prices two or three times higher. The 'special price' was for a tiny appetizer portion, not a full meal. Your actual crab course arrives at 12,000 yen. As travelers on [r/sapporo](#) note, legitimate Hokkaido crab restaurants don't need to employ touts on the street. The quality spots near Nijo Market post clear prices and let the food speak for itself. If someone is pulling you in off the sidewalk, the prices inside will not match the pitch outside. **Red Flags** A tout stands outside the restaurant actively soliciting passing tourists in English The advertised price for crab seems dramatically lower than other restaurants in the area The menu

shown outside differs from the one provided at the table The restaurant is above street level or tucked away where passersby cannot see inside Staff are reluctant to confirm the total price of your meal before you order How to Avoid Research crab restaurants in advance on Tabelog, Google Maps, or r/japantravel for honest pricing Avoid any restaurant that employs touts -- quality establishments in Sapporo do not need to solicit customers Visit Nijo Fish Market stalls where prices are displayed openly and you can see the product before buying Ask to see the full menu with prices before sitting down, and confirm the total cost of any set meal Budget 5,000-15,000 yen per person for a quality crab meal -- anything below 3,000 yen for king crab is bait ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Japanese Police (Keisatsu) station. Call 110. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at keishicho.metro.tokyo.lg.jp. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 1-10-5 Akasaka, Minato-ku, Tokyo. For emergencies: +81 3-3224-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Japan ■■

You're wandering Tanukikoji arcade, hungry for Hokkaido's famous crab, when a tout outside a restaurant waves a menu with glossy photos: 'Best king crab in Sapporo! Special price today!' The menu shows a crab set for 3,000 yen -- a steal for king crab. Inside, after you're seated, the actual menu appears with prices two or three times higher. The 'special price' was for a tiny appetizer portion, not a full meal. Your actual crab course arrives at 12,000 yen. As travelers on [r/sapporo](https://www.reddit.com/r/sapporo) note, legitimate Hokkaido crab restaurants don't need to employ touts on the street. The quality spots near ...

■ Red Flags

- A tout stands outside the restaurant actively soliciting passing tourists in English
- The advertised price for crab seems dramatically lower than other restaurants in the area
- The menu shown outside differs from the one provided at the table
- The restaurant is above street level or tucked away where passersby cannot see inside
- Staff are reluctant to confirm the total price of your meal before you order

■ How to Avoid

- Research crab restaurants in advance on Tabelog, Google Maps, or [r/japantravel](https://www.reddit.com/r/japantravel) for honest pricing
 - Avoid any restaurant that employs touts -- quality establishments in Sapporo do not need to solicit customers
 - Visit Nijo Fish Market stalls where prices are displayed openly and you can see the product before buying
 - Ask to see the full menu with prices before sitting down, and confirm the total cost of any set meal
 - Budget 5,000-15,000 yen per person for a quality crab meal -- anything below 3,000 yen for king crab is bait
-

■■ Tokyo

7 scams documented • Japan

The Bottakuri Bar Overcharge

A friendly local-looking guy outside a Roppongi bar invites you in for 'cheap drinks.' Inside, attractive hostesses keep your glass full without explaining the price. At the end of the night a bill arrives for ¥80,000 — four bouncers materialize at the door before you can object. You sign just to get out safely. These 'bottakuri' (rip-off) bars are well-documented in Tokyo's nightlife districts and specifically target solo male tourists who don't know what they're getting into.

■ Red Flags

- Someone actively recruits you from outside the venue
- No visible drinks menu or prices
- Hostess keeps ordering drinks without asking

- Intimidating staff appear when you question the bill
- Avoid any bar you didn't find on Google Maps with real reviews

■ How to Avoid

- Avoid any bar you didn't find on Google Maps with real reviews
 - Never enter a venue with a tout stationed outside
 - If no prices are visible, ask immediately and leave if they're evasive
 - Stick to bars with other tourists visible inside
-

The Kabukicho Street Tout Ambush

When you try to walk around him he sidesteps to stay in front of you, gently grabbing your arm. You think he's just aggressive about his pitch — but his partner may already be working your pockets. A Redditor documented being physically prevented from passing by a tout outside Golden Gai while the man's friend reportedly pickpocketed a French woman nearby for three minutes before giving up.

■ Red Flags

- Being physically blocked or touched by a tout
- Someone insists on walking you somewhere
- Tout disappears once you're inside the venue
- Late night, basement or alley location
- Walk straight, confidently, and don't engage

■ How to Avoid

- Walk straight, confidently, and don't engage
 - If blocked, be assertive immediately — polite often doesn't work here
 - Stick to well-lit main streets at night
 - Automated announcements in Kabukicho literally warn tourists about touts
-

The English Conversation / Student Scam

they're studying for an exam. After a pleasant 20-minute chat they suggest going for tea together. You end up at a very expensive tea house or bar where the 'student' orders lavishly and then vanishes when the bill arrives, leaving you with a ¥15,000 tab. This long-con variation is occasionally reported in Tokyo's tourist spots.

■ Red Flags

- Unprompted English practice request near tourist sites
- New friend suggests going somewhere specific — not somewhere you've chosen
- Friend seems to know the staff at the venue
- Friend visits the bathroom just as the bill arrives
- Suggest your own venue (that you found independently) if you want to have tea

■ How to Avoid

- Suggest your own venue (that you found independently) if you want to have tea
 - Virtually no one with good intentions will approach you and try to entice you somewhere
 - Keep your radar extra sensitive in entertainment and tourist areas
-

The Overpriced Metered Taxi

The driver nods, sets off — and proceeds to take a very scenic route to your hotel. The meter clicks away and your ¥800 ride becomes ¥4,000. When you try to use Google Maps to protest the route, he gestures that there was road construction or traffic. Tokyo taxis are generally honest but late-night, tourist areas do have a minority

of drivers who exploit directionally-challenged visitors.

■ Red Flags

- Driver doesn't use GPS or maps for a destination you described
- Route appears longer than expected
- Driver ignores your navigation suggestions
- Use Google Maps to follow your route in real time
- Screenshot the expected route before getting in

■ How to Avoid

- Use Google Maps to follow your route in real time
 - Screenshot the expected route before getting in
 - Use the Go taxi app for pre-set pricing
 - From Narita/Haneda, take the airport train — far cheaper than taxi
-

The Fake Kyoto Airbnb Cancellation

you'll need to cancel your reservation (at partial penalty) and pay them directly in cash for an 'identical' replacement room they can't list on Airbnb. It's a setup to force you to cancel (so they keep your money) and pay off-platform with no recourse. The host even claimed he had 'tears in his eyes' and wasn't trying to scam you. Airbnb support resolved this particular case, but many tourists get caught.

■ Red Flags

- Last-minute cancellation claim before non-refundable deadline
- Host wants you to cancel rather than cancelling themselves
- Offer of replacement unit requiring cash or off-platform payment
- Emotional manipulation to override your suspicion
- Never cancel your reservation — make the host cancel if there's an issue (they incur the penalty)

■ How to Avoid

- Never cancel your reservation — make the host cancel if there's an issue (they incur the penalty)
 - Contact Airbnb support immediately when anything feels off
 - Kyoto in particular has hosts trying to evade short-term rental laws
-

The Fake Monk / Donation Collector

Someone in Buddhist monk robes approaches you near Sensoji temple and places a small golden trinket or prayer card in your hands as a 'gift.' Before you know it, they're showing you a donation envelope and your free gift suddenly costs ¥3,000. The major Buddhist orders in Japan have specifically banned this type of solicitation because it's so widespread — these are not real monks.

■ Red Flags

- Unsolicited gift placed in your hands near tourist sites
- Donation envelope produced immediately after the gift
- Person dressed in religious robes approaches specifically tourists
- Don't accept anything placed in your hands
- Real monks in Japan do not solicit donations from tourists on the street

■ How to Avoid

- Don't accept anything placed in your hands
- Real monks in Japan do not solicit donations from tourists on the street
- Hand the item back immediately if you've already accepted it

The Kabukicho Crypto Wallet Drain

■ ■ Kabukicho red-light district in Shinjuku, Golden Gai alley bars (rare but documented), Roppongi nightlife area A friendly tout in Kabukicho named 'Ron' (or a similar Western name) invites you to a 'great bar ... A friendly tout in Kabukicho named 'Ron' (or a similar Western name) invites you to a 'great bar with cheap drinks.' The first round is free. Subsequent drinks are strong — stronger than normal. You wake up hours later unable to remember how you got back to your hotel. You check your phone and find your cryptocurrency wallet has been emptied. A Tokyo-based investigation documented this: while the victim was unconscious, bar staff used Face ID on his phone to access his crypto account and drained \$20,000. Reddit users on r/JapanTravelTips warned about Shinjuku specifically: 'My first time in Japan and was there for 3.5 days. So many scammers in tourist areas.' The Kabukicho area has seen convictions for bottakuri (rip-off) bar schemes. Red Flags A tout on the street approaches you in English and invites you to a specific bar or club by name The first drink is offered free or at an impossibly low price to get you inside Drinks feel unusually strong or you become disoriented after consuming less alcohol than would normally affect you Your phone has Face ID or other biometric unlock that could be used while you are unconscious The bar is located in a basement or upstairs room with no street-level visibility How to Avoid Never follow street touts (kyakuhiki) to bars in Kabukicho or Roppongi — it is technically illegal in Tokyo and signals a scam Disable Face ID on your phone and use a complex PIN when going out at night — this prevents biometric access while you are unconscious Keep cryptocurrency apps in a separate, secured device or use a hardware wallet rather than your main phone Choose your own bars using Google Maps reviews and Tabelog ratings — walk in on your own terms If you feel suddenly very intoxicated after one or two drinks, tell staff you are leaving and get to a public area immediately ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Japanese Police (Keisatsu) station. Call 110. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at keishicho.metro.tokyo.lg.jp. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 1-10-5 Akasaka, Minato-ku, Tokyo. For emergencies: +81 3-3224-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. Frequently Asked Questions Is Tokyo safe for tourists? ▼

A friendly tout in Kabukicho named 'Ron' (or a similar Western name) invites you to a 'great bar with cheap drinks.' The first round is free. Subsequent drinks are strong — stronger than normal. You wake up hours later unable to remember how you got back to your hotel. You check your phone and find your cryptocurrency wallet has been emptied. A Tokyo-based investigation documented this: while the victim was unconscious, bar staff used Face ID on his phone to access his crypto account and drained \$20,000. Reddit users on r/JapanTravelTips warned about Shinjuku specifically: 'My first time in...

■ Red Flags

- A tout on the street approaches you in English and invites you to a specific bar or club by name
- The first drink is offered free or at an impossibly low price to get you inside
- Drinks feel unusually strong or you become disoriented after consuming less alcohol than would normally affect you
- Your phone has Face ID or other biometric unlock that could be used while you are unconscious
- The bar is located in a basement or upstairs room with no street-level visibility

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow street touts (kyakuhiki) to bars in Kabukicho or Roppongi — it is technically illegal in Tokyo and signals a scam
- Disable Face ID on your phone and use a complex PIN when going out at night — this prevents biometric access while you are unconscious
- Keep cryptocurrency apps in a separate, secured device or use a hardware wallet rather than your main phone
- Choose your own bars using Google Maps reviews and Tabelog ratings — walk in on your own terms
- If you feel suddenly very intoxicated after one or two drinks, tell staff you are leaving and get to a public area immediately

■ ■ Yokohama

The Chinatown All-You-Can-Eat Bait

You enter Yokohama's Chinatown attracted by signs advertising 'All-You-Can-Eat Chinese Buffet -- 1,500 yen!' The price seems incredible for unlimited food. Inside, the dining room is cramped and the food options are limited to a few steam trays of mediocre dumplings and fried rice. When the bill comes, it's 3,500 yen per person -- the buffet was 1,500 yen but there's a mandatory drink order at 800 yen, a service charge of 500 yen, and a weekend surcharge of 700 yen, none of which were mentioned on the street sign. As [r/JapanTravel](#) posters warn, several Chinatown all-you-can-eat restaurants ...

■ Red Flags

- The advertised all-you-can-eat price seems significantly cheaper than neighboring restaurants
- Street-facing signage shows only the base price without mentioning additional charges
- Staff rush you to a seat without showing a full menu or explaining total costs
- The dining room feels more like a tourist processing facility than a restaurant
- Online reviews mention hidden charges, poor quality, or bait-and-switch pricing

■ How to Avoid

- Check Tabelog or Google Maps reviews for any Chinatown restaurant before entering -- look for specific price complaints
- Ask to see the full menu with all charges listed before being seated
- Choose restaurants rated above 3.5 on Tabelog, which indicates quality by Japanese dining standards
- Opt for individual dishes at established restaurants like Heichinrou or Manchinrou rather than all-you-can-eat deals
- Walk deeper into Chinatown's side streets where restaurants rely on repeat local customers rather than tourist foot traffic

The Izakaya Hidden Charge

The menu shows beer at 500 yen and yakitori at 150 yen per skewer -- classic Japanese bar prices. You order freely, enjoying the ambiance. Then the bill arrives with a 1,500-yen otoshi (appetizer charge) per person, a table charge of 500 yen, and a 10 percent late-night surcharge. Your casual 3,000-yen evening has become 7,000 yen. As [r/japanlife](#) users explain, otoshi is a legitimate Japanese custom where a small appetizer is served automatically, typically 300 to 500 yen. But some izakayas in tourist areas inflate the otoshi to 1,000 to 1,500 yen and stack additional charges that regular c...

■ Red Flags

- A small dish appears at your table that you did not order -- this is the otoshi and will be charged
- The menu does not list the otoshi price or any table charges
- Staff do not explain the charging structure when you sit down
- The izakaya is in a heavy nightlife district near the station targeting after-work crowds and tourists
- Late-night surcharges or weekend surcharges are not posted visibly

■ How to Avoid

- Ask 'Otoshi wa ikura desu ka?' (How much is the otoshi?) when seated to know the automatic appetizer charge
- Look for izakayas that display their otoshi and table charge policy on the menu or at the entrance
- Use chains like Torikizoku or Watami where pricing is transparent and uniform across locations
- Check if there's a time-based surcharge for sitting after a certain hour, especially past 10 PM
- Set a budget and ask for the bill periodically rather than running a large tab

The Counterfeit Goods Street Seller

■ ■ *Yokohama Chinatown side streets and near Motomachi shopping street* Browsing the side alleys of Yokohama Chinatown, you notice a vendor with an impressive display of ... Browsing the side alleys of Yokohama Chinatown, you notice a vendor with an impressive display of designer brand goods -- handbags, watches, and sunglasses at a fraction of retail price. A Louis Vuitton bag for 5,000 yen? A Rolex for 8,000 yen? The vendor assures you they're 'export quality surplus.' You buy a bag for your friend back home. At customs, the bag is confiscated as counterfeit, and in some countries you could face a fine for importing fake goods. As r/japan users note, while counterfeiting is taken seriously in Japan, some vendors in Chinatown areas operate discreetly. Buying counterfeit goods is illegal in Japan and can result in confiscation and embarrassment. Red Flags Luxury brand goods are priced at 90 percent or more below retail Products are displayed in a temporary setup that can be packed away quickly The seller avoids having you inspect the goods closely or compare to photos of originals There are no receipts, brand packaging, or authenticity certificates The goods are sold from side alleys or by vendors who move location frequently How to Avoid Buy designer goods only from authorized retailers in Motomachi or department stores like Sogo Know that legitimate surplus or outlet goods are sold through official brand outlet stores, not street vendors Remember that importing counterfeit goods can result in confiscation at customs in your home country If a luxury brand price seems too good to be true, it is counterfeit without exception Report counterfeit goods sellers to the local koban (police box) if you encounter them ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Japanese Police (Keisatsu) station. Call 110. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at keishicho.metro.tokyo.lg.jp. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 1-10-5 Akasaka, Minato-ku, Tokyo. For emergencies: +81 3-3224-5000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Japan ■ ■

Browsing the side alleys of Yokohama Chinatown, you notice a vendor with an impressive display of designer brand goods -- handbags, watches, and sunglasses at a fraction of retail price. A Louis Vuitton bag for 5,000 yen? A Rolex for 8,000 yen? The vendor assures you they're 'export quality surplus.' You buy a bag for your friend back home. At customs, the bag is confiscated as counterfeit, and in some countries you could face a fine for importing fake goods. As r/japan users note, while counterfeiting is taken seriously in Japan, some vendors in Chinatown areas operate discreetly. Buying c...

■ Red Flags

- Luxury brand goods are priced at 90 percent or more below retail
- Products are displayed in a temporary setup that can be packed away quickly
- The seller avoids having you inspect the goods closely or compare to photos of originals
- There are no receipts, brand packaging, or authenticity certificates
- The goods are sold from side alleys or by vendors who move location frequently

■ How to Avoid

- Buy designer goods only from authorized retailers in Motomachi or department stores like Sogo
- Know that legitimate surplus or outlet goods are sold through official brand outlet stores, not street vendors
- Remember that importing counterfeit goods can result in confiscation at customs in your home country
- If a luxury brand price seems too good to be true, it is counterfeit without exception
- Report counterfeit goods sellers to the local koban (police box) if you encounter them

■ Macau

■ ■ Macau

6 scams documented • Macau

Counterfeit Currency Exchange at Lisboa Grand

You head to the smoking room for a break from the slot machines when someone sidles up to you speaking Mandarin. They're from mainland China, they say, and they're struggling with their currency — could you exchange some HKD or USD for them at a better rate than the official counters? The deal sounds simple enough. What you don't realize is that a portion of the notes you receive in exchange are counterfeit. The scam works because you're handling unfamiliar currency in a noisy environment with bad lighting, and the fakes are good enough to fool a quick glance. Redditors have specifically fl...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you in a casino (especially Grand Lisboa) and offers informal currency exchange
- The rate offered is noticeably better than the official rate — too good to be true
- The approach happens in a noisy, crowded area like a smoking room or gaming floor
- The person is from mainland China and claims to have trouble using Alipay or UnionPay
- Notes you receive feel slightly different in texture than official currency

■ How to Avoid

- Exchange currency only at banks, official hotel desks, or licensed exchange counters inside the casino cage
 - Never accept informal currency exchange offers from strangers on the gaming floor
 - Inspect large bills carefully before completing any transaction — check for security features
 - If in doubt about a note, take it to the casino cage immediately for verification
 - Know the current HKD/MOP exchange rate (roughly 1:1) so any offered 'deal' is immediately suspicious
-

Casino Floor Loan Shark Trap

the classic loan shark look — approaches and quietly asks in Mandarin if you want 'credits.' He's calm, professional, and blends into the scenery. These are junket operators and informal money lenders who offer gamblers cash advances at brutal interest rates. You might think it's just a VIP cashier service. It isn't. Accepting funds from these individuals means entering an informal debt arrangement with people who have zero incentive to be patient about repayment. Macau's junket industry — which once represented up to 70% of casino revenue — has faced major crackdowns since 2022, with opera...

■ Red Flags

- A well-dressed person approaches you immediately upon entering a casino and offers 'credits'
- The offer is made quietly, in Mandarin, away from official cashier areas
- The person has no official casino badge or identification
- The conversation happens near escalator exits or in casino corridors rather than at cashier windows
- The offered credit amount is far larger than you'd need for casual gambling

■ How to Avoid

- Only obtain casino chips and credits from official casino cashier cages — they have badges and counters
 - Don't gamble more than you can afford to lose outright — never borrow to gamble
 - Ignore all unsolicited approaches on the casino floor, especially near entrances and escalators
 - Learn basic Cantonese phrases for 'no thank you' — mh-goi, m⁴h-g²i — to politely refuse
 - If approached repeatedly, move to a different part of the casino floor or notify casino security
-

Overpriced Taxi Detour

The queue moves quickly and you hop in. The driver asks your destination — the Ruins of St. Paul, about 5 minutes away — and nods. But then he takes a long looping route through the Northern District, past the Barrier Gate, and back through the Lisboa area. The meter ticks along. A 40 MOP trip becomes 100 MOP. Macau's

taxis are metered and generally legitimate, but there's a well-documented pattern of drivers taking longer routes with tourists who don't know the city's geography. The island itself is small — most destinations are within 15 minutes of each other in light traffic — so any rid...

■ Red Flags

- Driver doesn't turn on the meter or asks for a flat rate upfront
- The journey to a well-known nearby landmark takes more than 20 minutes
- Driver claims he doesn't know a major tourist site like the Ruins of St. Paul
- The driver becomes confused or evasive when you mention using a map on your phone
- Driver 'has no change' for large bills, pressuring you to overpay

■ How to Avoid

- Use the free casino shuttle buses from ferry terminals and airport — they run frequently and are completely free
 - Screenshot your hotel address in Chinese characters before getting into any taxi
 - Open Google Maps before entering the taxi so you can follow the route in real time
 - Carry small MOP bills (10s and 20s) to avoid the 'no change' excuse
 - Know the standard fares: Outer Harbour Terminal to Ruins of St. Paul is roughly 30–40 MOP
-

Lucky Casino Chip Scheme

You're strolling through the elegant cobblestones of Senado Square when a man approaches you holding what looks like a casino chip. He speaks enthusiastically — he's leaving Macau tomorrow and he has these 'lucky' chips he can't take back to mainland China. He'll sell them to you at a discount, say 500 MOP worth of chips for 300 MOP in cash. You arrive at the casino cage and discover the chips are counterfeit, or worse, they're from a casino that's been shut down and they're worthless. The scam exploits tourists' unfamiliarity with Macau's casino chip system. Each casino issues its own chip...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you on the street or near a casino entrance offering to sell casino chips
- The deal is framed as a 'discount' — paying less cash than the chip face value
- The seller is leaving the country and can't use the chips themselves
- Chips look slightly different from those you saw inside the casino
- The seller is insistent, keeps lowering the price, or becomes aggressive when you decline

■ How to Avoid

- Never purchase casino chips from anyone outside an official casino cage
 - Remember: legitimate casino chips cannot be sold person-to-person on the street legally
 - If approached, walk into the casino and ask security about the chips you were offered
 - Know that expired or counterfeit chips are completely worthless and unrecoverable
 - Stick to purchasing chips at official cashier counters with your passport or casino membership card
-

Fake Tour Package Bait & Switch

You're at the Outer Harbour Ferry Terminal arrivals hall when a friendly woman at a kiosk offers you an incredible day tour deal: the Cotai Strip, the Giant Buddha on Coloane, the Portuguese Quarter, lunch included, all for just 150 MOP. You pay, get a printed voucher, and the next morning a minibus picks you up. The tour is real — but the 'lunch included' is a cup of tea at a partner shop, and half the day is spent at jewelry and souvenir shops where your guide gets commissions. Deceptive tour packages are one of Macau's documented scams: operators advertise comprehensive experiences but d...

■ Red Flags

- Tour price seems extremely low compared to other operators
- The itinerary is vague about meal inclusions or admission fees
- The tour kiosk is informal — not a registered travel agency with a license number
- Guide mentions 'optional' stops at shops during the tour before you've even started
- The tour contract has exclusion clauses in small print you weren't shown before paying

■ How to Avoid

- Use the free casino shuttle buses and walk Macau's compact Historic Centre independently — no tour needed
- If booking a tour, use licensed agencies listed on the Macau Government Tourism Office website
- Ask explicitly: 'Does this tour stop at any commission shops?' — a legitimate guide should say no
- Get all inclusions in writing before paying any deposit
- Check TripAdvisor reviews specifically mentioning 'shopping stops' or 'bait and switch' in recent reviews

The Street Currency Exchanger at Casino Entrance

■ ■ *Outside Grand Lisboa, City of Dreams entrance, Venetian pedestrian bridge* You are walking toward the Grand Lisboa and a man approaches offering to exchange your RMB or HKD ... You are walking toward the Grand Lisboa and a man approaches offering to exchange your RMB or HKD at a better rate than the banks. He counts out the bills in front of you, but through sleight of hand, the final stack is short by several hundred dollars. Some of these exchangers use bills with different denominations mixed in — HKD500 and HKD50 notes look similar in dim light. A Reddit user on r/Macau noted that these exchangers are not necessarily outright scammers, as many are just trying to make a margin, but the risk of counterfeit notes or short-counts is high for tourists unfamiliar with the currency. **Red Flags** Someone approaches you outside a casino offering currency exchange The offered rate is significantly better than bank or ATM rates Bills are counted quickly and you are rushed to hand over your money before recounting The exchange happens on the street rather than in a licensed money changer shop Different denominations are mixed together in the stack making it hard to verify **How to Avoid** Use ATMs inside the casinos — they offer competitive rates and dispense local MOP or HKD Exchange currency only at licensed money changers in the Senado Square area If exchanging with anyone, recount every single bill slowly before handing over your money Be familiar with HKD and MOP denominations before arriving in Macau Casinos themselves offer fair exchange rates at their cashier cages ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Chinese Police (警察) station. Call 110 (Police) or 120 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mps.gov.cn. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Beijing is at No. 55 An Jia Lou Road, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100600. For emergencies: +86 10-8531-3000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in China** ■ ■

You are walking toward the Grand Lisboa and a man approaches offering to exchange your RMB or HKD at a better rate than the banks. He counts out the bills in front of you, but through sleight of hand, the final stack is short by several hundred dollars. Some of these exchangers use bills with different denominations mixed in — HKD500 and HKD50 notes look similar in dim light. A Reddit user on r/Macau noted that these exchangers are not necessarily outright scammers, as many are just trying to make a margin, but the risk of counterfeit notes or short-counts is high for tourists unfamiliar wi...

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- The offered rate is significantly better than bank or ATM rates
- Bills are counted quickly and you are rushed to hand over your money before recounting
- The exchange happens on the street rather than in a licensed money changer shop
- Different denominations are mixed together in the stack making it hard to verify

■ How to Avoid

- Use ATMs inside the casinos — they offer competitive rates and dispense local MOP or HKD
- Exchange currency only at licensed money changers in the Senado Square area

- If exchanging with anyone, recount every single bill slowly before handing over your money
 - Be familiar with HKD and MOP denominations before arriving in Macau
 - Casinos themselves offer fair exchange rates at their cashier cages
-

■ South Korea

■ ■ Busan

4 scams documented • South Korea

The Jagalchi Market Seafood Overcharge

Vendors on the first floor beckon enthusiastically, offering to let you pick live seafood from their tanks. You select some crab and shrimp. Upstairs on the second floor, a restaurant prepares your haul. The bill arrives: 120,000 KRW for your seafood, plus a per-person seating fee, a cooking fee, and side dish charges that were never mentioned. The same quantity at other Busan markets would cost 30,000-60,000 KRW. As Tripadvisor reviews and Reddit's r/korea threads document, Jagalchi vendors target foreign tourists with unpublished prices that are two to four times higher than what Korean c...

■ Red Flags

- The vendor quotes prices verbally without a visible price list
- Staff seem particularly eager to seat foreign customers while locals walk past
- Prices are not itemized -- you get a lump sum total without a breakdown
- The second-floor restaurant charges are mentioned only after your food has been prepared
- The vendor becomes agitated or aggressive if you try to compare prices with neighboring stalls

■ How to Avoid

- Ask for the price per item in writing before selecting any seafood, and confirm the total before it's prepared
 - Research standard seafood prices in Busan beforehand -- 1kg of raw crab should be around 15,000-25,000 KRW at market rate
 - Ask about all second-floor fees upfront: cooking fee (usually 5,000-10,000 KRW per dish) and seating fee (3,000-5,000 KRW per person) are normal
 - Consider ordering from the second-floor restaurants' own fixed-price menus for more predictable pricing
 - Visit the market with a Korean-speaking friend or use Papago translation app to negotiate and confirm prices
-

The Seomyeon Food Alley Shakedown

A restaurant tout pulls you inside, promising the best Korean BBQ in Busan. The menu seems straightforward. After your meal, the bill is 50,000 KRW per person -- more than any comparable meal you've had in Seoul. When you question it, the staff become confrontational. The Tripadvisor review that went viral called it 'dangerous and potentially violent,' describing aggressive enforcement tactics when tourists challenged inflated bills. As Korea Herald reports, overcharging foreign tourists in Busan's dining districts is a documented problem that contributed to the 71 percent surge in tourist ...

■ Red Flags

- A tout aggressively pulls you into the restaurant from the street rather than letting you walk in naturally
- The menu prices seem higher than comparable restaurants just one block away
- Staff are overly attentive about what you order and upsell premium options

- The restaurant primarily serves foreign tourists rather than a mix of locals and visitors
- The bill includes unordered items or charges that don't match the menu prices

■ How to Avoid

- Avoid restaurants with street touts -- quality Korean BBQ restaurants in Busan never need to pull customers off the street
 - Use Naver Map or Kakao Map to find restaurants rated by Korean locals, not just tourist review sites
 - Photograph the menu before ordering and compare it to the bill when it arrives
 - Eat where you see Korean families dining -- local patronage is the best quality and pricing indicator
 - If overcharged, ask for an itemized receipt and contact the Busan Tourism Complaint Center at 051-253-8253
-

The Religious Cult Recruitment

They compliment your outfit and say they're conducting a 'cultural survey' or 'personality test.' After friendly small talk, they invite you to a nearby cafe for a 'free cultural experience' or 'Bible study' that's definitely 'not a church.' What follows is a high-pressure recruitment session for groups like Shincheonji or the World Mission Society Church of God. The conversation escalates from casual to intense, and they request your phone number and social media. As documented by Creatrip, The Voyaging Teacher, and Reddit's r/korea, South Korean cult recruitment targeting foreigners is wi...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you in a tourist area with unusual flattery or a request to take a survey
- They claim to be from a cultural organization, personality research group, or 'non-church' Bible study
- The invitation involves going to a specific location for a presentation or free meal
- They are evasive when you ask directly which organization or church they represent
- They push hard for your phone number and personal contact information

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline any surveys, personality tests, or cultural experience invitations from strangers in tourist areas
 - If approached, ask directly: 'Are you from Shincheonji?' -- legitimate cultural workers will not be offended by the question
 - Do not share your phone number, KakaoTalk ID, or social media handles with strangers who approach you on the street
 - Understand that genuine Korean cultural exchange programs operate through tourism offices and universities, not beach boardwalks
 - Walk away firmly if the conversation becomes insistent -- you owe no one your time or personal information
-

The Haeundae Beach Umbrella Charge

■ ■ *Haeundae Beach and Gwangalli Beach public sand areas* You arrive at Haeundae Beach ready for a relaxing day. You set up on the sand and a man approaches, pointing to the nearby beach umbrellas and chairs. He gestures that you need to pay 20,000-30,000 KRW for a spot, implying the beach requires a fee. You pay, assuming it's official. Later, you notice plenty of free open sand just meters away where other beachgoers have set up their own towels. The umbrella vendor was an opportunistic private operator charging for what amounts to a basic chair on a public beach. As Busan travel forums and Reddit posts mention, some vendors at Haeundae and Gwangalli create the impression that the entire beach requires paid seating when only the chair rental area is commercial. **Red Flags** Someone approaches you immediately upon arriving at the beach insisting you need to pay for a spot They imply the entire beach area requires a fee rather than just the rental zone The price for a basic umbrella and chair seems high compared to nearby establishments There is no posted price list or official signage for the beach chair service Free public sand areas are visible nearby but the vendor discourages you from going there **How to Avoid** Understand that Haeundae and Gwangalli are public beaches -- you can set up your own towel and umbrella for free on the open sand If you want chair and umbrella rental, compare prices between vendors before committing -- standard rates are 10,000-15,000 KRW per set Look for official rental areas with posted price signs rather than individual operators who approach you Bring your own beach towel and portable shade from a convenience store to avoid

the rental entirely Visit the beach slightly away from the most central area for more free space and fewer vendor approaches

■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Korean National Police station. Call 112. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.go.kr. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 188 Sejong-daero, Jongno-gu, Seoul. For emergencies: +82 2-397-4114. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in South Korea ■■

You set up on the sand and a man approaches, pointing to the nearby beach umbrellas and chairs. He gestures that you need to pay 20,000-30,000 KRW for a spot, implying the beach requires a fee. You pay, assuming it's official. Later, you notice plenty of free open sand just meters away where other beachgoers have set up their own towels. The umbrella vendor was an opportunistic private operator charging for what amounts to a basic chair on a public beach. As Busan travel forums and Reddit posts mention, some vendors at Haeundae and Gwangalli create the impression that the entire beach requi...

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■ How to Avoid

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- Look for official rental areas with posted price signs rather than individual operators who approach you
- Bring your own beach towel and portable shade from a convenience store to avoid the rental entirely
- Visit the beach slightly away from the most central area for more free space and fewer vendor approaches

■■ Jeju

4 scams documented • South Korea

The Seongeup Folk Village Hard Sell

A local guide offers a free walking tour, explaining the history of Jeju's stone walls and traditional houses. It's genuinely fascinating for about fifteen minutes. Then the group is ushered into a room for a 'cultural presentation' that turns into a thirty-minute hard sell for horse bone powder at 360,000 KRW and horse oil cream at 50,000-140,000 KRW. The same horse oil is available at shops outside the village for 30,000 KRW. As Tripadvisor reviews overwhelmingly document, the sales pitch lasts twice as long as the village tour itself, and guides earn commission on every product sold.

■ Red Flags

- A free village tour transitions into a seated presentation about health products
- The guide emphasizes the 'limited availability' or 'village-exclusive' nature of the products
- Prices for horse bone powder and horse oil are multiples of what identical products cost elsewhere on Jeju
- The presentation room is set up like a sales floor with product displays and payment counters
- The guide becomes noticeably less friendly toward those who don't purchase anything

■ How to Avoid

- Visit Seongeup Folk Village independently rather than as part of a tour bus package
 - Politely decline the indoor presentation and continue exploring the village on your own
 - If interested in horse oil products, buy them at Jeju convenience stores or Olive Young for 50-70 percent less
 - Set a personal spending rule before entering and stick to it regardless of sales pressure
 - Remember that any product available here is also available elsewhere on Jeju Island at lower prices
-

The Taxi Meter Manipulation

The driver is friendly and the meter is running. But the route seems unusually long, winding through side roads you don't recognize instead of taking the main coastal highway. When you arrive, the meter shows 45,000 KRW for what should have been a 25,000-30,000 KRW ride. One widely reported case on Reddit and Korean media involved a driver charging a Chinese tourist 35,000 KRW for a short ride by insisting on collecting a round-trip fare for a one-way journey. With the Korea Tourism Organization reporting a 71 percent surge in tourist complaints, Jeju taxi overcharging is a recognized and g...

■ Red Flags

- The driver takes back roads instead of the direct highway route between the airport and your destination
- The fare seems significantly higher than what Kakao Map or Naver Map estimated for the same trip
- The driver claims extra charges for luggage, late-night rates, or 'holiday surcharges' not shown on the meter
- They insist on a flat fare instead of using the meter
- The driver demands a round-trip fare for a one-way journey

■ How to Avoid

- Use the Kakao T taxi app for GPS-tracked rides with upfront fare estimates in Jeju
 - Before departing, check the estimated fare on Kakao Map or Naver Map for your route
 - Always insist on the meter being used and confirm the starting fare is 4,800 KRW (Jeju standard)
 - Screenshot the recommended route on a navigation app and compare it to the driver's actual route
 - Report overcharging taxis to the Jeju Tourism Complaint Center at 064-740-6000 with the taxi's license plate number
-

The Overpriced Jeep Tour

You arrive at Manjanggul Cave and are approached by a driver offering a scenic jeep tour of the surrounding volcanic landscape. 'Special experience, only 100,000 KRW per person!' he says, gesturing at a rugged-looking vehicle. The tour turns out to be a bumpy 20-minute ride along dirt roads that you could have walked for free. The standard rate for similar jeep tours booked through proper channels is around 50,000 KRW, and the 'exclusive' routes are just public trails. As Reddit's r/korea and travel forums note, freelance jeep tour operators at Jeju's popular spots charge tourists double by...

■ Red Flags

- The jeep operator approaches you in a parking lot rather than operating from a ticketed office
- They claim the tour includes 'exclusive access' to areas that appear to be public trails
- The quoted price is more than double what online booking platforms list for similar tours
- There is no official signage, business card, or website for the tour operation
- Other tourists in the area seem to be walking the same routes for free

■ How to Avoid

- Book jeep tours in advance through platforms like Klook, where standard prices are around 40,000-60,000 KRW
- Research whether the area requires a vehicle to access or is walkable before agreeing to a tour
- Ask for the operator's business license number (saeop-ja deungnok beonho) before booking

- Compare prices with at least two other operators before committing
 - Use Jeju's excellent public bus system (bus.jeu.go.kr) to reach most tourist sites independently
-

The Counterfeit Volcanic Rock Souvenir

■ ■ Souvenir shops near Seongsan Ilchulbong (Sunrise Peak) and Jusangjeolli Cliffs You're browsing souvenir shops near Seongsan Ilchulbong when a vendor displays what he calls 'rare ... You're browsing souvenir shops near Seongsan Ilchulbong when a vendor displays what he calls 'rare Jeju volcanic rocks' arranged in decorative settings. They're priced at 15,000-25,000 KRW each and marketed as unique geological specimens from the UNESCO site. The vendor claims they're the last legal specimens available. What he doesn't mention is that collecting and exporting genuine volcanic rocks from Jeju's protected sites is prohibited, and the 'rare' rocks are ordinary basalt available at any garden supply store for a fraction of the price. As Korea Herald and travel forums report, counterfeit souvenir vendors near Jeju's natural attractions exploit tourists' desire for an authentic geological keepsake. **Red Flags** The vendor claims the volcanic rocks are rare or the last legally available specimens Prices are 3-5 times higher than similar decorative rocks in regular shops The seller cannot provide any certification of authenticity or legal export documentation The rocks look identical to common basalt available at any Korean garden or home goods store The shop is a temporary-looking stall near a tourist attraction rather than an established store **How to Avoid** Understand that exporting genuine Jeju volcanic rocks is prohibited -- any vendor selling them for 'export' is either selling fakes or breaking the law Buy Jeju souvenirs from official tourism shops like the Jeju Tourism Organization gift shop in Jeju City Choose Jeju's genuinely unique souvenirs: hallabong (citrus) products, omija tea, or Jeju black pork snacks If you want volcanic rock decor, purchase it from legitimate Korean home goods stores for fair market prices Walk past popup stalls near tourist attractions and shop at established stores in Jeju City instead ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Korean National Police station. Call 112. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.go.kr. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 188 Sejong-daero, Jongno-gu, Seoul. For emergencies: +82 2-397-4114. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in South Korea** ■ ■

You're browsing souvenir shops near Seongsan Ilchulbong when a vendor displays what he calls 'rare Jeju volcanic rocks' arranged in decorative settings. They're priced at 15,000-25,000 KRW each and marketed as unique geological specimens from the UNESCO site. The vendor claims they're the last legal specimens available. What he doesn't mention is that collecting and exporting genuine volcanic rocks from Jeju's protected sites is prohibited, and the 'rare' rocks are ordinary basalt available at any garden supply store for a fraction of the price. As Korea Herald and travel forums report, cou...

■ Red Flags

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- The rocks look identical to common basalt available at any Korean garden or home goods store
- The shop is a temporary-looking stall near a tourist attraction rather than an established store

■ How to Avoid

- Understand that exporting genuine Jeju volcanic rocks is prohibited -- any vendor selling them for 'export' is either selling fakes or breaking the law
 - Buy Jeju souvenirs from official tourism shops like the Jeju Tourism Organization gift shop in Jeju City
 - Choose Jeju's genuinely unique souvenirs: hallabong (citrus) products, omija tea, or Jeju black pork snacks
 - If you want volcanic rock decor, purchase it from legitimate Korean home goods stores for fair market prices
 - Walk past popup stalls near tourist attractions and shop at established stores in Jeju City instead
-

■ ■ Seoul

The Plastic Surgery Clinic Foreigner Price Gouge

At the consultation, the clinic gives you a quote — and it's nearly three times what Korean patients pay for the same procedure at the same clinic. Some clinics have entirely separate pricing systems for foreign patients, justified by 'English-speaking staff' but in practice just exploitation of medical tourists who won't be around to leave reviews or complain. One thread documented a user being charged thousands above standard Korean prices after getting the same consultation documents from Korean patients.

■ Red Flags

- Clinic immediately identifies you as foreign before quoting any price
- Quote is vague or doesn't match any online information in Korean
- Clinic is heavily advertised on English-language foreigner influencer channels
- Research clinics using Korean-language sites (Naver, not just English Google)
- Join [r/SeoulPlasticSurgery](#) and verify quotes through community members

■ How to Avoid

- Research clinics using Korean-language sites (Naver, not just English Google)
 - Join [r/SeoulPlasticSurgery](#) and verify quotes through community members
 - Ask for itemized pricing in writing before any commitment
-

The Taxi Refusal and Overcharge Combo

Taxi after taxi refuses to pick you up — some literally drive away when they see you're foreign. Finally one stops, but he says his app is broken and needs cash. He takes a very long route and demands double the standard fare at the end. Seoul taxi drivers sometimes refuse short fares or certain destinations, particularly in nightlife areas on weekends, and a minority exploit tourists on airport routes.

■ Red Flags

- Driver declines to use the meter or Kakao T app route
- Driver says the card reader is 'broken' (implies cash only)
- Route appears longer than necessary on Google Maps
- Download Kakao T app before arriving — it has a preset price system with no surprises
- AREX train from Incheon Airport is much cheaper and faster than any taxi

■ How to Avoid

- Download Kakao T app before arriving — it has a preset price system with no surprises
 - AREX train from Incheon Airport is much cheaper and faster than any taxi
 - If refused, use public transit — Seoul's subway runs until midnight and is excellent
-

The Fake Buddhist Monk Donation

Someone dressed in Buddhist robes approaches you near Gyeongbokgung Palace, strikes a small wooden bell, and hands you a prayer bead bracelet or card. They then produce a donation ledger with large amounts already filled in — implying that's the appropriate donation. South Korea's largest Buddhist organization, the Jogye Order, has explicitly banned this practice because fake monks have been exploiting tourists with it for years.

■ Red Flags

- Person in robes approaches you specifically (not inside a temple)
- Donation ledger shows large pre-filled amounts

- Item placed in your hand before any price discussion
- Legitimate monks in Korea do not solicit donations from tourists on the street
- Hand any item back immediately

■ How to Avoid

- Legitimate monks in Korea do not solicit donations from tourists on the street
 - Hand any item back immediately
 - The Jogye Order officially banned this practice — these are confirmed scammers
-

The Itaewon Bar Overcharge

You're in Itaewon and a friendly local-seeming person invites you to their 'favorite bar.' Once inside, bottles and mixers arrive without prices being stated. The tab runs up quickly. When you ask to leave, the bill is three times what you'd expect. The bar you're in is not in any popular review apps. Itaewon has a minority of bars that specifically target foreign men with this approach, particularly near the main strip on weekends.

■ Red Flags

- Led to a venue by a new acquaintance rather than going independently
- Venue has no listing on Naver Maps or Google Maps
- Drinks arrive without anyone asking for your order
- Choose your own venues using Naver Maps (Korean equivalent of Google Maps)
- Set a drink limit mentally before entering any bar

■ How to Avoid

- Choose your own venues using Naver Maps (Korean equivalent of Google Maps)
 - Set a drink limit mentally before entering any bar
 - Avoid venues with no online reviews entirely
-

The Cult Recruitment Cultural Experience

They compliment your appearance and ask if you have any relatives who recently passed away. They say they can help their souls find peace through a traditional Korean ceremony. You are led to a nearby building where the ceremony involves making a monetary offering calculated as 1,000 times your age in Korean won. A 30-year-old would be asked for 30,000 won. Travelers have reported this increasing to 300,000 won with additional emotional pressure. This is a well-documented cult recruitment technique in Seoul.

■ Red Flags

- An older woman and younger companion approach with specific questions about deceased relatives
- They mention a spiritual ceremony or cultural experience that requires a monetary offering
- You are led to a nondescript building rather than a recognized temple or cultural center
- The offering amount is calculated using a peculiar formula related to your personal information
- The interaction escalates from friendly conversation to emotional pressure about spiritual obligations

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline and walk away from any stranger who asks personal questions about deceased relatives
 - Legitimate Korean cultural experiences do not involve strangers approaching you on the street
 - Never follow strangers to unknown buildings regardless of how friendly or spiritual the invitation sounds
 - If interested in Korean cultural experiences, book through your hotel or official tourism offices
 - Report persistent cult recruiters to the Korea Tourism Helpline at 1330
-

The Hongdae Religious Cult Recruitment

■ ■ Hongdae pedestrian area, Sinchon university district, Myeongdong shopping streets, near Gyeongbokgung Palace You are walking through Hongdae when two friendly college-aged Koreans approach you and ask where you are from. They mention a 'free traditional Korean cultural experience' nearby — a tea ceremony with hanbok dress-up and food. It seems like a unique opportunity. You follow them to a building where you are served tea, dressed in traditional clothing, and then shown a religious presentation. Pressure builds to make a 'donation' or attend more sessions. Reddit users on r/koreatravel identified this as a well-known cult recruitment tactic used by groups like Shincheonji and Daesun Jinrihoe, who specifically target foreign tourists in popular districts. One user described it as leaving them with 'a weird and unsettling feeling' after a ceremony involving chanting and identity collection. Red Flags Friendly strangers approach you in a tourist area and immediately invite you to a 'free cultural experience' They are specifically targeting foreigners and speak unusually good English The invitation involves going to an unmarked building or upper-floor studio rather than a known tourist venue Once inside, the experience shifts from cultural to spiritual with religious chanting, texts, or lectures They ask for your phone number, social media, or personal details before you leave How to Avoid Politely decline unsolicited invitations from strangers — legitimate cultural experiences are available through tourist information centers and booked in advance Be especially cautious in Hongdae, Sinchon, and near universities where cult recruiters are most active Never share your phone number or personal information with people you just met on the street Research any 'cultural experience' name on Google before agreeing — known cult fronts are well-documented online If you feel uncomfortable during an experience, leave immediately — you are not obligated to stay or donate ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Korean National Police station. Call 112. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.go.kr. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 188 Sejong-daero, Jongno-gu, Seoul. For emergencies: +82 2-397-4114. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. Frequently Asked Questions Is Seoul safe for tourists? ▼

They mention a 'free traditional Korean cultural experience' nearby — a tea ceremony with hanbok dress-up and food. It seems like a unique opportunity. You follow them to a building where you are served tea, dressed in traditional clothing, and then shown a religious presentation. Pressure builds to make a 'donation' or attend more sessions. Reddit users on r/koreatravel identified this as a well-known cult recruitment tactic used by groups like Shincheonji and Daesun Jinrihoe, who specifically target foreign tourists in popular districts. One user described it as leaving them with 'a weird...

■ Red Flags

- Friendly strangers approach you in a tourist area and immediately invite you to a 'free cultural experience'
- They are specifically targeting foreigners and speak unusually good English
- The invitation involves going to an unmarked building or upper-floor studio rather than a known tourist venue
- Once inside, the experience shifts from cultural to spiritual with religious chanting, texts, or lectures
- They ask for your phone number, social media, or personal details before you leave

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline unsolicited invitations from strangers — legitimate cultural experiences are available through tourist information centers and booked in advance
- Be especially cautious in Hongdae, Sinchon, and near universities where cult recruiters are most active
- Never share your phone number or personal information with people you just met on the street
- Research any 'cultural experience' name on Google before agreeing — known cult fronts are well-documented online
- If you feel uncomfortable during an experience, leave immediately — you are not obligated to stay or donate

■ Taiwan

■ ■ Taipei

Taxi Meter Fraud

You've just landed at Taoyuan International Airport, exhausted after a long flight, and you join the taxi queue outside arrivals. The driver who takes your bag seems friendly enough. You settle in and notice the meter — it's running, so you relax. But the numbers are climbing faster than they should. Later, checking with your hotel, you learn the standard fare from Taoyuan to central Taipei is about NTD 1,100–1,300. You paid NTD 1,800. The meter wasn't rigged — the driver had taken a deliberately longer route through surface roads instead of the highway, adding 25 minutes and hundreds of do...

■ Red Flags

- Driver quotes a flat rate before starting the meter, especially from the airport
- Driver asks for payment before the journey begins rather than at destination
- Route appears on your phone to be significantly longer than the most direct path
- Meter was activated but numbers are climbing unusually fast (possible rigged meter)
- Driver claims you already paid when you arrive and demands payment again

■ How to Avoid

- Take the Taoyuan Airport MRT express train to Taipei Main Station — NTD 160, 35 minutes, no scam risk
 - Use the 55688 or Line taxi app which shows registered drivers and fixed routes with transparent pricing
 - If taking a street taxi, ensure the meter is on before you move — tap the meter clearly and make eye contact if needed
 - Note the driver's license number displayed on the dashboard — taking a photo of it deters fraud
 - Pay with an EasyCard or exact change — handing over large bills creates opportunity for the 'wrong change' trick
-

Israeli Dead Sea Skincare Kiosk

Walking through Ximending's pedestrian shopping district, you're flagged down by an attractive person holding a small tube of lotion. They put a dab of cream on your hand, and it genuinely feels luxurious. Before you can pull away, they're massaging your arm and telling you about the Dead Sea minerals. The free sample transitions seamlessly into a product demonstration that lasts 15 minutes, then a 'special price today only' offer for a starter kit at NTD 3,800. Social pressure builds as more staff appear. You're handed a bag to hold. The conversation moves toward payment before you've cons...

■ Red Flags

- Staff step into your path in a pedestrian shopping area and offer a free sample of lotion or skincare
- The product is marketed as Israeli or Dead Sea origin with aggressive claims about mineral content
- Staff begin touching your hands or arms to apply the product without explicit consent
- Price drops dramatically multiple times during the pitch — from NTD 9,000 to NTD 3,800 to 'final offer' NTD 2,500
- Multiple staff members appear during the demonstration to create social pressure

■ How to Avoid

- Decline any sample offer in pedestrian shopping areas — say 'no thank you' without breaking stride
 - Never allow a stranger to apply anything to your skin as a 'demonstration' — it creates social obligation
 - If already engaged, keep your hands in your pockets and say 'I need to think about it' while walking away
 - Know the brands: Israeli skincare kiosk operations are documented — searching brand names in Chinese reviews will confirm the scam pattern
 - Report aggressive sales tactics to the Consumer Protection Commission (1950 hotline) — Taiwan takes these complaints seriously
-

Night Market No-Price-Tag Markup

the air thick with scallion pancakes, pepper buns, and grilled squid, and every stall lit with warm yellow bulbs. You spot a stall selling intricate handmade accessories and pick one up to examine it. There's no price tag anywhere. The vendor quotes you NTD 800. You have no frame of reference, so you pay. Two stalls later you see nearly identical items for NTD 250. The first vendor made a judgment call about what you looked like you could pay — and charged accordingly. The no-price-tag practice in Taiwanese night markets isn't always a malicious scam, but it creates an environment where ven...

■ Red Flags

- Craft or souvenir stall has no visible price tags on any items
- Vendor names a price only after you've been holding or examining the item for a while
- Quote is vague or changes when you ask 'how much for two?'
- Vendor appears to assess you visually before naming a price
- Price is quoted in round numbers without any reference to a menu or price list

■ How to Avoid

- Ask the price before picking up any item — once you're holding it, the psychology shifts in the vendor's favor
 - Walk the whole market once before buying anything — you'll see price ranges for similar items at other stalls
 - Learn the phrase 'zhège dūshuō qián?' (这个多少钱? — how much?) — vendors often relax into fairer pricing when spoken to in Mandarin
 - Use the NTD 250–400 range as a mental anchor for common souvenir items — anything quoted above this warrants comparison
 - Shopping apps like Shopee Taiwan show retail prices for most categories, giving you a reference point
-

Club Overpriced Bottle or Cover Scheme

Taipei's glossy clubbing neighborhood — and someone working the door of a club on Songshou Road waves you in, saying there's no cover tonight. Inside, the music is good and you order a round of drinks. The first round costs NTD 600 per cocktail, which seems steep but not impossible. Three rounds later you ask for the bill and the total is NTD 9,800. Line items include a 'table service fee,' a 'music supplement,' and two drinks you're not sure you ordered. The total is not negotiable and a large staff member appears near the exit. Taipei's nightlife in the Xinyi district operates legitimately...

■ Red Flags

- Someone outside a club specifically invites you in with promises of 'free entry' or 'free first drink'
- No menu is visible at the entrance or immediately upon seating
- Drinks arrive before you ordered them and are added to your tab
- Bill includes service charges or fees that were not disclosed before entry
- Staff become unresponsive or a security figure appears when you question the bill

■ How to Avoid

- Research clubs before going out — use Google Maps reviews and ask at your hotel for recommendations
 - Always ask to see the menu and confirm the cover charge before entering any club
 - Pay by cash in increments rather than opening a tab — it limits exposure to unauthorized charges
 - If a bill includes charges you don't recognize, ask for itemized receipts in writing before paying
 - The Xinyi district's legitimate venues (Omni, Myst, Barcode) are well documented — stick to reviewed venues
-

Passbook Rental Money Laundering Trap

Someone messages you with a part-time job: all you need to do is open a bank account and let someone use it temporarily for 'overseas transfers' — you'll be paid NTD 5,000 per day. It sounds strange but not obviously criminal. You meet a friendly person at Taipei Main Station's underground mall who explains this is normal for

'international business reasons.' You hand over your passbook and ATM card with the PIN. This is one of Taiwan's most serious tourist-targeting scams and it carries criminal liability for the foreigner who participates, even unknowingly. The passbook is used to launder...

■ Red Flags

- Someone offers to pay you for the use of your bank account or ATM card
- Job posting asks you to open a new bank account and hand over the access credentials
- Request involves receiving money from one person and forwarding it to another
- Recruiter insists the arrangement is legal but can't explain it clearly in writing
- The payment offered (NTD 3,000–10,000 per day) is unusually high for simple administrative tasks

■ How to Avoid

- Never rent, lend, or sell your bank account or ATM card under any circumstances
- Understand that in Taiwan, providing your passbook to another person for their use is a criminal offense
- Legitimate part-time work never requires you to have access to a bank account for 'transfers'
- Report any such solicitation to the Criminal Investigation Bureau (165 fraud hotline)
- Verify any job offer through official channels — Taiwan's Work Permit Office has a list of legitimate employment agencies

Fake Exhibition or Tea Ceremony Invitation

■ ■ Zhongzheng District near National Palace Museum, Jiufen Old Street You're visiting the area near the National Palace Museum in Shilin when a well-dressed young ... You're visiting the area near the National Palace Museum in Shilin when a well-dressed young Taiwanese person approaches you with excellent English and says they're an art student whose professor has organized a small private exhibition today — would you like to come? It's free, and they're only inviting a few foreigners because their professor wants international feedback. The 'exhibition' is in a private apartment space 10 minutes away by taxi, where paintings are displayed at prices of NTD 8,000–40,000. You're served tea and feel uncomfortable leaving without buying. This scam is a direct analog of Beijing's famous art student scam, and has been documented in Taipei though far less frequently. The setup is nearly identical: a personable student, a free invitation, an art show in a private space, and significant social and financial pressure once inside. The r/taiwan community notes this happens most often near major tourist attractions including the National Palace Museum on Zhishan Road and occasionally in the Jiufen old street area where art and craft shops cluster. More common in Taipei is a softer version: being invited for a 'traditional tea ceremony' at a private teahouse that then presents a bill for NTD 2,000–5,000 for basic tea. The tea ceremony invitation version often targets couples or solo travelers and positions itself as a cultural experience rather than a sale. Either way, the mechanism is the same — a trusted social invitation that leads to a commercial pressure environment. Red Flags A stranger specifically seeks out foreigners to invite to a private art show or cultural experience The venue is a private apartment or non-commercial space rather than a gallery or tea house with posted prices Your host immediately serves you tea or food, creating social obligation before any prices are discussed Artwork prices are not displayed — they're revealed verbally during one-on-one pressure conversations The host becomes visibly hurt or disappointed if you express unwillingness to buy How to Avoid Decline private invitations from strangers near tourist attractions, no matter how charming the approach If you want a tea ceremony, book through a reputable teahouse with posted prices — Maokong Gondola area has many Say 'I appreciate it but I'm meeting friends nearby' — a simple, friendly excuse that ends the interaction cleanly If you enter and realize the situation, ask for the price list before accepting any refreshments Remember: genuine art students don't have professors who need foreign tourist feedback at private apartments ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest National Police Agency (NPA) station. Call 110 (Police) or 119 (Fire/Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at npa.gov.tw. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the American Institute in Taiwan (AIT) at No. 100, Jinhu Road, Neihu District, Taipei 11461. For emergencies: +886 2-2162-2000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides Popular Nearby Destinations ■ ■

You're visiting the area near the National Palace Museum in Shilin when a well-dressed young Taiwanese person approaches you with excellent English and says they're an art student whose professor has organized a small private exhibition today — would you like to come? It's free, and they're only inviting a few foreigners

because their professor wants international feedback. The 'exhibition' is in a private apartment space 10 minutes away by taxi, where paintings are displayed at prices of NTD 8,000–40,000. You're served tea and feel uncomfortable leaving without buying. This scam is a direc...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger specifically seeks out foreigners to invite to a private art show or cultural experience
- The venue is a private apartment or non-commercial space rather than a gallery or tea house with posted prices
- Your host immediately serves you tea or food, creating social obligation before any prices are discussed
- Artwork prices are not displayed — they're revealed verbally during one-on-one pressure conversations
- The host becomes visibly hurt or disappointed if you express unwillingness to buy

■ How to Avoid

- Decline private invitations from strangers near tourist attractions, no matter how charming the approach
 - If you want a tea ceremony, book through a reputable teahouse with posted prices — Maokong Gondola area has many
 - Say 'I appreciate it but I'm meeting friends nearby' — a simple, friendly excuse that ends the interaction cleanly
 - If you enter and realize the situation, ask for the price list before accepting any refreshments
 - Remember: genuine art students don't have professors who need foreign tourist feedback at private apartments
-

South Asia

19 cities • 125 scams • 5 countries

■ Bangladesh

■ ■ Dhaka

6 scams documented • Bangladesh

The CNG Auto-Rickshaw Meter Scam

The driver agrees to use the meter — a good sign. But the meter ticks far faster than it should, adding 50-100 BDT per kilometer on rides that should cost 20-50 BDT per km. A Kawran Bazar to TSC ride should be about 40 taka by the meter, but passengers report being charged 150 taka. The government has threatened fines of 50,000 BDT for meter tampering, but enforcement is nearly nonexistent. Alternatively, drivers refuse the meter entirely and quote a flat rate of 300 BDT for a ride worth 100.

■ Red Flags

- Driver agrees to meter but it ticks unusually fast
- Driver refuses to turn on the meter and insists on a flat fare
- Quoted flat fare is two to three times what the Pathao app shows
- Driver takes a longer route through congested areas claiming 'road closures'
- Download the Pathao or Uber app before arriving — it works in Dhaka and sets a fair market price

■ How to Avoid

- Download the Pathao or Uber app before arriving — it works in Dhaka and sets a fair market price
 - If taking a CNG, agree on the fare before getting in and use Google Maps to track the route
 - For airport transfers, use the pre-paid taxi counter inside the terminal rather than drivers outside
 - Learn the approximate fares for common routes from your hotel reception
-

The Airport Porter Shakedown

He is not in uniform and you did not ask for help, but he is already walking briskly toward the exit with your bags. Outside, he demands 500-1,000 BDT for carrying your bags twenty meters. If you protest, a second porter appears to back him up. These self-appointed porters work in teams, targeting visibly foreign arrivals with large luggage. Travelers on forums describe being physically blocked from their own bags until they pay.

■ Red Flags

- Person grabs your bags without asking permission
- No uniform, official badge, or airport ID visible
- Porter moves quickly toward the exit to create a sense of obligation
- A second person appears to support the first when you resist paying
- Keep a firm hand on your luggage cart and decline help with a clear 'no, dhonnobad' (no, thank you)

■ How to Avoid

- Keep a firm hand on your luggage cart and decline help with a clear 'no, dhonnobad' (no, thank you)
 - If you need a porter, use the official airport porters identified by uniforms and ID badges
 - Arrange hotel pickup in advance so someone is holding a sign for you at arrivals
 - If someone grabs your bag, stop walking, firmly say 'no,' and wait — do not follow them outside
-

The Fake Bus Ticket Tout

Before you can find the official counter, a tout approaches offering to 'help' you get a ticket. He claims seats are almost sold out and charges you 1,500 BDT for a ticket that costs 800 BDT at the counter. Sometimes the ticket is real but overpriced; sometimes it is for a cancelled departure or a lower-class seat than promised. Travelers on forums report being sold tickets for buses that do not exist, discovering the fraud only when no vehicle arrives at the designated bay.

■ Red Flags

- Person approaches you before you reach the official ticket counter
- Claims seats are 'almost sold out' and creates urgency to buy immediately
- Price is significantly higher than what you researched online
- Ticket is handwritten or lacks official company branding
- Tout discourages you from going to the official counter

■ How to Avoid

- Walk directly to the official ticket counter of a known bus company like Green Line, Shohagh, or Hanif
 - Book long-distance bus tickets online through Shohoz.com before arriving at the terminal
 - Ignore anyone who approaches you in the terminal — legitimate counter staff do not solicit
 - Ask your hotel to arrange bus tickets in advance
-

The Bait-and-Switch Product Swap

You inspect it, agree on the price, and the vendor takes it to 'pack it properly' in a back room. When you open the bag at your hotel, it is a completely different item — lower quality leather, wrong color, or visibly defective.

The vendor swapped your chosen item during wrapping. This bait-and-switch is especially common with clothing, leather goods, and handicrafts where items look similar. Travelers on Quora and forums specifically warn about this technique at Dhaka's popular shopping markets.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor takes the item out of your sight to 'wrap' or 'bag' it
- Item is wrapped in opaque packaging that discourages inspection
- Vendor rushes the final transaction and hands you a sealed bag
- Price seems unusually good for the apparent quality
- Never let the vendor take your chosen item out of your sight — insist on watching it being wrapped

■ How to Avoid

- Never let the vendor take your chosen item out of your sight — insist on watching it being wrapped
 - Open and inspect the packaged item before paying or leaving the stall
 - Mark your item discreetly with a small pen mark or photo before it goes behind the counter
 - Shop at fixed-price stores like Aarong for handicrafts where bait-and-switch is not possible
-

The Tour Guide Mid-Trip Price Hike

Three hours in, the guide suddenly announces that entry fees, a boat ride, and lunch are 'extra charges' not included in the original price — another 3,000 BDT. When you protest, he becomes upset and threatens to abandon you in an unfamiliar neighborhood. This escalation tactic works because tourists feel vulnerable in crowded, disorienting areas like the alleys of Old Dhaka. Travel forums report this pattern repeatedly with freelance guides near Sadarghat and Lalbagh Fort.

■ Red Flags

- Guide agrees to a suspiciously low price for a full-day tour
- No written agreement specifying what is included
- Surprise 'extra charges' appear midway through the tour
- Guide becomes hostile or threatens to leave you when you push back
- Get all inclusions in writing before starting — entry fees, transport, meals, boat rides

■ How to Avoid

- Get all inclusions in writing before starting — entry fees, transport, meals, boat rides
 - Book guides through your hotel or a verified platform like Viator, not freelancers at tourist sites
 - Carry offline maps on your phone so you can navigate independently if the guide abandons you
 - Pay a portion upfront and the rest at the end, ensuring leverage if the guide changes terms
-

The Fake Online Hotel Booking

■ ■ Online platforms targeting Gulshan, Uttara, and Banani hotel districts You find a hotel in Gulshan listed on Facebook Marketplace at an unbeatable rate — 2,000 BDT per night for a room that normally costs 5,000. The listing has professional photos and positive comments. You send an advance payment of 4,000 BDT via bKash mobile money. On arrival in Dhaka, the hotel has no record of your booking. The Facebook page has been deleted. The bKash transaction is irreversible. Travelers report that these scammers create new pages frequently, using stolen photos from real hotels. The scam spikes during peak travel seasons when legitimate hotels fill up. Red Flags Hotel price significantly below market rate for the neighborhood Booking is through Facebook Marketplace or WhatsApp rather than an established platform Payment requested via bKash or other mobile money with no refund option No verifiable phone number, physical address, or TripAdvisor presence for the hotel Pressure to pay quickly because rooms are 'almost sold out' How to Avoid Book only through established platforms like Booking.com, Agoda, or the hotel's official website Call the hotel directly using the number from Google Maps or their verified website to confirm your reservation Never send advance payment via bKash to an unverified party If a deal seems too good to be true for Gulshan or Banani, it almost certainly is ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Bangladesh Police station. Call 999 (Emergency) or 100 (Police). Get an

official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.gov.bd. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Dhaka is at Madani Avenue, Baridhara, Dhaka-1212. For emergencies: +880 2-5566-2000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides Popular Nearby Destinations ■■

2,000 BDT per night for a room that normally costs 5,000. The listing has professional photos and positive comments. You send an advance payment of 4,000 BDT via bKash mobile money. On arrival in Dhaka, the hotel has no record of your booking. The Facebook page has been deleted. The bKash transaction is irreversible. Travelers report that these scammers create new pages frequently, using stolen photos from real hotels. The scam spikes during peak travel seasons when legitimate hotels fill up.

■ Red Flags

- Hotel price significantly below market rate for the neighborhood
- Booking is through Facebook Marketplace or WhatsApp rather than an established platform
- Payment requested via bKash or other mobile money with no refund option
- No verifiable phone number, physical address, or TripAdvisor presence for the hotel
- Pressure to pay quickly because rooms are 'almost sold out'

■ How to Avoid

- Book only through established platforms like Booking.com, Agoda, or the hotel's official website
 - Call the hotel directly using the number from Google Maps or their verified website to confirm your reservation
 - Never send advance payment via bKash to an unverified party
 - If a deal seems too good to be true for Gulshan or Banani, it almost certainly is
-

■ India

■■ Agra

7 scams documented • India

The Fake Taj Mahal Guide

A well-dressed man approaches you outside the Taj Mahal offering a 'free' tour because he's a 'tourism student who needs practice.' The tour is pleasant enough, but at the end he steers you to his uncle's gemstone shop where you're pressured into buying overpriced stones. If you decline, he demands ■2,000 for the 'free' tour. Official guides at the ticket counter charge ■500-1,000 for a legitimate 2-hour tour with ID badges.

■ Red Flags

- Approaches you unsolicited outside the entrance
- Claims to be a student or volunteer
- No official ID badge or ASI authorization
- Tour ends at a shop
- Hire official guides only from the ticket counter inside

■ How to Avoid

- Hire official guides only from the ticket counter inside

- Official guides carry ASI-issued ID badges — ask to see it
 - Firmly decline unsolicited offers with 'No, thank you'
 - Book a verified guide through your hotel
-

The Gemstone Export Scam

a fraction of what they'd cost back home. He offers to ship them to your country where his 'business partner' will buy them back at 3x the price, earning you a profit. You pay \$500 for stones worth \$5. The 'partner' doesn't exist, the gems are colored glass, and the shipping address goes nowhere. This is one of Agra's oldest and most persistent scams.

■ Red Flags

- Promise of profit from reselling gems abroad
- Price seems like an incredible deal
- Shopkeeper has a 'business partner' in your home country
- Pressure to buy immediately before the deal expires
- Never buy gemstones from shops you were led to by a guide or tout

■ How to Avoid

- Never buy gemstones from shops you were led to by a guide or tout
 - If it sounds too good to be true, it is — always
 - Legitimate gem dealers don't approach tourists on the street
 - Get any gem independently appraised before purchasing
-

The 'Hotel Is Closed' Taxi Redirect

He shakes his head: 'That hotel is closed for renovation' or 'It burned down last week.' He offers to take you to a 'much better' hotel instead — one that pays him a fat commission. Your original hotel is perfectly fine. This scam is so common in Agra that most hotels now send their own drivers to collect pre-booked guests.

■ Red Flags

- Driver claims your hotel is closed, flooded, burned, or 'very bad'
- Offers an alternative hotel he 'personally recommends'
- Refuses to drive to your original booking
- The driver has a specific alternative hotel ready to suggest the moment you express confusion about the closure
- Call your hotel before arriving and arrange pickup

■ How to Avoid

- Call your hotel before arriving and arrange pickup
 - Use Ola or Uber instead of station taxis
 - Never believe a driver who says your hotel is closed — call the hotel directly
 - Pre-pay online so you have a confirmed reservation to show
-

The Overpriced E-Rickshaw to Taj Mahal

Incredible deal! But on the way back, the price is suddenly ₹500 because 'the meter is for one way only' or 'that was the morning price.' If you refuse, he gets aggressive or drives you to the wrong gate far from your hotel. The legitimate round-trip fare is ₹100-200.

■ Red Flags

- Suspiciously low initial price
- No price agreed for the return trip

- Driver insists on waiting for you
- The driver quotes a low price initially but adds surcharges for luggage, waiting time, or multiple stops mid-ride
- Agree on a round-trip price before getting in

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on a round-trip price before getting in
 - Use Ola or Uber for transparent pricing
 - The fair round-trip e-rickshaw price is ■100-200
 - Walk away from any driver who won't agree to a fixed price
-

The Baby Milk Scam

She does not ask for money; she asks you to buy milk powder for her baby from a nearby shop. Moved by the plea, you follow her to a small store where a tin of baby formula costs 1,500 rupees. You pay, she thanks you profusely, and you feel good about yourself. Ten minutes later, she returns the unopened tin to the shopkeeper, who resells it. They split the 1,500 rupees. This scam is extensively documented on [r/travel](#) and [r/solotravel](#) India threads, with multiple travellers confirming the formula-return-and-split arrangement after witnessing it themselves.

■ Red Flags

- A woman with a baby asks specifically for milk or formula rather than money
- She guides you to one particular shop rather than letting you choose where to buy
- The formula costs far more than you would expect, often over 1,000 rupees for a small tin
- The shopkeeper has the item ready and does not seem surprised by the request
- You see the same woman approaching other tourists shortly after your encounter

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline and walk away; if you genuinely want to help, buy food from a street vendor of your own choosing and hand it directly to the person
 - Never follow a stranger to a specific shop they recommend, as the shop is always part of the arrangement
 - If you want to donate, give directly to a registered charity rather than to individuals near tourist sites
 - Keep walking and avoid making prolonged eye contact, which is taken as an invitation to escalate the pitch
 - Warn other tourists nearby if you notice the pattern repeating with the same woman
-

The Shoe Cover Overcharge at Taj Mahal

You reach the Taj Mahal's marble platform and a man in a vest intercepts you, pointing at your shoes and shaking his head. He pulls out disposable shoe covers and slips them over your feet before you can react, then demands 200 to 500 rupees per pair. In reality, shoe covers are included free with your entry ticket, and most visitors simply remove their shoes and walk barefoot as the marble is clean and smooth. Travellers on TripAdvisor's Agra forum report this hustle at the base of the mausoleum steps, with some paying before realizing others around them were walking barefoot at no charge.

■ Red Flags

- Someone intercepts you at the steps and puts covers on your shoes without asking first
- They claim shoe covers are mandatory and that a fee applies
- Other visitors around you are walking barefoot without any issue
- The person is not wearing an ASI uniform or official ID badge
- They demand payment immediately after placing the covers on your feet

■ How to Avoid

- Know in advance that shoe covers are provided free with your Taj Mahal entry ticket, or you can simply remove your shoes and walk barefoot
- Politely decline and step away if someone tries to put covers on your shoes without your consent
- Carry your own shoe covers or plastic bags if you prefer not to go barefoot
- Look for the official ASI signage at the mausoleum steps which explains the free shoe cover policy
- Report aggressive vendors to the tourist police stationed near the main gate

The Fake Marble Inlay Workshop

■ ■ Shops along Fatehabad Road near Taj Mahal, streets behind Taj East Gate, workshops near Agra Fort Your auto-rickshaw driver pulls over outside a workshop and says this is where the descendants of ... Your auto-rickshaw driver pulls over outside a workshop and says this is where the descendants of Taj Mahal artisans still practice the pietra dura marble inlay technique. Inside, a craftsman demonstrates the intricate stone-cutting process. It is genuinely impressive. Then the sales floor opens up, displaying marble tabletops, plates, and boxes at prices ranging from 3,000 to 80,000 rupees. The 'marble' pieces are often made of soapstone with synthetic coloured resin rather than genuine marble with semi-precious stone inlay. Your driver earns a 30 to 40 percent commission on anything you buy. Reddit's r/india and multiple Quora threads document this auto-rickshaw-to-marble-workshop pipeline as one of Agra's most profitable tourist traps. Red Flags Your driver makes an unsolicited stop at a workshop or suggests visiting one as a 'free cultural experience' The craftsman demonstration transitions seamlessly into a high-pressure sales floor Prices are quoted without any weight or certification of the stone type The seller cannot provide an independent gemological certificate for the semi-precious stones Your driver waits at the shop rather than offering to pick you up later, indicating he earns commission How to Avoid Tell your driver at the start that you do not want any shopping stops and will not pay for the ride if detoured If you visit a workshop voluntarily, ask for an independent certificate of authenticity specifying the stone types and weights Compare prices at the government-run Uttar Pradesh State Emporium near Taj Mahal where fixed prices apply and quality is certified Real pietra dura with semi-precious stones is cold to the touch and heavy; soapstone knockoffs feel warmer and lighter Pay by credit card for any purchase over 5,000 rupees so you have dispute protection if the piece turns out to be fake ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in India ■ ■

Your auto-rickshaw driver pulls over outside a workshop and says this is where the descendants of Taj Mahal artisans still practice the pietra dura marble inlay technique. Inside, a craftsman demonstrates the intricate stone-cutting process. It is genuinely impressive. Then the sales floor opens up, displaying marble tabletops, plates, and boxes at prices ranging from 3,000 to 80,000 rupees. The 'marble' pieces are often made of soapstone with synthetic coloured resin rather than genuine marble with semi-precious stone inlay. Your driver earns a 30 to 40 percent commission on anything you b...

■ Red Flags

- Your driver makes an unsolicited stop at a workshop or suggests visiting one as a 'free cultural experience'
- The craftsman demonstration transitions seamlessly into a high-pressure sales floor
- Prices are quoted without any weight or certification of the stone type
- The seller cannot provide an independent gemological certificate for the semi-precious stones
- Your driver waits at the shop rather than offering to pick you up later, indicating he earns commission

■ How to Avoid

- Tell your driver at the start that you do not want any shopping stops and will not pay for the ride if detoured
- If you visit a workshop voluntarily, ask for an independent certificate of authenticity specifying the stone types and weights

- Compare prices at the government-run Uttar Pradesh State Emporium near Taj Mahal where fixed prices apply and quality is certified
 - Real pietra dura with semi-precious stones is cold to the touch and heavy; soapstone knockoffs feel warmer and lighter
 - Pay by credit card for any purchase over 5,000 rupees so you have dispute protection if the piece turns out to be fake
-

■■ Bangalore

4 scams documented • India

The Tampered Meter Trick

The driver agrees to use the meter -- seems legit. But as you ride, you notice the meter is jumping from 40 to 70 to 120, skipping numbers in impossible leaps. When you arrive, the meter shows 350 rupees for a ride that should cost 150. The driver shrugs and points at the meter as proof. Reddit's [r/bangalore](#) is full of reports about tampered meters that tick at double speed, especially on routes from major bus stands to tourist or business areas. Confrontation rarely works -- the driver has rehearsed his excuses.

■ Red Flags

- The meter display jumps in large increments rather than ticking smoothly
- The fare seems to be climbing much faster than the distance traveled
- The driver was unusually eager to use the meter rather than negotiating a flat rate
- When questioned, the driver blames 'night rates' or 'traffic surcharges' not reflected on any rate card
- The meter unit is positioned where you cannot easily see it during the ride

■ How to Avoid

- Use Ola or Uber instead -- transparent pricing, GPS tracking, and digital receipts
 - Check Google Maps for estimated travel time and fare before getting in any auto
 - If the meter seems fast, note the starting fare and check it against the official Bangalore auto fare chart (Rs 30 base + Rs 15/km)
 - Take a photo of the meter at the start of the ride as evidence
 - If the fare is clearly inflated, pay what is reasonable and walk away calmly
-

The Gem Export Opportunity

He owns a gemstone business, he says, and needs foreign tourists to help 'export' precious stones because of tax advantages. He'll give you gems to carry home and sell for triple the price -- he just needs you to buy a small sample batch for 50,000 rupees to prove you're serious. The gems are worthless glass. Variations include inviting you to a showroom with free chai where high-pressure salespeople convince you that sapphires worth 500 rupees are valued at 50,000. This gem scam runs across Indian cities and is frequently reported on [r/travel](#) and [r/solotravel](#).

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you with a 'business opportunity' involving gemstones or jewelry
- Claims of tax loopholes or export advantages that require a foreign tourist's involvement
- You are invited to a private showroom or office away from the main shopping area
- Free tea, snacks, or compliments are used to build rapport before the sales pitch
- Pressure to buy immediately because the 'deal' expires or stock is limited

■ How to Avoid

- No legitimate business recruits random tourists for gem exports -- this is always a scam
- Never follow a stranger to a private showroom or office, no matter how convincing the pitch

- If you want gems, buy from government-certified jewelers with GIA or IGI certification
 - Tell persistent touts you are a gemologist or journalist -- they'll back off quickly
 - Walk away from any 'investment opportunity' pitched by someone you just met on the street
-

The Fake Flat-Rate Airport Transfer

Before you reach the official taxi stand, a man in a quasi-official vest approaches with a laminated rate card and offers a 'prepaid taxi' to your hotel for 2,500 rupees. He insists the Ola/Uber surge price is higher and the official booth is closed. You agree, and he leads you to an unmarked car. Halfway through the ride, the driver claims your hotel area is 'restricted' and tries to divert you to a partner hotel paying him commission. The official KIAL prepaid booth is open 24/7 and charges roughly 800-1,200 rupees to most city areas -- the tout's price was triple.

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you before you reach the official prepaid taxi counter
- The person wears a vest that looks semi-official but has no airport authority branding
- Claims that the official taxi counter is closed, broken, or has a long wait
- The quoted fare is significantly higher than what Ola/Uber shows for the same route
- The vehicle is unmarked with no taxi permit displayed on the dashboard

■ How to Avoid

- Walk past all touts and go directly to the official airport prepaid taxi counter inside the terminal
 - Pre-book an Ola or Uber from the designated pickup zone -- the app works at Bangalore airport
 - Know approximate fares in advance: airport to central Bangalore should be 800-1,200 rupees
 - If a driver claims your hotel is closed or inaccessible, call the hotel directly to confirm
 - Share your live location with someone before getting into any vehicle
-

The SIM Card Swindle

■ ■ Near Majestic Bus Stand, City Railway Station, small mobile shops in tourist areas You arrive in Bangalore and need a local SIM card. A small shop near Majestic offers you a 'tourist SIM' for 1,500 rupees with 'unlimited data.' An official Airtel or Jio tourist SIM at a branded store costs 300-700 rupees. Worse, the SIM the vendor activates may be registered under someone else's identity -- a serious legal issue in India where SIM registration is tied to Aadhaar. Some travelers on r/india report receiving SIMs that stopped working within 48 hours because they were flagged as fraudulently registered, leaving them with no phone service and no refund. Red Flags The shop is not a branded Airtel, Jio, or Vi outlet but a generic 'mobile accessories' stall The SIM price is two to three times higher than official tourist SIM rates The vendor does not ask for your passport or perform biometric verification They promise 'instant activation' without the normal 2-24 hour verification period No proper receipt or documentation is provided How to Avoid Buy SIM cards only from official carrier stores -- Airtel and Jio have counters at the airport Expect to show your passport and complete an eKYC biometric process for legitimate registration Know the real price: tourist SIM packs from major carriers cost 300-700 rupees with ample data Confirm activation on the spot by making a test call before leaving the store Keep your receipt and activation reference number in case of issues ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakypuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in India ■ ■

A small shop near Majestic offers you a 'tourist SIM' for 1,500 rupees with 'unlimited data.' An official Airtel or Jio tourist SIM at a branded store costs 300-700 rupees. Worse, the SIM the vendor activates may be registered under someone else's identity -- a serious legal issue in India where SIM registration is tied to Aadhaar. Some travelers on r/india report receiving SIMs that stopped working within 48 hours because they

were flagged as fraudulently registered, leaving them with no phone service and no refund.

■ Red Flags

- The shop is not a branded Airtel, Jio, or Vi outlet but a generic 'mobile accessories' stall
- The SIM price is two to three times higher than official tourist SIM rates
- The vendor does not ask for your passport or perform biometric verification
- They promise 'instant activation' without the normal 2-24 hour verification period
- No proper receipt or documentation is provided

■ How to Avoid

- Buy SIM cards only from official carrier stores -- Airtel and Jio have counters at the airport
 - Expect to show your passport and complete an eKYC biometric process for legitimate registration
 - Know the real price: tourist SIM packs from major carriers cost 300-700 rupees with ample data
 - Confirm activation on the spot by making a test call before leaving the store
 - Keep your receipt and activation reference number in case of issues
-

■■ Chennai

6 scams documented • India

The Auto-Rickshaw Detour

You step out of Chennai Central station, bags in hand, and an auto-rickshaw driver quotes you 50 rupees to your hotel -- suspiciously cheap. You hop in. Instead of heading to your destination, he takes you on a scenic route through silk showrooms and jewelry shops, collecting commissions at each stop while insisting each visit will 'only take five minutes.' Two hours later, you're nowhere near your hotel and the driver now demands 500 rupees for the extended ride. Reddit's [r/india](#) is full of travelers reporting this commission-shop circuit, especially around major transit hubs in Chennai.

■ Red Flags

- An auto driver quotes a fare far below what ride-hailing apps show
- The driver insists on showing you 'the best shop' for silk or souvenirs
- Your route includes unexplained stops at stores you never requested
- The driver claims your hotel is closed, demolished, or 'too far' and suggests alternatives
- The final fare is dramatically higher than the original quote

■ How to Avoid

- Use Ola or Uber for transparent pricing and GPS-tracked routes
 - If taking an auto, negotiate the fare upfront and insist the driver use the meter
 - Track your route on Google Maps and speak up immediately if the driver deviates
 - Never accept unsolicited shop recommendations from your driver
 - Pre-book airport transfers through your hotel for arrival peace of mind
-

The Temple Blessing Shakedown

You're admiring the gopuram at Kapaleeshwarar Temple in Mylapore when a man in priestly garments approaches, places a garland of fragrant flowers around your neck, and dabs a tilak on your forehead. He leads you to a shrine, chants a quick blessing, then opens a 'donation book' showing entries of 2,000-5,000 rupees from previous visitors. When you offer 100 rupees, his demeanor shifts and he demands thousands for the 'special puja.' Travelers on [r/india](#) and [Tripadvisor](#) frequently report these forced blessing scams at temples

throughout Tamil Nadu.

■ Red Flags

- An unofficial-looking priest approaches you unsolicited outside the main sanctum
- Flowers or sacred items are placed on you without your consent
- A donation book is produced showing suspiciously large amounts from other tourists
- The priest becomes aggressive or guilt-trips you when offered a small donation
- You are led to a side shrine away from other worshippers

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline any unsolicited blessings or garlands by keeping your hands by your sides
 - Official temple priests never chase tourists outside the sanctum -- approach them yourself if interested
 - If you want a puja, ask at the temple office for official rates posted on notice boards
 - Never accept items placed in your hands or around your neck without agreeing first
 - Carry small bills so you can offer a modest donation and walk away confidently
-

The Marina Beach Parking Extortion

A young man in a fluorescent vest appears from nowhere, slaps a ticket on your windshield, and demands 100 rupees. When you return an hour later, he's waiting with a 'three-hour minimum' charge of 300 rupees and threatens to block your car. He has no official ID, no printed rate card, and no connection to the city parking authority. Local journalists have documented this racket extensively -- young men in their twenties collect fees in public spaces without any valid contract, a scam so widespread that Chennai residents have posted confrontation videos on social media.

■ Red Flags

- Parking attendant has no official badge, printed rate card, or uniform beyond a random vest
- You are charged for a multi-hour minimum regardless of actual time parked
- The attendant cannot produce a proper receipt with a serial number
- Multiple 'attendants' operate in the same stretch without clear territorial logic
- They become confrontational when you question the fee or ask for credentials

■ How to Avoid

- Use the official Chennai Smart City parking app or look for metered spots
 - Ask to see an official ID and printed municipal rate card before paying
 - Take a photo of the attendant and their 'ticket' as documentation
 - If pressured, offer to call the Chennai traffic police helpline (103) on the spot
 - Park in established lots at malls or hotels nearby and walk to the beach
-

The Silk Saree Switcheroo

Nagar -- one of Chennai's famous textile districts -- and a shopkeeper shows you a gorgeous Kanchipuram silk, letting you feel its weight and sheen. You agree on a price, he wraps it up beautifully, and you leave satisfied. Back at your hotel, you unwrap it to find a lighter, machine-made polyester saree swapped in during the elaborate packaging. The real silk you touched never left the store. Quora threads and r/india posts describe this bait-and-switch as a classic Chennai textile market scam, especially targeting foreign tourists who can't distinguish silk grades by feel alone.

■ Red Flags

- The shopkeeper insists on wrapping the saree himself in an elaborate, time-consuming process
- You are distracted during packaging by another staff member offering tea or showing more items

- The price seems surprisingly low for genuine Kanchipuram silk
- The shop has no return or exchange policy posted visibly
- Aggressive touts outside steer you toward a specific shop over others

■ How to Avoid

- Do the burn test: real silk smells like burnt hair, synthetic smells like plastic -- ask to test a thread
 - Rub the fabric between your fingers -- genuine silk warms up, synthetic stays cool
 - Watch the packaging process closely and inspect the saree again before final payment
 - Shop at established government emporiums like Co-optex or VTB Silks with official certifications
 - Pay by card for a transaction trail and potential chargeback protection
-

The Fake Travel Agent Vanish

You book a multi-day tour package to Mahabalipuram and Pondicherry through a travel agent found on social media who offers an incredible rate -- air-conditioned car, hotel, guide, all for half the price of established agencies. You pay the full amount via bank transfer. On the morning of your trip, the agent's phone is switched off. The office address doesn't exist. Your hotel reservation was never made. Travelers on Tripadvisor's India forum have documented cases of Chennai-based agents who collect payment, provide fake confirmation documents, then disappear entirely, leaving tourists stra...

■ Red Flags

- Prices significantly undercut all competitors for comparable services
- The agent insists on full payment via bank transfer or cash upfront
- No verifiable physical office address or established web presence
- The agent found you through social media DMs or unsolicited WhatsApp messages
- Confirmation documents look unprofessional or contain generic template text

■ How to Avoid

- Book through established platforms like MakeMyTrip, verified TripAdvisor-listed operators, or your hotel
 - Never pay full amount upfront -- legitimate agencies accept partial deposits
 - Verify the agency has a valid Ministry of Tourism approval number
 - Search the agency name plus 'scam' or 'review' before booking
 - Pay by credit card for chargeback protection if the service is never delivered
-

The Timeshare Presentation Trap

■ ■ DMart stores, malls in T. Nagar and Anna Nagar, hotel lobbies You fill out an innocent-looking coupon at a DMart store, thinking you have entered a prize draw. Within days, you receive a call congratulating you on winning a 'free Goa vacation package' worth thousands of rupees. The catch: you must attend a short presentation at a hotel conference room with your spouse. The presentation is a three-hour high-pressure timeshare sales pitch where aggressive salespeople guilt and shame you into signing a membership contract worth 50,000-200,000 rupees. As r/Chennai posters warn, the 'free' vacation vouchers are never honored, and the timeshare contracts are nearly impossible to cancel. Red Flags You are cold-called after filling a coupon at a mall or supermarket They insist both you and your spouse must attend to claim the prize The 'presentation' location is a hotel conference room with no signage Sales staff rotate in shifts, each more aggressive than the last The contract has a cooling-off period buried in fine print How to Avoid Never fill out promotional coupons at malls or supermarkets If called about a free vacation, ask which company is calling and research them Legitimate prizes never require you to attend a sales presentation If you accidentally attend, simply stand up and leave -- you have no obligation Never sign anything under pressure and always take contracts home to review ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ Track

Your Device If your phone was stolen, use *Find My (iPhone)* or *Find My Device (Android)* from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. [More Scam Guides](#) [More in India](#) ■■

Within days, you receive a call congratulating you on winning a 'free Goa vacation package' worth thousands of rupees. The catch: you must attend a short presentation at a hotel conference room with your spouse. The presentation is a three-hour high-pressure timeshare sales pitch where aggressive salespeople guilt and shame you into signing a membership contract worth 50,000-200,000 rupees. As [r/Chennai](#) posters warn, the 'free' vacation vouchers are never honored, and the timeshare contracts are nearly impossible to cancel.

■ Red Flags

- You are cold-called after filling a coupon at a mall or supermarket
- They insist both you and your spouse must attend to claim the prize
- The 'presentation' location is a hotel conference room with no signage
- Sales staff rotate in shifts, each more aggressive than the last
- The contract has a cooling-off period buried in fine print

■ How to Avoid

- Never fill out promotional coupons at malls or supermarkets
 - If called about a free vacation, ask which company is calling and research them
 - Legitimate prizes never require you to attend a sales presentation
 - If you accidentally attend, simply stand up and leave -- you have no obligation
 - Never sign anything under pressure and always take contracts home to review
-

■■ Delhi

8 scams documented • India

Fake Government Tourist Office

You've just rolled off the overnight train from Agra and you're standing on the platform at New Delhi Railway Station, bags heavy, looking for the tourist information desk. A man in a neat polo shirt approaches and asks if you need help finding your hotel. He says he's with the Delhi Tourism office — in fact, his office is right outside the station. He leads you through the crowds of Paharganj to a professional-looking establishment with maps on the wall and an 'India Tourism' sign. Inside, a suited man behind a desk tells you bad news: your hotel booking has 'cancelled' due to a double-boo...

■ Red Flags

- Person approaches you unprompted at the railway station or airport offering to 'help'
- Claims to work for India Tourism or Delhi Tourism with no official ID to verify
- Tells you your hotel reservation has been cancelled or the hotel is 'closed' or 'flooded'
- Office is in a commercial building rather than a government facility
- Pressure to purchase tour packages or prepay for accommodation upfront

■ How to Avoid

- Book accommodation in advance through verified platforms and confirm directly with the hotel
 - The real India Tourism office is at 88 Janpath — walk there yourself if you need help
 - Use prepaid metered taxis from the official booth inside New Delhi station, not touts
 - Ignore anyone who approaches you in the station claiming to be a tourism official
 - If taken to an office, leave without paying — no contract has been signed
-

'Closed Attraction' Rickshaw Redirect

As you approach, he slows down and shakes his head sadly. 'Today is closed — government holiday.' Or: 'The monument is being cleaned.' Or: 'There is a VIP visit, they are not allowing tourists.' He pivots quickly: 'But I know another place, even better — very famous, very authentic. I take you there free.' That 'free' place is a silk emporium, gem shop, or 'government emporium' where he earns a commission on everything you buy. This scam is so common in Delhi that r/travel has repeated warnings across years of posts. One user traveling from Delhi to Agra noted: 'The scammer knew there was a...

■ Red Flags

- Driver announces attraction is 'closed' before you've seen any sign to that effect
- Alternative destination is always a shop, market, or emporium rather than another monument
- Driver offers to take you to the 'alternative' for free or at reduced fare
- The 'government emporium' has prices far above street market rates
- Driver waits outside the shop while you're inside

■ How to Avoid

- Check ASI (Archaeological Survey of India) official website for opening hours before you leave the hotel
 - Take Uber or Ola directly to the monument gate — not an auto-rickshaw for your first visit
 - Never let a driver choose your next destination — have a plan before you get in
 - If told a site is closed, walk to the entrance yourself and verify
 - Ask at your hotel in the morning if any attractions have unusual closures
-

Paharganj Overpriced 'Guesthouse Full' Hustle

Paharganj, the backpacker neighborhood immediately west of New Delhi Railway Station, is both a brilliant budget hub and a gauntlet. You've booked a guesthouse on Main Bazaar but when your auto-rickshaw drops you off, a boy of about 16 runs up and says your guesthouse is 'full tonight' or 'closed for renovation.' He offers to walk you to something better — his uncle's place around the corner. If you follow him, you'll end up somewhere significantly more expensive than what you booked, and you'll have lost the deposit on your original reservation. Experienced India travelers on r/solotravel ...

■ Red Flags

- Boy or man near the station claims your specific booking is cancelled or the hotel is full
- Tells you he knows your hotel but leads you in a direction that doesn't match your map
- Destination turns out to be a guesthouse with a very similar name to your actual booking
- Asks for a 'finder's fee' for bringing you to the accommodation
- Original booking website is inaccessible or shows 'error' when you try to verify

■ How to Avoid

- Screenshot your booking confirmation with address and use Google Maps navigation independently
 - Call your guesthouse from the platform before you exit the station
 - Use prepaid WiFi SIM from the airport or station to have data on arrival
 - Do not follow anyone who claims your hotel is unavailable without calling to verify
 - Consider staying in South Delhi (Lajpat Nagar, Hauz Khas) which has fewer touts than Paharganj
-

Friendly Stranger Commission Tea Invite

You're sitting on the steps near Connaught Place's inner circle, looking at your map, when a well-dressed young man sits down nearby and strikes up a conversation in perfect English. He's a student, he says, studying English and loves to practice with foreigners. He's friendly, funny, and knows everything about Delhi. After twenty minutes he mentions a wonderful traditional tea house run by his family in a nearby lane — very authentic, very affordable. The tea house is real and does serve tea. But the 'authentic handicrafts' or 'family

business' goods displayed around you cost three to five...

■ Red Flags

- Stranger approaches you unprompted and is highly skilled at keeping conversation flowing
- Early in conversation he establishes credibility (student, professional, local guide)
- Mention of family business, home, workshop, or tea house comes up casually
- He seems uninterested in selling anything — makes it harder to object
- Insists on walking with you to the shop rather than just giving an address

■ How to Avoid

- Be friendly but give a firm 'no thanks' to any unsolicited invitation to a shop or home
 - If genuinely interested in handicrafts, go to fixed-price emporia like Cottage Industries Exposition on Janpath
 - Research fair prices for souvenirs before your trip so you know immediately if you're being overcharged
 - It is okay to enjoy conversation and then decline the shopping portion entirely
 - Trust your instincts — if the conversation pivots to commerce, the friendship was the setup
-

Fake Delhi Metro Token Tout

the Times Square of Delhi's underground system — you're trying to figure out the token machine during rush hour. It's hot, there's a queue behind you, and a helpful man offers to buy your token for you. You hand him a 500 rupee note and he buys you a token worth 30 rupees, pockets the change, and walks away in the crowd before you can say anything. A subtler version involves men outside the station offering to 'activate your metro card' for a processing fee. The Delhi Metro smart card is obtained at any station counter with zero activation fee — the man outside is simply pocketing your money...

■ Red Flags

- Person offers to help buy your ticket 'because the machine is confusing'
- Takes your cash and immediately operates the machine while blocking your view
- Offers to 'activate' or 'register' a metro card outside the official counter
- Asks for your card and then walks away from the machine to 'process' it
- Fee quoted for any metro service that is actually free at official counters

■ How to Avoid

- Use the official token vending machines at the counter — staff are usually nearby to help genuinely
 - Buy a tourist metro day/week pass at the airport metro station on arrival
 - Use the DMRC official app to plan routes and check fares before entering stations
 - If you need help, ask uniformed CISF security officers stationed inside every metro gate
 - Keep your phone or printed metro map accessible so you don't look lost and become a target
-

Overpriced Tuk-Tuk to Agra Road Vendors

On the Yamuna Expressway, your driver pulls off for what he says is a 'mandatory government rest stop.' Inside is a chai stall run by his friend, and around it are vendors selling marble figurines and leather goods at prices you'll later realize are five times Agra's shop prices. A r/travel user described a vivid version of this on the highway: 'I was stuck in traffic between Delhi and Agra. A monkey — wearing a small vest — was trained to snatch something from me through the open window. Its owner quickly 'shooed' it away and returned my item. A 'tip' was then expected.' The scam combines ...

■ Red Flags

- Driver takes a rest stop that isn't on any map or obvious highway service area
- Stop location has vendors immediately ready with goods and prices

- Driver says it is 'required by law' to stop or that the vehicle needs petrol even when full
- Performs trained animal trick or has a helper with animals near the road
- Any vendor claims to sell 'Agra marble' at the rest stop — real marble artisans are in Agra

■ How to Avoid

- Book your Delhi-Agra driver through a verified agency like Cleartrip or MakeMyTrip
- Agree in writing: no unplanned stops, direct route only
- Keep car windows up in slow-traffic zones near small towns
- If stopped, you don't have to get out or buy anything
- Buy marble and souvenirs only in Agra's Taj Ganj area at fixed-price shops

The Prepaid Taxi Counter Switch

You pay 650 rupees for a ride to Paharganj. Outside, a man with a clipboard directs you to a car. Twenty minutes into the ride, the driver announces your hotel is 'closed for renovation' and takes you to a travel agency that pressures you to book overpriced tours and a new hotel at 4x the market rate. The real prepaid counter is inside the terminal -- the one outside near the exit doors is often an unofficial operation run by commission touts.

■ Red Flags

- Taxi counter is outside the terminal rather than at the official booth inside
- Driver claims your hotel is closed, flooded, or no longer exists
- Driver takes you to a travel agency instead of your hotel
- The agent at the counter cannot show official airport authorization
- Use the official Delhi Traffic Police prepaid taxi counter inside the terminal

■ How to Avoid

- Use the official Delhi Traffic Police prepaid taxi counter inside the terminal
- Book an Uber or Ola from the airport -- both operate at IGI
- Confirm your hotel booking by calling them directly before accepting any claims it's closed
- Show the driver the address on Google Maps and track the route throughout the ride

The SIM Card Tourist Markup

■ ■ Shops near Paharganj, Connaught Place, outside metro stations You need a local SIM card and walk into a phone shop near your Paharganj guesthouse. The shopkeeper charges you 1,500 rupees for an Airtel tourist SIM with 2GB data, claiming foreigners require a 'special tourist plan' with extra documentation fees. The actual cost of the same plan from an official Airtel or Jio store is 200-300 rupees. Some shops also photocopy your passport and keep it, raising identity theft concerns. Red Flags Price exceeds 500 rupees for a basic prepaid SIM with data Shop is not an official branded store for the carrier Seller claims foreigners need a 'special' or 'tourist-only' plan They ask to keep your passport overnight for 'activation' How to Avoid Buy a SIM at the official Airtel or Jio store in the airport arrivals hall Standard tourist SIM with data costs 200-400 rupees at official stores Never leave your passport with a shop -- activation requires a photo copy, which you can provide Carry passport-sized photos for the SIM registration process ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in India ■■

The shopkeeper charges you 1,500 rupees for an Airtel tourist SIM with 2GB data, claiming foreigners require a 'special tourist plan' with extra documentation fees. The actual cost of the same plan from an official Airtel or Jio store is 200-300 rupees. Some shops also photocopy your passport and keep it, raising identity theft concerns.

■ Red Flags

- Price exceeds 500 rupees for a basic prepaid SIM with data
- Shop is not an official branded store for the carrier
- Seller claims foreigners need a 'special' or 'tourist-only' plan
- They ask to keep your passport overnight for 'activation'
- Buy a SIM at the official Airtel or Jio store in the airport arrivals hall

■ How to Avoid

- Buy a SIM at the official Airtel or Jio store in the airport arrivals hall
 - Standard tourist SIM with data costs 200-400 rupees at official stores
 - Never leave your passport with a shop -- activation requires a photo copy, which you can provide
 - Carry passport-sized photos for the SIM registration process
-

■ ■ Goa

7 scams documented • India

Taxi Mafia Fixed-Rate Extortion

Unlike the rest of India, Goa has no Uber or Ola — the taxi union successfully blocked app-based cabs for years. What you get instead is a cartel of local taxi drivers charging whatever they want. The 20-minute ride from Dabolim Airport to Baga Beach costs ■800–■1,200 in a state where the same distance in Mumbai would cost ■150. Say no, and they simply shrug — there's no competition. This is the single most complained-about issue in Goa's tourism ecosystem according to dozens of posts across [r/india](#), [r/goatravel](#), and major news outlets. In February 2025, a post titled 'Goa's Taxi Mafia — A ...

■ Red Flags

- Prices quoted are 3–5x what the same distance would cost in other Indian cities
- Driver refuses to accept any negotiation — 'this is the fixed rate'
- No meter is offered or available in any taxi at the stand
- Drivers at the airport stand seem to be operating as a coordinated group
- When you try to walk to find alternatives, you're told there are none

■ How to Avoid

- Pre-book a taxi through your hotel before arrival — hotel rates are usually better than airport stand rates
 - Download Rapido and check availability for your route before arriving in Goa
 - Renting a scooter (■300–■500/day) gives you complete transport independence
 - For airport transfers, GoaMiles (official Goa government taxi service) offers app-based booking
 - Budget in ■600–■1,200 for airport transfers — fighting it only wastes your vacation time
-

Scratch Card Resort Membership Scam

You're walking toward Aguada Fort or along the beach in Candolim when two friendly people approach with colorful scratch cards. They explain it's a promotion for a new resort — scratch and reveal your prize. You reveal 'First Prize: Free Holiday + ■5,000 cash.' They're delighted for you. All you need to do is visit their resort property to claim it. At the property (often a Karma Group or similar timeshare-style resort), you're given refreshments and then subjected to a 2–3 hour high-pressure sales pitch for a resort membership costing ■6–15 lakh (■600,000–■1,500,000). The 'free holiday' pr...

■ Red Flags

- Strangers approach with scratch cards that everyone appears to win
- The prize requires visiting a property to 'claim' it
- You're told the visit is 'just 30 minutes' — it will be 2–3 hours
- Staff are unwilling to explain the full cost of the membership before you visit
- The 'resort visit' is in a vehicle the promoters provide — limiting your ability to leave

■ How to Avoid

- Never accept scratch cards or 'promotional gifts' from strangers near tourist sites
 - Any 'prize' that requires visiting a sales office is not a real prize
 - If you accidentally visit, you can leave at any time — you are not obligated to stay or buy
 - Google 'Karma Group Goa scam' or the resort name before visiting any timeshare property
 - Report aggressive timeshare touts to the Goa Tourism Department at 0832-2437132
-

Fake Hotel Listing Booking Fraud

beautiful photos, glowing reviews, a price that's 40% cheaper than similar options on Booking.com. You pay in full via bank transfer or UPI. When you arrive at the address, it doesn't exist, or is an empty plot, or is a completely different property that has no record of your booking. This fraud became so large it made national news in January 2025, when the Times of India reported a multi-crore Goa scam where over 500 tourists were defrauded through fake hotel listings. Police arrested four suspects involved in creating fraudulent listings across multiple platforms. The scam typically runs...

■ Red Flags

- Hotel found only on obscure booking platforms or direct WhatsApp, not on major sites
- Price is significantly below market rate for the area and season
- Asked to pay full amount via bank transfer or UPI rather than through a booking platform
- Property cannot be verified on Google Maps Street View or satellite imagery
- Phone number provided is a mobile number with no landline option

■ How to Avoid

- Book only through established platforms: Booking.com, MakeMyTrip, Goibibo, or direct hotel websites
 - Before paying, verify the property on Google Maps — does the Street View match the photos?
 - Call the hotel on a number you find independently (not the one in the listing) to confirm your booking
 - Never transfer money via UPI/bank transfer to a person you haven't verified through multiple channels
 - If you arrive and a property doesn't exist, file an FIR at the nearest police station and report to Cyber Crime at cybercrime.gov.in
-

Drug Sting and Police Bribe Setup

sometimes friendly, sometimes a vendor — sells you drugs. Shortly after, uniformed police arrive. They 'search' you and find the substance. You are now in a terrifying position: arrested in a foreign country for drug possession. The officers make clear that the alternative to an official arrest is an immediate 'fine' — paid in cash, right now, to them — of ■5,000–■50,000. Both the seller and the police may be working together, or the police may be acting independently, taking advantage of the situation. [r/india](#) discussions note this scam is 'majorly associated with illegal stuff like escort...

■ Red Flags

- Strangers at beaches or parties offer drugs unprompted
- Anyone who approaches specifically mentioning 'what you're looking for' without you asking
- Overly friendly strangers who steer you away from crowds before offering anything
- Police appear suspiciously quickly after a purchase from someone you just met

- 'Officers' demand immediate cash rather than escorting you to a station

■ How to Avoid

- Do not purchase or accept drugs from any stranger in Goa — ever
 - If police approach you, do not pay any cash on the spot — demand to be taken to a police station formally
 - Contact your country's embassy or consulate immediately if arrested
 - Keep your Indian SIM card active and pre-save the local tourist police helpline: 1800-111-363
 - Traveling with a group and staying in well-reviewed accommodations significantly reduces exposure to this scam
-

Beach Shack Chair and Umbrella Ambush

You settle in for what you think is a free public beach — all Indian beaches are public under law. Within minutes, a shack operator appears and demands ■300–■600 per chair 'rental,' even though you never agreed to rent anything. The chair was placed there deliberately, without signage, as a trap. This 'passive trap' scam was mentioned in multiple r/goatravel posts in 2025. In a viral incident, a tourist who questioned the charge was threatened and reportedly paid 2.5x the initially demanded amount after two shack men 'of a certain stature' appeared. The beach shack economy in Goa has become...

■ Red Flags

- Chairs and umbrellas are placed in the sand with no visible rental signage or price list
- A charge is demanded only after you've sat down, not before
- The price quoted varies based on how long you've been there
- Multiple men approach rather than a single polite server
- Physical intimidation or shouting when you question the charge

■ How to Avoid

- Before sitting, ask any beach shack whether chairs are for paying customers — if so, either order food or find a different spot
 - Bring a beach mat and sit away from shack infrastructure entirely
 - On less touristy beaches (Morjim, Mandrem, Agonda in South Goa), this problem is significantly reduced
 - If surrounded and threatened over a beach chair, pay the minimum demanded amount and leave — then file a complaint with Goa Tourism Police
 - Note the shack name on any signage and report aggressive behavior to North Goa tourist police: 0832-2419990
-

Motorbike Rental Damage Claim

But a subset of rental shops has turned it into a lucrative scam. You return a bike you've rented for two days, and suddenly the owner points to a small scratch that was 'definitely not there' when you left. The security deposit (■2,000–■5,000) is forfeit. Some operators go further and demand you pay for 'full repair costs' — ■3,000–■8,000 for a scratch on an old bike. Travelers on r/goatravel describe returning bikes in perfectly good condition and having damage claims manufactured on the spot. In some cases, the owner scratches the bike after return, out of sight of the tourist. In others...

■ Red Flags

- Rental shop refuses to document existing damage or do a walk-around inspection at pickup
- No written rental agreement is provided
- Security deposit is unusually high (over ■3,000) for a standard scooter
- Owner's demeanor changes notably when you return the bike, before inspecting it
- Damage 'discovered' is in an area you could not see at pickup

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph every panel, scratch, dent, and scuff on the bike before leaving the rental shop — include timestamps

- Insist on a written rental agreement noting all existing damage before signing
 - Do a video walkthrough of the bike at pickup with the owner present
 - Pay deposit by card if possible — it's easier to dispute
 - Book through well-reviewed shops on Google Maps (4+ stars, 50+ reviews) rather than roadside stands
-

The Free Public Toilet Fee

■ ■ Calangute Beach, Baga Beach, Anjuna Flea Market area, near churches in Old Goa You need a restroom near Calangute Beach and spot what appears to be a public toilet. A man sitting outside demands 20-50 rupees for entry. The toilet is actually a free public facility maintained by the local panchayat, but self-appointed attendants position themselves at the entrance and charge tourists who do not know better. Some attendants even add 'toilet tissue' charges of 10-20 rupees extra. R/goatravel users describe random men charging foreigners for free public toilets as one of the pettiest but most persistent scams in Goa, happening at every major beach and tourist site. **Red Flags** A person sitting on a chair outside a toilet demands payment There is no official fee board or government signage They cannot produce a receipt for the fee they charge The fee is only demanded from tourists, not from locals using the same facility The attendant has no uniform or official identification **How to Avoid** Look for official municipal signage indicating whether the toilet is free or paid Use restrooms at restaurants, hotels, or beach shacks where you are a customer Ask to see an official receipt if someone demands payment Check with other tourists or nearby shop owners whether the toilet is actually free Carry your own toilet paper so you cannot be charged for tissues ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in India** ■ ■

A man sitting outside demands 20-50 rupees for entry. The toilet is actually a free public facility maintained by the local panchayat, but self-appointed attendants position themselves at the entrance and charge tourists who do not know better. Some attendants even add 'toilet tissue' charges of 10-20 rupees extra. R/goatravel users describe random men charging foreigners for free public toilets as one of the pettiest but most persistent scams in Goa, happening at every major beach and tourist site.

■ Red Flags

- A person sitting on a chair outside a toilet demands payment
- There is no official fee board or government signage
- They cannot produce a receipt for the fee they charge
- The fee is only demanded from tourists, not from locals using the same facility
- The attendant has no uniform or official identification

■ How to Avoid

- Look for official municipal signage indicating whether the toilet is free or paid
 - Use restrooms at restaurants, hotels, or beach shacks where you are a customer
 - Ask to see an official receipt if someone demands payment
 - Check with other tourists or nearby shop owners whether the toilet is actually free
 - Carry your own toilet paper so you cannot be charged for tissues
-

■ ■ Hyderabad

6 scams documented • India

The Fake Pearl Sting

You're exploring the colorful lanes of Laad Bazaar near Charminar, and a shopkeeper calls you over to see his 'genuine Hyderabad pearls.' He shows you a lustrous strand, lets you feel the weight, quotes 12,000 rupees, then 'discounts' it to 4,000 because you seem like a nice person. Back home, a jeweler confirms they're plastic beads coated with a pearlescent finish. Market reports estimate over 25% of Hyderabad's pearl trade involves counterfeits made from plastic, glass, or shell imported from Nepal and Tibet. Reddit and Quora threads are littered with accounts of tourists discovering th...

■ Red Flags

- Dramatic discounting from an inflated starting price -- a classic anchoring tactic
- The shopkeeper cannot provide a GIA or IGI gemological certificate
- No GST bill, no exchange policy, and no branded packaging
- Your auto or taxi driver specifically recommends this shop -- he earns 30-40% commission on your purchase
- The shop name mimics a well-known brand like 'Jagdamba' -- multiple imitation shops exist in Basheerbagh

■ How to Avoid

- Buy pearls only from certified dealers like Krishna Pearls, Jagdamba Pearls (original store), or Mangatrai
 - Always demand a gemological certificate and GST-compliant receipt
 - Do the tooth test: real pearls feel slightly gritty when rubbed against teeth, fakes feel smooth
 - Never follow your driver's recommendation for pearl shops -- they earn massive commissions
 - Research prices online before shopping: a genuine freshwater pearl strand starts at 3,000-5,000 rupees minimum
-

The Airport Shared Taxi Trap

You land at Hyderabad's RGIA and a friendly man in the arrivals hall offers a taxi into the city for just 500 rupees -- half the normal prepaid fare. You agree. He takes your luggage, leads you outside, then makes you wait while he collects three more passengers for his 'shared taxi.' Forty-five minutes later, you're crammed into a sedan with four strangers, your luggage in another vehicle entirely, and the driver takes a circuitous route dropping people off across the city. What was supposed to be a 45-minute ride to Banjara Hills becomes a 3-hour ordeal. Telangana Today reported on this c...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you inside the terminal before you reach the official taxi counter
- The fare quoted is significantly below the official prepaid taxi rate
- You are asked to wait while additional passengers are gathered
- Your luggage is placed in a separate vehicle or held by someone other than the driver
- The vehicle has no visible taxi permit or commercial license plate

■ How to Avoid

- Use only the official prepaid taxi counter or Ola/Uber pickup zone at RGIA
 - Never hand your luggage to anyone who is not your verified driver
 - Pre-book a transfer through your hotel or a verified car service
 - If the fare seems too good to be true, it's a shared-ride hustle -- walk to the official counter
 - Verify the car's license plate matches your booking before getting in
-

The Golconda Fort Unofficial Guide

You arrive at Golconda Fort and before you even reach the ticket window, a man with a laminated 'guide' badge around his neck latches onto you. He claims to be an ASI-certified guide and starts rattling off facts about the fort's acoustics. The tour is engaging, but at the end he demands 2,000 rupees -- far above the official 500-600 rupee rate for certified guides. When you resist, he summons friends who crowd around you near the exit. These self-appointed guides hustle arriving tourists at the entrance gate and may know their history, but they

are not officially certified and their fees a...

■ Red Flags

- The guide approaches you before you enter rather than being stationed at an official desk
- His 'certification' badge looks homemade or does not reference ASI (Archaeological Survey of India)
- No price is discussed upfront -- the fee is revealed only after the tour ends
- He becomes aggressive or enlists others to pressure you when you negotiate the price
- Other unofficial guides at the entrance seem to respect his territory rather than competing

■ How to Avoid

- Hire guides only from the official counter inside the fort entrance -- ASI-certified guides charge 500-600 rupees
 - Agree on the price in writing before starting any tour
 - Use audio guide apps or a Lonely Planet guidebook for self-guided exploration
 - A firm 'I already have a guide, thank you' stops most touts immediately
 - If pressured for payment, walk toward the ticket office or security personnel
-

The Old City Rickshaw Runaround

The driver nods, then takes you on a winding route through the old city's narrow lanes. He stops at three different shops -- a perfume attar shop, a bangle store, and a pearl dealer -- insisting each is 'on the way.' At each stop, shopkeepers offer you chai and hard-sell overpriced goods. The 15-minute ride has turned into an hour, and the driver demands 400 rupees for a trip that should cost 80. In the old city area, auto-rickshaws universally refuse meters, and drivers near Charminar are well known for commission-based detours targeting visitors.

■ Red Flags

- The driver refuses to use the meter and quotes a flat rate that seems oddly cheap
- Unexplained stops at shops you never requested during the ride
- The driver insists a particular shop has the 'best prices' and he's just being helpful
- The final destination seems to require a bizarrely circuitous route through market lanes
- Shopkeepers at the stops seem to already know the driver by name

■ How to Avoid

- Use Ola or Uber for all point-to-point travel in the old city -- prices are fixed and routes tracked
 - If taking an auto, agree on the fare and destination before getting in, with no stops
 - Track your route on Google Maps and call out deviations immediately
 - The old city is walkable between major sites -- consider walking between Charminar, Mecca Masjid, and Laad Bazaar
 - If the driver makes an unsolicited stop, refuse to leave the vehicle and insist on your destination
-

The Biryani Bait-and-Bill

You order one plate of biryani and a drink. When the bill arrives, there's no printed receipt -- just a verbal total of 800 rupees. A plate of biryani here should cost 250-350 rupees. Side dishes you never ordered have been added: raita, salan, mirchi ka salan, all itemized verbally. When you question it, the waiter claims these are 'standard accompaniments' included in the service. Several copycat restaurants trade on the names of famous establishments, with similar signage but inferior food at tourist-inflated prices. Travel bloggers and food writers warn specifically about non-transparen...

■ Red Flags

- No printed menu with prices is available or offered
- The bill is quoted verbally without an itemized printed receipt

- Side dishes or extras appear that you did not order
- The restaurant name is suspiciously similar to a famous brand but with a slight variation
- The waiter suggests specific dishes without mentioning prices

■ How to Avoid

- Always ask for a printed menu with prices before ordering
- Demand an itemized printed bill -- GST regulations require it
- Verify the restaurant's authenticity on Google Maps or Zomato before sitting down
- Know the going rate: biryani at top Hyderabad spots costs 250-400 rupees per plate
- Stick to well-reviewed establishments: Paradise, Bawarchi (original), Shah Ghouse (verified location)

The Emporium Guided Shopping Scam

■ ■ *Shops near Charminar, Laad Bazaar, government emporiums on Nampally Road* Your tour guide takes you to what he calls an 'authentic government emporium' where you can buy ... Your tour guide takes you to what he calls an 'authentic government emporium' where you can buy local handicrafts at fixed prices. Inside, a salesperson shows you a marble chess board, Bidriware, or pearl jewelry at 'certified' prices. You pay 30,000 rupees for a chess board. The next day, you see the identical item at a regular market stall for 3,000 rupees. The guide earns a 30-40 percent commission on every purchase, and the emporium is a private shop masquerading as a government outlet. As r/india users report, a foreign tourist in Hyderabad was sold a marble chess board for 30,000 rupees at an emporium recommended by a guide, only to find the same item later for a tenth of the price. **Red Flags** Your guide or driver insists on stopping at a specific shop The shop claims to be a 'government emporium' but has no official AP Tourism signage Prices are not labeled on items and are quoted verbally The salesperson and your guide seem overly friendly with each other You are told prices are 'fixed' and non-negotiable **How to Avoid** Visit only official AP Tourism or Telangana State emporiums with verifiable government signage Research market prices online before shopping for handicrafts or jewelry Tell your guide that you will choose your own shopping stops Compare prices at Laad Bazaar and Begum Bazaar before buying at any emporium If a guide's recommended shop has inflated prices, report the guide to the tourism office ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. *More Scam Guides* *More in India* ■ ■

Your tour guide takes you to what he calls an 'authentic government emporium' where you can buy local handicrafts at fixed prices. Inside, a salesperson shows you a marble chess board, Bidriware, or pearl jewelry at 'certified' prices. You pay 30,000 rupees for a chess board. The next day, you see the identical item at a regular market stall for 3,000 rupees. The guide earns a 30-40 percent commission on every purchase, and the emporium is a private shop masquerading as a government outlet. As r/india users report, a foreign tourist in Hyderabad was sold a marble chess board for 30,000 rupee...

■ Red Flags

- Your guide or driver insists on stopping at a specific shop
- The shop claims to be a 'government emporium' but has no official AP Tourism signage
- Prices are not labeled on items and are quoted verbally
- The salesperson and your guide seem overly friendly with each other
- You are told prices are 'fixed' and non-negotiable

■ How to Avoid

- Visit only official AP Tourism or Telangana State emporiums with verifiable government signage
- Research market prices online before shopping for handicrafts or jewelry
- Tell your guide that you will choose your own shopping stops
- Compare prices at Laad Bazaar and Begum Bazaar before buying at any emporium

- If a guide's recommended shop has inflated prices, report the guide to the tourism office
-

■■ Jaipur

7 scams documented • India

Gem Export Profit Scam

He mentions casually that he works in the gem trade and that Jaipur is one of the world's top ruby and sapphire cutting centers. Over chai at a nearby shop, he explains an 'incredible opportunity': gems bought here can be resold in Europe or North America for 5–10x the price. He just needs a trustworthy foreign partner to carry them through customs — and he'll split the profit. This is one of the most elaborate scams in India's tourism ecosystem, reported so frequently on r/india that it has its own warning pinned in several travel forums. The gems are either fake (colored glass or syntheti...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger mentions gem trading and profit-sharing opportunities unprompted
- You're invited for free chai before any 'business discussion'
- The pitch involves carrying gems through customs on the seller's behalf
- Certificates of authenticity are produced but issued by unknown private bodies
- Price is 'specially reduced' because you're helping with their export quota

■ How to Avoid

- Never buy gems as investment items from unsolicited sources in India
 - Genuine gems for personal purchase should be bought from GIA-certified or government gem labs
 - If a local offers to make you money by using you as a courier, walk away immediately
 - Any legitimate gem purchase for personal use should come with a proper GST invoice from a registered shop
 - For real gemstone shopping, use the Rajasthan government's fixed-price emporia (Rajasthali)
-

Rickshaw Driver Textile Commission Loop

He's friendly, speaks decent English, and seems knowledgeable. Midway through your itinerary, he mentions his 'cousin's shop' — a silk emporium or carpet showroom — just a 'five-minute detour.' The shop is in the suburbs, far from any tourist area. Inside, staff immediately serve you chai and begin unrolling carpets or laying out shawls, while your driver waits outside. This is the most consistently reported scam in Jaipur according to r/india and r/travel. As u/nuck_forte_dame noted in r/india: 'The cab driver tried to scam me. He took me to a house out in the burbs and they had textiles f...

■ Red Flags

- Driver offers a city tour rate well below market price (under ■300 for 4 hours)
- Any mention of 'cousin's shop,' 'family business,' or 'just 5 minutes'
- The shop is outside the main tourist bazaar areas and feels like a private residence
- All other customers in the shop appear to be foreign tourists
- You're served free chai immediately upon entering a shop — this creates social obligation

■ How to Avoid

- Book rickshaws through your hotel's front desk or Ola/Uber app for transparent pricing
- At the start of any ride, state clearly: 'No shops, direct to destination only'
- If driver insists on a 'quick stop,' say 'Please take me to [destination] now or I'll find another auto'
- Shop at Bapu Bazaar or Johari Bazaar yourself — browse independently without a middleman
- Rajasthali government emporium on MI Road has fixed prices and no commission pressure

Fake Government Tourist Office

You've just arrived at Jaipur Railway Station and notice a sign that says 'Government Tourist Information Office' or 'Rajasthan Tourism Bureau.' Inside, smartly dressed staff offer to book tours, hotels, and transport at 'government rates.' They may show you an official-looking rate card and brochures that mimic real government publications. The tours they sell cost 3–5x what legitimate operators charge. This is a well-documented scam throughout Rajasthan. Redditors on [r/india](#) and [r/travel](#) describe these fake offices as indistinguishable from real ones, with staff in khaki-colored shirts, p...

■ Red Flags

- Tourist office is located outside the station or in a shopping area rather than the official tourism counter
- Staff quote 'government rates' but prices are higher than what major booking sites show
- You're asked to pay full cash upfront for multi-day tours
- The office name is slightly different from 'RTDC' (the actual Rajasthan Tourism Development Corporation)
- Staff seem oddly eager to book everything for you on your first visit without any prior research

■ How to Avoid

- The real RTDC office is inside or directly adjacent to Jaipur Railway Station — use it, not the shops nearby
 - Verify any tourism office by Googling its name + 'Jaipur' before paying anything
 - For tours, book through internationally recognized platforms (Viator, GetYourGuide) or your hotel
 - Never pay full cash upfront for multi-day packages from an operator you just met
 - The Government of India's official tourism website is incredibleindia.org — check it before booking
-

Elephant Ride Bait-and-Switch at Amber Fort

You arrive early to beat the heat, and a handler approaches with a smiling elephant named something like Lakshmi. He quotes ₹600 for the ride up. You agree and climb on. Halfway up the ramp, he announces the price was 'per person' not 'for the ride,' or adds charges for the mahout's 'tip,' the elephant's 'food fund,' and a ₹200 'photography charge' if you take out your phone. Separately, the official elephant ride booking has a regulated price posted at the base of the fort — currently around ₹900 per elephant (shared, for up to 2 people) — but touts quote lower prices to hook you, then inf...

■ Red Flags

- Handler quotes a price that sounds too low compared to signboards at the entrance
- Price is quoted 'per person' ambiguously without clarifying what's included
- New charges for 'tips,' 'photos,' or 'elephant food' appear mid-ride
- Handler operates from outside the official elephant ride queue area
- No printed ticket or receipt is offered for the booking

■ How to Avoid

- Check the official Amber Fort elephant ride price board before approaching any handler
 - Book the elephant ride only through the official booking counter inside the fort premises
 - Insist on a printed ticket with total price before boarding
 - Consider the electric golf cart (₹50) or walk — both are scam-free alternatives
 - Agree on total all-inclusive price including any tip before the elephant moves
-

Hotel Tout 'Your Booking Cancelled' Scam

Before you reach the exit, a man in a uniform-like shirt says he works for the railway tourist information center and asks where you're staying. When you mention your hotel, he frowns and picks up his phone. 'I'm sorry, your hotel had a fire last night. It is closed for repairs.' Or: 'That area has flooding.' He happens to know another hotel

— his cousin's — that has a special rate. This scam mirrors what happens in Mumbai but is reportedly even more common in Jaipur, which sees enormous tourist traffic for the Golden Triangle itinerary. r/india has multiple threads describing this exact sc...

■ Red Flags

- Anyone at the station proactively asks about your accommodation
- Your confirmed hotel is described as suddenly closed, flooded, or under renovation
- The alternative hotel is suggested within seconds of the 'bad news'
- The person offering help is in civilian clothes but uses officious language
- They offer a 'free lift' to the new hotel in their personal vehicle

■ How to Avoid

- Call your hotel directly (using the number from your booking confirmation) if told it's closed
 - Pre-book a pick-up with your hotel and have the driver's name/number before you land
 - Only take prepaid taxis or Ola/Uber from the station — avoid anyone who approaches you
 - The real tourist information counter is staffed by RTDC in official booths — not men in private clothes
 - If accommodation is genuinely unavailable, use Booking.com to rebook rather than trusting a stranger
-

Free Henna 'Gift' Pressure Scam

A woman near Hawa Mahal smiles and approaches, offering to apply henna (mehndi) on your hand as a 'welcome gift' or 'for good luck.' She starts before you can respond, squeezing intricate patterns onto your palm with practiced speed. When she finishes five minutes later, she announces a price — ■500–■2,000 — for the 'free gift.' Her male relatives appear nearby. Refusing to pay becomes socially difficult and sometimes frightening. This scam is low-violence but psychologically coercive. Redditors on r/india describe being physically grabbed by the wrist as the henna artist begins, making it ...

■ Red Flags

- Henna application begins without any price discussion or consent
- The word 'free' or 'gift' is used to start the interaction
- The artist physically takes your hand without asking
- Male associates appear nearby as the application progresses
- Price is only mentioned after the design is complete

■ How to Avoid

- Decline all unsolicited henna offers by saying 'no thank you' and continuing to walk
 - If you want mehndi, seek out a designated stall in Johari Bazaar or Bapu Bazaar with a clear price sign
 - Never let anyone apply anything to your body without agreeing on a price first
 - If henna is applied without consent and a high price demanded, offer only the fair price (■50–■150) and walk away
 - Avoid lingering near tourist sites' entrances where hawkers concentrate — move with purpose
-

Milk and Baby Formula Sympathy Scam

■ ■ Outside Amber Fort, Hawa Mahal, main bazaar areas Near Jaipur's tourist sites, a woman approaches holding a baby, sometimes with a young child at her feet. She explains, in broken English, that her husband is ill or has died and she can't afford milk for her baby. She's not asking for money — just milk. She points to a nearby shop where she says they sell the formula she needs. You feel relieved: this isn't about cash. The shop charges you ■800–■1,200 for a tin of baby formula. The moment you leave, the woman returns the tin to the shopkeeper and splits the 'sale' with them. This scam plays specifically on the guilt tourists feel about refusing to help a child in need. Redditors in r/india have documented this running in Jaipur and other Rajasthan cities for years, with u/pro_grammer_ writing: 'The worst in my experience was in Jaipur, a lady was asking for money to buy milk for her little son. I clearly knew it was a scam but couldn't say no after seeing the baby cry.' Donations to genuine aid programs (child welfare NGOs, local temples that run feeding programs) are far more

effective than formula purchases. Red Flags Sympathy pitch doesn't ask for money directly but steers you toward a specific nearby shop The shop sells only the specific item requested — formula, medicine, or food — at high prices Price of the item at the shop is far above normal market rate Woman and shopkeeper appear to know each other The same woman is seen at the same spot on multiple days How to Avoid Politely decline and continue walking — the best response to all street sympathy pitches If you want to help families in need, donate to verified local NGOs rather than individuals on the street Never enter a specific shop at the direction of a stranger who has just told you a sob story If moved to help with food, offer packaged food you buy independently from a different store Understand that organized begging rings use children specifically because adults find them harder to refuse ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in India ■■

She explains, in broken English, that her husband is ill or has died and she can't afford milk for her baby. She's not asking for money — just milk. She points to a nearby shop where she says they sell the formula she needs. You feel relieved: this isn't about cash. The shop charges you ■800–■1,200 for a tin of baby formula. The moment you leave, the woman returns the tin to the shopkeeper and splits the 'sale' with them. This scam plays specifically on the guilt tourists feel about refusing to help a child in need. Redditors in r/india have documented this running in Jaipur and other Rajas...

■ Red Flags

- Sympathy pitch doesn't ask for money directly but steers you toward a specific nearby shop
- The shop sells only the specific item requested — formula, medicine, or food — at high prices
- Price of the item at the shop is far above normal market rate
- Woman and shopkeeper appear to know each other
- The same woman is seen at the same spot on multiple days

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline and continue walking — the best response to all street sympathy pitches
 - If you want to help families in need, donate to verified local NGOs rather than individuals on the street
 - Never enter a specific shop at the direction of a stranger who has just told you a sob story
 - If moved to help with food, offer packaged food you buy independently from a different store
 - Understand that organized begging rings use children specifically because adults find them harder to refuse
-

■■ Kolkata

8 scams documented • India

The Howrah Station Ticket Trap

Before you even find the exit, a man in a quasi-official looking shirt intercepts you: 'Ticket office is closed, sir. Your train is fully booked anyway. Come to our government-approved agency -- I arrange everything.' He guides you to a small office nearby where tickets cost three times the official rate plus a hefty 'service charge.' As widely reported on r/india and r/solotravel, the Howrah Station touts are among India's most aggressive, preying on disoriented arrivals who don't know the ticket office operates around the clock.

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you inside or outside the station claiming the ticket office is closed
- They claim your train is cancelled or fully booked without showing official evidence

- They steer you toward a 'government-approved' booking office that's actually a private shop
- The office charges significantly more than the official IRCTC rates
- They create urgency: 'Only two seats left, you must book now'

■ How to Avoid

- Walk directly to the official Indian Railways ticket counter inside the station -- it's always open
 - Book trains in advance through the official IRCTC website or app
 - Ignore anyone who approaches you unsolicited at the station, no matter how official they look
 - Indian Railways ticket offices never close permanently -- verify at the counter yourself
 - If confused, ask uniformed Railway Police (RPF) for directions, not random civilians
-

The Kalighat Temple Donation Scam

Outside Gate 2, a man in saffron robes approaches: 'I am temple Brahmin. Come, I give you VIP darshan -- skip the long line!' He guides you through side corridors, placing flowers in your hand, touching your forehead with vermillion. At the sanctum, he produces a worn notebook: 'See, other tourists donated -- John from USA, 3,000 rupees; Mark from France, 5,000 rupees.' The names are written in the same handwriting. He expects you to match or exceed them. As Tripadvisor reviewers of Kalighat warn, fake pandits pocket 100 percent of these 'donations' -- none reaches the temple.

■ Red Flags

- Someone outside the temple offers VIP or skip-the-line darshan for a fee
- They show a donation book with suspiciously neat entries and foreign names with large amounts
- They place items in your hands (flowers, offerings) without asking, then demand payment
- The 'priest' is not inside the temple sanctum but operating in corridors and outside gates
- They become aggressive or invoke spiritual consequences if you refuse to donate

■ How to Avoid

- Enter through the official Gate 2 public entrance and stand in the regular darshan line
 - Buy puja accessories from authorized stalls before entering, not from individuals outside
 - Never accept items placed in your hands by strangers -- this creates an obligation to pay
 - If you want to donate, use only the official donation box inside the temple
 - Say 'Nahi chahiye' (I don't need it) firmly and keep walking
-

The New Market Commission Guide

Almost immediately, a friendly young man appears: 'First time? I know the best shops -- wholesale prices, very cheap!' He leads you through the maze of stalls to a fabric shop where the owner greets him like family. The silk saree the owner quotes at 3,000 rupees? A similar one costs 800 rupees three stalls away. Your 'guide' earns 30-40 percent commission on everything you buy. As travelers on India forums describe, New Market's self-appointed guides are essentially working salesmen who add a 300-500 percent markup to every purchase.

■ Red Flags

- An unsolicited guide appears the moment you enter the market
- They claim to know 'wholesale' or 'factory direct' prices at specific shops
- The shops they take you to have no visible price tags on merchandise
- The guide and shopkeeper clearly know each other and communicate in Bengali about pricing
- The guide becomes offended or aggressive if you want to browse independently

■ How to Avoid

- Firmly decline all unsolicited guides at the market entrance: 'No guide needed, thank you'

- Shop independently and compare prices at multiple stalls before buying
 - Ask for prices at stalls the guide did NOT suggest to establish a baseline
 - Use Google Maps to pre-identify specific shops with good reviews before visiting
 - Visit the fixed-price government emporium shops (Manjusha, Biswa Bangla) for guaranteed fair rates
-

The Prepaid Taxi Hotel Diversion

Twenty minutes into the ride, the driver pulls over and makes a phone call in Bengali. He turns to you with rehearsed concern: 'Sir, very bad news. Your hotel has closed down. Water problem, flooding. But don't worry -- my brother has a nice guesthouse nearby, very clean.' You've already paid the fare. As documented on Tripadvisor's Kolkata forum and across r/india, this is one of India's most common arrival scams -- the hotel is perfectly fine, and the driver's 'brother' pays him 500-1000 rupees for every tourist delivered.

■ Red Flags

- The driver claims your hotel is closed, flooded, burned down, or overbooked
- He makes a mysterious phone call mid-journey then delivers the bad news
- He has an immediate alternative ready -- always run by his friend, brother, or cousin
- The alternative is conveniently nearby while your actual hotel is 'too far now'
- He refuses to take you to your original hotel to verify the claim yourself

■ How to Avoid

- Call your hotel before getting in the taxi to confirm your reservation and get their exact address
 - Insist the driver take you to your booked hotel: 'Take me there anyway -- I'll check myself'
 - Use Ola or Uber from the airport for GPS-tracked rides directly to your hotel
 - Have your hotel confirmation with the address saved on your phone to show the driver
 - If the driver refuses to go to your hotel, get out and find another taxi
-

The Sudder Street Pickpocket Ring

A cluster of small children appears, tugging at your sleeves and clothes, showing you trinkets, making noise. They're persistent and surprisingly coordinated, pressing close from all sides. One pulls your arm while another reaches for your pocket. By the time you've gently pushed through the group, your wallet is gone. As Kolkata safety guides warn, organized child pickpocket groups operate specifically along Sudder Street targeting tourists, with the youngest children doing the actual theft while older ones create the distraction.

■ Red Flags

- A group of children suddenly surrounds you in an organized manner
- They pull at your clothing, hands, and bags simultaneously from multiple directions
- The children are persistent even when you say no and try to walk away
- An older child or teenager watches from nearby, directing the group
- You feel light touches near your pockets, waistband, or bag zippers

■ How to Avoid

- Keep valuables in a money belt or deep front pocket, never in back pockets
 - Carry only the cash you need and leave extra money in your hotel safe
 - When children approach in a group, firmly say 'No' and walk away quickly without stopping
 - Avoid walking through Sudder Street's narrow lanes after dark with visible electronics
 - Use a cross-body bag worn in front with the zipper against your body
-

The Rickshaw Fare Explosion

Outside the Victoria Memorial, you hail one of Kolkata's iconic hand-pulled rickshaws for a short ride to the Indian Museum. The puller agrees to 50 rupees. It's a slow, atmospheric journey through the Maidan's green expanse. At the museum gates, the puller suddenly demands 500 rupees, gesturing angrily. Within seconds, two other rickshaw pullers materialize to support his claim, insisting the price was always 500. As travelers on India forums note, the backup pullers are part of the act -- they work the Victoria Memorial area in teams, knowing solo tourists won't risk a confrontation again...

■ Red Flags

- The rickshaw puller agrees to your price too easily without any counter-offer
- At the destination, the agreed price suddenly multiplies by a factor of ten
- Other rickshaw pullers appear to back up the driver's inflated claim
- The pullers become physically imposing or block your path to pressure payment
- They switch between languages, speaking Bengali among themselves and broken English to you

■ How to Avoid

- Confirm the fare clearly: hold up fingers showing the number and have the puller nod in agreement
 - Write the agreed price on your phone and show it to the puller before starting
 - Carry exact change in small bills (10 and 20 rupee notes) so you can pay precisely what was agreed
 - Use Ola or Uber for longer rides where fare disputes are more likely
 - If confronted by a group, stay calm, pay the originally agreed amount, and walk toward a busy area or police officer
-

The Currency Note Swap

He examines it, frowns, and hands it back: 'Sir, this note is fake. See, the watermark is wrong.' He shows you what appears to be the same note -- but it isn't. Through sleight of hand, he's swapped your genuine 500-rupee note for a counterfeit one. Now you're holding a worthless bill, and he insists on a different note for the fare. As warned on India travel forums and [r/solotravel](#), the currency swap scam is a practiced magic trick that targets tourists unfamiliar with Indian banknotes.

■ Red Flags

- A driver or vendor claims your note is fake immediately after you hand it over
- They examine the note below the counter or at an angle where you can't see the swap
- The 'returned' note looks slightly different in color or feel from the one you gave
- They insist on payment with a different note or in smaller denominations
- This happens with a 500 or 2000 rupee note -- never with small bills

■ How to Avoid

- Before handing over large notes, photograph them or note the serial number
 - Watch the note at all times and never let it go below a counter or out of your sight
 - Pay with exact change or small denominations whenever possible
 - Exchange currency only at banks or authorized exchange counters, not at street stalls
 - Familiarize yourself with Indian banknote security features before your trip
-

The Dakshineswar Temple Pandit Shakedown

■ ■ *Dakshineswar Kali Temple, north Kolkata You visit Dakshineswar Temple and are intercepted outside by a man in priest's robes who insists on ... You visit Dakshineswar Temple and are intercepted outside by a man in priest's robes who insists on guiding you through the 'proper darshan ritual.' He takes you to the inner sanctum, performs a brief puja, and then demands 2,000-5,000 INR as dakshina (priest offering). When you hesitate, other temple-area workers surround you and insist the payment is mandatory. A Reddit user on [r/kolkata](#) described becoming a victim of multiple scams in one trip, with the temple pandas at Dakshineswar being particularly aggressive. Real temple entry is free, and official priests do not demand specific amounts. Red Flags Someone intercepts you outside the temple claiming to be an official pandit They*

promise VIP access or skip-the-line entry for a fee After a brief ritual, a specific large amount is demanded as 'mandatory donation' Multiple people surround you when you hesitate to pay The amount demanded is above 500 INR for a basic blessing How to Avoid Enter the temple through the main queue — free darshan is available to everyone Politely but firmly decline anyone who approaches you outside offering guided entry If you want a puja performed, agree on the exact donation amount before the ritual begins Keep only small bills in an accessible pocket — leave larger denominations in your hotel safe Visit during less crowded hours when pressure from touts is reduced ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in India ■■

You visit Dakshineswar Temple and are intercepted outside by a man in priest's robes who insists on guiding you through the 'proper darshan ritual.' He takes you to the inner sanctum, performs a brief puja, and then demands 2,000-5,000 INR as dakshina (priest offering). When you hesitate, other temple-area workers surround you and insist the payment is mandatory. A Reddit user on r/kolkata described becoming a victim of multiple scams in one trip, with the temple pandas at Dakshineswar being particularly aggressive. Real temple entry is free, and official priests do not demand specific amou...

■ Red Flags

- Someone intercepts you outside the temple claiming to be an official pandit
- They promise VIP access or skip-the-line entry for a fee
- After a brief ritual, a specific large amount is demanded as 'mandatory donation'
- Multiple people surround you when you hesitate to pay
- The amount demanded is above 500 INR for a basic blessing

■ How to Avoid

- Enter the temple through the main queue — free darshan is available to everyone
 - Politely but firmly decline anyone who approaches you outside offering guided entry
 - If you want a puja performed, agree on the exact donation amount before the ritual begins
 - Keep only small bills in an accessible pocket — leave larger denominations in your hotel safe
 - Visit during less crowded hours when pressure from touts is reduced
-

■■ Mumbai

8 scams documented • India

Black Taxi Meter Scam

You've just arrived at CST station or the Gateway of India, bags in hand, and a black-and-yellow kaali peeli cab pulls up. The driver smiles and quotes you a price — but when you arrive, the fare has somehow doubled. He claims the meter was 'running on night rate' or shows you a laminated rate card with confusing multipliers. Some drivers simply don't turn the meter on at all, or turn it on partway through the ride and add a 'waiting charge' for every red light. Redditors in r/mumbai describe this as one of Mumbai's oldest tricks. One commenter recounted being taken from Bandra to Colaba — ...

■ Red Flags

- Driver refuses to start the meter or says it's 'broken'
- Driver quotes a fixed price that feels high before starting the trip
- A laminated 'rate card' is produced that you've never seen before

- Driver takes a longer route than Google Maps suggests
- No change is available and driver insists on rounding up heavily

■ How to Avoid

- Use Ola or Uber for all rides — fixed price shown upfront
 - If using a kaali peeli, insist the driver starts the meter before you get in
 - At the airport, only use the official prepaid taxi counter inside arrivals
 - Screenshot Google Maps route before getting in so you know the right road
 - Know the approximate fare: ■25 minimum + ~■15/km for rickshaws, ~■25/km for taxis
-

Dhobhi Ghat 'Free Guide' Commission Trap

As you approach the viewing bridge, a friendly local materializes beside you. He says entry is 'from this side' and leads you down a different path. After giving you a surprisingly informative tour of the washermen below, he suggests a nearby textile shop or chai stall where 'real Mumbai silk' is sold at 'wholesale prices.' The tea is free, the pressure is not. This follows the classic Indian guide-commission scam well-documented on r/india and r/travel. The guide receives 20–40% commission from every shop he steers tourists into. The 'wholesale' prices are actually marked up 3–5x from what...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches and offers to show you a 'better viewing angle' for free
- The guide steers you away from public streets toward private shops
- Tea or snacks are offered for free as a way to obligate you
- Shop owners seem to know the guide personally and immediately offer 'special prices'
- You feel social pressure to buy after receiving hospitality you didn't ask for

■ How to Avoid

- View Dhobhi Ghat from the free public bridge on Dr. E. Moses Road — no guide needed
 - Politely decline all unsolicited 'guide' offers near tourist sites
 - If someone walks alongside you uninvited, say firmly: 'No guide needed, thank you'
 - Do not accept free tea, snacks, or gifts from strangers near tourist areas
 - If you want a real guide, book through your hotel or a licensed government-approved service
-

Dating App Café Bill Scam

After a few charming messages, they suggest meeting at a trendy bar or club in Andheri West or Bandra. The conversation flows, the drinks keep coming — and then your date suddenly gets an 'emergency call' and disappears. Minutes later, a waiter delivers a bill for ■30,000–■60,000. When you protest, intimidating staff appear. The items listed are things you never ordered. This scam became headline news in Mumbai in 2024 when at least 22 victims were identified at just two pubs, with one man losing ■61,000 at The Godfather Club in Andheri. The women (or men) involved are paid accomplices who ...

■ Red Flags

- Match on dating app immediately suggests an expensive-looking venue you haven't heard of
- Your date is unusually eager and pushes for a same-day meeting
- The venue has minimal online reviews or reviews that seem fake
- Staff seem to know your date personally and are unusually attentive
- Your date disappears shortly after ordering multiple rounds

■ How to Avoid

- For first meets, always suggest a well-known, highly reviewed public place of your own choosing

- Check the venue on Google Maps and TripAdvisor before going — no reviews is a red flag
 - Ask to see a full menu with prices before sitting down; leave if staff refuse
 - Never let someone else order on your behalf without seeing prices
 - If threatened over a bill, call Mumbai Police on 100 — threatening tourists over fake bills is illegal
-

Fake 'Your Hotel Is Closed' Redirect

A friendly man in a polo shirt — he looks vaguely official — approaches and asks if you're looking for transport. When you mention your hotel name, his face falls. 'Oh, that hotel is closed for renovation this week. I can take you to a better place, same area, better price.' He's already reaching for your bags. This is one of the oldest scams in the India travel playbook, reported repeatedly on r/travel and r/india. The driver takes you to a hotel that pays him ₹500–₹2,000 per referral. Your 'original' hotel was never closed — the scammer made it up. The substitute hotel is often overpriced...

■ Red Flags

- Stranger approaches you at the airport claiming to know your hotel's status
- Anyone who isn't a uniformed official warns you that your accommodation is 'closed' or 'flooded'
- The person suggests an alternative hotel immediately after breaking the bad news
- They seem to know the name of your hotel even before you mention it
- The ride to the 'new' hotel takes you further from the area you booked in

■ How to Avoid

- Pre-book a pickup with your hotel or use the official airport prepaid taxi counter
 - If told your hotel is closed, call the hotel directly using the number from booking confirmation — not a number the stranger provides
 - Never let a stranger carry your bags or guide you toward transport
 - Only exit through the official arrival gates and ignore anyone before you reach the main taxi/app counter
 - Screenshot your hotel's address and share your live location with someone you trust during the ride
-

Overpriced Colaba Causeway 'Antique' Sellers

hawkers spread out brass Ganeshas, silver jewelry, pashminas and carved wooden boxes on cloth. A seller spots you slowing down and immediately starts his pitch: this pendant is 'real silver,' that bowl is a '100-year-old antique,' and your interest has apparently given him an 'excellent feeling' about your luck. Prices start high but drop dramatically as you walk away. The items are rarely what they claim. 'Pure silver' jewelry often turns green within weeks. 'Antiques' are mass-produced the week before. 'Kashmiri pashminas' are synthetic acrylic. Redditors in r/mumbai and r/india consis-

■ Red Flags

- Seller claims items are 'pure silver,' 'real gold,' or 'genuine antique' without any certification
- Price drops by more than 50% the moment you show disinterest — real quality goods don't work this way
- Seller draws you into a back room away from the main street to see 'better stock'
- You're told this is a 'special price only for you today' — a common pressure tactic
- The item has no hallmark stamp, certification, or receipt offered for silver/gold

■ How to Avoid

- Treat all Colaba Causeway goods as decorative souvenirs, not investments
- Never pay more than 25–30% of the opening price for street market items
- For actual silver or gold, buy from certified stores with hallmark stamps (BIS hallmark for gold)
- Decline invitations to enter private back rooms or climb stairs to 'private showrooms'
- Walk away completely if the vibe shifts to high-pressure; legitimate sellers let you go

Elephanta Island Boat Ticket Touting

Before you reach the official ticket window, men in casual clothes surround you offering 'better boats,' 'VIP seats,' 'skip the queue' tickets, or a combined boat-plus-guide package. They name a price — ■500–■800 per person — that sounds reasonable for such a famous trip. The actual government ferry costs ■200 round trip. Some of these touts sell genuine tickets at inflated prices. Others sell you tickets that are technically valid but for slower, less comfortable boats. The worst version involves paying for a 'guide' who then demands ■2,000–■3,000 for a 'complete tour' once you're on the i...

■ Red Flags

- Anyone approaches you with ferry tickets before you reach the official counter
- Price quoted is higher than ■200–■250 for the standard round-trip government ferry
- Someone insists a 'guide' is mandatory for Elephanta Island
- You're told the official counter is closed or the queue is 'hours long'
- A guide quotes a vague price for their services rather than a fixed amount before boarding

■ How to Avoid

- Buy tickets only from the official MTDC (Maharashtra Tourism) counter near the Gateway of India
 - Official round-trip ferry fare is posted clearly — verify the current price before approaching touts
 - Decline all unsolicited guides; you can hire an official licensed guide on the island itself
 - If hiring a guide on Elephanta, agree on the total price before you leave the dock area
 - Check last ferry times before you go — missing the return ferry forces expensive alternatives
-

Train Ticket 'Reservation Assistance' Scam

A helpful stranger materializes and says the tourist quota counter 'is on the second floor' or that 'online is broken today.' He can get you a confirmed ticket right now, no queue needed. You follow him to a travel agent's office two blocks away where tickets are sold at 2–3x face value with a large 'service fee.' This scam is so pervasive at Indian railway stations that [r/india](#) and [r/travel](#) have dedicated warning threads. The Indian Railways booking system (IRCTC) has a specific tourist quota for foreign visitors at most major stations — including CSMT Mumbai — but touts redirect tourists ...

■ Red Flags

- Anyone outside the station offers to help you buy train tickets 'more easily'
- Told that the official counter is 'closed' or 'only for Indian nationals'
- The 'travel agent' office is located away from the station premises
- Ticket price is significantly higher than what IRCTC website shows
- Asked to pay cash rather than by card for the ticket

■ How to Avoid

- Book in advance on [IRCTC.co.in](#) or the IRCTC Rail Connect app — you can use international cards
 - At CSMT, go directly to the Foreign Tourist Quota counter on the ground floor — show your passport
 - Ignore all helpers outside railway stations offering to 'assist' with tickets
 - If the counter is genuinely full, use a government-approved travel agent with visible IATA/TAAI accreditation
 - Screenshot your confirmed booking — legitimate tickets have a PNR number you can verify on [irctc.co.in](#)
-

The Street Card Game Hustle

■ ■ Outside Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus, near Gateway of India, busy intersections in Colaba, and street corners along Linking Road in Bandra You notice a small crowd gathered around a man with three boxes and a ball on the pavement near CST station. Two or three bystanders place bets and win money easily, doubling their stakes each time. It

looks simple. A Reddit user on r/mumbai described exactly this setup: card game scammers where 2-3 insiders win easy money to lure bystanders into betting. When a genuine passerby joins, the rules subtly change so you cannot win. While you focus on the game, an accomplice pickpockets your bag or back pocket. The entire crowd of supposed winners and spectators are part of the same team. **Red Flags** A street game where multiple bystanders appear to win easily and enthusiastically encourage you to try The game operator engages you in conversation and makes the rules seem impossibly simple The winning bystanders are always the same people who never actually leave with their winnings You feel people pressing close around you as you watch -- they are positioning to pickpocket The game is set up in a busy area where the crowd provides cover for theft How to Avoid Never participate in street gambling games -- they are rigged and every apparent winner is an insider Keep walking past any street crowd gathered around a game or performance without stopping Keep your phone and wallet in front zippered pockets when passing through crowded areas near tourist sites If you stop to watch, keep your bag in front of you and maintain awareness of people standing behind you Report illegal street gambling setups to the nearest police officer or call 100 ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in India ■■

Two or three bystanders place bets and win money easily, doubling their stakes each time. It looks simple. A Reddit user on r/mumbai described exactly this setup: card game scammers where 2-3 insiders win easy money to lure bystanders into betting. When a genuine passerby joins, the rules subtly change so you cannot win. While you focus on the game, an accomplice pickpockets your bag or back pocket. The entire crowd of supposed winners and spectators are part of the same team.

■ Red Flags

- A street game where multiple bystanders appear to win easily and enthusiastically encourage you to try
- The game operator engages you in conversation and makes the rules seem impossibly simple
- The winning bystanders are always the same people who never actually leave with their winnings
- You feel people pressing close around you as you watch -- they are positioning to pickpocket
- The game is set up in a busy area where the crowd provides cover for theft

■ How to Avoid

- Never participate in street gambling games -- they are rigged and every apparent winner is an insider
- Keep walking past any street crowd gathered around a game or performance without stopping
- Keep your phone and wallet in front zippered pockets when passing through crowded areas near tourist sites
- If you stop to watch, keep your bag in front of you and maintain awareness of people standing behind you
- Report illegal street gambling setups to the nearest police officer or call 100

■■ Rishikesh

6 scams documented • India

The Fake Ashram Yoga Teacher Training

The 'certification' comes from a made-up yoga alliance, classes have 60+ students, and the guru has no formal training. Some ashrams operate like factories, churning out uncertified yoga teachers. Others have darker issues — there have been documented cases of ashram operators targeting solo female travelers.

■ Red Flags

- Price well below \$800-1,200 for legitimate 200-hour YTT
- No Yoga Alliance (YA) certification mentioned or verifiable

- Ashram has few reviews or reviews mentioning overcrowding
- Guru has no verifiable credentials or lineage
- Verify the school is registered with Yoga Alliance (yogaalliance.org)

■ How to Avoid

- Verify the school is registered with Yoga Alliance (yogaalliance.org)
 - Read recent Google and TripAdvisor reviews focusing on class size and quality
 - Budget \$800-1,500 for a legitimate 200-hour YTT in Rishikesh
 - Speak to recent graduates before enrolling — legitimate schools will connect you
-

The Fake GST Billing Scam

Many charge this tax without valid GST registration — meaning the tax goes straight into the owner's pocket, not to the government. In 2024, Indian authorities flagged widespread fake GST billing in tourist areas including Rishikesh.

■ Red Flags

- GST charged but no GSTIN number printed on the receipt
- Restaurant adds GST to prices already listed as inclusive
- Bill has a handwritten GST line rather than a printed tax calculation
- Ask for a proper GST invoice with the GSTIN number
- Verify the GSTIN on the government portal (gst.gov.in)

■ How to Avoid

- Ask for a proper GST invoice with the GSTIN number
 - Verify the GSTIN on the government portal (gst.gov.in)
 - If a business charges GST without displaying their registration, the charge may not be legitimate
 - Small eateries and street food vendors are exempt from GST
-

The Milk Powder Beggar Scam

She points to a specific shop nearby. Moved by the baby, you enter the shop and buy a 500-rupee tin of milk powder. After you leave, the woman returns the milk powder to the shopkeeper, they split the 500 rupees, and she goes back to the bridge to find the next tourist. The same baby, the same shop, the same routine, all day long. This scam is reported across India but is particularly prevalent in Rishikesh due to the high concentration of sympathetic spiritual tourists.

■ Red Flags

- A woman with a child approaches specifically asking you to buy milk from a particular shop
- She refuses cash and insists on being taken to a specific store rather than any nearby shop
- The milk powder at the suggested shop is priced significantly higher than at other stores
- The same woman and child are seen repeating the approach with other tourists
- The shopkeeper and the woman interact as though they know each other

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline and walk away — your compassion is being exploited by an organized operation
 - If you genuinely want to help, donate to established charities like Parmarth Niketan ashram's social programs
 - Never buy anything from a specific shop that a street beggar directs you to — it is always a kickback arrangement
 - Carry small denomination notes if you wish to give directly to people in need
 - Report persistent begging scams to the Rishikesh tourist police station near Triveni Ghat
-

The Rafting Operator Safety Scam

The price seems great. On the morning of the trip, you are handed a torn life jacket with no buckles and loaded into a raft with twelve other people plus a guide who looks like a teenager. There is no safety briefing, no helmet, and no rescue kayaker following. Legitimate operators charge 1,500 to 2,500 rupees and limit group sizes to 8 with certified guides. Multiple drowning incidents have been linked to unlicensed operators cutting corners on safety to undercut prices.

■ Red Flags

- The price is significantly lower than 1,500 rupees for the standard Shivpuri to Lakshman Jhula stretch
- The booking agent cannot show a license from the Uttarakhand Tourism Department
- Life jackets are worn, damaged, or missing buckles and straps
- No safety briefing is conducted before entering the water
- The group size exceeds 8 people per raft or there is no safety kayaker following the raft

■ How to Avoid

- Book with UTDB-licensed operators like Red Chilli Adventure, Jumpin Heights, or Camp Ganga Riviera
 - Ask to see the operator's license from the Uttarakhand Tourism Development Board before paying
 - Inspect the life jacket before getting in — it must have working buckles and fit snugly
 - Refuse to raft without a proper safety briefing covering paddle commands and what to do if you fall out
 - Pay the full price for a reputable operator — the cost difference is not worth risking your life
-

The Spiritual Healer Fee Trap

You are sitting at a riverside cafe when a man in saffron robes approaches and says he can sense spiritual blockages in your aura. He offers a free blessing. You accept. He performs a brief ceremony, whispers mantras, ties a red thread on your wrist, and then asks for a donation of 5,000 rupees for the temple. When you hesitate, he says the blessing will turn into a curse if the offering is not completed. Similar encounters happen at the ghats where self-appointed priests perform unsolicited pujas and demand large donations afterward.

■ Red Flags

- A stranger claims to sense your spiritual state and offers unsolicited spiritual services
- The service is described as free but a specific donation amount is demanded afterward
- The person uses fear of curses or bad karma to pressure you into paying
- They operate alone outside an ashram rather than within an established spiritual institution
- The requested donation is far above what ashrams charge for legitimate pujas — typically 100 to 500 rupees

■ How to Avoid

- Never accept unsolicited spiritual services from strangers on the street or at ghats
 - If you want a puja ceremony, visit an established ashram like Parmarth Niketan where donations are voluntary
 - A genuine spiritual teacher will never threaten you with curses for not paying
 - Legitimate ghat ceremonies during Ganga Aarti are free to attend and donations are voluntary at 50 to 200 rupees
 - Simply say 'no thank you' and walk away — do not engage in conversation
-

The Street Approach Commission Scam

■ ■ *Laxman Jhula bridge area, Tapovan main road near cafes, Ram Jhula crossing area, and streets near Triveni Ghat* You are walking near Laxman Jhula after dinner when two men approach and start a friendly conversation. They claim to be yoga teachers or spiritual guides and invite you to visit their ashram or shop. If you follow, you end up in a high-pressure sales situation for expensive yoga courses, gemstones, or healing sessions. A Reddit user posted a warning about Rishikesh on r/TravelInIndia describing two men who approached after dinner near Tapovan with exactly this approach. They are commission agents who earn a percentage of whatever you spend at the establishments they bring you to. The

friendliness is calculated -- they target solo travelers and couples who appear new to India. Red Flags Strangers approach you on the street and initiate conversation about yoga, spirituality, or your travel plans They claim to be yoga teachers but cannot name the specific ashram or school they teach at They suggest visiting a specific shop, ashram, or healer that they personally recommend The conversation quickly shifts from friendly chat to specific commercial suggestions They become persistent or follow you when you try to end the conversation How to Avoid Do not engage with strangers who approach you on the street with unsolicited recommendations Research and book yoga courses and ashrams independently through established platforms before arriving If interested in yoga, choose ashrams registered with Yoga Alliance and verified through multiple review platforms Walk with purpose and do not stop for unsolicited conversations, especially after dark If someone follows you persistently, walk into a restaurant or shop and ask staff for help ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in India ■■

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■ Red Flags

- Strangers approach you on the street and initiate conversation about yoga, spirituality, or your travel plans
- They claim to be yoga teachers but cannot name the specific ashram or school they teach at
- They suggest visiting a specific shop, ashram, or healer that they personally recommend
- The conversation quickly shifts from friendly chat to specific commercial suggestions
- They become persistent or follow you when you try to end the conversation

■ How to Avoid

- Do not engage with strangers who approach you on the street with unsolicited recommendations
- Research and book yoga courses and ashrams independently through established platforms before arriving
- If interested in yoga, choose ashrams registered with Yoga Alliance and verified through multiple review platforms
- Walk with purpose and do not stop for unsolicited conversations, especially after dark
- If someone follows you persistently, walk into a restaurant or shop and ask staff for help

■■ Udaipur

6 scams documented • India

The Lake Palace Boat Photography Scam

Beautiful, right? Mid-ride, he positions the boat perfectly in front of the Taj Lake Palace and pulls out a camera: 'Special photo, only ■500!' Before you can decline, he's taken 20 shots. Now he wants ■500 per photo. The prints are poor quality, and you could have taken better shots on your phone.

■ Red Flags

- Boat ride is suspiciously cheap
- Boatman produces a camera mid-ride
- Photos are taken without clear price agreement
- Price per photo revealed only after shooting

- Agree on the total price for the boat ride including any extras before departing

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on the total price for the boat ride including any extras before departing
 - Decline photo services — your phone captures the same views
 - Book through your hotel for transparent pricing
 - Fair boat ride price: ■400-800 per hour depending on boat size
-

The Miniature Painting Workshop

the brushwork is genuinely impressive. After 20 minutes of conversation and chai, comes the sales pitch: paintings at ■5,000-50,000. The work you watched was real, but what they sell you is often a factory reproduction. Genuine miniature paintings by trained artists start at ■10,000-15,000 and take days, not minutes.

■ Red Flags

- Painting demonstration happens in a commercial shop, not a studio
- Multiple 'unique' paintings of the same subject available
- Aggressive discounting — 'special price for you'
- Artist completes intricate work suspiciously fast
- Buy from government-certified art cooperatives or Shilpgram craft village

■ How to Avoid

- Buy from government-certified art cooperatives or Shilpgram craft village
 - Genuine miniature painters are associated with the Rajasthan School of Art
 - If you want authentic miniatures, visit Bhartiya Lok Kala Mandal museum and their affiliated artists
 - Enjoy the demonstration but don't feel obligated to buy
-

The Auto-Rickshaw Hotel Commission Diversion

The driver tells you your hotel is closed, flooded, burned down, or has terrible reviews. He suggests a better place that his cousin runs. You reluctantly agree and end up at a mediocre hotel paying double the rate. Your original guesthouse was perfectly fine. The driver earns a commission of 30 to 50 percent of your first night's stay.

■ Red Flags

- The driver claims your hotel is closed or has a problem before you arrive to verify yourself
- He has an alternative hotel ready to suggest immediately
- He becomes insistent or takes detours rather than driving to your booked accommodation
- The replacement hotel is notably more expensive than what you booked
- The driver offers to wait outside the suggested hotel while you check in

■ How to Avoid

- Insist firmly on being taken to your pre-booked accommodation and refuse any detours
 - Call your hotel before arriving to confirm your reservation and get directions for the driver
 - Use Ola or Uber apps for transparent routes and pricing when available
 - If the driver insists your hotel is closed, have the hotel's phone number ready to call on the spot
 - Book accommodation that offers a free pickup from the station to eliminate this issue entirely
-

The Fake Cashmere Pashmina Scam

He walks you to a shop filled with shawls and paintings. He holds up a scarf and tells you it is pure pashmina cashmere from Kashmir worth 5,000 rupees as a special price for you. The scarf is actually synthetic polyester worth 200 rupees. Udaipur shops near tourist sites routinely sell factory-made goods as handmade Rajasthani crafts at massive markups.

■ Red Flags

- A tout approaches you on the street with a story about an art exhibition or special event
- The shop has no visible price tags and the seller names prices verbally
- The seller claims items are handmade or pure cashmere but cannot provide certification
- You are offered chai while browsing, creating social pressure to buy
- The initial price drops by 70 percent or more during bargaining suggesting the start price was absurd

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow touts to shops as they earn commission on your purchases
 - Test fabric authenticity by rubbing it between your fingers as real pashmina is incredibly soft and thin
 - Buy textiles from government emporiums like Rajasthali which sell certified handicrafts at fixed prices
 - If you want to shop in local markets, research fair prices online first and bargain to 30 to 40 percent of the asking price
 - Visit shops recommended by Lonely Planet or TripAdvisor reviews rather than following street touts
-

The Boat Ride Bait-and-Switch

Fifteen minutes into the ride the boatman stops and says the ride to Jag Mandir island costs extra. Then the sunset view costs extra. Then he asks for a tip on top of the inflated total. What started as 300 rupees becomes 1,500. There are no fixed regulated prices for private boat rides on Lake Pichola, which gives boatmen room to escalate once you are on the water.

■ Red Flags

- The initial quoted price seems too good for the promised duration and route
- The boatman adds surcharges for specific stops or views once you are already on the water
- He claims the original agreement did not include the island or the sunset
- Other boats nearby appear to be charging different rates for the same route
- The boatman asks for a tip on top of a price that has already been inflated

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on the complete route and all stops before boarding and confirm the total price covers everything
 - Use the government-run boat service from Rameshwar Ghat which has fixed published rates
 - Book through your hotel which can arrange a boatman at a fair pre-negotiated price
 - Confirm whether the price is per person or for the whole boat before agreeing
 - Carry the exact amount agreed upon so there is no room for additional demands at the end
-

The Gangaur Ghat Timeshare Ambush

■ ■ Gangaur Ghat lakefront area, Lake Pichola promenade, Lal Ghat neighborhood You are walking along Gangaur Ghat admiring the lake views when a smartly dressed Indian man ... You are walking along Gangaur Ghat admiring the lake views when a smartly dressed Indian man strikes up a friendly conversation. He says he works for a 'prestigious country club' and invites you to a free lunch or drinks at a nearby hotel to learn about a special membership. Once there, you endure a two-hour high-pressure timeshare presentation. If you sign anything, getting out of the contract is extremely difficult. A Reddit user on r/udaipur described this: 'At best this was not a scam and just very scummy marketing practices for timeshare country club nonsense.' The practice mirrors international timeshare schemes but targets tourists in India. Red Flags A well-dressed stranger engages you in conversation near a tourist site and steers toward a business proposition You are offered free food, drinks, or gifts in exchange for attending a 'brief presentation' The presentation takes place at a hotel or resort and involves membership, investment, or vacation package purchases High-pressure sales tactics include

time-limited offers, discounts that expire 'today only,' and multiple closers rotating through They ask for credit card details or a deposit before you have had time to think or research How to Avoid Decline any invitation from strangers that involves free meals or presentations — there is always a sales pitch attached If you accidentally attend a timeshare presentation, never sign anything or provide credit card information on the spot Research any 'country club' or 'resort membership' name online before engaging further Know that Indian consumer protection laws allow a cooling-off period for timeshare contracts — but prevention is far easier than cancellation Keep walking and politely decline — a firm 'No thank you, I'm not interested' repeated once or twice usually ends the interaction ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in India ■■

You are walking along Gangaur Ghat admiring the lake views when a smartly dressed Indian man strikes up a friendly conversation. He says he works for a 'prestigious country club' and invites you to a free lunch or drinks at a nearby hotel to learn about a special membership. Once there, you endure a two-hour high-pressure timeshare presentation. If you sign anything, getting out of the contract is extremely difficult. A Reddit user on r/udaipur described this: 'At best this was not a scam and just very scummy marketing practices for timeshare country club nonsense.' The practice mirrors int...

■ Red Flags

- A well-dressed stranger engages you in conversation near a tourist site and steers toward a business proposition
- You are offered free food, drinks, or gifts in exchange for attending a 'brief presentation'
- The presentation takes place at a hotel or resort and involves membership, investment, or vacation package purchases
- High-pressure sales tactics include time-limited offers, discounts that expire 'today only,' and multiple closers rotating through
- They ask for credit card details or a deposit before you have had time to think or research

■ How to Avoid

- Decline any invitation from strangers that involves free meals or presentations — there is always a sales pitch attached
- If you accidentally attend a timeshare presentation, never sign anything or provide credit card information on the spot
- Research any 'country club' or 'resort membership' name online before engaging further
- Know that Indian consumer protection laws allow a cooling-off period for timeshare contracts — but prevention is far easier than cancellation
- Keep walking and politely decline — a firm 'No thank you, I'm not interested' repeated once or twice usually ends the interaction

■■ Varanasi

7 scams documented • India

The Ganga Offering Shake-Down

You're watching the evening Ganga Aarti ceremony when a man in priestly garb places a flower offering and a small oil lamp on your lap. Before you can react, he pushes it toward the river and says a prayer. Then he demands ■2,000-5,000 for the 'ceremony' he just performed. If you haven't agreed to a price upfront, you're stuck in an awkward negotiation at a sacred site with crowds watching.

■ Red Flags

- Items placed in your hands without asking

- No price discussion before the ceremony
- Priestly dress but no affiliation with the main ghat temples
- Emotional pressure using religious significance
- Never accept items placed in your hands without asking the price first

■ How to Avoid

- Never accept items placed in your hands without asking the price first
 - The Ganga Aarti at Dashashwamedh Ghat is free to watch from the steps
 - If you want to do an offering, negotiate the price clearly beforehand (■100-200 is fair)
 - Politely say 'Nahi chahiye' (I don't want it) and keep your hands at your sides
-

The Boat Ride Price Inflation

Sounds great. Halfway through, he announces the 'sunrise viewing fee' is extra, stopping at the burning ghat costs more, and returning to your original ghat has a surcharge. Your ■100 ride becomes ■1,500. If you refuse, he threatens to leave you at a ghat far from your hotel.

■ Red Flags

- Very low initial quoted price
- No written agreement on what's included
- Extra charges announced mid-ride
- Agree on exact price, duration, stops, and return point before boarding
- ■300-500 per hour is the fair rate for a private boat

■ How to Avoid

- Agree on exact price, duration, stops, and return point before boarding
 - ■300-500 per hour is the fair rate for a private boat
 - Book through your hotel or a verified agency
 - Have the boatman confirm the total price — ideally written down
-

The Silk Shop Detour

The shortcut happens to pass directly through his family's silk shop. Inside, you're served chai and shown 'authentic Banarasi silk' at 'special prices.' The chai is genuinely good, but the silk is often machine-made polyester sold at 10x its value. Saying no after accepting hospitality feels rude — which is exactly the plan.

■ Red Flags

- Unsolicited guide through narrow lanes
- Route conveniently passes through a shop
- Free chai and excessive hospitality
- Claims of 'government-certified' silk with no verifiable proof
- Navigate using Google Maps — don't accept shortcuts from strangers

■ How to Avoid

- Navigate using Google Maps — don't accept shortcuts from strangers
 - Authentic Banarasi silk has a specific weave pattern and feel — research before buying
 - It's perfectly fine to drink the chai and leave without buying
 - Buy silk from government emporiums like UP Handloom for guaranteed quality
-

The Fake Priest Blessing Scam

You are walking along the ghats when a man in orange robes approaches and places a tilak on your forehead while chanting. He then asks for your parents' names and blesses them individually. The ritual feels authentic and meaningful. Then he asks for a donation. When you offer 50 rupees he becomes angry and demands 2,000 to 5,000 rupees, claiming you insulted his blessing. He follows you aggressively until you pay. Self-appointed priests at the ghats are not associated with any temple and perform this routine dozens of times daily.

■ Red Flags

- A priest approaches you unprompted and begins a ritual without being asked
- He applies tilak or ties a thread on your wrist before discussing any payment
- He asks for personal information like family names to make the blessing seem personalized
- The suggested donation escalates dramatically from a reasonable amount to thousands of rupees
- He follows you aggressively if you attempt to walk away without paying

■ How to Avoid

- Politely but firmly decline any unsolicited blessings or rituals at the ghats
 - Do not allow anyone to put anything on your forehead or wrist without your explicit agreement
 - If you want a genuine puja ceremony, arrange one through your hotel or a recognized temple priest
 - Walk away firmly if a self-appointed priest demands money and do not engage in negotiation
 - The legitimate Ganga Aarti ceremony at Dashashwamedh Ghat is free to watch and does not require individual donations to priests
-

The Burning Ghat Photography Extortion

A young man stops you and says he works for the cremation families. He offers to explain the rituals and guide you respectfully. He walks you close to the cremation platforms. Then he says photography is forbidden and if you have taken any photos you must pay a fine of 5,000 rupees or delete them. He demands a large donation for the wood used in cremations. While photography near active cremations is indeed inappropriate, the fine and wood donation demands are a scam run by unauthorized touts.

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you before Manikarnika Ghat offering to be your guide
- The guide takes you very close to active cremations then suddenly claims you have violated rules
- He demands a specific large sum for a wood donation or photography fine
- The guide claims to work for the Dom families who manage the cremation ground
- He becomes threatening or aggressive if you try to walk away without paying

■ How to Avoid

- Do not photograph active cremations out of respect, but know that there is no official fine for photography
 - Decline unsolicited guides at the cremation ghats and observe respectfully from a distance
 - If you want to understand the cremation rituals, ask your hotel to recommend a legitimate guide
 - Any claims about donations for cremation wood being mandatory are false
 - Walk away firmly from anyone demanding money and head toward crowded areas if you feel threatened
-

The Auto-Rickshaw Meter Refusal and Hotel Diversion

He drives for ten minutes then says your hotel is in a restricted zone and autos cannot enter. He drops you at a crossroads and a man appears saying he knows a better hotel nearby. The restricted zone claim is real for some narrow ghat areas, but the alternative hotel suggestion is a commission-based diversion. Your original hotel likely has a known drop-off point the driver should use.

■ Red Flags

- The driver claims your hotel is in a restricted zone and he cannot reach it
- A tout conveniently appears at the drop-off point suggesting an alternative hotel
- The driver refuses to call your hotel or follow GPS directions
- The driver chose an unusual drop-off point rather than the commonly used access point for your ghat area
- The suggested replacement hotel is significantly more expensive than what you booked

■ How to Avoid

- Contact your hotel before arrival and ask for the exact drop-off point and directions for rickshaw drivers
- Use Ola or Uber apps when available for GPS-tracked transparent routing
- If the driver cannot reach your hotel entrance, he should drop you at the recognized access point for that ghat area
- Have your hotel's phone number ready so you can call them to confirm directions if the driver claims access issues
- Book accommodation that offers airport or station pickup to avoid this situation entirely

The Blue Lassi Shop Tourist Markup

■ ■ *Blue Lassi shop near Kashi Vishwanath Temple, Ram Bhandar sweet shop, Dashashwamedh Ghat food stalls* You visit the famous Blue Lassi shop near Kashi Vishwanath Temple, drawn by its legendary status on travel blogs. The shop is packed with tourists. You order a special lassi — the price is three to five times what locals pay at identical lassi shops on the same street. The lassi itself is good, but the experience is more about Instagram than value. Reddit users on r/varanasi called 'Blue Lassi the biggest scam, followed by Ram Bhandar' — both iconic Varanasi eateries that have leveraged their fame to charge tourist premiums. While the food quality may be acceptable, the prices do not reflect local market rates. **Red Flags** The shop is packed exclusively with tourists while nearby shops serving similar products are empty Prices are not displayed or are written only in English at inflated rates Staff aggressively encourage larger and more expensive orders The same product is available at half the price from neighboring shops Blog posts and influencer recommendations create artificial demand despite ordinary quality **How to Avoid** Explore beyond the most-photographed shops — excellent lassi and sweets are available throughout Varanasi at fraction of the tourist price Ask locals where they eat rather than following tourist blogs — authentic street food experiences are better and cheaper Compare prices at two or three shops before ordering to understand the local market rate Be aware that fame does not equal quality — many hyped Varanasi food spots trade on reputation rather than taste For the burning ghat experience, walk independently and firmly decline all approaches from 'guides' who will lead you into donation scams ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Indian Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at citizenservices.gov.in. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in New Delhi is at Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021. For emergencies: +91 11-2419-8000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in India** ■ ■

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■ Red Flags

- The shop is packed exclusively with tourists while nearby shops serving similar products are empty
- Prices are not displayed or are written only in English at inflated rates
- Staff aggressively encourage larger and more expensive orders
- The same product is available at half the price from neighboring shops
- Blog posts and influencer recommendations create artificial demand despite ordinary quality

■ How to Avoid

- Explore beyond the most-photographed shops — excellent lassi and sweets are available throughout Varanasi at fraction of the tourist price
 - Ask locals where they eat rather than following tourist blogs — authentic street food experiences are better and cheaper
 - Compare prices at two or three shops before ordering to understand the local market rate
 - Be aware that fame does not equal quality — many hyped Varanasi food spots trade on reputation rather than taste
 - For the burning ghat experience, walk independently and firmly decline all approaches from 'guides' who will lead you into donation scams
-

■ Maldives

■ ■ Maldives

6 scams documented • Maldives

Liveaboard Cruise Booking Fraud

The Maldives Independent reported that dozens of tourists are stranded each year in the Maldives by liveaboard booking scams, with the problem harming the country's international reputation. Scammers create fraudulent websites that copy legitimate liveaboard operators, collect full payment (\$2,000-8,000 per person for a week-long cruise), and then disappear. At least 88 Russian and German tourists were stranded in November 2013 after a single scam operation. The Minivan News archive documented how a Hong Kong-based tour operator reported that Poseidon Tours stranded several guests 'desperat...

■ Red Flags

- The website offers liveaboard cruises at 30-50% below prices listed on established platforms like LiveAboard.com or Dive The World
- Payment is requested via bank wire transfer rather than credit card through a secure booking platform
- The website has no verifiable physical address in the Maldives, no local phone number, or only a WhatsApp contact
- Reviews on the website itself are glowing, but the operator has no TripAdvisor, Google, or Trustpilot presence
- The operator pressures you to book immediately with a 'limited availability' or 'flash sale' urgency

■ How to Avoid

- Book liveaboards only through established aggregators like LiveAboard.com, PADI Travel, or Dive The World that vet operators and offer booking protection
 - Verify the operator is registered with the Maldives Ministry of Tourism at tourism.gov.mv before paying any deposit
 - Pay by credit card for chargeback protection; never wire funds or use cryptocurrency for travel bookings
 - Cross-reference the boat name and photos across multiple independent review sites to confirm the vessel exists and matches descriptions
 - Contact the boat operator directly using phone numbers found independently (not from the booking site) to confirm your reservation exists
-

Resort Transfer Price Shock

TripAdvisor's Maldives forum features an extensive thread titled 'Don't want to pay high transfer fees' where travelers express shock at transfer costs that were not clearly communicated before booking. Seaplane transfers range from \$290 to \$700 per person roundtrip, with some luxury resorts charging up to \$900. A separate thread titled 'Question re: Seaplanes - Scam?' captures the confusion many first-time visitors feel

when quoted \$1,000+ for a couple's roundtrip transfer on top of already expensive resort rates. The Points Guy's comprehensive guide to Maldives resort transfer fees docume...

■ Red Flags

- The resort's headline nightly rate does not mention transfer costs, taxes, or service charges anywhere on the booking page
- The booking confirmation says 'transfer cost to be confirmed' rather than providing a fixed price
- Your international flight arrives after 3:30 PM and the resort has not mentioned a mandatory overnight in Male
- The resort is on a distant atoll requiring a seaplane but the total price seems comparable to resorts near Male accessible by speedboat
- The 'all-inclusive' package does not specify whether transfers, excursions, and taxes are included

■ How to Avoid

- Before booking any resort, email them directly asking for the total cost including transfers, taxes (16% VAT + 10% service charge), Green Tax, and any mandatory meal plans
 - Choose resorts in North or South Male Atoll for speedboat transfers (\$100-250 roundtrip) instead of distant atolls requiring seaplanes (\$400-900 roundtrip)
 - Book international flights arriving before 2 PM to avoid the mandatory overnight in Male; seaplanes do not fly after sunset
 - Compare total costs (room + transfer + taxes) rather than nightly rates; a cheaper-per-night distant resort can cost more overall than a pricier nearby one
 - Consider guesthouses on local islands (Maafushi, Thulusdhoo) where speedboat transfers from Male cost \$25-40 per person
-

Excursion and Watersport Upselling

The Before You Go Travels 2026 Maldives guide documents aggressive upselling at both resorts and local island guesthouses. Guesthouses on popular local islands like Maafushi and Dhigurah quote snorkeling, dolphin watching, and sandbank excursions at prices significantly above what independent boat operators on the same island charge. A dolphin cruise quoted at \$80 per person through a guesthouse can be booked directly with boat captains at the harbor for \$30-40. The GoDigit Maldives scam guide reveals hidden fee structures on excursions: some trips include surprise charges for life jacket r...

■ Red Flags

- The guesthouse or resort insists their excursion is the only option and discourages you from booking independently
- The excursion price does not include equipment rental, insurance, or other fees that are added at the dock
- A 'free' snorkeling trip requires mandatory purchases of photos, videos, or equipment at inflated prices
- The resort's 'all-inclusive' rate excludes premium drinks, specific restaurants, water sports, and spa services
- There is no written confirmation of what the excursion price includes before you pay

■ How to Avoid

- On local islands, walk to the harbor and negotiate directly with boat captains for excursions; prices are typically 40-60% of guesthouse quotes
 - Get a written breakdown of all excursion inclusions (equipment, fuel, lunch, snacks) before paying, and confirm there are no surprise fees
 - For resort stays, request a detailed menu of all-inclusive inclusions before booking to understand exactly what is and is not covered
 - Book excursions through TripAdvisor or GetYourGuide with reviews that confirm the total price and what is included
 - Bring your own snorkel gear and reef-safe sunscreen to avoid inflated equipment rental charges
-

Guesthouse Bait-and-Switch Accommodation

FRAUD TOUR OPERATOR IN MALDIVES' about UI Maldives in Hulhumale, where a traveler arrived to find their pre-paid booking did not exist. The Before You Go Travels guide confirms this as a systematic pattern: fraudulent operators create attractive listings on booking platforms, collect full payment, then either provide a drastically inferior room or have no room at all. The Never Ending Footsteps blog published a detailed account titled 'Scammed in Guraidhoo' describing a guesthouse owner who advertised beachfront rooms with ocean views but provided a windowless room with mold-covered walls, ...

■ Red Flags

- The guesthouse price is significantly below other properties in the same area and category on Booking.com
- The host insists on direct bank transfer rather than booking through Booking.com, Airbnb, or Agoda with platform protection
- Photos show a luxury beachfront property but the location is on a local island where such properties do not exist
- The agent or host has few verified reviews, or reviews appear generic and posted within a short time period
- Communication becomes slow or stops after payment is made

■ How to Avoid

- Book only through major platforms (Booking.com, Agoda, Airbnb) that offer verified listings and refund protection
- Cross-reference the guesthouse address on Google Maps to verify it exists and matches the listed island and location
- Read TripAdvisor reviews specifically checking for bait-and-switch complaints; filter for recent 1-star reviews mentioning different rooms than advertised
- Pay by credit card for chargeback protection and never send money via wire transfer or Western Union
- Confirm your booking directly with the guesthouse via email or phone before arrival, using contact info found independently

Taxi and Transport Overcharging in Male

The GoDigit Maldives tourist scam guide documents that taxi drivers in Male purposely do not turn on meters and overcharge travelers, driving longer routes to inflate fares for a city that is only 5.8 km long. The before-arrival cost of a taxi from the airport to Male ferry terminal should be 25-30 MVR (\$1.60-2), but tourists regularly report being charged 100-200 MVR (\$6.50-13). The Wiki For Travel Maldives guide describes a group scam variant: at bars or restaurants in Hulhumale, groups of locals approach tourists, order food and drinks, and later pressure the tourist to pay for everyone....

■ Red Flags

- The taxi driver claims the meter is broken or suggests a flat rate significantly above 30 MVR for a Male city center trip
- A speedboat operator at the harbor dismisses the public ferry as unsafe and insists you must take their private boat
- A group of friendly locals at a bar wants you to join them and insists on ordering for the table
- The driver takes a circuitous route through Male's narrow streets rather than the direct coastal road
- Transport costs are only quoted verbally with no written receipt or confirmation

■ How to Avoid

- Insist on the meter for all Male taxi rides; the starting fare is 25 MVR plus per-kilometer charges
- Use the airport taxi counter where fixed-rate tickets are sold for standard destinations rather than negotiating with individual drivers
- Take the public ferry between Male and Hulhumale or the airport island (\$1-2); departures are frequent and safe
- For inter-island speedboats, check MTCC (Maldives Transport) public ferry schedules at mtcc.com.mv before accepting private boat quotes
- Never split bills with strangers at restaurants; politely decline invitations from people you just met to join their table

The Food Bank Dual Menu Scam

■ ■ *Food Bank restaurant in Male, restaurants near the Male ferry terminal* You walk into Food Bank, a popular restaurant near the Male ferry terminal, and receive an ... You walk into Food Bank, a popular restaurant near the Male ferry terminal, and receive an English-language menu with prices that are two to three times higher than the Dhivehi menu given to locals at the next table. The same chicken biryani is 120 MVR on your menu and 45 MVR on theirs. A Reddit user on r/maldives called Food Bank out by name as a tourist trap that has been operating dual menus for over fifteen years. The practice is not illegal in the Maldives, but it is deliberately deceptive. Other restaurants near the ferry terminal run similar schemes targeting the captive audience of tourists waiting for resort transfers. *Red Flags* Prices on the English menu seem high compared to what you have paid at similar local restaurants You notice locals receiving different menus or being quoted different prices The restaurant is positioned near the airport ferry terminal where tourists wait Menu items are identical on both versions but with dramatically different prices Staff seat tourists in a different section from local diners *How to Avoid* Ask to see the local menu — some restaurants will show it if asked directly Use Google Maps reviews to check for dual pricing complaints before dining Eat at restaurants recommended by your guesthouse rather than ones near the ferry terminal Compare prices with delivery apps like FoodPanda which show a single price for everyone If transferring to a resort, eat at the airport hotel restaurant where prices are standardized ■ *What to Do If You Get Scammed* ■ *File a Police Report* Go to the nearest Metropolitan Police station. Call 999 (emergency) or 101 (non-emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at met.police.uk. ■ *Cancel Your Cards* Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ *Lost Passport?* Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy is at 33 Nine Elms Lane, London SW11 7US. For emergencies: +44 20 7499 9000. ■ *Track Your Device* If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. *More Scam Guides Popular Nearby Destinations* ■ ■

You walk into Food Bank, a popular restaurant near the Male ferry terminal, and receive an English-language menu with prices that are two to three times higher than the Dhivehi menu given to locals at the next table. The same chicken biryani is 120 MVR on your menu and 45 MVR on theirs. A Reddit user on r/maldives called Food Bank out by name as a tourist trap that has been operating dual menus for over fifteen years. The practice is not illegal in the Maldives, but it is deliberately deceptive. Other restaurants near the ferry terminal run similar schemes targeting the captive audience of ...

■ Red Flags

- Prices on the English menu seem high compared to what you have paid at similar local restaurants
- You notice locals receiving different menus or being quoted different prices
- The restaurant is positioned near the airport ferry terminal where tourists wait
- Menu items are identical on both versions but with dramatically different prices
- Staff seat tourists in a different section from local diners

■ How to Avoid

- Ask to see the local menu — some restaurants will show it if asked directly
- Use Google Maps reviews to check for dual pricing complaints before dining
- Eat at restaurants recommended by your guesthouse rather than ones near the ferry terminal
- Compare prices with delivery apps like FoodPanda which show a single price for everyone
- If transferring to a resort, eat at the airport hotel restaurant where prices are standardized

■ Nepal

■ ■ Kathmandu

8 scams documented • Nepal

Art School Mandala Scam

You're wandering the dusty lanes of Thamel, camera around your neck, when a friendly young man falls into step beside you. He introduces himself as a student and says you're lucky — his art school just opened an exhibit nearby and he'd love to show you. 'Just looking, no obligation,' he says with a wide smile. You feel curious, so you follow him through a narrow side alley and into a small shop packed with painted mandalas and thangka scrolls. A woman immediately launches into a passionate explanation of each piece — the symbols, the months of hand-painting, the spiritual significance. The ...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger in Thamel 'coincidentally' wants to show you his art school for free
- Prices are quoted in US dollars, not Nepali rupees
- You're told today is a unique festival or special occasion
- The shop is tucked in an alley and not a regular storefront
- The guide lingers at the door while you browse, creating social pressure to buy

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline and keep walking — say 'namaste' and don't engage further
 - If you want to buy Nepali art, find shops yourself on Thamel's main streets
 - Research what 'festivals' are actually happening on any given day before your visit
 - Know the approximate price ranges for mandalas (decent ones start at 500–1500 NPR in regular shops)
 - Never let a stranger lead you to a 'friend's shop' — always go independently
-

Fake Festival Blessing Trap

'You are very lucky!' he says. 'Today is the only day of the year for the Annapurna festival. I want to take you to receive a special blessing — completely free!' He walks with you toward a small stupa you hadn't noticed before, explains the significance of each carving, and an older man at the entrance places a tika on your forehead and drapes a khata scarf around your neck. The 'tour' lasts about 20 minutes and feels genuinely cultural — until the moment it ends and the guide turns to you with open palms. The blessing, he explains, requires a donation. The amount isn't fixed. He might nam...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger claims today is a unique, once-a-year festival you've never heard of
- The 'guide' emphasizes the blessing is free before the tour begins
- You're walked to a small, obscure stupa rather than a famous temple
- An older man performs a ritual without explaining any costs
- Donation is requested only after the experience is complete

■ How to Avoid

- Search online for any supposed festival before agreeing to visit — if it doesn't appear in search results, it's likely invented
 - Never follow strangers to religious sites — research and visit independently
 - If you want temple experiences, hire a licensed guide through your hotel
 - Carry only small bills when sightseeing so any demanded payment stays modest
 - Politely say 'no thank you' and walk away — the fake urgency vanishes immediately
-

Fake Gem & Jewelry Export Scam

He's charming, knowledgeable, and seems to genuinely want to educate you about Nepali gemstones. Then comes the proposition: he has a surplus of high-quality gems — rubies, turquoise, lapis — that are worth double in your home country. If you buy them here and resell them back home, you'll make a 200% profit. He even offers to help you with the export paperwork. The gems turn out to be worthless glass or low-grade stones. The

export paperwork may be fraudulent. Some travelers have been stopped at immigration and faced serious trouble for attempting to export items they didn't realize were f...

■ Red Flags

- A shopkeeper proposes a 'too good to be true' resale profit scheme in your home country
- Gems or antiques are sold with promises of guaranteed value abroad
- The seller offers to handle 'export paperwork' for you
- Prices seem too low for supposedly high-value items
- You're asked to buy multiple pieces rather than a single souvenir

■ How to Avoid

- Never purchase gems or antiques with the intent to resell abroad based on a stranger's advice
 - Know that Nepal bans export of antiques over 100 years old without government certification
 - If buying genuine gems, use a certified gemologist or reputable store with verifiable reviews
 - Stick to mass-produced souvenirs you can clearly identify as modern crafts
 - Declare any significant purchases at customs to avoid problems at the border
-

Grocery Rice Bag Scam

He doesn't want money, he says — he just wants to chat. His English is good, he's curious about where you're from, and he walks alongside you pointing out interesting spots. After 20 minutes, you've relaxed your guard. Then he brings up his family — his children are sick, his wife hasn't eaten, and he doesn't want money, just a small kindness: some food from that shop over there. You agree, feeling generous. But when you enter the small grocery near the intersection, he starts picking items — a 25kg sack of rice at 1,000 rupees (market price: 200 rupees), 10 liters of cooking oil, powdered ...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger walks with you unprompted for an extended time, building rapport before asking anything
- They explicitly say 'I don't want your money' — this is a setup for the pivot
- The suggested shop is a specific backstreet location, not a regular supermarket
- Prices in the shop seem wildly inflated compared to normal
- The request is for large quantities of staple goods rather than a single small item

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline all offers from strangers who approach you on Thamel's streets
 - If genuinely wanting to help someone, donate to a verified local charity instead
 - Know that 1kg of rice costs roughly 80–100 NPR in Nepal — anything far above that is suspicious
 - Don't enter shops accompanied by someone you just met on the street
 - Use the Pathao app for price-check norms and stay aware of local costs before your trip
-

Unlicensed Trekking Agency Fraud

You've finally decided to do the Annapurna Circuit and you're shopping for a trekking company along Thamel's main street. The third shop you enter quotes a suspiciously low price — half the going rate — with a guide who speaks perfect English and a laminated certificate on the wall. You pay a deposit, get a printed itinerary, and go to sleep excited. On departure day, either the guide doesn't show, the agency number goes dead, or a totally unprepared, unlicensed person appears who has no idea what to do in an emergency. Unlicensed trekking guides and outright fraudulent agencies are a real ...

■ Red Flags

- Trekking package prices are significantly lower than competitors without clear explanation

- The agency has no online presence or reviews on TripAdvisor/Google
- Guide certificates can't be verified on the Nepal Tourism Board official website
- Pressure to pay the full amount upfront rather than a deposit
- Any suggestion from a 'guide' to fake an illness for helicopter insurance fraud

■ How to Avoid

- Verify trekking agencies on the Nepal Tourism Board website (ntb.gov.np) before booking
 - Ask for the guide's license number and check it independently
 - Book through internationally reviewed platforms like TripAdvisor or reputable travel blogs
 - Never pay more than 50% upfront — pay the balance after completing the trek
 - Absolutely refuse any suggestion involving false insurance claims — it's a serious crime
-

Taxi Overcharge & No-Meter Scam

One steps forward confidently and quotes you 1,500 rupees to Thamel — a price that sounds reasonable to someone who doesn't know that the metered fare should be around 700–800 NPR. You're tired, you agree, and you've just paid double without knowing it. Worse, some drivers will agree to use the meter, then tamper with it or 'forget' to start it until you're well underway. In the city itself, rickshaws near Durbar Square are a classic overcharge zone. Drivers quote foreigner prices that can be five to ten times the local rate, then become aggressive if you try to negotiate down. Some will st...

■ Red Flags

- Driver quotes a price in USD rather than Nepali rupees
- Meter is 'broken' or driver refuses to turn it on
- Price is negotiated verbally without being confirmed in writing
- Driver takes noticeably longer routes or circles around before reaching your destination
- The driver didn't come from an official taxi stand or prepaid booth

■ How to Avoid

- Use the prepaid taxi counter inside the airport arrivals hall — fixed rates, receipts
 - Download the Pathao app before landing — it shows upfront fares like Uber
 - Agree on a price in Nepali rupees before entering any vehicle
 - Research current Thamel taxi rates online before your trip (currently ~700-800 NPR from airport)
 - Insist the meter runs from the moment you enter — if refused, find another cab
-

Volunteer/Orphanage Scam

For a fee of \$1,000–\$2,000, you'll spend two weeks teaching English at an orphanage or helping at a community school near Kathmandu. It seems meaningful and the photos on the website are heartbreaking. But when you arrive, something feels off — the children seem well-fed and not particularly disadvantaged, and the 'director' asks for more money for unexpected 'materials.' Nepal has become a hub for what's called 'voluntourism fraud.' As the r/Nepal community explains: 'Many such orphanages don't have actually orphans. They go to poor villages, pay the parents certain money to have their kid...

■ Red Flags

- Volunteer fees are paid upfront to a small organization with little verifiable history
- The program involves direct contact with children as a selling point
- The organization can't produce audited financials or third-party certifications
- Children seem coached or are presented as props in promotional materials
- The 'orphanage' director keeps asking for additional donations or fees

■ How to Avoid

- Research any volunteer organization through CCNN (Concerning Children Nepal) or similar watchdog groups
 - Avoid programs that place volunteers with children — legitimate programs rarely do this
 - Look for organizations affiliated with established international NGOs (UNICEF, Save the Children)
 - Ask for recent independent financial audits before paying any fees
 - Consider donating to verified organizations rather than paying for a volunteer 'experience'
-

The Tribhuvan Airport Fake Representative

■ ■ Tribhuvan International Airport arrivals hall You exit customs at Tribhuvan Airport and a man holding a clipboard with your hotel's logo ... You exit customs at Tribhuvan Airport and a man holding a clipboard with your hotel's logo approaches, offering to carry your bags and take you to a 'hotel shuttle.' He loads your luggage into an unmarked vehicle and drives you to a different hotel than the one you booked, claiming your original reservation was cancelled. The new hotel charges double the rate. Redditors on r/Nepal confirm that fake airport representatives are common at Tribhuvan, with some posing as hotel staff and others claiming to be from the tourism board. The real hotel shuttles display official identification and your booking confirmation number. Red Flags Person approaches inside arrivals before you reach the official taxi counter They know your name but cannot show your booking confirmation number The vehicle is unmarked with no hotel branding They claim your original hotel is 'full' or 'closed for renovation' They ask for payment upfront for the transfer How to Avoid Arrange airport pickup through your hotel before arriving — get the driver's name and phone number Ask any greeter to show your booking confirmation number before following them Use the official prepaid taxi counter inside the airport arrivals hall Call your hotel directly if someone claims your reservation was cancelled Download the hotel's contact details offline before flying ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Nepal Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 102 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at nepalpolice.gov.np. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Kathmandu is at Maharajgunj, Kathmandu. For emergencies: +977 1-423-4000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Nepal ■■

You exit customs at Tribhuvan Airport and a man holding a clipboard with your hotel's logo approaches, offering to carry your bags and take you to a 'hotel shuttle.' He loads your luggage into an unmarked vehicle and drives you to a different hotel than the one you booked, claiming your original reservation was cancelled. The new hotel charges double the rate. Redditors on r/Nepal confirm that fake airport representatives are common at Tribhuvan, with some posing as hotel staff and others claiming to be from the tourism board. The real hotel shuttles display official identification and your...

■ Red Flags

- Person approaches inside arrivals before you reach the official taxi counter
- They know your name but cannot show your booking confirmation number
- The vehicle is unmarked with no hotel branding
- They claim your original hotel is 'full' or 'closed for renovation'
- They ask for payment upfront for the transfer

■ How to Avoid

- Arrange airport pickup through your hotel before arriving — get the driver's name and phone number
 - Ask any greeter to show your booking confirmation number before following them
 - Use the official prepaid taxi counter inside the airport arrivals hall
 - Call your hotel directly if someone claims your reservation was cancelled
 - Download the hotel's contact details offline before flying
-

■■ Pokhara

The Milk Powder Beggar Scam

She seems genuinely distressed, so instead of cash, you offer to buy the milk yourself. She leads you to a nearby shop and points to the most expensive imported milk powder — around NPR 2,000-3,000. After you pay and leave, she returns the powder to the shopkeeper, who was in on it, and they split the refund. As r/nepal users frequently warn, this is one of Pokhara's most persistent scams, and the same women work the Lakeside area daily with the same routine.

■ Red Flags

- A woman with a child specifically asks for milk rather than money
- She insists on going to a particular shop rather than the nearest one
- She points to the most expensive brand of milk powder available
- The shopkeeper and the woman seem to know each other
- If you want to help, donate to established charities or NGOs in Pokhara

■ How to Avoid

- If you want to help, donate to established charities or NGOs in Pokhara
 - Politely decline and walk away — this is a known daily routine
 - If you do buy something, choose a modest item from a shop of your choosing
 - Don't feel guilty — the money does not go to feed children
-

The Unlicensed Trekking Agency

A hawker on the Lakeside strip offers an all-inclusive package for half the price of established agencies. The Instagram page looks legit, but there's no office address and payment is cash only. As r/travel users report, many of these operators lack Nepal Tourism Board authorization, use uninsured vehicles, and send untrained guides who may abandon you mid-trail. Some simply disappear with your money. In worst cases, guides have pressured trekkers into faking altitude sickness for helicopter evacuations, then filed fraudulent insurance claims — a scheme that has led to arrests across Nepal.

■ Red Flags

- Prices significantly below market rate for popular treks
- No physical office — just a hotel desk or street-side operation
- Cash-only payment with no official receipt or contract
- The operator has a flashy social media presence but no verifiable registration
- Only book through agencies registered with the Nepal Tourism Board (NTB)

■ How to Avoid

- Only book through agencies registered with the Nepal Tourism Board (NTB)
 - Ask to see the operator's NTB license and TIMS card before paying
 - Read recent reviews on TripAdvisor or Lonely Planet forums, not just Instagram
 - Pay by card or bank transfer with a paper trail, never cash on the street
 - Report suspicious operators to the NTB tourist helpline
-

The Helicopter Rescue Insurance Fraud

You're trekking the Annapurna Circuit from Pokhara when your guide suddenly insists you look unwell and need an emergency helicopter evacuation. He contacts a rescue service and within hours you're airlifted to a Pokhara hospital where doctors run unnecessary tests and keep you for days. Your travel insurance gets billed tens of thousands of dollars. As r/travel and international media have reported, Nepal police arrested 33 people

in 2026 in connection with a \$20 million fake rescue racket — guides, rescue companies, and hospital staff colluded to stage evacuations, forge medical reports, ...

■ Red Flags

- Your guide pressures you to accept a helicopter rescue when you feel fine
- The guide suggests you exaggerate symptoms for insurance purposes
- A budget agency offered you a suspiciously cheap or 'free' trek
- The hospital insists on extended stays and excessive testing
- Choose reputable, NTB-registered agencies with verified reviews

■ How to Avoid

- Choose reputable, NTB-registered agencies with verified reviews
 - Carry your own pulse oximeter and know the symptoms of altitude sickness
 - Never agree to exaggerate symptoms — it voids your insurance and is illegal
 - Contact your insurance provider directly before agreeing to any evacuation
 - Report any coercion to Nepal's Tourist Police immediately
-

The Lakeside Money Exchange Trick

You hand over your dollars and the changer counts out the rupees quickly, seemingly correct. But as r/nepal users explain, fast-hand counting tricks are standard here — bills get palmed, old invalid notes get mixed in, or the changer shortchanges you by folding bills to make a stack look thicker. By the time you recount back at your hotel, you're missing NPR 1,000-2,000. Street changers also give no receipts, which means you can't convert unused rupees back when you leave.

■ Red Flags

- An exchange rate significantly better than bank rates
- No receipt or official documentation provided
- The changer counts very quickly and discourages you from recounting
- The location is a small unregistered shop or a street-side stall
- Use banks or licensed exchange counters with posted rates and receipts

■ How to Avoid

- Use banks or licensed exchange counters with posted rates and receipts
 - Count your money carefully at the counter before walking away
 - Know the current official exchange rate before approaching any changer
 - Keep the receipt — you'll need it to convert unused rupees back to your currency
-

The Massage Parlor Upsell

maybe NPR 500 for a full-body Ayurvedic treatment. You go in and the session starts normally. But partway through, the masseuse begins adding 'premium' oils, 'special' techniques, and extra treatments you never asked for. The final bill hits NPR 3,000-5,000. As r/solotravel users describe, if you refuse to pay, the staff become hostile and the exits seem to get blocked. The coupons circulating on the street are designed to get you through the door, not to give you a deal.

■ Red Flags

- Flyers or coupons distributed on the street with heavy discounts
- No clear menu or price list displayed inside the parlor
- The masseuse adds services without asking your permission
- Staff become aggressive when you question the final bill

- Book massages through your hotel or guesthouse, not from street flyers

■ How to Avoid

- Book massages through your hotel or guesthouse, not from street flyers
 - Ask for a full price list before any service begins and confirm the total
 - Refuse any extras that weren't agreed upon from the start
 - Read recent reviews online — legitimate places have consistent feedback
-

The Taxi Meter Refusal

■ ■ Pokhara Airport, Lakeside, Prithvi Chowk bus stop You step out of Pokhara Airport or the bus station and approach a taxi. When you ask about the meter, the driver waves it off — 'Meter is broken, sir' — and quotes NPR 800-1,000 for a ride to Lakeside that should cost NPR 200-300. As r/nepal users confirm, almost every taxi at tourist arrival points in Pokhara refuses the meter. They target tired arrivals who don't know local prices. Some drivers also take deliberately long routes through town to justify the inflated fare, or insist on stopping at a 'friend's shop' along the way. Red Flags The driver claims the meter is broken or doesn't apply The quoted fare is much higher than what locals would pay The driver insists on a specific route or wants to stop along the way Multiple drivers at a rank all quote the same inflated price How to Avoid Ask your hotel or guesthouse to arrange airport pickup in advance Know approximate fares: Pokhara Airport to Lakeside is around NPR 200-300 Use ride-hailing apps like inDrive or Pathao when available Walk to the main road away from the terminal to find drivers willing to use the meter ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Nepal Police station. Call 100 (Police) or 102 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at nepalpolice.gov.np. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Kathmandu is at Maharajgunj, Kathmandu. For emergencies: +977 1-423-4000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Nepal ■ ■

When you ask about the meter, the driver waves it off — 'Meter is broken, sir' — and quotes NPR 800-1,000 for a ride to Lakeside that should cost NPR 200-300. As r/nepal users confirm, almost every taxi at tourist arrival points in Pokhara refuses the meter. They target tired arrivals who don't know local prices. Some drivers also take deliberately long routes through town to justify the inflated fare, or insist on stopping at a 'friend's shop' along the way.

■ Red Flags

- The driver claims the meter is broken or doesn't apply
- The quoted fare is much higher than what locals would pay
- The driver insists on a specific route or wants to stop along the way
- Multiple drivers at a rank all quote the same inflated price
- Ask your hotel or guesthouse to arrange airport pickup in advance

■ How to Avoid

- Ask your hotel or guesthouse to arrange airport pickup in advance
 - Know approximate fares: Pokhara Airport to Lakeside is around NPR 200-300
 - Use ride-hailing apps like inDrive or Pathao when available
 - Walk to the main road away from the terminal to find drivers willing to use the meter
-

■ Sri Lanka

■ ■ Colombo

Gemstone Shop Steering Scam

A well-dressed man catches your eye — he seems cultured, professional. He mentions he recognizes your nationality and starts chatting warmly about your country. Within minutes, he's guiding you toward a gem shop he says he knows personally. An empty tuk-tuk pulls up right alongside you, as if by coincidence. Inside the shop, you're shown blue sapphires, star rubies, padparadscha — Sri Lanka's famous gemstones, the stuff of legend. The stones are beautiful. The salesperson is charming. You buy a 'certified' piece for \$100 as a gift for your mom. It's only later, cross-checking on TripAdvisor...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger proactively befriends you and transitions the conversation toward shopping
- A tuk-tuk happens to appear conveniently at exactly the right moment
- The gem shop has no presence on Google Maps or TripAdvisor
- Certificates are offered for stones but from organizations you can't independently verify
- High-pressure sales tactics appear once you're inside — staff hover closely and prices fluctuate

■ How to Avoid

- Ignore any unsolicited offer to visit a gem shop from a street contact, regardless of how friendly
 - If you want to buy genuine gems, visit the National Gem and Jewellery Authority (NGJA) — the government body that certifies reputable dealers
 - Require a GIA or AGL certificate for any significant gemstone purchase — and verify the certificate number online
 - Research and book appointments at reputable dealers through your hotel concierge before arrival
 - Keep in mind: the steerer is paid commission — the 'friendly local' is a professional actor in this scenario
-

Tuk-Tuk Mafia Overcharging

Three drivers immediately cluster around you. You pick one, ask the price. He says 500 rupees. You get in. On arrival he demands 1,500 and refuses to budge. You didn't agree in writing. You're on a quiet street. You pay. Or worse: a friendly local on the street says he'll 'help you get a tuk-tuk' — he signals one over, they exchange a few words in Sinhala, and you get in. You assume the local negotiated for you. He ran away before you noticed, and the driver demands 10,000 rupees at the destination (roughly \$33 — but the real rate would be 500). A Redditor on r/srilanka described exactly th...

■ Red Flags

- Multiple drivers cluster around you before you've indicated you need one
- A 'helpful local' volunteers to negotiate a tuk-tuk on your behalf
- No price is agreed upon before getting in the vehicle
- The driver doesn't start a meter and deflects when you ask
- The fare quoted at destination is dramatically higher than what was stated at pickup

■ How to Avoid

- Use PickMe for all Colombo tuk-tuk rides — price and route are shown before you confirm
 - If using a street tuk-tuk, agree the price in rupees before getting in, confirm it's per person or per trip, and reconfirm it at arrival
 - Never accept a stranger's offer to 'help' you arrange transport — this is part of the scam setup
 - Order PickMe from a slightly different location from tourist attractions to avoid being seen by cartel drivers
 - If a driver demands much more than agreed, photograph their plate and license number — that alone often resolves disputes
-

Fake 'Free' Tourist Guide

He's knowledgeable, explains the Buddhist iconography, points out rare artifacts. He doesn't mention payment — he seems genuinely enthusiastic about sharing his culture. You relax. He walks you through the whole temple. It's actually wonderful. At the exit, the expectation becomes clear. He wants ¥2,000 to 3,000 LKR (roughly \$6–10), or sometimes significantly more. When you express surprise that there was a fee, he becomes aggressive or appeals to your guilt — he has a family, he's licensed, this is his job. Other times the fee is reasonable but was never disclosed, leaving a sour note on w...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger joins you at a site without introduction and begins explaining things without being asked
- They seem to position themselves between you and the natural flow of the attraction
- No mention of payment or credentials until the experience is complete
- They offer 'special access' or inside knowledge that official channels don't provide
- They become upset or guilted when you don't pay what they expect

■ How to Avoid

- Book licensed guides through the Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) official portal
 - Politely decline any unsolicited guide offer at the entrance of attractions — 'no thank you, I prefer to explore alone'
 - If you accept any guide service, agree the fee before beginning and ask to see their SLTDA license
 - Know that all major Colombo attractions have free information at entrance — English signage is generally good
 - If you want a proper Colombo city tour, your hotel concierge can arrange a licensed guide with clear pricing
-

Tuk-Tuk 'Tour Package' Trap

A tuk-tuk driver approaches you outside your hotel with an appealing offer: a city tour covering Gangaramaya Temple, the National Museum, Pettah Market, and Independence Square for a flat rate. He shows you a laminated picture book of all the spots. He seems professional. You agree on 3,000 LKR for the day. The tour starts fine. Then there's a 'traditional batik shop' stop. Then a spice market. Then a gem store. Then another shop. Each stop involves a subtle pitch from staff, and your driver waits outside collecting commission the whole time. The promised sights get rushed or cut entirely. ...

■ Red Flags

- Driver has a laminated photo book of 'must-see' places — this is a prop, not professionalism
- The price for an all-day city tour seems low (under 2,500 LKR for many stops)
- The itinerary includes 'local markets' or 'craft workshops' with no specific names
- Driver seems invested in you entering specific shops but not others
- You're rushed through genuine attractions but given plenty of time in shopping venues

■ How to Avoid

- Use PickMe for point-to-point travel and plan your own sightseeing itinerary
 - Book organized city tours through your hotel or a licensed agency where shopping stops are disclosed upfront
 - If a driver mentions shopping stops, explicitly say you're not interested in shopping — a legitimate guide will respect that
 - Research your own Colombo itinerary using r/SriLankaTravel recommendations — the city is very navigable
 - Agree on specific named destinations before starting any tuk-tuk tour, and add a 'no shopping stops' clause verbally
-

Currency Exchange Shortchange

You need to exchange some dollars and someone near your hotel or in Pettah points you to an unofficial money changer who offers a better rate than the bank. The man counts out a thick stack of rupees — it looks

right, he counts it quickly while talking to you, and hands it over. Later, counting carefully at your hotel, you're short by 5,000–10,000 LKR. The technique involves the classic 'distraction count' — counting notes quickly while asking you a question, palming a handful, then handing you a short stack. It's fast, confident, and hard to catch in the moment. Another variant involves a ...

■ Red Flags

- Someone proactively offers to take you to a 'better' money changer
- The exchange counter has no visible license or certificate
- The counter person counts money quickly while maintaining eye contact and conversation
- The stack of notes is handed to you before you've had a chance to recount
- The counter is in a back room, side street, or non-commercial setting

■ How to Avoid

- Use licensed exchange counters at Hatton National Bank, Commercial Bank, or Sampath Bank — widely available
 - Always count your money yourself, slowly, before leaving the counter — staff will wait
 - Use ATMs where possible — they dispense accurate amounts from your account
 - If using a hotel exchange desk, note that rates are slightly worse but transactions are honest
 - Never accept a recommendation from a stranger to a 'better rate' money changer
-

Overpriced Airport Transfer Touts

some official, some not. A man approaches claiming to work for your hotel and offers a transfer. He's confident, even mentions your booking details. You follow him to a car. The 'hotel representative' is unaffiliated — he simply hangs around arrivals to intercept tourists before they reach the official taxi rank. The ride to your Colombo hotel that should cost 3,000–4,000 LKR (using the official prepaid taxi counter) ends up costing you 8,000–12,000 LKR with a private driver who quotes in dollars. Alternatively, the airport's own official prepaid taxi service is right inside arrivals. You p...

■ Red Flags

- Someone holding a sign for your hotel approaches before you've reached the official pick-up area
- A transfer is offered verbally without any booking confirmation on their end
- The driver quotes the price in USD rather than LKR — always a bad sign
- The vehicle is parked in the general parking area rather than the official taxi rank
- No receipt or printed confirmation of the fare is provided before departure

■ How to Avoid

- Use the airport's official pre-paid taxi counter inside arrivals — fixed rate, fully licensed
 - Book a PickMe taxi from inside the terminal using the app — the price is fixed and the driver is verified
 - Arrange hotel transfers in advance with your accommodation — they'll send a legitimate driver with a sign
 - Ignore anyone who approaches you claiming to represent your hotel unless you've pre-arranged it
 - The Colombo city train (the CTB Express service from Katunayake) is also an option for the budget-conscious — takes 30–45 minutes to Fort station
-

The Supermarket Sob Story

■ ■ Near Cargills, Keells, and Arpico supermarkets in Colombo Fort and Pettah You are walking near a supermarket in central Colombo when a well-dressed man approaches with a ... You are walking near a supermarket in central Colombo when a well-dressed man approaches with a polite story -- his wallet was stolen, his child is sick, and he just needs someone to buy a bag of milk powder or rice so his family can eat tonight. He leads you into the supermarket and starts loading the basket with expensive items: baby formula, cooking oil, canned goods. The bill climbs to 5,000-10,000 rupees. After you pay and leave, he returns the items for a cash refund and splits the proceeds with the store clerk. R/srilanka users confirm this exact scam operates near supermarkets around Colombo and is repeated on tourists daily. Red Flags A

stranger approaches you specifically near a supermarket entrance The story involves a stolen wallet and a sick or hungry child They steer you into the store rather than asking for cash directly The shopping basket fills up with expensive staples very quickly The person seems overly familiar with the store layout and staff How to Avoid Politely decline and walk away -- genuine hardship cases approach local charities, not tourists If you want to help, offer to buy one small item yourself rather than handing them the basket Watch for the same person repeating the routine with different tourists Donate to established Sri Lankan charities instead of street solicitations Do not feel guilty for saying no -- this is a well-documented scam across Colombo ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Sri Lanka Police station. Call 119 (Police) or 110 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.lk. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Colombo is at 210 Galle Road, Colombo 03. For emergencies: +94 11-249-8500. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Sri Lanka ■■

You are walking near a supermarket in central Colombo when a well-dressed man approaches with a polite story -- his wallet was stolen, his child is sick, and he just needs someone to buy a bag of milk powder or rice so his family can eat tonight. He leads you into the supermarket and starts loading the basket with expensive items: baby formula, cooking oil, canned goods. The bill climbs to 5,000-10,000 rupees. After you pay and leave, he returns the items for a cash refund and splits the proceeds with the store clerk. R/srilanka users confirm this exact scam operates near supermarkets around...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you specifically near a supermarket entrance
- The story involves a stolen wallet and a sick or hungry child
- They steer you into the store rather than asking for cash directly
- The shopping basket fills up with expensive staples very quickly
- The person seems overly familiar with the store layout and staff

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline and walk away -- genuine hardship cases approach local charities, not tourists
- If you want to help, offer to buy one small item yourself rather than handing them the basket
- Watch for the same person repeating the routine with different tourists
- Donate to established Sri Lankan charities instead of street solicitations
- Do not feel guilty for saying no -- this is a well-documented scam across Colombo

■■ Galle

5 scams documented • Sri Lanka

The Galle Fort Gem Shop Lure

He tells you about a 'gem museum' inside the fort walls — free entry, just to learn about Sri Lanka's famous sapphires. Inside, you're given tea and a convincing presentation about gem grading. Then the pressure starts. A smooth-talking salesman shows you 'certified' sapphires at 'wholesale prices.' As r/srilanka users have warned for years, the certificates are fake, the stones are low-quality or synthetic, and the prices are massively inflated. Some tourists have lost hundreds of dollars on worthless stones they thought were investment-grade gems.

■ Red Flags

- A friendly stranger steers you toward a 'gem museum' or 'gem exhibition'
- You're offered free tea and a presentation before seeing any prices

- The shop claims to offer 'wholesale' or 'duty-free' prices
- Certificates of authenticity look generic or lack verifiable details
- Never buy gems from a shop you were led to by a stranger

■ How to Avoid

- Never buy gems from a shop you were led to by a stranger
 - If you want gems, visit a National Gem and Jewellery Authority certified dealer
 - Assume that any gem offer inside Galle Fort from an unsolicited contact is a scam
 - Walk away the moment anyone offers 'free' tea followed by a sales pitch
-

The Stilt Fisherman Photo Trap

It's the perfect photo. You pull over and start snapping pictures, and immediately the 'fisherman' climbs down and demands LKR 1,000-2,000 per photo. As [r/solotravel](#) users explain, these are not real fishermen — they're men paid to pose on stilts all day specifically to attract tourist cameras. Genuine stilt fishing is a dying tradition, and the ones you see near the road are purely performative. If you refuse to pay, they may become aggressive or block your car.

■ Red Flags

- Fishermen are perched right next to the road where tourists stop
- They are not actually catching any fish
- They immediately climb down and approach your car after photos are taken
- Multiple 'fishermen' are stationed at regular intervals along the coast
- If you want a photo, agree on a price before taking any pictures — LKR 200-500 is fair

■ How to Avoid

- If you want a photo, agree on a price before taking any pictures — LKR 200-500 is fair
 - Understand this is a paid photo opportunity, not authentic fishing
 - Photograph from a distance without stopping if you don't want to pay
 - Visit early morning or late afternoon to see genuine fishing activity further from tourist routes
-

The Galle Train Station Tuk-Tuk Scam

One offers a 'metered' ride to your hotel. He claims to be government-approved and shows a laminated card. The meter runs, but it's rigged — ticking twice as fast as it should. Or he takes a long detour via a gem shop and a batik factory, each adding time to the meter. As [r/srilanka](#) users report, the real distance from Galle station to Galle Fort is barely 1 kilometer — an easy walk. If you do need a tuk-tuk, the fare should not exceed LKR 200-300, yet drivers outside the station routinely charge LKR 800-1,000.

■ Red Flags

- Drivers claim to be government-approved with a laminated card
- The meter runs suspiciously fast
- The driver takes a route through commercial areas or shops
- The fare for a short ride seems wildly inflated
- Walk from Galle Railway Station to Galle Fort — it's only about 1 kilometer

■ How to Avoid

- Walk from Galle Railway Station to Galle Fort — it's only about 1 kilometer
 - Use the [PickMe](#) app to book a tuk-tuk with a fixed price
 - If you do take a tuk-tuk, agree on a price before getting in — LKR 200-300 max
 - Ask your accommodation to send directions for walking from the station
-

The Turtle Hatchery Guilt Trip

You pay LKR 500-1,000 at the gate and enter to find sea turtles crammed into tiny concrete tanks. A guide encourages you to hold baby turtles for photos, even though handling stresses them. The 'sick' turtles supposedly being rehabilitated seem fine but are kept permanently for tourist revenue. As travelers on r/srilanka have reported, many of these so-called conservation centers are commercial operations disguised as charities. Your driver earns a commission for every tourist he delivers.

■ Red Flags

- Your tuk-tuk driver insists on taking you to a specific hatchery
- Turtles are kept in small concrete tanks and seem distressed
- Staff encourage you to handle the turtles and take photos
- The facility claims to be nonprofit but has no verifiable conservation credentials
- Visit only hatcheries certified by the Department of Wildlife Conservation

■ How to Avoid

- Visit only hatcheries certified by the Department of Wildlife Conservation
 - The Sea Turtle Conservation Project in Koggala is a more reputable option
 - Refuse to handle turtles — legitimate centers do not allow tourist handling
 - Research online reviews before visiting any hatchery
-

The Galle Fort 'Helpful' Stranger

■ ■ Galle Fort entrance, ramparts near the clock tower You enter Galle Fort and a friendly young man falls into step beside you. He says he lives in the fort and offers to show you the best viewpoints, the hidden Dutch tunnels, and the 'real' local restaurants. The tour is pleasant but ends predictably — at his cousin's lace shop, his uncle's spice store, and a jewelry showroom, all inside the fort. At each stop, you face intense sales pressure. As r/solotravel users describe, these 'helpful' locals earn commission on everything you buy, and if you don't purchase anything, they'll demand a guide fee of LKR 2,000-5,000 for the unsolicited tour. Red Flags A stranger offers unsolicited help or a free tour inside the fort They know detailed history but have no official credentials The walk keeps ending at shops owned by their family or friends They become upset or demand payment if you don't buy anything How to Avoid Explore Galle Fort independently using a guidebook or Google Maps Politely but firmly decline unsolicited offers of assistance If you want a guide, book one through your hotel or the Galle Heritage Foundation The fort is small and walkable — you don't need a guide to find the key sites ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Sri Lanka Police station. Call 119 (Police) or 110 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.lk. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Colombo is at 210 Galle Road, Colombo 03. For emergencies: +94 11-249-8500. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Sri Lanka ■■

He says he lives in the fort and offers to show you the best viewpoints, the hidden Dutch tunnels, and the 'real' local restaurants. The tour is pleasant but ends predictably — at his cousin's lace shop, his uncle's spice store, and a jewelry showroom, all inside the fort. At each stop, you face intense sales pressure. As r/solotravel users describe, these 'helpful' locals earn commission on everything you buy, and if you don't purchase anything, they'll demand a guide fee of LKR 2,000-5,000 for the unsolicited tour.

■ Red Flags

- A stranger offers unsolicited help or a free tour inside the fort
- They know detailed history but have no official credentials
- The walk keeps ending at shops owned by their family or friends
- They become upset or demand payment if you don't buy anything
- Explore Galle Fort independently using a guidebook or Google Maps

■ How to Avoid

- Explore Galle Fort independently using a guidebook or Google Maps
 - Politely but firmly decline unsolicited offers of assistance
 - If you want a guide, book one through your hotel or the Galle Heritage Foundation
 - The fort is small and walkable — you don't need a guide to find the key sites
-

■■ Kandy

7 scams documented • Sri Lanka

The Spice Garden Detour

Then he casually suggests stopping at a spice garden 'just to look.' Inside, a self-proclaimed 'Ayurvedic doctor' or 'professor' gives you a tour of cinnamon, clove, and pepper plants. It feels educational until the hard sell begins — jars of miracle cream, herbal remedies, and overpriced spice sets. As r/srilanka users regularly warn, the quality is poor, the prices are astronomical (LKR 5,000-15,000 for items worth a fraction), and your driver gets a commission on everything you buy.

■ Red Flags

- Your tuk-tuk driver insists on stopping at a specific spice garden
- A 'doctor' or 'professor' gives the tour and prescribes remedies for ailments you mentioned
- Prices are not clearly displayed and items seem vastly overpriced
- The driver becomes moody or aggressive if you refuse to visit
- Politely decline any detours to spice gardens suggested by your driver

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline any detours to spice gardens suggested by your driver
 - If you want spices, buy them at a regular supermarket or the Kandy Central Market
 - Agree on the exact route and stops before hiring a tuk-tuk
 - Remember that real Ayurvedic doctors don't work out of roadside spice gardens
-

The Temple of the Tooth Fake Guide

Kandy's most sacred site — and a well-dressed man introduces himself as an 'official temple guide.' He walks with you through the complex, pointing out details and telling stories about the relic. He seems knowledgeable. At the end, he demands LKR 5,000-10,000 for the tour you never agreed to. As visitors report on r/travel, these self-appointed guides latch onto tourists near the entrance, and some even claim they work at your hotel. The temple has its own audio guides and official staff, so you don't need anyone else.

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you outside the temple claiming to be an official guide
- They don't have a visible ID badge or temple-issued credentials
- The guide says they work at your hotel or were sent by your guesthouse
- No price is discussed before the 'tour' begins
- Use the temple's own audio guide or printed guide available at the ticket counter

■ How to Avoid

- Use the temple's own audio guide or printed guide available at the ticket counter
- Only accept guides arranged through the temple's official information desk
- Ask to see an official ID badge before agreeing to any tour

- Tell persistent touts firmly that you prefer to explore independently
-

The Kandy Railway Station Tuk-Tuk Mafia

You step off the train at Kandy Railway Station, tired from the scenic ride from Colombo, and immediately a pack of tuk-tuk drivers surrounds you. They all quote the same inflated fare — LKR 1,000-1,500 to Kandy city center, a ride that should cost LKR 200-300. As r/srilanka users describe, these drivers operate as a cartel outside the station, and if one quotes a price, the others refuse to undercut it. Some will even refuse to take you unless you also agree to a full-day tour with them the next day. Walk a few minutes away from the station to find honest drivers.

■ Red Flags

- Multiple drivers quoting the exact same inflated fare
- Drivers becoming aggressive or blocking your path
- A driver insists you book a full-day tour as a condition of the ride
- They refuse to use a meter and dismiss PickMe or Uber
- Walk 5-10 minutes away from the station to find tuk-tuks at normal rates

■ How to Avoid

- Walk 5-10 minutes away from the station to find tuk-tuks at normal rates
 - Use the PickMe app to book a ride with a set fare before arriving
 - Ask your guesthouse to arrange pickup from the train station
 - Know that Kandy Railway Station to the city center should cost around LKR 200-300
-

The Special Ceremony Redirect

You're walking near Kandy Lake when a friendly local tells you there's a 'special Buddhist ceremony' happening right now at a lesser-known temple nearby. He offers to take you there in his tuk-tuk. Excited, you hop in. But instead of a temple, you end up at a gem shop, a batik factory, or a spice garden — all of which pay him a commission. As travelers on r/travel describe, the ceremony story is a well-rehearsed script to get you into the tuk-tuk. The driver then takes you on an hour-long 'tour' of commission shops, wasting your time and hoping you'll feel pressured to buy.

■ Red Flags

- A stranger tells you about a 'special ceremony' happening right now
- They offer to take you there in their tuk-tuk for free or very cheap
- The supposed destination keeps changing or involves multiple stops
- You end up at shops rather than a temple
- Ignore unsolicited claims about special events or ceremonies

■ How to Avoid

- Ignore unsolicited claims about special events or ceremonies
 - Plan your own temple visits using guidebooks or your hotel's advice
 - If a ceremony is genuine, your hotel staff will know about it
 - Never get into a tuk-tuk arranged by a stranger on the street
-

The Botanical Garden Fake Ticket Seller

You arrive at the Royal Botanical Gardens in Peradeniya and someone outside the gate approaches you wearing what looks like a staff uniform. They offer to sell you a ticket for LKR 3,000 — slightly less than the official foreigner price of LKR 3,540 — and throw in a 'free guided tour.' The ticket looks legitimate, but it's either counterfeit or a used ticket from earlier that day. As r/srilanka users note, the actual ticket office is clearly

marked inside the main entrance. These touts position themselves before you reach the real counter, hoping to intercept tourists who don't know the off...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you outside the main gate offering discounted tickets
- They offer an unsolicited guided tour bundled with the ticket
- The price is slightly lower than the official rate to seem like a deal
- They try to direct you away from the main entrance
- Only buy tickets at the official counter inside the main entrance gate

■ How to Avoid

- Only buy tickets at the official counter inside the main entrance gate
 - The official foreigner entry fee is around LKR 3,540 — know this before you go
 - Decline anyone offering tickets outside the gate, no matter how official they look
 - Official guides can be arranged at the information desk inside the gardens
-

The Gemstone Export Investment Scam

Inside, a well-dressed man shows you sapphires and rubies, explaining that Sri Lankan gems sell for ten times the price in your home country. He offers to sell you stones at 'local price' to resell at home for massive profit. A Reddit user on r/srilanka warned about this scam under the title 'Leaving Sri Lanka with a bitter note,' describing how they purchased gems that turned out to be glass when appraised at home. The shops often provide fake certificates of authenticity.

■ Red Flags

- A tuk-tuk driver offers a free ride to a 'friend's gem shop'
- The seller claims you can resell the gems at five to ten times the purchase price abroad
- Certificates of authenticity are printed on generic paper without verifiable lab details
- The shop has no visible government gem authority license displayed
- You are discouraged from taking the stones to an independent appraiser before buying

■ How to Avoid

- Never buy gems from shops recommended by tuk-tuk or taxi drivers — they receive commissions of 30-40 percent
 - If buying gems, only purchase from shops certified by the National Gem and Jewellery Authority
 - Ask for an independent appraisal certificate from the NGJA before paying
 - The resale-at-profit story is always false — gem trading requires expertise and licensed channels
 - Walk away from any high-pressure gem pitch — legitimate dealers let you take time
-

The Overpriced Souvenir Triple-Charge

■ ■ *Shops near the Temple of the Tooth, Kandy Central Market, souvenir shops on Dalada Veediya* You buy three small items — a wooden elephant, some tea, and a sarong — near the Temple of the Tooth. The shopkeeper quotes individual prices that sound reasonable, but the total comes out far higher than expected. A Reddit user on r/srilanka posted 'Almost got scammed for 16,000 LKR in Kandy' describing how a shopkeeper bundled items together and inflated the total by adding charges for wrapping, packaging, and a 'temple donation' surcharge. The trick relies on tourists not doing quick mental math when prices are quoted in thousands of rupees. **Red Flags** Prices are quoted verbally rather than written or tagged on items Additional charges appear at payment for packaging, wrapping, or 'donations' The total seems higher than the sum of individual quoted prices Shopkeeper uses a calculator and turns the screen away from you You are rushed through the payment process **How to Avoid** Ask for prices in writing before selecting items and add them up yourself Use your phone calculator to verify the total before paying Decline any add-on charges for packaging or donations you did not agree to Compare prices at multiple shops before buying — the market is competitive Pay in exact change when possible to avoid short-change issues ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Sri Lanka Police station. Call 119 (Police) or 110 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can

also report online at police.lk. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Colombo is at 210 Galle Road, Colombo 03. For emergencies: +94 11-249-8500. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Sri Lanka ■■

The shopkeeper quotes individual prices that sound reasonable, but the total comes out far higher than expected. A Reddit user on [r/srilanka](https://www.reddit.com/r/srilanka) posted 'Almost got scammed for 16,000 LKR in Kandy' describing how a shopkeeper bundled items together and inflated the total by adding charges for wrapping, packaging, and a 'temple donation' surcharge. The trick relies on tourists not doing quick mental math when prices are quoted in thousands of rupees.

■ Red Flags

- Prices are quoted verbally rather than written or tagged on items
- Additional charges appear at payment for packaging, wrapping, or 'donations'
- The total seems higher than the sum of individual quoted prices
- Shopkeeper uses a calculator and turns the screen away from you
- You are rushed through the payment process

■ How to Avoid

- Ask for prices in writing before selecting items and add them up yourself
- Use your phone calculator to verify the total before paying
- Decline any add-on charges for packaging or donations you did not agree to
- Compare prices at multiple shops before buying — the market is competitive
- Pay in exact change when possible to avoid short-change issues

Middle East

22 cities • 130 scams • 11 countries

■ Armenia

■■ Yerevan

6 scams documented • Armenia

The Airport Taxi Shakedown

You walk out of Zvartnots Airport baggage claim and a driver in a leather jacket waves you toward his car, quoting 8,000-15,000 AMD for a ride that should cost 3,000 AMD on the GG app. He insists there's no Wi-Fi here, no rideshare coverage, or that 'the app doesn't work at night.' Redditors on [r/armenia](https://www.reddit.com/r/armenia) warn that these unlicensed drivers swarm new arrivals — one poster reported being charged 10x the fair rate before learning about GG Taxi. Walk five minutes past the airport parking zone, connect to data, and book through the app to

save yourself the grief.

■ Red Flags

- Driver approaches you aggressively inside the terminal
- Claims rideshare apps don't operate at the airport
- Refuses to use a meter or show a fixed-rate card
- Vehicle has no visible taxi company markings or license
- Download the GG Taxi or Yandex Taxi app before landing

■ How to Avoid

- Download the GG Taxi or Yandex Taxi app before landing
 - Walk past the arrivals hall to get away from unlicensed touts
 - A fair airport-to-center fare is 2,500-4,000 AMD via app
 - If you must take a street taxi, agree on the price before getting in
 - Carry small AMD bills so you don't need change from a driver
-

The Republic Square Meter Dodge

But there's no meter running and he hasn't quoted a price. When you arrive, he demands 3,000-5,000 AMD for a ride that costs 600 AMD on the meter. If you argue, he insists that's the 'tourist rate' and blocks you from leaving. Travelers on [r/solotravel](#) describe this happening repeatedly on Northern Avenue and near the Cascade steps. The trick works because Yerevan taxis are cheap — tourists don't realize just how cheap, and drivers exploit the ignorance.

■ Red Flags

- Driver doesn't turn on the meter when you get in
- No price discussion before the trip begins
- Takes a suspiciously long route through side streets
- Quotes a flat fare that's 3-5 times the metered rate
- Always insist the meter is running before the car moves

■ How to Avoid

- Always insist the meter is running before the car moves
 - Use GG Taxi or Yandex Go for fixed, transparent pricing
 - Know that most in-city rides cost 400-1,000 AMD on the meter
 - Screenshot your route on Google Maps to catch detours
-

The Vernissage 'Handmade' Hustle

You're browsing the sprawling Vernissage flea market on a sunny weekend, admiring intricate Armenian carpets and khachkar carvings. A vendor swears on his grandmother that this rug was hand-woven by artisans in Gyumri. The price? \$200. Redditors on [r/travel](#) warn that many of these 'handmade Armenian crafts' are factory-produced imports from China or Turkey, marked up 4-5x for tourists. One poster noted the same 'hand-painted' ceramics available on AliExpress. Without a local friend, you're paying a premium for mass-produced goods.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor claims everything is handmade with no proof
- Price is dramatically higher than what locals would pay
- Identical items appear at multiple stalls — a sign of factory sourcing
- Vendor discourages you from comparing prices elsewhere

- No artisan markings, certificates, or provenance details

■ How to Avoid

- Bring an Armenian friend or ask your hotel for vendor recommendations
 - Haggle aggressively — starting at 30-40% of the quoted price is expected
 - Buy directly from verified artisan cooperatives instead
 - Compare prices at multiple stalls before committing
 - For authentic goods, visit the GUM Market or Erebuni Museum shop
-

The ATM Skimmer Helper

You're withdrawing cash from a standalone ATM on Northern Avenue when a friendly man approaches offering to 'help you avoid the service fee.' While he walks you through the menus, he's watching your PIN and carrying a pocket skimmer that clones your card in seconds. Travelers on r/travel have reported unauthorized withdrawals days later. The scam targets ATMs outside banks — the standalone machines near tourist sites that lack security cameras. One Redditor lost \$800 before their bank flagged the activity.

■ Red Flags

- A stranger offers unsolicited help at an ATM
- The ATM is standalone and not attached to a bank branch
- The card slot feels loose, bulky, or different from normal
- Someone stands unusually close while you type your PIN
- Only use ATMs inside bank branches like Ameriabank or Ardshinbank

■ How to Avoid

- Only use ATMs inside bank branches like Ameriabank or Ardshinbank
 - Cover the keypad with your hand when entering your PIN
 - Decline all help from strangers at ATMs — no exceptions
 - Never accept Dynamic Currency Conversion (DCC) at ATMs — it adds hidden fees
 - Enable transaction notifications on your banking app
-

The Restaurant Bill Pad

The food was great, the wine flowed freely. Then the bill arrives and it's 30-40% higher than expected. Hidden in the total are a 'service charge,' bread you didn't order, and two glasses of brandy that appeared as 'complimentary' but are now priced at 3,000 AMD each. Redditors on r/travel warn that restaurants on the main tourist strip add phantom items to foreign-looking customers' bills, knowing most won't scrutinize a bill written in Armenian script.

■ Red Flags

- Menu prices are vague or missing entirely
- 'Complimentary' items that show up on the final bill
- Bill is handwritten or only in Armenian with no English translation
- Service charge added without being mentioned on the menu
- Bread and water appear on the bill despite being presented as free

■ How to Avoid

- Ask for a menu with prices and photograph it before ordering
- Clarify if bread, water, and service charges are included
- Request an itemized bill and check it line by line before paying
- Eat where locals eat — one block off the main squares

- Use Google Translate's camera feature on Armenian-only bills
-

The Ride-Hailing App Driver Decoy

■ ■ Zvartnots International Airport pickup area, Republic Square taxi ranks, busy pickup zones in central Yerevan You order a Yandex or GG taxi at Republic Square. The app shows a driver nearby. You see a car matching the description pull up. But as you walk toward it, the driver starts moving slowly forward, eventually driving off — leaving you at the pickup point while the meter runs. Then the app cancels and charges a fee. Meanwhile, an unofficial taxi driver who has been watching offers to take you for a flat cash rate. Reddit users on r/armenia described this: 'Taxi drivers wait until you are near enough to start the ride (with GG/Yandex taxi) then they drive off without you.' The tactic either generates cancellation fees or funnels passengers to more expensive unofficial taxis. **Red Flags** Your ride-hailing driver accepts the trip but does not actually stop for you at the pickup location The driver's car moves slowly away from you as you approach, as if drawing you down the street An unofficial taxi driver appears immediately after your app ride fails, offering a convenient alternative The cancellation fee is charged even though you were standing at the correct pickup point The app driver has very few ratings or recently created their account **How to Avoid** Always verify the license plate number on the app matches the actual car before approaching If the driver does not stop, do not chase the car — wait at the pin location and let them come to you or cancel the ride yourself Report ghost rides and fake pickups to Yandex or GG through the app to get your cancellation fee refunded Save screenshots of the driver's details, pickup location, and time to support any dispute For airport transfers, prebook through your hotel or use the airport's official taxi desk rather than relying on ride-hailing apps ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Armenian Police station. Call 102 (Police) or 103 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.am. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact the US Embassy in Yerevan at 1 American Avenue, Yerevan 0082. For emergencies: +374 10-464-700. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides Popular Nearby Destinations** ■ ■

The app shows a driver nearby. You see a car matching the description pull up. But as you walk toward it, the driver starts moving slowly forward, eventually driving off — leaving you at the pickup point while the meter runs. Then the app cancels and charges a fee. Meanwhile, an unofficial taxi driver who has been watching offers to take you for a flat cash rate. Reddit users on r/armenia described this: 'Taxi drivers wait until you are near enough to start the ride (with GG/Yandex taxi) then they drive off without you.' The tactic either generates cancellation fees or funnels passengers to...

■ Red Flags

- Your ride-hailing driver accepts the trip but does not actually stop for you at the pickup location
- The driver's car moves slowly away from you as you approach, as if drawing you down the street
- An unofficial taxi driver appears immediately after your app ride fails, offering a convenient alternative
- The cancellation fee is charged even though you were standing at the correct pickup point
- The app driver has very few ratings or recently created their account

■ How to Avoid

- Always verify the license plate number on the app matches the actual car before approaching
 - If the driver does not stop, do not chase the car — wait at the pin location and let them come to you or cancel the ride yourself
 - Report ghost rides and fake pickups to Yandex or GG through the app to get your cancellation fee refunded
 - Save screenshots of the driver's details, pickup location, and time to support any dispute
 - For airport transfers, prebook through your hotel or use the airport's official taxi desk rather than relying on ride-hailing apps
-

■ Azerbaijan

■■ Baku

5 scams documented • Azerbaijan

The Bolt Taxi Bait-and-Switch

A driver accepts your request and picks you up. Once you are in the car with your luggage in the trunk, the driver cancels the Bolt booking on his phone and tells you the app had a problem. He then announces a new, much higher cash price for the ride. If you refuse to pay, he implies your luggage might not come with you, or he becomes aggressive. You are in a foreign city, tired from your flight, and you pay. TripAdvisor's Baku forum thread 'Common scams in Baku' documents this exact pattern, warning about Bolt taxi drivers who are aggressive and cancel bookings after passengers board, then...

■ Red Flags

- Your Bolt or taxi app booking is cancelled by the driver after you have already gotten into the car
- The driver claims the app had a technical error and quotes a cash price significantly higher than the app showed
- The driver stops at a store mid-route, claiming you need to exchange money or buy a SIM card there
- The driver becomes aggressive or refuses to release your luggage from the trunk when you dispute the fare
- The driver asks you to pay in cash rather than through the app's payment system

■ How to Avoid

- Before the car moves, confirm the driver's name, car plate, and that the trip is active in the app — screenshot the booking details
- Keep your luggage with you in the back seat rather than the trunk so it cannot be held hostage
- If the driver cancels mid-ride, immediately report through the app and book a new ride — do not agree to an off-app cash fare
- Pre-arrange your airport transfer through your hotel for a fixed, agreed price before arrival
- Decline all stops at stores or exchange offices en route — these are commission-based detours that benefit the driver, not you

The Apartment Rental Switcheroo

Days before arrival, the host calls to say the apartment has had a plumbing problem or electrical issue and is unavailable. But do not worry — they have another apartment that is equally nice. You arrive tired and follow them to the replacement, which turns out to be a dingy unit in a worse location that nobody would have booked voluntarily. Meanwhile, your original apartment is being rented to someone else at a higher walk-in rate. ShavysWorld.com identifies this as the most commonly used scam in Baku: tourists see a beautiful apartment at an attractive price and book it, but before arriva...

■ Red Flags

- The host contacts you shortly before arrival claiming the booked apartment is suddenly unavailable due to maintenance issues
- You are offered a replacement apartment that you did not choose and cannot preview online
- The host asks you to cancel your original booking yourself rather than handling it through the platform
- Upon arrival, the apartment's location, size, or condition differs significantly from the listing photos
- The host asks for cash payment outside the booking platform to avoid fees

■ How to Avoid

- Book accommodations with free cancellation through Booking.com or Airbnb and never cancel the original booking at the host's request — let the platform handle any changes
- If offered a replacement apartment, insist on seeing photos, the exact address, and reviews before agreeing to the switch

- Consider booking a hotel instead of an apartment — the price difference in Baku is often minimal and hotels offer more accountability
 - Read reviews carefully and look for patterns of bait-and-switch complaints — avoid listings with multiple mentions of substitutions
 - Never hand over your phone to a host or allow them to access your booking account for any reason
-

The Carpet Shop Export Trap

After animated bargaining, you agree on a price of 500 manat and pay with pride. The dealer wraps it up and you head to the airport. At customs, your carpet is confiscated. Any rug produced before 1960 requires a special export permit, and even newer pieces need documentation from the Carpet Museum certifying they are not culturally significant. The dealer conveniently forgot to mention any of this. Turkpidya's 2026 Karabakh rug buying guide describes the market as 'a minefield' with volatile pricing, strict government export controls, and total redevelopment of historic trading districts. ...

■ Red Flags

- The dealer does not mention export permits or documentation requirements when completing the sale
- Prices vary wildly from shop to shop for seemingly identical items, suggesting a lack of standardized pricing
- You are taken to a private home or unmarked location to see better pieces rather than a proper shop
- The dealer claims the carpet is antique or handmade but cannot provide any certification or provenance
- The price drops dramatically with minimal haggling — suggesting the initial ask was wildly inflated

■ How to Avoid

- Buy carpets only from the National Carpet Museum shop or official Azerkhalcha showrooms where export documentation is included with every purchase
 - For any carpet purchase, ask for and verify the export certificate before paying — the seller must provide this
 - Research current prices and export regulations before shopping — any rug pre-dating 1960 may be banned from export entirely
 - Never follow a stranger to a private home to see carpets — stick to shops with visible business licenses
 - Budget for the export documentation process: getting a certificate from the Carpet Museum can take 1-2 days, so do not leave this to your last afternoon
-

Nizami Street Vendor Overcharging

You are strolling down Nizami Street, Baku's famous pedestrian shopping boulevard, when a vendor catches your eye with beautifully displayed hairbread and pastries. You pick one up and take a bite before asking the price. The vendor names a figure several times what the same item costs at a bakery around the corner. Since you have already eaten half of it, arguing feels pointless. At a nearby restaurant, you notice the waiter brings complimentary-looking side dishes and bread, but the bill includes charges for every item placed on your table. TripAdvisor reviews of Nizami Street include spe...

■ Red Flags

- A vendor hands you food to taste before telling you the price — creating a fait accompli
- Prices are not displayed on any items and are quoted only after you have engaged or consumed something
- The vendor targets you specifically while ignoring local pedestrians walking past
- At a restaurant, dishes arrive at your table that you did not order and are later charged for
- A friendly stranger recommends a specific spice shop or restaurant and accompanies you there

■ How to Avoid

- Always ask the price before touching, tasting, or accepting any food item from a street vendor
- At restaurants, confirm with the waiter that only items you specifically ordered will appear on your bill

- Compare prices at multiple vendors before buying — walk the length of Nizami Street first to understand the normal range
 - Decline recommendations from strangers to visit specific shops or restaurants — they likely earn commissions
 - The Hilton corner restaurant is noted by TripAdvisor reviewers as offering meals at fair prices despite being in the tourist zone
-

The Bus Station Taxi Ambush

■ ■ *Baku Central Bus Station, international bus terminal, routes between cities and the airport, and shared taxi stands throughout Azerbaijan* You arrive at Baku's bus station planning to take a bus to Sheki or Quba. As you step off the platform, persistent taxi drivers swarm you, insisting there are no buses today, the next bus is hours away, or the route is closed. They offer to drive you for 80-120 manat — many times the bus fare of 10-15 manat. You start to worry that maybe there really are no buses, until you push past them to the ticket window and discover a bus leaving in 20 minutes. Bulbul on the Wing's guide to Azerbaijan scams specifically documents persistent taxi drivers at bus stations claiming there are no buses to your intended destination as a common ploy to coerce tourists into using their taxis at inflated prices. The buses, the guide confirms, are usually available. ShavysWorld.com corroborates this, noting that another variant involves the taxi driver's contact at the next stop who approaches you claiming to work at your hotel. World Nomads' Azerbaijan safety tips recommend ignoring persistent touts at transport hubs and going directly to official ticket windows. Red Flags Multiple taxi drivers approach you immediately upon arrival at a bus station, all claiming there are no buses They create urgency by saying the road is closed, the bus is cancelled, or it will not arrive for many hours The quoted taxi fare is 5-10 times the bus ticket price for the same route They physically block your path to the ticket window or try to take your luggage toward their car None of the drivers can show you an official fare schedule or taxi license How to Avoid Ignore taxi touts entirely and walk directly to the official bus ticket window to check schedules yourself Check bus schedules online before arriving at the station so you know when the next departure actually is If you do need a taxi, use the Bolt app for a quoted fare rather than negotiating with station touts Keep a firm grip on your luggage and do not let anyone carry it toward a vehicle without your explicit consent A firm 'Yox, sa■ olun' (No, thank you in Azerbaijani) while walking with purpose is the most effective response ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Azerbaijan Police station. Call 102 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at mia.gov.az. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Embassy in Baku at 111 Azadlig Avenue. For emergencies: +994 12-488-3300. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides Popular Nearby Destinations ■■

As you step off the platform, persistent taxi drivers swarm you, insisting there are no buses today, the next bus is hours away, or the route is closed. They offer to drive you for 80-120 manat — many times the bus fare of 10-15 manat. You start to worry that maybe there really are no buses, until you push past them to the ticket window and discover a bus leaving in 20 minutes. Bulbul on the Wing's guide to Azerbaijan scams specifically documents persistent taxi drivers at bus stations claiming there are no buses to your intended destination as a common ploy to coerce tourists into using th...

■ Red Flags

- Multiple taxi drivers approach you immediately upon arrival at a bus station, all claiming there are no buses
- They create urgency by saying the road is closed, the bus is cancelled, or it will not arrive for many hours
- The quoted taxi fare is 5-10 times the bus ticket price for the same route
- They physically block your path to the ticket window or try to take your luggage toward their car
- None of the drivers can show you an official fare schedule or taxi license

■ How to Avoid

- Ignore taxi touts entirely and walk directly to the official bus ticket window to check schedules yourself
 - Check bus schedules online before arriving at the station so you know when the next departure actually is
 - If you do need a taxi, use the Bolt app for a quoted fare rather than negotiating with station touts
 - Keep a firm grip on your luggage and do not let anyone carry it toward a vehicle without your explicit consent
 - A firm 'Yox, sa■ olun' (No, thank you in Azerbaijani) while walking with purpose is the most effective response
-

■ Georgia

■■ Tbilisi

6 scams documented • Georgia

Airport Taxi Triple-Charge

The driver doesn't mention a price — he just loads your bags and starts driving. When you arrive at your hotel in the Old Town, the meter shows 105 GEL. A Bolt ride for the same trip costs 26 GEL. The meter wasn't broken — it was programmed to a higher tariff. Turkish-style taxi meters used in Georgia can store multiple tariff rates, and switching between them requires only a button press. This is one of the most extensively documented scams in Tbilisi. TripAdvisor has multiple dedicated threads including 'Scammed by a taxi at Tbilisi airport' and 'Airport Taxi Scam' with years of accumulat...

■ Red Flags

- The driver does not discuss the fare before starting the trip
- The meter shows a starting fare higher than the standard 1 GEL opening charge
- The fare climbs noticeably fast relative to the distance traveled
- The driver approaches you inside the terminal rather than waiting at the official rank
- The quoted or metered fare exceeds 40 GEL for the airport-to-center trip

■ How to Avoid

- Download and use Bolt before landing — the fare from TBS to the city center is 20-30 GEL, quoted in advance
- Alternatively, take the airport bus (Bus 37) for 0.50 GEL to the city center
- If you must take a taxi, agree on the exact fare in writing before getting in — 30-35 GEL is fair
- Never get into a taxi that doesn't have a visible, functioning meter or a pre-agreed fare
- Ask your hotel to arrange airport pickup at a fixed price, which is typically 30-40 GEL

Nightclub Bill Extortion Ring

You match with someone on a dating app or are approached on the street by an attractive, English-speaking person who invites you for drinks at a 'great local bar.' The venue looks normal — dim lighting, music, a bartender. Your companion orders champagne and cocktails. The bill arrives: 1,770 GEL (about \$650). The menu showed nothing over 50 GEL, but the champagne your companion ordered costs 1,200 GEL. Staff insist on cash only. When you resist, bouncers appear and psychological pressure intensifies until you pay. This is Tbilisi's most notorious tourist scam, with an entire website (tbili...

■ Red Flags

- Someone you just met (in person or on dating apps) suggests a specific bar or club
- The venue is on a quiet side street with no visible price list or reviews
- Your companion orders champagne, cocktails, or premium drinks without discussing cost
- The venue insists on cash-only payment — legitimate bars accept cards
- Bouncers or large staff members become visible when you question the bill

■ How to Avoid

- Never let someone you just met choose the venue — always pick your own bar from a list with TripAdvisor reviews
- Check menu prices before ordering anything and confirm the cost of each item

- Be immediately suspicious if someone from a dating app wants to meet at a specific bar rather than a well-known restaurant
 - If the bill is outrageous, call the police (112) rather than paying under duress — the 2019 convictions show authorities take this seriously
 - Avoid bars on Ioane Shavteli Street that you haven't specifically researched in advance
-

Wine Tour Hidden Costs and Bait-and-Switch

You book a 'full-day Kakheti wine tour' from a Tbilisi street agency for 50 GEL per person, excited to explore Georgia's famous wine country. The tour bus picks you up, drives to Kakheti, and stops at one winery where you taste one small glass of wine. Lunch isn't included despite being implied. The 'five-winery tour' turns out to be one winery and four souvenir shops. Back in Tbilisi, you've paid 50 GEL for the tour, 40 GEL for lunch, and 30 GEL for 'extras' — more than you would have paid for a quality full-service tour. The Wander-Lush travel blog's comprehensive Kakheti wine tour guide ...

■ Red Flags

- The tour price is significantly below 80 GEL per person, suggesting corners will be cut
- The operator cannot provide a clear written itinerary listing which wineries you'll visit
- Food and lunch are described as 'available' rather than 'included'
- The booking is through a street flyer or kiosk rather than an established operator with online reviews
- The operator describes 'five stops' without specifying that some are shops rather than wineries

■ How to Avoid

- Book through operators with hundreds of TripAdvisor or GetYourGuide reviews (Eat This Tours, Gourmet Georgia, Taste Georgia)
 - Confirm in writing what's included: number of winery visits, number of tastings per winery, lunch, transport
 - Expect to pay 80-120 GEL per person for a quality full-day tour — lower prices mean lower quality
 - Ask whether the guide is knowledgeable about wine or just a driver who speaks English
 - Consider hiring a private driver (100-150 GEL per day) and visiting wineries independently, which offers more control
-

Currency Exchange Commission Trap

better than the bank rate of 2.65. You hand over \$200 and receive 540 GEL. But when you check the receipt (if you got one), there's a 28% commission buried in the fine print. Your effective rate was 2.16 GEL per dollar, not 2.70. You lost about \$40. ATMs present a different trap: the machine offers to convert your withdrawal to your home currency at a 'guaranteed rate.' This Dynamic Currency Conversion (DCC) applies a markup of 5-8%. Backpack Moments' Georgia money guide warns: 'Some companies have commission fees as high as 28%. Before you exchange currency in Georgia, make sure that compa...

■ Red Flags

- The advertised rate is significantly better than what banks offer — the gap is hidden in commission
- No commission rate is displayed alongside the exchange rate
- The office is located directly at a tourist landmark, train station, or airport
- The cashier counts quickly and discourages you from verifying before leaving
- An ATM offers to convert your withdrawal to your home currency at a 'guaranteed rate'

■ How to Avoid

- Ask 'is there a commission?' before exchanging any money — the best offices charge zero commission
- Use exchange offices on Pushkin Street or Aghmashenebeli Avenue away from tourist landmarks
- At ATMs, always decline Dynamic Currency Conversion (DCC) and let your home bank handle the exchange
- Withdraw from TBC Bank or Bank of Georgia ATMs inside branches for the best security

- Exchange only small amounts at airports or hotels and get the rest at city exchange offices
-

Rental Car Deposit Confiscation

The rental goes smoothly — you drive the Georgian Military Highway, explore Kazbegi, and return the car in the same condition you received it. The company refuses to return your deposit, claiming you drove on 'unapproved roads' that were 'poorly described in the contract.' The contract, written in Georgian with a brief English summary, apparently restricted the car to paved roads only — but the company knew you were planning a mountain trip. This deposit dispute pattern is documented on TripAdvisor's Tbilisi forum, where travelers report that local companies like Mimino Rent Car requested c...

■ Red Flags

- The company requires a cash deposit rather than a credit card hold
- The contract is only in Georgian with a brief, vague English summary
- Road restrictions in the contract are vaguely worded or seem designed to be violated unknowingly
- No thorough vehicle condition report is completed at pickup with photos
- The company has mixed reviews with multiple complaints about deposit disputes

■ How to Avoid

- Rent from international companies (Europcar, Hertz) or well-reviewed locals (Local Rent) that offer no-deposit options
 - Photograph the entire car at pickup and return, including all existing damage
 - Read the full contract carefully — get a Georgian friend or your hotel to translate restrictions
 - Pay deposits by credit card rather than cash so you can dispute if the deposit is unfairly withheld
 - Purchase full CDW/Super CDW insurance to limit your liability regardless of the deposit
-

Street Money Changer Sleight-of-Hand

■ ■ Rustaveli Avenue near the parliament, Freedom Square, the area around the Dry Bridge Market, and near the Central Train Station A man near the Dry Bridge Market approaches and offers to exchange your dollars or euros at a rate ... A man near the Dry Bridge Market approaches and offers to exchange your dollars or euros at a rate noticeably better than exchange offices. You agree to change \$100. He counts out the lari slowly and carefully, showing you each note. Satisfied, you take the stack. Back at your hotel, you recount: you're 50 GEL short. During the count, he palmed several notes using a technique so smooth you didn't notice. Tourist Scams Co's Tbilisi page warns about 'local money exchangers offering to exchange GEL for foreign coins at a very good rate' as a documented scam. My Geo Trip's currency guide adds: 'Be cautious of street vendors or unofficial exchange services that may offer seemingly attractive rates.' The technique relies on the better-than-market rate drawing you in, combined with practiced sleight-of-hand that exploits the fact that you're unfamiliar with Georgian lari denominations. The rule is simple: never exchange money on the street. Georgia has hundreds of licensed exchange offices (many open 24 hours) that offer competitive rates with zero commission. There is never a legitimate reason to exchange currency with a street vendor. Red Flags A stranger on the street offers currency exchange at rates better than exchange offices They count money very quickly or use distracting conversation during the count The exchange happens while walking or in a doorway rather than at a fixed location with a receipt They become agitated or try to rush you if you attempt to recount The person has no fixed stall, shop, or business registration visible How to Avoid Never exchange money with street vendors — always use licensed exchange offices or bank ATMs If offered a street exchange, simply say 'no thanks' and walk to the nearest exchange office Always count your money at the counter of an exchange office before leaving Learn the basic Georgian lari denominations (1, 2, 5, 10, 20, 50, 100, 200) before arriving The best exchange offices are on Pushkin Street and Aghmashenebeli Avenue, open 24 hours ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Georgian Police (Patrol Police) station. Call 112 (Emergency) or 022-241-106 (Police). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.ge. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Embassy in Tbilisi at 11 George Balanchine Street. For emergencies: +995 32-227-7000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides Popular Nearby Destinations ■ ■

A man near the Dry Bridge Market approaches and offers to exchange your dollars or euros at a rate noticeably better than exchange offices. You agree to change \$100. He counts out the lari slowly and carefully, showing you each note. Satisfied, you take the stack. Back at your hotel, you recount: you're 50 GEL short. During the count, he palmed several notes using a technique so smooth you didn't notice. Tourist Scams Co's Tbilisi page warns about 'local money exchangers offering to exchange GEL for foreign coins at a very good rate' as a documented scam. My Geo Trip's currency guide adds: ...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger on the street offers currency exchange at rates better than exchange offices
- They count money very quickly or use distracting conversation during the count
- The exchange happens while walking or in a doorway rather than at a fixed location with a receipt
- They become agitated or try to rush you if you attempt to recount
- The person has no fixed stall, shop, or business registration visible

■ How to Avoid

- Never exchange money with street vendors — always use licensed exchange offices or bank ATMs
 - If offered a street exchange, simply say 'no thanks' and walk to the nearest exchange office
 - Always count your money at the counter of an exchange office before leaving
 - Learn the basic Georgian lari denominations (1, 2, 5, 10, 20, 50, 100, 200) before arriving
 - The best exchange offices are on Pushkin Street and Aghmashenebeli Avenue, open 24 hours
-

■ Israel

■ Jerusalem

8 scams documented • Israel

Mount of Olives Pickpockets & Fake Sellers

You arrive at the Mount of Olives lookout at the start of your Jerusalem tour, and the panoramic view of the Old City takes your breath away. While you're distracted by the scenery and searching for the best camera angle, vendors press close offering scarves, souvenirs, and 'authentic' goods. In the commotion, pickpockets work through bags and camera bags are left unattended.

■ Red Flags

- Vendors crowding around you when you stop for photos
- Unsolicited items placed around your neck or in your hands
- Someone distracting you while another lingers near your bag
- Keep bags zipped and in front of you at all crowded overlooks
- Change camera lenses in a corner or inside the nearby cemetery

■ How to Avoid

- Keep bags zipped and in front of you at all crowded overlooks
 - Change camera lenses in a corner or inside the nearby cemetery
 - Decline anything placed in your hands without asking
-

Red String Blessing Scam

On your way to the Western Wall, a man approaches and begins wrapping a red string around your wrist before you realize what's happening, saying a blessing aloud. He then asks for a donation for the 'holy ceremony' he just performed. Refusing feels awkward in such a sacred location, and many tourists hand over money out of social pressure rather than genuine intention.

■ Red Flags

- Someone reaches for your wrist without asking
- Blessing performed without consent or prior agreement
- Donation requested in a prominent public spot
- Firmly say 'no thank you' before they can touch your wrist
- Keep walking and avoid making eye contact with persistent string-sellers

■ How to Avoid

- Firmly say 'no thank you' before they can touch your wrist
 - Keep walking and avoid making eye contact with persistent string-sellers
 - If a string is tied before you can stop it, you're not obligated to pay
-

Menu Without Prices Restaurant Trick

but no prices are listed anywhere. You order what sounds reasonable, expecting a normal meal, but when the bill arrives you're charged \$25 for a falafel plate you thought was \$7. The waiter insists you ordered the 'full plate' not the sandwich, and there's no way to dispute it.

■ Red Flags

- Menu has no prices listed
- Waiter doesn't confirm which version of a dish you want
- Restaurant located in a heavy tourist corridor
- Never order from a menu without prices — leave if prices aren't displayed
- Explicitly confirm: 'I want the falafel in pita, how much is that exactly?'

■ How to Avoid

- Never order from a menu without prices — leave if prices aren't displayed
 - Explicitly confirm: 'I want the falafel in pita, how much is that exactly?'
 - Check Google or TripAdvisor reviews for price complaints before sitting down
-

Jaffa Gate ATM & Money Exchange Scam

There are money changers right at the gate offering convenient exchange, and ATMs nearby. The money changers offer what sounds like a good rate until you realize after the transaction that they used a different rate than quoted, or the ATM charged enormous fees with a terrible exchange rate built in.

■ Red Flags

- Money changers shouting rates near tourist entry points
- ATMs at tourist hotspots often operated by private companies with high fees
- Rate offered verbally is better than the rate on the paperwork you sign
- Avoid the ATMs directly at Jaffa Gate — use bank ATMs inside the city
- Use your bank card at a legitimate bank ATM and decline 'dynamic currency conversion'

■ How to Avoid

- Avoid the ATMs directly at Jaffa Gate — use bank ATMs inside the city
- Use your bank card at a legitimate bank ATM and decline 'dynamic currency conversion'
- Exchange money at your hotel or a reputable bank before arriving at the Old City

Aggressive Old City Souvenir Sellers

You're walking the Via Dolorosa trying to follow the stations of the cross, but every few meters a shopkeeper calls out to you or physically steps in your path to show you goods. Some place items in your hands and then demand payment claiming you've 'agreed to buy.' The pressure is relentless and the narrow alleys make it hard to walk away quickly.

■ Red Flags

- Shopkeeper physically blocks your path
- Item placed directly in your hands without asking
- Vendor follows you down the street after you say no
- Keep walking with purpose — make eye contact only if you genuinely want to browse
- If something is placed in your hands, set it down firmly and walk on

■ How to Avoid

- Keep walking with purpose — make eye contact only if you genuinely want to browse
- If something is placed in your hands, set it down firmly and walk on
- A polite but firm 'la shukran' (no thank you in Arabic) is respected

Fake 'Closed' Attraction Redirect

You're walking toward the Church of the Holy Sepulchre when a man approaches and tells you it's closed today for a special ceremony, but he can take you to another church that's even more beautiful. He leads you to a relative's shop or a less-notable site, then expects a guiding fee. The original church was open the entire time.

■ Red Flags

- Stranger tells you a major attraction is 'closed today' without you asking
- They offer an alternative and want to guide you there personally
- No official closure notice visible at the site entrance
- Verify closure claims by walking to the attraction yourself
- Check official opening hours online before visiting each site

■ How to Avoid

- Verify closure claims by walking to the attraction yourself
- Check official opening hours online before visiting each site
- Never follow a stranger who claims to know of a 'better' alternative

Ben Gurion Airport Taxi Overcharge

An unofficial driver approaches offering a 'fixed price' of 500 NIS for the trip, which should only cost 250-350 NIS by meter. Some drivers refuse to use the meter entirely, claiming it is broken or that there is a 'night surcharge' that makes the fixed rate cheaper. Reddit users on r/Israel report being charged between 300 and 500 NIS for rides that should cost far less. One user documented a driver who quoted in shekels, then demanded payment in dollars at the destination.

■ Red Flags

- Driver approaches you inside the arrivals hall rather than at the official taxi stand
- Quoted fare is above 350 NIS for a standard Jerusalem ride
- Driver claims the meter is broken or that fixed rate is 'the law'
- No official taxi markings or Gett/taxi company branding on the vehicle
- Driver asks for payment in dollars instead of shekels

■ How to Avoid

- Use the official Nesher shared shuttle service from TLV to Jerusalem for about 64 NIS per person
 - Book a Gett taxi through the app before exiting the terminal
 - Insist on the meter — the legal fare from TLV to central Jerusalem is around 250-350 NIS
 - Always decline 'dynamic currency conversion' and pay in local currency
 - Report overcharging to the Ministry of Transport hotline at *5678
-

King Hussein Bridge Border Crossing VIP Scam

■ ■ *King Hussein (Allenby) Bridge border crossing from Jordan* You are crossing from Jordan into Israel through the King Hussein border and a man in semi-official ... You are crossing from Jordan into Israel through the King Hussein border and a man in semi-official clothing offers you the VIP fast-track service for a premium. You pay, hand over your passport, and then wait for over an hour anyway while your passport sits in a pile with everyone else's. The 'VIP' service was a fabrication — a Reddit user on r/TravelsIsrael described paying extra for expedited processing that never materialized, with their passport held hostage for the duration. The crossing is notoriously slow regardless of what you pay. **Red Flags** Someone offers VIP or expedited border processing for a cash fee Your passport is taken out of your hands by an unofficial intermediary There is no official signage or receipt for the premium service You are told the regular line will take 'four hours' but VIP takes 'twenty minutes' **How to Avoid** Use only the official JETT bus service from Amman which includes proper border processing Never hand your passport to anyone except uniformed border officials behind the counter Expect the crossing to take 1-3 hours regardless — plan your day accordingly If offered VIP service, ask for an official receipt with a government stamp before paying Carry snacks and water — the wait areas have limited facilities ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Israel Police (Mishtara) station. Call 100 (Police) or 101 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at police.gov.il. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Jerusalem is at 14 David Flusser Street, Jerusalem 9378322. For emergencies: +972 2-630-4000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **Frequently Asked Questions** *Is Jerusalem safe for tourists?* ▼

You are crossing from Jordan into Israel through the King Hussein border and a man in semi-official clothing offers you the VIP fast-track service for a premium. You pay, hand over your passport, and then wait for over an hour anyway while your passport sits in a pile with everyone else's. The 'VIP' service was a fabrication — a Reddit user on r/TravelsIsrael described paying extra for expedited processing that never materialized, with their passport held hostage for the duration. The crossing is notoriously slow regardless of what you pay.

■ Red Flags

- Someone offers VIP or expedited border processing for a cash fee
- Your passport is taken out of your hands by an unofficial intermediary
- There is no official signage or receipt for the premium service
- You are told the regular line will take 'four hours' but VIP takes 'twenty minutes'
- Use only the official JETT bus service from Amman which includes proper border processing

■ How to Avoid

- Use only the official JETT bus service from Amman which includes proper border processing
 - Never hand your passport to anyone except uniformed border officials behind the counter
 - Expect the crossing to take 1-3 hours regardless — plan your day accordingly
 - If offered VIP service, ask for an official receipt with a government stamp before paying
 - Carry snacks and water — the wait areas have limited facilities
-

■■ Tel Aviv

Taxi Meter Manipulation and Route Inflation

The driver greets you warmly and starts driving toward Tel Aviv. You notice he has not turned on the meter — or the meter is running but the numbers are climbing suspiciously fast. When you arrive at your hotel, the fare is 350 shekels for a trip that should cost 150-180. The driver insists this is the correct fare, pointing to the meter. If you argue, he becomes aggressive or claims there is a 'night surcharge' and an 'airport fee' that were not disclosed. Taxi overcharging is the most frequently reported tourist scam in Tel Aviv. Quora threads and TripAdvisor forums document cases of driv...

■ Red Flags

- The driver does not turn on the meter or claims the meter is broken — by law, the meter must run
- The meter is set to Rate 2 during regular daytime hours (Rate 2 is only for nights after 9pm, Shabbat, holidays, or 3+ passengers)
- The driver takes an obviously circuitous route through neighborhoods that are not on the direct path to your destination
- The driver quotes a flat rate significantly higher than what ride-hailing apps show for the same trip
- The driver refuses to give you a receipt or becomes hostile when you ask for one

■ How to Avoid

- Use the Gett app (Israel's main ride-hailing service) or Uber, which show estimated fares and GPS-tracked routes
- If taking a street taxi, insist on the meter (say 'Moneh, bevakasha') and confirm it is set to Rate 1 during daytime hours
- From Ben Gurion Airport, use the official taxi stand and confirm the fixed fare to your destination before departing — it should be 170-200 NIS to central Tel Aviv
- Note the driver's ID number and taxi number displayed inside the cab, and always ask for a printed receipt at the end
- Follow the route on Google Maps during the ride — if the driver deviates significantly, say something immediately

Dead Sea Cosmetics Aggressive Sales Pressure

You are walking down Dizengoff Street when a charismatic salesperson calls out, offering a free sample of Dead Sea mineral cream. They take your hand and begin applying product before you can object. After the demo, they quote a price of 300-500 shekels (\$80-140) for a small pot of cream that you can buy online for \$15. When you try to leave, they block your path, drop the price, apply emotional pressure, and make you feel obligated because they 'spent time' with you. Some tourists have reported being accompanied to ATMs to withdraw cash. The Dead Sea cosmetics hard-sell is a globally docum...

■ Red Flags

- A salesperson physically stops you on the sidewalk and begins applying product to your hand or face without asking
- The product has no visible price tag, and the price is only revealed after a lengthy demonstration
- The quoted price is 5-10 times higher than what the same product costs online or at a local pharmacy
- The salesperson becomes aggressive, emotional, or guilt-tripping when you try to leave without buying
- They offer increasingly dramatic discounts — dropping from 500 to 300 to 150 shekels — which reveals the initial price was fabricated

■ How to Avoid

- Do not let anyone apply product to your skin — politely say 'Lo todah' (no thanks) and keep walking without stopping
- Remember you have zero obligation to buy anything, regardless of how much time a salesperson has spent demonstrating
- If you are interested in Dead Sea products, buy them at a pharmacy like Super-Pharm or at the Dead Sea itself at a fraction of the tourist-area price

- Never follow a salesperson to an ATM or agree to a purchase under pressure — walk away and return only if you genuinely want the product
 - Research prices online before your trip so you can immediately recognize inflated quotes
-

Beach Theft While Swimming

You lay out your towel, put your phone and wallet under your shirt, and head into the Mediterranean for a swim. When you return 15 minutes later, your phone, wallet, and sunglasses are gone. Your towel is still there, neatly undisturbed. The thief knew exactly where to look and was in and out in seconds. Beach theft is one of the most common crimes reported by tourists in Tel Aviv. The city's beach culture means thousands of people leave valuables on the sand daily, and professional thieves work the beaches systematically. Quora threads on Tel Aviv safety specifically note that 'thefts are ...

■ Red Flags

- Someone is lingering near your belongings or walking slowly past without their own beach setup nearby
- A stranger offers to 'watch your stuff' and then disappears with your valuables when you go swimming
- You are at a crowded beach with valuables visible on your towel — this is the highest-risk scenario
- Your spot is far from lifeguard stations or other beachgoers where a theft would be less likely to be witnessed
- You notice the same person walking back and forth past various groups' belongings

■ How to Avoid

- Use a waterproof phone pouch (available at any beach shop for 20-30 NIS) and take your phone and cash into the water with you
 - Leave your passport and extra valuables at your hotel — bring only what you need for the beach
 - Ask the lifeguard station if they offer a secure locker or deposit service — some Tel Aviv beaches have these during summer
 - Go to the beach with a friend and take turns watching belongings — never leave everything unattended
 - Bury your valuables in a ziplock bag under your towel as a last resort — professional thieves look under towels and shirts first, but a buried bag is harder to find quickly
-

Red String Kabbalah Bracelet Donation Scam

a common day trip from Tel Aviv — when a man steps in front of you, gently ties a red string around your wrist, recites a blessing, and then demands a 'donation' of 50-100 shekels. If you try to refuse, he says the bracelet is already blessed and cannot be removed, and that not paying would bring bad luck. Some people work in groups and become aggressive if you resist. This scam is extensively documented on TravelingIsrael.com's Jerusalem scam guide, which describes the red string scammers who operate along the approach to the Western Wall. The red string is associated with Kabbalah mystici...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you and ties a string or bracelet on your wrist without asking permission
- They recite a blessing or prayer and then immediately demand a 'donation' — the amount is suspiciously specific (50-100 NIS)
- They claim the bracelet is 'blessed' and cannot be removed, or that refusing to pay will bring bad luck
- Multiple people work together near the entrance to a religious site, creating a gauntlet that is hard to walk through
- The person is not affiliated with any visible organization, synagogue, or charity

■ How to Avoid

- Do not let anyone tie anything on your wrist — pull your hand away and say 'Lo todah' (no thanks) firmly
- If a string is already tied, you can remove it yourself — there is no obligation to pay or keep it
- Buy a red Kabbalah string at a Judaica shop for 5 NIS if you want one as a souvenir — do not buy from street vendors

- Walk with purpose and avoid eye contact with people trying to stop you near the Western Wall entrance
 - Know that this is a well-documented scam, not a genuine religious practice — real rabbis do not approach strangers demanding money
-

Fake Apartment Rental Fraud

Rothschild Boulevard, gorgeous photos, fully furnished, \$80 per night, which is half the price of similar listings on Airbnb. The host responds quickly by email with a heartwarming story: their Israeli mother recently passed away and left this apartment, and they are renting it at a discount because they live abroad. They ask for two months' rent and a deposit upfront via bank transfer. You pay \$2,400 and receive an address. When you arrive, the apartment either does not exist, belongs to someone else, or is nothing like the photos. This scam is documented extensively on TripAdvisor's Israe...

■ Red Flags

- The rental price is significantly below market rate — if Airbnb shows similar apartments at \$150/night and this one is \$80, it is likely fraudulent
- The host claims to live abroad and cannot show you the apartment in person before you pay
- They request payment via bank wire transfer, Western Union, or cryptocurrency — not through a secure booking platform
- The host's story involves a recently deceased relative, relocation abroad, or other emotional narratives designed to explain why they cannot meet
- The same apartment photos appear in reverse image searches linked to listings in other cities

■ How to Avoid

- Book apartments only through platforms with buyer protection — Airbnb, Booking.com, or established Israeli agencies like Tzion Apartments
 - Never send money via wire transfer or cryptocurrency for accommodation — use credit cards through booking platforms for chargeback protection
 - Reverse-search the apartment photos on Google Images — scammers reuse the same photos across multiple cities
 - If a deal seems too good to be true for Rothschild Boulevard or beachfront Hayarkon Street, it almost certainly is
 - Insist on a video call showing the apartment and the host's government ID before any payment — real hosts will comply
-

Carmel Market Tourist Price Inflation

You pick up a beautiful hand-painted ceramic bowl and ask the price. The vendor says 180 shekels without hesitation. You think it is reasonable for handmade work. What you do not know is that the same vendor sold an identical bowl to an Israeli customer 10 minutes ago for 60 shekels. When you attempt to negotiate, the vendor acts offended, insisting the price is already 'special for you.' Price inflation for tourists at the Carmel Market is a well-known phenomenon. TripAdvisor threads on the market discuss haggling customs: 'bargaining is common for goods, while prices for food items are ge...

■ Red Flags

- The vendor quotes a price instantly without checking — the price was calculated based on your appearance, not the item
- No price tags are displayed on goods, allowing different prices for different customers
- The vendor becomes dramatic or emotional when you try to negotiate — claiming you are insulting their craft
- Spices are weighed on a small handheld scale rather than a proper fixed scale with visible markings
- You are quoted a price significantly higher for the same item you saw priced lower at a stall 50 meters away

■ How to Avoid

- Walk the entire market first without buying anything — compare prices for similar items across multiple vendors

- For souvenirs, start by offering 40-50% of the quoted price and negotiate from there — settling at 60-70% is normal
 - Buy spices by weight at shops with fixed scales and visible price tags, or at supermarkets like Shufersal for guaranteed pricing
 - Ask Israeli friends, your hotel concierge, or check recent TripAdvisor reviews for fair price ranges on specific items
 - Remember that food items at the market — fresh juice, hummus, falafel, baked goods — are generally fairly priced and do not require haggling
-

The Ashtray Art Gallery Overcharge

■ ■ *Gallery shops near Jaffa flea market, Nahalat Binyamin Arts and Crafts Fair, tourist shops on Ben Yehuda Street* You wander into a small art gallery near the Jaffa flea market. The owner is friendly and shows you handcrafted ceramics. You admire an ashtray and ask the price. He says '145.' You assume shekels and agree. He runs your credit card for \$1,900 — it was 145 in some invented unit, or he simply keyed in a larger number. A Reddit post that gained wide attention described a US tourist being 'detained after charging tourist \$1,900 for ashtray.' The tourist initially was told the price was 145 (unclear currency), and when he said he had no cash, 'he reluctantly remembered he had a credit card machine and promptly charged me \$145 instead of 145 shekels' — though even that was vastly inflated. **Red Flags** Prices in a shop are not clearly labeled or are quoted verbally without specifying the currency The shop owner quickly produces a credit card machine after you express interest The price quoted seems reasonable in one currency but would be extremely high in another You are told there is a 'special price' just for you that is not posted anywhere The shop does not display a business license or price list as required by Israeli consumer law **How to Avoid** Always confirm prices in New Israeli Shekels (NIS) before agreeing to any purchase Watch the credit card terminal screen to verify the exact amount being charged before approving For art and crafts, compare prices at the Nahalat Binyamin Arts Fair where artists post prices openly Request a detailed receipt showing the item description, currency, and amount before completing any transaction Report overcharging to the Israel Consumer Protection Authority or call the police at *100 — Israeli law protects tourists from fraud ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Israel Police (Mishtara) station. Call 100. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at gov.il/israel_police. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact the US Embassy in Tel Aviv at 71 HaYarkon Street, Tel Aviv. Phone: +972-3-519-7575. For emergencies after hours: +972-3-519-7551. Other nationalities should check their embassy's Tel Aviv location. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **Frequently Asked Questions** Is Tel Aviv safe for tourists? ▼

The owner is friendly and shows you handcrafted ceramics. You admire an ashtray and ask the price. He says '145.' You assume shekels and agree. He runs your credit card for \$1,900 — it was 145 in some invented unit, or he simply keyed in a larger number. A Reddit post that gained wide attention described a US tourist being 'detained after charging tourist \$1,900 for ashtray.' The tourist initially was told the price was 145 (unclear currency), and when he said he had no cash, 'he reluctantly remembered he had a credit card machine and promptly charged me \$145 instead of 145 shekels' — though...

■ Red Flags

- Prices in a shop are not clearly labeled or are quoted verbally without specifying the currency
- The shop owner quickly produces a credit card machine after you express interest
- The price quoted seems reasonable in one currency but would be extremely high in another
- You are told there is a 'special price' just for you that is not posted anywhere
- The shop does not display a business license or price list as required by Israeli consumer law

■ How to Avoid

- Always confirm prices in New Israeli Shekels (NIS) before agreeing to any purchase
 - Watch the credit card terminal screen to verify the exact amount being charged before approving
 - For art and crafts, compare prices at the Nahalat Binyamin Arts Fair where artists post prices openly
 - Request a detailed receipt showing the item description, currency, and amount before completing any transaction
 - Report overcharging to the Israel Consumer Protection Authority or call the police at *100 — Israeli law protects tourists from fraud
-

■ Jordan

■■ Amman

6 scams documented • Jordan

Yellow Taxi No-Meter Overcharge

a fifteen-minute ride that should cost under 2 JOD. The driver nods and pulls into traffic without touching the meter. When you arrive, he announces a price five times higher and refuses to budge. This is the taxi trap that is so universally reported in r/jordan that local and expat Redditors treat it as a law of the land: never take a yellow taxi without either the meter running or a firm, pre-agreed price. As u/notmercedesbenz wrote in r/jordan: 'Definitely use Uber or Careem and not the yellow taxis. My worst experiences in Jordan have been with them. Unfortunately, they will scam the he...

■ Red Flags

- Driver does not reach for the meter as soon as the car moves
- Driver refuses to confirm a price before starting the journey
- Meter is present but the driver claims it is broken or unplugged
- Driver takes a noticeably indirect route and seems unconcerned about traffic
- The quoted fare at arrival is dramatically higher than what you discussed

■ How to Avoid

- Use Careem or Uber exclusively in Amman — both have transparent fixed pricing
- If you must take a yellow taxi, agree on the exact fare in Jordanian dinars before entering
- Confirm the price again when you arrive and have exact change ready
- The official airport taxi rate is 22.5 JOD to central Amman — anything higher is overcharging
- Ask your hotel to call a trusted driver or arrange transport rather than flagging cabs

Petra Horse & Guide Bait-and-Switch

You have barely passed through the Petra visitor center when a man with two horses steps forward with a wide smile and announces that the horse ride to the Treasury is included in your ticket — free. You climb on gratefully; your feet are already aching. But when the horse stops at the main plaza and the handler helps you dismount, the friendliness evaporates. He demands 30 JOD, then follows you aggressively to the nearest ATM, breathing over your shoulder while you withdraw cash. This exact scenario was described in detail by u/Costanza-man on r/travel: 'The biggest tourist trap was easily...

■ Red Flags

- Anyone offering a free horse ride, donkey, or camel service at Petra
- A guide who sets a price but upgrades the service mid-tour and demands more
- Being directed toward an ATM machine at any point during or after a tour
- A guide or vendor who physically follows you or blocks your path
- Men dressed as characters (like Jack Sparrow) who offer free photos then demand payment

■ How to Avoid

- Politely but firmly decline any free offer at Petra — there is no such thing
- If you want the horse ride, negotiate and confirm the price before mounting

- Hire official licensed guides through the Petra Visitors Center, not touts at the gate
 - Keep to the marked pathways and avoid being led to side areas or secret spots
 - Carry only what you plan to spend in Petra — leave cards at the hotel if possible
-

Dead Sea Private Resort Fee Trap

You have driven 45 minutes from Amman to reach the Dead Sea, which you have been dreaming about since you booked this trip. A man in a reflective vest waves you toward a beach parking area and points to what appears to be a public entry. You pay the access fee he quotes — which turns out to be 15 JOD for a private beach club you did not intend to visit and cannot reasonably leave without a confrontation. The Dead Sea shoreline in Jordan is divided between hotels, private resort clubs, and a small stretch of public beach. Locals on r/jordan regularly warn that the private resort access fees ...

■ Red Flags

- A person in a vest directing cars to a parking area without clear signage of fees
- Quoted entry fee is vague about what facilities are included
- Dead Sea mud or salt products sold from roadside stalls claiming medical certification
- No printed price list is visible before you commit to parking or entry
- The fee collector avoids direct answers about who operates the facility

■ How to Avoid

- Book a specific Dead Sea resort or use the government Amman Beach facility in advance
 - Look up the official entry fee for any facility before leaving Amman
 - Never commit to a parking or entry fee until you see it printed on a sign or receipt
 - Buy Dead Sea products from established pharmacies or mall stores in Amman
 - GPS-navigate directly to your chosen beach; ignore roadside flaggers
-

Fake Closed Attraction Redirect

'Ah, you are going to the Citadel? Very sad — it is closed today for a government event. But I know a better place, my cousin's shop, very beautiful carpets.' The Citadel is, in fact, open. You know this because you checked. But many tourists do not check, and they end up in a carpet shop being pressured into overpriced purchases. The closed attraction diversion is a classic scam documented across the Middle East and referenced in multiple r/travel threads about Jordan. The scammer positions near popular sites and intercepts tourists who look uncertain. The goal is always the same: redirect...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger proactively informs you that your intended destination is closed
- The alternative they suggest involves a shop, cousin, family business, or restaurant
- The person claims special knowledge: 'my uncle works there' or 'they called this morning'
- The diversion leads away from the main street into less-trafficked areas
- You feel gently guided rather than clearly informed — the conversation feels engineered

■ How to Avoid

- Check official opening times for every attraction before leaving your hotel each morning
 - If told an attraction is closed, verify on Google Maps or the official website before changing plans
 - Politely disengage from any stranger who begins directing you away from your destination
 - Buy souvenirs from the official site shops inside attractions, not from referred shops
 - Use Jordan Pass for major sites — it also gives you better awareness of what is legitimately included
-

Wadi Rum Unofficial Bedouin Camp Fraud

the photos were beautiful, the price was reasonable, and the man who replied was charming. When the 4WD drops you at a cluster of tents that looks nothing like the photos, and the included activities turn out to cost extra, you realize you have been sold a ghost listing. Wadi Rum is genuinely spectacular but has a documented problem with unofficial operators and fake listings, especially on Instagram, Facebook Marketplace, and WhatsApp. Multiple r/jordan posts recommend booking only through the official Wadi Rum Protected Area visitor center or through platforms like SafariBookings or estab...

■ Red Flags

- Camp booking made only via Instagram DM or WhatsApp with no formal contract
- Price significantly below other verified camps on SafariBookings or TripAdvisor
- Jeep drivers at Rum Village offering last-minute deals without licensed operator badges
- Camp photos on booking look dramatically better than what you see on arrival
- Driver asks for additional payment mid-tour for activities described as included

■ How to Avoid

- Book Wadi Rum camps only through SafariBookings, GetYourGuide, or TripAdvisor-verified operators
- Confirm your booking has a physical address for the Wadi Rum Protected Area
- Ask for the camp's official license number from the Jordan Tourism Board
- Pay by credit card where possible so you have recourse if services are not delivered
- Research your specific camp name plus 'review' on TripAdvisor before committing

The Shisha Bar Bill Shock

■ ■ Bars and lounges in the Rainbow Street area, nightlife venues in Sweifieh, unmarked hookah lounges near 1st Circle, bars recommended by strangers near the Citadel You are approached by a friendly local or fellow tourist near a popular landmark who suggests ... You are approached by a friendly local or fellow tourist near a popular landmark who suggests grabbing drinks and shisha at a place they know. The venue looks legitimate, and the night seems to be going well. When the bill arrives, it is 1,000 JD or more — over 1,400 USD — for what you thought was a couple of drinks and a hookah session. Reddit users on r/Amman report this exact scenario, with a Ukrainian tourist sharing that a bar tried to scam him out of 1,000+ JD after he ordered only a couple of drinks and shisha. The bars involved often have no visible menu with prices, or the menu shown to you is different from the one used to calculate the bill. Large security staff prevent you from leaving without paying. Your credit card may be charged without your consent if you hand it over to 'settle the dispute.' This scam specifically targets solo male travelers and those who follow recommendations from strangers near tourist attractions. Red Flags A stranger near a tourist site recommends a specific bar or lounge and offers to take you there personally The venue has no visible menu with prices or the staff discourage you from asking about prices before ordering The bar is below street level, accessed by elevator, or otherwise difficult to leave quickly Security guards are stationed at the door and outnumber the serving staff Attractive staff or other patrons encourage you to order expensive bottles or premium shisha blends without stating prices How to Avoid Never follow a stranger's recommendation to a bar — choose venues independently using Google Maps reviews with at least 100 ratings Always ask to see a printed menu with prices before ordering anything, and photograph it with your phone as evidence Stick to well-established venues along Rainbow Street and Abdali Boulevard that are reviewed on TripAdvisor and Google Never hand over your credit card to settle a dispute — offer to call the tourist police at 110 instead If you feel threatened or trapped, call the Jordanian Tourist Police directly at 110 or the general emergency number 911 ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Public Security Directorate (PSD) station. Call 911. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at psd.gov.jo. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Amman is at Al-Umayyaweene Street, Abdoun, Amman. For emergencies: +962 6-590-6000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Jordan ■ ■

You are approached by a friendly local or fellow tourist near a popular landmark who suggests grabbing drinks and shisha at a place they know. The venue looks legitimate, and the night seems to be going well. When the bill arrives, it is 1,000 JD or more — over 1,400 USD — for what you thought was a couple of drinks and a

hookah session. Reddit users on r/Amman report this exact scenario, with a Ukrainian tourist sharing that a bar tried to scam him out of 1,000+ JD after he ordered only a couple of drinks and shisha. The bars involved often have no visible menu with prices, or the menu sho...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger near a tourist site recommends a specific bar or lounge and offers to take you there personally
- The venue has no visible menu with prices or the staff discourage you from asking about prices before ordering
- The bar is below street level, accessed by elevator, or otherwise difficult to leave quickly
- Security guards are stationed at the door and outnumber the serving staff
- Attractive staff or other patrons encourage you to order expensive bottles or premium shisha blends without stating prices

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow a stranger's recommendation to a bar — choose venues independently using Google Maps reviews with at least 100 ratings
 - Always ask to see a printed menu with prices before ordering anything, and photograph it with your phone as evidence
 - Stick to well-established venues along Rainbow Street and Abdali Boulevard that are reviewed on TripAdvisor and Google
 - Never hand over your credit card to settle a dispute — offer to call the tourist police at 110 instead
 - If you feel threatened or trapped, call the Jordanian Tourist Police directly at 110 or the general emergency number 911
-

■■ Petra

6 scams documented • Jordan

The 'Free' Animal Ride

You enjoy the ride and the views, but when you try to dismount, the handler demands a hefty payment — sometimes \$50 or more — and blocks your path until you pay. Refusing causes a scene, and tourists often feel trapped and unsafe. The word 'free' was never meant honestly.

■ Red Flags

- Anyone offering a 'free' or 'gift' ride unprompted
- No price discussed before mounting the animal
- Handler insists you try the animal 'just for a photo'
- Never accept any ride without agreeing on a price first, in writing if possible
- Politely but firmly decline all unsolicited 'free' offers

■ How to Avoid

- Never accept any ride without agreeing on a price first, in writing if possible
 - Politely but firmly decline all unsolicited 'free' offers
 - Walk the trails yourself — the distances are very manageable
-

Unofficial Guide Overcharge

He seems knowledgeable and walks with you for an hour, pointing out carvings and telling stories. At the end he asks for \$80 for the 'guide fee' — far above the official rate. There was no agreement made upfront, and he now claims it's standard.

■ Red Flags

- Guide approaches you near the entrance without an official badge
- No price discussed before the tour begins
- Pressure to 'just come look' before any commitment is made
- Only hire guides who are officially licensed and wear visible ID
- Book tours through your hotel or the official Petra visitor center

■ How to Avoid

- Only hire guides who are officially licensed and wear visible ID
 - Book tours through your hotel or the official Petra visitor center
 - Agree on the exact price and duration before starting
-

Bedouin Romance Scam

A charming Bedouin man invites you for tea in his cave dwelling, becoming increasingly flirtatious and attentive over your visit. Over days he builds what feels like a genuine connection, talking about love and a future together. Eventually he asks for money — for a visa, a sick relative, or a business venture. Women have lost thousands of dollars and even moved to Jordan before realizing the relationship was a practiced performance.

■ Red Flags

- Very fast emotional intimacy from a local man toward solo female travelers
- Requests for money, gifts, or help with visa applications
- Elaborate personal stories involving tragedy or hardship
- Be cautious of fast-moving romantic interest from vendors inside Petra
- Never send money to someone you met recently while traveling

■ How to Avoid

- Be cautious of fast-moving romantic interest from vendors inside Petra
 - Never send money to someone you met recently while traveling
 - Search Facebook groups like 'Stop the Petra Bedouin Women Scammers' for documented cases
-

The Inflated Taxi/Transport Package

Along the way he changes the terms — the hotel he promised isn't available so he takes you to his 'cousin's' guesthouse at triple the price, and he refuses to drive on until you pay for accommodation you never agreed to. Some drivers hold tourists' luggage hostage until they comply.

■ Red Flags

- Driver insists on booking your accommodation as part of the deal
- Price changes mid-journey with various excuses
- Driver deviates from the agreed route
- Book transport through your hotel or a verified app like Careem
- Never let a driver book accommodation for you

■ How to Avoid

- Book transport through your hotel or a verified app like Careem
 - Never let a driver book accommodation for you
 - Use JETT bus for Amman-to-Petra to avoid taxi scams entirely
-

Overpriced Goods with No Fixed Prices

He looks you up and down and quotes a price five times what it's worth, watching to see if you flinch. Everything is negotiable and tourists are always quoted a 'tourist price' first. Without knowing local rates, you can easily

overpay massively.

■ Red Flags

- No prices displayed on any items
- Vendor asks where you're from before quoting a price
- Price drops dramatically the moment you walk away
- Always bargain — starting at 30-40% of the first quoted price is normal
- Check prices at multiple stalls before committing

■ How to Avoid

- Always bargain — starting at 30-40% of the first quoted price is normal
 - Check prices at multiple stalls before committing
 - Learn a few phrases in Arabic — vendors respect the effort and quote more fairly
-

Hidden Photo Spot Entry Fee

■ ■ *High Place of Sacrifice and monastery viewpoints* You're told by a local that there's an incredible secret viewpoint just off the main trail, and he ... You're told by a local that there's an incredible secret viewpoint just off the main trail, and he guides you there enthusiastically. Once at the top, he or an associate blocks the viewpoint and demands payment for 'access' to this private land. The viewpoint may or may not be worth it, but the fee was never disclosed. **Red Flags** Anyone directing you off the main marked trails No official signage at the entrance to the viewpoint Person lingers after showing you the spot **How to Avoid** Stick to official Petra trails marked on the site map Download offline maps of the archaeological site before entering Agree on any fee before following someone off the beaten path ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Public Security Directorate (PSD) station. Call 911. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at psd.gov.jo. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Embassy in Amman is at Al-Umayyaween Street, Abdoun, Amman. For emergencies: +962 6-590-6000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **Frequently Asked Questions** Is Petra safe for tourists? ▼

You're told by a local that there's an incredible secret viewpoint just off the main trail, and he guides you there enthusiastically. Once at the top, he or an associate blocks the viewpoint and demands payment for 'access' to this private land. The viewpoint may or may not be worth it, but the fee was never disclosed.

■ Red Flags

- Anyone directing you off the main marked trails
- No official signage at the entrance to the viewpoint
- Person lingers after showing you the spot
- Stick to official Petra trails marked on the site map
- Download offline maps of the archaeological site before entering

■ How to Avoid

- Stick to official Petra trails marked on the site map
 - Download offline maps of the archaeological site before entering
 - Agree on any fee before following someone off the beaten path
-

■ Lebanon

■ ■ Beirut

Taxi Overcharging and Airport Rip-Off

You exit Beirut's Rafic Hariri International Airport and are immediately surrounded by taxi drivers shouting destinations and waving. You ask one how much to get to Hamra. He says '\$50.' Another says '\$40.' You agree to the \$40 ride, thinking you negotiated well. The trip takes 15 minutes covering about 10 kilometers. Later, you learn the fair price is \$10-15, and locals using the same route pay even less. Taxi overcharging is the most documented tourist scam in Beirut. TravelScams.org's Lebanon page notes that 'taxis in Lebanon do not use meters, so inflated fares can be quoted if you have...

■ Red Flags

- Multiple drivers aggressively compete for your business at the airport exit — this is a marketplace, not a regulated taxi rank
- The driver quotes a price in US dollars rather than Lebanese lira — a tactic to maximize the fare from foreign tourists
- There is no meter in the vehicle, or the driver claims the meter is broken or 'not needed for airport trips'
- The quoted price is \$30-70 for a trip within Beirut — most trips between neighborhoods should cost \$5-15
- The driver takes an unnecessarily long route through Beirut's notoriously congested streets to justify a higher fare

■ How to Avoid

- Pre-arrange airport pickup through your hotel — most hotels in Beirut offer shuttle services at fixed, reasonable rates
- Use the Bolt or Uber app, which work in Beirut and show transparent fare estimates before you confirm the ride
- Research approximate taxi fares before arrival: airport to Hamra should be \$10-15, airport to Gemmayzeh \$12-18, airport to Downtown \$8-12
- For city trips, agree on a price before getting in the car and confirm whether it is in USD or Lebanese lira
- Use the 'service' (shared taxi) system for short trips within the city — a service ride on a fixed route costs about 100,000 LBP (\$1-2)

Currency Exchange and Counterfeit Bill Scam

At your hotel, the rate is 89,500 LBP per dollar. A man on Hamra Street offers 91,000 — a seemingly better deal. You hand over \$300. He counts out stacks of worn lira notes with impressive speed, fanning them for you to verify. Back at your hotel, you discover you received only about \$240 worth of lira — several high-denomination notes were palmed during the rapid counting. Two of the 100,000 LBP notes feel wrong. They are counterfeit. Lebanon's currency crisis has created a complex exchange landscape that scammers exploit. Al Jazeera published an investigation titled 'Like a drug deal: Ins...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you on the street offering to exchange money at a better rate than banks or exchange offices
- The exchanger counts money extremely quickly with elaborate hand movements and discourages you from recounting
- The transaction takes place on the street, in a doorway, or in any location that is not a licensed exchange office
- Some bills in the bundle feel different in texture, weight, or color compared to others — these may be counterfeit
- The exchanger adds a surprise 'commission' or 'fee' after the exchange is supposedly complete

■ How to Avoid

- Exchange money only at licensed exchange offices (sarrafs) or withdraw from ATMs at banks like Banque du Liban, BLOM Bank, or Bank Audi
- Since 2024, the official bank rate matches the market rate — there is no longer an advantage to exchanging on the street
- Always count your money carefully at the counter before walking away, and check each bill for security features

- Familiarize yourself with Lebanese lira denominations and security features before arriving — the Central Bank website has images
 - Carry US dollars for larger transactions (hotels, high-end restaurants often price in USD) and exchange only what you need for daily expenses
-

Fake Tour Guide Scam

You are standing at Martyrs' Square, photographing the bullet-riddled statue, when a well-dressed man approaches speaking excellent English. He says he is a university professor and history enthusiast who loves sharing Beirut's story with visitors. He offers to walk you through the city for free — 'just for the pleasure of conversation.' Over the next two hours, he takes you to interesting spots but also to specific shops where he gets commission on your purchases. At the end, he asks for a 'small donation for his time' — suggesting \$50-100. When you offer \$10, he becomes aggressive and acc...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you at a tourist site and offers a free or very cheap guided tour — they will expect significant payment later
- The 'guide' takes you to specific shops, restaurants, or services where they clearly have a relationship with the owner
- They cannot show you an official guide license from the Lebanese Ministry of Tourism when asked
- The tour seems improvised rather than following a structured itinerary, and historical information may be inaccurate
- At the end, a 'donation' is requested that is far higher than what was implied (or nothing was discussed upfront)

■ How to Avoid

- Book guided tours through your hotel, a licensed tour company, or platforms like GetYourGuide and Viator with transparent pricing
 - If someone offers to show you around, agree on an exact price before starting — get it in writing or text if possible
 - Ask to see an official guide license from the Ministry of Tourism — licensed guides will have credentials readily available
 - Decline to enter shops that the 'guide' recommends unless you independently planned to visit them — these are commission stops
 - Research Beirut's history using free audio guides or apps before your visit so you can spot inaccurate information
-

Overpriced Tourist Menu at Restaurants

The waiter brings an English menu. A mezze platter is listed at \$25, hummus at \$12, a cocktail at \$18. You order a spread for two and the bill comes to \$120. What you did not realize is that the Arabic menu at the next table shows the same mezze platter at \$15, the hummus at \$7, and cocktails at \$12. Additionally, a 15% service charge and a 'live music' surcharge were added to your bill without disclosure. Restaurant overcharging is documented across Beirut travel guides. TheWorldTravelIndex.com's Beirut safety section specifically warns about 'restaurants that add hidden charges to your bi...

■ Red Flags

- You are given a separate English menu while Arabic-speaking diners receive a different menu — compare prices if possible
- Prices are not listed on the menu, or the menu shows only dish names and descriptions without costs
- Extra charges appear on the bill — service charges, live music fees, bread charges, or cover charges not mentioned when you sat down
- The waiter recommends specific items without mentioning their price — these are often the highest-margin dishes
- The restaurant is on a main tourist strip (Rue Gouraud, Armenia Street) with prominent English-language signage and aggressive hosts outside

■ How to Avoid

- Ask for a menu with prices before sitting down — if the menu has no prices, request them verbally for each item you consider ordering
- Ask explicitly whether a service charge is included before ordering, and whether there are any cover charges or surcharges
- Check Google Maps and TripAdvisor reviews for specific pricing complaints before choosing a restaurant
- Eat where locals eat — walk one or two blocks off the main Gemmayzeh and Mar Mikhael strips for authentic restaurants at fair prices
- If you suspect dual pricing, politely ask for the Arabic menu or compare your menu with what other tables received

ATM Approach and Card Skimming Scam

You are using an ATM on Hamra Street when a friendly man approaches and says he can help you 'avoid the local bank fees.' He offers to show you which buttons to press for the best exchange rate. While seemingly helping, he watches you enter your PIN and may have a card skimmer in his pocket that he brushes against your card. Three days later, unauthorized transactions appear on your account from across Lebanon. ATM-related scams in Beirut follow the same pattern documented across the Middle East and Latin America. WikiForTravel's Beirut scam guide specifically describes the scenario: 'Someo...

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you while you are using or about to use an ATM, offering help or advice
- The ATM card slot feels loose, bulky, or has an attachment that does not match the rest of the machine
- Someone is standing unusually close or positioned where they could see your PIN entry
- The ATM is in an isolated location without security cameras or bank staff nearby
- Your card gets 'stuck' in the machine and a helpful bystander suggests entering your PIN again to retrieve it

■ How to Avoid

- Use ATMs inside bank branches during business hours only — BLOM Bank, Bank Audi, and Byblos Bank have secure indoor ATMs
- Always cover the keypad completely with your hand when entering your PIN, even if no one appears to be watching
- Never accept help from strangers at an ATM — if the machine is not working, go to a different one inside a bank
- Check the card slot and keypad for loose parts, extra attachments, or anything that looks different from normal before inserting your card
- Enable transaction notifications on your banking app and set daily withdrawal limits before traveling to Lebanon

Souvenir and Antique Overpricing in the Souks

■ ■ *Beirut Souks (Downtown), Byblos Old Souk, Saifi Village galleries, and antique shops in the Gemmayzeh area* You are browsing the restored Beirut Souks downtown and find a beautiful brass tray that the vendor ... You are browsing the restored Beirut Souks downtown and find a beautiful brass tray that the vendor calls 'Ottoman-era antique.' He quotes \$300. You negotiate down to \$200 and feel good about the deal. Back home, you discover it is a modern reproduction worth about \$30 — mass-produced in Turkey and aged artificially with chemicals. Similarly, a shop in Byblos sells 'genuine Phoenician' artifacts at prices ranging from \$50 to \$500 — all of which are reproductions sold as authentic. Lebanon has a well-documented counterfeit antiques market. A detailed numismatic study published on Snible.org examined coins purchased at the Byblos Antique Shop and found that 'all three Byzantine gold solidus coins examined were forgeries,' with one fake 'so thin and malleable that it could be folded double with the fingers.' The study noted that Lebanon has a flourishing counterfeiting industry, with fakes produced locally and imported from Turkey, Syria, Greece, and Egypt. Beyond coins, the problem extends to 'antique' brassware, textiles, pottery, and jewelry sold across tourist areas. Some vendors operate honestly and price reproductions accordingly, but others deliberately misrepresent modern factory items as centuries-old antiques. The practice is especially prevalent in Byblos, where tourists expecting to find genuine Phoenician artifacts are easy targets. **Red Flags** The vendor describes an item as an 'antique' from the Ottoman, Phoenician, or Roman period but cannot provide provenance documentation The price has been dramatically reduced from the initial asking price — genuine antiques do not drop 70% in negotiation Multiple 'identical' antiques are available — real antiques are one-of-a-kind, not produced in sets The aging on the item looks artificial — uniform patina, chemical darkening, or

machine-made wear patterns The shop is in a heavy tourist zone and the vendor specifically targets foreign visitors while ignoring local customers How to Avoid Assume all 'antiques' in tourist areas are reproductions unless you have expert knowledge — buy them because you like them, not because they are 'genuine' If you want authentic Lebanese craftsmanship, visit established galleries and cooperatives like the Lebanese Artisan Association or L'Artisan du Liban For any purchase over \$100, ask for a written authenticity certificate and the vendor's business registration — legitimate dealers provide these Be aware that exporting genuine antiquities from Lebanon is illegal without a government permit — if a vendor offers to ship an 'antique' with no paperwork, it is either fake or illegal Shop at fixed-price stores in Saifi Village or Beirut Souks for quality Lebanese souvenirs at transparent prices ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Internal Security Forces (ISF / Quwwa al-Amn ad-Dakhili) station. Call 112. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at isf.gov.lb. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Embassy in Beirut at Awkar, facing the Municipality. Phone: +961-4-542-600. For after-hours emergencies: +961-4-543-600. Other nationalities should check their embassy or consulate location in the Beirut area. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. Frequently Asked Questions Is Beirut safe for tourists right now? ▼

You are browsing the restored Beirut Souks downtown and find a beautiful brass tray that the vendor calls 'Ottoman-era antique.' He quotes \$300. You negotiate down to \$200 and feel good about the deal. Back home, you discover it is a modern reproduction worth about \$30 — mass-produced in Turkey and aged artificially with chemicals. Similarly, a shop in Byblos sells 'genuine Phoenician' artifacts at prices ranging from \$50 to \$500 — all of which are reproductions sold as authentic. Lebanon has a well-documented counterfeit antiques market. A detailed numismatic study published on Snible.org ...

■ Red Flags

- The vendor describes an item as an 'antique' from the Ottoman, Phoenician, or Roman period but cannot provide provenance documentation
- The price has been dramatically reduced from the initial asking price — genuine antiques do not drop 70% in negotiation
- Multiple 'identical' antiques are available — real antiques are one-of-a-kind, not produced in sets
- The aging on the item looks artificial — uniform patina, chemical darkening, or machine-made wear patterns
- The shop is in a heavy tourist zone and the vendor specifically targets foreign visitors while ignoring local customers

■ How to Avoid

- Assume all 'antiques' in tourist areas are reproductions unless you have expert knowledge — buy them because you like them, not because they are 'genuine'
- If you want authentic Lebanese craftsmanship, visit established galleries and cooperatives like the Lebanese Artisan Association or L'Artisan du Liban
- For any purchase over \$100, ask for a written authenticity certificate and the vendor's business registration — legitimate dealers provide these
- Be aware that exporting genuine antiquities from Lebanon is illegal without a government permit — if a vendor offers to ship an 'antique' with no paperwork, it is either fake or illegal
- Shop at fixed-price stores in Saifi Village or Beirut Souks for quality Lebanese souvenirs at transparent prices

■ Oman

■ Muscat

5 scams documented • Oman

The No-Meter Taxi Swindle

The driver quotes 10 OMR — which sounds like nothing until you realize 10 OMR is roughly \$26 USD. The actual fair price for this common tourist route is 3-5 OMR. Since most Muscat taxis do not have meters, every ride requires negotiation, and drivers around major tourist sites consistently quote prices 2-3x the fair rate. The Atlas Guide's Oman scam guide confirms that 'taxi drivers in Muscat, particularly around Muttrah Corniche and the Sultan Qaboos Grand Mosque, refuse to use meters and quote fixed fares that are 2-3 times higher, such as 10 OMR for a 5 OMR ride to Old Muscat.' GoDigit's...

■ Red Flags

- The driver quotes a fare without you asking — proactive pricing almost always means overcharging
- The quoted price in OMR sounds low numerically but converts to \$20+ USD for a short urban ride
- The driver refuses to discuss the route or claims there is 'only one way' to reach your destination
- The taxi has no meter, no official markings, or the driver is not wearing any identification
- Other taxis at the same stand are quoting similar inflated prices — tourist site taxi ranks are coordinated

■ How to Avoid

- Use ride-hailing apps (OTaxi, Marhaba, or Uber) which show routes and prices transparently before you confirm
 - If taking a street taxi, research the approximate fare on Google Maps before flagging one down — most Muscat rides cost 2-5 OMR
 - Negotiate firmly before getting in and walk away if the price is not reasonable — another taxi will come
 - Ask your hotel for a recommended taxi driver or company — many hotels keep a list of trusted drivers with fair rates
 - Remember the OMR conversion: 1 OMR = \$2.60 USD — a 10 OMR ride is \$26, which helps calibrate whether a fare is reasonable
-

Muttrah Souq Price Inflation and Fake Antiques

The shopkeeper tells you the one you are admiring is a genuine antique — 'my grandfather's,' he claims — priced at 75 OMR (\$195 USD). It is actually a modern replica made in India worth about 10 OMR. At a silver jewelry stall further in, a vendor weighs a bracelet and tries to charge you the silver-per-ounce price for the decorative stone set into it, exploiting the language barrier when questioned. Muttrah Souq is Muscat's top tourist attraction and its most active haggling ground. One TripAdvisor review titled 'Overpriced junk, rude people, NOT a true Omani experience' describes it as 'th...

■ Red Flags

- A vendor claims an item is a family heirloom, antique, or one-of-a-kind — in a tourist market, it almost certainly is not
- The initial price is quoted in round numbers with no itemization — '75 OMR for the dagger' with no breakdown
- A 'certificate of authenticity' is offered — fake certificates for fake antiques are part of the scam
- The vendor follows you out of his shop or creates a crowd of helpers to pressure a quick purchase
- Prices are quoted per weight (gram/ounce) for items where the decorative elements are clearly more valuable than the metal

■ How to Avoid

- Never buy 'antiques' in a tourist souq — genuine Omani antiquities are sold through licensed dealers, not market stalls
 - Research typical prices before visiting: frankincense (1-3 OMR), silver bracelets (5-15 OMR), pashminas (3-8 OMR)
 - Negotiate down to at least 40-50% of the first quoted price — starting high is expected and not considered rude
 - Walk the entire souq before buying anything — seeing multiple stalls helps you understand fair pricing
 - For genuine Omani crafts, visit the Omani Heritage Gallery or government-sponsored artisan shops where prices are fixed
-

Unauthorized Grand Mosque 'Tour Guide'

You arrive at the Sultan Qaboos Grand Mosque and are approached in the parking lot by a man in traditional Omani dress who introduces himself as a 'mosque guide.' He offers to show you the mosque's highlights and explain the Islamic art and architecture — 'just a small donation at the end.' The tour is informative, and he takes you to shops he knows in the area afterward for 'the best frankincense' and 'authentic Omani coffee.' At the end, he demands 30-50 OMR (\$78-130 USD) and becomes aggressive when you offer less. The shops he took you to are commission-based tourist traps. The Atlas Gui...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you outside the mosque offering tour services — the mosque's own guides are available inside for free
- They mention a 'donation' or 'whatever you feel is fair' instead of stating a clear price upfront
- The tour includes stops at shops, restaurants, or other businesses — legitimate mosque guides stay within the mosque grounds
- They are not wearing any official identification badge from the mosque or the Ministry of Tourism
- They follow you or approach persistently even after you decline

■ How to Avoid

- Use the mosque's own free guided tours available through the visitor center — they are conducted by knowledgeable, official volunteers
- Politely decline any offers from people in the parking lot or entrance area — 'No thank you, I have a guide already'
- Research the mosque's visiting hours and tour schedule on the official website before arriving
- If you want a private guide, book one through your hotel or a Ministry of Tourism-licensed agency
- Enter the mosque directly through the main visitor entrance without stopping to engage with anyone in the parking area

Desert Safari Bait and Switch

it promises dune bashing, a camel ride, a traditional Bedouin camp dinner, and stargazing. On the day, the vehicle is an older SUV with bald tires. The 'dune bashing' lasts 10 minutes before the driver says it is too dangerous to continue. The camel ride is a 5-minute walk in a circle. Dinner is plain rice and grilled chicken, not the advertised feast. And when you ask about stargazing, you are told the camp generator lights make it impossible. There is no refund. GoDigit's Oman tourist scam guide warns to 'seek help from reliable locals or trustworthy travel agents regarding selecting tour...

■ Red Flags

- The price is significantly lower than established operators — legitimate Wahiba Sands tours start at 50-70 OMR per person
- The operator has no presence on TripAdvisor, Google Reviews, or GetYourGuide — only a website or social media page
- The booking confirmation is vague about specifics: vehicle type, camp name, meal details, or activity durations
- Payment is required in full upfront with no cancellation or refund policy stated
- The operator cannot provide references, their tourism license number, or details about their guides' qualifications

■ How to Avoid

- Book desert safaris through established operators with strong TripAdvisor ratings — Arabian Desert Tours, Desert Discovery Tours, and Oman Safari Tours are well-reviewed
 - Ask for specifics before booking: What vehicle? Which camp? What is on the dinner menu? How long is each activity?
 - Read the most recent reviews (last 3 months) on TripAdvisor, filtering for the exact tour you are considering
 - Pay a deposit only and settle the balance after the safari — legitimate operators will accept this arrangement
 - Book through your hotel's tour desk for curated, vetted experiences — they protect their reputation by recommending reliable partners
-

The Car Rental Deposit Vanish

■ ■ Muscat International Airport rental counters, independent car rental offices in Al Qurum and Ruwi, and online rental brokers You rent a car at Muscat airport, paying a 150-200 OMR (around 400-500 USD) cash deposit. Upon return, the agent claims damage you did not cause and withholds part or all of your deposit. Multiple Reddit users on r/Oman reported exactly this -- a tourist police thread described trying to recover a deposit from a rental company that stopped responding to emails. TripAdvisor threads warn specifically against certain operators at Muscat Airport who charge for phantom damage. The cash deposit structure, common in Oman, gives the rental company leverage since disputing a withheld cash deposit from abroad is nearly impossible. **Red Flags** The rental company insists on a cash deposit rather than a credit card hold The agent rushes through the vehicle inspection at pickup and discourages you from documenting the car's condition The rental agreement is vague about what constitutes chargeable damage versus normal wear Upon return, the agent points out scratches or dents that were present at pickup The company has negative reviews on TripAdvisor or Google specifically mentioning deposit disputes **How to Avoid** Rent from internationally recognized companies like Europcar, Hertz, or Budget where disputes can be escalated globally Use a credit card for the deposit rather than cash -- credit card companies can dispute charges on your behalf Take timestamped video of the entire car exterior and interior at both pickup and return, including the odometer Insist on a signed condition report at pickup noting every existing scratch, dent, and mark If the deposit is withheld unfairly, file a complaint with the Royal Oman Police tourist assistance line ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Royal Oman Police station. Call 9999 (Police) or 9999 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at rop.gov.om. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact the US Embassy in Muscat at PCRS, Way 3007, Al Sarooj. For emergencies: +968 2464-3400. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides Popular Nearby Destinations** ■ ■

Upon return, the agent claims damage you did not cause and withholds part or all of your deposit. Multiple Reddit users on r/Oman reported exactly this -- a tourist police thread described trying to recover a deposit from a rental company that stopped responding to emails. TripAdvisor threads warn specifically against certain operators at Muscat Airport who charge for phantom damage. The cash deposit structure, common in Oman, gives the rental company leverage since disputing a withheld cash deposit from abroad is nearly impossible.

■ Red Flags

- The rental company insists on a cash deposit rather than a credit card hold
- The agent rushes through the vehicle inspection at pickup and discourages you from documenting the car's condition
- The rental agreement is vague about what constitutes chargeable damage versus normal wear
- Upon return, the agent points out scratches or dents that were present at pickup
- The company has negative reviews on TripAdvisor or Google specifically mentioning deposit disputes

■ How to Avoid

- Rent from internationally recognized companies like Europcar, Hertz, or Budget where disputes can be escalated globally
 - Use a credit card for the deposit rather than cash -- credit card companies can dispute charges on your behalf
 - Take timestamped video of the entire car exterior and interior at both pickup and return, including the odometer
 - Insist on a signed condition report at pickup noting every existing scratch, dent, and mark
 - If the deposit is withheld unfairly, file a complaint with the Royal Oman Police tourist assistance line
-

■ Qatar

■ ■ Doha

5 scams documented • Qatar

Taxi Meter Manipulation and Airport Overcharge

The driver greets you warmly but doesn't start the meter. When you arrive, he quotes 150 Qatari riyals for a trip that should cost 40-50 QAR by meter. When you point this out, he claims there's a flat rate from the airport, or that his meter is broken, or that the tariff changed. Without knowledge of local fares, you pay. TripAdvisor's Doha forum has a dedicated thread titled 'Feedback on taxis in Doha' documenting this pattern. GoDigit's Qatar tourist scam guide and ILoveQatar.net both list taxi overcharging as the most frequent tourist scam in the country. The tactics include refusing to ...

■ Red Flags

- The driver does not start the meter when the journey begins or claims it is broken
- The meter appears to already have a fare on it from a 'previous passenger'
- The vehicle lacks a yellow license plate with the letter 'T' or has no tariff sticker on the side windows
- The driver takes an unfamiliar route that seems longer than necessary
- At the end of the ride, the driver claims he has no change for your large bill

■ How to Avoid

- Use the Doha Metro for airport transfers and major destinations — it connects the airport to West Bay and Souq Waqif area for just 2 QAR
 - Use Uber or Careem apps for transparent, pre-quoted fares with GPS tracking and digital payment
 - If taking a taxi, insist the meter is running and verify it starts from the base fare (currently 4 QAR daytime)
 - Check that the taxi has a yellow 'T' license plate and a tariff sticker visible on the side windows
 - If the driver doesn't turn on the meter, you are not legally obligated to pay — state this calmly and offer to call the police
-

Souq Waqif Counterfeit Goods and Pearl Fraud

You're browsing Souq Waqif and stop at a jewelry stall where the vendor shows you what he says are 'authentic Qatari natural pearls' — a symbol of the country's heritage. He quotes a price of 2,000 QAR for a necklace, saying it's a special deal. What you're actually holding are cultured pearls imported from Southeast Asia worth a fraction of that price. A genuine Qatari natural pearl typically costs between 5,000 and 30,000 QAR and is only available from a handful of specialized collectors and traders. Pearl-Guide.com has a dedicated thread titled 'Qatar Natural Pearl Fraud — Buyer Beware' ...

■ Red Flags

- A vendor claims pearls are 'authentic Qatari natural pearls' at a price below 5,000 QAR — genuine ones start much higher
- Designer brand goods (bags, watches, perfumes) are sold at prices far below retail — they are almost certainly counterfeit
- The vendor cannot provide a certificate of authenticity or refuses to let you examine goods closely
- Gold jewelry finishing looks rough or stones lack sparkle compared to genuine precious gems
- The vendor pressures you to buy immediately, claiming the item is rare or the price is 'today only'

■ How to Avoid

- Buy pearls only from established, reputable dealers who provide certificates of authenticity — not from market stalls
 - Purchase gold from shops in the Gold Souq that display official certifications and provide stamped receipts with karat weight
 - Ask for receipts and authenticity certificates for any expensive purchase — legitimate shops always provide them
 - Compare prices across multiple vendors before buying and research typical prices online beforehand
 - For designer goods, only buy from authorized retailers in malls like Villaggio, City Center, or The Pearl-Qatar
-

Friendly Bar Lure and Inflated Bill

often attractive and well-dressed — start chatting with you. After some pleasant conversation, they suggest moving to a different bar they know nearby. You follow them to a dimly lit lounge where drinks are ordered and the conversation continues. When the bill arrives, it's 2,000-3,000 QAR for what you thought were a few drinks. Your 'new friends' have disappeared, and a large security guard is standing between you and the door. GoDigit's Qatar tourist scam guide specifically describes this scenario: 'Two friendly girls or guys make small talk and lead you to believe there is mutual interes...

■ Red Flags

- Attractive strangers at a hotel bar initiate unusually friendly conversation and quickly suggest moving to another venue
- The suggested venue is one you haven't heard of and isn't listed on Google Maps or TripAdvisor with credible reviews
- The bar or lounge has no visible menu with prices displayed or the menu seems surprisingly cheap
- Your new acquaintances order freely and seem unconcerned about the cost
- When the bill arrives, it includes charges for items or services you never agreed to

■ How to Avoid

- Stay at established, well-reviewed hotel bars rather than following strangers to unfamiliar venues
- Always check the menu prices before ordering anything at a new bar — if there's no menu, leave immediately
- Be cautious of strangers who are overly friendly and quickly suggest changing location — this is a classic setup
- Pay for your own drinks as you go rather than running a tab that could be inflated later
- If presented with an outrageous bill, calmly dispute it, refuse to pay for items you didn't order, and threaten to call the police (999)

Fake Tour Guide and Desert Safari Scam

Your hotel concierge is unavailable, so you book a desert safari through a man distributing flyers in the Souq Waqif area. He promises a full-day experience — dune bashing, camel ride, dinner under the stars — for 300 QAR per person, well below the 500-700 QAR that established operators charge. You pay in full upfront. The next morning, a beat-up SUV arrives with bald tires and no safety equipment. The 'desert safari' is two hours of driving to a spot where you sit on a mat for 30 minutes before being driven back. No dinner, no camel, no dunes. TripAdvisor's Doha forum includes reviews of '...

■ Red Flags

- The price is significantly below what established operators charge — 40-50% cheaper is a major warning sign
- The operator has no website, physical office, or verifiable online reviews
- They insist on full cash payment upfront or payment via WhatsApp/bank transfer with no invoice
- Flyers are distributed by hand in tourist areas rather than being available through hotels or licensed agencies
- They cannot provide a license number from the Qatar National Tourism Council

■ How to Avoid

- Book desert safaris through your hotel concierge, a licensed tour operator, or platforms like Viator and GetYourGuide with buyer protection
- Verify the operator has a physical office and check reviews on TripAdvisor and Google before booking
- Never pay the full amount upfront in cash — use a credit card for fraud protection
- Ask for the operator's Qatar National Tourism Council license number and verify it before paying
- Compare prices across at least three established operators — a typical quality desert safari costs 450-700 QAR per person

The Miracle Oil Sales Pitch

■ ■ Around Souq Waqif, Corniche promenade, near mosques in the Diplomatic Area While strolling near Souq Waqif, a friendly stranger approaches with small vials of oil, claiming ... While strolling near Souq Waqif, a friendly stranger

approaches with small vials of oil, claiming they have miraculous healing properties -- curing joint pain, skin conditions, or even bringing good luck. They offer a free sample dab on your wrist, then launch into a sales pitch for bottles priced at 200-500 QAR. The oils are ordinary fragrance or cooking oils repackaged in ornate bottles. As r/qatar users caution, this scam targets tourists in areas around Souq Waqif and the Corniche, especially during evening hours when foot traffic is highest.

Red Flags A stranger approaches you unprompted with vials of oil They claim the oil has medicinal or spiritual healing properties A free sample is offered before any price is discussed The oils are in unlabeled or handwritten bottles with no ingredient list They become persistent or follow you if you decline the first time

How to Avoid Politely decline any unsolicited product demonstrations on the street Buy fragrances and oils from established shops inside Souq Waqif instead If something sounds too good to be true medically, it certainly is Do not let anyone apply any product to your skin without knowing what it is Walk into a nearby shop if someone follows you persistently

■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Ministry of Interior — Qatar Police station. Call 999. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at Ministry of Interior Portal / Metrash2 App. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Report to the nearest police station and file a report through the Metrash2 app, then contact your country's embassy immediately. Tourism hotline: 106. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead.

Frequently Asked Questions Is Doha safe for tourists? ▼

While strolling near Souq Waqif, a friendly stranger approaches with small vials of oil, claiming they have miraculous healing properties -- curing joint pain, skin conditions, or even bringing good luck. They offer a free sample dab on your wrist, then launch into a sales pitch for bottles priced at 200-500 QAR. The oils are ordinary fragrance or cooking oils repackaged in ornate bottles. As r/qatar users caution, this scam targets tourists in areas around Souq Waqif and the Corniche, especially during evening hours when foot traffic is highest.

■ Red Flags

- A stranger approaches you unprompted with vials of oil
- They claim the oil has medicinal or spiritual healing properties
- A free sample is offered before any price is discussed
- The oils are in unlabeled or handwritten bottles with no ingredient list
- They become persistent or follow you if you decline the first time

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline any unsolicited product demonstrations on the street
- Buy fragrances and oils from established shops inside Souq Waqif instead
- If something sounds too good to be true medically, it certainly is
- Do not let anyone apply any product to your skin without knowing what it is
- Walk into a nearby shop if someone follows you persistently

■ Saudi Arabia

■■ Dammam

4 scams documented • Saudi Arabia

The Broken Meter Taxi

A driver waves you over enthusiastically, loads your bags, and pulls away before you can check the meter. Five minutes into the ride he casually mentions, 'Meter is broken today, but I give you good price.' When you arrive at your hotel in Al Shatea, he demands 150 SAR for what should be a 40-50 SAR trip. If you protest, he points to your bags still in the trunk. As expats on Saudi forums warn, unlicensed drivers often intercept passengers

before they reach the official taxi line, and the broken meter excuse is how the overcharging begins.

■ Red Flags

- Driver approaches you before you reach the official taxi queue
- The meter is conveniently broken or not turned on
- Driver loads your luggage before discussing the fare
- No visible taxi license or identification displayed on the dashboard
- Driver avoids the main road and takes a longer scenic route

■ How to Avoid

- Use Uber or Careem instead of street taxis -- both apps are widely used in Dammam and show upfront pricing
 - If taking a taxi, insist the meter is running before the car moves and refuse the ride if it is broken
 - Keep your luggage with you in the back seat rather than letting the driver put it in the trunk
 - Note the taxi number and take a photo of the driver's ID displayed on the dashboard
 - A fair airport-to-downtown Dammam fare should be 40-60 SAR by meter
-

The Fake Airport Official

You're walking through the arrivals hall at King Fahd Airport looking a bit lost when a well-dressed man approaches with an official-seeming badge. 'Welcome to Saudi Arabia! Please, let me see your passport and visa -- I need to verify your entry.' He examines your documents carefully, then says there's a small problem with your paperwork and guides you toward a waiting car outside instead of to the official taxi stand. As travel safety forums note, these imposters target confused-looking tourists and steer them toward unlicensed taxis where overcharging is guaranteed. Real immigration offi...

■ Red Flags

- Someone asks to see your passport or visa outside the official immigration checkpoint
- They wear a badge or lanyard that does not match official Saudi government credentials
- They claim there is a problem with your visa or entry paperwork
- They offer to help by leading you to a specific vehicle or driver outside
- They become pushy or insistent when you try to walk away

■ How to Avoid

- Never hand your passport to anyone outside of official immigration counters
 - Real Saudi officials do not approach tourists in the arrivals hall to check documents
 - Walk directly to the official taxi stand or ride-share pickup zone and ignore solicitors
 - If someone claims there is a visa issue, go directly to the airport information desk to verify
 - Keep your passport in a secure inner pocket and only show it at government checkpoints
-

The Gold Souk Switch

A shopkeeper invites you in for tea and shows you a stunning 21-karat gold set at what seems like a bargain price. You agree to buy and he wraps it up beautifully. Back at your hotel, you notice the pieces feel lighter than expected. As reported by Arab News and expat forums, fake gold has been a recurring problem in Saudi souks, with some vendors selling gold-plated items as solid gold, particularly to tourists and pilgrims who may not know how to verify karat markings. The piece you paid 2,000 SAR for might be worth a fraction of that.

■ Red Flags

- The price seems significantly lower than other shops for similar pieces
- The shopkeeper wraps the item quickly and discourages you from inspecting it closely
- There is no hallmark stamp or the stamp looks hand-scratched rather than machine-pressed

- The seller pressures you to pay in cash and does not offer a formal receipt with karat details
- The shop is located away from the main souk cluster with few other customers

■ How to Avoid

- Buy gold only from established shops in the main souk that display Saudi commerce ministry certificates
- Ask for a detailed receipt showing weight, karat, and the shop's commercial registration number
- Check that every piece has a proper hallmark stamp -- Saudi-sold gold must be stamped with karat purity
- Compare prices per gram with the current Saudi gold rate posted daily by major jewelry chains
- If making a large purchase, ask the shop to test the gold in front of you with an acid test kit

The Bird Dropping Distraction

■ ■ *Al Khobar Corniche and Dammam waterfront promenades* You're strolling along the Corniche in the evening, enjoying the Gulf breeze, when you feel ... You're strolling along the Corniche in the evening, enjoying the Gulf breeze, when you feel something wet land on your shoulder. You look up -- no birds in sight. Before you can react, a helpful stranger appears with tissues and cleaning spray. 'Bird dropping! Very dirty, let me help!' As he fusses over your shoulder, dabbing and wiping, his partner works your pockets or bag from the other side. By the time you realize the white paste was squirted by the first accomplice, your wallet is gone. As travelers on Middle East forums have warned, this classic distraction theft has been reported across Gulf cities including the Eastern Province. **Red Flags** A white or yellowish paste suddenly appears on your clothing with no birds overhead A stranger immediately appears with cleaning supplies ready to help The helper positions themselves very close and makes prolonged physical contact A second person hovers nearby or bumps into you during the cleaning The incident occurs in a crowded waterfront area popular with tourists **How to Avoid** If something lands on you, step away from everyone before cleaning it yourself Keep your phone and wallet in zipped front pockets or a cross-body bag when walking on the Corniche Politely decline help from strangers and move to a well-lit shop or cafe to clean up Be aware that the mess is fake -- real bird droppings do not appear on demand Travel with a companion who can watch your belongings while you deal with the distraction ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Saudi Arabian Police station. Call 999 (Police) or 911 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at moi.gov.sa. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact the US Embassy in Riyadh at PO Box 94309. For emergencies: +966 11-488-3800. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides** **More in Saudi Arabia** ■ ■

You're strolling along the Corniche in the evening, enjoying the Gulf breeze, when you feel something wet land on your shoulder. You look up -- no birds in sight. Before you can react, a helpful stranger appears with tissues and cleaning spray. 'Bird dropping! Very dirty, let me help!' As he fusses over your shoulder, dabbing and wiping, his partner works your pockets or bag from the other side. By the time you realize the white paste was squirted by the first accomplice, your wallet is gone. As travelers on Middle East forums have warned, this classic distraction theft has been reported ac...

■ Red Flags

- A white or yellowish paste suddenly appears on your clothing with no birds overhead
- A stranger immediately appears with cleaning supplies ready to help
- The helper positions themselves very close and makes prolonged physical contact
- A second person hovers nearby or bumps into you during the cleaning
- The incident occurs in a crowded waterfront area popular with tourists

■ How to Avoid

- If something lands on you, step away from everyone before cleaning it yourself
- Keep your phone and wallet in zipped front pockets or a cross-body bag when walking on the Corniche
- Politely decline help from strangers and move to a well-lit shop or cafe to clean up
- Be aware that the mess is fake -- real bird droppings do not appear on demand
- Travel with a companion who can watch your belongings while you deal with the distraction

■■ Jeddah

7 scams documented • Saudi Arabia

Airport Taxi Fare Inflation

The driver quotes 500 SAR for the ride to your hotel in the Al Balad district. The actual fare should be 100-120 SAR. When you express surprise, he claims the meter is broken, traffic is heavy, or there is a surcharge for airport pickups. If you have already loaded your bags, you feel trapped into paying. TripAdvisor's Jeddah forum has a thread titled 'Jeddah Airport taxi prices' where travelers documented being 'quoted 500 SAL (120 euros/135 dollars) when the normal taxi ride should be 100-120 SAL.' GoDigit.com's Saudi Arabia scam guide confirms that 'Jeddah taxi drivers tend to overcharge...

■ Red Flags

- The driver quotes a fare of 300-500 SAR for a ride that ride-hailing apps price at 80-120 SAR
- The driver claims the meter is broken, out of order, or not applicable for airport rides
- He loads your bags before discussing the price, creating pressure to accept the quoted fare
- The driver approaches you inside the terminal rather than waiting at the designated taxi queue
- He quotes the fare in US dollars or euros rather than Saudi Riyals, adding an unfavorable conversion premium

■ How to Avoid

- Use Careem or Uber exclusively in Jeddah — both operate reliably at the airport with fixed upfront pricing
- If using a taxi, insist the driver activates the meter before the car moves and do not accept broken meter claims
- Check the Careem estimate for your route before negotiating with any taxi driver as a price reference
- Pre-book airport transfers through your hotel with a fixed agreed rate
- Never load your bags into a taxi before agreeing on the fare — negotiate first

Al Balad Souq Pickpocketing

You are exploring Jeddah's beautiful Al Balad historical district, marveling at the coral stone buildings and browsing the souqs. The narrow streets are crowded with both tourists and pilgrims. As you stop to photograph a building, someone bumps into you from behind. You barely notice — the streets are packed. Back at your hotel, you realize your wallet is gone from your back pocket. Professional pickpockets operate in teams in the souq, with one creating a bump or distraction while the other lifts your valuables. GoDigit.com's Saudi Arabia scam guide specifically lists 'Al Balad Souk in Je...

■ Red Flags

- You are in a crowded souq and someone bumps into you or presses unusually close
- Your attention is deliberately drawn to something — a commotion, a vendor's call, or someone asking for directions
- You are carrying a wallet in your back pocket or have a bag with easy-access zippers in a crowded area
- You are standing still photographing buildings while crowds flow around you
- It is peak season (Hajj or Umrah) and the souq is more crowded than usual

■ How to Avoid

- Keep your wallet in a front pocket or use a money belt under your clothing when visiting the souqs
 - Carry only the cash you need for the day and leave extra money, cards, and your passport in your hotel safe
 - Wear your bag on your front in crowded areas and keep a hand on it at all times
 - Be extra vigilant during Hajj and Umrah seasons when crowds are largest and pickpockets most active
 - Avoid stopping in narrow, crowded passageways to take photos — move to an open area first
-

Fake Gold and Jewelry at the Gold Souq

You are browsing Jeddah's Gold Souq when a vendor outside the main shops offers you a gold necklace at a price dramatically below what the established stores charge. He swears it is 21-karat gold and shows you a hallmark. You buy it for 800 SAR, feeling like you got a fantastic deal. A jeweler at home tests it and confirms it is gold-plated brass worth about 20 SAR. Arab News reported that 'concerns rise over fake gold in Saudi Arabia,' documenting how 'some gold manufacturers manipulate weight of gold and diamonds.' The article notes that 'smugglers try to sell their fake gold and jewelry ...

■ Red Flags

- Gold is offered at prices dramatically below what established shops charge for similar items
- The seller is a street vendor, informal stall, or shop without proper signage and commercial license
- The hallmark or karat stamp on the jewelry looks irregular, shallow, or poorly made
- No proper invoice or receipt with the seller's commercial registration number is offered with the purchase
- The seller is especially aggressive during Hajj and Umrah seasons, targeting pilgrims on the street

■ How to Avoid

- Only buy gold from established, licensed shops in the Gold Souq — Malabar Gold & Diamonds and other known retailers
 - Always demand a detailed invoice with the seller's commercial registration number, karat weight, and item weight
 - Verify gold purity by checking the hallmark stamp — Saudi gold is typically sold in 18K, 21K, or 22K
 - Never buy gold from street vendors, hotel touts, or informal sellers regardless of the price
 - Compare prices across several established shops before buying — gold prices should be consistent based on weight and karat
-

Hajj and Umrah Package Fraud

You book a Hajj or Umrah package through what appears to be a legitimate travel agency for an attractive all-inclusive price. You wire the payment and fly to Jeddah. Upon arrival, you discover the accommodation your agent booked does not exist — or it is a cramped room shared with 20 other pilgrims rather than the private hotel you were promised. The 'included' transportation turns out to be non-existent, and essential services like visa processing were never completed. The agency is unreachable. The UK's Council of British Hajjis (CBHUK) warns about widespread Hajj and Umrah fraud, and The...

■ Red Flags

- The package price is significantly below what authorized, established agencies charge for similar services
- The agency is not registered with the Saudi Ministry of Hajj or your home country's travel protection scheme (like ATOL in the UK)
- Payment is requested by wire transfer to a personal account rather than a business account with proper documentation
- The agency cannot provide specific hotel names, addresses, or confirmation numbers for your accommodation
- Hidden fees appear after initial payment for visas, transportation, meals, or other services that should be included

■ How to Avoid

- Only book Hajj and Umrah packages through agencies authorized by the Saudi Ministry of Hajj — verify on the official Nusuk platform
 - Ensure your agency is registered with ATOL (UK), IATA, or your country's equivalent financial protection scheme
 - Get everything in writing: hotel names and addresses, transportation details, visa processing timeline, and refund policy
 - Pay by credit card or through protected payment methods — never wire money to personal accounts
 - Verify your hotel reservation directly with the hotel using the confirmation number provided by the agency
-

Rental Car Damage and Deposit Hold

At return, the agent claims to find a seat stain or minor scratch that was there when you picked up the vehicle. He charges 57 SAR for the stain and withholds your 2,000 SAR deposit for a 'damage assessment' that can take weeks. One month later, despite written requests, the deposit has not been returned. Some agencies register legal cases against tourists who dispute charges, hoping the threat of international legal action will force payment. A specific case documented by travel bloggers describes how 'Keys Car Rental blamed them for a car seat stain' and charged 57 SAR. The Saudi Gazette ...

■ Red Flags

- The pickup agent rushes through the inspection and discourages you from documenting the vehicle
- At return, the agent claims damage that you believe was pre-existing or not caused by you
- The agency demands immediate cash payment rather than processing through your insurance
- Your deposit is not returned within the promised timeframe despite follow-up requests
- The agency is a small local operation without international brand accountability

■ How to Avoid

- Take detailed video and photos of every surface including seats, mirrors, and the dashboard before driving off
 - Insist all pre-existing damage is marked on the rental agreement before signing
 - Rent from international companies (Hertz, Budget, Europcar) with established dispute resolution
 - Get zero-excess insurance through your credit card or a third-party provider
 - At return, get written confirmation that the vehicle is returned without new damage before leaving the counter
-

Overpriced Corniche and Waterfront Vendors

You are enjoying an evening stroll along Jeddah's beautiful Corniche when a vendor approaches selling fresh juice, snacks, or souvenirs. He does not mention a price until after you have consumed the drink or accepted the item. The price turns out to be 3-5 times what the same items cost at a nearby convenience store or in the city center. A fresh juice that costs 5 SAR in town is suddenly 20-25 SAR on the Corniche. Refusing to pay after consuming the product puts you in an awkward confrontation. This is a common pattern at tourist waterfront areas worldwide, and Jeddah's Corniche is no exce...

■ Red Flags

- The vendor does not state the price before you accept or consume the product
- You are at a tourist hotspot like the Corniche and the vendor approaches you rather than you approaching a stall
- The same product is available at a quarter of the price at a nearby shop or supermarket
- The vendor becomes aggressive or confrontational when you express surprise at the price
- During Hajj or Umrah season, prices are inflated even further than usual

■ How to Avoid

- Always ask the price before accepting any food, drink, or item from a vendor — 'Bikam?' (How much?) in Arabic
 - Buy drinks and snacks from convenience stores or supermarkets along the Corniche rather than from roaming vendors
 - Carry your own water and snacks when visiting tourist areas to avoid vendor markups entirely
 - Know that a fresh juice costs about 5-10 SAR and a water bottle about 1-2 SAR at normal retail prices
 - If quoted an outrageous price, politely decline and walk away — you are under no obligation to pay for unsolicited items
-

The Bus Transfer SIM Card Swindle

■ ■ Jeddah Airport, specifically in Basma buses transferring Hajj and Umrah pilgrims You have just arrived at Jeddah Airport for Umrah and board a Basma shuttle bus to the city. During the ride, a man wearing what looks like an official lanyard approaches passengers and demands that everyone purchase a SIM card from him, claiming it is mandatory for all

pilgrims in Saudi Arabia. The SIM cards cost 200-400 SAR -- far above the 75-100 SAR you would pay at an official STC or Mobily counter in the airport. The SIM may not even work properly. As r/Jeddah users report, this scam specifically targets exhausted pilgrims on airport transfer buses who do not yet know their way around. Red Flags A man on a bus claims SIM cards are mandatory and must be purchased immediately He flashes an unofficial-looking lanyard or badge but has no company uniform The price is significantly higher than what official airport counters charge He pressures multiple passengers at once, creating herd mentality The SIM card packaging looks unofficial or has no brand markings How to Avoid Buy your SIM card at official STC, Mobily, or Zain counters inside the airport terminal Research current SIM card prices before arriving so you know the fair rate Politely decline any sales pitches on buses or in transit areas SIM cards are never mandatory for purchase from a random vendor on a bus Activate an eSIM before travel to avoid the airport SIM card market entirely ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Saudi Arabian Police station. Call 999 (Police) or 911 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at moi.gov.sa. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Embassy in Riyadh at PO Box 94309. For emergencies: +966 11-488-3800. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Saudi Arabia ■■

During the ride, a man wearing what looks like an official lanyard approaches passengers and demands that everyone purchase a SIM card from him, claiming it is mandatory for all pilgrims in Saudi Arabia. The SIM cards cost 200-400 SAR -- far above the 75-100 SAR you would pay at an official STC or Mobily counter in the airport. The SIM may not even work properly. As r/Jeddah users report, this scam specifically targets exhausted pilgrims on airport transfer buses who do not yet know their way around.

■ Red Flags

- A man on a bus claims SIM cards are mandatory and must be purchased immediately
- He flashes an unofficial-looking lanyard or badge but has no company uniform
- The price is significantly higher than what official airport counters charge
- He pressures multiple passengers at once, creating herd mentality
- The SIM card packaging looks unofficial or has no brand markings

■ How to Avoid

- Buy your SIM card at official STC, Mobily, or Zain counters inside the airport terminal
 - Research current SIM card prices before arriving so you know the fair rate
 - Politely decline any sales pitches on buses or in transit areas
 - SIM cards are never mandatory for purchase from a random vendor on a bus
 - Activate an eSIM before travel to avoid the airport SIM card market entirely
-

■■ Mecca

7 scams documented • Saudi Arabia

The Fake Hajj/Umrah Package

half the usual price. The 'agency' has a polished website, fake testimonials, and answers your WhatsApp messages promptly. You pay via bank transfer. As departure approaches, the agency goes silent. You arrive at the airport to discover your tickets are fake and your hotel reservation doesn't exist. British pilgrims have lost between 1,000 and 33,000 pounds to such schemes. Redditors on r/hajj warn that fraudulent operators spike every year before Hajj season, with organized crime groups specifically targeting Muslim communities.

■ Red Flags

- Package price is 40-50% below market rate
- Payment required via bank transfer or cash only, no credit card option
- Agency has no ATOL license or Saudi Embassy accreditation

- Heavily promoted through social media ads rather than established channels
- No physical office address or the listed address is fake

■ How to Avoid

- Book exclusively through the official Nusuk platform for Hajj
 - Verify travel agencies are ATOL-protected and accredited by the Saudi Embassy
 - Pay by credit card for chargeback protection — never wire transfer or cash
 - Check the agency's track record on forums like r/hajj and CBHUK
 - If a deal seems too good to be true, it is a scam
-

The Tawaf Pickpocket Ring

Your focus is entirely on prayer. Meanwhile, a team of pickpockets works the crowd: one bumps into you, another uses a razor blade to slice your waist pouch strap or belt, and a third catches whatever falls. They've stolen cash, passports, and phones worth thousands. Undercover Grand Mosque police have arrested operatives carrying \$2,500 in stolen cash and multiple phones. Cameras now cover the Haram, but the density of the crowd still provides cover. Redditors on r/hajj share stories of losing passports and phones during peak Tawaf times.

■ Red Flags

- Someone presses unusually close to your body during Tawaf
- A person bumps you while another reaches toward your waist or pocket
- Your belt or bag strap feels tugged or loosened
- A distraction is created nearby — someone falls or cries out
- Use a flat, RFID-blocking money belt worn under your ihram or clothing

■ How to Avoid

- Use a flat, RFID-blocking money belt worn under your ihram or clothing
 - Leave your passport at the hotel safe and carry a photocopy
 - Carry minimal cash and no unnecessary electronics during Tawaf
 - Perform Tawaf during less crowded times (early morning or late night)
 - Keep your phone in a zipped interior pocket, never a back pocket
-

The Fake Zamzam Water

the holy water every pilgrim wants to bring home. The bottle looks legitimate with proper labeling. But Saudi police have raided underground factories in Makkah where workers filled hundreds of bottles with regular tap water and non-drinkable water, sealing them to look authentic. In one bust, they found 600 fake bottles ready for sale. Tests on supposed Zamzam water sold in other countries have found high arsenic levels, making fake Zamzam a health hazard beyond just fraud. Redditors on r/islam warn against buying from any unofficial source.

■ Red Flags

- Zamzam sold by street vendors rather than official distribution points
- Price seems unusually cheap or the vendor is overly aggressive
- Bottles lack official holographic seals from the Saudi government
- Seller operates from a blanket or cart rather than a licensed shop
- Water tastes different from what's freely available inside the Haram

■ How to Avoid

- Collect Zamzam water for free from official dispensers inside Masjid al-Haram

- Buy only from official Saudi government distribution points
 - For bottles to take home, use the Zamzam water service at King Abdulaziz International Airport
 - Never buy from street vendors or unlicensed shops outside the Haram
 - If the seal looks tampered with or different from official bottles, don't drink it
-

The Hotel Bait-and-Switch

You arrive exhausted after a long flight and the shuttle takes you to a rundown apartment in Azizia, 25 minutes away by bus. The room barely qualifies as 1-star. When you complain, the operator says the 'original hotel was overbooked' and offers no refund. This is a deliberate bait-and-switch: rogue operators advertise premium accommodations at full price but book the cheapest rooms they can find, pocketing the difference. UK Parliament has debated Hajj fraud after thousands of British pilgrims reported this exact scheme.

■ Red Flags

- Hotel name in the package is vague or doesn't appear on booking sites
- Operator can't provide a booking confirmation number you can verify directly with the hotel
- Package price is suspiciously low for 'Haram-view' accommodation
- Operator avoids specifics about hotel star rating and exact distance to the Haram
- Contract has fine print allowing 'equivalent substitution'

■ How to Avoid

- Book hotels directly through Booking.com, Agoda, or the Nusuk platform
 - Verify hotel booking confirmations independently by calling the hotel
 - Read the fine print on accommodation 'substitution' clauses in tour contracts
 - Research the hotel location on Google Maps to verify walking distance to the Haram
 - Check [r/hajj](#) and [CBHUK](#) forums for reviews of specific operators
-

The Unauthorized Pilgrim Guide

You're at the Haram for your first Umrah and an English-speaking man in a clean thobe approaches, offering to guide you through the rituals for 200 SAR. He seems knowledgeable and helpful. But halfway through Tawaf, he starts rushing you, skipping steps, and pressuring you for additional payment. Some unauthorized guides abandon pilgrims mid-ritual after collecting the fee. Others deliberately mislead first-timers about required rituals to create confusion and dependency. Licensed guides are assigned through official Umrah operators — anyone approaching you unsolicited at the Haram is opera...

■ Red Flags

- Guide approaches you unsolicited at the Haram gates or hotel lobby
- No official ID badge or accreditation from the Ministry of Hajj
- Demands payment upfront in cash before beginning
- Rushes through rituals or skips steps to handle multiple groups
- Cannot answer detailed questions about the rituals confidently

■ How to Avoid

- Arrange guides only through your licensed Umrah operator or hotel
 - Study the Umrah rituals beforehand using the official Nusuk app guide
 - Ask to see the guide's Ministry of Hajj accreditation badge before agreeing
 - Never pay the full fee upfront — pay after completion if you hire privately
 - Report unlicensed guides to Haram security for the protection of other pilgrims
-

The Overpriced Souvenir Prayer Beads

A vendor shows you prayer beads he claims are carved from rare oud wood or Yemeni agate, quoting 300-500 SAR. He swears on the Quran they're authentic. The beads are actually plastic or low-grade stone, worth 10-20 SAR. The emotional high of completing pilgrimage makes many visitors less discerning. Vendors near the Haram gates know that pilgrims feel generous and spiritual, and exploit this to charge 10-20 times fair value for mass-produced religious souvenirs. Redditors on r/hajj advise buying souvenirs from supermarkets or reputable shops away from the Haram.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor claims items are made from rare materials (oud, agate, pure silver)
- Price is far above what similar items cost in other shops
- No receipt offered or vendor resists giving one
- Vendor uses religious appeals to justify the price
- Items are identical across multiple shops, suggesting factory production

■ How to Avoid

- Compare prices at several shops before buying — the Haram-adjacent shops are the most expensive
- Buy standard souvenirs from supermarkets like Bin Dawood or Al-Othaim
- Real oud and agate have distinctive characteristics — research before buying
- Never buy under emotional pressure right after completing rituals
- Ask for receipts and check if the shop has a commercial license displayed

The Organized Begging Ring at the Haram

■ ■ Gates of Masjid al-Haram, pedestrian bridges between hotels and the mosque, Zamzam Tower area You are walking to the Haram for Fajr prayer when a woman with children approaches, tearfully ... You are walking to the Haram for Fajr prayer when a woman with children approaches, tearfully explaining she was robbed and needs money to feed her family. You give her 100 SAR. Two hours later, you see the same woman running the same story on a different group of pilgrims. A Reddit user on r/Umrah described organized begging scams at Masjid al-Haram where the same individuals work different gates throughout the day, specifically targeting pilgrims whose spiritual state makes them more generous. Some scammers claim to be collecting for a sick child or a stranded family, using photos of children on their phone for effect. Red Flags Beggar approaches with a detailed and emotionally compelling story involving children The same person is seen at different locations running the same story They specifically target pilgrims in spiritual attire walking to or from the mosque Photos of sick children are shown on a phone to generate sympathy The requested amount is specific — exactly enough for a 'hotel room' or 'hospital bill' How to Avoid Give charity through established Haram donation boxes rather than to street beggars Politely say 'Allah yarhamak' (God bless you) and keep walking Report organized begging rings to the Haram security forces stationed at every gate If you want to help those in genuine need, donate to your country's official Hajj fund or UNHCR Remember that Saudi authorities provide free food and water to all pilgrims during Hajj season ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Saudi Arabian Police station. Call 999 (Police) or 911 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at moi.gov.sa. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Embassy in Riyadh at PO Box 94309. For emergencies: +966 11-488-3800. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Saudi Arabia ■■

You are walking to the Haram for Fajr prayer when a woman with children approaches, tearfully explaining she was robbed and needs money to feed her family. You give her 100 SAR. Two hours later, you see the same woman running the same story on a different group of pilgrims. A Reddit user on r/Umrah described organized begging scams at Masjid al-Haram where the same individuals work different gates throughout the day, specifically targeting pilgrims whose spiritual state makes them more generous. Some scammers claim to be collecting for a sick child or a stranded family, using photos of chil...

■ Red Flags

- Beggar approaches with a detailed and emotionally compelling story involving children

- The same person is seen at different locations running the same story
- They specifically target pilgrims in spiritual attire walking to or from the mosque
- Photos of sick children are shown on a phone to generate sympathy
- The requested amount is specific — exactly enough for a 'hotel room' or 'hospital bill'

■ How to Avoid

- Give charity through established Haram donation boxes rather than to street beggars
 - Politely say 'Allah yarhamak' (God bless you) and keep walking
 - Report organized begging rings to the Haram security forces stationed at every gate
 - If you want to help those in genuine need, donate to your country's official Hajj fund or UNHCR
 - Remember that Saudi authorities provide free food and water to all pilgrims during Hajj season
-

■■ Medina

5 scams documented • Saudi Arabia

The Fake Refugee Sob Story

You've just finished prayers at the Prophet's Mosque and are walking through the sunlit plaza when a well-dressed man approaches, speaking urgently. He says he's from Gaza, that his entire family was killed, and that he desperately needs money for a bus ticket to Jeddah. His eyes are filled with tears and his story is heart-wrenching. You reach for your wallet. But as Tripadvisor and Reddit's r/saudiArabia forums document extensively, this is one of Medina's most common scams -- the same individuals rotate through the mosque plazas daily, wearing designer watches and leather jackets while s...

■ Red Flags

- The person approaches you specifically near the mosque during high foot-traffic prayer times
- Their clothing and accessories are inconsistent with someone in genuine financial distress
- The story involves a specific, emotionally charged conflict zone like Gaza, Syria, or Yemen
- They ask for a precise amount that happens to be just enough for transport or medicine
- You see the same person approaching multiple other pilgrims with the same story

■ How to Avoid

- Direct any genuine charity through established organizations like the Saudi Red Crescent or mosque donation boxes
 - Politely say 'La, shukran' (No, thank you) and continue walking
 - Understand that Saudi authorities actively assist verified refugees through official channels
 - If you want to help the needy, donate through the mosque's official zakat and sadaqah programs
 - Report persistent beggars to mosque security, as begging is illegal in the Haram area
-

The Ghost Hotel Booking

They promised a four-star hotel with a Haram view, just a two-minute walk from the Prophet's Mosque. You paid in full upfront. But when you arrive exhausted after a long journey, the hotel either doesn't exist at the address given, or you find a run-down property thirty minutes from the mosque with no record of your booking. As the UK government travel advisory and pilgrims on Reddit warn, organized crime groups specifically target Hajj and Umrah travelers with fake accommodation deals, and the losses can run into thousands of dollars. During peak pilgrimage season, genuine hotels near the ...

■ Red Flags

- The agent offers luxury hotel rooms near Al-Haram at prices significantly below market rate
- They demand full payment upfront via wire transfer rather than through a secure booking platform

- The hotel cannot be independently verified on Booking.com, Agoda, or Google Maps
- Communication becomes evasive or stops entirely as your travel date approaches
- The agent is not registered on Saudi Arabia's official Nusuk platform for pilgrimage services

■ How to Avoid

- Book accommodations only through the official Nusuk platform or verified booking sites like Booking.com and Agoda
 - Verify any hotel exists by searching its exact name and address on Google Maps and reading recent reviews
 - Never pay the full amount upfront -- use platforms with buyer protection and refund policies
 - Confirm your booking directly with the hotel by calling their front desk before traveling
 - Use only Saudi-licensed Hajj and Umrah tour operators listed on the Nusuk portal
-

The Pickpocket Prayer Crowd

You're inside the Prophet's Mosque during Friday prayers, surrounded by thousands of worshippers packed shoulder to shoulder. The crowd surges toward the Rawdah area -- the most sacred section between the Prophet's pulpit and his tomb. In the crush of bodies, you feel a slight brush against your pocket but dismiss it as the crowd pressing. It's only after prayers, when you reach for your phone or wallet, that you realize they're gone. As Tripadvisor and pilgrimage forums describe, organized pickpocket teams work the Rawdah crowds specifically because worshippers are focused on prayer and th...

■ Red Flags

- Someone presses unnecessarily close to you even when space is available
- A person creates a minor disturbance or bumps into you repeatedly in the crowd
- You notice the same individuals moving against the flow of foot traffic near you
- Someone drops something in front of you, causing you to stop and look down
- Your bag or pocket feels lighter after passing through a bottleneck area

■ How to Avoid

- Use an anti-theft money belt or neck pouch worn under your ihram or clothing
 - Leave your passport locked in your hotel safe and carry only a photocopy
 - Keep your phone in a zipped inner pocket rather than in a thobe or trouser pocket
 - Stay alert during crowd surges and keep one hand on your valuables at all times
 - Visit the Rawdah during off-peak hours when crowds are thinner for a safer experience
-

The Unlicensed Taxi Overcharge

It looks like a taxi, and he quotes 150 SAR to your hotel near the Haram. You agree and climb in. But the car has no meter, no official taxi markings, and no license displayed. At your hotel, the driver demands 300 SAR, claiming the original quote was per person, or that traffic required a longer route. Without an official meter receipt, you have no leverage. As travelers on r/saudiArabia note, unlicensed taxis targeting pilgrims at the airport and near mosque gates routinely inflate fares by 200-400 percent, especially during Hajj and Umrah peak seasons when demand overwhelms supply.

■ Red Flags

- The vehicle has no visible taxi markings, roof light, or meter
- The driver quotes a flat fare without using a meter or app
- They approach you aggressively at the airport exit rather than waiting in the official taxi queue
- The driver cannot produce an official taxi license when asked
- The quoted price seems high compared to the 20-30 SAR that ride-hailing apps show for the same route

■ How to Avoid

- Use the Uber or Careem app in Saudi Arabia for transparent GPS-tracked pricing
- If using a taxi, take one from the official airport taxi rank with marked vehicles and meters
- Always confirm the fare before getting in and insist on the meter being turned on
- Screenshot the Uber or Careem estimated fare to use as a price reference when negotiating
- Book airport transfers in advance through your hotel for a fixed, agreed-upon rate

The Souvenir Short-Change

■ ■ *Shops along King Faisal Road and the commercial streets surrounding Al-Masjid an-Nabawi* You're browsing the souvenir shops near the Haram, picking up prayer beads, dates, and attar perfume as gifts. The vendor is warm and hospitable, offering you Arabic coffee while you browse. You select several items and hand over 200 SAR. The vendor counts out change quickly, pressing the bills into your hand with a smile. It's only later at the hotel that you count your change and realize you're 50 SAR short. As pilgrimage travel forums warn, some vendors use quick counting and the distraction of friendly conversation to short-change tourists who are unfamiliar with Saudi riyal denominations. The tactic is especially effective with larger purchases involving multiple items. **Red Flags** The vendor counts change very quickly and presses it into your hand without pausing. They distract you with conversation or offer you another item while making change. There is no cash register or point-of-sale system -- all transactions are manual. Prices are not clearly labeled and are quoted verbally during negotiation. The vendor becomes defensive or rushes you if you try to count the change in the shop. **How to Avoid** Count your change slowly and carefully in front of the vendor before leaving the counter. Pay with exact change whenever possible to eliminate the short-changing opportunity. Use contactless payment through Apple Pay, STC Pay, or card payments to avoid cash handling entirely. Familiarize yourself with Saudi riyal bill denominations (1, 5, 10, 50, 100, 500) before shopping. Shop at established stores with electronic POS systems and receipts for reliable pricing. ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Saudi Arabian Police station. Call 999 (Police) or 911 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at moi.gov.sa. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact the US Embassy in Riyadh at PO Box 94309. For emergencies: +966 11-488-3800. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in Saudi Arabia** ■ ■

The vendor is warm and hospitable, offering you Arabic coffee while you browse. You select several items and hand over 200 SAR. The vendor counts out change quickly, pressing the bills into your hand with a smile. It's only later at the hotel that you count your change and realize you're 50 SAR short. As pilgrimage travel forums warn, some vendors use quick counting and the distraction of friendly conversation to short-change tourists who are unfamiliar with Saudi riyal denominations. The tactic is especially effective with larger purchases involving multiple items.

■ Red Flags

- The vendor counts change very quickly and presses it into your hand without pausing
- They distract you with conversation or offer you another item while making change
- There is no cash register or point-of-sale system -- all transactions are manual
- Prices are not clearly labeled and are quoted verbally during negotiation
- The vendor becomes defensive or rushes you if you try to count the change in the shop

■ How to Avoid

- Count your change slowly and carefully in front of the vendor before leaving the counter
- Pay with exact change whenever possible to eliminate the short-changing opportunity
- Use contactless payment through Apple Pay, STC Pay, or card payments to avoid cash handling entirely
- Familiarize yourself with Saudi riyal bill denominations (1, 5, 10, 50, 100, 500) before shopping
- Shop at established stores with electronic POS systems and receipts for reliable pricing

■ ■ Riyadh

Broken Meter Taxi Overcharge

The driver loads your bags and starts driving. When you ask about the meter, he claims it is broken and quotes a fare of 150 SAR for a ride that should cost 50-70 SAR. Another tactic involves the meter running but the driver taking a deliberately long route through Riyadh's sprawling suburbs, doubling the distance and fare. Some drivers park outside the official taxi rank and intercept tourists before they reach the legitimate queue. GoDigit.com's Saudi Arabia scam guide documents that 'the most common taxi scam is to claim that the meter is broken so you need to strike a deal, and they usu...

■ Red Flags

- The driver claims the meter is broken and insists on a fixed fare significantly higher than app-based rides show
- The driver approaches you before you reach the official taxi queue, offering a 'special price'
- The route does not match what Google Maps shows as the optimal path to your destination
- The vehicle has no visible taxi license, meter, or driver identification on display
- The driver becomes aggressive or refuses to let you exit when you challenge the fare

■ How to Avoid

- Use Uber or Careem exclusively for transportation in Riyadh — both show the fare upfront and route on the map
 - If you must take a street taxi, insist the driver activates the meter before the car moves — if they refuse, find another taxi
 - Check the Uber or Careem estimate for your route before negotiating with any taxi driver so you know the fair price
 - Pre-book airport transfers through your hotel with a fixed rate agreed in advance
 - Follow your GPS throughout the ride and challenge the driver if they deviate from the direct route
-

Souk Counterfeit Designer Goods

You are exploring the bustling Al Batha market district in southern Riyadh when a vendor beckons you over to see 'authentic' designer handbags, watches, and sunglasses at prices that seem too good to be true. The Gucci bag looks convincing, and the vendor swears it is 'first quality, same factory.' You pay 500 SAR, feeling like you got a bargain. Back home, anyone with passing knowledge of luxury goods immediately spots the fake. Worse, bringing counterfeit goods through customs in many countries can result in confiscation or fines. Al Arabiya News reported that 'fake products boom in Saudi...

■ Red Flags

- Designer-branded items are sold at prices dramatically below retail — a 'Gucci' bag for 200 SAR should be an obvious warning
- The vendor uses terms like 'first quality,' 'same factory,' or 'AAA copy' to describe the merchandise
- Items are stored in the back room rather than openly displayed, suggesting the seller knows they are illegal
- The product lacks proper branding details, serial numbers, dust bags, or authentication cards that genuine items include
- The vendor insists on cash only and provides no receipt for the transaction

■ How to Avoid

- If you want genuine luxury goods, shop at official brand boutiques in Riyadh Park Mall or Kingdom Centre
 - Remember that Saudi law imposes penalties of up to one year in prison and fines of up to SR1 million for selling counterfeits — buyers can also face issues
 - Do not assume that market-priced luxury goods are 'overstock' or 'factory seconds' — they are fakes
 - Many countries confiscate counterfeit goods at customs and may fine you for importing them
 - Buy authentic Saudi handicrafts, oud perfumes, and dates as souvenirs instead — they are the real luxury of Riyadh
-

High-Pressure Carpet and Antique Sales

You are exploring the Dira Souq when a warm, English-speaking shopkeeper invites you in for Arabic coffee and a look at his 'museum' of antique carpets and artifacts. The hospitality is genuine — the coffee is excellent — but after 30 minutes of viewing, the sales pitch begins. The carpet that was 'priceless' is suddenly available for 5,000 SAR, then drops to 3,000, then 2,000 with increasing emotional appeals. You are told it is a rare Bedouin piece that will increase in value. In reality, many of these carpets are mass-produced imports from Pakistan or India. GoDigit.com's Saudi scam guid...

■ Red Flags

- The shopkeeper offers drinks and insists you sit down before showing any merchandise
- Claims that the item is a rare antique, one-of-a-kind, or will increase in value — common high-pressure tactics
- The initial price drops by 50% or more with minimal negotiation, suggesting it was never worth the original ask
- The seller creates emotional urgency: 'I have not sold anything today' or 'This is the last one from my grandfather's collection'
- You feel uncomfortable leaving because you accepted hospitality and feel socially obligated to buy something

■ How to Avoid

- Enjoy the coffee and conversation but make clear from the start that you are 'just looking' and not planning to buy today
 - Research fair prices for carpets and antiques before visiting the souq so you can recognize inflated pricing
 - Never feel obligated to buy because you accepted tea or coffee — hospitality is part of the culture and does not create a debt
 - Walk away from any seller whose price drops dramatically with each refusal — the real value is far below even the 'final' price
 - If you genuinely want a carpet, visit established shops like Deira Antiquities or buy from government-certified heritage stores
-

Fake Taxi at Airport Interception

Before you reach the official taxi rank, a man in casual clothes approaches offering to carry your bags and take you to your hotel at a 'good price.' His car looks like a regular sedan with no taxi markings. He loads your bags in the trunk before you have agreed on a price. During the ride, he quotes a fare of 250 SAR — four times the Careem rate. Since your bags are in his trunk, you feel you have no choice but to pay. GoDigit.com's Saudi Arabia guide warns that 'fake taxis pretending to be legal ones are quite common in Saudi Arabia, with the driver potentially intercepting you before you...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches you inside the terminal or before you reach the official taxi rank offering a ride
- The vehicle has no taxi markings, license, or meter visible
- The driver loads your luggage before discussing or agreeing on a price
- No driver identification is displayed and the driver avoids giving you a receipt
- The quoted price is significantly higher than what ride-hailing apps show for the same route

■ How to Avoid

- Order a Careem or Uber while still inside the terminal and only go to the designated pickup zone
 - Never let anyone load your luggage into a vehicle before you have confirmed the driver, price, and license plate
 - Walk past anyone approaching you in the arrivals hall offering rides — proceed directly to the official taxi rank
 - Pre-arrange airport transfers through your hotel with a driver holding a sign with your name
 - If using an official taxi, verify it has a proper taxi sign, license plate, and driver ID before entering
-

The Approaching Woman Social Engineering Scam

■ ■ Shopping malls in Olaya district, Kingdom Centre mall, areas around Al Masmak Fortress, and near major hotel entrances You are a Western male tourist in a Riyadh mall when an Arab woman in traditional dress approaches ... You are a Western male tourist in a Riyadh mall when an Arab woman in traditional dress approaches and starts a flirtatious conversation. As a foreigner, you find the interaction unusual but exciting. She suggests meeting later or invites you somewhere private. The end goal is either a direct cash demand, a setup for a compromising photo to use as blackmail, or luring you to a location where accomplices rob you. A Reddit user on r/Riyadh described this as a known scam, noting that as a Westerner, they were never comfortable being approached by Arab women in public. In Saudi Arabia's conservative culture, genuine public flirtation from a stranger is extremely uncommon, making these approaches almost certainly fraudulent. Red Flags A woman approaches you in a public place and initiates conversation, which is culturally unusual in Saudi Arabia She suggests meeting privately or visiting a specific location The interaction feels rehearsed or too good to be true given Saudi Arabia's conservative social norms She asks about your hotel, how long you are staying, or whether you are alone She asks you to send money or buy something expensive How to Avoid Understand that unsolicited approaches from strangers in Saudi Arabia are almost always scams regardless of gender Politely decline and walk away from any unsolicited social interaction that seems romantic or unusually forward Never follow a stranger to a secondary location, especially if they suggest somewhere private Be aware that Saudi Arabia has strict laws about extramarital relationships -- even the appearance of impropriety can cause legal problems for foreigners If you feel you are being followed or pressured, enter a hotel lobby or shopping mall security area ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Saudi Arabian Police station. Call 999 (Police) or 911 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at moi.gov.sa. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Embassy in Riyadh at PO Box 94309. For emergencies: +966 11-488-3800. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Saudi Arabia ■■

You are a Western male tourist in a Riyadh mall when an Arab woman in traditional dress approaches and starts a flirtatious conversation. As a foreigner, you find the interaction unusual but exciting. She suggests meeting later or invites you somewhere private. The end goal is either a direct cash demand, a setup for a compromising photo to use as blackmail, or luring you to a location where accomplices rob you. A Reddit user on r/Riyadh described this as a known scam, noting that as a Westerner, they were never comfortable being approached by Arab women in public. In Saudi Arabia's conserv...

■ Red Flags

- A woman approaches you in a public place and initiates conversation, which is culturally unusual in Saudi Arabia
- She suggests meeting privately or visiting a specific location
- The interaction feels rehearsed or too good to be true given Saudi Arabia's conservative social norms
- She asks about your hotel, how long you are staying, or whether you are alone
- She asks you to send money or buy something expensive

■ How to Avoid

- Understand that unsolicited approaches from strangers in Saudi Arabia are almost always scams regardless of gender
- Politely decline and walk away from any unsolicited social interaction that seems romantic or unusually forward
- Never follow a stranger to a secondary location, especially if they suggest somewhere private
- Be aware that Saudi Arabia has strict laws about extramarital relationships -- even the appearance of impropriety can cause legal problems for foreigners
- If you feel you are being followed or pressured, enter a hotel lobby or shopping mall security area

■ Turkey

■■ Antalya

6 scams documented • Turkey

Taxi Meter Manipulation

In one reported case, the same taxi company charged 170 TL from the domestic terminal but 55 EUR (approximately 306 TL) from the international terminal for a journey between terminals that are only 100 meters apart. The driver assumed the international arrival would not know local prices and quoted in euros, nearly doubling the fare. Another traveler reported their fare from the airport to their hotel was double what it should have been, with the driver deliberately taking a route through deserted streets at night to inflate the distance. Common tactics include refusing to turn on the meter...

■ Red Flags

- The driver refuses to turn on the meter or claims it is broken
- The driver quotes the fare in euros instead of Turkish lira
- The driver approaches you inside the arrivals hall instead of waiting at the official taxi stand outside
- The meter is running on the night rate (gece tarife) during daytime hours
- The driver takes an obviously indirect route or drives through deserted side streets

■ How to Avoid

- Always insist the meter is running and set to the daytime rate (gunduz tarife) before the car moves
- Use the BiTaksi app to book taxis with tracked routes and pre-estimated fares, or arrange a hotel transfer in advance
- At Antalya Airport, use only the official taxi stand outside arrivals and reject drivers who approach you inside the terminal
- Know approximate fares: airport to Kaleici is roughly 350-500 TL, airport to Lara Beach is 250-400 TL in 2025 prices
- Request a receipt (makbuz) for every trip and report overcharging to local police at 155 or the tourism hotline

Restaurant Bill Inflation

TripAdvisor's Antalya forum features a thread titled 'Scammed At A Turkish Restaurant Who To Complain To?' in which travelers describe a consistent pattern: the waiter presents a normal menu with reasonable prices, but when the bill arrives, items are charged at two to three times the listed price. One poster reported dishes priced at 150 TL on the menu appearing as 350 TL on the bill. Another thread titled 'Beware restaurant Tax scam' documents restaurants adding fabricated 'tax' line items that do not actually exist in Turkish dining. A separate TripAdvisor review thread discusses bars in...

■ Red Flags

- A tout on the street aggressively invites you into the restaurant with promises of discounts or free items
- The waiter brings bread, water, or meze to the table without you ordering it, then charges for it
- The bill is presented quickly and the waiter hovers while you review it, pressuring a fast payment
- Prices on the bill do not match what was listed on the menu you were shown earlier
- A service charge or tax appears on the bill that was not disclosed on the menu or verbally

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph the menu including prices before ordering, and compare each item to the bill before paying
 - Avoid restaurants with aggressive touts on the street; choose places where locals eat and check Google reviews first
 - Ask explicitly if bread, water, and service charges are included or extra before sitting down
 - Always check the bill line by line and do not feel rushed; politely insist on time to review each charge
 - If overcharged, refuse to pay the inflated amount and threaten to call the tourist police (155); restaurants often back down immediately
-

Carpet Shop Pressure Sales

Scam Detector's profile of 'Turkish Salesmen' documents the carpet scam pattern in detail: touts flood tourist areas like Kaleici and invite visitors to see '125-year-old rugs' which are actually recent productions. The Rick Steves Travel Forum has a notable thread titled 'Turkish Carpets...Don't buy!!!!' where travelers share experiences of high-pressure sales sessions that lasted hours. The scam involves being served tea, shown dozens of carpets, and subjected to escalating emotional pressure until the tourist feels obligated to purchase. The Scam Detector report warns that the market is...

■ Red Flags

- A friendly stranger on the street strikes up conversation and offers to show you their 'family carpet shop'
- You are served tea and made to feel obligated to buy after a lengthy presentation
- The seller claims the carpets are antiques or handmade silk but cannot provide independent verification
- Prices start extremely high and the seller rapidly drops them, making you feel like you are getting a deal
- The shop offers to ship the carpet to your home country, removing your ability to inspect it again before paying

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow a street tout into a carpet shop; if you want a carpet, research specific reputable dealers with verified reviews beforehand
 - Get any carpet independently appraised before purchasing; do not rely on certificates provided by the seller
 - Understand that feeling obligated after tea and conversation is the entire strategy; you owe nothing for accepting hospitality
 - If you do buy, pay by credit card so you can dispute the charge if the carpet turns out to be fake or misrepresented
 - Set a firm budget and a time limit before entering any shop, and do not let the salesperson talk you past either boundary
-

Accommodation Booking Fraud

ScamWatch360's Antalya report highlights a growing trend of fraudulent accommodation listings that offer dramatically below-market rates for luxury properties. Trustpilot reviews of Antalya development companies reveal complaints from tourists who paid deposits for vacation rentals that either did not exist or were significantly different from the photos shown. Inspired To Explore's Turkey scam guide documents cases where fake hotel booking confirmations are used to extract advance payment, after which the scammers become unreachable. The scam typically begins with a listing on social media...

■ Red Flags

- The rental price is significantly below comparable properties in the same area
- The host insists on bank transfer payment rather than booking through Airbnb, Booking.com, or another platform with buyer protection
- The host refuses to provide a video call or real-time photos of the property when requested
- The listing has few or no reviews, or reviews that all appear to have been posted around the same time
- The host pressures you to book immediately claiming high demand or a limited-time offer

■ How to Avoid

- Book accommodation only through established platforms like Booking.com, Airbnb, or Hotels.com that offer verified listings and refund policies
- Never send money via bank transfer or Western Union for any accommodation booking
- Cross-reference the property address on Google Maps and Google Street View to verify it exists and matches the listing photos
- Read recent reviews specifically mentioning the property matching its description; look for multiple reviews across different months

- Contact the property directly using phone numbers found through independent searches, not just the number provided in the listing
-

Watersport Equipment Bait and Switch

CapeTanos travel guide and Antalya Tourist Information document watersports operations on popular beaches that quote low prices to attract tourists, then add hidden charges for fuel, insurance, safety equipment, or photos taken during the activity. Jet ski rentals on Konyaalti Beach are advertised at \$50-80 for 10-15 minutes, but tourists report being charged extra for a mandatory 'fuel deposit' of \$30-50 that is never returned, or being told after the ride that the timer started when the safety briefing began rather than when they entered the water. FantastiX Watersports in Kemer offers se...

■ Red Flags

- No visible price board and the operator negotiates verbally without written confirmation
- You are told the activity has no insurance and you must sign a damage liability waiver
- The operator asks for cash payment upfront with no receipt provided
- Additional charges for fuel, safety equipment, or photos are mentioned only after you have committed
- The operator takes your personal camera or phone during the activity and demands payment to return it

■ How to Avoid

- Book watersports through your hotel or a licensed operator with posted prices and Google reviews rather than beach touts
 - Get a written quote including all charges before committing, and confirm whether fuel, equipment, and insurance are included
 - Pay by credit card when possible for dispute protection; if paying cash, insist on a receipt with the business name and total
 - Photograph any equipment before use so you have evidence against fake damage claims
 - Check that the operator has a Turkish tourism license displayed and carries third-party liability insurance
-

Bar Drink Spiking and Bill Inflation

■ ■ *Bar Street (Barlar Sokagi) in Kaleici, clubs near the marina, late-night bars in Lara Beach hotel zone, rooftop bars targeting solo male tourists* TurkeyTravelPlanner.com documents the 'Let's Have a Drink' scam that operates across Turkish resort ... TurkeyTravelPlanner.com documents the 'Let's Have a Drink' scam that operates across Turkish resort cities including Antalya. A friendly local, often an attractive woman, strikes up conversation with a male tourist and suggests going to a nearby bar for drinks. The bar is in on the scam. Drinks arrive at what seems like normal prices, but the bill at the end of the night is \$500-2,000 for a few rounds. When the tourist protests, bouncers appear and become threatening. The ChasingTheDonkey travel blog lists this among the 25 common tourist scams in Turkey. TripAdvisor reviews of 'Club Ally' in Antalya include a detailed report titled 'TOURIST SCAM ok one off visit' describing how the establishment lured tourists with promises of free entrance and cheap drinks, then presented inflated bills with entrance fees and per-drink surcharges that were never disclosed. Another TripAdvisor thread warns of bars that add unauthorized charges and refuse to correct deliberate calculation errors on bills. The more dangerous variant involves drink spiking. CareInsurance's UAE travel guide (which covers Turkey as a regional comparison) notes that tourists in bars may have their drinks spiked to facilitate robbery. Victims wake up hours later with wallets, phones, and watches stolen. This has been reported in Kaleici late-night bars targeting both solo male and solo female tourists. Red Flags A friendly stranger suggests going to a specific bar they know rather than letting you choose The bar has no visible menu with prices, or the menu shown differs from what appears on the bill You feel unexpectedly drowsy or disoriented after one or two drinks Bouncers or security become involved when you question the bill The bar is in a basement or side street with no other visible customers when you arrive How to Avoid Never go to a bar suggested by a stranger you just met; choose your own venue based on Google reviews and visible foot traffic Always check the menu with prices before ordering and keep it at your table for reference when the bill arrives Never leave your drink unattended; order bottled drinks and open them yourself when possible Set a spending limit and pay for each round as it arrives rather than running a tab Go out in groups rather than alone, and let someone know where you are going and when you expect to return ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Turkish National Police (Emniyet Genel Mudurlugu) station. Call 155. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You

can also report online at Turkish National Police Online Portal. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your country's nearest consulate; many European countries maintain honorary consulates in Antalya. The nearest US Consulate is in Adana. Carry a photocopy of your passport separately from the original. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. *Frequently Asked Questions Is Antalya safe for solo female travelers?* ▼

TurkeyTravelPlanner.com documents the 'Let's Have a Drink' scam that operates across Turkish resort cities including Antalya. A friendly local, often an attractive woman, strikes up conversation with a male tourist and suggests going to a nearby bar for drinks. The bar is in on the scam. Drinks arrive at what seems like normal prices, but the bill at the end of the night is \$500-2,000 for a few rounds. When the tourist protests, bouncers appear and become threatening. The ChasingTheDonkey travel blog lists this among the 25 common tourist scams in Turkey. TripAdvisor reviews of 'Club Ally' ...

■ Red Flags

- A friendly stranger suggests going to a specific bar they know rather than letting you choose
- The bar has no visible menu with prices, or the menu shown differs from what appears on the bill
- You feel unexpectedly drowsy or disoriented after one or two drinks
- Bouncers or security become involved when you question the bill
- The bar is in a basement or side street with no other visible customers when you arrive

■ How to Avoid

- Never go to a bar suggested by a stranger you just met; choose your own venue based on Google reviews and visible foot traffic
 - Always check the menu with prices before ordering and keep it at your table for reference when the bill arrives
 - Never leave your drink unattended; order bottled drinks and open them yourself when possible
 - Set a spending limit and pay for each round as it arrives rather than running a tab
 - Go out in groups rather than alone, and let someone know where you are going and when you expect to return
-

■■ Bodrum

5 scams documented • Turkey

Nightclub Bar Bill Extortion

The Let's Travel to Turkiye blog documents 20 common tourist scams in Turkey, with the bar bill scam ranked among the most dangerous. A well-dressed man approaches tourists (usually solo males) on the street, claims to be a local who wants to practice English, and invites them to a 'great bar' for a drink. Once inside, women join the table and expensive drinks are ordered. The tourist is then presented with a bill of 5,000-63,000 TRY (\$150-\$1,900). The Travel blog The Travel published a first-person account titled 'How I Escaped Istanbul's Infamous Bar Scam' describing the mechanics: many d...

■ Red Flags

- A friendly stranger on the street invites you to a specific bar or club, often claiming to be a local or fellow tourist
- Women immediately join your table after you sit down and begin ordering expensive drinks
- Drinks arrive at your table that you did not order, especially bottles of champagne or premium spirits
- The bar has no visible menu with prices or the menu you are shown does not match the prices on the bill
- Staff become aggressive or block the exit when you question the bill

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow a stranger to a bar or club, regardless of how friendly they seem; choose your own establishments based on Google reviews
 - Check prices on the menu before ordering and confirm with the waiter what each drink costs before it is served
 - Keep your credit card in your pocket; pay in cash at bars to avoid having a large amount charged to your card under duress
 - If presented with an inflated bill, refuse to pay and call the Tourist Police (155) immediately; scam bars typically back down when police are mentioned
 - Stick to well-known bars and clubs with strong Google or TripAdvisor reviews; avoid any venue without an online presence or with only a few vague reviews
-

Carpet Shop Pressure Sales

The Property Turkey blog documents common tourist scams including the carpet shop scheme that operates across Turkey's resort cities. Tours advertised as 'cultural insights into Turkish folk life' are often high-pressure sales presentations for carpets. After brief weaving demonstrations, sellers launch into aggressive sales sessions for rugs priced at \$1,000-5,000. The Scam Detector profile of 'Turkish Salesmen' reveals that the market is flooded with Chinese machine-made fakes sold as handwoven Turkish originals. The Rug Chick blog's expert analysis titled 'Silk Rug Scams (ALL Buyers Bewa...

■ Red Flags

- A friendly local offers to show you their 'family carpet shop' or invites you to see a 'free weaving demonstration'
- You are served tea and subjected to an increasingly emotional sales pitch over an hour or more
- The seller claims carpets are handmade antiques but cannot provide independent authentication
- Prices start at \$3,000-5,000 and rapidly drop to \$1,000-2,000, making you feel like you are getting a deal
- The shop offers to ship the carpet home, removing your ability to return it after discovery of fraud

■ How to Avoid

- Never follow a street tout into a carpet shop; if you want a Turkish carpet, research reputable dealers independently before your trip
 - Get any carpet independently appraised before purchasing; the seller's 'certificate of authenticity' is printed in-house and worthless
 - Accepting tea does not obligate you to buy anything; Turkish hospitality is genuine, but scam shops weaponize the feeling of obligation
 - Pay by credit card for chargeback protection if the carpet is misrepresented; never pay cash for expensive items
 - Set a firm budget and time limit before entering any shop; walk out the moment you feel uncomfortable or pressured
-

Boat Tour Hidden Charges

Tours are advertised at attractive prices of \$20-40 per person 'including lunch,' but alcohol, soft drinks, and ice cream are sold at inflated prices onboard with no alternative available. Some operators explicitly state 'No outside alcoholic or non-alcoholic beverages are accepted on our boat,' creating a captive market where a beer costs \$8-10 and a cocktail \$15-20. Discount Travel Bodrum's listings show that tour operators compete fiercely for bookings with low headline prices, but the actual experience includes upsells for 'premium' swimming stops, photos, banana boat rides, and equipme...

■ Red Flags

- The tour price seems unusually low compared to competitors advertising the same route
- The booking confirmation does not specify what drinks, meals, and activities are included in the price
- You are told you cannot bring any food or drinks aboard the boat
- The operator quotes the price verbally without providing a written itinerary or inclusion list
- Additional activities (banana boat, jet ski, snorkeling equipment) are aggressively upsold once you are on the water

■ How to Avoid

- Get a written list of all inclusions before booking: meals, drinks (alcoholic and non-alcoholic), equipment, and entrance fees
 - Ask specifically whether you can bring your own drinks aboard; if not, ask for the onboard drink price list before committing
 - Book through TripAdvisor, Viator, or GetYourGuide where reviews reveal the true total cost including all add-ons
 - Choose operators that explicitly advertise 'all-inclusive' with specific inclusions listed, even if the headline price is higher
 - Compare at least three operators before booking and ask each one for a total-cost breakdown including all possible extras
-

Restaurant Tout Menu Bait-and-Switch

The Property Turkey blog documents that restaurants near popular tourist attractions in Turkey often charge two to three times the local price for mediocre food, and walking two or three streets away typically yields better food at a fraction of the cost. TripAdvisor's Bodrum restaurant reviews describe a consistent pattern: restaurants with touts on the street who aggressively invite tourists inside present one menu while seating, then bring the bill based on different (higher) prices. The Tripventura Turkey guide warns about the bread and water trap: Turkish restaurants traditionally brin...

■ Red Flags

- A tout on the street aggressively invites you into the restaurant, often offering free drinks or discounts
- Bread, water, or meze appears at your table without being ordered
- The waiter does not provide a menu with prices or suggests ordering fresh fish 'by weight' without quoting the per-kilo price
- The bill includes items you did not order, a service charge not mentioned on the menu, or prices that do not match what was listed
- The restaurant has very few Turkish customers and caters almost exclusively to foreign tourists

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph the menu including prices before ordering and compare every item on the bill against your photo
 - Ask 'Ekmek ve su dahil mi?' (Is bread and water included?) before sitting down
 - For fish, always ask the price per kilogram and confirm the total cost before the fish is cooked
 - Walk two to three streets back from the waterfront to find restaurants where locals eat; check Google reviews filtering for recent Turkish-language reviews
 - If overcharged, calmly refuse to pay the disputed amount and call the Tourist Police at 155; restaurants typically correct the bill immediately
-

Taxi Meter Fraud and Long-Routing

■ ■ *Milas-Bodrum Airport taxi rank, Bodrum bus station (otogar), late-night taxis from Bar Street, routes between Bodrum town and beach resorts (Gumbet, Bitez, Yalikavak)* The Cab Istanbul fraud guide and Tripventura Turkey scam guide both document Turkish taxi scams as ... The Cab Istanbul fraud guide and Tripventura Turkey scam guide both document Turkish taxi scams as among the most persistent tourist issues. In Bodrum, the airport-to-town transfer is a common overcharging point: the metered fare should be approximately 200-300 TRY (\$6-9), but some drivers quote flat rates of 500-800 TRY (\$15-25), especially for late-night arrivals. The tactic involves claiming the meter is broken and offering a 'standard rate' that is 2-3x the actual metered fare. The Let's Travel to Turkiye guide describes long-routing tactics where drivers take scenic routes between Bodrum town and resort areas like Gumbet (normally a 10-minute, 50 TRY ride) by circling through back roads, inflating the fare to 150-200 TRY. Some drivers switch the meter to the nighttime rate during daytime rides, which doubles the per-kilometer charge. The Chasing the Donkey Istanbul scam guide notes that taxi scam techniques are consistent across Turkish tourist cities: claiming the meter is broken, switching rates, taking longer routes, and making intentional 'wrong change' when paying with large bills. BiTaksi, the Turkish ride-hailing app, operates in

Bodrum and provides transparent upfront pricing that eliminates all meter manipulation. **Red Flags** The driver claims the meter is broken and quotes a flat rate, especially from the airport or bus station The meter starts at a rate higher than the standard starting fare of approximately 15-20 TRY The driver takes a route you do not recognize or seems to be circling rather than driving directly The driver gives incorrect change, typically shorting you by switching denominations (giving a 5 TRY note instead of 50 TRY) The driver insists on being paid in euros rather than Turkish lira, using an unfavorable exchange rate **How to Avoid** Use the BiTaksi app for all taxi rides; it shows the fare upfront and routes are tracked by GPS Always insist on the meter; if the driver claims it is broken, exit and take the next taxi For airport transfers, pre-book through your hotel or use the HavasBus airport shuttle (40 TRY) to Bodrum bus station Know approximate fares: airport to Bodrum town 200-300 TRY, Bodrum to Gumbet 50-80 TRY, Bodrum to Yalikavak 200-250 TRY Pay in Turkish lira with small bills and count your change carefully before exiting the taxi ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Turkish National Police (Emniyet) station. Call 155 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at egm.gov.tr. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Consulate General in Istanbul is at Kaplicalar Mevkii No. 2, ■stinye, 34460 Istanbul. For emergencies: +90 212-335-9000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **More Scam Guides More in Turkey** ■■

The Cab Istanbul fraud guide and Tripventura Turkey scam guide both document Turkish taxi scams as among the most persistent tourist issues. In Bodrum, the airport-to-town transfer is a common overcharging point: the metered fare should be approximately 200-300 TRY (\$6-9), but some drivers quote flat rates of 500-800 TRY (\$15-25), especially for late-night arrivals. The tactic involves claiming the meter is broken and offering a 'standard rate' that is 2-3x the actual metered fare. The Let's Travel to Turkiye guide describes long-routing tactics where drivers take scenic routes between Bodr...

■ Red Flags

- The driver claims the meter is broken and quotes a flat rate, especially from the airport or bus station
- The meter starts at a rate higher than the standard starting fare of approximately 15-20 TRY
- The driver takes a route you do not recognize or seems to be circling rather than driving directly
- The driver gives incorrect change, typically shorting you by switching denominations (giving a 5 TRY note instead of 50 TRY)
- The driver insists on being paid in euros rather than Turkish lira, using an unfavorable exchange rate

■ How to Avoid

- Use the BiTaksi app for all taxi rides; it shows the fare upfront and routes are tracked by GPS
- Always insist on the meter; if the driver claims it is broken, exit and take the next taxi
- For airport transfers, pre-book through your hotel or use the HavasBus airport shuttle (40 TRY) to Bodrum bus station
- Know approximate fares: airport to Bodrum town 200-300 TRY, Bodrum to Gumbet 50-80 TRY, Bodrum to Yalikavak 200-250 TRY
- Pay in Turkish lira with small bills and count your change carefully before exiting the taxi

■■ Cappadocia

5 scams documented • Turkey

The Pottery Showroom Heist

A craftsman gives a charming demonstration on the wheel, then guides your group into a showroom filled with ceramics. The sales staff are aggressive but polished -- pointing out 'museum-quality' pieces and offering Turkish tea while you browse. A group of Singaporean tourists reported on Turkish media paying \$3,000 for two pots, a plate, and four cups. They only realized the scam when they googled prices later -- the same items sold for \$20-50 at regular shops. The pottery center's excuse was that items were marked in USD when they were priced in Turkish Lira, a currency confusion that infl...

■ Red Flags

- Your tour includes a 'complimentary pottery demonstration' at a specific workshop
- Prices are displayed ambiguously -- no clear currency symbol or decimal formatting
- Staff apply intense pressure after the demonstration, making it awkward to leave empty-handed
- Credit card machines default to EUR or USD instead of Turkish Lira
- The tour guide receives a visible kickback or disappears to a back room during your 'shopping time'

■ How to Avoid

- Before tapping your card, explicitly confirm the currency on the terminal screen is Turkish Lira
 - Research pottery prices in advance: a nice handmade Avanos pot costs 200-500 TL, not thousands
 - You have zero obligation to buy anything after a demonstration -- smile, thank them, and leave
 - Book tours through your hotel or a TripAdvisor-reviewed agency that discloses all stops
 - If pressured, say you need to check with your partner first and step outside
-

The Phantom Balloon Booking

You pay a \$200 deposit via credit card. On the morning of your flight, the 4 AM shuttle never arrives. You call the number -- disconnected. You email -- no reply. The website was a clone of a real balloon company, and your money is gone. Even with real companies, Tripadvisor reviews document cases where operators deny any record of your reservation or payment after collecting deposits. Some travelers arrive in Cappadocia to find all balloon flights sold out for the entire week because they booked through an unverified intermediary who never actually secured a slot.

■ Red Flags

- The booking website URL doesn't exactly match the company's official domain
- Unusually cheap prices for balloon rides (legitimate flights cost \$150-300 per person)
- Payment is requested via bank transfer rather than a secure card gateway
- No confirmation email with a proper booking reference number arrives
- A hotel receptionist or street tout offers to 'arrange' a balloon flight for a suspiciously low price

■ How to Avoid

- Book directly through established companies: Butterfly Balloons, Royal Balloon, or Voyager Balloons
 - Verify the company website URL carefully before entering payment details
 - By Turkish law, only licensed travel agencies or balloon companies themselves can accept reservations
 - Book well in advance -- legitimate companies often sell out weeks ahead during peak season
 - Pay via credit card with chargeback protection, never bank transfer
-

The Fake Underground City Tour

The minibus picks you up at dawn and drives for two hours. Your first stop is a 'lemon storage warehouse' that the guide presents as a lesser-known underground city. The Ihlara Valley visit consists of standing at a distant viewpoint and looking at the valley from kilometers away. Instead of Goreme panoramas, you are shown village houses in a hamlet called Cardak. The entire itinerary was fabricated to avoid entrance fees while filling time with commission-generating shop stops. Business Turkey Today documented this scam affecting foreign tourists specifically.

■ Red Flags

- The tour price is significantly cheaper than competitors offering the same itinerary
- The guide is vague about exact locations when asked for specifics
- You visit 'alternative' or 'secret' versions of famous sites rather than the real thing

- Most of the tour time is spent at carpet shops, pottery workshops, or onyx stores
- Other tourists on the bus seem confused about whether they are seeing the real attractions

■ How to Avoid

- Book tours through agencies with strong TripAdvisor or Google reviews and many photos of actual sites
 - Confirm the itinerary includes entrance tickets to Derinkuyu or Kaymakli Underground City
 - Ask your hotel concierge which agencies deliver genuine itineraries
 - If a tour costs less than 500 TL, question what corners are being cut
 - Research what the real attractions look like so you can recognize fakes immediately
-

The Carpet Shop Hospitality Trap

You're walking through Goreme when a friendly shopkeeper invites you in for apple tea -- 'no obligation to buy, just Turkish hospitality.' The tea is delicious. Then he begins unfurling carpets, explaining the silk-versus-wool weave, the natural dyes, the generations of craftsmanship. More tea appears. An hour passes. You feel socially obligated after all this hospitality, and when he quotes 2,000 euros for a carpet 'worth 5,000,' it feels like a deal. At home, you find the identical machine-made carpet on Amazon for 35 euros. A Medium travel blog documented a traveler who paid 200 EUR for ...

■ Red Flags

- Unsolicited invitations for free tea with 'no obligation to buy'
- The demonstration is long, elaborate, and designed to create emotional attachment
- Prices start very high and are dramatically 'discounted' during negotiation
- The shopkeeper claims the carpet is handmade, antique, or one-of-a-kind without documentation
- Offers to ship the carpet to your home country to bypass luggage concerns

■ How to Avoid

- Enjoying free tea is fine, but recognize it as a sales technique -- you owe nothing
 - Never buy a carpet impulsively -- take photos, research prices, and return the next day if interested
 - Ask for a certificate of authenticity and origin for any 'handmade' claim
 - A genuine handmade Turkish silk carpet starts at \$500+ -- anything cheaper is machine-made
 - If you want authentic carpets, visit cooperative workshops recommended by Lonely Planet, not street touts
-

The Cave Hotel Bait-and-Switch

■ ■ Goreme hotels, online booking platforms You book a stunning cave hotel room in Goreme through Booking.com -- the photos show a beautifully ... You book a stunning cave hotel room in Goreme through Booking.com -- the photos show a beautifully carved stone room with fairy chimney views. Days before your trip, you receive a WhatsApp message from a different phone number claiming your reservation was lost due to 'internet issues' and asking you to pay again via a new link. The link is a phishing page. Alternatively, you arrive and the hotel insists the Booking.com price was wrong and demands a higher cash rate, threatening to give your room away. Tripadvisor's Cappadocia forum has multiple reports of both the WhatsApp phishing scam and the in-person price inflation tactic at smaller cave hotels. Red Flags A WhatsApp or SMS message about your booking comes from a number not listed on the hotel's website You are asked to pay again through a link rather than through the original booking platform Upon arrival, the hotel claims your booking is not in their system despite your confirmation Staff pressure you to pay cash at a higher rate than your online booking The hotel's real appearance differs drastically from the listing photos How to Avoid Never click payment links sent via WhatsApp -- contact the hotel directly using the number on Booking.com Screenshot your booking confirmation with the price and show it at check-in Book through platforms with strong buyer protection: Booking.com or Hotels.com If the hotel tries to charge more, contact the booking platform's support immediately from the lobby Read recent reviews specifically mentioning check-in experience before booking smaller properties ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Turkish National Police (Emniyet) station. Call 155 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at egm.gov.tr. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the

thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Consulate General in Istanbul is at Kaplicilar Mevkii No. 2, ■stinye, 34460 Istanbul. For emergencies: +90 212-335-9000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Turkey ■■

You book a stunning cave hotel room in Goreme through Booking.com -- the photos show a beautifully carved stone room with fairy chimney views. Days before your trip, you receive a WhatsApp message from a different phone number claiming your reservation was lost due to 'internet issues' and asking you to pay again via a new link. The link is a phishing page. Alternatively, you arrive and the hotel insists the Booking.com price was wrong and demands a higher cash rate, threatening to give your room away. Tripadvisor's Cappadocia forum has multiple reports of both the WhatsApp phishing scam an...

■ Red Flags

- A WhatsApp or SMS message about your booking comes from a number not listed on the hotel's website
- You are asked to pay again through a link rather than through the original booking platform
- Upon arrival, the hotel claims your booking is not in their system despite your confirmation
- Staff pressure you to pay cash at a higher rate than your online booking
- The hotel's real appearance differs drastically from the listing photos

■ How to Avoid

- Never click payment links sent via WhatsApp -- contact the hotel directly using the number on Booking.com
 - Screenshot your booking confirmation with the price and show it at check-in
 - Book through platforms with strong buyer protection: Booking.com or Hotels.com
 - If the hotel tries to charge more, contact the booking platform's support immediately from the lobby
 - Read recent reviews specifically mentioning check-in experience before booking smaller properties
-

■■ Istanbul

8 scams documented • Turkey

The Shoe Shine Drop Trick

You picked it up and handed it back — a natural, polite thing to do. He thanked you profusely and immediately insisted on shining your shoes as a gesture of gratitude. The shine took 90 seconds and then he presented a bill for 200 lira — about €8 — and became aggressive when you offered far less. The 'accidental' drop is deliberate. Reddit's r/istanbul and r/solotravel describe it as one of the most charming cons in the city precisely because it exploits basic human kindness.

■ Red Flags

- A shoe shiner drops his brush or tools directly in your path
- He thanks you warmly for picking it up and immediately offers a 'free' shine
- No price is mentioned before the work begins
- The final bill is outrageously high for what was done
- He becomes upset or follows you if you don't pay the full amount

■ How to Avoid

- If you see a brush fall, simply step around it rather than picking it up
 - If you do pick it up out of reflex, decline the offered shine firmly: 'No, thank you'
 - Never let anyone touch your shoes without agreeing on a price first
 - The shoe shine drop trick is so well-known it's cited in every Istanbul travel guide — awareness is your protection
 - If caught mid-shine, agree only to a specific amount before he continues
-

Let's Have a Drink Bar Bill Shock

Near Taksim Square, a friendly Turkish man asked where you were from, laughed at your answer, and said 'I know a great local bar, not touristy, you must come.' It seemed genuine — he seemed like the kind of guy who just loves meeting people. An hour later you were in a basement bar with two women who'd joined your table, and the bill arrived: 8,000 lira for four drinks. The exit was through a narrow corridor where two large men stood. Your new 'friend' had vanished. This is the most-reported high-danger scam in Istanbul — r/travel posted 'Scary scams in Istanbul we experienced — beware' and...

■ Red Flags

- An overly friendly local approaches specifically to invite you to a bar
- The bar is down an alley, in a basement, or noticeably away from the main street
- Attractive companions join your table shortly after you arrive
- Drinks arrive you didn't order; no prices were shown when you entered
- The bill is ten to twenty times what you'd expect; the exit is guarded

■ How to Avoid

- Decline any bar or club invitation from a stranger you just met on the street
 - Choose bars that are street-level, have visible price menus posted, and are clearly busy with regular patrons
 - If you're already inside and the bill arrives unexpectedly high, call 155 (police) immediately — do not pay
 - Share your location with someone before going out and check in every hour
 - The Turkish Tourist Police have a specific unit for these cases — asking to call them often resolves the situation fast
-

Taxi Overcharge and Route Manipulation

Your taxi from Sabiha Gökçen Airport started the meter honestly, but the driver claimed the direct route was 'under construction' and took a highway loop that added 40 minutes and tripled the fare. When you questioned it, he showed you a phone with a Google Maps route — but the route shown had already been calculated to maximize toll roads. Redditors in r/istanbul consistently warn that Istanbul taxis are among the most problematic in Europe, with drivers also known to swap 100 lira notes with 5 lira notes and claim you underpaid, or to have tampered meters that run fast.

■ Red Flags

- Driver claims your direct route is blocked and suggests an alternative
- The meter appears to tick faster than expected
- Driver handles your cash payment and quickly claims you gave a smaller bill
- No receipt is offered and the driver is evasive about the final total
- Ride takes significantly longer than Google Maps estimated

■ How to Avoid

- Use BiTaksi or inDriver apps for fixed-price or metered Istanbul taxis with GPS tracking
 - Photograph the meter reading at trip start and monitor it against your expected route
 - Hand over cash in full view, name the denomination clearly: 'Here is 200 lira'
 - Know the approximate fare before you get in — Sultanahmet to Taksim is roughly 80–120 lira
 - The Istanbul Metro (M1, M2) and tram (T1) serve all major tourist zones cheaply and reliably
-

Carpet Shop Pressure Selling

'just to look, no obligation, tea is free.' Inside, you were seated on a low cushion with tea in hand while carpets unrolled at your feet one after another. An hour passed. The family narrative, the tea, the prices crossing down from €2000 to €400 — it all created a pressure that felt impossible to refuse. You left with a €350 carpet you

didn't need. Reddit's [r/solotravel](#) describes this as 'soft-scam' territory: the carpets may be real, but the social engineering to separate you from money you didn't plan to spend is highly refined.

■ Red Flags

- An invitation to 'just look' immediately transforms into a full sales session
- Tea and hospitality are used to create social obligation
- Prices start absurdly high and drop rapidly to create a false sense of a deal
- Salespeople use personal family stories and emotional appeals
- You feel unable to leave without buying something after accepting hospitality

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline carpet shop invitations near the Blue Mosque and Hagia Sophia
 - It's fine to enter and look, but know that accepting tea creates social expectation — you can still walk out
 - If interested in buying, research carpet values independently before entering any shop
 - Leave the shop, sleep on it overnight, and return only if you genuinely want to buy
 - Real carpet quality can be assessed (knot density, dye tests) — ask for these demonstrations and walk away if refused
-

Fake Police / ID Check Robbery

You were walking back to your hotel near the Grand Bazaar at night when two men in plain clothes showed badges and said they were undercover police conducting a drug check. They asked to see your passport and wallet to 'verify your identity.' When you handed them over — feeling you had no choice — one walked a few steps away to 'check the documents' while the other kept you talking. By the time the first man returned your passport, a significant amount of cash was missing from your wallet and they were gone before you processed what had happened. Reddit users in [r/travel](#) describe Istanbul a...

■ Red Flags

- Plain-clothes men approach at night flashing laminated ID cards quickly
- They request your wallet as well as your passport — real police need only documents
- They separate the interaction: one officer talks while another handles your belongings
- The interaction happens on a quiet street rather than a public, populated area
- They ask you to come 'just over here' away from the main street or witnesses

■ How to Avoid

- Request to go to the nearest police station (karakol) — real officers will agree; scammers refuse
 - Call 155 (Turkish police) immediately on your phone while they are present
 - Never hand your wallet to anyone claiming to be police — documents only, and only if you are confident
 - Keep passport in hotel safe and carry a color photocopy instead
 - Travel in groups or well-lit, populated routes at night near the bazaar areas
-

Istanbulkart 'Helpful' Overcharge

A man approached offering to help you use the machine — he loaded a card with 200 lira but charged your cash at 350, pocketing the difference before you understood what happened. In a more aggressive version described in [r/solotravel](#), the helper swaps your card for one with minimal credit after the top-up, keeping the loaded card. The Istanbulkart machine has a basic English interface, but the combination of transit anxiety and tourist inexperience makes newcomers easy targets for 'helpful' intermediaries.

■ Red Flags

- A stranger at a transit machine offers to help before you've even asked
- They handle your cash directly rather than pointing to where you insert it

- They complete the transaction very quickly before you can track the amounts
- The card they hand you feels different from the one you held initially
- They ask for more cash than the machine's price list shows

■ How to Avoid

- Use the Istanbulkart machines yourself — English interface is available on all machines
 - Decline all unsolicited help at transit stations politely but firmly
 - Buy your Istanbulkart at the official IETT kiosk inside the station rather than the machine if overwhelmed
 - Verify the balance on your card at the turnstile immediately — it shows on the reader
 - The card costs 70 lira plus however much you load — know this number before you approach the machine
-

The Grand Bazaar Aggressive Upsell

The owner offers you apple tea and begins unfurling progressively more expensive carpets. An hour later, you're surrounded by silk rugs and the shopkeeper has shifted from friendly host to insistent negotiator. He quotes 8,000 lira for a carpet, then drops to 3,000 when you stand up to leave. The genuine market price is around 1,500 lira. The tea, the story about his family weaving tradition, and the 'special price just for you' are all part of a rehearsed sales performance that plays out identically in dozens of shops throughout the bazaar.

■ Red Flags

- Shopkeeper offers tea immediately and begins showing merchandise you didn't ask for
- Prices drop dramatically (50%+) when you move toward the door
- Claims the carpet is hand-woven antique silk when it could be machine-made polyester
- Pressure to pay now because 'this price is only for today'
- A 'certificate of authenticity' is offered with no independent verification

■ How to Avoid

- It's fine to browse and drink tea -- just know you can always walk away
 - Research carpet types and fair prices before entering the Grand Bazaar
 - Compare prices at multiple shops before buying anything over 500 lira
 - If you want quality carpets, visit shops outside the bazaar with fixed prices and Google reviews
 - Never feel obligated to buy because you accepted tea -- it's a sales tactic, not a gift
-

The Airport Taxi Meter Trick

■ ■ *Istanbul Airport (IST), Sabiha Gokcen Airport (SAW)* You take a taxi from Istanbul Airport to Sultanahmet. The driver starts the meter but toggles it to the night-rate setting (*gece*), which charges double, even though it's 2 PM. The meter climbs quickly and the ride costs 450 lira instead of the correct 250 lira. Some drivers also take the long way around via the coast road rather than the direct O-3 highway. At Sabiha Gokcen on the Asian side, the same trick is even more common because tourists don't know the expected fare. **Red Flags** The meter shows '*gece*' (night rate) during daytime hours Driver takes the scenic coastal route instead of the highway Fare seems to climb unusually fast in the first few kilometers Driver insists his meter is correct when you question the rate **How to Avoid** Use BiTaksi app for GPS-tracked, metered rides from the airport Know that IST Airport to Sultanahmet should cost 200-300 lira via highway Check the meter starts at the correct base fare (approximately 30 lira as of 2025) Night rate (*gece*) only applies from midnight to 6 AM Take the Havaist airport bus to Sultanahmet for 140 lira as an alternative ■ **What to Do If You Get Scammed** ■ **File a Police Report** Go to the nearest Turkish National Police (*Emniyet*) station. Call 155 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at egm.gov.tr. ■ **Cancel Your Cards** Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ **Lost Passport?** Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Consulate General in Istanbul is at Kaplicilar Mevkii No. 2, ■ *stinye*, 34460 Istanbul. For emergencies: +90 212-335-9000. ■ **Track Your Device** If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. **Frequently Asked Questions** Is Istanbul safe for tourists? ▼

The driver starts the meter but toggles it to the night-rate setting (gece), which charges double, even though it's 2 PM. The meter climbs quickly and the ride costs 450 lira instead of the correct 250 lira. Some drivers also take the long way around via the coast road rather than the direct O-3 highway. At Sabiha Gokcen on the Asian side, the same trick is even more common because tourists don't know the expected fare.

■ Red Flags

- The meter shows 'gece' (night rate) during daytime hours
- Driver takes the scenic coastal route instead of the highway
- Fare seems to climb unusually fast in the first few kilometers
- Driver insists his meter is correct when you question the rate
- Use BiTaksi app for GPS-tracked, metered rides from the airport

■ How to Avoid

- Use BiTaksi app for GPS-tracked, metered rides from the airport
 - Know that IST Airport to Sultanahmet should cost 200-300 lira via highway
 - Check the meter starts at the correct base fare (approximately 30 lira as of 2025)
 - Night rate (gece) only applies from midnight to 6 AM
 - Take the Havaist airport bus to Sultanahmet for 140 lira as an alternative
-

■■ Marmaris

6 scams documented • Turkey

Fake Holiday Rep Excursion Fraud

You check into your Marmaris hotel and the next morning a smartly dressed man appears in the reception area holding a clipboard with the Jet2 or TUI logo. He introduces himself as your tour operator's holiday rep and invites you to a 'welcome meeting.' He offers excursion packages — boat trips, Dalyan mud baths, Ephesus tours — at what seem like reasonable prices. A family of four pays £320 for several trips (£80 per person). When they contact Jet2, the airline confirms they don't have a rep in Marmaris. The excursions never materialize, or they're substandard knockoffs of what was promised...

■ Red Flags

- Someone claiming to be your tour operator's rep appears in the hotel lobby uninvited
- They cannot provide proper identification beyond a branded clipboard or polo shirt
- Excursions are cash-only with no printed receipts or official booking confirmation
- Prices per person seem comparable to what you'd expect, but no child discounts or group rates are offered
- Your booking paperwork from the tour operator does not mention a representative at your specific hotel

■ How to Avoid

- Verify any claimed tour operator rep through the operator's official app or customer service number before buying anything
 - Your genuine rep will be identified in your pre-departure paperwork — check before you travel
 - Book excursions through verified local operators with TripAdvisor reviews or through your tour operator's official app
 - Never pay cash without a proper printed receipt from a registered business
 - Ask the hotel reception directly whether the person is an authorized rep — but verify independently as some hotels are complicit
-

Bar Street Bill Inflation and Drink Spiking

Promoters on the street offer 'free entry' and cheap drink deals. Inside, the first round seems fairly priced. But the drinks keep flowing, and when the bill arrives at closing, it's 1,200 Turkish lira for what you thought was four vodkas — plus a 500-lira 'service charge' that was never mentioned. You're charged £58 for four vodka mixers that should have cost half that. In the most alarming reports, unfamiliar people join your table and buy you drinks that turn out to be spiked, leading to memory loss and, in some cases, robbery. TripAdvisor's Marmaris forum is filled with Bar Street compl...

■ Red Flags

- Promoters on the street lure you in with 'free entry' or 'first drink free' offers
- No visible price list or menu is available inside the venue
- Unfamiliar people join your table uninvited and insist on buying you drinks
- You feel significantly more intoxicated than the amount you've drunk would suggest
- The bill includes a large 'service charge' or items you did not order

■ How to Avoid

- Choose bars with clearly posted price lists and pay per round rather than running a tab
 - Never accept drinks from strangers or leave your drink unattended — keep it in your hand at all times
 - Go out with friends and agree to watch each other's drinks throughout the evening
 - If you feel unexpectedly intoxicated, tell your friends immediately and leave the venue together
 - Check TripAdvisor reviews for specific Marmaris bars before going out to avoid venues with complaints
-

Boat Trip All-Inclusive That Isn't

You book an 'all-inclusive' boat trip from the Marmaris harbor for 600 lira per person, expecting a full day of swimming, lunch, and unlimited drinks. Once on the boat, the crew confiscates all the food and water you brought and tells you it's 'for safety reasons.' Then they proceed to sell their own food and drinks at premium prices — fries for 100 lira, water for 50 lira. Cocktails displayed on large posters behind the bar are 'not available' when ordered. The 'all-inclusive' lunch turns out to be a small portion of rice and grilled chicken. One TripAdvisor reviewer of the Orca II Boat in...

■ Red Flags

- The crew confiscates your personal food and drinks once you're on the boat
- Items advertised as included (cocktails, specific foods) are 'not available' once underway
- Additional charges appear for food, drinks, or activities that were supposed to be included
- The booking agent couldn't provide a written itemization of what 'all-inclusive' covers
- The price was significantly lower than other operators, suggesting corners will be cut once you're captive on the boat

■ How to Avoid

- Get written confirmation of exactly what 'all-inclusive' covers before paying — meals, specific drinks, snorkeling equipment
 - Book through operators with hundreds of TripAdvisor reviews rather than street agents
 - Ask specifically whether you can bring your own food and water aboard
 - Compare prices with at least three operators — a legitimate all-inclusive day boat costs 15-35 euros per person
 - Read the most recent reviews, not just the overall rating, as quality can change between seasons
-

Taxi Meter Manipulation and Route Padding

The meter starts at a normal rate, but you notice it's climbing unusually fast. What should be a 60-80 lira ride shows 180 lira when you arrive. The meter was legitimate — but programmed to a higher tariff rate. Turkish taxi meters can store multiple tariff rates, and switching between them requires only a button press. This form of meter manipulation is extensively documented across Turkey's tourist destinations by Chasing the Donkey, The

Istanbul Insider, and Inspired to Explore. While most examples focus on Istanbul, the same meters and tactics are used in resort towns like Marmaris. Com...

■ Red Flags

- The meter starts at a number higher than the minimum opening fare
- The fare is climbing noticeably fast relative to the distance traveled
- The driver takes a route you don't recognize when you have a general sense of the geography
- Additional charges for luggage, passengers, or 'night rates' are added on top of the meter
- The driver offers a 'fixed rate' that is significantly higher than what you'd expect for the distance

■ How to Avoid

- Check that the meter resets to the minimum opening fare when your ride begins
- Have Google Maps running on your phone so you can see the route in real time
- Use BiTaksi app or hotel shuttle services for transparent pricing
- For the Dalaman Airport to Marmaris transfer, pre-book through your hotel or a licensed transfer company at a fixed rate
- Learn the approximate fare for common routes (Marmaris center to Icmeler should be about 60-80 TRY) and challenge overcharges

Jet Ski and Water Sports Damage Charge

Before you go out, the operator gives you a cursory walkthrough but no written condition report or contract. After your ride — which was uneventful — the operator 'discovers' a scratch on the jet ski that he claims wasn't there before. He demands 2,000 lira for the damage. Without documentation of the jet ski's pre-ride condition, it's your word against his. This damage-charge scam at Turkish beach resorts is a variation of the rental car scam documented across Turkey's tourist destinations. Property Turkey and Chasing the Donkey both warn about water sports operators who extract inflated d...

■ Red Flags

- No written rental agreement or damage waiver is provided before the activity
- The operator does not conduct a documented pre-activity inspection of the equipment with you
- After the activity, the operator 'discovers' damage that you don't recall causing
- The demanded payment for damage seems wildly disproportionate to a minor scratch
- The operator becomes aggressive or threatens to 'call the police' themselves to pressure immediate payment

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph or video the equipment from all angles before using it, with the operator present
- Insist on a written rental agreement that notes the current condition of the equipment
- Only use operators with established online reviews (TripAdvisor, Google)
- If accused of damage, offer to call the Jandarma (military police, 156) to mediate — this often resolves spurious claims
- Pay by credit card rather than cash so you can dispute fraudulent charges later

The Carpet and Leather Shop Lure

■ ■ Grand Bazaar area, shops along Bar Street, Netsel Marina shopping arcade A shopkeeper calls out 'hello my friend, where are you from?' and before you know it, you are ... A shopkeeper calls out 'hello my friend, where are you from?' and before you know it, you are sitting in his shop drinking apple tea while he rolls out carpets. The tea is genuine Turkish hospitality, but the prices are five times what you would pay at a bazaar in Istanbul. After forty-five minutes of presentation, the social pressure to buy something is immense. The municipality has actually taken action to close shops in Marmaris that harass tourists, as reported in a Reddit thread, but the practice persists in side streets away from enforced zones. Red Flags Shopkeeper calls out to you aggressively from the doorway Free tea or drinks are offered immediately to get you seated inside Prices are not displayed on items — they are quoted after an extended presentation The shopkeeper uses

emotional manipulation: 'this carpet took my mother three months to weave' You feel unable to leave without buying due to social pressure after accepting hospitality How to Avoid Politely decline the tea invitation if you are not genuinely interested in buying If you enter a shop, it is perfectly acceptable to look and leave without purchasing Ask for prices before any product demonstration begins Compare carpet and leather prices at shops with fixed price tags before considering bazaar purchases The tea is free regardless — you are never obligated to buy after accepting hospitality in Turkey ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Turkish National Police (Emniyet) station. Call 155 (Police) or 112 (Emergency). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at egm.gov.tr. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Consulate General in Istanbul is at Kaplicalar Mevkii No. 2, ■stinye, 34460 Istanbul. For emergencies: +90 212-335-9000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Turkey ■■

A shopkeeper calls out 'hello my friend, where are you from?' and before you know it, you are sitting in his shop drinking apple tea while he rolls out carpets. The tea is genuine Turkish hospitality, but the prices are five times what you would pay at a bazaar in Istanbul. After forty-five minutes of presentation, the social pressure to buy something is immense. The municipality has actually taken action to close shops in Marmaris that harass tourists, as reported in a Reddit thread, but the practice persists in side streets away from enforced zones.

■ Red Flags

- Shopkeeper calls out to you aggressively from the doorway
- Free tea or drinks are offered immediately to get you seated inside
- Prices are not displayed on items — they are quoted after an extended presentation
- The shopkeeper uses emotional manipulation: 'this carpet took my mother three months to weave'
- You feel unable to leave without buying due to social pressure after accepting hospitality

■ How to Avoid

- Politely decline the tea invitation if you are not genuinely interested in buying
- If you enter a shop, it is perfectly acceptable to look and leave without purchasing
- Ask for prices before any product demonstration begins
- Compare carpet and leather prices at shops with fixed price tags before considering bazaar purchases
- The tea is free regardless — you are never obligated to buy after accepting hospitality in Turkey

■ United Arab Emirates

■■ Abu Dhabi

6 scams documented • United Arab Emirates

Unlicensed Taxi Overcharge

The National newspaper reported that Abu Dhabi Police fined more than 2,000 illegal taxi drivers offering unlicensed transport services in a single enforcement period. These unlicensed operators use personal vehicles without meters and specifically target tourists who are unfamiliar with official taxi services. Offenders face a 3,000 AED fine, vehicle seizure for 30 days, and 24 black points, yet the practice persists due to the high profit margins from overcharging tourists. Khaleej Times warned Abu Dhabi residents about the dangers of using illegal taxis, noting that these drivers often l...

■ Red Flags

- The driver approaches you inside the airport terminal rather than waiting at the official taxi stand
- The vehicle lacks official taxi markings, a visible meter, or a driver ID card displayed on the dashboard
- The driver refuses to use the meter and insists on a flat fare, or quotes the price in USD or EUR instead of AED
- The driver does not follow the route shown on your phone's GPS app
- The driver claims the meter is broken and offers a 'special price' instead

■ How to Avoid

- Use only official Abu Dhabi taxis (silver vehicles with the TransAD logo) from designated taxi stands at the airport and major attractions
- Download the Abu Dhabi Taxi app or use Careem/Uber for tracked rides with upfront pricing and digital receipts
- Know the official rates: base fare is 5 AED, minimum fare 12 AED, airport surcharge 25 AED; a ride from the airport to downtown should be 70-100 AED
- Insist the meter is running before the car moves and keep Google Maps open on your phone to monitor the route
- Report unlicensed taxi operators to Abu Dhabi Police by calling 8002626 or sending an SMS to 2828

Fake Gold and Jewelry Scam

Khaleej Times reported that Abu Dhabi police seized 27 kilograms of fake gold jewelry from shops in the emirate, valued at 6 million AED. A separate Gulf News report documented a seizure of fake goods worth 100 million AED in Abu Dhabi, including counterfeit jewelry. These operations reveal a systematic problem of fake gold being sold to tourists at authentic gold prices in shops that appear legitimate. AngelOne's guide on avoiding Dubai Gold Souk fraud (practices identical in Abu Dhabi) describes common techniques: sellers stamp lower-karat gold with higher-karat markings, so a tourist pay...

■ Red Flags

- The price is significantly below the current gold market rate for the stated karat weight
- The seller offers a 'special tourist discount' or claims to be offering wholesale prices
- The jewelry lacks an ESMA purity stamp or the stamp appears irregular or freshly applied
- The seller discourages you from having the piece independently tested or certified
- The shop is a temporary stall or pop-up rather than an established store in a major souk or mall

■ How to Avoid

- Buy gold only from ESMA-certified shops that provide a detailed receipt with the exact karat, weight in grams, and the daily gold rate applied
- Check the current international gold price on a live tracker before shopping and calculate what your piece should cost by weight
- Request to see the ESMA certification for any piece before purchasing and verify the hallmark stamp with a jeweler's loupe
- Pay by credit card for purchases over 500 AED so you have dispute protection if the gold is later found to be misrepresented
- If buying a significant piece, ask the shop to have it independently verified at a certified laboratory while you wait; reputable dealers will agree

Fake Parking Attendant

FEW.ae's Abu Dhabi tourist scam guide documents unofficial parking attendants who demand 50 AED or more for 'parking' in public spaces. Abu Dhabi's public parking is managed by the Mawaqif system with official zones identified by blue signs and ticket machines. These fake attendants position themselves near popular tourist destinations and wave drivers into spots, then demand cash payment for their 'service' of guiding you to park. The scam works because many tourists from countries with informal parking attendants consider this normal. However, in Abu Dhabi, all public parking payments go ...

■ Red Flags

- Someone approaches your car in a public parking area and waves you into a spot or claims to be managing parking
- The person demands cash payment for parking rather than directing you to a Mawaqif meter or SMS payment system
- The person is not wearing a Mawaqif uniform or visible official ID badge
- You are told your car will be towed or is not safe unless you pay the attendant
- The demanded amount is a round number like 50 AED rather than the standard Mawaqif rate of 2-3 AED per hour

■ How to Avoid

- Download the Darb app for official Mawaqif parking payments throughout Abu Dhabi; all legitimate parking is managed through this system
 - Look for official blue Mawaqif signs and meter machines to confirm you are in a legitimate paid parking zone
 - Never pay cash to anyone on the street for parking; all official payments are through SMS, the app, or meter machines
 - If someone claims to be a parking attendant, ask to see their Mawaqif ID card; if they cannot produce one, ignore them and walk away
 - Report fake parking attendants to Abu Dhabi Police by calling 8002626 or using the AD Police App
-

Desert Safari Bait and Switch

FEW.ae's Abu Dhabi scam guide warns that offers of 'VIP' desert safari experiences in Abu Dhabi frequently 'vanish faster than a mirage.' Unlicensed tour operators attract tourists through social media ads and hotel lobby flyers offering desert safaris at 50-70% below market rates, with promises of luxury camp experiences, gourmet dinners, and exclusive activities. After advance payment, the actual experience is dramatically different from what was advertised. GoDigit's UAE tourist scam guide documents the pattern in detail: fake tour operators demand advanced payment for what they describe...

■ Red Flags

- The safari price is dramatically below competitors offering similar packages, especially below 100 AED per person
- The operator insists on cash payment or bank transfer rather than credit card payment through a verified booking platform
- The operator communicates only through WhatsApp or social media and has no physical office or verifiable business license
- The package includes numerous 'premium' activities but the price is lower than basic packages from established operators
- There are no recent, verified reviews on Google, TripAdvisor, or Viator for the specific company

■ How to Avoid

- Book desert safaris only through established operators with consistent reviews on TripAdvisor, Viator, or GetYourGuide, or through your hotel concierge
 - Verify that the operator is licensed by the Abu Dhabi Department of Culture and Tourism before booking
 - Pay by credit card through a recognized booking platform for full consumer protection and refund rights
 - Compare prices across multiple operators; legitimate premium safaris cost 300-700 AED per person, while budget options cost 150-250 AED
 - Get a written itinerary listing every included activity, vehicle type, meal details, and pickup time before paying
-

Counterfeit Luxury Goods

Gulf News reported a massive counterfeit goods bust where fake goods worth 100 million AED were seized in Abu Dhabi, including imitation designer bags, watches, electronics, and perfumes. The Abu Dhabi fake market near Mina Port openly sells counterfeit goods including imitations of popular brands in fashion, electronics, and accessories, attracting tourists with the promise of branded items at a fraction of the cost. While many tourists knowingly buy fakes, others are misled into believing items are genuine. Khaleej Times documented a UAE

authority warning about fake shopping sites and sca...

■ Red Flags

- Brand-name luxury items are sold at prices 70-90% below official retail stores
- The seller takes you from a shop front to a separate location like an apartment or back room to view the merchandise
- The product lacks original packaging, authentication codes, serial numbers, or official brand documentation
- The seller claims items are 'export quality' or 'factory seconds' to explain the low price
- Electronics do not come with a manufacturer warranty card valid in the buyer's home country

■ How to Avoid

- Buy luxury goods only from authorized retailers in established malls like Yas Mall, Al Wahda Mall, or the Galleria on Al Maryah Island
- If buying perfume, check for the ESMA certification label and purchase only sealed, boxed products from authorized retailers
- Never follow a seller from a shop to a secondary location to view 'special' merchandise
- For electronics, verify the warranty is internationally valid and check the serial number against the manufacturer's online verification tool
- Report counterfeit goods to the UAE Ministry of Economy consumer protection hotline at 600-522225

Timeshare-Style Vacation Club Cold Call

■ ■ Malls near Marina Mall and Yas Mall, hotel lobbies, phone calls to tourists' hotel rooms, pop-up stands in Al Maryah Island You receive a cold call to your hotel room or get stopped at a mall kiosk by a well-dressed ... You receive a cold call to your hotel room or get stopped at a mall kiosk by a well-dressed salesperson offering a 'free gift' — electronics, hotel vouchers, or spa treatments — in exchange for attending a short promotional presentation. Reddit users on r/dubai report these operations are run by fake tourism companies that lure visitors to high-pressure timeshare or vacation club pitches lasting two to four hours. Once inside, salespeople use rotating teams to wear you down. They demand deposits of 2,000-5,000 AED for memberships that prove nearly impossible to cancel. The 'free gifts' are either low-quality knockoffs or come with conditions that make them worthless. Redditors on r/abudhabi confirm that these presentations target tourists staying at mid-range hotels, with staff sometimes complicit in providing guest phone numbers. Red Flags You receive an unsolicited call offering free electronics, hotel stays, or vouchers just for attending a 'short presentation' The salesperson cannot clearly explain their company name or provide a verifiable business registration number You are told the offer expires today and pressured to commit immediately during the presentation The contract includes a multi-year commitment with payments spread across installments The presentation location is a private office or unmarked suite rather than a recognized tourism agency How to Avoid Decline all unsolicited offers of free gifts or promotional presentations, whether by phone, in malls, or at hotel lobbies Ask your hotel front desk not to transfer promotional calls to your room and report any that come through If you do attend a presentation, never sign anything or provide credit card details on the same day — legitimate offers allow cooling-off periods Verify any tourism company through the Abu Dhabi Department of Culture and Tourism's licensed operator registry before engaging Report aggressive timeshare operations to Abu Dhabi Consumer Protection at 600-522225 ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Dubai Police station. Call 999. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at dubaipolice.gov.ae. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Consulate General is at Corner of Al Seef Road & Sheikh Khalifa Bin Zayed Road, Dubai. For emergencies: +971 4-309-4000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. Frequently Asked Questions Is Abu Dhabi safe for tourists? ▼

You receive a cold call to your hotel room or get stopped at a mall kiosk by a well-dressed salesperson offering a 'free gift' — electronics, hotel vouchers, or spa treatments — in exchange for attending a short promotional presentation. Reddit users on r/dubai report these operations are run by fake tourism companies that lure visitors to high-pressure timeshare or vacation club pitches lasting two to four hours. Once inside, salespeople use rotating teams to wear you down. They demand deposits of 2,000-5,000 AED for memberships that prove nearly impossible to cancel. The 'free gifts' are ...

■ Red Flags

- You receive an unsolicited call offering free electronics, hotel stays, or vouchers just for attending a 'short presentation'
- The salesperson cannot clearly explain their company name or provide a verifiable business registration number
- You are told the offer expires today and pressured to commit immediately during the presentation
- The contract includes a multi-year commitment with payments spread across installments
- The presentation location is a private office or unmarked suite rather than a recognized tourism agency

■ How to Avoid

- Decline all unsolicited offers of free gifts or promotional presentations, whether by phone, in malls, or at hotel lobbies
 - Ask your hotel front desk not to transfer promotional calls to your room and report any that come through
 - If you do attend a presentation, never sign anything or provide credit card details on the same day — legitimate offers allow cooling-off periods
 - Verify any tourism company through the Abu Dhabi Department of Culture and Tourism's licensed operator registry before engaging
 - Report aggressive timeshare operations to Abu Dhabi Consumer Protection at 600-522225
-

■■ Dubai

6 scams documented • United Arab Emirates

The Tinder Date Bar Trap

She invites you to a 'great bar' she knows. Once inside, drinks are poured without showing prices. You get increasingly intoxicated as she orders round after round. At the end of the night a bill for AED 42,000 (≈\$11,500 USD) lands on the table — four bouncers appear at the door before you can protest. You sign in a daze. The woman is gone. This is documented repeatedly on Reddit's UAE and Dubai subs.

■ Red Flags

- Match is suspiciously enthusiastic and moves fast to meet
- She chooses the venue, not you
- Drinks arrive without you ordering them
- Bill is never shown until you're clearly drunk
- Security staff materialize when you question charges

■ How to Avoid

- Choose your own venue for any date — somewhere you've independently found with good reviews
 - Ask for a price list before anything is served
 - Never sign a bill or authorize payment while intoxicated
 - File a credit card chargeback immediately — you may have recourse
-

The Unofficial Taxi No-Meter Rip-Off

he has a real car, looks professional. No meter, but he quotes what sounds like a fair price. By the time you reach your hotel he's tripled it, your luggage is in his trunk, and you're in an unfamiliar country. Legal Dubai taxis have strict metered pricing, but unofficial ride touts congregate specifically at airport arrivals to catch tired and confused tourists.

■ Red Flags

- Driver approaches you before you reach the official taxi rank
- No visible meter in the vehicle

- Quote sounds suspiciously cheap or price is vague
- Luggage loaded before price is agreed
- Use the official Dubai Taxi app or Careem (local Uber equivalent)

■ How to Avoid

- Use the official Dubai Taxi app or Careem (local Uber equivalent)
 - Only take taxis from official ranks inside the terminal
 - Uber is also fully operational in Dubai
-

The Gold Souk Fake Weight / Bait-and-Switch

the salesperson insists it's 22-karat and weighs it in front of you. You buy it, feeling triumphant about your bargaining. Back at the hotel you notice a hallmark that doesn't match, and when you get home a jeweler tells you it's gold-plated. Some Gold Souk shops swap pieces after weighing, substitute lower karat gold, or show you one piece then bag a cheaper version. The legitimate shops are the majority, but the few dishonest ones specifically target tourists.

■ Red Flags

- Vendor insists on an unusually low price before you've even asked
- Piece swapped out of sight during packaging
- No official receipt or hallmark documentation provided
- Inspect the exact piece you paid for before leaving the store
- Ask for a certificate of authenticity and official receipt

■ How to Avoid

- Inspect the exact piece you paid for before leaving the store
 - Ask for a certificate of authenticity and official receipt
 - Large, well-established shops in the center of the souk are lower risk than peripheral smaller stalls
-

The Desert Safari Overcharge

the smiling agent promises dune bashing, camel rides, dinner, and belly dancing for just AED 80. You arrive at a random pickup point and end up in a beat-up SUV with bald tires driven by someone who seems to be making it up as they go. The 'included' dinner has a cash supplement. The photo fee isn't included. The promised activities are half-delivered. You paid a middleman who kept 70% and passed you to the cheapest operator available.

■ Red Flags

- Price is dramatically lower than all reputable operators
- Agent at a shopping mall kiosk, not a licensed tourism office
- No paperwork or confirmation number provided
- Pickup is at a non-hotel location
- Book directly with a licensed operator or through your hotel concierge

■ How to Avoid

- Book directly with a licensed operator or through your hotel concierge
 - Read recent TripAdvisor reviews — not just star ratings
 - Anything under AED 150 for a full desert safari is almost certainly cutting corners
-

The Timeshare Presentation Lure

A charming person at Dubai Mall tells you you've been 'selected' to receive free tickets to a water park, a restaurant voucher, or a luxury hotel stay — just for attending a 90-minute presentation. The presentation turns into a 4-hour high-pressure timeshare sales pitch, and the promised gift has so many conditions attached it's basically worthless. You've lost half a day of your holiday.

■ Red Flags

- 'You've been selected' or 'lucky winner' language unprompted
- Only asks for your time, not money — upfront
- Gift or prize requires ID and a 'short' meeting
- Location: high-foot-traffic tourist areas
- There are no free tickets — there's always a catch

■ How to Avoid

- There are no free tickets — there's always a catch
 - Simply decline and walk away
 - Research common scams before visiting this area
-

The Spiked Drink Robbery

■ ■ Bars and clubs in Bur Dubai, Deira nightlife areas, hotel bars You're at a bar in Bur Dubai when an attractive stranger starts chatting you up, buying rounds of drinks. After your third drink, things go fuzzy. You wake up hours later in your hotel room with your wallet emptied, watch missing, and phone gone. Your credit card has been used at several ATMs. Drink spiking targeting solo tourists -- both men and women -- is documented across Dubai's nightlife areas, often coordinated between the person who befriends you and an accomplice who rifles through your belongings while you're incapacitated. Red Flags A stranger is unusually eager to buy you drinks Your drink tastes slightly off or bitter You feel disproportionately drunk relative to what you consumed Your new friend steers you away from your group or toward the exit The bar staff seem uninterested in your safety How to Avoid Never leave your drink unattended and never accept drinks from strangers Go out with friends and watch each other's drinks If you suddenly feel much more intoxicated than expected, alert bar staff immediately Keep your hotel room key separate from your wallet Stick to well-known, reputable venues with security cameras ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Dubai Police station. Call 999. Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at dubaipolice.gov.ae. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact your nearest embassy or consulate. The US Consulate General is at Corner of Al Seef Road & Sheikh Khalifa Bin Zayed Road, Dubai. For emergencies: +971 4-309-4000. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. Frequently Asked Questions Is Dubai safe for tourists? ▼

After your third drink, things go fuzzy. You wake up hours later in your hotel room with your wallet emptied, watch missing, and phone gone. Your credit card has been used at several ATMs. Drink spiking targeting solo tourists -- both men and women -- is documented across Dubai's nightlife areas, often coordinated between the person who befriends you and an accomplice who rifles through your belongings while you're incapacitated.

■ Red Flags

- A stranger is unusually eager to buy you drinks
- Your drink tastes slightly off or bitter
- You feel disproportionately drunk relative to what you consumed
- Your new friend steers you away from your group or toward the exit
- The bar staff seem uninterested in your safety

■ How to Avoid

- Never leave your drink unattended and never accept drinks from strangers
- Go out with friends and watch each other's drinks
- If you suddenly feel much more intoxicated than expected, alert bar staff immediately

- Keep your hotel room key separate from your wallet
 - Stick to well-known, reputable venues with security cameras
-

Central Asia

4 cities • 20 scams • 2 countries

■ Kazakhstan

■■ Almaty

5 scams documented • Kazakhstan

The Friendly Bar Setup

often attractive women — strike up a conversation and suggest grabbing drinks at a nearby bar. The bar looks decent, but there's no menu on the table. After two rounds of shots, the bill arrives: 50,000-100,000 KZT (\$100-\$200) for drinks that should cost 5,000 KZT. When you protest, security guards appear and escort you to an ATM to withdraw cash. Redditors on r/solotravel describe this as the most dangerous scam in Almaty — the bars are in on it, splitting the profit with the lures.

■ Red Flags

- Strangers who are overly eager to drink with you
- They suggest a specific bar rather than letting you choose
- No visible menu or price list at the table
- Staff ignore your requests and keep bringing more drinks
- Security appears when you question the bill

■ How to Avoid

- Always suggest the bar yourself — never go where a stranger recommends
 - Ask for the menu and check prices before ordering anything
 - Never leave your credit card with bar staff as a 'tab'
 - If the bill seems inflated, call the police (102) — don't go to an ATM
 - Politely decline invitations from overly friendly strangers in tourist areas
-

The Fake Police Shakedown

You're strolling through Panfilov Park when two men in casual clothes flash what looks like a police badge and demand to see your passport. They claim your documents have an 'irregularity' and insist you pay a fine of 20,000-50,000 KZT (\$40-\$100) on the spot to avoid being taken to the station. Redditors on r/travel warn that real Kazakh police never demand cash fines on the street. These impersonators target tourists near ATMs and in crowded areas, banking on your fear of foreign authorities to make you pay without questioning.

■ Red Flags

- Officers are not in full uniform or drive unmarked vehicles
- They demand cash payment for an on-the-spot 'fine'
- They want to inspect your wallet, not just your passport
- They become aggressive when you ask to see proper identification
- They refuse to take you to an actual police station

■ How to Avoid

- Always ask to see official ID — real officers carry proper credentials and will comply
 - Insist on going to the nearest police station to resolve any issue
 - Carry a photocopy of your passport; keep the original in your hotel safe
 - Call 102 (police emergency) if you feel threatened
 - Real fines in Kazakhstan are issued through official written protocols, never cash
-

The Green Bazaar Currency Shuffle

You need tenge and a friendly tout outside the Green Bazaar offers a 'better rate than the banks.' He counts out your money slowly, but uses sleight-of-hand to shortchange you — pocketing a 5,000 KZT note while fanning the bills. Or he quotes 1 USD = 400 KZT when the real rate is 450 KZT. Travelers on r/travel report losing 10-20% of their exchange this way. The scam relies on the confusing denominations and the speed of the transaction in a noisy, crowded market environment.

■ Red Flags

- Money changer approaches you on the street rather than sitting at a licensed booth
- Exchange rate offered is significantly worse than the posted bank rate
- Quick hand movements while counting bills
- Rushes you to complete the transaction
- Distracts you with conversation while handling your money

■ How to Avoid

- Exchange money only at banks or licensed exchange offices
 - Check the National Bank of Kazakhstan rate online before exchanging
 - Count your money carefully before walking away
 - Use ATMs inside bank branches for the best rates
 - Never exchange money with street touts or informal dealers at bazaars
-

The Big Almaty Lake Taxi Gouge

The driver quotes 10,000-15,000 KZT one way for a ride that costs 1,500-2,000 KZT on Yandex Go. He insists the app 'doesn't work in the mountains' or that 'the road is restricted and only local drivers know the way.' Redditors on r/solotravel note that some drivers type 'Big Almaty Lake' as the destination in the Yandex app, which adds an extra 1,500 KZT to your fare — but drops you at the same spot as the cheaper route to the visitor centre.

■ Red Flags

- Driver claims rideshare apps don't cover the mountain road
- Price quoted is 5-8x the Yandex Go estimate
- Driver insists on a round-trip deal that locks you into waiting
- Claims special permits or restricted access that only he can provide
- Book through Yandex Go to the 'Big Almaty Lake Visitor Centre' specifically

■ How to Avoid

- Book through Yandex Go to the 'Big Almaty Lake Visitor Centre' specifically
- Set the destination to the visitor centre, not the lake itself, to avoid fare inflation
- Take bus 28 from the city center to reduce the taxi distance needed
- Arrange return transport in advance or join a shared tour group
- Download offline maps since mobile coverage is patchy in the mountains

Krisha Apartment Rental Fraud

■ ■ Online listings on Krisha.kz targeting tourists seeking short-term rentals in central Almaty, particularly Dostyk Avenue and Abay Avenue areas You find a seemingly perfect apartment on Krisha.kz, Kazakhstan's most popular property rental ... You find a seemingly perfect apartment on Krisha.kz, Kazakhstan's most popular property rental platform, at a price that undercuts hotels. The listing has attractive photos and the 'landlord' is responsive over WhatsApp, requesting a deposit of 50,000-100,000 KZT to secure the booking. Reddit users on r/Kazakhstan report that after transferring the deposit via Kaspi bank transfer, the landlord goes silent, the listing disappears, and the apartment either does not exist or belongs to someone else entirely. One Redditor described spending a 'small fortune on hotels' before attempting Krisha, only to lose their deposit to a ghost listing. The scam exploits the fact that Krisha.kz has limited verification of landlord identities and tourists unfamiliar with the platform do not know which safety features to use. Locals recommend always viewing the apartment in person before transferring any money and using Kaspi's escrow-style payment features when available. **Red Flags** The rental price is significantly below market rate for the neighborhood and apartment quality shown in photos The landlord insists on a bank transfer deposit before you have viewed the apartment in person Communication is only through WhatsApp rather than through the Krisha.kz platform messaging system The landlord provides excuses for why they cannot meet you at the apartment or do a video tour A reverse image search of the listing photos shows them appearing on other rental platforms for different cities How to Avoid Never transfer money for a Krisha.kz rental until you have physically visited the apartment and verified the landlord's identity with a passport check Use Kaspi Gold payment with its buyer protection features rather than direct bank transfers when possible Cross-reference the listing address on Google Maps and 2GIS to verify the building exists and matches the photos For short stays, use established booking platforms like Booking.com that offer refund guarantees, or book through your hotel concierge Download Yandex Taxi and 2GIS before arrival — locals on r/Kazakhstan universally recommend these over street taxis and random booking sites ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Kazakhstan Police station. Call 102 (Police) or 103 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at gov.kz. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Embassy in Astana or Consulate in Almaty at 97 Zholdasbekov Street, Almaty 050010. For emergencies: +7 727-250-4802. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides Popular Nearby Destinations ■■

You find a seemingly perfect apartment on Krisha.kz, Kazakhstan's most popular property rental platform, at a price that undercuts hotels. The listing has attractive photos and the 'landlord' is responsive over WhatsApp, requesting a deposit of 50,000-100,000 KZT to secure the booking. Reddit users on r/Kazakhstan report that after transferring the deposit via Kaspi bank transfer, the landlord goes silent, the listing disappears, and the apartment either does not exist or belongs to someone else entirely. One Redditor described spending a 'small fortune on hotels' before attempting Krisha, ...

■ Red Flags

- The rental price is significantly below market rate for the neighborhood and apartment quality shown in photos
- The landlord insists on a bank transfer deposit before you have viewed the apartment in person
- Communication is only through WhatsApp rather than through the Krisha.kz platform messaging system
- The landlord provides excuses for why they cannot meet you at the apartment or do a video tour
- A reverse image search of the listing photos shows them appearing on other rental platforms for different cities

■ How to Avoid

- Never transfer money for a Krisha.kz rental until you have physically visited the apartment and verified the landlord's identity with a passport check
- Use Kaspi Gold payment with its buyer protection features rather than direct bank transfers when possible

- Cross-reference the listing address on Google Maps and 2GIS to verify the building exists and matches the photos
 - For short stays, use established booking platforms like Booking.com that offer refund guarantees, or book through your hotel concierge
 - Download Yandex Taxi and 2GIS before arrival — locals on r/Kazakhstan universally recommend these over street taxis and random booking sites
-

■ Uzbekistan

■■ Bukhara

4 scams documented • Uzbekistan

The Silk Carpet Certificate Scam

He unrolls stunning silk carpets and flashes a 'certificate of authenticity' printed in Cyrillic, claiming the rug is hand-knotted pure Bukhara silk worth \$2,000. His opening price is \$800 — a steal! In reality, many carpets sold in Bukhara's tourist shops are machine-made, blended with synthetic fiber, and worth \$50-100. Vendors inflate the supposed value 3-4 times and present fake certificates that any print shop could produce. Redditors on r/travel say Bukhara is the worst city in Uzbekistan for inflated carpet claims.

■ Red Flags

- Certificate of authenticity is a simple printed document in Cyrillic
- Vendor claims the carpet is 'antique' or '100 years old'
- Initial price drops dramatically with minimal bargaining
- Vendor discourages you from checking thread count or doing a burn test
- Claims of export certificates or customs clearance are thrown in casually

■ How to Avoid

- Learn basic silk vs synthetic tests: real silk feels warm, synthetics feel cool
 - Ask to burn a small thread — real silk smells like burning hair, synthetics melt like plastic
 - Start bargaining at 25% of the asking price and don't exceed 40%
 - Buy from cooperatives recommended by your guesthouse rather than bazaar stalls
 - Be aware that exporting items over 50 years old requires a government permit you won't get
-

The Taxi Mafia Overcharge

The loudest one grabs your bag and quotes 100,000 soum for a ride to Lyabi-Hauz — the fair price via Yandex Go is about 15,000-20,000 soum. If you try to pull up Yandex on your phone, drivers physically block you or claim the app doesn't work here. At the airport, the situation is worse: organized groups control the pickup zone and harass anyone trying to book via app. Redditors on r/travel describe the Tashkent and Bukhara taxi mafia as aggressive but ultimately avoidable with Yandex.

■ Red Flags

- Drivers swarm you at stations and grab your luggage
- Price quoted is 5-10 times the Yandex Go estimate
- Driver claims Yandex 'doesn't work' in this area
- Group of drivers work together to block you from alternatives
- No meter offered and cash-only demanded

■ How to Avoid

- Download and set up Yandex Go before arriving in Uzbekistan
 - Pre-book airport transfers through your guesthouse or hotel
 - Walk 100 meters away from the station to book a Yandex ride without harassment
 - Never let a stranger carry your bags without agreeing on a price first
 - If negotiating, offer one-third of their asking price and walk away if they refuse
-

The Restaurant Menu Switcheroo

The food arrives and it's delicious. Then the bill comes: your 40,000 soum plov is listed as 80,000, and a bread basket you never ordered appears as a 15,000 soum charge. When you question it, the waiter says 'the menu changed today' or brings a different menu with higher prices. Backpackers on Reddit report this is common at Bukhara's prime-location restaurants, where the tourist markup can be 100% over what locals pay at the same establishment.

■ Red Flags

- Menu has no prices or prices are written in pencil
- Waiter takes the menu away quickly after you order
- Bill includes items you didn't order like bread, water, or service charges
- Staff claims prices changed 'today' when you compare to the menu
- Different menus exist for locals and tourists

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph the menu with prices before ordering
 - Confirm each item's price verbally when placing your order
 - Check the bill line by line and dispute any items you didn't order
 - Eat where locals eat — one or two streets back from Lyabi-Hauz
 - Use Google Maps reviews to find restaurants with consistent pricing
-

The Black Market Money Exchange

■ ■ Near bazaars, train station, approaches on the street throughout old town A man approaches you near Bukhara's covered bazaar and whispers an exchange rate that's 10-15% ... A man approaches you near Bukhara's covered bazaar and whispers an exchange rate that's 10-15% better than official rates. It sounds tempting — your \$100 could get an extra 100,000 soum. You agree and he counts out an impressive wad of bills. But the bills are old, damaged, or in smaller denominations than you thought. Some travelers report receiving counterfeit notes mixed into the bundle. Worse, street money changing is illegal in Uzbekistan, meaning you can't complain to police without risking trouble yourself. Travel forums document this as a legacy scam from when official rates were far below market value. Red Flags Stranger offers exchange rate better than banks or official bureaus Transaction happens on the street rather than in an exchange office Money is counted quickly and the person rushes you to agree Notes are old, worn, or in unexpectedly small denominations Exchanger watches to see how much cash you carry How to Avoid Exchange money only at banks, hotels, or official exchange bureaus Since 2017, official and black market rates are nearly identical — there's no benefit to street exchange Use ATMs at bank branches for the best rates with lowest risk If you must carry cash, bring clean US dollars in recent series Never show your full cash supply to anyone on the street ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Uzbekistan Police (Militsiya) station. Call 102 (Police) or 101 (Fire) or 103 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at iiv.uz. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Embassy in Tashkent at 3 Moyqorqhon Street, Tashkent 100093. For emergencies: +998 78-120-5450. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Uzbekistan ■ ■

A man approaches you near Bukhara's covered bazaar and whispers an exchange rate that's 10-15% better than official rates. It sounds tempting — your \$100 could get an extra 100,000 soum. You agree and he counts out an impressive wad of bills. But the bills are old, damaged, or in smaller denominations than you thought. Some travelers report receiving counterfeit notes mixed into the bundle. Worse, street money changing is illegal in Uzbekistan, meaning you can't complain to police without risking trouble yourself. Travel forums document this as a legacy scam from when official rates were fa...

■ Red Flags

- Stranger offers exchange rate better than banks or official bureaus
- Transaction happens on the street rather than in an exchange office
- Money is counted quickly and the person rushes you to agree
- Notes are old, worn, or in unexpectedly small denominations
- Exchanger watches to see how much cash you carry

■ How to Avoid

- Exchange money only at banks, hotels, or official exchange bureaus
 - Since 2017, official and black market rates are nearly identical — there's no benefit to street exchange
 - Use ATMs at bank branches for the best rates with lowest risk
 - If you must carry cash, bring clean US dollars in recent series
 - Never show your full cash supply to anyone on the street
-

■■ Samarkand

5 scams documented • Uzbekistan

The Train Station Taxi Ambush

You step off the high-speed Afrosiyob train from Tashkent and exit the station to find a mob of taxi drivers shouting prices. They open with 300,000 UZS for a ride to the Registan area -- ten times the fair price. If you try to walk past, they follow you, grab your bags, and insist this is the 'official rate.' Unlike Tashkent, the Yandex Taxi app works poorly in Samarkand, leaving you with fewer options. Backpacker blogs describe the station taxi mob as 'hellbent on souring your first impression' of the city. The real price to the center is 20,000-30,000 UZS.

■ Red Flags

- Opening price of 100,000+ UZS for a ride to the city center
- Drivers physically grabbing your luggage
- Claims that ride-hailing apps don't work here
- Multiple drivers working together to block cheaper options
- Quoting prices in US dollars to confused arrivals

■ How to Avoid

- Try Yandex Go app despite inconsistent coverage -- it sometimes works
 - Walk 100 meters past the taxi crowd to the main road and flag a regular car
 - The fair price to Registan is 20,000-30,000 UZS -- don't pay more
 - Arrange airport/station pickup through your hotel in advance
 - Have the Uzbek for 'how much to Registan?' ready on your phone translator
-

The Fake Silk Carpet Certificate

You're admiring handwoven carpets in a shop near the Registan when the vendor presents a 'certificate of authenticity' in Cyrillic script, claiming the carpet is genuine Samarkand silk, hand-knotted, and worth \$2,000. He offers you a 'special tourist price' of \$500. The certificate is meaningless, the carpet is machine-made with synthetic fibers, and similar items sell at Siab Bazaar for \$30. Vendors have been documented adding decades to a carpet's age and misrepresenting materials. Tripadvisor reviewers warn that tourist-area shops routinely charge 3-4 times the real value.

■ Red Flags

- Certificate of authenticity written only in Cyrillic or Uzbek
- Starting price 3-4 times what similar items sell for elsewhere
- Vendor claims the carpet is an antique or rare piece
- High-pressure sales with tea and prolonged conversation
- Located directly adjacent to a major tourist attraction

■ How to Avoid

- Visit the Samarkand Bukhara Silk Carpets Factory to see real production and fair prices
 - If you want a carpet, compare prices at multiple non-tourist shops first
 - Haggle aggressively -- offer one-third of the asking price
 - A Cyrillic certificate proves nothing about authenticity
 - Know that genuine handmade silk carpets start at \$100+ per square meter at fair prices
-

The Registan Unofficial Guide Shakedown

You approach the Registan and a man offers to be your guide for a 'small donation.' He speaks good English and shares genuinely interesting facts about the madrasas. But when the tour ends, he blocks the exit path and demands \$30-50 USD. If you offer less, he becomes aggressive or claims you agreed to the higher price. Some guides also steer you to specific souvenir shops where they earn commission. Samarkand has official Tourist Police at major sites, but these unofficial guides operate just outside their line of sight.

■ Red Flags

- Unsolicited guide approaching at the entrance without official badge
- Vague language about payment -- 'small donation' or 'whatever you want'
- Tour ending at a specific shop or with blocking behavior
- No visible Tourist Police badge or Uzbektourism credential
- Guide positioning between you and the exit when discussing payment

■ How to Avoid

- Hire licensed guides wearing official Uzbektourism badges
 - Agree on the exact price before the tour starts -- in writing if needed
 - Approach the Tourist Police at Registan if you feel pressured
 - Pay only after the tour is complete and you're satisfied
 - Explore with a guidebook or audio guide from your hotel instead
-

The Siab Bazaar Tourist Tax

You wander into the legendary Siab Bazaar next to the Bibi-Khanym Mosque looking for Samarkand's famous non bread and dried fruits. Vendors in the souvenir section quote you prices two to three times what locals pay. In the dried fruit aisles, they weigh your purchase on a rigged scale or add extra weight after you agree on a price per kilo. The covered souvenir section is the worst offender, selling average-quality goods at inflated prices because tourists assume bazaar equals bargain.

■ Red Flags

- Prices quoted without you asking -- vendors calling out to you
- Scales that seem to jump or give inconsistent readings
- First price quoted with no expectation of haggling
- Vendor adding items to your bag before you agree
- Products identical to what you can find cheaper in non-tourist shops

■ How to Avoid

- Offer one-third of the first quoted price and negotiate from there
- Watch the scale carefully -- ask them to zero it before weighing
- Buy non bread and fresh items from the local food section, not the tourist side
- Compare prices with at least three vendors before buying
- Bring your own small bag so vendors can't add unwanted items

The Aggressive Souvenir Seller at Registan

■ ■ *Souvenir stalls inside Registan Square madrasas, Siyob Bazaar covered section, shops along the approach to Shah-i-Zinda, and Ulugh Beg Observatory gift shop* You enter one of the Registan madrasas to admire the tilework. A vendor in a small shop inside the building calls you over to look at ceramics or miniature paintings. You pick something up to examine it. The vendor immediately wraps it and announces a price. When you try to put it back, they insist you have committed to buying it by touching it. A Reddit user on r/Uzbekistan described vendors who touch you and follow you aggressively, noting it has gotten worse recently. The covered section of Siyob Bazaar is similarly aggressive with overpriced tourist souvenirs. Always negotiate -- the first price is typically 3-4 times the real value. Red Flags A vendor calls you into their shop and hands you items to examine without you asking to see them They wrap or bag an item the moment you touch it and announce a price as if the sale is already agreed The price is in US dollars rather than Uzbek sum, indicating tourist markup The vendor physically blocks the exit or follows you out of the shop when you try to leave Multiple identical items suggest mass production, not the handmade craftsmanship claimed How to Avoid Do not pick up items in shops unless you are genuinely interested in buying -- touching an item is treated as intent to purchase Negotiate aggressively -- offer one-third of the asking price and settle at roughly half Shop at the smaller stalls on the edges of Siyob Bazaar rather than the tourist-facing covered section Buy ceramics from the Konigil paper mill village or the Gijduvan ceramics center outside Bukhara for better prices and quality Say 'Rahmat, kerak emas' (Thanks, I do not need it) firmly and walk away ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Uzbekistan Police (Militsiya) station. Call 102 (Police) or 101 (Fire) or 103 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at iiv.uz. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Embassy in Tashkent at 3 Moyqorghon Street, Tashkent 100093. For emergencies: +998 78-120-5450. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Uzbekistan ■ ■

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■ Red Flags

- A vendor calls you into their shop and hands you items to examine without you asking to see them
- They wrap or bag an item the moment you touch it and announce a price as if the sale is already agreed
- The price is in US dollars rather than Uzbek sum, indicating tourist markup
- The vendor physically blocks the exit or follows you out of the shop when you try to leave
- Multiple identical items suggest mass production, not the handmade craftsmanship claimed

■ How to Avoid

- Do not pick up items in shops unless you are genuinely interested in buying -- touching an item is treated as intent to purchase
 - Negotiate aggressively -- offer one-third of the asking price and settle at roughly half
 - Shop at the smaller stalls on the edges of Siyob Bazaar rather than the tourist-facing covered section
 - Buy ceramics from the Konigil paper mill village or the Gijduvan ceramics center outside Bukhara for better prices and quality
 - Say 'Rahmat, kerak emas' (Thanks, I do not need it) firmly and walk away
-

■■ Tashkent

6 scams documented • Uzbekistan

The Airport Taxi Mob

You exit Tashkent Airport's arrivals hall and are immediately swarmed by unofficial taxi drivers quoting \$10-15 for the 5km ride to the city center -- a trip that should cost \$3 or roughly 40,000 UZS. They're persistent, following you across the parking lot, grabbing at your luggage, and insisting the 'official rate' is what they're quoting. A 2024 blog post from The Foodie Nomad documents being followed relentlessly until pre-booked transport arrived. Tripadvisor threads confirm drivers start high and drop to \$5, but the real price through Yandex Taxi is under 30,000 UZS.

■ Red Flags

- Multiple drivers aggressively competing for your attention at arrivals
- Quoted price in US dollars rather than Uzbek soum
- Driver grabbing your luggage without permission
- No visible taxi license or meter in the vehicle
- Refusal to use the Yandex or MyTaxi app

■ How to Avoid

- Download Yandex Taxi or MyTaxi before landing and order from inside the terminal
 - Visit the Uzbektourism desk in the arrivals hall -- they'll call a fair taxi
 - Walk past the taxi crowd to the main road and hail a regular cab
 - Never let anyone grab your luggage -- it creates obligation
 - Know the real rate: airport to city center should be 25,000-40,000 UZS
-

The Restaurant Bill Surprise

When the bill arrives, it's 50% higher than expected. The waiter explains that a 'service charge' was added, or that today's prices are different from the menu, or that your dish was the 'large portion.' If you ordered something priced per 100 grams, you now owe for the full 400-gram serving you were brought. Redditors report restaurants near tourist sites adding phantom charges and giving incorrect change, knowing most visitors won't argue.

■ Red Flags

- Menu prices listed per 100g rather than per serving
- No prices on the menu at all -- or a 'tourist menu' vs local menu
- Bill includes undisclosed service charge or table fee
- Waiter claims prices changed 'today' or portion was 'premium'
- Incorrect change returned, always in the restaurant's favor

■ How to Avoid

- Confirm the total price before ordering -- ask 'how much for one full serving?'
 - Watch for per-100g pricing and calculate the full portion cost
 - Count your change carefully at the table
 - Eat where locals eat, away from the main tourist strips
 - Use Google Translate to read Uzbek-language menus for real prices
-

The SIM Card Swindle

The vendor sells you a 'monthly unlimited' plan for 50,000 UZS. A week later, the SIM stops working entirely. It turns out the vendor didn't properly register your passport with the network, so the carrier deactivated the line. Or worse, they sold you a recycled SIM with only a few days left on a prepaid plan. Backpackers on r/travel report losing connectivity mid-trip with no recourse since the kiosk vendor has no accountability.

■ Red Flags

- SIM sold from an unmarked kiosk rather than an official carrier store
- Vendor doesn't scan or photocopy your passport during registration
- Price significantly below what official stores charge
- Vendor rushes the transaction without explaining the plan details
- No receipt or documentation of the plan you purchased

■ How to Avoid

- Buy SIM cards only from official Ucell, Beeline, or Mobius stores
 - The airport arrivals hall has official carrier counters -- use those
 - Ensure the vendor scans your passport and completes registration
 - Ask for a receipt showing the plan duration and data allowance
 - Test the SIM in the store before leaving to confirm it works
-

The Chorsu Bazaar Pickpocket Ring

In the crowded covered sections, someone bumps into you or a vendor creates a diversion by aggressively offering samples. Meanwhile, an accomplice lifts your phone or wallet from your pocket or open bag. Travel guides note that while the bazaar is perfectly safe to visit, pickpocketing cases have been reported in the tightest, most crowded sections where tourists are most absorbed in the sensory experience.

■ Red Flags

- Unusual crowding or someone pressing against you unnecessarily
- Vendor aggressively pushing samples into your hands as a distraction
- Someone bumping into you from behind in a narrow aisle
- Children surrounding you asking questions simultaneously
- Open bags or pockets in the densely packed sections

■ How to Avoid

- Use a crossbody bag with zippers facing inward
 - Keep your phone in a front pocket, not back pocket or open bag
 - Be extra alert in the crowded covered dome sections
 - Don't carry more cash than you plan to spend
 - Visit early morning when the bazaar is less crowded
-

The Found Money Hustle

You're walking near a metro station when someone ahead of you 'finds' a wad of cash on the ground and excitedly shows you. They suggest splitting it -- but first you need to put up some of your own money as a 'good faith deposit.' Once you hand over your cash, a third person appears claiming the money is theirs. In the ensuing confusion, both your money and the 'found' cash disappear with the scammers. This confidence trick surfaces near Tashkent's metro stations where foot traffic is heaviest.

■ Red Flags

- Stranger excitedly 'finds' money right in front of you
- Immediate suggestion to split the found cash
- Request for you to put up your own money as a deposit
- A third person conveniently appears to claim the money
- The entire scene feels rehearsed and moves very quickly

■ How to Avoid

- Never engage with anyone who claims to have found money
- Walk away immediately without responding
- Never hand over your own money in a street transaction
- If someone drops money, ignore it -- it's always a setup
- Report the scam to tourist police if you see it happening

The Restaurant Bill Markup for Foreigners

■ ■ Restaurants near Amir Timur Square, cafes along Broadway (Sayilgoh), eateries near Chorsu Bazaar You sit down at a mid-range restaurant near Amir Timur Square and order plov and tea. The bill arrives at 150,000 som when the items on the menu should total 50,000 som. When you question it, the waiter points to a 'service charge' and 'tourist menu' that was not the one you saw. Reddit users on r/Uzbekistan confirmed this practice: 'Some shopkeepers tend to overcharge me — even in a mid-range restaurant the bill was supposed to be 50,000 but came to much more.' The markup targets visible foreigners, especially those who do not speak Russian or Uzbek. Red Flags The waiter brings a different menu from the one you initially saw or ordered from Prices are not clearly printed on the menu or are listed only in Uzbek The bill includes unexplained service charges, cover charges, or 'tourist fees' The total is significantly higher than what you calculated from the menu Staff become evasive when you ask for an itemized breakdown of the bill How to Avoid Photograph the menu with prices before ordering to have evidence if the bill does not match Ask for an itemized receipt (chek) and verify each line item against the menu Use Google Translate to read menus in Uzbek if an English menu is not available Eat at restaurants recommended by your hotel or listed on Google Maps with recent tourist reviews All legitimate fines are paid through apps or government offices — never pay cash to a police officer or restaurant 'fine' ■ What to Do If You Get Scammed ■ File a Police Report Go to the nearest Uzbekistan Police (Militsiya) station. Call 102 (Police) or 101 (Fire) or 103 (Ambulance). Get an official crime report — you'll need this for insurance claims. You can also report online at iiv.uz. ■ Cancel Your Cards Call your bank immediately. Most have 24/7 numbers on the back of the card (keep a photo saved separately). Block any suspicious transactions before the thieves use your details. ■ Lost Passport? Contact the US Embassy in Tashkent at 3 Moyqorghon Street, Tashkent 100093. For emergencies: +998 78-120-5450. ■ Track Your Device If your phone was stolen, use Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device (Android) from another device. Don't confront thieves yourself — share the location with police instead. More Scam Guides More in Uzbekistan ■ ■

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■ Red Flags

- The waiter brings a different menu from the one you initially saw or ordered from
- Prices are not clearly printed on the menu or are listed only in Uzbek
- The bill includes unexplained service charges, cover charges, or 'tourist fees'

- The total is significantly higher than what you calculated from the menu
- Staff become evasive when you ask for an itemized breakdown of the bill

■ How to Avoid

- Photograph the menu with prices before ordering to have evidence if the bill does not match
 - Ask for an itemized receipt (chek) and verify each line item against the menu
 - Use Google Translate to read menus in Uzbek if an English menu is not available
 - Eat at restaurants recommended by your hotel or listed on Google Maps with recent tourist reviews
 - All legitimate fines are paid through apps or government offices — never pay cash to a police officer or restaurant 'fine'
-

■■ Stay Safe Out There

This guide covers the most common tourist scams across Asia, sourced from real travelers on Reddit and verified by the tabiji.ai team.

For the latest updates, visit tabiji.ai/scams/

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This guide is for informational purposes only. Always exercise common sense and due diligence while traveling.